THOUSAND BLACK STAR

A Novel of Sixty Loves Beneath One Dark Sky

Al Fayaz

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For everyone who has kept a sentence behind their teeth.

The Sixty Couples

Dramatis Personae. Each pair is a love story; the Register numbers of all one thousand souls are kept in the Keeper's ledger.

- **Tomás Villaverde** & **Inês Carvalho**: Lisbon, Portugal
- **Kwame Mensah** & **Abena Owusu**: Accra, Ghana
- **Hiroshi Tanabe** & **Mei Sato**: Osaka, Japan
- **Dmitri Volkov** & **Anya Petrova**: St Petersburg, Russia
- **Rafael Ortega** & **Camila Reyes**: Mexico City, Mexico
- **Omar Haddad** & **Layla Mansour**: Cairo, Egypt
- **Lars Eriksen** & **Sigrid Haugen**: Bergen, Norway
- **Arjun Nair** & **Meera Menon**: Kochi, India
- **Carlos Mendes** & **Beatriz Lima**: São Paulo, Brazil
- **Emeka Okafor** & **Chidinma Eze**: Lagos, Nigeria
- **Pierre Dubois** & **Margaux Laurent**: Lyon, France
- **Jakub Nowak** & **Zofia Kowalska**: Kraków, Poland
- **Ahmed Yilmaz** & **Elif Kaya**: Istanbul, Türkiye
- **Vikram Rathore** & **Priya Sharma**: Jaipur, India
- **Liam O'Connor** & **Aoife Brennan**: Galway, Ireland
- **Daniel Cho** & **Ji-woo Han**: Seoul, South Korea
- **Samuel Bekele** & **Selam Tesfaye**: Addis Ababa, Ethiopia

- **Marco Bellini** & **Giulia Rossi**: Verona, Italy
- **Hamza Qureshi** & **Sana Ahmed**: Karachi, Pakistan
- **Nikolai Ivanov** & **Elena Georgieva**: Sofia, Bulgaria
- **Thabo Dlamini** & **Naledi Khumalo**: Johannesburg, South Africa
- **Mateo Fernández** & **Valentina Cruz**: Buenos Aires, Argentina
- **Yusuf Abdullahi** & **Hauwa Garba**: Kano, Nigeria
- **George Papadakis** & **Eleni Stavrou**: Crete, Greece
- **Kenji Watanabe** & **Haruka Mori**: Kyoto, Japan
- **Andrei Popescu** & **Ioana Dumitrescu**: Bucharest, Romania
- **Mustafa Karim** & **Noor Hashim**: Baghdad, Iraq
- **Jonas Müller** & **Clara Weber**: Vienna, Austria
- **Otieno Odhiambo** (Kisumu, Kenya) & **Wanjiru Kamau** (Nairobi, Kenya)
- **Fayaz Rahman** (Dhaka, Bangladesh) & **Ermis Larasati** (Yogyakarta, Indonesia)
- **Alessandro Greco** & **Chiara Esposito**: Naples, Italy
- **Tariq Al-Rashid** (Dubai, UAE) & **Maryam Al-Sayed** (Muscat, Oman)
- **Gabriel Santos** & **Maricel Dela Cruz**: Manila, Philippines
- **Petr Novák** & **Lucie Horáková**: Prague, Czechia
- **Anil Perera** (Colombo, Sri Lanka) & **Nadeesha Fernando** (Galle, Sri Lanka)
- **Sebastián Torres** (Bogotá, Colombia) & **Daniela Ruiz** (Medellín, Colombia)

- **Hassan Idris** (Cairo, Egypt (from Khartoum)) & **Amal Yusuf** (Cairo, Egypt)
- **Ravi Chaudhary** & **Sunita Verma**: Delhi, India
- **William Hartley** & **Poppy Ashworth**: Manchester, England
- **Youssef Benali** (Casablanca, Morocco) & **Salma Idrissi** (Marrakech, Morocco)
- **Ivan Horvat** & **Marija Kovač**: Split, Croatia
- **Baatar Munkh** & **Oyun Dorj**: Ulaanbaatar, Mongolia
- **Joseph Tembo** & **Grace Banda**: Lusaka, Zambia
- **Quân Nguyễn** (Hanoi, Vietnam) & **Hà Trần** (Huế, Vietnam)
- **Erik Johansson** (Stockholm, Sweden) & **Astrid Lindqvist** (Gothenburg, Sweden)
- **Kofi Boateng** & **Esi Appiah**: Kumasi, Ghana
- **Ali Rezaei** & **Parisa Karimi**: Isfahan, Iran
- **Hugo Martin** & **Camille Bernard**: Marseille, France
- **Takumi Ishikawa** & **Yuki Nakamura**: Sapporo, Japan
- **Héctor Álvarez** & **Rosa Hernández**: Havana, Cuba
- **Rahim Chowdhury** (Chittagong, Bangladesh) & **Nusrat Jahan** (Sylhet, Bangladesh)
- **Putu Wirawan** & **Dewi Anggraini**: Ubud, Indonesia
- **Patrick Murphy** & **Ellen Walsh**: Boston, USA
- **Mikhail Sokolov** & **Katrin Tamm**: Tallinn, Estonia
- **Victor Adeyemi** & **Funmi Balogun**: Ibadan, Nigeria

- **Anders Nilsen** & **Ingrid Solberg**: Oslo, Norway
- **Sergio Castillo** & **Lucía Paredes**: Lima, Peru
- **Idris Hakimi** (Toronto, Canada (from Kabul)) & **Fatima Noori** (Toronto, Canada)
- **Harry Whitcombe** & **Dorothy Penrose**: Cornwall, England
- **Edmund Ashby** (Cornwall, England) & **Seraphine Wyndham-Rao** (Colombo / Cornwall)

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PROLOGUE

Spoken by the Chorus

In heaven’s field a thousand stars lie dark, Not dead, but dimmed by words they dared not speak; Yet each doth bend the light about its arc And draws the wandering heart to what they seek. Come, then, kind friends, and lend a patient ear: We tell of sixty loves beneath one sky, Of some made glad, and some that drown in fear, Of some that break mid-word and leave no why. A boy from Dhaka, banks of river-rain, A girl whose islands rise from Java’s sea, Shall write across the dark their long refrain, And ask the night what yet may come to be. Not all shall end as hearts would have them end— Yet read: the dark hath light enough to lend.

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ACT I — THE LEDGER OPENS

Chapter 1: The Night the Ledger Opened

“I forgave you years ago and never said so.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0086

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There is a house on the Cornish cliffs where the wind knocks at every window as though it, too, had a letter to deliver.

It is called Lantern House, and on the last night of her life it held three things worth the keeping: an old woman, a young one, and a thousand secrets in a locked oak cabinet that smelled of salt and cedar.

The old woman was Seraphine Wyndham-Rao. She was seventy-eight years old, born in Colombo under a monsoon sky, trained in London under a ceiling of lamps, and she had spent forty-five years learning that the heart is the only telescope that points both ways. She lay propped on four pillows beside a window that looked out upon nothing at all, for it was the dark of the moon, and the sea and the sky had agreed to be one colour.

The young woman was her grand-niece, Nadeesha Fernando, twenty-nine, a nurse from Galle, who had flown six thousand miles to hold a hand and had learned

in four days what her profession had not taught her in seven years: that one can be perfectly competent and perfectly helpless in the same breath.

“You are doing it again,” said Seraphine.

“Doing what, Aunty?”

“Counting my pulse as though it were a debt you hoped to settle.” She smiled, and the smile cost her something. “Put down the wrist, child. It is not going anywhere that it has not been before.”

Nadeesha put down the wrist. She did not put down the fear. Fear, like a stray cat, is not so easily dismissed once it has been fed.

“Tell me what is tonight,” said Seraphine.

“The new moon.”

“The new moon.” The old woman closed her eyes. “The one night in the month when the sky withholds its lamp and shows you what is truly there. Do you know what an astronomer loves best, Nadeesha? Not the stars. The *dark between* them. For the dark is where the unseen things hold their court.”

“Aunty, you should rest.”

“I shall rest presently, and at length, and with no one to wake me.” She opened her eyes, and they were bright and grey and absolutely clear. “Listen, for I will say this once, and then I shall be an inconvenience no longer.”

She spoke then, not in prose, for the dying sometimes find their sentences fall into measure of their own accord, as water finds its level:

Beneath my bed, the cabinet; the key Lies in the lamp. A thousand letters keep Their silence there. I swore I would not share A single word while I had breath to guard it. I have no breath to guard it now. At midnight Unlock the doors. Let every letter speak. Let strangers read what strangers feared to say, And let them learn what I have learned too late: The word unspoken is no silent thing. It bends the course of every life it touches, As unseen stars bend light.

"A thousand letters," said Nadeesha. "I thought—"

"You thought it was a few dozen love notes from sailors." Seraphine's laugh was a dry, small thing, like the rustle of a page. "A thousand people, child, over forty-five years. Each wrote me one letter, and each letter holds the one sentence its writer could never say to the person who needed to hear it. I numbered them in the order I shelved them, which is not always the order they came; the heart keeps its own calendar. I answered none. I kept every one." She paused. "The first, Entry 0001, I confess, was not a stranger's."

"Whose was it?"

"A man's. A foolish, frightened, honourable man, who left me on a railway platform in nineteen seventy-seven because he was afraid he would love me too much." The grey eyes went somewhere very far. "He wrote it from a ship, a month after, in a hand that shook with the sea. I read it a hundred times. And then I thought: if one man has a sentence like that, how many more? And so I began a ledger. And so it became a life."

“And the thousandth?”

“Ah.” Seraphine’s hand moved, very slightly, toward her own breast. “The thousandth is mine. You will find it in the lamp with the key. You are not to read it until I am dead, and not aloud until the proper hour, and then only to the one it is for. He will know.”

“Aunty—”

“There. I have been long enough with you. Go and open the doors.”

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She died at eleven minutes before midnight, which is to say she died exactly as she had lived: a little early for her own appointment, so as to be sure of finding a good seat.

Nadeesha sat with her for the length of one breath, and then another, and then a third, as though each might be given back. Then she wept, plainly and without shame, the way the very young and the very honest weep. Then she wiped her face with her sleeve, for she was a nurse, and nurses are trained to finish what the hour requires.

She found the key inside the lamp. She found the cabinet. She found, beneath the cabinet’s loose board, a small laptop with a single file on its screen, and one button, and one line of text:

PUBLISH THE REGISTER. — S.W.R.

Behind her the window rattled. The clock on the mantel, which Seraphine had wound daily for forty years, said four minutes to midnight.

On the screen of a small laptop, in a house at the edge of England, a young woman put her trembling finger upon a key.

She did not press it at once. Reader, forgive her. The hand that has never broken a rule is slow to break the first, and Nadeesha stood a long minute in the lamplight, thinking of a hundred ordinary kitchens, a hundred ordinary pillows, a hundred people who had trusted an old woman with the worst sentence of their lives. *Who am I to open a door that is not mine?* And the answer came, in a dry little voice she had heard all week, though the owner of the voice lay quiet now behind her: *The one who was asked, child. The one who is awake.*

Mark this, reader. A thousand doors, long locked, are about to open at once. And what comes through them is not wind.

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Lisbon, 00:02.

In the great grey sorting office by the river, a postwoman named Inês Carvalho was eating a custard tart over a tray of undelivered letters, which is a sin against both pastry and postage.

“They say it is the end of the world,” said Pereira, the lamp-seller, who had no business in the sorting office at midnight and had come in, as he always did, to tell her that business was bad. “Not the whole world. Only the part where people keep quiet.”

“What are you talking about, Pereira?”

“The Register.” He held up a phone as though it were a gospel. “Some old English witch has died and given away a thousand secrets. All free. Confessions. *Love* confessions. There is a search bar, Inês. You type a city, and up come the sinners.”

Inês, who read every address twice and every postcard three times (and had never, in nine years, been caught), took the phone out of his hand and typed, with the casual air of one who is merely checking the weather: *Lisbon*.

Eleven names appeared. Not names — numbers, and beneath each number a sentence.

The sixth said: **“I wrote to a woman whose face I have never seen.”**

Her tart went cold in her hand.

For she, Inês Carvalho, twenty-seven, postwoman of Alfama, had delivered a letter exactly seven months ago, addressed in careful block capitals to a *Senhora, Rua da Saudade 14, Lisboa*, and the street did not exist, and she had kept it, and she had read it in the bath, and she had never been able to forget the second line.

It is not much of a Register, Pereira, she thought, *if it tells the truth.*

“Well?” said the lamp-seller. “What does it say?”

“It says,” said Inês, closing the phone, “that the night is long, and the post is slow, and you should go home.”

“That is not what it says. Your ears have gone red.”

“My ears are cold. It is the river.”

“It is a warm night for November.”

“Then my ears,” said Inês with great dignity, “are *ambitious*.”

Pereira looked at her ears, then at the phone, then at the tart. He was a lamp-seller. He knew, better than most, the look of a person who has just been lit from inside.

“I will sell you a lamp,” he said gently. “Eighty euros. It is a very good lamp for reading in the bath.”

Inês looked at him for a long moment.

“Go home, Pereira.”

“Seventy.”

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Dhaka, 06:05. *(The same hour of the world, seen from the other side of it. The clocks, as we shall see, disagreed.)*

In a rented flat in Mirpur, where the electricity came and went like a temperamental relative, a young man sat before a laptop at the first grey of morning, with his sleeves rolled and his pride rolled up with them.

His name was Fayaz Rahman. He was twenty-six, and he looked like a man who had once been very sure of something and was now merely well-mannered about its absence. He had run a small software company for eighteen months, and the company had died as small things die: quietly, owing money. He had a father whose business had gone with it, a mother whose breathing had

grown shallow, a sister named Tithi whose exams required fees, and two embassy letters, each beginning *We regret.*

He had, in short, a great many problems and no leisure in which to be unhappy about them. That, as he sometimes observed to the tea-stall boy at the corner, is how you know it is serious.

"Bhaiya," said Tithi, appearing in the doorway with a phone held out like a hot coal. "Look. There is a thing. Everyone is sharing it. *The Register of Black Stars.* You *wrote* to this, remember? Two winters ago. You said it was a stupid idea and then you did it at three in the morning."

"I never said that."

"You said it *and* you did it. Look. Your number. *Zero-seven-one-three.*"

He took the phone. The screen said, in plain white type on black:

ENTRY 0713 — Dhaka, Bangladesh. *"I would tell you everything, if I were free to."*

He had written that. He remembered writing it, at a desk that was then a good desk, in a company that was then alive, to a person who was then a mere shape he hoped one day to meet. He had not expected it to be *read.* One does not write to the dark expecting an answer. It is, rather, a way of dropping a coin down a well and listening for the splash.

"It is embarrassing," said Fayaz.

"It is *poetry*," said Tithi.

“It is a sentence with a conditional, Tithi. A conditional is a confession that has lost its nerve.”

“That is what poetry is.”

He nearly smiled. Then his eyes, which were tired and honest, moved a little to the right, as eyes will, and fell upon the entry beside his own.

ENTRY 0714 — Yogyakarta, Indonesia. *“I am an hour ahead of you, and I keep looking back.”*

He read it. He read it again. A line, in a telescope of ten thousand words, can be the one that fits the lens.

Underneath, in the margin, in a small, steady, old-fashioned hand, someone had pencilled a note, and the note had been scanned along with the page:

0713 posted 22:40, Dhaka. 0714 posted 23:41, Yogyakarta. One minute apart, by the stars. One hour, by the clocks. — S.W.R.

Outside, the call to prayer had finished and the first rickshaw bells were starting up along the road. Somewhere below, a landlord was climbing the stairs with the particular tread of a man who has come about the month’s rent. Fayaz heard the tread and did not look up. For the length of one breath, a stranger’s sentence in Yogyakarta weighed more than all of it.

“Bhaiya?” said Tithi. “Why are you looking at it like that?”

“No reason.”

“You are *blushing*.”

“The generator is on the wrong circuit.”

“You do not have a generator.”

“Then it is the *idea* of a generator,” said Fayaz, with the dignity of a man in considerable trouble, “and I would be grateful if you went to get ready for college.”

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Yogyakarta, 07:06. *(An hour ahead. Always an hour ahead.)*

In a workshop that smelled of hot wax and indigo, with a copper canting in one hand and a half-drawn flower in the other, a young woman who had not been to bed was swearing at a parrot.

“Ayu,” said Ermis Larasati, twenty-four, designer of batik and keeper of very large ambitions, “if you say it one more time I will give you to the cousins.”

“*TOO LATE!*” said the parrot, which belonged to her grandmother, spoke only three sentences, and had learned them all from an argument. “*TOO LATE! TOO LATE! BEAUTIFUL!*”

“That is two sentences.”

“*TOO LATE!*”

Ermis put down the canting. Her phone, propped against a jar of wax beads, was lit by a stream of messages from her cousin Dewi in Bali: *Have you seen it? THE REGISTER. Look at yours. Your number is next to somebody’s!!!*

She had written to the old astronomer one night in her last year of design school, when she had been very tired and very sure that the thing she wanted most

would be taken from her by the thing she wanted next. She had put a sentence in an envelope, because it was easier than putting it in a person, and sent it to an address in England that she had found on a foreign website. She had half-forgotten it.

Now she opened the link, and found her own sentence in the open air, and was a little annoyed at how much it sounded like truth.

I am an hour ahead of you, and I keep looking back.

She had meant a friend. She had meant a boy at university who had gone home to a city one time zone away, and she had never told him why she kept watching his lit window long after it went dark. It was a small sorrow, tidy as a pressed flower.

But that was not what she looked at now. She looked at the line on the *left* of her own.

I would tell you everything, if I were free to.

She read it aloud. The workshop was very quiet. Even the parrot, who had views on everything, said nothing.

“Dhaka,” said Ermis. “Bangladesh.” She looked at the clock above the door, which said 07:06. “That is an hour behind me.”

She did the sum again, not because it was difficult, but because it was a pleasure to do.

Then, as sensible people do when something strange has happened, she took out a pencil and drew a small flower on the corner of the page, and wrote beneath it, in the Latin letters she used for clients and strangers:

Hello, Dhaka. You are one hour behind. I am not sorry about it.

She did not send it. Not yet. A message is a lamp, and one should know where one is hanging it.

"*BEAUTIFUL!*" said the parrot.

"Hush, Ayu."

"*TOO LATE!*"

"Is it?" said Ermis, to no one. And then, to the pale morning outside, and to the one window an hour behind it that seemed to hold her gaze: "Is it, though?"

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Cornwall, 00:00.

At the stroke of midnight, a thousand doors opened.

They opened in Lisbon, where a postwoman sat very still over her cold tart. They opened in Accra, where a pharmacist and a taxi-fleet owner, who had not spoken in six years and lived eighty yards apart, each reached at the same moment for a phone, and each, noticing the other's lit window, pretended not to. Somewhere down the lane a roof loudspeaker coughed and said, to nobody, "Brothers and sisters of the Rank, something is happening." They opened in Osaka, in Cairo, in Bergen, in Kochi, in São Paulo, in Lagos, in Lyon, in Kraków, in a hundred other places where somebody was awake and ashamed.

They opened in a lighthouse in Galle, where a young man named Anil Perera, who kept the lamp for the ships, watched a signal fail on his phone, and could not have

said why his hands trembled.

They opened at first light in a window in Dhaka, and an hour later, by the clocks, in a window in Yogyakarta: two mornings, one hour apart, and two people who did not yet know that they were sharing one.

And on a cliff in Cornwall, in a house with the wind at its door, a grey-eyed old woman lay quite still, with a smile on her face that said she had never in her life been so completely on time.

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Cornwall, 00:11.

Nadeesha had expected a silence after the key. Instead the little laptop gave a soft chime, like a spoon against a glass, and a counter in the corner of the screen turned from 0 to 1.

Then to 9. Then to 140. Then it stopped being a number a person could read and became a pulse.

She sat on the edge of the bed with the cold laptop warm on her knees and watched strangers arrive: Lisbon, Dhaka, Osaka, Accra, Yogyakarta, each a small blue dot on a map that had been black all her life. She thought, absurdly, of the ward at home on the night shift, when the monitors go off one by one and a nurse has to choose which of them to run to first.

“Aunty,” she said to the still shape beside the window, “they are all coming at once.”

The wind had dropped. Outside, the sea breathed in and out, which is all the sea has ever done by way of comment.

Sleep now, Keeper, said the Chorus, who is permitted a word at the end of a long day, and who has been watching this house a great deal longer than you:

The light you kept is out. The pull remains. Where one dark star has set, a thousand turn Their faces to the room and ask their names. Sleep. We shall keep the lamp. It is our turn.

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Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

The thousand are not a thousand people. They are one people, sleeping in a thousand beds, dreaming the same dream of being known. Let them wake. Let them read. Let them, if they are brave, answer. — and if they are not brave, let them at least be kind.

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End of Chapter 1.

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Chapter 2: The Postwoman of Alfama

“I wrote to a woman whose face I have never seen.”
— Register of Black Stars, Entry 0753

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Lisbon is built upon seven hills, and the Post has been trying to climb all of them since eighteen hundred and something.

It does not climb them well. A letter in Alfama does not travel; it is *carried*, up stairs that were laid out by a medieval drunkard, past walls tiled in blue by a hundred dead hands, beneath washing-lines strung from window to window like the bunting of a small and unwinnable war. And the carrier of the letters in that quarter, for nine years, had been a young woman named Inês Carvalho, who knew every door in it by its knock, every dog by its opinion, and every widow by the particular quality of her gratitude.

She did not sleep that night. At six, with the sky going from pewter to pearl above the river, she was already on the Rua de São Miguel with her yellow satchel and her red bicycle (which she pushed, for no bicycle born could ride that street), and in the satchel, beneath the gas bills and the pension slips, lay one envelope that was not hers.

She did not need to take it out. She had it by heart.

It had come to the sorting office seven months before, among the dead letters, which is the name the Post gives to mail that belongs to nobody: wrong addresses, vanished tenants, the tender misspellings of the very old. The envelope was cream, a little soft at the corners, addressed in careful block capitals to *SENHORA, RUA DA SAUDADE 14, LISBOA.* There is a Rua da Saudade in a number of Portuguese towns, for we are a people who name our streets after what we miss. There is none in Lisbon. Inês had held it up to the lamp, and a thing she had never before done in nine years of honest service had happened: she had opened it, and had told herself, with the ease of a woman who is lying to the one person who will believe her, that it was a matter of *procedure.*

To the lady who writes small kindnesses on the backs of other people's envelopes:

I am a man who mends things that carry others, and I would like, once, to be carried.

It was that second line. She had read the rest, a page and a half, in the bath, with the taps running to cover the sound of her own breathing, and every word of it had been courteous and clear and slightly frightened. But it was the second line that lodged in her like a fish-bone. *I would like, once, to be carried.*

She had never answered it. There was nobody to answer. It was signed with no name at all, only a drawing, a very small drawing, in pencil, of a wheel.

And now, on the screen of Pereira's cracked phone, in the night just gone, there had been a sentence beneath a number: *I wrote to a woman whose face I have never seen.*

Entry 0753. Lisbon.

She had sent the lamp-seller home. She had stayed on alone among the sleeping sorting machines, with the night shift gone to its coffee, and there on her own small phone she had pressed thumb and forefinger against the screen to enlarge the scan, as one pulls back a curtain.

The Register, you understand, did not keep only the words of its confessors. It kept the *paper*. Seraphine Wyndham-Rao had been an astronomer, and astronomers do not trust a report of a star; they want the plate. So each letter had been photographed whole, cream and blue-lined and stained and creased, and the hand of 0753 was there in the open air for anyone to see: small, square, careful, upright as a row of soldiers, every letter built as if load-bearing.

Inês laid the phone upon the table, and beside it, very gently, the envelope.

The capitals were the same.

"*Ai,*" said Inês Carvalho, to the machines. And then, as a precaution, "*Ai, ai, ai.*"

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By nine o'clock the news had gone round Alfama the way news does there: by no known channel, and faster than light.

“It is *you*,” said Pereira, who had arrived at the foot of the Escadinhas with a barrow of lamps and the expression of a man who has found a truffle. “I said it last night, did I not? I said, her ears have gone red. And what does a woman do with red ears and a Register? She searches for a *man.*”

“I am not searching for a man.”

“You are searching for a *handwriting*, which is a man with his clothes off.”

“Pereira!”

“I am a lamp-seller, Inês. I deal in revelation.” He held up a brass lamp the size of a cat. “For you, a special price, eighty euros. Read your love-letters by a better light.”

“I do not have love-letters.”

“Then why are you smelling envelopes?”

She was. It is a thing postwomen do. She had been going down the street with the morning’s post and holding each envelope a moment to her nose, as a sommelier holds a glass, for the cheap ink of the Tax Office, the lavender of the widows, the cigarettes of the men who wrote to football clubs. She was searching, by smell and by script, for a square hand that built every letter as if it carried weight.

It was not a good method. It produced, in the course of one hour, the following events:

She delivered Senhor Matos’s pension to the widow Matos’s cat, which sat upon the step and refused to be signed for.

She gave the Tax Office's final demand to a young man in a bakery who had been the one *sending* it, and who took it, read it, and went quite grey.

She stopped a stranger outside the Sé Cathedral, a pale German in new walking boots, and asked him with great solemnity to write the words *BOA NOITE* on the back of her hand.

"Why?" said the German.

"It is a matter of *procedure.*"

"Is it a crime?"

"Not yet," said Inês, studying the capital B, "but I am hopeful."

It was in the Rua dos Remédios, outside a plumber's van, that she came to the first suspect.

"Inês, my *life,*" said Rui Costa, plumber, thirty-eight, in a voice like warm gravel. He had been, for eleven months at the age of twenty-six, the great sorrow of her life, and had since become a mild irritation, as great sorrows do when they are properly stored. He was wearing a vest and a look of suspicious innocence. "I saw it. I read it. The Register. And I thought to myself, Rui, you fool. She has been waiting."

"Waiting for what?"

"For the man who wrote to the woman whose face he never saw." He placed a hand upon his heart. "It was I."

"Rui."

“It was *I*, Inês. I wrote it years ago. In block capitals. I am a man of block capitals.” He indicated the invoice pad on the dashboard, where indeed the numbers had been stamped in a hand of formidable squareness. “You see? The hand!”

She looked. It was a square hand, certainly. It was also a hand in which the number *four* had a small curl at the foot, like a pig’s tail, and the capital *R* had a leg that kicked out at the world.

“Rui,” she said gently. “You have seen my face.”

“Naturally.”

“You pinched my cheek at my sister’s wedding.”

“It was a *tender* pinch.”

“You told me I looked like a boiled egg in a hat.”

“It was a very *affectionate* egg.”

“So you cannot have written to a woman whose face you have never seen.”

Rui Costa considered this. He was not stupid, merely hopeful, which is the more dangerous condition.

“Then perhaps,” he said, “I wrote it to another.”

“Perhaps you did.”

“Very likely it is *her* I meant.” He stared into the middle distance. “A *mystery* woman. Hm. I will write to her again.”

“Please do. Take your time.”

She was walking away, with the German's *BOA NOITE* drying on her hand, when she heard behind her the long, aggrieved sigh of a man who has been wrong and will shortly be very loud about it. She did not turn round. A postwoman, like a sailor, learns not to look back at weather.

✦ ✦ ✦

It was on a bench at the Miradouro de Santa Luzia, that same noon, with the whole bright shabby city laid out below her like a letter spread to dry, that her sister found her.

Rita Rocha, thirty-two, journalist, wore the face she kept for other people's scandals: bright and attentive and entirely without mercy. She sat. She unwrapped a pastry. She held it out.

"I have been wanting to say a thing," said Rita.

"Do not."

"It is about your entry."

"My *entry*?" Inês did not look round. "I have no entry."

"Entry zero-zero-fifty-three. 'I kept one letter that was never mine.' Lisbon. It is quite beautifully put."

There was a pause, in which a tram went grinding up the hill behind them, and a pigeon, which had been planning to approach the pastry, thought better of it.

"I never posted that," said Inês.

"No," said her sister. "You did not."

"I wrote it. I put it in a drawer."

“You did.”

“It was in an envelope that I *sealed*, Rita, and it had no stamp on it, and it was in the drawer in the *kitchen,* under the string.”

“It was,” said Rita, “an excellent place for it. Very secure. I had to move the string.”

“*Rita.*”

“Do not be angry. You were crying into the sink. I am your elder, and you were crying into the sink. And a person who cries into a sink about a letter should not keep the letter in a drawer; she should post it to a woman in England who will keep it for ever and tell no one.” She took a bite of pastry. “As, you will observe, she did.”

“She was seventy-eight!”

“She was *efficient,*” said Rita.

Inês opened her mouth, and found that all the sharp things she wished to say had melted, and that in their place was a soft, hot, helpless feeling, like a letter discovering that someone has finally read it.

“You are the worst journalist in Portugal,” she said at last.

“I am the *best,*” said Rita. “I have just got you to admit it is yours.”

She stood, brushing sugar from her coat. “And the man? The one who wrote to the woman with no face?”

“I have a handwriting.”

“Have you a name?”

“No.”

“Then find him,” said Rita Rocha, “before somebody else is *found*,” and she was gone down the steps in a flurry of scarf, leaving upon the bench a bitten pastry and a much-embarrassed postwoman.

Mark this, reader. It is a curious thing, but the people who say *I never told* are very seldom the ones who did not. The truth is a letter of its own, and it finds its post.

✦ ✦ ✦

A street in Santo Amaro. A tram depot, long and green-lit and smelling of oil and hot metal. In the pit beneath an old yellow carriage, a pair of boots, and a voice.

“Now, Dona Conceição,” said the boots. “We have discussed this. You are a lady of ninety-eight, and you have a gear-box like a general’s stomach, and you will *not* seize up on me today. I have a feeling about today.”

“*What* feeling?” said a second voice, above, from the platform. This was Nuno Pereira, twenty-seven, mechanic, best friend, and liar by vocation. He held his phone aloft like a priest with a relic. “Did you see it? The Register? There is a woman in Lisbon with a line like a knife. *‘I kept one letter that was never mine.’* Entry zero-zero-fifty-three.”

“Who keeps a letter that is not hers?”

“A thief. A romantic. A postwoman.”

“Oh, come.” The boots shifted. “There are three hundred postwomen in Lisbon.”

“But how many kept yours?”

There was a short, hard silence in the pit, in which the cooling engine ticked like a clock.

“Mine,” said the boots, “was a dead letter. It went to a nonexistent street. It was supposed to be *unfindable.* That was the *point.*”

“A man who sends a love-letter to a street that does not exist,” said Nuno, with deep admiration, “is either a poet or a fool, and I have always said you were both.”

Tomás Villaverde, twenty-nine, tram-mechanic, slid out upon his creeper as if the engine were delivering him. He had a spanner in one hand and a smear of black grease from the temple to the jaw, and the look of someone who has stared into the dark so long that it has begun to stare back with shapes.

“I reasoned it out,” he said. “I did not know her address. I know only her hand. So I wrote to *nowhere.* And the Post, if it is a decent institution, sends nowhere to somebody. I thought: the dead letters will go to the desk of the woman who writes on them. And she will either read it, or she will not.” He wiped his face, and made it worse. “That is seven months, Nuno. In seven months I have had one reply. It was from the tax office, and it was about my *car.*”

“Perhaps she is shy.”

“Perhaps she is sixty, with a moustache.”

“She is,” said Nuno, who had never seen her, “exactly sixty, and has a moustache like a Habsburg admiral.”

“You are a liar.”

“And a very good friend of liars,” Nuno agreed. “I can recommend it.”

But Tomás had slipped back beneath the carriage, and his voice, thinned by the iron above him, took on the strange musical quality of a man who is talking to himself in the one place where he is sure of no audience. He was not speaking in prose. He had not meant to. The engine had asked him, in its way, as engines do.

They say a man who mends the things that move Is moved by none. I say it is not so. I have been underneath this yellow thing A thousand nights, and listened to it ache, And known the very shiver in its wheel Before the driver felt it. That is love, Or else it is a trade, and I forget Which one I practise. Lady, if you read The small square words I sent into the dark, I do not ask you answer. Only know That somewhere underneath a tram, a man Is lying on his back, and looks at iron, And sees, quite plainly, through the iron, you.

“That was very good,” said Nuno, from above, after a respectful pause.

“It was the gear-box.”

“It was *poetry.*”

“It was *oil,*” said Tomás, and hit the gear-box, which, as if repentant, began to hum.

✦ ✦ ✦

At twenty minutes past four, at the Largo das Portas do Sol, tram twenty-eight stopped.

It had not intended to. It stopped as an elderly person stops upon a staircase: suddenly, with dignity, and with an air of having been betrayed by the stairs. A hundred tourists leaned out of the windows to photograph their own disappointment. The driver spread his hands to heaven. Up the hill, in a white cloud of ceremony, came Pereira with a barrow, selling lamps to the stranded, and behind him, shaking her head in the steady rhythm of a woman who has seen too many things go wrong in Alfama to be shocked by another, came the postwoman.

"A *call* has been made," said Pereira. "The mechanic comes."

"I don't care."

"He is said to be the best in the depot."

"I do not care *at all.*"

"And his name," said Pereira, who had a nose for it, "is *Tomás Villaverde.*"

Inês stopped.

Now it must be said, for the sake of accuracy, that she had not known the name. She had known a hand. But Rita, who is a journalist, had known someone who knew someone who had once fixed her washing machine, and Rita had sent a message at noon: *Tram depot, Santo Amaro, a Villaverde. Hands like a surgeon's, jokes like a cousin's, no wife.* To be right on a hunch about a stranger is a sorrow and a joy together, and Inês felt both at once, like two hot coins in one pocket.

She did not look at the tram. She looked at the pavement.

Beneath the carriage, from out of the shadow beneath it, protruded a pair of old black boots.

They did not move. A voice came from within the iron, the voice of a man engaged in an argument with a mechanism and slightly winning. "*Come on,*" it said. "Come on, my lady. Have a little courage. One more turn of the bolt and we shall both be heroes."

Inês, who had a satchel to deliver, a round to finish, and a handwriting to find, stood there with the whole city looking on and discovered, to her considerable annoyance, that her knees had gone.

The boots slid out. A body followed, in a blue boiler-suit gone black at the elbows. A face looked up from the pavement: long, serious, rather tired, with a smear of oil from temple to jaw and a pair of eyes the colour of a wet slate roof.

It was not, she thought, a face she knew. And he, for his part, looked upon the yellow satchel, and the red bicycle, and the cold-reddened ears, and the hand on which a faint blue *BOA NOITE* was running in the sun, and did not know hers either.

You will observe, reader, what is happening, for neither of them does. She has come by a hundred roads to the one man in Lisbon, and he has lain under a hundred trams for the one woman, and here, at the top of the hill, with a hundred tourists photographing the sky, the two of them stand a yard apart and do not know it. It is the cruelest of the old comedies, and the kindest.

"I am sorry," said Tomás. "I'm afraid I am in your way."

“You are not in my way. You are in the *road.*”

“A fine distinction.”

“I am a postwoman,” said Inês. “I am *rather* precise about roads.”

“Ah.” He sat up. A peculiar thing happened to his face, a tightening and a slackening together, like a man who has caught his own name called in a crowd. “A postwoman.”

“Yes.”

“In Alfama?”

“Nine years.”

“Then you must know,” said Tomás, with the elaborate lightness of the frightened, “what becomes of a letter when it has no address.”

The hundred tourists had gone quiet. Pereira, who was the soul of discretion when it paid him, put down a lamp.

“We keep it,” said Inês.

“For how long?”

“Seven years. Then it is burned.”

“*Seven.*”

“The Post is very patient. It is only people who are in a hurry.” She was looking at the oil on his chin, and at nothing else, since she did not dare. “Seven months so far.”

She saw him do the arithmetic. She saw it go through him as a current goes through a wire, and was glad of it, and alarmed, and could not in the whole world have said why, except that a man who counts months has plainly been counting them.

"And is the lady," said Tomás, very slowly, "who keeps such things… is she kind?"

"She is nosy," said Inês.

"I had heard that."

"She reads everything twice."

"I had heard *that,* too." He was getting up. He was taller than she had expected; he had to put a hand on the tram to find his balance. "She is, I am told, sixty, with a moustache."

"She is *twenty-seven,*" said Inês, crimson to the hair-line, "and has never shaved her lip in her life."

For a second there was nothing in the whole hill-top. Then a tourist from Ohio began to clap, and then his wife, and then the carriage full, and Pereira, who had never missed an occasion, said in a very loud and sacred voice, "A special price on lamps!" and Tomás Villaverde, wearing an expression no mechanic has ever worn in the history of the Carris, said:

"I think my name is Tomás."

"I think mine is Inês."

"The post," said Tomás, "is slow."

“But sure,” said Inês, and took out of her satchel a cream envelope, soft at the corners, and held it for one moment against her chest, where he could see it, and did not give it to him. “I will have to *check* the address.”

Behind them, with a long metallic sigh of relief, Dona Conceição gave up her objections and shuddered into motion.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, S.W.R.:

Entry 0753 wrote to a woman he had never seen; Entry 0053 wrote to a woman who would never post it. Between them stand an envelope, a sister, and a hill. I have never known the Post to be late for a love, only careful.

Observe, Keeper’s reader: the tram has stopped. It will start again. That is all any of us may ask of a machine, or a heart.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 2.

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Chapter 3: Two Pharmacies, One Street

“I know who paid it. I was waiting for you to say.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0941

✦ ✦ ✦

In Accra there is a lane called Palm Lane, though no palm has stood on it since the British left, and it is eighty yards long, and it holds two shops, one taxi yard, nine opinions, and a war.

At the northern end, in a cream building with green shutters and a red cross painted by a sign-writer who had been paid in kenkey, stood **Owusu Chemist & Dispensary**, whose proprietor, Abena Owusu, twenty-eight, wore a white coat as another woman might wear armour, and counted tablets in fives as if she had caught nature cheating. At the southern end, behind a gate of corrugated iron painted the yellow of a ripe plantain, lay **Mensah Cabs**, forty-one taxis and a goat, belonging to Kwame Mensah, thirty-one, who had never in his life been seen to count anything but other people’s blessings.

Between them lay eighty yards of cracked tar, which for six years neither had crossed.

“It is a *scandal,*” said Quaye.

Quaye was fifty-eight, the senior driver of Mensah Cabs, and the leader, by acclamation and by volume, of the Taxi Rank, which is what the drivers of Palm Lane called themselves when they sat upon their bonnets at dawn and considered the affairs of the world. They were a Chorus in all but name, for they spoke when the thing happened and not before, and said what everyone else was thinking a little too loudly.

"A scandal," agreed the Rank.

"Eighty yards."

"Eighty yards," said the Rank.

"I have measured it with my feet. A man could cross in a minute, with a bag of oranges. And these two" (he waved at the cream building and the yellow gate) "have not crossed in six years. What is that? Is that pride? Is that *hatred?* My friends, I have been a taxi driver for thirty-one years, and I tell you that when a man will not cross eighty yards, it is *love.*"

"It is parking," said a young driver, called Yaw, who was twenty-three and worked also as a waiter, and thus had a reputation for realism.

"Everything is parking," said Quaye. "That is how love is carried out in Accra."

For this, in fairness, was the history of the war. The Mensah taxis had begun parking, six years ago, in front of the pharmacy, and the pharmacy's queue of patients, aunties with prescriptions and boys with rashes, had begun to spread across the Mensah yard; and a notice had been affixed to the pharmacy door reading **NO TAXIS. THIS IS A PLACE OF HEALING**; and the Mensah gate

had received, two days later, a reply in letters a yard tall: **AND THIS IS A PLACE OF GETTING THERE.** Since that morning the two had communicated exclusively through signs, and the signs had grown steadily in size, wit and venom, until the Ghana Standards Board, passing in a Land Cruiser, had reportedly slowed down to read.

It was against this background that, at nine minutes past six on the morning after the new moon, Kwame Mensah's phone began to play a hymn.

✦ ✦ ✦

"*Chale,*" said Nii Tetteh.

He was Kwame's oldest friend, choir director of the Methodist church at Adabraka, a large devout man with the tender, theatrical face of one who has led nine hundred Sundays of "Rock of Ages." He held the phone out at arm's length, for he had left his spectacles in the choir loft, and he read aloud in the full resonant baritone that he used for the Gospel and for football.

"*Entry six hundred and twenty-five. Accra, Ghana.* 'I paid your father's debt and let you think it was forgiven.'"

The yard went very still. A goat looked up. Under the mango tree, Akosua Tetteh, Kwame's mother, who was sixty, a brilliant cook and a hopeless remembrancer, put down the groundnut she was shelling and said, "Who has paid whose father's debt?"

"Mama," said Kwame.

"Is it a *pharmaceutical* debt?"

“Mama, it is nothing.”

“It is the last line of a hymn,” said Nii. “You wrote it, Kwame. Two years ago. I drove you to the post office in the rain. You said it was a *medical letter.*”

“I never said that.”

“You said it was for your *back.*”

Kwame Mensah could discuss the carburettor of any engine ever manufactured, and had once talked a police captain out of a bribe by asking after his mother. He took the phone with a very steady hand and read the thing he had written. He had written it at a kitchen table, after a bad week, to a woman in England he had never met, because she had promised to tell no one. It was a sentence that had cost him eleven drafts.

He had not expected it to be read in his own yard, by a hundred strangers’ eyes, at six in the morning, with a goat.

“And the next one,” said Nii, who was a man of kind intentions and limited mercy, scrolling further. “Lord help us. *Entry nine hundred and forty-one. Accra, Ghana.*”

“Do not.”

“‘I know who paid it. I was waiting for you to say.’”

Now, there is a particular silence, in a place where thirty people have heard a thing, and the thirty are all attempting to appear deaf. It lasted perhaps four seconds. Then a voice from the mango tree, belonging to Ama Tetteh, eighty-two, retired welder, who had said nothing in the yard since Easter, remarked pleasantly:

“Well, *finally.*”

“Ma?”

“I told her six years ago, if she had eyes in her head she’d know.” She shelled a groundnut. “A woman does not need a *letter* to know a taxi.”

“Which taxi?” said Kwame hoarsely.

“The *one that paid,*” said Ama Tetteh, and cracked her nut.

✦ ✦ ✦

At the other end of the lane, in a dispensary that smelled of menthol and clean linoleum and a faint, honest sweetness of cough syrup, Abena Owusu was reading the same two entries aloud to the same silence, and for the same reason: she had no choice.

For her friend Adwoa, who owned the kiosk beside the pharmacy and who kept everything in the world that happened within eighty yards of Palm Lane in a mental card-index, had arrived at five forty-five with her phone held aloft and her whole face lit like a church window, and had said, “You are *in* it. You are in the Register. And so is *he.*”

“Who?”

“You know *who.*”

“I do not know who,” said Abena, with a pharmacist’s frigid accuracy. “There are four hundred thousand people in the district. One of them is a vet who owes me eleven cedis.”

“The yellow gate.”

Abena had put down her pestle.

She was a small woman with a straight back and quick hands and a tongue that she kept, like the poisons cabinet, locked, labelled and open only to the properly qualified. She had run this shop for six years: ever since the spring when her father, Kojo Darko, a good, proud, hopeless man who had founded the dispensary and then remortgaged it twice on the promise of a cocoa scheme, had been told by the bank that it would be taking possession at the end of the month. She had been twenty-two. She had been counting the stock for the last time when a letter arrived, on the bank's thick white paper, to say that the debt had been *settled in full by a benefactor who wishes to remain unnamed.*

She had taken her mother's name, Owusu, over the door that very week, to see how it would look. Her father had died in June. He had been proud of her, and had told her it was nothing, in the last week of his life, as people do who find the great things difficult to say and the small things easy. She had cried at the funeral for the shop, which was easier than crying for the man.

And she had known, in the way one knows a number before the bill arrives, who had paid.

"It is a *taxi* kind of generosity," she said now to Adwoa, who had become very quiet. "It does not leave a name. It leaves a smell of diesel and goodwill. The bank clerk said *a gentleman, tall, very polite, who laughed at his own car*. And then the landlady, Madam Naa, who said she'd had *a clerical error* with my rent, in my

favour, for six years running. What clerical error is consistent? What clerical error pays on the first of every month, in cash, on a Tuesday?"

"A very *devoted* one," said Adwoa.

"It is a *theft,*" said Abena, her voice cracking. "It is the cruellest theft in Accra. He took from me the chance to *thank* him. I have been walking past that yellow gate for six years with a sentence in my mouth like a stone, and he is *sitting there,* and he *knows,* and I cannot say it because he never said it first."

"So say it."

"I am *waiting for him to say.*"

"Abena," said Adwoa, gently, "so is he."

✦ ✦ ✦

By midday the whole Rank knew, because Quaye had put it on the radio.

It was not exactly the radio. Quaye had, in the roof of his taxi, a small loudspeaker for the announcement of fares, and he had found by experiment that any sentence addressed to it carried over eighty yards of tarmac with the clarity of a sermon. And since the Register of Black Stars had been published, he had been making use of it for the public good.

"*Attention, attention,*" said the roof of the taxi, to the lane, the cream building, the goat and the sky. "*This is your Rank. We read the Register. We have read the Register, and I can tell you the entry of Mr. Kwame is a very fine one. Wait. I will read both of them, since they are not far apart.*"

"Quaye, turn it off," said Kwame, from the yard.

"*It is for your benefit, my friend.*"

"Quaye."

"*'I paid your father's debt and let you think it was forgiven.' Good, good. That is Mr. Kwame, our employer, who is also a pharmacist of a kind, in the sense that he dispenses lifts. And the reply: 'I know who paid it. I was waiting for you to say.' That is Madam Abena, from the pharmacy. She is not here but she is perhaps listening. It is a thing I would not say if I were not an old man who has driven across Ghana nine times, and has learned that there is no eighty yards in the world like eighty yards of two proud people.*"

"*QUAYE!*"

"*I hope you will excuse the liberty.*"

Behind the green shutters, the pharmacy had gone entirely silent. Behind the yellow gate, forty-one taxis and a goat had done the same.

And then, from the northern end, there came out, quite slowly, into the white noon light, a small figure in a white coat, with a biscuit-tin held in both hands.

✦ ✦ ✦

The harmattan was early that year. A thin brown dust hung over Palm Lane, so that the sun was only a pale coin and the colours of the world were all faintly eaten. The Rank, to a man, had gone silent upon their bonnets. A woman in a white coat was walking down the middle of the lane, as if she had always done so.

It was eighty yards, and it took her a minute, and in the course of the minute a number of things happened that nobody afterwards would be able to agree upon. Quaye maintained that he heard a clock. Yaw, the waiter, said that she smiled once, a small and terrible smile, at the goat. Adwoa, from the kiosk, said only that she saw a woman who had been very frightened for six years take a decision, as one takes a pill: briskly, with water, and without looking at what it was.

She stopped at the gate.

It swung open. Kwame Mensah stood there in a clean white shirt and an expression of the most profound dread, as if summoned to be thanked.

“Mr. Mensah,” said Abena.

“Miss Owusu.”

“I have something for you.”

“I have nothing to say that—”

“I have *not* asked you to say anything.” She held out the tin. It was a round blue tin, such as is used for Danish butter biscuits in every home from Aflao to Tamale, and it was held out to him with the stiff correctness of a bailiff presenting a summons. “This is yours.”

“What is it?”

“It is the debt.”

“There is no debt.”

“There is a debt of forty-two thousand cedis to the bank, settled in the spring of the year I was twenty-two, by a gentleman, tall, who laughed at his own car.” She

said it very fast, as one pulls a plaster. “And there is rent, paid in cash every first of the month for seventy-one months, by a clerical error. I have kept the figures. I have kept *every* figure. I have been putting aside for six years, in a tin, in the dispensary safe, behind the morphine. It is not all. I have not got interest. I do not know *what interest to charge on a kindness.* But it is the principal, and it is yours, and I should like you to take it, so that we may be *even.*”

There was a long, high, unbearable silence, with a goat in it.

“No,” said Kwame.

“It is not a *request.*”

“No,” said Kwame Mensah, and his voice, which was rich and easy and had never in its life been shaken, shook now, once, like a plank over a stream. “I did not want you to feel owed.”

“I do not feel *owed,*” said Abena. “I feel *robbed.*”

“Robbed?”

“Of the chance to thank you! Of the whole occasion!” Her hands were trembling around the tin. “I would have done it so *well,* Kwame. I had a speech. I had it for months. It had a *beginning.* And you went and made it unnecessary, in your yellow gate, with your goat, and you said *nothing,* you let me think it was the bank, you let me think the world had been generous, and I walked around for six years being grateful to *nobody.* Do you know what that is? It is like swallowing a prayer with no God at the end.”

For a moment he said nothing. Then, very quietly, and rather to his own surprise, in the language he had been taught at his mother's knee, Kwame said something in Twi that the Rank had no business hearing, and which will not be set down here. It was brief. It was a proverb, about water, and the person who carries it to the thirsty without being asked.

She replied, in the same tongue, with another.

It was shorter.

Quaye, who understood both, took off his cap.

"So," said Abena, in English, recovering herself with an effort that the entire lane could hear, "will you take it?"

"No."

"Then I will leave it."

"Where?"

She looked about her with sudden decision, and set the tin, with a small dry click, upon the bonnet of the nearest cab, which was a very old green Corolla known to the Rank as *Auntie Beatrice,* and then folded her arms and said, to nobody, scrupulously: "You may count it."

"I will not count it."

"Then you may *not count it,* but I have left it."

"And I will not open it."

"Then it will sit."

"Then it will *sit,*" said Kwame, "on Auntie Beatrice, in the sun, for ever."

“So be it,” said Abena.

They stood a yard apart, in the white dust, with the tin between them like a small round moon. And it seemed to every driver watching that this was a quarrel of such perfect and symmetrical courtesy that it could not be settled by any further word; that it would simply be carried over, like a debt, to the next day and the day after, a perfectly balanced sorrow, in which each held the other’s gift and refused it, and each was glad.

“The loudspeaker on that taxi roof,” said Abena abruptly, looking away. “It is too loud. It disturbs my patients.”

“The queue outside your door,” said Kwame, “disturbs my *taxis.*”

“Then it is war.”

“It is a great pity.”

“It is *thoroughly* a pity,” said Abena, and turned, with her back straight and her coat flapping and her whole slim body radiating offence, and walked the eighty yards home.

She did not look back. A pharmacist does not.

But at the green shutters, she paused, with her hand upon the door, and a long, shy, secret curl came into the corner of her mouth, which Adwoa, from the kiosk, would swear to on any Bible you cared to name.

✦ ✦ ✦

And here the Rank, who had held its breath through the whole of it, let it out together, and since a Chorus must say something, said it in the only measure it knew, which is the rhythm of a taxi on a bad road:

Eighty yards of tar, and neither one would take it; A tin upon a bonnet, and neither one would break it. She said, I owe thee. He said, Thou owest not. The sun went down on two proud hearts, both caught. Oh, who will count the cedis? None of us, we think. The debt is made of kindness, and kindness has no ink.

"That is not bad," said Quaye, wiping his eyes. "Who wrote it?"

"You did," said Yaw, "just now."

"Then I am a poet, and I demand a rise."

✦ ✦ ✦

That night, when the Rank had gone home and the dust had settled and the lane was as dark as a good conscience, Kwame Mensah went out to the green Corolla alone, and took the tin from the bonnet, and carried it to his office, and sat before it for a very long time.

He did not count the money.

He had promised.

But he turned the tin over once, as a man turns a stone, and under the lid, in neat violet pharmacist's ink, on a white sticky label of the kind that she used for the dosage on every bottle in her shop, was a line in her small straight hand:

TAKE AS DIRECTED. MAY CAUSE DROWSINESS, DIZZINESS AND UNEXPECTED FEELINGS. DO NOT OPERATE HEAVY MACHINERY UNTIL YOU HAVE CALLED.

And, beneath that, smaller, as if she had changed her mind and been too stubborn to cross it out:

(Eighty yards. I counted.)

Kwame Mensah, who had never been seen to cry, sat in the harmattan dark with a biscuit-tin on his knee, and laughed like a prisoner released from a long sentence, till the goat in the yard woke and complained.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, S.W.R.:

Entry 0625 and Entry 0941. Between them eighty yards of Accra, a tin, and six years of arithmetic. They think they are settling accounts. They are doing the opposite. A debt, rightly held, is the surest bond that two people can share: it is a thing each has promised the other never to forget.
I once lent a man a book. I never asked for it back. Reader, I am still waiting for the return.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 3.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 4: The Critic Who Would Not Taste

“I cook one bowl each night for the woman who never returned.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0510

✦ ✦ ✦

The people of Osaka are said to eat until they fall down. The expression is *kuidaore*, and the city is proud of it, as other cities are proud of their cathedrals.

On the night of the new moon, in the narrow alley behind the Tenma canal where the lanterns hang so close together that they gossip, there was a shop with eight stools, one counter, a curtain the colour of old tea, and a single man. The curtain bore, in letters faded by many winters, the words **TANABE-YA**. The man bore a white towel about his head, a pair of forearms scarred with small honest burns, and a silence so complete that his regulars had been known to lose money betting on it.

“Seven words,” said Daichi Ito, setting his phone upon the counter. “My calculation. Since opening at six. *Irasshai. Hai. Mō ippai? Arigatō.* That is four. And a *nn*, which I count as a half, and a cough, which I do not.”

“Cough counts,” said Rin Hayashi, from the third stool.

“A cough is not a *word.*”

“It is when *he* does it.”

Daichi, thirty-four, a historian from Kobe who was said to be writing a history of the noodle and was believed by his friends to have been writing it since the Meiji era, folded his hands. He was a superstitious man. He would not sit at a table of four, nor whistle at night, nor begin a chapter on a Friday, and for the past fourteen months he had also declined, with a small shudder, to look at stool number eight.

For stool number eight was empty. It was always empty. Though the shop was full, though salarymen stood in the alley in the November chill with their collars up and their breath standing before them, stool eight stayed bare, and at the end of the counter, in front of it, a place was laid: lacquered chopsticks upon a rest, a glass of water, and a small blue towel, folded in thirds.

At eleven-forty, Hiroshi Tanabe would make one bowl.

He made it exactly as he made all the others: the clear brown broth, fourteen hours in the pot, kombu and pork bone and dried bonito and a hundred small secrets; the noodles, thin and straight and springy, lowered into the water for exactly the time that it takes to say a short prayer; the pale slice of pork, the half-egg gone soft as a thought, the green onion cut so fine that it looked like a rumour. He set it upon the counter before the empty stool. He stood back, and bowed to the air.

And for twenty minutes, while the room went quiet, the bowl sat, and steamed, and cooled.

“It is a *ghost,*” whispered Daichi. “I have told you. It is a ghost, and it eats.”

“It does not eat,” said Rin. “I have watched.”

“That is *because* it is a ghost.”

“Daichi. The man gives it a bowl. At midnight he pours it into the sink.”

“Into the *sink?*”

“And then he washes the bowl, by hand, and dries it, and puts it on the shelf with the others, and does not use it again.” Rin looked at the broad, silent back at the stove. “Four hundred and twenty-six nights.”

“He is counting?”

“He has counted since he was a boy. I think he counts the way other men pray.”

At the stove, without turning round, Hiroshi lifted one finger from the ladle, lightly, as a conductor does. It meant: *you are speaking of what is mine.*

Daichi shrank. Rin laughed. In the corner a very old woman in a quilted jacket, who had been shelling pickles for an hour into a steel bowl, said briskly, in the high dry voice of Kyoto, which she had never surrendered, “*Honma, you boys are noisy. My son hears everything. He has been hearing everything since he was four years old. He just does not say.*”

“Obā-san,” said Rin, with deep respect. “You know the story?”

Nanami Shimizu, seventy, retired schoolteacher, gossip, and Hiroshi's mother, placed a pickle in her mouth, looked at the ceiling, and said, with a profound air of withholding:

"I know *some* of it."

✦ ✦ ✦

Across the canal, five floors up, in an apartment of white walls and exactly three plants, a woman sat in the dark with her phone, and did not weep. She had learned not to. Weeping, since the illness, had a flavour of nothing, which is the worst flavour of all.

Her name was Mei Sato. She was thirty-three, and for six years she had been the most feared and most loved restaurant critic in Osaka: author of the Sunday column *A Hundred Bowls,* in the *Naniwa Shimbun,* wherein she had once reduced a three-star kaiseki master to tears with the single sentence *"The soup is afraid of its own salt."* People said that Mei Sato could taste the sorrow in a sauce. They said she could name the hand that held the ladle. They said, in the tone of men who fear for their trade, that if you wished to be remembered, you should be eaten by Mei Sato.

Fourteen months ago she had had a fever, a common one, of the sort that arrives on a Tuesday and is forgotten by Friday. On Saturday she had sat down before a bowl of her favourite *tamagoyaki,* and had tasted nothing.

Not weak. *Nothing.* A warm softness, as of wet cloth. Salt, a ghost of salt, there and then not. She had put down her chopsticks and had looked at the egg, which

was yellow, and glistening, and perfectly made, and had understood that she was standing at the edge of a country from which she would not be permitted to return.

"I'm *telling* you," said Nanami Yamamoto, from the sofa, with the severity of someone who works the Tempozan ferry in all weathers and never takes back a word. "You are going to the doctor."

"I have been to six doctors."

"Go to a seventh."

"They say it is the nerve. They say it may return. They say it may not." Mei's voice was flat. "They say, *Miss Sato, you are very lucky; you can still smell lemon.* I can smell lemon, Nanami. I cannot taste a lemon. A lemon is a shape and a cold."

"So what do you do? With the *column?*"

There it was. The question that her friend had waited fourteen months to ask, and had asked only on the night when the whole country was reading its own heart in a stranger's ledger.

Mei said nothing for a long while.

"I write from memory," she said at last. "Every Sunday, I go to a shop. I sit. I order. I watch the faces of the people eating. I hear the sound the noodles make, I feel the heat, I watch the way a man closes his eyes when the broth goes down. And I write what I *remember* it would taste like, if it were good. Or bad." She put down the phone. "I have been right, Nanami. Mostly I have been right. That is the shame of it. I am a counterfeit whose forgeries are better than the originals."

“Your editor knows?”

“Mr. Kato suspects. He has begun sending me to places that cannot lie. Tofu shops. Plain noodles.” She smiled. It was a dreadful smile. “And Sakura at the newsstand, who thinks she can do my job better than I, has begun to read my column aloud with a very peculiar voice.”

“Sakura Takahashi is a *snake.*”

“She is a newsagent. It is the same thing, with more weather.”

Nanami laughed, in spite of herself. Then she took the phone from the table, thumbed it alight, and without speaking held the screen out, as a nurse holds out a cup.

ENTRY 0510 — Osaka, Japan. “I cook one bowl each night for the woman who never returned.”

Mei looked at it.

She looked at it for a time that was a good deal longer than it takes to read eleven words.

Entry 0810 — Osaka, Japan. “I can no longer taste a thing, and I am ashamed.” That one was hers; she had written it three nights after the fever, to a woman in England who would never tell. It stood two columns to the right. They did not touch. They did not need to.

“You know him,” said Nanami.

“I have not seen him in fourteen months.”

“But you know who he is.”

“He is the best cook in Osaka,” said Mei Sato, in a voice she did not recognise as her own. “He was my Thursday for two years. Seat eight. He never asked me what I thought. He did not need to. I would eat, and I would put down my chopsticks, and he would look at the bowl, and I would nod, and that was the whole of the review. And then the fever came. And I could not go back to the one man who would know, in a *glance,* that the nod was a lie.”

“So you did not go.”

“So I did not go.”

“For fourteen months.”

“I am a very *disciplined* coward,” said Mei.

She rose and went to the window. Below, in the long black ribbon of the canal, the lights of the city lay broken and trembling. A boat went by, with a small red lantern at its prow, and a man singing.

It was then, as she stood against the glass, that she spoke, not to Nanami, and not to the night, but to the thing in between that is called the heart’s ear, and she did not do so in prose:

They say the tongue remembers what it loved. They lie. The tongue forgets. It is the mind That holds the sweetness, and the mind grows thin. I have a hundred bowls inside my head, And every one is cold. I taste them still The way a blind man tastes the sun: by heat, By the soft weight of light upon the skin. He cooked for me four hundred nights and six, And I was not there to be disappointed. Oh, cruel kindness, to forgive so hard A woman who has nothing

left to judge! I will go down. I will not eat. I will sit
And let him see me not taste, and be shamed, And
then at last be free.

"That," said Nanami Yamamoto, wiping her eyes, "was extremely *bad* for a woman with no sense of taste."

"I had a metaphor."

"You had a *sword.* Go. Go before you think of a better one."

✦ ✦ ✦

It is a fact little known to those who have not suffered it that the world, when stripped of flavour, grows louder.

Mei Sato walked the six minutes to the alley and was astonished by it. She could not smell the sweet-sour breath of the *takoyaki* stall, with its octopus and its bonito flakes dancing in the steam. She could not smell the grilled eel, nor the fried batter, nor the sea-reek of the canal. But she could *hear* it all: the clack of a tin spatula; the hiss of oil; the laughter, the high laughter, of three girls in rain-capes; a vendor calling "*Atsui, atsui!*" in the cracked tenor of a man who has sold hot things for forty years. She could *see* it. She could feel the warmth of every shop-front as she passed, on one cheek and then the other, like a series of small hands.

She came to the curtain at eleven-thirty-eight.

She did not go in. She stood at the gap between the cloth and the post, and looked.

He was there. Of course he was there. He was in the white towel, with his back to the room and his hands upon the pot, a heavy, still, unhurried man, and she saw

the shoulders that she had watched for two years, and a thing happened inside her that she had not been prepared for; homesickness for a house she was standing in front of.

The regulars were silent. The old woman at the end had stopped shelling pickles. The historian, with the wide eyes of one who has seen the dead, was holding his phone aloft as though to capture a miracle.

And then, at the exact stroke of eleven-forty, Hiroshi Tanabe lowered noodles into the water.

She watched him make it. She had always wished to watch him make it, and had never done so, for a critic does not stare at the cook; it is a breach of the contract. But now she was no critic. She was a woman in a doorway. She saw him lift the noodles with the long chopsticks in one smooth turn of the wrist and shake them, twice, with a motion like a bell-ringer's. She saw the broth go in, the colour of dark amber. She saw the egg laid down, the onion scattered, the pale pork fanned like a hand of cards.

She saw him set the bowl before the empty stool, and stand, and bow.

And then she did the one thing she had not told Nanami she would do.

She pushed aside the curtain.

✦ ✦ ✦

There is a particular noise, in a small room full of people, when a sound that has been expected for fourteen months finally arrives. It is not a gasp. It is much quieter

than that. It is the sound of eight strangers deciding, simultaneously, to hold their breath.

"*Irasshai,*" said Hiroshi Tanabe.

He had not turned. He had known her footstep, as he might have known the footstep of weather.

"I am sorry," said Mei. "I am late."

He said nothing. His mother, at the far end, said "*Ara,*" very softly, and put down a pickle.

Mei crossed the floor. It was a short floor, four steps, and she took each of them as one crosses ice. She sat on stool number eight. It was warm. It was warmer than the room. And it took her a moment to understand why, and when she did, she nearly stood up again: it was *kept* warm. He had placed upon it, earlier that evening, a small heated cushion, such as the old use in winter, and had plugged it in at the wall, and had done so for four hundred and twenty-six nights.

She put her hands in her lap.

"It is still hot," said Hiroshi.

It was the first thing he had said, in her hearing, in three years that was not *irasshai* or *arigatō.* His voice was low, and very slow, like a bell struck in a distant temple. "It has been on the counter two minutes. The broth holds."

"Hiroshi-san," said Mei.

"Eat."

"I *cannot.*"

She had meant to say it better. She had meant to say it with the whole of her critic's armoury of syntax and irony. What came instead was five words, flat on the counter like a dropped plate, and she heard them, and did not take them back.

"I cannot taste," said Mei Sato. "Since September of last year. A fever. It has not come back. I write about food and cannot taste it, and I am so ashamed that I have not been able to walk down your street." Her eyes were stinging, which she found, in an odd detached way, to be very interesting. "I wrote a column every Sunday from *memory.* I am a fraud. I do not deserve a bowl. I do not deserve a *stool.* You should pour it down the sink."

She waited for the blow.

In the shop, you could have heard a noodle fall.

"I know," said Hiroshi.

"You—?"

"Your column." He wiped his hands upon the towel, slowly, one finger at a time. "Eleven weeks ago. The shop at Namba. You wrote that the broth was *a clear autumn pond.* Their broth is thick. It is a pig's bath. A person who had *tasted* it would not say *pond.*" He paused. "You do not make mistakes by being wrong. You make them by being *beautiful.* I knew."

"And you cooked for me *anyway?*"

"I did not cook for the critic," said Hiroshi Tanabe. "I cooked for the woman who ate my noodles with her eyes closed."

He set down the chopsticks on their rest. Then, because great events, for him, could only be expressed in small adjustments, he turned the bowl, a quarter-turn, so that the handle of the spoon lay toward her right hand.

"Eat," he said. "Not to taste. To be *fed.*"

✦ ✦ ✦

The old woman at the end of the counter had her hand upon her mouth. The historian had lowered the phone. Rin Hayashi, who had been a lifeguard for eight years and had pulled four swimmers out of Osaka Bay, now found himself with a lump in the throat, and addressed it to the ceiling.

Mei took up the chopsticks. They were light, and made of some pale wood, and they were warm from his hand.

She lifted the noodles. She was astonished to find that she knew them; that her whole arm remembered the weight, the long smooth resistance, the little spring of them against the lips. They went into her mouth, and she tasted nothing, a hot softness, an oil, a coolness of onion that was only cold. She drank the broth. It was heat, and the memory of heat, and a faint richness upon the lip.

She closed her eyes.

She was a critic. She had been trained for a decade to name what she ate. And so she sat in the dark of her own eyelids, with the steam against her chin, and lis-

tened to a room full of people not speaking, and attempted for the first time in fourteen months to say not what was *in* the bowl, but what the bowl was *for*.

"It is warm," said Mei.

"Yes."

"It is the warmest thing I have been given in a year."

He did not answer. She heard the faint scrape of a ladle. When she opened her eyes, he was standing over her with the pot, and was, with a gentle, almost shy movement, filling the bowl again to the brim, as one tops up the lamp of a vigil kept too long.

"Kaedama," said Hiroshi. "Second noodles. Free."

"Hiroshi."

"I have been told," said the cook, "I am too quiet."

He bowed. It was the smallest bow she had ever seen, no more than a lowering of the eyes, but the whole shop saw it, and the old woman at the end rose, and so did Rin, and so did the salarymen from the alley in their damp coats, and the girls in rain-capes, and Daichi Ito, historian, who had begun to cry, and who had to be given a pickle.

Behind them all, from the corner, a high excited voice said, quite clearly: "*It worked! Look! Look at the picture! The ghost bowl! Eight thousand likes!*"

This was Daichi's young cousin, aged sixteen, who had been sitting very still beside the pickle-jar for an hour with her phone held steady, and who had, in the confusion of the great moment, taken an excellent photograph

of an empty stool, a perfect bowl, and, in the foreground, out of focus and unmistakable, the back of a woman's head.

Nobody had heard her. Nobody ever does, at the beginning.

"Hush," said Hiroshi's mother, taking the phone away and putting it among the pickles. "Let her eat."

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, S.W.R.:

Entry 0510 cooked four hundred and twenty-six bowls for a woman who could not taste them. Entry 0810 hid for fourteen months from a man who would not have minded. Reader, I have known critics, and I have known cooks. The former tell you what is wrong with the world; the latter feed it. She thinks that she has lost the thing she was. She has only mislaid the part that could be fooled. (And somebody, I note, has taken a photograph. Never trust the cousins.)

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End of Chapter 4.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 5: The Pianist’s Silence

“I wrote a waltz for you and never asked you to dance.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0234

✦ ✦ ✦

In St Petersburg the first snow does not fall. It is *issued,* like an order, from a sky the colour of an old spoon, and the whole city, which has been waiting for it with the stoicism of a very long marriage, pulls up its collar and carries on.

It was issued that Thursday at four in the afternoon, upon the Fontanka, upon the bronze horses, upon the green roof of the Nevsky Chamber Theatre, which on this night, of all nights in its hundred and twenty years, was giving a gala.

“A *gala,*” said Sergei Orlov, with the reverent contempt of one who has to sew it. “Eleven hundred sequins on the soprano alone. She has asked for a train. I said, Madam, there is no room on the stage for a train; she said, then we shall move the stage.”

“And have you?” said Dmitri Volkov, from the piano.

“I have moved the *soprano.*”

The theatre at that hour was a cavern of dust and half-light, full of ladders and the smell of size and varnish and hot lamps. In the pit, at a black Bechstein with a cracked lid and a candle-stub on the music-desk (against all regulations, and by common consent of the fire-marshal, who was a patron), sat the pianist, in the stiff dark jacket he had worn to every rehearsal for sixteen years, and he was running through the programme, which he had printed on a single sheet and pinned to the wall like a bill of indictment.

He was forty. He had a long grave face with a good deal of forehead in it, a pair of hands that seemed borrowed from a much taller man, and a courtesy so rigid it could have served as scaffolding. He rose when women entered rooms. He apologised to doors. He had accompanied, in his time, four hundred performances of the repertory and one funeral, and had never once been heard to say what he thought of any of them.

"Number nine," said Sergei, reading the sheet over his shoulder, for he read everything over everybody's shoulder; it was a vice, and a devout one, for he said that God had given him two eyes so that one might guard the other. "*Waltz.* Composer: *Anonymous.* Dmitri Andreyevich, you cannot do this. A gala is for the *famous* dead. Nobody will know whose it is."

"That is the idea."

"It is a very strange idea."

"It is a very *short* waltz," said Dmitri, "and I should like it to be heard without being explained."

"And who is the dedicatee?"

“There is no dedicatee.”

“I did not say *dedicatee,*” said Sergei Orlov, who was fifty-seven, a dressmaker, a deacon’s cousin and a man of subtle instruments. “I said *who is it for?* A tune like that is never for *no one.* I have heard you at night, Dmitri. Every night when the house is dark you play it, twenty-four bars, very soft, as if you were arguing with a ghost. The whole fourth floor knows it. The boy who sweeps the stairs whistles it.”

“Sergei.”

“The ballet mistress hums it.”

“*Sergei.*”

“Madam Petrova’s students have been heard to *dance* to it,” said Sergei, and then, with the instinct of a good tailor who knows exactly when to put down the shears, stopped.

Dmitri did not turn his head. He did not stiffen. He did not do any of the things that a man does when a nerve has been touched, because for sixteen years he had practised not doing them. He merely placed one hand flat on the closed lid of the Bechstein, as one steadies a horse, and said in his most perfectly courteous voice:

“The snow will be heavy by seven. I should like the stage-door lamp to be lit.”

“It will be lit.”

“Thank you.”

“It is no trouble,” said Sergei. And, thoughtfully, after a long moment, to the empty house: “It is *all* trouble.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Above the theatre, on the fourth floor, in a studio with a bare wooden floor and a long barre and a window from which one may see, on a clear night, the whole slow shining curve of the river, a woman of thirty-eight stood with her hand on a child's back.

"*Longer,*" said Anya Petrova. "The neck is a swan, not a *goose.* Yuri, are you listening? You are standing like a man waiting for a bus."

"I'm waiting for you to say stop, Anna Sergeyevna."

"I shall say stop when you have *earned* it."

The boy was twelve, thin as a blade of grass, with a cough he had had since October and a determination to conceal it that touched her more than she would allow. His name was Yuri Orlov. He was the best pupil in the school and the worst liar, and she did not mention the cough. She had her reasons. She had been told by doctors, when she was thirty-two, that a knee is a hinge and a dancer's knee a hinge made of glass, and she had learned in the long winter afterward which truths to press and which to leave, like a sheet, folded.

She had been, for ten years, the first dancer of the Nevsky. They had written about her in four languages. They had compared her to a candle, to a bird, to a thing seen once in a childhood dream; and then one night in the second act of a ballet she had danced two hundred times, the left knee had gone out beneath her, quietly, like a lamp in the next room, and she had finished the act on one leg and sat down in the wings, and had not stood on a stage since.

That was six years ago.

She walked now with the slightest hitch, a faint hesitation upon the left foot as it landed, so small that strangers took it for a mannerism and friends for a courage. She had a bad temper, a good sister, and a flat above a theatre in which every night, after the last curtain, a man sat down at a piano in the dark and played twenty-four bars of waltz.

"It is a very *beautiful* waltz," said the boy shyly, and the sentence went through her like a fork.

"What waltz?"

"The one he plays. Upstairs. Downstairs. I do not know where. I hear it through the floor." He coloured. "Seryozha says it is yours."

"Seryozha is a *rumour* in a cardigan."

"But is it?"

"Plié," said Anya Petrova. "*Now.*"

✦ ✦ ✦

She had known it, of course, from the first night.

She had known it as a woman knows her own footfall upon an empty stair. It had come up through the old planks of the studio, one night in the first winter after her fall, a small clear waltz in three-quarter time, very simple, very sad; twenty-four bars, and then silence; and then the same twenty-four again. At first she had thought it a student's piece. By the third night she had stopped doing her exercises and sat upon the floor with

her back against the barre, in her stockinged feet, with her good leg tucked under her and the bad one stretched out, and counted.

In the seventh bar, upon the third beat, there was a rest. A small one. An eighth-note's silence, no more; a hitch, like a breath caught on a stair.

She had *limped* there.

Not on the stage, where she had never limped; in the corridor. In the back stair. She had gone up and down it every evening for six years, and somebody, lying in the dark beneath her, had listened, and had put it in the music.

She had told no one. Not Natalia, her sister, who kept an inn on Kronstadt and cried at weddings. Not Oleg Popov, the policeman, her oldest friend, a thin wry man who had stood guard over her pride for twenty years and had never once been asked to. She had gone on listening. She had gone on being too proud to knock on the door of a man who was too proud to knock on hers.

And on Monday of that week, a niece of Sergei's had put a telephone in her hands and said, "Anna Sergeyevna, you must look; it is the *Register*—" and she had looked.

Entry 0234 — St Petersburg, Russia. "I wrote a waltz for you and never asked you to dance."

And there, in the same column, on the other side of the night:

Entry 0017 — St Petersburg, Russia. "I heard the waltz and knew it was mine."

She had written that one herself. She had sat up on a winter night six months before, and had written it, and had posted it to an address on the English coast; and had never, until that Monday, understood that somewhere in the same city, on the same night, a man had been writing the other half of her sentence.

"You are not going," said her sister on the telephone, in the voice of an innkeeper who has lost a patience contest.

"I am not."

"They have sent you the card. *Madam Petrova is invited as guest of honour.* Anechka, you have refused six times. You are a woman of principle."

"I am a woman with a *knee.*"

"Then sit down in a box."

"I will not be looked at, Natasha. I will not be *observed* by eleven hundred people to see if I weep."

"Then do not be *in* the box." Natalia Lebedev, thirty-five, innkeeper, sister, had a quick brutal mind that she hid inside a soft round face. "Go to the wings. Go where you used to stand. Stand in the dark behind the black cloth, where nobody can see you and you can hear every note. And if you do not like it, you can go home. And if you do—" She stopped.

"If I do?"

"Then you shall have heard it," said Natalia, "without having to decide anything."

It was, Anya thought afterward, the wisest thing that had been said to her in six years, and she hated it with a fervour she kept for what was true.

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By half past seven the Nevsky was full.

It was full to the roof: a sea of black and gold, of furs steaming in the warmth, of jewelled throats and old men with medals, and in the pit the musicians were tuning like birds in a dispute. Dr. Oleg Morozov, the chairman of the board, who was also, by one of those arrangements that history makes when it is bored, the theatre's dentist, rose upon the stage to deliver his speech. He had a toothache. He had had it for three days. Every sentence, therefore, came out with a certain compressed fury, like a man reading the Gospel through a hot coal.

"*Ladies and gentlemen!* One hundred and twenty years! A *great* theatre! A theatre of tradition! Of *courage!* Of—" he put a hand to his jaw "—*molars.*"

A rustle went through the house.

"Of *moral* fibre," said Dr. Morozov, recovering, and sat down, and was seen, in the dark, to be offered a clove by the soprano.

The gala went on. A tenor sang, and a girl of sixteen played Prokofiev with her whole face; a mezzo wept in an aria and was forgiven; a chorus of fifty old men from the Naval Choir sang a song about a river, and no one in the house, not the Chairman, nor the Minister's wife, nor the deaf man in the tenth row, was dry-eyed at the end. And in the wings, in a corner so black that the

stage-hands had learned never to look at it, a woman in a plain grey dress, with one hand upon the cold brick wall and the other gripping her own wrist, stood and waited.

She had not been seen. Sergei, who saw everything, had seen it, and had put his thumb to his lips, and gone to hide in a basket of wigs.

At twenty to ten, the stage emptied. The lights fell to a single warm pool at the centre. And out of the dark at the left walked a man in a stiff jacket, with his long hands at his sides, who crossed to a piano, and bowed to the house with the rigid exactness of a mourner at a public funeral, and sat.

The programme said: *9. Waltz. Anonymous.*

Eleven hundred people coughed, rustled and settled. A woman in the third row said, in a whisper that carried: "Who is *he?*"

"The pianist," said her husband.

"But who is the *composer?*"

"Anonymous."

"I never heard of him."

"Nobody has," said the husband, with an air of finality, and was, for once in his marriage, entirely correct.

Dmitri Volkov raised his hands.

He did not look at the house. He looked, as he always did before the first note, at nothing, at a point a little above the music-desk, where, a pianist will tell you, the

first note is waiting. And in the wings, in the dark, with her hand upon the wall, Anya Petrova heard him breathe in.

And the waltz began.

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How shall the page say it? Music is the one confession that cannot be forged and cannot be translated. Let it be told, therefore, as the thing was done: plainly, and in three-quarter time.

It began in the left hand: a low, quiet, rocking figure, *one*, two, three, *one*, two, three, like a child being walked to sleep by a mother who is herself too tired to sleep. Over it, the right hand laid down a melody, small and clear, that went up a little way and came down again, as one goes up the stair of a house one has loved. It was not a grand waltz. It was not made for ballrooms. It was a waltz for a corridor: for a lamp at the end of a passage, and a person walking toward it who did not yet know that she was being watched.

And in the seventh bar, upon the third beat, the pianist let go his breath, and the music stopped.

One eighth-note. Barely more.

It was not a hesitation. It was an *attention.* It was the sound of a man standing at the foot of a stair, listening to a footstep that he has loved so long he knows each place where it falters, and *waiting for it,* as one waits for a friend who is always slightly late; holding the whole bar open like a door.

Then the melody went on.

In the wings, Anya Petrova made a sound.

It was not a sob. She would have been the first to say that she was not a woman who sobbed. It was a short, sharp, dry intake of breath, as of someone dipping their hand in cold water, and she pressed the heel of her hand against her mouth, and stood perfectly still; and the whole of her face, which had been for six years a face she held, was for the first time unguarded in the dark.

So that is how it sounds, to be forgiven. The thing I limped upon, and hid, and cursed, He took and made a rest in. I had thought The hinge was broken. He has made it music. Oh, you have listened to me going home, Alone, up all those stairs, and said not one Word of it, not one word, in six long years, But set it in the middle of a waltz Where all the city hears and no one knows. I should be angry. I am proud, I know it; I am a woman with a temper, and a knee. I should go out and strike him for his courage. I cannot move. I cannot, for I am Dancing. Here, in the dark, against the wall, My foot is keeping time.

It was true. She had not noticed. Under the long grey skirt, upon the bare boards of the wings, her left foot, her bad foot, had begun to move: a little, a very little, a small and obedient step, *one*, two, three, *one*, two, three: and upon the third beat of the seventh bar it paused, like a breath, and took the music up again.

The waltz ended as it had begun: quietly, with the left hand last, a single low chord that hung in the air like a held coat.

There was silence.

Eleven hundred people sat in it. They did not know why. A man in the front row, a retired admiral with a chestful of ribbons, was found afterward to have taken off his glasses and to be unable to find them. A woman in a green dress said, loudly, "*Well!*" and was hushed. And then somebody began to clap, a single pair of hands, high in the gods, and then the house.

Dmitri Volkov rose. He bowed, rigidly, to the dark. He did not look into the wings, because he did not know that anyone was in them. He turned, with his formal and perfect exactness, and walked off the opposite side, and the lights went up on an elderly baritone, who looked at the pianist's departing back with the deep and venomous envy of a man who must follow an act he cannot follow.

By the time the pianist had reached the stage-door, and stood there in the cold, with the snow on his shoulders and his long hands trembling, and the whole of the river dark beyond the lamp, the gala was nearly over; and the woman in the wings had gone.

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"Dmitri Andreyevich," said a voice at his elbow.

It was the voice of a man who has been doing something he is ashamed of for some time and now wishes to be congratulated upon it. Sergei Orlov, in his shirtsleeves and with a wig on his arm, was standing at the foot of the iron stair, holding a small cream envelope.

"This," said Sergei, "has been left for you."

"By whom?"

“By *nobody.*” He cleared his throat. “Under the stage-door lamp. In the snow. By a person with a slight hesitation on the left foot, who did not wait. And I should tell you, as an honest Christian, that I have read it, because it was folded, and an unfolded letter is an invitation, and I am weak.”

“Sergei.”

“I have *read it.* It is four lines. I want you to know, Dmitri Andreyevich, that I wept like a calf.”

Dmitri took the envelope. His hands were not steady, and he disliked the fact, and looked at it. Then, with the tact of one who had apologised to doors all his life, he drew out a single sheet, white as the snow, and unfolded it beneath the lamp.

There were four lines. They were written in a quick, proud, upright hand, with a pen pressed hard.

Seventh bar. Third beat. I limp there. How long have you been listening? Six years is a very long time to hold a door. — A.P.

He read it.

He read it again.

The snow fell, issued by the sky, upon the bronze horses and the green roof and the long black river. A tram went by, in a rattle of yellow light. On the fourth floor, in the window of a studio above the theatre, a lamp, which had not been lit in half an hour, came on.

“Well?” said Sergei Orlov, in a hushed and sacred voice, with the wig clutched to his bosom like a lamb. “What will you do?”

And Dmitri Volkov, who had played four hundred performances and one funeral, and who had never once been heard to say what he thought, folded the letter very carefully along its crease, put it in the inner pocket of his jacket, over his heart, and said, with an expression that no one in the whole Nevsky Chamber Theatre had seen on his face in sixteen years:

"I think I shall need to go upstairs."

"*Now?*"

"It is only four flights."

"It is *six years,*" said Sergei. "But go. Go, go. Take the lamp."

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Margin note, in pencil, S.W.R.:

Entry 0234 wrote a waltz for a woman he never asked to dance. Entry 0017 heard it through a floor for six years. Neither has knocked. Both, I observe, have lived in the same building the whole while. Reader, a man may stand at the foot of a stair for half his life, and call it patience. It is not patience. It is only that he has not yet been given the first step. (Four flights. I was a cautious woman, too. It is a long way to go for a thing that is only up.)

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End of Chapter 5.

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Chapter 6: Walls of Color

“Your face is on a hundred walls and you do not know.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0299

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Long after the dead have been fed, Mexico City still smells of marigolds.

They are everywhere: heaped in the Jamaica market in orange mountains, crushed in the gutters of the Roma, caught in the grilles of bus shelters and the hair of small girls, and weeks after the last candle has guttered on the last altar, their bitter gold perfume goes on hanging in the thin high air, as if the city were not yet quite sure that the visitors had gone home.

It was in this season, upon a scaffold of rusted pipe on the Calle Zacatecas, in the blue hour before dawn, that a young man named Rafael Ortega stood with a bucket of cobalt blue in his left hand, a radio blasting a ranchera into the whole sleeping neighbourhood, and the end of a very large nose upon his right.

It was the nose of a woman. It was thirty feet high. It was one of a hundred and three.

“She has the *worst* nose,” said Marisol García, holding the ladder, from the street. “It’s too long, Rafa. She looks like a heron who has read a lot.”

“It is the nose of a *lawyer.* A woman who reads like that is going to be a lawyer or a saint. She had a book as thick as a loaf. She was frowning at it as though it had insulted her mother.” He leaned back, with one foot on a plank and the other on empty air. “And she was *right.* Whatever the book had said.”

“You saw her once, at the Parque México, in the rain, two Novembers ago. And once in a dream.”

“The dream,” said Rafael, “was more *detailed.*”

He was twenty-six, loud, broad in the shoulder and long in the leg, with a mop of black hair stiff with a decade of paint and a pair of eyes in which every emotion arrived at once and nobody was ever in charge. He painted as other men argue: with his whole body, at the top of his lungs. In two years he had covered, without a permit, without a sponsor, and without, as far as anyone could tell, any plan, a hundred and three walls of the capital with a single face.

It was always the same. A young woman on a bench, reading. Her hair fell forward over one shoulder; her mouth was set in a line of ferocious concentration; her head was bowed, and her eyes, upon every one of the hundred and three, were *closed.* The critics called it *La Lectora.* The children called it *La Señorita Que No Se Cansa.* The city had begun to leave small offerings at the foot of her bigger walls: a marigold; a pencil; once, on the Calle Chihuahua, a copy of the Civil Code.

“And why,” said Marisol, who was forty-five, and a painter, and had known him since he was a boy with chalk on his knees, “are the *eyes* shut?”

Rafael did not answer for a moment. A truck went past. On the radio, a man sang of a girl who had broken his heart in Guadalajara.

“Because I do not know,” he said at last, “what colour they are.”

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At the end of the block, in the thin first light, there was a policeman.

He was a very fine policeman. He had a moustache of formidable architecture, a belt that creaked with importance, and a profile that he turned, wherever he stood, slightly to the left, so that the world might benefit from its better side. His name was Alejandro Hernández. He was forty-five and had been making Rafael Ortega’s life a misery for two years, with that peculiar tenderness that exists between a man and the thing he is obliged to fine.

“*Ortega!*” called the officer. “Article forty-one of the Civic Culture Law! Unauthorised alteration of a building!”

“It is a *wall,* Commandante!”

“It is the property of a private citizen!”

“The private citizen has asked me to do it. He is eighty. He is weeping with joy. He has given me a plate of *tamales.*”

“The tamales will be taken into evidence.”

“They are in my stomach.”

“Then your stomach will be taken into evidence.” But the policeman’s eye had strayed up to the wall, as it always did, as it had done on the hundred and two previous walls; and as always he found himself regarding the great painted face with an expression in which severity and something else contended. He cocked his head. He turned his profile. He regarded the line of the painted jaw.

“That *jaw,*” said Alejandro Hernández, slowly.

“What of it?”

“It is a very strong jaw.”

“It is a woman’s jaw, Commandante.”

“I have been told,” said the policeman, “I have a similar jaw. I have been told that by a number of people, including the *barber*.” He folded his arms. “I have the impression, Ortega, over two years, that you have been painting a *portrait.* And I do not wish to say that I believe it is *me.* I only wish to observe that the resemblance is *close.*”

“Commandante. It is a *girl.*”

“A girl with my jaw.”

“She is twenty-five.”

“A *young* girl,” said Alejandro Hernández, with a shiver of indignant satisfaction, “with *my* jaw.” He took out his citation book. He wrote, for a long time. Then he tore the sheet out and handed it up on the end of his baton, which was long enough, and said gruffly, like one

who has had a lot to bear and very little to say: “That is a fine for the scaffold. For the *painting,* I make no comment.”

“Thank you.”

“I am saving money to disappear, you know,” said the Commandante, staring into the middle distance. “To a small village in Oaxaca. To keep goats. I tell this to no one.”

“You have just told it to a street.”

“It is a *private* street,” said the policeman, and walked away down it, with a tread that was faintly unsteady, and his profile turned to the left.

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Three kilometres to the south, in an apartment in the Colonia Narvarte with a map of the capital pinned to the kitchen wall, a young woman was losing an argument with her best friend, and enjoying it.

“It is *circumstantial,*” said Camila Reyes.

“It is a hundred and three walls,” said Lupita Hernández, who was a chef at a restaurant in Xochimilco, twenty-five, round-faced, unalarmable, and had arrived at six in the morning with a pan of *chilaquiles* and a phone. “You have been to ninety-one. You keep the list in a *drawer.*”

“I keep the list *for research.*”

“On what?”

“On the phenomenon of *public portraiture.*”

“Cami. The woman has your nose.”

“A nose is not evidence of identity.”

“Show me a heron,” said Lupita, “who reads the Constitution, in a coat, with *that* chin.”

Camila Reyes, twenty-five, fourth-year student of law at the National University, and the most disciplined human being in the south of the city, shut her eyes. She was a small, plain, intense young woman with her hair twisted up in a pencil, a flat voice that she used on judges, and a heart that she kept, by long habit, in the same drawer as the list. She had lived all her life by the principle that a fact is a fact and a feeling is an *allegation.* She had noticed the first wall two Decembers ago, on the Avenida Álvaro Obregón, when she was walking home with her books, and had stopped dead in the middle of the pavement, and had stood there for twenty minutes with a bag of oranges, because a thirty-foot woman with her own mouth was reading her own case-book, in the rain, with her eyes shut.

She had been very *angry.* It had taken her a month to understand why: it is uncomfortable to be seen by a stranger, and seen *accurately.*

“Read me his,” said Lupita softly.

Camila took the phone.

Entry 0299 — Mexico City, Mexico. “Your face is on a hundred walls and you do not know.”

“He’s wrong,” said Camila.

“Is he?”

“I *do* know.”

“I know you know. *He* doesn’t.”

“And mine?” said Camila, very low. “Show me mine.”

Entry 0121 — Mexico City, Mexico. “I have walked to every wall to find the hand that painted me.”

She had written it at three in the morning, after the eighty-ninth wall, and posted it to England in a general despair. It was a very unlawyerly sentence, with no conditionals, no reservations and no precedent: the single honest line in her entire body of written work.

“There is a new wall,” said Lupita, scrolling, with the finger of a conspirator. “On Zacatecas, in the Roma. It went up *last night.* The one that was at the top of the page. Everyone says it is the biggest. Everyone says—” she paused “—it has a *tag.*”

“A *what?*”

“A line at the bottom. Hand-lettered. It says, *To the one who reads: I have not finished your eyes.*”

Camila Reyes stood perfectly still, in her kitchen, with a map on the wall behind her and a hundred and three pins in it, and a plate of chilaquiles going cold.

“What time,” she said, “is the light?”

“Half past six,” said Lupita, who was a chef and knew about mornings. “He paints at first light.”

“It is ten to six.”

“I know.”

“I am going to need a coat.”

“I have brought you,” said Lupita, who had been right in advance, “*two.*”

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Dhaka, 22:41. Yogyakarta, 23:41.

(Between the two cities and the two walls: a small thing, a pulse of light. Let us listen.)

In the corner of a lane in Mirpur, under a tin awning thick with the smoke of evening stoves, a tea-stall boy named Bunny, thirteen, was explaining the art of the *cha* to a customer who had not asked.

“The secret,” said Bunny, “is not the leaf. The secret is the *wait.* You must let it sit exactly as long as it takes a man to decide whether he is going to be a coward. And then you pour. Here, Bhaiya.”

Fayaz Rahman, twenty-six, took the glass with the weary courtesy of someone just home from a fourteen-hour day on a contract paid in a currency not his own. He had walked here from his flat with a laptop that smelled of hot dust, and he sat on a bench with his sleeves down and his shoes grey with dust, looking at his phone without looking at it, as men do who have been waiting for a week without admitting it.

For eight nights he had read the Register on his phone. He had read the line beside his own, and then he had read it again. He had not written to the girl who had written it. He had begun, perhaps forty times. He had typed *Dear* and deleted it; he had typed *Hello* and deleted it; he had once typed *I don’t wish to intrude* and had deleted that so hard the whole screen went white. Politeness, in an hour of need, offers so many ways of not saying it.

And then the phone, in his hand, in the lane, under the tin and the smoke, gave a small pale shiver.

It was not a ring. It was only the tiniest of lights, an envelope, a name.

Ermis Larasati: *Hello, Dhaka. You are one hour behind. I am not sorry about it.*

He read it.

He read it a second time, which is to say, he went on reading it, though the sentence had long since ended, as a man goes on holding a door after the guest has come in.

Behind his shoulder, in the steam of the stall, Bunny, who was a boy of the most spotless discretion and no manners whatsoever, had planted his chin.

"*Bhaiya,*" said Bunny, in a hushed and terrible voice.

"Do not read it."

"I was not reading it. I was *visiting.*"

"She is a *stranger.*"

"She is a stranger," said Bunny, "who has an hour to *spare* and has *sent* it to you. That is not an ordinary thing. Say *hello* with *dignity.*"

"I am a person," said Fayaz, with a faint despairing smile, "who apologises to a vending machine."

He did not say that. He typed, in the end, a thing that took him three minutes and cost him a pound of nerves and read, when it was done, exactly like the work of a man who had spent three minutes on it, which is to say, honestly:

Fayaz Rahman: *Sorry. (Reflex. It was not about the hour.) Hello, Yogyakarta. I would tell you everything, if I were free to. May I tell you a little?*

He looked at it. His thumb hovered. A bead of steam ran off the awning and down his wrist.

He sent it.

The word *delivered* appeared. The word *seen* appeared beneath it, almost at once, small and grey and merciless.

And now it was her turn. She sat, in her workshop, an hour ahead of him, at the exact minute a week since the old astronomer's margin had pencilled them side by side; at 23:41, by the clock above the door, with the stove burnt down and the wax gone cold and a copper pen lying idle in its dish; and beside her, on the rail of the window, eyeing her with a cold and bottomless suspicion, a large green bird.

"*TOO LATE,*" said Ayu.

"Hush."

"*TOO LATE. BEAUTIFUL.*"

"I said hush!" said Ermis, and laughed, once, with her hand to her mouth, like a girl caught at a keyhole. The phone was shaking in her hand. She looked at what he had written. *Sorry. Reflex.* She looked at it again.

It was not what she had expected. She had expected something cool: a *Thank you for your message.* She had not expected an apology for a thing he had not done, nor that it would feel so *exactly* like the thing she had been listening for.

She typed. She deleted. She typed.

She did not draw a flower on the corner this time. She simply wrote, in the Latin letters she used for clients and for strangers, and sent it before she could think better of her own hand:

Ermis Larasati: *A little is how every pattern starts. Begin.*

And then, because it was a night in which courage was in the air like a smell of marigolds, and nobody was watching but a parrot, she put down the phone and laid her forehead for a moment against the cold edge of the table, and said, very softly, in Javanese, a word that was only a name.

Three lines, the reader will say. *That is all?* It is the whole of the matter: a lamp lit, a hand raised, a small, stiff, honourable reply. The great speeches are seldom long. They fit upon a telephone, and are said at night, across an hour.

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Calle Zacatecas, Colonia Roma. Half past six.

The light came up over the Roma as it comes up over every Mexican morning: not as a dawn, but as an *announcement,* the whole east flushing from lemon to rose to a gold so fierce it seemed to have been purchased. The pigeons rose off the roofs in a clatter.

And on the pavement, below the longest and newest of the hundred and three walls, in a borrowed coat, with her hair coming out of its pencil and her heart, which

she had kept in a drawer, now beating in her ears like a fist, stood a young woman looking up.

It was *her*. It was, without any possibility of doubt, her. There was the nose; there was the dreadful chin. There was the exact way her hair fell forward over her left shoulder; the way her mouth was set; the little frown, between the brows, of a woman who reads as though the page might be taken away. And all thirty feet of it was alive with colour: rust and violet and a blue like the first hour of the night; and the whole face, for the first time, was not looking down, but *up*; the book was lowered; the head was lifted, as if at some sound; and the eyes were still shut, and were *waiting.*

Beneath, in a long ragged line of yellow capitals, a man had written:

TO THE ONE WHO READS: I HAVE NOT FINISHED YOUR EYES.

Up on the scaffold, thirty feet above the traffic, with a brush in his hand and a bucket of ochre in the crook of his elbow, a young man with a mop of paint-stiff hair had stopped in the middle of a stroke. He had seen a woman come into the street. He did not know her. He knew only that she was standing exactly where the wall was best seen from; that she had put her hands in her pockets; that she was looking up at his work as though it had said something *libellous* about her mother.

"*Hey,*" said Rafael Ortega, from the sky.

"You've given me a nose like a *heron,*" said Camila.

For a moment nothing moved upon the Calle Zacatecas. The ranchera on the radio had gone on to its second verse. A dog barked.

Then the scaffolding, which had been designed by an optimist, creaked; and Rafael Ortega began, with a haste that put every regulation in the country to shame, to come down it.

He came down the last six feet by a means known only to painters and the fallen. He landed in the street, with paint to the elbows and a smear of ochre across his forehead, and stood before her with his arms at his sides and his mouth open, for once with nothing in it.

"I—" said Rafael.

"Camila Reyes."

"I—"

"Fourth year of law. Narvarte. I have been to ninety-one of your walls." She said it as one reads a charge. "I have eaten bad *tortas* at six in the morning in eleven different colonias. I have been *stared at* by a man in a moustache. I have stood beneath my own face in the rain for two years, and I would like to know, Mr. Ortega, *why you never finished the eyes.*"

He opened his mouth. He closed it. Something went across his face that was too large for it, like a weather.

Because I would not guess. A hundred times I stood before a wall with that same brush And could have made them brown, or black, or grey, Or any colour that would make a pleasing Picture; and each time I could not lie. I saw you once. You looked up once.

You were Not looking at me, but you looked, and it Was gone, a second, a grey-green, a ring Of something. I do not know. I would not make The thing I did not know. I'd rather paint A hundred closed doors than one false window.

"Brown," said Camila.

"What?"

"They are brown. With a ring of green round the pupil. It is called *hazel,* and it's a very ordinary colour, and I am rather ashamed of it." Her voice was almost steady. "I have never liked them. You will find them very *dull.*"

"Dull?"

"They do not *do* anything."

"Camila Reyes," said Rafael, staring at her eyes with the unashamed attention of someone starved for two years, "I have been looking at them for four seconds, and I would like it to be known that they have *already* done *everything.*"

It is unseemly to burst into tears in the Colonia Roma at six in the morning, in front of a stranger, a pigeon and a hundred and fifty gallons of paint. She did it nonetheless: a short, furious sob, like a flood out of a locked cellar, and then another, and then she laughed, and put both hands over her face.

He held out a brush.

She looked at it through her fingers. It was a thick, soft, fat-bellied brush, wet with ochre-brown and a little green.

"You do it," said Rafael.

“I cannot paint.”

“You cannot be *wrong* about your own eyes.”

“It is thirty feet up.”

“There is a scaffold.”

“It was built by an optimist.”

“I am an optimist,” said Rafael. “I will hold the ladder.”

She climbed. It took her eleven minutes, and the ladder swayed, and a bus-driver, passing, sounded his horn in the manner of a Greek chorus; and at the top, in the cold sweet gold of the morning, with the whole slumbering city spread below her like a quilt, a small woman in a borrowed coat stood on a plank at the level of her own face and laid, with a hand that shook only a little, a single brown arc beneath the lid.

And the painted woman opened her eyes.

Far down in the street, a policeman, who had returned for the *tamales,* stopped dead, with a half-written citation in his hand. He looked up at the wall. He looked at the two small figures on the plank, the girl and the boy, with the great closed face blooming between them into sight.

“*Unauthorised alteration,*” said Alejandro Hernández, faintly, to the empty street.

Then he put the citation book in his pocket, took off his cap, and, turning his profile for once away from the light, stood with his hand to his heart like a man at an anthem.

“Article forty-one,” said the Commandante, “is *suspended.*”

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, S.W.R.:

Entry 0299 painted a face a hundred times without once daring to guess its eyes. Entry 0121 walked to every wall and was too proud to ask. Between them: one hundred and three portraits, a heron’s nose, and the one thing a painter will not do, which is lie.

And elsewhere, at 22:41 and 23:41, in two lit windows an hour apart, a few words crossed an ocean. The Keeper remarks that she has seldom seen so small a letter carry so great a weight.

Entries 0713 and 0714 — three lines. The pattern has begun. I shall be watching the wax.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 6.

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Chapter 7: The Restorer’s Seal

“I knew it was false. I kept it because it was yours.”
— Register of Black Stars, Entry 0666

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In Cairo it is said that everything is for sale, and that the only question is whether it is the thing you were told it was.

Nowhere is the saying tested more cheerfully than in the Khan el-Khalili, that warren of brass and perfume and patient bargaining where for six hundred years the same lanes have sold the same lamps to the same astonished strangers. A man may buy there a coffee-pot that belonged to a pasha or a tray that belongs to nobody at all, and leave happy in either case. This is the true miracle of the place.

And in the narrowest, crookedest of its alleys, between a spice-seller’s pyramids of red and gold and a boy who sold hibiscus in dripping glasses, stood a little shop with a green door and a sign painted in two languages: **HADDAD & SONS, ANTIQUITIES AND CURIOSITIES. EST. WHEN GOD WAS YOUNG.**

It had no sons. This was a matter on which the proprietor was sensitive, and on which the neighbours were not.

“Sons,” said Karim Fouad, potter, thirty-nine, fearless, who had known the proprietor since the proprietor was nine and had once been sold, by him, a scarab, a camel and a share in the Suez Canal. “The sign says *sons.* How many do you have, Omar?”

“I have *potential.*”

They were sitting in the long, mirrored, noisy room of Fishawi’s café, where the glass has hung since the days of Napoleon’s cousins and every gilt-framed reflection holds a different century. It was the hour of the afternoon prayer, and the air was thick with apple smoke and with mint. At the next table, upon a velvet cushion, in a suit that had been fashionable in nineteen-sixty, a very old man was holding court to nobody.

“I am the greatest novelist in Egypt,” announced Sherif Sabry, seventy-two, retired writer, vain as a peacock in a fountain, “whom nobody has read. This is the whole secret of my genius. Had I been *read,* I should have been *contradicted.* But this Register! A thousand confessions, every one *better* than my novels, and all of them under one hundred words. It is an insult to a profession.”

“Read us one,” said Omar Haddad, and his voice, which had been light, went very quiet. “Read us *six hundred and forty.*”

He was thirty-five, and he was handsome the way a very good counterfeit is handsome: so smooth, so apt, so exactly what one hoped to find, that it took a careful eye and a bad experience to look for the seam. He had a

gold tooth he did not need and a ring he had not paid for, and he had once sold a tourist the same Fatimid door twice in a single afternoon.

Sherif scrolled. "*Entry six hundred and forty. Cairo, Egypt.* 'I sold you a forgery and have never confessed.'" He lowered the phone. "Well, that's a *confession.* That's a very lazy one. Where are the details? Where is the *crime?*"

"The crime," said Omar, "was a cat."

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It was a small cat.

It was eleven centimetres tall, and made of bronze, and it sat upright upon a base inscribed with a line of hieroglyphs in a style that was not quite right and not quite wrong; and it had been sold, three years before, in a back room of the Khan, by a young dealer with a gold tooth, to a young woman with a very straight back, for exactly three thousand Egyptian pounds.

A Ptolemaic Bastet, he had said. *Late period. From a private collection in Alexandria. It has been in the family since the days of the Khedive.*

It is lovely, she had said, turning it in the light. *It is very, very lovely.*

And she had paid. And had carried it home in a handkerchief, as one carries a bird.

"It was a good one for the tourists," said Omar, rubbing his eyes. "I had it made by a man in Giza who had made six. I added the patina myself: vinegar, tea, a little cat-litter, a month in a drawer. I asked her name three

times, because I wanted to *know* it. She turned it in her hand, and looked at the base, and I thought: *she knows.* I waited for her to say. She said it was *lovely.* And she *paid.* I have been sixteen years in this trade, Karim, and I have never been paid for a thing by someone who knew it was a lie. So I assumed she did not know. She has kept my cat three years on the shelf over her lamp, and I have not been able to *sleep.*"

"Why do you not simply tell her?"

"Because she would look at me," said Omar Haddad, in a voice that none of them had ever heard him use, "as a restorer looks at a thing which has been made to deceive; with perfect attention and no hope."

"So what will you do?" said Sherif, entirely sober.

Omar rose. His reflection rose with him in a gilt frame, looking suddenly much older, and he spoke, not in the brisk patter of the sales-floor, but slowly, as one says a thing one has not yet decided to believe:

I will confess in the one grammar she respects. She does not read men's words. She reads their hands, The tool-mark in the metal, the small slip Of a chisel that will not lie. She reads How long a man has loved a thing, by how The edges soften. So I'll make her one. I'll make a piece, a perfect piece, in brass, A forgery so exact, so obviously false To any eye that has an eye to see, That she shall turn it over, once, and find Beneath the hinge, in letters smaller than A grain of rice, the thing that I have never

said. And if she throws it from the window, well. At least I'll be the first man in the Khan To tell the truth in brass.

"That," said Sherif Sabry, after a considerable pause, wiping his eye with the tip of a silk handkerchief, "was an *extremely* good speech."

"Thank you, Ammu."

"I should like to have written it."

"I will give you the credit, in the obituary."

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The Conservation Laboratory of the Museum of Islamic Art stands behind a green iron gate in a quiet street, and within it a very clean silence is kept.

It smelled of acetone and warm dust; it had white walls, a skylight, six benches, and on each bench a lamp. At the farthest bench, under the best of the lamps, a woman of thirty-two sat, with a loupe screwed into her right eye, a lacquered brush in her left hand, and a fragment of fourteenth-century glass held in a pair of tweezers to the light.

Her name was Layla Mansour. She was exacting, dry, small, and immaculate; she wore a grey linen apron, sleeves rolled to exactly the same height, and she spoke to objects in the voice that other people use to speak to a nervous child. She had been called, in the journals, *the finest eye in North Africa.* She had been called, in the corridors, *the Ice Pharaoh.* She had once told a German

professor to his face that a Mamluk lamp he had proudly authenticated was *twelve years old and from Marseille,* and had been proved right in eleven days.

On the shelf above her lamp, as it had sat for three years, sat a small bronze cat.

“It is looking at you again,” said Dina Shaker.

Dina, fourteen, was the granddaughter of the only woman cab-driver in Heliopolis; she had arrived at the Museum two years ago on a school trip, refused to leave, and had since been appointed, by a process nobody could reconstruct, Official Sweeper and Unofficial Witness. She had enormous round spectacles and an inability to let a silence lie.

“It is a *cat,* Dina.”

“It is a cat that *looks.* I think it knows you’ve read the Register. You read it on Monday, at your bench, with your lips, and went the colour of a boiled egg. the Director said, *Is something wrong, Madam Layla?* and you said, *It is the acetone.* But the acetone was in the cupboard.”

“Then say it to the *floor.*”

“The floor is not interested,” said Dina Shaker, with dignity, and swept.

It is true that Layla had read it. She had read the whole of it, in her kitchen, on the Monday night, on a small cracked tablet, with a glass of hibiscus at her elbow; and she had found, beside the Register’s long ribbon of Cairo, two entries she had known she would find. The first: *I sold you a forgery and have never confessed.*

The second, which was her own, written on a night she did not wish to remember, to the Keeper in England: *I knew it was false. I kept it because it was yours.*

"Madam Layla," said a voice in the doorway, with a trembling deference. "Forgive me. Did I come at a bad time?"

The speaker was a thin, anxious man in an enormous overcoat, carrying a battered satchel with both arms, as a man holds a baby he is afraid to put down. This was Tarek Hassan, forty-one, librarian of Alexandria, who had come to Cairo for the week to consult with the Museum on a catalogue and who had not slept properly since the night of the new moon, because he remembered, with perfect clarity, the exact day on which every dreadful thing had ever happened to him.

"Not at all, Mr. Hassan."

"It is only that I was *told*—" he lowered his voice "—that there is *a certain dealer,* with *a package,* coming *here,* to be *authenticated.*"

"Many packages come here."

"But *this* package," said Tarek, with the glassy fixity of a man who recalls the Twelfth of March nineteen-ninety-eight, a Thursday, rain, a dropped ink-pot, "is *cursed.*"

"By whom?"

"By *love,*" said the librarian, and put down the satchel, and sat upon it, and was not seen to stand up again for some time.

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He came at four o’clock.

He came in his best suit, a pale cream linen that had been, in its day, an act of financial violence; with a hat, a stick, a gold tooth and a wooden box. And he came in at the green iron gate with the swagger of a man who is trying very hard to walk as if he were not afraid of a woman in an apron.

“Madam Layla,” said Omar Haddad. “May the day be blessed.”

“May it be blessed twice, Mr. Haddad.”

“I have something,” he said, “for you to look at.”

“I assumed you had. You have not been to this laboratory in three years. I take it it is not a social call.”

“I have not been *invited.*”

“You have not been *willing.*” She did not look up from the glass. “Put it on the bench.”

It was a small box of brass, inlaid with silver. He set it down upon the white cloth with both hands. It was a pen-box, such as scribes had carried in the belt in the days of the Mamluks: long, narrow, with a hinged lid, and upon the lid in lines of beaten silver an ornament of looping vines and stars, and about the rim a band of inscription in a firm, flowing, practised hand.

“A *qalamdan,*” said Omar. “Fourteenth century. Syrian work, I think; possibly Damascene; brought to Cairo in the time of Sultan Hasan. From a house in Giza. I believe it to be extremely fine.”

“I should like your seal,” said Omar, “upon it. If it is, as I hope, sound.”

There was a silence. Dina, in the corner, had forgotten her broom. Tarek Hassan, on his satchel, had gone the colour of the wall.

Layla Mansour put down the glass, and screwed in the loupe.

She did it as she always did: in order, in silence, by the book. She looked at the brass under the lamp, and then under the ultraviolet, where an old patina glows a dull amber and a young one flares like a cheat. She tapped the rim and listened for the ring. And then she did what the great forgers have always feared more than any machine: she *smelled* it.

"It is modern," said Layla.

"Is it?" said Omar, faintly.

"Brass sheet, rolled in the last ten years. The patina is vinegar and tea, with a little *tobacco.* You have used cigarette-ash to dull the rim." Her voice was quite level. "The vines are good. The stars are better. The inscription is a stock verse of blessing, in a thuluth that is nearly right but for the *alif,* which the Mamluk scribes never drew with a serif. It is a very beautiful forgery, Mr. Haddad. I should say it is the best that I have seen this year."

"I am so very sorry to have wasted your time."

"You have not."

She had not looked up. She held the box in the lamplight, close to her eye, and her fingers, which were small and square and as steady as a surgeon's, were turning it over slowly, as one turns a sleeping child.

“Because there is something *wrong* with it,” said Layla.

“Wrong?”

“It is *too good.* A forger who makes a thing to deceive makes it to be *admired.* He makes the hinge as fine as he can. He makes the silver as bright as he dares. But this—” She stopped.

It was a very small repair. A hairline crack, in the brass at the pivot, such as comes of a hundred years of opening and shutting a lid; and over it, in place of the usual neat invisible mend, a mend made *visibly:* a single thread of soft yellow gold, laid in with a fine tool along the length of the crack, so that the flaw was not hidden but *shown,* made a thing of beauty, a seam of light.

Layla Mansour did not move.

It was a mend she knew. It was a mend she had made. She had made it, in that very manner, on forty-one objects in the Museum of Islamic Art, over the course of nine years, against the advice of three directors. It was her habit. It was her *signature.* She had never said so; she had never written about it; she had never, to her knowledge, told another living soul.

“Who did this?” said Layla.

“I do not know,” said Omar, in a voice that was trying very hard to be a salesman’s.

“It is my *mend.*”

“Is it?”

"It is not a *copy* of my mend. A copy would be neat. This is *crooked,* in just the place that mine goes crooked: *there,* at the third turn, where my wrist catches. It is a copy of my *mistake.*" She put down the box. "Mr. Haddad. You have forged not the piece, but the *restoration.* You have made a box that was found, broken, and mended by *me.*"

Her voice, which had never in thirteen years wavered upon a bench, now did, very slightly, as a thread does when it takes a strain. "That is not a forgery of an antique. It is a forgery of my *taste.*"

"Layla—"

"Under the hinge."

He did not answer.

"There is something under the hinge. I can feel it. There is an engraving." She had taken up the loupe again, and bent, and the long clean lamp lay over her face and over the little box, with its stars and its seam of gold. For a time there was only the sound of her breathing and a distant mutter of the muezzin from a minaret across the roofs.

Then she read it.

It was in letters smaller than a grain of rice, in a perfect, delicate, beautifully formed thuluth, cut with the point of a needle on the underside of the lid:

Made by the hand of Omar Haddad, in the year of the Register, in a house in the Khan, with a good deal of vinegar. He sold you a cat three years ago and has been

sorry every day since. He would like to be forgiven, and cannot see how.

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She sat for a long time with the loupe in her eye, which made it impossible for anybody to tell whether she was reading or weeping, and a woman in an apron is under no obligation to explain which. She put it down at last, and reached up to the shelf above the lamp, and took down the little bronze cat.

She set it beside the box.

"It was sold to me," said Layla Mansour, "as a Ptolemaic Bastet. Late period. From a private collection in Alexandria."

"I know what I said."

"It has the left ear of a reproduction cast in Brooklyn in nineteen-ninety-one. The base was recut in the last decade by a competent man with an electric tool. The patina is vinegar, tea and *cat-litter,* Mr. Haddad. *Cat-litter*. I could smell it from across the Khan."

"You *knew?*" said Omar.

His voice cracked in the middle of the word like a plate.

"Of course I knew."

"From the *first moment?*"

"From the moment you put it in my hand."

"But you *paid!*"

“I paid three thousand pounds,” said Layla, “which was a *fair price,* for the hours of work, and the value of the lie.” She did not look at him. She was looking at the cat, with a face of such formidable composure that it could only have been held up by a very great weight. “I had never in my life been *sold* anything with so much hope. You stood there with your gold tooth and your ring, and you said it had been in the family since the Khedive, and I looked at your face, and I thought: *he is lying to me, and he is not enjoying it.* And I had never seen that before.”

“Layla.”

“So I kept it.”

“Why?”

“Because it was yours,” said Layla Mansour.

There are silences made of nothing and silences made of everything, and this was the second kind. Tarek Hassan, who had been sitting on his satchel in a state of spiritual collapse, took out a large clean handkerchief and blew his nose like a trumpet. Dina Shaker said, very loudly and to nobody: “I *knew* it.”

“So,” said Omar, and sat down upon the nearest stool, which was Dina’s, as though his strings had been cut, “I have been confessing for three years to a person who was *waiting for me to start.*”

“I would not put it so.”

“How *would* you put it?”

“I would say,” said Layla, drawing a clean sheet of paper from the drawer and uncapping a pen, “that you are, Mr. Haddad, a very bad forger and a very fine craftsman, and that the two have never before been found in one man.”

She wrote. She wrote for some time, in her small upright hand, upon the Museum’s cream paper with the crescent at the head; and when she had written, she took from the inside of her apron a small brass seal on a ribbon, which she had worn for nine years and used on five thousand pieces of the heritage of Egypt, and breathed upon it, and pressed it, hard, in red, at the foot of the page.

She turned the paper round.

CERTIFICATE OF EXAMINATION. Object: one pen-box, brass inlaid with silver, of modern manufacture. Opinion: not a work of the fourteenth century. A work of the twenty-first, wholly and honestly made. Authentic — as to the hand that made it.

— L. Mansour, Conservator.

Omar Haddad read it three times. He had the look of a man who has been given a kingdom, and is looking about him for the forgery.

“It is not for sale,” said Layla.

“I know.”

“The Director will wish to buy it. He will offer forty thousand pounds. I shall decline. It is not a museum piece; it is evidence.”

“Of what?”

“That,” said the Ice Pharaoh, and for the first time in three years the corner of her mouth moved, which Dina Shaker would afterwards swear was a *smile,* “is for the court to decide. Dina. Mr. Hassan. I think the laboratory will be closing early.”

“Mr. Hassan,” said Dina, hauling the librarian to his feet by one sleeve with the strength of a very small and determined crane, “I think it is time for a *tea.*”

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The door closed behind them. The skylight had turned a deep and dusty rose. Across the roofs a muezzin began, in a high clear thread of sound, to call the faithful to prayer, and the whole of Old Cairo lay in the last gold of the afternoon.

Omar stood up. He did not know what to do with his hands.

“I should like,” he said carefully, “to ask whether I might—”

“You may take me to dinner,” said Layla.

“I was going to say *apologise.*”

“You have apologised. In brass. It is in the record.” She took off the apron, folded it exactly in three, and laid it on the bench. Without the apron she seemed younger, and a good deal less formidable, and a great deal more frightened. “But you may take me to dinner. On the condition that you will tell me nothing that is not true.”

“Madam Layla, I am a *dealer.*”

“Then I shall require provenance,” said Layla Mansour, “for every word.”

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Margin note, in pencil, S.W.R.:

Entry 0640 forged a cat. Entry 0666 knew, and paid. Between them hang three years, a shelf, and a seam of gold. Reader, there is a school of thought that holds that a forgery is a lie told in metal. I hold otherwise. A forgery that is made for one person, and fits her to the grain, is the nearest thing that metal has ever come to a love-letter.

I have had a thousand confessions. I have seldom had one so well mended.

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End of Chapter 7.

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Chapter 8: Nets and Numbers

“My boat is failing and so am I.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0443

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SCENE I

Bergen harbour, a Tuesday in late November, before dawn.

In Bergen it rains two hundred and forty days of the year, and on the remaining one hundred and twenty it is merely considering it.

The Bergensers do not complain of this. To complain would be to admit that the weather had an opinion, and they prefer to think of it as a lodger: noisy, always behind with the rent, and, in the end, part of the household.

On a Tuesday in the last week of November, at ten minutes past seven, with the sun still some hours from its brief and grudging appearance, a man named Lars Eriksen stood on the deck of a boat and spoke to it as one speaks to an aged and expensive relation.

“You will start,” said Lars.

The boat, whose name was *Ragnhild*, did not reply. She was eleven metres of tarred oak and old paint, built in the year his grandfather had been young and his grandfather's opinions had been newer. She had a wheelhouse the size of a confessional, a winch that groaned like a bad conscience, and a diesel engine that, in the spring, had begun to cough as a smoker coughs, politely at first and then without apology.

"I have been patient," said Lars.

The engine considered this, and coughed.

Lars Eriksen was thirty years old, tall and square and weathered beyond his years, with hands like folded oars and eyes the grey of the fjord at its least forthcoming. He was the third of his name to fish out of Bergen, and he would, it was generally agreed, be the last, since the *Ragnhild* owed the bank four hundred and twelve thousand kroner, the quota for his class of vessel had been trimmed twice in three years, and the sea, which had once been a sort of savings account, had become a sort of overdraft.

He was a man of very few words. These he spent as a poor man spends his coins, one at a time, with a look of faint regret afterward.

"Ikke bra," said a voice from the quay.

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It was the voice of Kristian Strand, who was seventy-eight, and who had been for fifty-one years a waiter at the finest restaurant on the Bryggen wharf, and who had never, in his retirement, put down his napkin. It hung

over his left forearm even now, in the rain, in the dark, at a fishing dock. In his right hand he carried two paper cups of coffee on an imaginary silver tray.

He had married Lars's mother late in both their lives, and had buried her six winters since, and in the grief of it had simply gone on being a father, in the way a clock goes on ticking after the room has emptied. Lars called him *Far*, which is father. Kristian called Lars *the young master*, which was a joke that had stopped being a joke in about the year two thousand and twelve.

"That engine," said Kristian, passing down a cup, "sounds like a man trying to remember a name."

"She will start."

"Of course she will start. Everything starts. It is the question of what happens next." He examined the *Ragnhild* with the cold eye of one who has seen ten thousand dishes sent back to the kitchen.

"You are carrying passengers today."

"The institute. The woman with the nets."

"The biologist." Kristian's eyebrows rose by about one millimetre, which in a waiter of his school was the equivalent of a flourish of trumpets. "The one who talks."

"She is not so bad."

"Lars Eriksen," said the old man. "That is the longest sentence you have said in praise of any human being since your confirmation."

"It was *four words*."

“In this house, young master,” said Kristian, “four words is a sonnet.”

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SCENE II

The Fish Market, Bergen. Eleven o’clock. The light has arrived, in the manner of an inspector: late, grey, and with no intention of staying.

There is a woman at the corner of the Fisketorget who sells umbrellas, and she is not popular.

Her name was Solveig Dahl. She was thirty-six, an umbrella maker from Ålesund, who had come south on the theory that if one must sell umbrellas it is wise to sell them in the one city that requires them. Her stall carried a hand-lettered sign that said, in two languages, *UNBREAKABLE*.

“Excuse me,” said a tourist, a large and aggrieved gentleman from Ohio, holding up a skeletal wreck that had, a few moments before, been an umbrella. “Your sign says unbreakable.”

“Yes.”

“It broke.”

“It did not break,” said Solveig. “The *wind* broke.”

“The wind broke my umbrella.”

“The wind,” said Solveig, with the patience of a great teacher, “was not covered by the guarantee.”

“Ma’am, I’d like a refund.”

“I do not give refunds. I give *advice*. The advice is: do not stand in the wind.”

The gentleman went away muttering. Solveig watched him go with a very faint and secret satisfaction, and turned to find that a tall young woman in a yellow oilskin had stopped at her stall, and was examining the stock with the frown of one who solves problems for a living.

This was Sigrid Haugen.

She was twenty-nine, a marine biologist at the Institute of Marine Research on the Nordnes peninsula, with the look of one who has had a great many ideas in the last ten minutes and is trying to finish all of them at once. Her hair, the colour of dark honey, was escaping from three separate clips. When she stood, she bounced very slightly, as though the ground were a little too slow for her.

“Is it really unbreakable?” said Sigrid.

“No.”

“Then why does the sign—”

“A sign is not a *promise*,” said Solveig. “A sign is a hope with a frame around it.” She looked Sigrid up and down. “You are restless.”

“I am *not*.”

“Your left foot is going. You have been tapping it since you arrived.” Solveig produced a small umbrella the colour of a ripe plum and held it out like a gift. “Take it. You cannot go through the world with a hood. A hood makes you look at your feet. An umbrella makes you look *up*, to see what is the matter.”

“What would I owe you?”

“Two hundred and ten kroner.”

“That is a great deal for a thing that is not unbreakable.”

“I am saving money,” said Solveig Dahl, and for a moment something very small and naked looked out of her face, and then went back inside, “to disappear.”

Sigrid blinked. “I beg your pardon?”

“I said, to *dis*count it. Two hundred, then.” Solveig looked away at the grey water. “Take the umbrella.”

Sigrid took the umbrella. She paid the two hundred. It was not until she was halfway back to the institute, and the rain had begun in earnest, that she opened it and found, stitched into the lining in tiny, furious, red thread, a line that Solveig Dahl had embroidered for no customer in particular, and perhaps for herself:

Look up. It is only weather.

Which is, as the reader may have noticed, the whole philosophy of the Norwegian people in six words, and the reason that they are, on the whole, rather cheerful.

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At the institute, a thing was waiting on Sigrid’s desk, and it was not an email.

The foundations that give money to scientists send their good news by electronic mail and their bad news in the post. A thick cream envelope, with a window and a crest, is the equivalent of a surgeon’s face when he steps out of the theatre.

Sigrid sat down on her chair without taking off her oilskin. She did not tear the envelope; she was a scientist; she slit it with the tip of a pipette, as though the letter might have fingerprints.

Dear Dr. Haugen,

We are delighted to confirm that the Foundation will continue to support work in your field. We regret, however, that the present grant for the coastal cod study cannot be renewed beyond the thirty-first of March. Funding for the successor programme has been allocated to the Arctic station at Ny-Ålesund, Svalbard, where a post of fourteen months is offered to the present holder of the grant, subject to acceptance by the fifteenth of January…

She read the paragraph twice, as one reads a map one hopes to be wrong.

Fourteen months. In Ny-Ålesund, in the high Arctic, where the sun does not rise for four months of the year, and the nearest city is a thousand kilometres of black water away. A post of a lifetime. Everything she had spent her twenties writing applications to be offered; and, laid on a desk in a cream envelope, it had the exact weight of a stone.

And if I take it, thought Sigrid, who could do such sums in her head faster than she could control her feelings, *I will not be back for a year and a quarter. And if the programme grows, as such programmes do, I may not be back at all.*

"Sigrid."

She turned. A man stood in the door of her office, a slender, dry, dark-haired man in a surgeon's green scrubs with a raincoat over them, holding a sheet of paper in one hand and a coffee in the other. He did not enter. He did not speak. He held up the paper.

The paper said, in black marker: **HOW ARE YOU?**

"Henrik," said Sigrid. "You are standing in my doorway with a sign."

He shrugged and held up a second sheet, which he had evidently prepared for the occasion: **I TRIED TO TELEPHONE. I CANNOT. I CAME IN PERSON.**

"It is three kilometres from the hospital."

IT IS A LONG WAY WHEN YOU ARE AFRAID.

Henrik Strand was thirty-one, a surgeon of real skill, who had held human hearts in his hands and could not bring himself to lift a telephone to his ear and hear a voice come out of it. He had been her best friend since the age of nine. He wrote everything down.

She handed him the letter.

He read it standing, which is how a surgeon reads bad news. Then he took a third sheet from his pocket, uncapped his marker, and wrote, with his usual neat and merciless hand:

YOU ARE GOING TO TAKE IT.

"I have not decided."

YOU ARE GOING TO TAKE IT. AND YOU ARE GOING TO WISH SOMEONE WOULD ASK YOU NOT TO.

“Henrik—”

WHO WOULD YOU LIKE TO ASK YOU?

She opened her mouth. She closed it. A small unbidden image rose before her: grey eyes under a wet cap, a square jaw, a man who had said, in six months of weekly voyages, not four hundred words in all.

“No one,” said Sigrid.

Henrik regarded her for a long moment. Then he wrote one more sheet, and put it carefully on her desk, and went away down the corridor, a figure in green, with his coffee going cold.

The sheet said: **YOUR LEFT FOOT IS GOING.**

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SCENE III

The Byfjorden. Two in the afternoon. The sun, having made its inspection, has begun to leave. A fog is coming down the water like a slow white curtain at the end of a very long play.

“One more station,” said Sigrid. “Just one more. I need the dip at ninety fathoms, and then I swear on my mother’s good name that we go home.”

“Your mother’s good name is not at risk,” said Lars.

“That was a joke.”

“I know. I am being *supportive.*”

She laughed. It was a surprised, delighted, startled laugh, the laugh of a person who has been told a joke by a wall. She sat on an upturned crate on the foredeck, in her yellow oilskin, with her plum umbrella furled between her knees (it was not raining, and she held it nonetheless, as a man will hold his hat in church), and wrote numbers in a little notebook with a pencil on a string.

They had done eleven stations. They had netted, tagged, measured, and returned to the sea some forty cod, each of them looking at her, as cod do, with an expression of profound moral surprise. They had spoken, between them, perhaps sixty words, of which Sigrid had supplied fifty-four.

It was the best day of her week. She knew it; she was a scientist, and had at last learned to count the things that were not on her list.

And then the engine coughed.

It coughed once, like an old man being asked to climb a stair. Lars, at the wheel, did not move. Sigrid saw that his shoulders had gone very still, as a horse's do when it hears something the rider does not.

It coughed again.

And then the *Ragnhild* made a sound that was not a cough, but a long, descending, apologetic sigh, like a great beast lying down, and the engine, which had borne them through a hundred grey mornings, went silent.

The silence that followed was enormous. The water lapped. A gull remarked upon the situation and flew away. Behind them the fog slid over the city, which went

out like a candle.

“Lars,” said Sigrid.

“I know.”

“Is it—”

“It is nothing.” He turned the key. Nothing. He turned it again. A small, wretched click. “It is flooded. It will clear.”

He went below.

For eleven minutes she listened to the sounds of a proud man talking to a machine: a clank, a murmur, a muttered Norwegian syllable of a kind not found in the hymnbook. She did not go down. She did not offer to help, which was the kindest thing she could have done, for a man who is ashamed will bear almost any burden but a witness.

Reader, let us go below, since it is permitted, and since the lady cannot.

The engine room of the *Ragnhild* was the size of a coffin and about as cheerful. Lars Eriksen knelt before the engine with a wrench in his hand and a lamp in his teeth. He took the lamp out. He spoke, and because he thought himself alone, he spoke in the only form a taciturn man will trust: in measure, slow and low, with the pauses where a man swallows.

Old girl, I have nursed you since the spring, And bought you parts I could not well afford, And lied to the bank, and lied to my own father, And told myself the sea would give me back The thing I put in. And she does not give. She takes. She is the one great

creditor Who does not send a letter. Nor will I. I have not told a living soul how far Behind I am. I have not told the woman Who sits above me with her careful numbers, And laughs, and does not know she is the light Upon this deck. I would not tell her. No. What could a man like me say? That I fish For cod that are not there? That I am tired? That I would sooner drown than ask for help, And that the drowning is the cheaper course? Start, damn you. Start. If you are all I have, At least be something. Be a boat. Be warm. Be a thing that does what it was built to do, And I will be a man. We'll go together.

The engine, which had been listening with every appearance of sympathy, did nothing at all.

Lars put his forehead against its cold green flank. He stayed there some time. Then he took a breath, and straightened his shoulders, and returned the lamp to his teeth.

Mark this, reader. He did not weep. There is a species of courage that consists wholly in carrying on with a wrench. It is not much admired in poems. It should be.

✦ ✦ ✦

By the time he came up, the dark had come down.

The dark comes early in the north: a short grey afternoon, a long blue dusk, and then the black, with only the lights of the far shore laid out along the water like beads on a thread. They drifted in a pocket of clear air, with the whole city shining three miles off, and five hundred feet of water beneath them.

Sigrid had turned on the cabin lamp. She had put the kettle on the little stove. She had found, in a locker, a bag of *skolebrød*, the sweet custard buns of Bergen, rather stale, and set two of them on a saucer, as people do when everything else has gone wrong.

“We could call,” she said.

“No.”

“The rescue boats are volunteers. They would come in half an hour. It is what they are *for*.”

“We are not in danger.”

“We are adrift in a fjord in the dark, Lars.”

“We are in a *fjord*,” he said. “That is not a danger. That is an address.”

She looked at him. He sat on the locker opposite, in the glow of the lamp, with engine-grease on his cheek, holding a stale bun as though it were a document he had been asked to sign. He did not look at her. He looked, with great concentration, at the bun.

“It is the money,” said Sigrid.

He said nothing.

“You do not want to call because the rescue society asks a donation, and the tow, and the engineer, and you do not have—” She stopped. “I am sorry. That was not mine to say.”

“No,” said Lars. “It was not.”

“But it is true.”

He was silent for a long time. The kettle began to mutter. Out on the black water something moved, a seal, perhaps, or the tide.

"Four hundred and twelve thousand," he said at last, to the bun. "It is what I owe. It is not so very much. My father had more, once. I think about the number at night, you understand. It has a shape."

"What shape?"

"A *hook*." He very nearly smiled. "It is a stupid thing to say."

"It is not."

"I have not said it to anyone."

"Then," said Sigrid, softly, "I will not either."

It was the most they had said to one another in six months. She poured two cups of tea, and handed one across; and for a moment their fingers touched on the warm china, and withdrew, each with the air of a party that has been formally introduced.

And Sigrid Haugen, who could not keep a foot still, who had never in her life kept a secret for longer than a week, felt the cream envelope lie in her pocket like a sleeping coal. *Fourteen months. By the fifteenth of January.* She opened her mouth to tell him. She had always told everyone everything. It was a fault.

"Lars—"

"Yes?"

Say it, thought Sigrid. *Say: I have been offered the sun at the top of the world, and I do not want it, and I cannot say why.*

"Your tea is going cold," said Sigrid.

Ah, reader. Two people on a small boat in a large dark, each with a letter against the breast, and both of them, in the great Norwegian manner, discussing the temperature of tea. There is an art to missing the moment by exactly the width of a cup. The whole nation practises it daily.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE IV

Half past nine. The lights of the rescue boat come over the water like two kind and slightly officious stars.

They were found by a boat from the Sea Rescue, crewed by six volunteers in orange suits, among whom was a retired poet.

His name was Espen Lund, he was forty-nine, he wrote the weather-poems that were chalked each morning on the board outside the harbour café ("Today: wet, with rising hope"), and he served as a rescue volunteer for the excellent reason that it gave him something to rhyme. He leaned from the bow and caught the line Lars threw.

"Eriksen!" he called. "I have written a poem about you."

"I am not yet dead."

“It is a *preventive* poem. Nothing rhymes with ‘diesel’.”

“Then throw the rope.”

On the quay a small crowd had assembled, for in Bergen a breakdown is a public entertainment. Marit Strand was there, Kristian’s daughter and Lars’s stepsister since the cradle, a train guard of thirty-eight in a very good coat, who arrived in the middle of a sentence she had evidently been conducting alone for some time.

“—and I said to the stationmaster, a woman of my position cannot be told that the eight-fifteen is *philosophically late*. Lars! You have grease on your face, it is very *attractive*—who is this? Oh, you are the *biologist.* Lars says nothing but I can read it in his eyebrows. Is that a plum umbrella? How *sensible*—”

“Marit,” said Lars.

“Yes?”

“Breathe.”

“I *am* breathing, I am breathing *through* it, it is an art —”

And the young woman in the yellow oilskin, who had a letter in her pocket and a left foot which, she noticed with surprise, had at last stopped tapping, looked once across the black water at a tall, silent man being hugged by a talking train guard, and thought, with a clarity that astonished her:

I would like to be on that boat again on Tuesday.

And then, a second later, with the dread of the scientist at the moment the data refuse to fit:

And I have until the fifteenth of January.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0443: “My boat is failing and so am I.” Entry 0610: “My grant ends in spring and I may not return.”

They were posted on different nights by two people who did not know that each had written the other’s reply. A boat is a promise made of wood. A grant is a promise made of paper. I have watched skies for forty-five years, and I will tell you which of them floats: neither. It is the one who stays on board who keeps the boat afloat.

They will have to decide which of the two of them is the boat.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 8.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 9: The Bookshop at Kochi's Edge

"I hid a poem in a book I knew you would buy." — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0699

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE I

Fort Kochi, Kerala. The small hours of the twenty-sixth of November. The north-east monsoon, which the Malayalis call thulavarsham, *is leaning on the roof like a tired guest who has no intention of leaving.*

At two in the morning, in a room above a bookshop, a man was copying a poem for the seventh time, and had not yet got it right.

His name was Arjun Nair, he was twenty-seven, and he possessed the three gifts of the shy: a neat hand, a good memory, and a talent for being found out by nobody. He had a long, grave, kind face, spectacles mended at the hinge with a thread, and a way of standing in his own shop as though apologising to the shelves for the intrusion. The shop below him was called Karayil Books, which is to say *On the Shore*, and it stood at the very edge of Fort Kochi, where the old Dutch lanes run out of ideas and become the sea.

He wrote with a pencil, on onion-skin paper, in Malayalam script, with its great loops and curls like waves seen from above. He had written it first when he was twenty, on the afternoon a girl in a green churidar had come into the shop, and asked for a copy of a certain children's annual, and said "Thank you" so exactly, with such a plain bright courtesy, that he had gone upstairs afterward and sat on the stairs for an hour.

He had not told her. He had done the other thing, which is cheaper and takes longer. He had folded the poem very small and slipped it between pages forty-one and forty-two of the book she was carrying away, and then stood in his doorway while she walked down the lane with it, saying to himself, with the unreason of the very young, *If she finds it, she will know; and if she does not, I shall be spared.*

She had found it. He knew that, because the following November she had come back and asked for the same annual, and the November after that, and every November since, with the unfailing punctuality of the tides. And every November he had copied the poem out afresh, in new pencil, on new paper, and tucked it between forty-one and forty-two.

Neither had said a word of it. Seven years. It is the longest conversation in the history of Fort Kochi, and not a syllable of it has been spoken.

Here, since it is the thing itself and the reader is owed it, is the poem. It does not sound so well in English. Poems seldom do. They are like fish carried inland.

**You do not know my name; I do not mind. The ink is small, the paper thin as air. I put it where I knew that you would find, And then I turned away, and was not there.*

I am the shelf you pass and do not see; The shop-bell that announces who has come; I am the hour between your tea and me, The word a shy man keeps beneath his tongue.

*And if one year the page should come out blank, Know that the pencil failed, and not the hand; Know that the book, the sea, the year are thanks To one who could not say it. Understand.**

"Seven years," said Arjun aloud, to the lamp. "And I still cannot rhyme *hand* with anything."

A voice from the doorway, brittle and anxious, made him jump.

"You are *talking* again," said his father.

✦ ✦ ✦

Hari Panicker, seventy-six, was a retired butcher, a large, anxious, soft-eyed man in a lungi and an undershirt, who had spent forty years in the confident trade of carving and the last seven in the unconfident one of worrying about a son who read. (A Panicker by birth, he had married into a Nair house and been absorbed by it as a stream by a river; the boy had taken the river's name.) He stood at the top of the stairs holding the old brass scale that had hung in his shop for four decades, which he had brought to the bookshop and which now sat on the counter below, where it weighed, with great solemnity, the cheaper kind of paperback.

“Achan,” said Arjun. “It is two in the morning.”

“I could not sleep. The rain is coming in at the back wall. I have been listening to it. It says something.”

“What does it say?”

“It says, *Hari, move the books.* Every year the tide comes up the lane. What do you intend to do about the poetry?”

“Put it on a high shelf.”

“And the thing you are writing?”

Arjun put his hand, very lightly, over the onion-skin paper.

“That,” said Hari, with a sigh that carried forty years of fathers, “is the *only* part of the shop that is not insured.”

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

Mattancherry. A schoolroom. Nine in the morning. Rain.

“Class Six,” said Meera Menon, “who can tell me what a metaphor is?”

Thirty hands went up, which was a lie, because eleven of the children had been told by their mothers to put their hands up, and nineteen had no idea. Meera Menon was twenty-six, a schoolteacher, with a long braid, a green sari the colour of a parrot’s wing, and the straight bold look of a woman who has never been afraid of a classroom. She taught English at the old Jewish

quarter's school, in a room with four fans, two of which worked, and a view of the spice-merchants' lane, where on a dry day the whole air tasted of ginger and pepper and the dried-fish smell that is the real perfume of Kochi.

"A metaphor," volunteered a small boy in the front, "is when you say a thing is a different thing, and it is *not*."

"Very good, Anoop. Example?"

"The rain is a teacher."

"And why is it a teacher?"

"Because it comes every day," said Anoop, "and it is always wet."

A little girl at the back, fourteen years old and the oldest of the class by the grace of a long illness, lifted her hand, and Meera nodded. This was Sreeja Nambiar, the school's unofficial librarian, a solemn child with a plait to her waist who saw everything and reported nothing, which is the whole equipment of the born novelist.

"Teacher," said Sreeja. "You are going to the bookshop today."

"Whatever makes you say that?"

"It is the twenty-sixth."

There was a delicate pause.

"Every year on the twenty-sixth," said Sreeja, "you wear the green sari, and you go to Mr. Arjun's shop, and you come back with *The Schoolchild's Annual*, and for

the rest of the day you smile at it like a person who has been told a very good secret." The solemn eyes did not blink. "That is a simile, Teacher."

"It is an *impertinence*," said Meera. "Sit down."

"I *am* sitting."

"Then be quiet in a sitting position." But she was laughing, and she coloured to the roots of her braid, and thirty children, who had not the faintest idea what was going on, applauded.

✦ ✦ ✦

The rain, by noon, had stopped being weather and become geography.

It poured on the harbour and the ferries, which crossed from Ernakulam with the dazed look of ducks in a bath. It came down on the Chinese fishing nets, those great wooden cantilevers, with a roar that drowned the church bells and the muezzin and the temple drums alike.

"Madam!" shouted Vishnu Kurup, from the front of his auto-rickshaw. "I cannot take you down the lane! There is a river!"

Vishnu Kurup was forty-five, a rickshaw puller, a large grave man with a moustache like a wet broom, who had been Meera's friend since she was a student and who had adopted, on that basis, a severe and total authority over her life. He stopped the rickshaw at the mouth of Princess Street. Before them lay a thing that had been a road.

"Ten centimetres of water," he announced, "and rising. It is the high tide and the rain agreeing with each other. In my experience, madam, nothing worse can happen than two things agreeing."

"I must go to the bookshop."

"The bookshop is *drowning*."

"Then," said Meera, taking off her sandals and tucking them into her bag, "I had better go and help it drown *with dignity.*"

"You are going for the book."

"I am going for the *shop*."

"You are wearing the green sari," said Vishnu, gravely. "Everyone in Kochi knows what the green sari is."

She tucked up the border of the sari, which in Kerala is a thing a woman does the way a soldier slings a rifle, and stepped into the brown water with her chin up.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

Karayil Books. A quarter to one. The tide in the lane has reached the doorstep, considered it, and come in.

A particular silence falls over a bookshop when water enters it: that of a very large congregation holding its breath.

Arjun stood in water to his shins with a stack of Malayalam poetry in his arms and an expression of calm despair. The lower shelves were already gone: the cookbooks, the maps, the volumes of Marxist theory that no-

body had ever bought and nobody had ever sold. They stood in the brown flood like a row of drowned gentlemen. Somewhere at the back, with a wet slap, a shelf of Agatha Christie gave way, and forty murders were solved all at once, with no detective present.

"Achan, take the dictionaries to the loft!"

"I am *carrying* the dictionaries!"

"You are *weighing* them!"

"A man must know what he is losing!" shouted Hari, with his scale in his arm and a Concise Oxford under it.

The door banged open. A woman in an oilskin poncho and rubber boots strode in, carrying a large red toolbox in each hand and followed by a short wet man with a sack of sand.

"Where is the problem?" said Sreeja Iyer.

She was fifty-five, a plumber from Alappuzha, who had been called out for a quite different job in the next street, and had seen the shop's door standing open in a drowning lane with the instinct of her calling. She regarded a crisis as a personal compliment. Her hair was iron grey, her forearms were a mason's, and she had a way of saying "problem" that made the problem feel it had been *found out*.

"The problem," said Arjun, "is the *sea.*"

"The sea is not a problem. The sea is a customer." She slung a tool-bag across the doorway. "Sand-bag the threshold. Sreenath! Raise the lower shelves onto the bricks. Who is in charge of this establishment?"

"I am," said Arjun, and Hari, simultaneously: "I am."

“Then you are both useless. Where is the pump?”

“We do not *have* a pump.”

“Then you have a *bucket.* Madam—” this to a green-saried figure that had come through the door with a whoosh and a splash, and was already wading to the nearest shelf “—you, yes, are you family?”

“I am a customer,” said Meera.

“Good. Customers carry things.”

✦ ✦ ✦

It was a very Kochi sort of rescue, which is to say it involved everybody.

Word went down the lane by that mysterious route by which news travels in the rain: through the café, the chai-shop, the fishermen mending their nets under the tarpaulin. A line of people formed, thirty, forty, then sixty, from the shop’s back door up the narrow stairs to the loft. Fishermen in dripping lungis. Two nuns from the convent school. A Jewish antiques dealer from Jew Town, with a face like a kindly walnut, who announced that he had survived the great flood of 2018 on a single prayerbook and was happy to attempt another. A pair of Gujarati sweet-makers, a troop of Class Six children who had walked out of school without permission and were not, strictly, supposed to be there, and Sreeja Nambiar at their head with her plait tied round her head like a general.

They passed the books from hand to hand, hand over hand, up the stair, in the dark and the wet, in four languages and one rhythm:

“Take it. Pass it. Take it. Pass it.”

And in the café next door, a young woman in a white apron watched through the window with her arms folded, delivering a commentary to a customer who had not asked for one.

Lakshmi Panicker was twenty-seven, a waitress, and the café’s principal asset, with enormous good humour and no discretion whatsoever. She had been standing in the doorway since eleven, ostensibly serving banana fritters, in practice conducting a running broadcast to the lane.

“Look at that,” said Lakshmi, to the customer. “Look at Arjun Chetta. The man has lifted four hundred books in the last half-hour, and he has not once looked at the one he is *afraid* of losing.”

“Which one is that?” said the customer, a sleepy tourist from Hamburg.

“The one with the *poem*.” She dropped her voice to a stage whisper that could have been heard in Ernakulam. “I do not know what it says. I know only that every November, a woman in a green sari comes, and the shop goes quiet, and he cannot look at her and I cannot look at him, and there is a banana fritter growing cold in my hand for *seven years*.”

“I see,” said the tourist, who did not.

“It is the greatest tragedy in Kerala. *I* would do something, but I am a waitress. I only bring tea to history.”

“What a lot of rain,” said the tourist, politely.

“That,” said Lakshmi, “is also a metaphor.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Arjun, at the head of the line, had not looked at Meera for seven minutes.

This was not because he had not seen her. He had seen her at the instant she entered, as one sees lightning before the thunder, in the green sari with its hem tucked up and her braid coming loose and her face fierce with purpose. He had seen her seize a box of cookbooks and wade away with it as though it were a baby. He had thought, quite clearly: *I will never be able to speak to her again, because I have seen her in my shop, in a flood, and a man cannot be expected to survive that.*

So he gave her wide berth, in a foot of brown water, with a stack of Tagore.

"Arjun," said Meera, from behind him.

He dropped the Tagore. It floated.

"Oh," said Meera. "I am so sorry. *Gitanjali* is going."

"It is—it is all right, it is—" He plunged for it, and surfaced with a damp, sodden, reproachful volume. "It is a very forgiving book."

"It is *dripping.*"

"It was always a little *emotional.*"

She laughed. It was, he thought, the sound of a very bright coin on a stone floor. He felt his ears go hot, and prayed, in the way of the bookish, that the dark of the shop would hide it.

"It is the twenty-sixth," said Meera.

"Is it?"

"You know it is."

"I—the Annual. It came last night. It is on the top shelf. It is quite safe. It is—" He stopped, with a face of the purest panic. "I have not *looked* at it."

"Good," said Meera, very gravely, and a little pink. "I should not like you to have looked."

"No?"

"I would like to find it," she said, "as it is."

There was a silence. It was the silence of a very large number of things not being said, and it had room in it for the whole flood.

"I will fetch it," said Arjun, and fled up the stairs.

✦ ✦ ✦

He found the crate at the top, safe and dry. He found the copy on the top, the best, with its cover unbent, and he opened it, and there between pages forty-one and forty-two lay the folded square of onion-skin, which he had slipped in at dawn.

She asked to find it as it is, thought Arjun. *Does she know? Has she known all along, and been waiting seven years for the shop-boy to say one word?*

He had a pencil in his pocket. It would take only a moment, and a half-sentence, in the margin: *It is I.*

And a voice from below, unmistakable, shouted: "Arjun! The dictionaries have gone! The Oxford is *floating!*"

He put the pencil back.

Reader, I do not blame him. A man with one hand on a poem and the other on the Oxford English Dictionary is pulled by both ends of language. Few have recovered.

✦ ✦ ✦

By dusk the water had begun, grudgingly, to retreat.

It left behind a thin brown shine on the floor, a smell of wet paper that would last a month, and a shop that was, by some miracle of human arms, nearly intact. The Marxist theory was ruined. The cookbooks were a complete loss. But upstairs in the loft, in tall dry stacks, with the dictionaries on top and the poetry at the summit, were four thousand books, and in the lane below were two hundred people who had saved them and who were now being fed by Lakshmi's café on the house.

"I wish to record," announced Sreeja Iyer, wiping her hands on her poncho, "that this is the best flood I have been in. Normally the householder is *grateful.* Here everybody is *talking.* Gopal-sir! Come and look at the tide."

This was Gopal Varma, fifty-eight, a village vet from Alappuzha and the most unstoppable matchmaker in three districts. He had come that morning to propose to Hari Panicker a girl from Kottayam with a chemistry degree and a *jathakam* that matched Arjun's on nine points out of ten; he had been trapped in the loft since one o'clock, and had formed, in the interval, a different opinion.

"I have been looking at the stars," said Gopal, with a thoughtful frown.

"You cannot see stars. It is raining."

“I have been looking at them *internally.* The Kottayam girl’s chart matches Arjun’s on nine points. But I have also been observing this *other* young lady, in the green sari. I do not have her chart. But I have observed, in three hours, that when the boy drops a book, she picks it up, and when she drops a book, he picks it up, and neither has dropped a book at the same time. In forty years of horoscopes, I have never seen so *perfect* a synchrony.” He closed the folder. “Hari-sir. I withdraw the girl from Kottayam. The stars have had an internal revision.”

“What do the stars say?” said Hari, anxiously.

“They say,” said Gopal Varma, “it is a *great deal of rain.*”

✦ ✦ ✦

At the shop door, in the blue light of the end of the day, Arjun put the book into Meera’s hands.

He said, “It is a little damp.”

“It is a very good book.”

“It was always a little damp,” said Arjun. “In a way.”

“I know,” said Meera. She held it a moment, against her chest, and looked at him; and in the look was seven Novembers, and a green sari, and the flood. “Thank you, Arjun. For the…” She stopped. “For the shop. For everything. I will see you next—”

“Yes.”

“*—soon.*”

“Yes.”

She went down the lane in the failing light, barefoot, her sandals in her bag, with the book wrapped in the end of her sari to shelter it from the last of the rain; and Vishnu Kurup, with his rickshaw bobbing at the corner like a small steamship, took one look at her face, and did not say a word, which for Vishnu Kurup was an act of heroism.

On the back seat, in the light of a dim bulb and the ticking of the rain, Meera Menon opened the book to pages forty-one and forty-two.

It was there: folded small, on onion-skin paper, in pencil.

She read it by the light of passing shop-windows, as she had read it seven times, with her heart doing its usual absurd gymnastics. She came to the last verse, which she knew by heart, and read it nonetheless with the old fresh shock of gladness.

And if one year the page should come out blank…

And then she stopped.

For the paper had been caught, in the loft, in a single drop that must have fallen from the leaking roof, and it had run: and where the last line of the poem had been, the single line that said *Understand*, there was now a faint grey smear, the pencil dissolved into a cloud.

She stared at it. She turned it to the light. She could not read it.

“Madam?” said Vishnu from the front. “Madam. Are you well?”

“I am very well,” said Meera, in a voice that was unusually small. “The rain has taken the last word.”

“That is a great pity.”

“Yes.” She folded the paper. She kept it against her heart, damp as it was. “But I know what it was.”

“Do you?”

“I have *always* known what it was,” said Meera Menon, and looked out of the little window at the drowned and glittering town, “and I think, Vishnu, that it is time somebody said it out loud.”

“Who?” said Vishnu.

She did not answer. She was smiling at the rain, with the look of one who has at last made up her mind.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0699 (Kochi): “I hid a poem in a book I knew you would buy.” Entry 0153 (Kochi): “I buy that book every year to read the poem again.”
Mark that the Register places them five hundred and forty-six entries apart. It is not far. It is, in matters of the heart, the width of a bookshelf, and I have known men to spend a lifetime in the aisle.
I will say this for the rain. It takes the last word, as it takes everything. But it cannot take what is already known. And the one thing a flood cannot wash from paper is the shape of the hand that wrote it.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 9.

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Chapter 10: Surgeon’s Hands

“I lost the patient you taught to walk.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0818

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SCENE I

São Paulo, Brazil. The rehabilitation wing of the Hospital Santa Aurora. Seven in the morning. The city outside is already honking, in a dozen million keys.

São Paulo does not sleep; it merely lowers its voice from a roar to a mutter, and by seven in the morning it has remembered its mistake.

Carlos Mendes, thirty-three, sports physiotherapist, stood at the end of a set of parallel bars and said, in the voice of a man coaxing a nervous horse over a stream: “Dona Cida. One more. It is only a step. A step is the smallest unit of heroism.”

“I am seventy-one,” said Dona Cida, “and it is a *very large* step.”

She took it. The little ward, which contained a dozen patients, six physiotherapists, and one television tuned to a soap opera in which somebody’s twin had just returned from the dead, burst into applause. Carlos bowed. He had a warm, crooked, handsome face, brown

eyes that crinkled at the outer corners, and the easy manner of a man who has made it his life's work to be useful to people in pain, and has found that if one is sufficiently useful, no one inquires after one's own.

On the fourth finger of his left hand, a plain gold ring caught the light of the fluorescent tube.

He had worn it for three years, as one wears a thing that has become part of the body. His patients assumed that he had a wife. His colleagues, who knew that she had died of a long illness two Marches ago, did not mention it, in the delicate Brazilian way, by mentioning everything else at great length. His friend Paulo Souza, the pharmacist across the street, who never answered telephones but sent voice messages of eleven minutes' duration, had once said: "Carlos, one does not have to take it off. But one might *polish* it less."

He polished it, in fact, on the hem of his white coat, whenever he thought himself unwatched.

I am a widower, he had written to an old woman in England, one night, with a bottle of cachaça and a bad conscience, *pretending to be a free man.*

It was a good sentence. It was a true sentence. It had never been spoken.

"Seu Carlos," said a young voice. "Excuse me."

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He turned.

A boy stood at the entrance to the ward, sixteen, in school uniform, a thin, serious, wide-eyed boy holding a paper bag against his chest, and in his face, at once,

Carlos knew the family.

“Leandro,” he said, very quietly. “Raimundo’s grandson.”

“Yes, senhor.”

“You came all the way from Santos?”

“The bus is two hours, senhor. My grandmother sends this.” The boy held out the bag, which was warm and smelled of cheese. “It is *pão de queijo.* She says, thank you for the fourteen months. She says that you made him a man who could curse you on his own two feet.”

It was the exact and only epitaph that Raimundo Teles would have wished.

He had been fifty-eight, a bus driver, a vast and furious man who had fallen from a scaffold while painting his daughter’s house and had woken in a hospital with a verdict that he would never again walk to his own front door. Carlos had spent fourteen months proving the verdict wrong. Raimundo had insulted his mother, his methods, and the football team he supported, and on the last day, panting between the bars, three hundred steps and not one of them pretty, he had said: “Doutor, I will walk to my own funeral.”

Which, three weeks ago, in the narrow and ironic geometry of life, he had very nearly done.

“My grandmother also wants to thank the doctor,” said Leandro.

“Which doctor?”

“The one who tried.” The boy swallowed. “The lady surgeon. She says the lady cried.”

The ward, which was full of noise, became for Carlos Mendes a very long and quiet corridor.

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SCENE II

The same day. The staff cafeteria, 9 p.m. Rain, in great loud sheets, as it comes in São Paulo: not falling so much as arriving.

Beatriz Lima had been awake for thirty-one hours, and was eating a bowl of beans with the expression of a woman reading a final demand.

She was thirty-one, the youngest vascular surgeon in the hospital's history, and she looked it only in that she had not yet learned to stop proving it. She was tall and straight-backed, in green scrubs, with black hair pulled back so tightly it seemed an act of discipline, and large dark eyes rimmed with the grey of a person who has forgotten the use of sleep. Among the nurses she was called *a Doutora*, in a tone that contained admiration, fear, and a pity they never let her hear.

Her mother's name was Lima. She had kept it, after the funeral, as one keeps the key to a house that no longer exists.

"Eat," said her father, from across the table.

"I *am* eating."

"You are pushing a bean from the left side of the bowl to the right. It is a sad little pilgrimage."

Pedro Rocha was sixty, a retired chef, a huge, bald, talkative man with the forearms of a blacksmith and the soul of a tabloid. He had arrived at eight-thirty with a thermos of feijoada the size of a fire extinguisher, in defiance of every regulation concerning outside food, and had distributed it among the nursing staff like sacraments. He was so proud of his daughter that it had never occurred to him to say so; it would have been a vulgar attempt to describe the sun.

"Papai, I lost a patient."

"You lose patients. It is your profession. You are a surgeon."

"I *lose* them very rarely."

"Then it is the more astonishing that it should have happened to you." He leaned forward. "Who was he?"

"A bus driver."

"A *bus driver!* A man of the road! Salt of the earth! What was his name?"

"Raimundo Teles. He was fifty-eight, and he had been paralysed from the waist, and a physiotherapist taught him to walk. And then on the morning of the surgery, Papai, he *walked in.* Three hundred metres, from the front doors. He refused the stretcher. He told the porters, 'A man who has walked for Carlos Mendes can walk into any hospital in Brazil.' And I stood at the end of the corridor and watched him come." She put down the spoon. "And the aneurysm gave way at four minutes past ten, on the table, and there was nothing, *nothing*, not a thing I could do."

Pedro Rocha said nothing. For a talkative man, it was a feat of love.

“I have never met the physiotherapist,” said Beatriz. “I have only seen his name on charts. But I think about it every night. I think: a man spent fourteen months, and made a man whole, and then I—” Her voice caught. “I could not hold him a *morning.*”

“Daughter.” Her father reached across the table and put a hand like a spade over hers. “It is not your fault. Do you think the Lord, who is not a fool, would send a man a physiotherapist for fourteen months and a surgeon for ten minutes if He did not know how to count?”

She laughed. It was a small, startled, wet laugh, and she covered her face with her free hand.

“Ah,” said Pedro. “There she is. Now let me show you something that will cheer you up.” He took out his phone with the pride of one displaying a grandchild. “You know, of course, that I have a *blog.*”

“Papai, nobody reads your—”

“A hundred and forty thousand people have read *this.*”

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The photograph showed an empty counter: a long counter of pale wood, in a very small shop; eight stools, a red-and-white curtain, a steam-clouded window. In the foreground a bowl of ramen stood at the eighth stool, the last one, by the pipe: perfect, golden, steaming, with a single sheet of seaweed and an egg cut in half, and no one before it.

Under it, in Portuguese and in a clumsy English translation, Pedro had written:

Osaka, spring. The chef told me, through the interpreter, that he makes one bowl every night for a woman who stopped coming. He sets it at her stool. He does not eat it. At closing he pours it away, and in the morning, he begins again. I asked, "How long?" The chef did not answer. He only wiped the counter.

Her father wiped his eyes with a napkin. "A man in Curitiba proposed to his girlfriend over it," he said.

Beatriz looked at the photograph for a long time.

A single bowl, steaming, before an empty stool. A thing made every night for one who is not there. She did not know why her throat had closed; she was a doctor, and wished to blame the beans.

I know that bowl, she thought, and could not have said why.

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SCENE III

A lift, in the old wing, at a quarter past ten. The storm has taken the lights. The elevator, one of those great brass antiques that the Hospital Santa Aurora refuses to retire on grounds of sentiment, has stopped between the second and third floors.

It was, of course, a conspiracy.

The reader should not be surprised. A hospital contains choirs, locksmiths, and matchmakers in roughly equal proportions, and when all three are present, the

result is inevitable.

The choir was that of Fábio Santos, a thirty-year-old director from Campinas, who conducted the hospital's Christmas ensemble every Thursday in the ground-floor atrium. The locksmith was Thiago Oliveira, forty-one, vain and glittering, with a waxed moustache, who had been summoned by the porters to rescue the elevator, and who, being a matchmaker by vocation and a locksmith by trade, regarded the entire building as a lock with a very obvious solution.

"Who is in the lift?" he asked the porter.

"The Doutora Beatriz. And the physiotherapist. Seu Carlos."

"Both?"

"Both, Seu Thiago."

"Hm." Thiago Oliveira put down his bag, and looked at the ceiling with an expression of great professional delicacy. "It will take," he said, "approximately forty minutes."

"Forty? It is a simple fault. A child could—"

"A *good* lock," said Thiago, "is a slow lock."

And he sat down, and began, with a flourish, to lay out his tools in order of size.

Mark this, reader. In forty minutes of a stuck lift, more things have been said than in forty years of dinner.

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It was dark. It was warm. There was a crack of emergency light along the floor, thin and amber, and by it they could see each other's shoes.

"I am sorry," said Carlos. "I was on my way to the pharmacy."

"I was on my way to a bed." She was standing with her back to the wall, arms crossed, in the gloom. "You are Mendes."

"I am."

"Lima. Beatriz Lima." There was a pause. "I was Raimundo Teles's surgeon."

"I know."

"I should have come to find you."

"I should have come to find *you*," said Carlos.

The elevator creaked. Somewhere beneath them, down in the atrium, a thin sound began, a choir with its hymn-book open, and the notes crept up the shaft like a faint, sweet smoke.

"He walked in," said Beatriz. "You must know that. He walked into my hospital, three hundred metres, in front of the whole ward, and he said your name. He said it to the porters, to the nurse, to the lift. I stood there, and I thought, *This is a man who has been given his life back. And I am about to—*" She stopped. "I have not been able to put it down."

"Doutora."

"Do not tell me it was not my fault. Everyone says so, and it is a kindness, and I cannot *use* it."

“I was not going to say that,” said Carlos.

There was a silence, thick as velvet.

“I was going to say,” he said, “that I have thought about that morning every day. Not about the aneurysm. About the three hundred metres. Do you know what I realised? Fourteen months. And in all that time, he never once walked for *me.* He walked to spite me, to prove me wrong, to see my face. But that morning he walked for *himself.* To a hospital. Into the hands of a woman he had never met. It was the whole point.” His voice roughened. “I taught him to walk, Doutora. You gave him a place to walk *to.* There are not many surgeons who could say that.”

She was silent. In the thin light he saw her put a hand to her mouth.

“That,” said Beatriz, at last, unsteadily, “is the first thing anyone has said to me in three weeks that I can bear.”

“I will say more if you want. I am a physiotherapist. I can say things for hours in a very reassuring voice.”

She laughed. It broke out of her like water out of a cracked jug, and she slid down the wall of the lift to sit upon the floor, laughing and weeping at once, in her crumpled scrubs. Carlos, after a moment, sat down on the other side, at a safe and gentlemanly distance of about a metre, and found a clean handkerchief in his pocket, and extended it across the gap.

She took it. Their hands touched.

And in the amber glimmer, she saw it: a plain gold band on the fourth finger of a warm brown hand.

It is a curious thing, the speed of the heart. It can fall four floors in a quarter of a second.

“Your wife,” said Beatriz, drawing her hand back with great composure, “must be very patient, to have a husband who sits on floors with strangers.”

Carlos looked at the ring.

For a moment he opened his mouth. *Not what you think,* he thought. *It is exactly what you think. It is neither.* Words stood in his throat like men in a doorway, each waving the others past.

“She—” he said. “It is—a difficult matter.”

“I am sure it is,” said Beatriz, with the clipped kindness of a surgeon closing a wound. “Thank you for the handkerchief. I am very sorry for keeping you from the pharmacy.”

Ah, says the Keeper, quietly, from the dark between the floors. *There it is. He might have said: I am a widower. A word of three syllables, and a world of difference. And she might have said: I should like to know. And neither did, and the lift did not move.*

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O small gold circle, three years on my hand, You are the thing that says a thing is so When I cannot. You are my grammar. You Stand where a verb should stand. I never said, “She’s gone.” I said, “My wife.” The tense is wrong, And no one corrects me, for they are kind. I wear you as a man might wear a

bandage, Long past the time the wound has closed.
And yet, If I should take you off, I fear I'd find The
skin beneath is pale, and strange, and mine.

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The lights came on at ten fifty-two.

They came on with a great shudder, like a house waking. The lift gave a sob, and a lurch, and began to rise; the doors opened on the third floor, and a golden wedge of light fell in upon two people sitting very straight on opposite sides of the floor, each studying the ceiling.

And from the stair below, in four-part harmony, with great conviction, came Fábio Santos's choir, singing a carol which had been chosen, apparently, in the belief that it was Christmas in November.

"*Thiago!*" shouted a nurse. "What took so long?"

"A very old lock," said Thiago Oliveira, rising from his tool-box and brushing his moustache. He glanced at the elevator, in which a surgeon was standing up with great dignity and a physiotherapist was handing her a lost shoe, and in his face there was something that in any other man would have been tenderness and in Thiago was merely vanity. "They do not make them like that any more. I should say they were *made* for each other."

"Which lock?" said Fábio, a little confused.

"*Any* of them," said Thiago, and sailed off in search of his fee.

Beatriz stepped out first. She turned, in the doorway, and said, with perfect composure: "Seu Carlos. Thank you. I think we shall not need to speak of this again."

“No?”

“No.” And then, a little more softly: “But I shall be at the rehab wing on Thursday, for a follow-up. A patient I am concerned about. If that is… not an imposition.”

“It will be,” said Carlos, “an honour.”

“It is a *follow-up*,” said Beatriz Lima, very sternly, and walked away down the corridor with her chin up, and her hand, which she did not know she was doing, pressed to the pocket where she had put his handkerchief.

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SCENE IV

Osaka, Japan. Twelve hours ahead. It is eleven in the morning of the next day, and has been, here, all along. The ward of Tenma, where the ramen shops put out their curtains like flags.

There is an old joke, among those who live between time zones, that it is always tomorrow somewhere. In Osaka it was already the next morning, and in a narrow apartment above a stationer’s a woman of thirty-three stood in her kitchen with a cup of tea she could not taste, looking at a phone.

Mei Sato had been a food critic for eleven years. She had written, for the *Naniwa Shimbun*, reviews in a cadence of salt and smoke, sweetness and acid, that readers called *a hymn in a bowl.* And last September, when a fever that should have been forgotten by Friday had

gone, she had sat down to a plate of *tamagoyaki* and tasted nothing at all. It had been, she thought, like hearing the world's last piano go quiet.

She had told no one. She wrote now from memory. She was good at it. She could construct a review of any bowl in Osaka from the vocabulary of her past, and no one, so far, had known the difference. But she had stopped going out. And she had stopped, in particular, going to a very small ramen shop in an alley in Tenma ward, eight stools, run by a taciturn man called Tanabe, where she had eaten, on the eighth stool, at the end, near the pipe where the steam rose, every Thursday for two years.

She had not been back since the new-moon night, when she had sat at his counter, said the one true thing, been fed, and gone home to the quiet of her own mouth. *One night of being fed is a kindness,* she thought. *Every night would be charity. And he would see it.*

On her phone, a friend had sent a link, with a single line: *Is this your Tanabe?*

She opened it.

A photograph. A counter. A bowl. An empty stool, the eighth, at the end, near the pipe.

The caption was in Portuguese, which she did not read. But beneath it ran an English translation, and she read that, very slowly, with her hand on the cold kitchen counter.

He makes one bowl every night for a woman who stopped coming.

She put the phone down.

Across the city, she knew, a man of thirty-four sat alone behind a counter in the clean quiet of a closed shop, skimming a pot he had begun at three in the morning. And between that man and a stranger's photograph, in a kitchen, with a cup of tea that tasted of nothing, stood the one woman for whom the bowl was made.

"Daichi," said a voice, in a shop across the city, to a historian who had arrived with a mobile phone and the news. "You are telling me that I am famous in *Brazil.*"

"A hundred and forty thousand hearts, Tanabe-san! A woman in Recife says you have ruined her mother's soup!"

Hiroshi Tanabe did not look at the phone. He did not look at the empty stool. He lifted the ladle, tasted the broth, adjusted nothing, and said, with the economy of a man who had spent one sentence a day for six months:

"Eat."

At the kitchen window of a flat above a stationer's, Mei Sato put on her coat.

She stood in the hall. She took it off.

She put it on again.

Thursday, she thought. *It is only Thursday. I will go on Thursday, and either I will tell him the rest of the truth, or I will tell him a lie, and either way I shall have been there.*

Far away, a boy called Leandro slept in Santos with the smell of cheese still on his sleeves, a surgeon sat in her car in a hospital garage with a man's handkerchief

in her pocket, and a physiotherapist polished a ring on the hem of his coat.

And at a small shop on a narrow street, a bowl would be set that night at the eighth stool, by the pipe, and steam, as though it knew.

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Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0016 and Entry 0818, São Paulo. A ring and a scalpel. He is afraid to take off the one; she is afraid to put down the other. They are two hands, each holding the same grief, each convinced that the other has the better grip.

Entry 0510 and Entry 0810, Osaka. A bowl and a tongue. The one cooks for a guest who cannot taste; the other cannot taste, and will not sit at the bowl. It is the oldest comedy and it is, as always, a tragedy by Thursday.

And I notice that the lift stopped between two floors. That is the whole state of the human heart. It is always waiting for a locksmith with a sense of occasion.

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End of Chapter 10.

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Chapter 11: The Founder and the Dressmaker

“I only design clothes for the woman I am afraid to become.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0954

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SCENE I

Yaba, Lagos, Nigeria. Adeniran Court, a five-storey building that was once a bank, then a church, and is now a cluster of ambitions with a shared generator. Six in the morning. The generator has begun.

In Lagos, the sun does not rise. It is *switched on*, by a large and unseen hand, at an hour when everybody has already been awake for three hours, and the first sound of the day is not a bird but a generator.

It is a sound of enormous character. It is a cough, a clearing of the throat, a long grinding grievance, and then a steady and defiant drone, as of a man determined to have the last word in an argument that began in nineteen-eighty. Under the drone, in a city of twenty million, the danfo minibuses begin to hoot, the *okada* motorbikes weave like needles through the go-slow, a woman at the corner begins to fry *puff-puff* in a pan the size of a cart-

wheel, and from the Third Mainland Bridge there rises the roar of a metropolis that has never in its history been asked to wait.

On the fourth floor of Adeniran Court, in an office with a whiteboard, nine desks, and a very handsome neon sign that said **AJO**, a young man sat alone before a laptop, and read the same bank notification for the eleventh time.

Your balance is insufficient for the scheduled transfer.

"It is not *insufficient*," said Emeka Okafor, aloud, to nobody. "It is *shy*."

He was twenty-eight, the founder of a company named for the *ajo*, the old Yoruba savings circle in which a dozen neighbours each put a little money in a pot every week and take the whole pot in turn, so that a market woman can buy a freezer and a tailor can buy a machine, with no bank and no interest and nothing at all but trust. He had built a phone application to do the same thing on a grand scale. For two years it had been the most promising thing in the building. It had been featured in a magazine. It had won a prize in Nairobi, and a lunch in London, and the heart of an investor who had said, with tears in his eyes, that Emeka was *going to change Africa.*

And then, in March, the investor had changed *his mind.*

It had gone quickly, as a good building goes: first the funding, then the clients, then the app store ranking, and finally, in the quiet of a Thursday, the last of the

sense that anyone would ever want to talk to him about it again. The company was dead. It was simply that nobody had told its heart.

He had nine employees. He paid them, on the twenty-fifth of each month, from his own account: from his savings, from the sale of a good watch, from a loan against a flat in Surulere, from the last of his father's gift. He had not told them. He had not told his sister. He had not told the neon sign, which went on every morning with its hopeful buzz, and which he had begun to hate.

My company is dead, he had written to an old woman in England, on a night in which the generator had failed, *and I keep paying salaries from my own pocket.*

He had meant it as a confession. He had not realised it was also a budget.

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SCENE II

Mama Put Joint, behind the building. Noon. A tin roof, long benches, and enormous steaming pots. A woman of sixty in a sailor's cap is eating amala *with the manner of a captain taking a ship.*

"You are looking," said Ifeoma Bello, "like a man who has swallowed an anchor."

She was sixty, a tiny, wiry woman from Ibadan, who had gone to sea at nineteen as the only woman on a Lagos-registered freighter, and had spent thirty-one years on the oceans of the world, rising to first mate and acquiring a vocabulary that could blister a bulkhead.

She had retired with a pension, a parrot-handled cane, and a very large number of opinions, and she now invested small sums in the young, on the condition that they take her to lunch.

"I am well, Auntie."

"You are lying. It is the first thing a young man learns, and the last he learns to do *well*." She tore a morsel of *amala*, dipped it in *ewedu* and gbegiri, and chewed with great deliberation. "What is the number?"

"Which number?"

"The number you are not saying."

He looked at his plate. "Four million, one hundred thousand naira. Outstanding. After the payroll."

"And the company?"

"It has—" He stopped. "Auntie, it has three customers. They are all my cousins."

"Hm." Ifeoma Bello put down her morsel, and wiped her fingers on a napkin with an air of solemn purpose. "I will tell you a thing from the sea. There is a story of the captain who goes down with his ship. It is a very fine story and you will find it in every poem. In thirty-one years, young man, I met three captains who went down with their ships. They were all *very* dead." She raised an eyebrow. "The captain who lives is the one who writes the lifeboat list on the *first* night of the leak, and lets his crew read it."

"They will blame me."

“Naturally. They will blame you for a week. And then they will remember that you paid them for nine months from your own pocket, and they will blame you for being a fool, which is a different thing, and keeps better.”

“How do you know I—”

“Emeka,” said Ifeoma gently, “you have sold your watch. You have a pale line on your wrist like a very sad bracelet.”

He looked at his wrist. He put his hand under the table.

“Pride,” said the old sailor, “is a heavy ballast. A ship needs some. Not so much that it cannot rise.” She pushed the pot of *ewedu* towards him. “Eat. And go and look at the third floor. I am told that there is a young woman there who is making something you could learn from.”

“A woman?”

“A *dress*,” said Ifeoma Bello, with great dignity, “is also a company. It also dies if nobody pays. Go.”

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SCENE III

The third floor. A workroom, gold with afternoon. Bolts of cloth in every colour of the earth: adire in indigo, aso-oke in rust and wheat, ankara in a hundred voices. A long table. A mannequin in the corner.

Now we must make the acquaintance of a young woman who lives in her own opera.

Chidinma Eze was twenty-seven, a fashion designer from Enugu, who had come to Lagos at twenty with a suitcase, a sewing machine, and a conviction that the whole city was a stage on which she had been unaccountably cast as the maid. She was small, quick, and brilliant, with a short crop of black hair, a mouth that could convey eleven emotions per sentence, and a way of entering a room as though she had been announced. She wore her own designs always: that day a gold-and-indigo wrap with sleeves like a pair of wings, and a headscarf that made her look like the figurehead of a very expensive ship.

She was at that moment kneeling at the feet of a mannequin, with a mouth full of pins.

"No," she was saying, round them. "*No.* The shoulder must be sharper. Sharper, my dear. You are a woman who walks into a boardroom and *causes it to be silent.* You do not have a *gentle* shoulder."

The mannequin did not argue.

It stood in the corner, headless, in a jacket of heavy indigo adire with hand-pleated sleeves, and beside it, on a hook, hung eight garments in different states of completion. It was the strangest thing in the studio, and the most beautiful, and Chidinma, who confided in it as other women confide in their mothers, called it *Her.*

"Excuse me," said a voice from the door. "I am told that the sea requires me to go and look at a dress."

She did not turn. "Who is there?"

"Emeka Okafor. Fourth floor. The, ah, *Ajo* people."

“The neon people.”

“The neon people.”

“You are the ones who have been stealing my diesel.”

“We pay our levy.”

“You have *not* paid your levy for two months. The generator committee has a list. You are number three. I am number one, because I am saintly.” She took the pins from her mouth and turned, at last, on her knees, and looked up at the tall, tired, handsome, creased young man in the doorway, with a lock of hair falling into his eyes and a pale line on his wrist. And, because she was a designer, she saw the whole of him in a glance, as a tailor does: the slope of the shoulder, the tension in the jaw, the shirt that had been ironed with great care and a failing hope.

That man, she thought, *has not slept in a month.*

“I will pay the levy,” said Emeka.

“You will not,” said Chidinma. “I paid it. For both of us.”

There was a short and terrible silence.

“I did not ask you to.”

“No. You did not ask anyone for anything. It is a *remarkable* condition.” She stood and brushed off her knees with a theatrical flourish. “Do not worry. It is four thousand naira. I charged it to the ministry of nobody.”

“Why?”

“Because the generator is a *commons,*” said Chidinma, “and the whole of the building is a *tragedy* of it, and I am an actress at heart. If I see a man with a grave face and a fine shirt and a company that is making the sound of a deflating tyre, I do what any decent woman does. I pay his diesel and say nothing, and then I wait for the opening to say it *very* loudly.” She smiled. “Welcome to the third floor.”

He looked at the mannequin.

“Who is she?”

“Nobody.” The smile went out. “It is a dress form.”

“It has a name.”

“Everything has a name.” She went rather pink. “Do not mind it.”

He came into the room and stood before the jacket, looking at it in silence for a long time, with his hands in his pockets, as one looks at a diagram one does not understand but cannot bear to leave. It was the most extraordinary garment he had ever seen. It was powerful. It had a collar like a drawn bow. It looked like the coat of a woman who had decided, at last, to be *looked at.*

“It is not a *design,*” said Emeka. “It is an *argument.*”

Chidinma looked at him for a moment in a manner she had not looked at anyone for a long time.

“Yes,” she said, very quietly. “That is exactly what it is.”

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In her workroom, that night, with the machines asleep, she speaks to the empty room, and to the headless guest, in the only manner a designer can trust; which is to say, in the language of the thing she cannot afford to say in daylight.

> *I have been sewing thee these seven years, My silent lady of the sharp-cut sleeve. I never gave thee eyes, for fear of finding Thou lookedst somehow like myself. Thou art The woman I am frightened of: unbowed, Unasking, tall, and not apologetic; The woman who has never said, "I'm sorry To take up room." I dress thee every season. I say, "She is a fiction. She is cloth." And then I stand before thee, in the dark, And measure: here the shoulder; there the waist; And find that every inch of thee is mine. It is a mortal thing to make a woman Whom thou wouldst love, and tremble to become.*

She stood in the dim, with a pin in her hand, until the generator coughed and went out. Then she laughed, once, at herself, and said, "You see, *Her*, this is the problem with being theatrical. The cure is worse than the complaint."

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE IV

The next evening. The lobby of Adeniran Court. The light has not merely gone: it has been taken by the State, with a smile, and without notice, and forty people stand in the dark with their phones lit, a congregation in a cathedral of small blue candles.

It was the night of the show.

It had been meant to take place in a great ballroom on Victoria Island, with a runway, a sponsor, and a DJ. Eight weeks ago the venue had been booked. Three weeks ago the sponsor had withdrawn. A week ago the venue had demanded a deposit of two million, three hundred thousand naira, which Chidinma had not got and could not borrow. And yesterday she had called her father in Enugu, a retired tailor, a devout and silver-haired man with a stern face and a very tender conscience, who had said, over a faint line, in the voice of a man who has said the thing many times: "Nnem, a coat is a coat, whether it is hung in a palace or a lobby. The woman who wears it will not ask."

So the show was in the lobby.

The tenants of Adeniran Court had made themselves its audience: the lawyers from the second floor, the three young men who ran an app for hailing motorcycles, the woman with the dental practice, a pack of children from the compound, Mama Ngozi from the stairwell. There were plastic chairs and a runway of ankara cloth laid down the length of the tile. There were eight models, all friends, a single working speaker, and a cousin of Chidinma's in a bow tie with a laptop; and in the middle of an enormous silence, with great ceremony, the power failed.

"*Abeg,*" said somebody in the audience. "Not again."

"It is a *design feature,*" said somebody else.

Chidinma, in the wings, in gold, closed her eyes.

“Chineke,” she whispered. “It is a joke. It is a very bad joke, and God is the comedian.”

“Madam?”

She opened them. On the stair, with the lights of eleven phones behind him like a very small constellation, stood Emeka Okafor in his ironed shirt, flanked by a short, powerful young woman in coveralls with a spanner in her belt and a face of divine patience.

“This is Ngozi,” said Emeka. “She is a mechanic.”

“I am her *best friend,*” said Ngozi Afolabi, who was thirty-three and had been, for six years, the sole person on earth to whom Chidinma Eze did not play. “And I have been downstairs for twenty minutes, and your generator has the soul of a man who has been told it is Monday. It needs a *belt.*”

“We do not have a belt!”

“*I* have a belt,” said Emeka, “and it is in the car, and I will go and fetch it, and I will also bring the cables from the office, and the nine laptops, which will be the light.” He paused. “It is a thing we know about. We are a company that has been running on very little for some time.”

Chidinma stared at him.

“You are a founder,” said Ngozi Afolabi, wiping a spanner on her coverall, “and a man of *infrastructure.* This is a rare thing. Do not waste him.”

“I am not wasting—” said Chidinma. “I am only—”

“Go on,” said Emeka, quietly. “Get ready. It will be lit.”

It was.

For in fifteen minutes the nine desks of AJO had been emptied, and nine staff members, whom their employer had supposed to be ignorant of the entire state of his finances, filed down the stair in a solemn procession, each carrying a laptop, an extension cable, and an expression of great composure. Tobi, the youngest, a twenty-four-year-old with spectacles and a ferocious talent for code, set down his machine on the lobby floor and opened it with a click. It lit a small circle of tile in a pale electric blue. Beside it, another. And another.

They arranged the nine screens in a long line along the sides of the ankara runway, like the lamps along a harbour. Each of them, on a white background, burned a single word, which Tobi had typed in thirty seconds, with the dry humour of the very young.

WELCOME.

ENTER.

PAY.

(Support available.)

"Oga," said Tobi, to his employer, as the crowd laughed and the light settled over the tile like warm water. "We have been reading your bank alerts on the office printer for two months. We thought you would tell us when you were ready."

Emeka did not speak.

"We are not stupid, oga," said Tobi, very gently. "We are *nine.* We have been quietly agreeing, in the toilet, that we shall keep coming to work until the building falls."

✦ ✦ ✦

The show began in the glow of nine screens, and it was the best thing that had ever happened in Adeniran Court.

The first model came down the cloth in a skirt of golden aso-oke that moved like a lit bell. The second, in an adire wrap the colour of the deep Atlantic. The third, the fourth, the fifth: coats and gowns and caftans cut from the old loom-cloths of three peoples, remade as armour, as laughter, as a woman who knows her price. The audience went quiet; then, as the sleeves went by, it began to murmur; and by the sixth garment they were on their feet.

And at the back, by the stair, a very old woman in a purple wrapper and white head-tie, who had been standing in the stairwell of the building for eleven years, offering to any who would listen the word of the Lord, said, in a voice that carried: "*I have seen it!*"

"Mama Ngozi?" said Emeka, beside her.

"I saw it in a dream, my son." She was fifty-nine, the leader of a small chapel in Yaba, a woman of true and unwavering faith and no sense of direction whatsoever; and she gripped his sleeve with a hand like a bird's. "I saw that a man in this building would lose everything on a Thursday and gain it on a Friday. I did not know what it meant. I thought it was the stock market."

"It is *Wednesday,* Mama."

"Then," said Mama Ngozi, with perfect serenity, "I am early." She looked at the runway, and the lit faces, and the nine screens glimmering, and the girl in gold at the

end of the cloth with her hands clasped before her in a posture that no one had ever seen on her. “But I do not think the Lord *minds.*”

And there was a hush, because the last model had not come out.

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She had not come.

There was a gap. The whole room felt it. There was a silent beat at the end of the runway, where the eighth garment should have come: the jacket, the indigo, the sharp-shouldered one, the armoured one that cost her eleven weeks. Beneath it in the dark, with a hand on her mouth, stood a young woman in gold who had expected to see it lifted down from its hook by a friend who had that morning been called away to a funeral in Anambra.

“Where is *Her?*” whispered Chidinma. “Ngozi, where is the eighth?”

“The model—her train—”

“She is not coming?”

“She will not come.”

She looked at the jacket on its hook. She looked at the dark. She looked, for the first time in seven years, directly at the woman she had been making.

It is a jacket. It is cloth.

It is not cloth.

She took it down.

Mark this, reader. A person does not walk into the thing she fears with a flourish. She walks into it with one foot and a bad heartbeat, in the wrong shoes. Chidinma Eze put on the coat in the dark, and it fitted as if it had been cut against her bones, and she stepped onto the ankara cloth between two lines of glowing screens, with forty people in the dark before her, and the whole tall frightening woman she had stitched, shoulder by shoulder, for seven years, walked into the light.

No one spoke.

At the end of the runway, in the nine small blue lights, a young man in an ironed shirt stood up out of his chair, without knowing that he had, with his hands at his sides and a pale line on his wrist, and thought, with absolute clarity, in the middle of the end of his company:

I know that woman. I will do anything not to lose her.

And then, from somewhere at the back, the generator, with a long shuddering gasp, caught.

The lights came on.

The people of Lagos will applaud a thing for any reason at all, but a thing that is *true* they applaud as though it were a goal.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0051 and Entry 0954. A company that is dead and keeps its payroll; a woman who wears her fear and dresses it as courage. It is the same condition. Each is performing an act of faith in a thing no longer visible.

I would like it noted that nine young people sat in a toilet and agreed to go on working for a man who had not told them the truth. There is a kind of love that does not go in the Register at all. It goes in the payroll.

The woman will have to learn to be seen. The man will have to learn to be helped. I do not know which is harder. I only know that the generator coughed first, and the lights came on after.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 11.

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Chapter 12: Flour and Violets

“I still bake my wife’s bread every Sunday.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0844

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SCENE I

Lyon, France. The Croix-Rousse, the steep hill of the silk-weavers. Sunday, a quarter to four in the morning. A fog from the two rivers has climbed the hill and is looking in at the windows.

At the hour when the honest are asleep and the dishonest are, for once, at a loss, a baker was talking to a lump of dough.

“You are too wet,” said Pierre Dubois. “It is the weather. Do not take it personally.”

He was forty-five, large and stooped and flour-white to the elbow, with a nose that had been broken at rugby and a pair of hands that had never in their lives been idle. He had inherited the shop from his father and the habit of silence from his mother, and had added, by his own labour, a reputation for the best *pain de campagne* on the hill and the worst temper. He kneaded with his

whole back, in the yellow light of the oven, in the warm, sweet dark of a bakery before dawn, which is the nearest thing on earth to the inside of a heart.

It was Sunday. On Sundays he made *the other bread.*

It was a round loaf, dark-crusted, with walnuts and a little rye and a pinch of cumin that no one else in Lyon would have dared, and it had been invented in the kitchen of a small flat in the Rue Imbert-Colomès by a woman called Odile, who had died four years ago in the spring of a thing that had taken eleven months to say its name. She had baked it every Sunday of their marriage. He had never in his life made it until the first Sunday after she was gone, when he had woken at four, and found his hands in the flour, and understood that they had decided without him.

He had never sold it. He gave it away. Every Sunday, before the first church bell, a boy of thirteen came on a bicycle, and took twelve loaves in a basket, and delivered them to the old and the lonely of the hill, who had no idea who sent them, and who ate them in silence, with butter, as if they were an answer to a prayer.

I still bake my wife's bread every Sunday, he had written, to a stranger, in the dark. *I do not know how to stop. I do not think I want to.*

"Pierre."

He turned. The boy was in the doorway: Baptiste Lefèvre, thirteen, a thin, severe child in an oversized anorak, with a school satchel, a bicycle helmet, and the expression of a very small and uncompromising judge.

"You are early."

“I am never early. *You* are late.”

“It is not yet four.”

“It is *five to,*” said Baptiste, “and you have flour on your face. It is the look of a man who has been thinking.”

“Go and sit down.”

“I do not sit. I *witness.*” He looked about the shop with narrowed eyes. “Has it come yet?”

Pierre’s hands stopped in the dough.

“Has what come?”

“The thing,” said Baptiste, with the impatience of the young explaining the obvious to the old, “that is on your step every Sunday. A little before four. I am a boy who gets up. I have *seen.*”

✦ ✦ ✦

For eleven weeks, on Sunday mornings, a small bunch of violets had been laid at the baker’s door.

They were Parma violets, the sweet-scented double kind that Lyon’s gardeners coax into bloom under glass in the cold months: a dozen blooms, tight as a clenched fist, tied with a grey ribbon, in a twist of brown paper. They had no card. They had no name. They lay on the worn stone step in the first light, damp with the fog and smelling of a spring that was months away, and Pierre, who found them each week when he opened the shutter, had begun, to his own annoyance, to look forward to the finding.

He did not know who. He had asked. He had put it, in his gruff and wounded manner, to every female customer who had come in that month: “Madame, did you leave some flowers?” and had been given, in return, a series of long stares of the kind that a woman gives a man who has just asked whether she is in love with him.

Now he put down the dough and went to the door.

He opened it a crack, as one opens the door on a stranger, and the fog came in, white and cold, and with it, curling through the cold, faint as a note from a distant room: *violets.*

On the step lay a small twist of brown paper.

He looked up. Down the steep hill, at the corner, in the lamplight, for a single moment, a figure in a long grey coat was walking away, quickly, with its head down, past the shuttered bank and the tobacconist’s, toward the river and the flower market. A woman. He saw the line of her shoulder, and a scarf the colour of a pigeon’s wing, and then the fog closed round her like a hand.

He did not call out. His throat had forgotten how.

“It is the florist,” said Baptiste, at his elbow.

Pierre turned. “*What?*”

“Madame Laurent. From the Rue de la Martinière. The one with the sad shop.” The boy shrugged, with magnificent indifference. “I do not know why. She leaves them and she looks at the window and she goes. I did not tell you, because I was not asked, and I am not good at apologising when I am wrong.”

“You were not *wrong.*”

“I might have been. It is a risk.”

Mark this, reader. There is a great deal of wisdom in thirteen-year-olds, and nearly all of it is used to avoid being embarrassed.

Pierre stood a long moment with the violets in his hand. Then he went back inside, and wiped his palms, and took from the cooling rack the last loaf of the morning, the dark round one with the walnuts, and wrapped it in a clean cloth.

“I have always baked twelve,” he said gruffly. “Today you will take thirteen.”

“To whom?”

“To the Rue de la Martinière. Say nothing.”

“I never do,” said Baptiste, “unless I am not asked.”

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At the other end of the hill, in a very small shop, a woman in a long grey coat had just come in out of the fog, and was hanging up her scarf with a hand that was not quite steady.

Margaux Laurent was forty-two, a florist, a widow of three years’ standing, with soft brown hair going silver at the temple, and a way of pausing before she spoke as though she were arranging the sentence in a vase. Her husband Luc had been a violin-maker and had died quickly, in the middle of a Tuesday, and she had been left with a shop called *Les Violettes,* an unpaid lease, and a house that was too quiet by half. She was gentle and humorous and exceedingly shy, and had, eleven weeks ago, done the most daring thing of her life.

She had been walking to the flower market in the dark. She had passed the bakery on the Croix-Rousse, where the lamp was lit; and she had looked, for no reason, through the window, and seen a large man with his arms in a trough of dough, and his shoulders shaking.

It is a thing we are not supposed to see. She had stood there for a full minute in the fog, with violets in her basket meant for the market. And then she had done what a florist does, which is to know when a thing is not a bunch of flowers but a sentence.

She laid them on the step. She walked away.

I left the flowers at your door, she had written, afterwards, to an old woman in England, with the kettle going cold. *It was always me.*

Now she stood in her little shop among the zinc buckets and the paper cones and the smell of wet green stalks, and said to her assistant, who happened to be her twenty-year-old brother, another Baptiste (the hill, it must be said, had an inordinate number of them), and who was at that moment arranging chrysanthemums in a manner she found personally offensive: “He saw me.”

“Who?”

“The baker.”

“Did he *speak* to you?”

“He did not speak. He *stood.*” She sank onto a stool. “He looked at me through a fog. I have not been looked at through a fog since nineteen-ninety-nine.”

“What do you intend?”

“To go on,” said Margaux, gently and appalled, “and to be a coward at the same time. It is a skill. I have been practising it for three years.”

The shop bell rang. A thin boy in an oversized anorak stood in the door with a basket, and in it, wrapped in a clean cloth, one round dark loaf, warm still, and smelling of walnuts and a pinch of something that no one else in Lyon would have dared.

“From a witness,” said Baptiste Lefèvre, and set it on the counter, and fled.

Margaux Laurent looked at the loaf. She broke it. The steam rose, and she put her face into it, as one puts one’s face into a flower.

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SCENE II

Kraków, Poland. The workshop of a clockmaker on Floriańska Street, a long dark room that ticks, as a forest breathes, with a hundred small lives. Noon. The great bugle of St. Mary’s Church is about to sound from the tower.

In Kraków, at every hour, a trumpeter climbs to the window of the tallest tower in the square, and plays a short, old, sad tune to the four corners of the earth; and at the exact moment the tune would reach its end, it stops.

It is cut in the middle of a note, by tradition, because on one afternoon long ago the player on the tower was shot in the throat by a Tatar arrow while sounding the

alarm, and the city has kept the tune unfinished ever since, in his honour. So that every hour, in the clear air above the square, a stranger may hear a thing that stops mid-sentence. The people of Kraków have been trained for centuries to bear a sentence that stops.

"It is noon," said Jakub Nowak, without lifting his eyes from the movement before him.

"I know," said Zofia Kowalska. "I heard it."

She had not.

The reader may keep that, with the rest of the day's secrets, for later.

Jakub was twenty-four, the apprentice of the oldest clockmaker in the street, a precise and gentle young man, fair-haired and long-fingered, with a loupe pushed up into his hair and the habit of holding his breath when he worked, as though the watch under his hands might wake. He had learned in four years that a clock is only a promise to go on, and that everything in the trade follows from the discovery that one must not hurry a promise.

Zofia was twenty-three, a violinist in her last year at the Academy of Music, a slight, luminous girl with a mass of dark hair and a face of such fine and shadowed attention that people, on meeting her, tended to lower their voices. Six weeks ago she had left in the shop a silver pocket-watch wrapped in a handkerchief, with a worn look about the eyes, and said: "It stopped four years ago, at eleven fifty-two. It was my grandfather's."

The master had given the job to his apprentice. And Jakub had opened the case, and read, engraved inside in a tiny copperplate hand: *Zofia, for her birth.*

He had mended it. It was a *minute repeater,* a rare thing, the kind of watch that chimes the hour and the quarter and the minute on two tiny silver gongs at the touch of a slide; and he had sat for six weeks of evenings, with a light and a loupe, restoring it, and when it was done, on the last night of October, he had thought, with no reason at all: *Zofia. It is the name of the girl who plays the violin under the tower.* For he had heard her. Every Thursday at dusk, at the foot of the church, in a thin red scarf, she played for coins. He had stood across the square every Thursday for a year with his hands in his pockets, and had never once put a coin in her case, because he could not trust his face.

And now she had come to collect it, at noon, and was holding out his own work as though it were only hers.

"It is ready," said Jakub. "It is a repeater. It will chime. Listen."

He pressed the slide.

The tiny silver chime was bright as a drop of water on glass: high notes for the hour, then the quarters, then the minutes, as precise as a heartbeat. It filled the shop; it was the sweetest sound a clockmaker knows; and he watched her face as it rang, and saw it do a thing he did not understand.

It went very still. It went, for one moment, the stillness of a person listening to a door that is not opening. And then she smiled, a bright, composed, practised

smile, and said:

"It is perfect."

He frowned. "You heard all of it?"

"*Of course.*"

"The last four notes? They are very high."

"They are very beautiful," said Zofia, with the smile fixed, and he did not press her; for he was twenty-four, and a gentleman, and a man who had learned that a person who says a thing very quickly is generally not asking to be examined.

She had heard the first three notes. She had not heard the rest.

It is a small matter, the top of a scale, in a young woman's left ear. She had noticed it in September. She had told no one. She had told herself that it was the damp.

✦ ✦ ✦

"You play," said Jakub, a little later, after he had named a price she could pay and she had pretended to argue.

"How do you know?"

"You hold your hands like a person carrying a bowl."

"I am a violinist."

"I know. I have heard you." He went red from the collar upward. "I mean, I have *heard of* you. At the tower. On Thursdays."

"You have *heard* me?"

“I have a window,” said Jakub, desperately.

She laughed. It was a clear, surprised, delighted sound, and for a moment the clocks seemed to quiet to hear it. “You are a very strange man,” said Zofia. “You mend a watch that is not yours and you listen to a girl from a window. Is that a profession?”

“It is *horology.*”

“I am sure it is.” She stood up, glancing about the long ticking room, and her eyes fell on the back wall. “Is that a piano?”

It was. It stood in the corner, an old upright pianino of walnut with a missing candle-bracket, which had belonged to the master’s wife, and on which Jakub, in the long dull afternoons, with the door shut, played the songs his grandmother had sung to him in Nowy Targ.

“It is out of tune.”

“Everything is out of tune. Play me something.”

“I do not—I am not—”

“Play me *anything,*” said Zofia, “and I will do the rest.”

✦ ✦ ✦

So it was that on the twenty-ninth day of November, at a quarter past noon, in a clockmaker’s shop in the most beautiful medieval city in Europe, with a hundred clocks ticking and a very old piano missing its candle, a boy and a girl played the first duet of their lives.

It was a simple tune: an old Polish lullaby, four bars and a turn. He played the chords, in his careful, even, gentle way, as a man lays bricks. She took the violin from its worn case and tucked it under her chin and closed her eyes, and drew the bow, and the shop was *filled.*

I cannot describe it; I have only words. It was as though a window had been opened in a closed room, and a bird had flown in. She played the way a river runs. And he, bent over the keys, looking for the first time in his life at nothing but the notes, felt his chest do a thing that was not on any list of the diseases of the heart.

She did not once look at him. She played with her eyes shut, her whole body bent toward the piano, her head a little turned.

Turned. He saw it, in the end, with the unforgiving eye of a man who takes engines apart: she had turned her right ear toward the piano, and her left away.

She was following his hands.

He did not know what it meant. He knew only that when he slowed, a hair, in the second bar, because he had caught his breath, she slowed an instant before him, as though she had *seen* the beat, rather than heard it; and that in the high register, in the turn, when she should have lifted the line, her bow dipped, ever so slightly, and found the note by the width of a hair.

A clock does not lie, thought Jakub. *Nor does a person who plays by sight.*

And in the shop behind them a dozen clocks struck the quarter at once, in a bright, scattered chorus, and *she did not hear it.*

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

Lisbon, Portugal. A tram, the 28, climbing the hills of Graça and Alfama in the rain. Evening. The tiles shine like the sides of fishes.

The old yellow tram ground up the Rua da Graça with a noise like a bad conscience, and in the cab, behind the driver, on a folding seat, an engaged man was telling an engine that he loved it.

"Not *you,*" Tomás Villaverde hastened to explain, patting the great brass controller. "You are a friend. I mean *her.* I have asked her. She has said yes. It is a matter of the postal service."

"You have said so four times," said Nuno Pereira, his friend and fellow mechanic, from the other end of the cab.

"It is a matter of the *postal service,* Nuno. I proposed, as everything between us has happened, by *post.* I wrote it in a very good letter, in the correct format, I sent it to *Senhora Inês Carvalho, Rua das Flores* (a street I have never seen), and the post, in the person of Inês, with her own hands, delivered it to *herself.*"

"And she said?"

“She said she had read it twice. She reads everything twice. And then she took out a pen and signed the back, and *returned* it to the sender.” He took out a creased, much-handled sheet. On the bottom, in a small round hand, it said: *Yes. Delivered. — I.C.*

It was the best receipt he had ever been issued.

At the bottom of the hill, in the rain, Pereira the lamp-seller was holding forth to a captive passenger. “I sold her a lamp, you know. A small one, for the table. She said it was for her mother. It was for the *letter.* To read it by. A person must have good light for a thing like that. It is the principal duty of my trade, and no one has ever thanked me.”

Inês Carvalho, at that moment, was in her tiny flat above the sorting-office, with a small lamp on the table, and a ring that was not a ring, because he could not afford one yet, but a small loop of copper wire from a tram’s motor, that he had bent into a circle with his own pliers and slipped on her finger with the solemnity of a bishop. She sat with it before her in the light. Across the table, her sister Rita, thirty-two, a journalist, was looking at her with an expression of the most complete and unrepentant smugness.

“You *sent* it,” said Inês. “The first letter. To the street that did not exist. It was *you.*”

“I was the one who sent the letter,” said Rita. “Yes. I am the author of this entire romance. I put a letter in a postbox. I would like some credit.” She poured the wine. “I will accept a toast.”

“Rita.”

"I will accept *two.*"

Inês laughed. She turned the copper ring in the light, as a postwoman turns a letter, looking for the postmark, and found it, in the shine of the wire: the small bright mark of a man who could not rhyme, and had mended it with his hands.

It is a good ring, thought Inês, who read everything twice. *I shall read it for a lifetime.*

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0844 and Entry 0908. A loaf and a bunch of violets, a step and a street. It is the gentlest of the comedies, and I have saved it for the last of the autumn because it is the one that shows how little a person needs: one gift, left at a door, and the courage not to knock.
Entry 0471 and Entry 0609. A watch that chimes, and a girl who cannot hear it. I have not the heart to tell you what comes after. I will only say that I have read the whole of the Register, and a good clockmaker is a better friend than a good doctor, since he will wait.
Entry 0753 and Entry 0053. They are engaged. It is very sweet. It is copper wire and a receipt. Let them have it. Let them have every hour of it.
The winter will ask for payment.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 12.

✦ ✦ ✦

ACT II — THE HOUSES AT WAR

The Chorus

When frost has closed the harbours of the heart, Old quarrels wake, like wolves behind a wall; And house on house, with envy set apart, Will stake the young upon the pride of all. Two ferries cross one strait with hostile prow; Two shops divide one street with hostile eyes; Yet love, that knows no feud, nor flag, nor vow, Slips through the fence beneath the winter skies. Some shall be saved by what their fathers spurned; Some shall be lost to what their fathers swore; And some shall wait where all their letters burned, And hear the tide knock softly at the door. Then mark the cold; it tests what will not fail, And what is true outlives the winter’s gale.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 13: Two Ferries

“I write poems to the boy on the other ferry.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0732

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE I

Istanbul, Türkiye. The Üsküdar pier, on the Asian shore. Early December, a quarter to seven. A fog has settled on the Bosphorus like a sheet on a sleeping giant, and out of it, one after another, come the ferries.

There is a city that stands with one foot in Europe and the other in Asia, and washes both in the same water, and the water has never decided which of them to belong to.

It is called the Bosphorus, and it is a river only in the way that a lion is a cat. It runs for thirty kilometres between the Black Sea and the Marmara, under the old stone fortresses and the red roofs of the wooden houses, and every morning, in the grey before the call to prayer has finished echoing from the minarets, it is crossed by a thousand ferries carrying a million people to their jobs. Gulls follow them in screaming flocks. Tea-sellers move down the aisles with tulip glasses on brass trays. A boy

of fourteen with a flat basket on his head sings out the price of *simit,* the sesame bread-rings of the city: "*Simit, sıcak simit!*"

Two of those ferries, on this particular morning, were red and blue.

The red was the *Hızır,* of the Yılmaz Line, which had run between Üsküdar and Karaköy since 1956, with a tall black funnel and a crew who would have drowned for the captain and for each other, in that order. The blue was the *Nilüfer,* of the Kaya Line, with a white-and-blue band round her funnel like a bandage, and the same crossing, the same hour, the same passengers, and the same quiet and ancient hatred.

For thirty years the two houses had sailed the same water. For twenty-two of them they had not spoken.

It had begun, like most great quarrels, in a very small place. A fog. A grounding on a sandbar in the winter of 1996. A ferry damaged, a passenger hurt, two partners who had each been at the wheel of a different boat and each remembered, quite sincerely, that the other was at fault. Captain Süleyman Yılmaz had stood on a pier in front of three hundred people and sworn, with his hand on his heart, *by my mother's grave, I will see the Kaya flag go under.* Recep Kaya, who was not a man to be outdone in an oath, had sworn the same, and the two had gone their ways, and built their separate fleets, and the Bosphorus had been in a state of cold war ever since.

And now, in the Council hall in Fatih, a ten-year licence for the crossing was up for award, and both families had bid.

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At the window of the Kaya Line ticket office, on the pier, twenty paces from the Yılmaz window, a young woman has lifted the blind.

Elif Kaya was twenty-six, a ticket clerk, small and quick and dark-eyed, with her hair pinned up under a navy cap and a pencil behind her ear, and she was, in the unanimous opinion of the pier, the fastest hand with a ticket machine on the Bosphorus. She was also, in the unanimous ignorance of the pier, a poet.

She wrote on the backs of old tickets, on the margins of the timetable, on the paper bag of her morning *simit,* in the old manner, in rhymed couplets with a repeated refrain, which her grandmother had taught her; and since the age of fifteen she had kept them in a biscuit tin under her bed.

For six months she had been writing them to somebody.

He stood, every morning, on the bow of the *Hızır* when she came alongside: a tall young man in a navy jersey, with a coil of rope on his shoulder and a face she could have drawn with her eyes closed. He was the captain’s son. His name was Ahmed Yılmaz. He was twenty-eight, broad of shoulder and quick of temper and kind to a degree that infuriated the people around him, and he stood, every morning, with his back to the dock, looking at the water, and whistling.

It was an old tune. It belonged to the shepherds of the Black Sea coast, and had no words, and rose and fell like a boat on a swell. He whistled it very softly, every day, as

the *Nilüfer* came alongside; and every day, in the ticket office, with her hand on the machine, Elif Kaya pretended she could not hear it.

Reader, I will tell you what was in the paper bag.

It was, that morning, a poem. She folded it small. She put it inside a *simit* wrapper, and she held it up to the little window, and a boy of fourteen with a flat basket on his head, who stood among the hawkers on the pier with an expression of bookish and entirely unwarranted innocence, took it from her hand without a word.

"For the tall one on the red boat," said Elif.

"I know."

"You are not to read it."

"I have read it," said Burak Aydın. "I read all of them. I need to know what I am carrying. It is a matter of professional ethics."

"You are fourteen."

"It is the age of *discretion,*" said Burak. "And you owe me four books."

He walked away across the pier with his basket, calling "*Simit, sıcak simit!*" and, in a lull between calls, lifting the paper to his nose with a look of profound and satisfied connoisseurship.

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**O wind, who crossest water east and west, Tell him: the other ferry carries me. The boat is blue, the boy is on the red; Tell him: the other ferry carries me.*

The fog has swallowed both our lamps, and yet I know the tune he whistles in the mist. I fold my silence small, and send it out: Tell him: the other ferry carries me.

*The fathers wage a war across the strait. The daughters read the tide and say no word. If drowning is the price of knowing him, Tell him: the other ferry carries me.**

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SCENE II

The ferry café at the Eminönü landing. The cook's kitchen is a counter, two gas rings, and an enormous brass samovar. A crowd of sailors, porters, and clerks. It is the only ground on the Bosphorus on which, by an ancient custom, no quarrel may be fought.

Sema was fifty-one, wide, fierce, and floury, with her sleeves rolled to the shoulder and the strongest forearms in Eminönü. She had cooked at the landing for twenty-eight years, had fed three generations of both houses off the same chipped plates, and had made it a law that whoever brought a quarrel in at the door left it on a hook, along with the coat.

"Tea has no flag," she was fond of announcing, to the room at large.

"It is the *truth,*" said her husband Kerem. "I read it in a paper."

Kerem Arslan was forty-four, a grocer, thin and gloomy, with a moustache like a question mark, who believed everything he read, to the great sorrow of the

newspapers.

“What did it say?”

“That on the day of the Council vote, the sea will be lowered by three centimetres. It is something with the moon.”

“Kerem. You have never been to sea in your life.”

“I have seen it from the *bus,*” said Kerem, wounded.

Sema ladled out two plates of *menemen,* the creamy eggs and tomatoes of the Turkish breakfast, and slid them across the counter in opposite directions, toward two tables, one red and one blue, where two groups of men were drinking tea with their backs to one another, in the cold manner of ancient enemies. At the red table sat the crew of the *Hızır,* and at their head the old engineer, Kerem Aydın, seventy-three, retired in name and never in fact, who had kept the Yılmaz boats running for half a century and who had raised the captain’s son with a spanner in one hand and a string of prayer beads in the other. At the blue table sat the crew of the *Nilüfer,* and at their head a short, sunburnt man with a pair of headphones round his neck: Mehmet Şahin, sixty-three, radio-man of the Kaya Line, the uncle who had raised Elif after her father’s death, and who ran the fleet from a small glass room full of crackling dials, trusting, as a man must who spends his life listening, almost everything he was told.

“I will tell you the whole matter,” said Sema to her tea-glasses, in an under-voice that carried the width of the room. “They quarrel because they are the same. Both want the crossing. Both want the other to go under.

And neither can sail without the other, because a man with no one to be angry at will go quite *mad.* God made the sea a *single sea,* and the fools have given it names. It has *one.* The rest is labels."

Mark this, reader. She was talking about eggs. She was, as the wise often are when they think themselves at a stove, entirely correct.

At the red table, a voice rose.

"I will see it done by Christmas," said Captain Süleyman Yılmaz.

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He had come in at the door. He was fifty-eight, a tall, magnificent, scowling man with a white moustache, a captain's cap, and a voice trained over thirty years to carry across a gale. He stood in the doorway like a statue of the sea, and spoke to the room.

"The Council will award the crossing to the family that has run it longest. That is *us.* And I tell you, on the head of the Prophet, that I will see the Kaya flag lowered on that mast if I have to haul it down myself."

Across the room, at the blue table, a chair scraped.

"You will do *nothing* of the kind," said Mehmet Şahin. He had risen: a small man, but he stood now with his headphones round his neck like a noose, and a ferocity in his sunburnt face that a stranger would never have suspected in a man who listened for a living. "My brother-in-law Recep, God rest his soul, built that line

with his two hands. I will not see his name washed off a funnel by a man who cannot tell a sandbar from a mirror."

"*Gentlemen,*" said Sema.

She did not shout. She lifted a ladle, an enormous brass ladle, the kind that serves forty, and brought it down on the counter with a crack like a pistol. The two tables froze.

"My café," said Sema, "has a rule. Leave the quarrel on the hook with the coat. And *eat.* I have made two hundred plates of menemen this morning and I will not have them go cold for the sake of a sandbar."

There was a very long silence.

Then, to the astonishment of the pier, Captain Yılmaz sat; and Mehmet Şahin sat; and a hundred men began, gingerly, to eat.

"Better," said Sema, and went back to her pan. "Kerem. The sea has not gone down by three centimetres."

"It is not the day *yet,*" said Kerem.

At the red table the captain's son, who had said nothing throughout, sat with his fork motionless in the eggs and his gaze fixed on the café's open door, where for an instant a pair of dark eyes in a blue cap had appeared, and as quickly gone. The old engineer, Kerem Aydın, saw it, and said nothing either.

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SCENE III

Dusk. The pier. The last ferry of the day has gone. The water is the colour of a plum, and the minarets of the old city stand against it like a row of pens.

They did not speak. They had never spoken.

They stood on the two piers, the Yılmaz and the Kaya, twenty paces apart, in the failing light, with the water between them and a white gull sitting on the rail, and she was in her cap and he was in his jersey, and in the lap of the tide, with the passing of the last ferry, was a long, soft silence.

It had been six months, and one hundred and seventy-three poems carried across by a boy in a basket, with four books outstanding. It had been, in return, a whistle, to which she had never replied, because there is no reply to a whistle that does not contain a promise.

At last, that evening, the boy had come back with the paper bag, and on the inside of it, in a large, square, unaccustomed hand, a line.

It said: *I cannot write as you do. I can only say that I hear it. — A.*

She read it twice. Then she went down onto the pier in the failing light, in the blue cap, and stood at the very edge, where the stone met the water, and looked across.

He was there.

He stood at the end of the Yılmaz landing, twenty paces off, very large and very still, and she could not see his face. He lifted one hand. He did not wave. He only held it out, palm open, to the water.

She lifted hers.

Between them the Bosphorus slid by, black and silver and indifferent, with the lights of Europe coming on along the farther shore like a thousand small intentions. Behind her, in the glass room at the end of the pier, her uncle listened to the wrong stations. Behind Ahmed, up the hill, his father was cleaning a cap he meant to wear to the Council on the day the Kaya flag went down.

There are two oaths in this scene, reader, and neither is the one you think. One is the oath of the fathers. The other has not yet been sworn.

He began, very softly, to whistle.

She stood at the edge of the pier with her hand still lifted and the tune coming over the water in the dusk, thin and sweet and brave, like a thread drawn through a needle; and Elif Kaya, who had a poem for everything, who had a couplet for the sea and a refrain for the night, found that she had no words at all.

She put her hand to her mouth.

And from the pier behind her, from a flat basket, a boy's voice, low and pleased and a little aggrieved, said: "That is a *very* good poem, and you have not even written it yet."

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SCENE IV

Accra, Ghana. Osu, on Oxford Street. The same day. Accra keeps its clocks three hours behind Istanbul's, so the dusk comes here later, and the air is the gold of the

harmattan: that dry, dust-laden wind that comes down from the Sahara every December and turns the sunsets to copper.

On a certain street in Accra, beside the great, bright, honking river of the evening traffic, there stood two shops.

One was a pharmacy, in whose window a very bright green cross shone through the dust; the other was a taxi depot, with a hand-lettered sign over the door, reading *MENSAH CABS — YOU CALL, WE ARRIVE (EVENTUALLY).* Between them there lay twelve metres of pavement, a gutter, and, in the hearts of the people on either side, an ocean.

On the night of the ninth of December the pharmacy was dressed in garlands, and a banner hung across its door.

OWUSU PHARMACY — GREATER ACCRA PHARMACY OF THE YEAR.

"*Ei!* The woman has done it," said an old driver, leaning on the bonnet of a yellow cab across the road with a bottle of malt in his hand. "She has won the prize. Who is surprised? *Quaye* is not surprised."

Quaye was seventy, the oldest driver in the fleet, a small, bandy-legged man in a flat cap and a faded football shirt, with a gold tooth and a commentary on everything. He kept court on the bonnet of his taxi each evening like a parliament of one, and announced the weather, the football scores, and the secret feelings of his employer in the same breath. Around him the drivers had formed a half-circle, a Greek chorus at leisure.

“She worked for it,” said one.

“She has the best-kept shop in Osu,” said Quaye. “She has the honestest scales. She has a *brain.* And she has a debt that someone paid.”

There was a silence.

“Who paid it?” said a young driver, who was new.

“Someone who lives twelve metres to the east and is *very* bad at hiding,” said Quaye. “If a man does a kindness, and then goes and sits at the back of every ceremony with a face like a church door, in my profession we call him a man with a problem. It is called *pride.* It is the worst passenger there is.”

Behind him, across twelve metres of dusty pavement, in the lit doorway of the Owusu Pharmacy, a young woman in a kente stole was standing with her award in her hands.

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Abena Owusu was twenty-eight, a pharmacist, with a sharp tongue and a straight back and a grave, watchful face, and she was holding a glass trophy in the shape of a mortar and pestle as though it were a very hot dish. Beside her stood her friend Adwoa Tetteh, forty-four, the kiosk-owner from the next street, a tall, restless woman who never forgot an insult and had been listing them, at length, to the guests.

“You must say a word,” said Adwoa. “The Minister is coming.”

“I do not make speeches.”

“You make *prescriptions.* It is the same. You tell people what they need and they do not like it.”

Abena laughed in spite of herself. Then, as the guests began to gather on the pavement in the dust-gold light, and a choir of twenty began to sing in the lively, rolling, many-voiced harmonies of the Ghanaian Methodist hymn, led by Nii Tetteh, forty-three, choir-master, who told lies for amusement and never in church, she turned to look across the road.

He was there.

He was standing, as he always stood, at the back, by the door of his own depot, a tall, broad, quiet man of thirty-one in a plain white shirt, with his hands behind him and a face that had been carved from a very hard wood and then left out in the rain. Kwame Mensah. Taxi-fleet owner. He would lend money to a stranger at a lamp-post and then lecture him on his reasons, and could not, to save his life, pay a woman a compliment.

He caught her eye.

He nodded, once, formally, as a man nods to a landlord.

She nodded back.

And then, because the Minister was late, and the choir had run out of verses, and the whole street had gone quiet, and a hundred people were looking at her, Abena Owusu stepped forward to the pavement, with the trophy in her hand, and the gold dust in the air, and said, in a clear, low, startling voice:

“Thank you. I will be brief, since the Minister is not here.

“Everything good in this shop was given to me. The floors by my mother. The scales by my father, who is not here to see them. The stock by a bank that has been very patient. And the rest—” She paused. “The rest I owe to a neighbour.”

A ripple went through the crowd. On the bonnet of the taxi, Quaye took off his cap.

“There is a debt,” said Abena, in the stillness, “that was once mine. It was paid. I was told it was *forgiven.* And I accepted it, because it was kind.” She looked across the road, and her voice did not shake, but it did slow. “But I am a pharmacist. In my profession we do not give a person medicine without telling them what it is. It is a matter of respect.

“So I will say this, and then I will sit. I know. I have known for some time. I am not angry. I am only waiting. I have always been very good at waiting. It is the only skill my profession allows.”

There was a silence.

Then the choir, which had no idea what had just occurred, struck up a very loud and cheerful hymn, and the whole street began to clap; and Abena Owusu went in, with her glass mortar, and set it on a shelf between the aspirin and the ointments, and put her hand over her face.

At the back of the depot, Kwame Mensah did not move.

“Boss,” said Quaye, quietly, from his bonnet, “I have been your driver for nineteen years, and I have never asked you for anything but the day off for funerals. I am asking now. Go and say *something.* A man does not have to say the whole of a thing. He only has to say the first word. The road is very long, but it starts at the gate.”

Kwame looked across twelve metres of dusty street, at a lit doorway where a woman in kente had set down her prize and was straightening a row of tablets that did not need straightening.

He took one step.

He stopped.

“It is a very long road,” said Kwame Mensah, in a low, hard, hopeless voice, “and I have never been good at the gate.”

“Then it is a good thing,” said Quaye, “that tomorrow is also a day.”

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Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0211 and Entry 0732, two ferries, one strait. Entry 0625 and Entry 0941, two shops, one street. In the first, an oath was sworn by fathers, and the children will have to find which of them is bound by it. In the second, a debt was paid, and the debtor has had the sense to know it, and the payer has not yet the sense to be known.
I have always said that the Register is a book about distances, and that the most dangerous distance is not an ocean. It is twenty paces of pier. It is twelve

metres of pavement. A man can cross an ocean in nine hours. A pier may take him all his life.

I notice that Sema is right. It is a single sea.

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End of Chapter 13.

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Chapter 14: The Heiress and the Guide

“I am the heir of a haveli with no roof.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0626

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Enter the Chorus, with a pocket watch in each hand and a third in his hat.

At midnight, Dhaka; Jaipur, half an hour Behind;
and Bergen, five hours back, and yet At dusk and
dinner; and, a step ahead, Yogyakarta, one o’clock,
and set To sleep, and not asleep. Observe, good
friends: The world keeps seven clocks and one true
hour, And lovers are the only horologists Who read
them all at once. Attend. The tower Of Babel was a
scheme to stop the clocks; We merely ask you not to
break the locks.

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SCENE I

Jaipur. The boardroom of Sharma Textile House, above a lane of block-printers’ shops. A long table, nine uncles, one tea tray, and a young woman holding a roll of cloth as though it were a sleeping child.

There are two ways to be an heiress. The first is to inherit. The second is to be *told* you will inherit, at every wedding, by every aunt, until the word becomes a coat sewn so exactly to your shoulders that you cannot lift your arms. Priya Sharma, twenty-seven, had worn the second kind since she was nine.

"Beta," said her father, Mahendra Sharma, who sat at the head of the table with the patience of a man who had lost an argument to his daughter in 1998 and had been preparing his revenge since. "We are a house that *sells* cloth. We have sold cloth to three maharajas and one Hollywood film. We do not make poems."

"It is not a poem, Papa. It is a collection."

"A collection of what?"

"Of roofs," said Priya.

Nine uncles looked at nine cups of tea.

She unrolled the cloth. It ran down the length of the table like a river that had been told a secret: dabu, the old mud-resist print of Bagru, dipped and dipped again in indigo until the blue went down into black, and across that black, in gaps where the clay had held back the dye, there were small shapes the colour of milk. They were not flowers, as every uncle in the room expected. They were the little arched windows of old Jaipur, and above each window, where a roof should have been, the cloth was left open: bare, pale, without a lid.

"Sky," said Priya, and her voice shook only once. "I want to print the houses of this city as they are when the roof has gone and the sky has moved in. People do not

want another peacock, Papa. They want to be told that a thing may fall and still be beautiful."

"Who told you this?"

"A man with no roof."

At that precise moment, with a sense of timing that no stage-manager could have invented and no stage-manager would have dared, the door of the boardroom was thrown open, and into it swept a figure in a saffron safa, a waistcoat embroidered with peacocks (which Priya's uncles regarded as a personal insult), and a moustache oiled, curled, and, one suspected, individually named.

"*Namaste, esteemed gentlemen!*" cried Vikram Rathore, thirty, heritage guide, and the sole surviving heir of a house in the Chandpole bazaar whose roof had been carried off by the monsoon of 1998 and never replaced. "I am *late*. This is a deliberate strategy. A man who is early is a clerk; a man who is late is an *arrival*."

"Who," said Mahendra Sharma, "is this?"

"My consultant," said Priya, with great firmness and no authority whatever.

"Her *humble witness*," said Vikram, bowing so low that his moustache brushed the tea tray.

He had met her five weeks before. She had come to the old city with a camera and a ruinous idea: that somewhere behind some stone gate where the paint had given up, the printing-houses of her great-grandmother's time still kept their wooden blocks, forgotten, unsold. The guild had sent a man in a peacock

waistcoat who announced, in the first minute, that a Dutch tourist had once mistaken him for a maharaja and that he had not corrected her.

He had led her, in the end, to his own front door: a tall carved door in a lane that smelled of marigold and diesel, and behind it a courtyard with a neem tree, a broken swing, a staircase that ascended to nothing, and, in a shaft of light that fell straight down through the place where the roof had been, three hundred blocks of seasoned teak, stacked like the pages of a closed book.

"My great-grandfather's," Vikram had said, and for the first time in her hearing he did not perform. "The family printed for the court. Then the court was gone, and the printing was gone, and then the roof. I give tours on Thursdays. I call it *The House That Chose the Sky.* Tourists weep." He had shrugged, a small shrug with no peacock in it. "Mostly the Dutch."

She had stood in the column of daylight, with dust turning in it like slow gold, and thought: *There is the whole collection. A thing that lost its lid and let in the stars.*

It is a dangerous thing, reader, to be shown a ruin by a vain man who is, for one minute, not vain. Engagements are made of less.

Back in the boardroom, the humble witness cleared his throat.

"Gentlemen," said Vikram, in the voice of a man who had once read the Ramayana at a wedding and been asked to stop. "A house without a roof is still a house, if the sky consents to be its ceiling. Your daughter—" a

dreadful pause "—your daughter has seen what nine gentlemen with nine calculators have not. People do not buy cloth. They buy the *reason* the cloth was made. Give her fifty pieces. If they do not sell, I will personally eat my safa."

"I would do it *slowly,*" he added, "with chutney, and in public."

It was the first time the Sharma boardroom had laughed since the Gulf War. In the corridor, a writer named Pooja Tiwari, twenty-seven, who had come for the gossip and stayed for the odds, passed a folded note to the clerk who kept the tea ledger: *Ten rupees says Papa Sharma says yes. Twenty says the guide proposes by Diwali.*

Papa Sharma said: "Fifty pieces. Not fifty-one."

And Priya Sharma, who had held her breath since the age of nine, let it out quietly, in the boardroom, in front of nine uncles, in the shape of her name.

She did not look at Vikram. This is how you may know she was looking at nothing else.

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SCENE II

Bergen. The sea off Askøy, 3:40 on a Tuesday afternoon, which in a Norwegian December is the evening. A wooden boat, a gale, and a woman with a clipboard.

If Jaipur's trouble was a roof that had gone, Bergen's was a hull that was going.

The boat was the *Ragnhild,* eleven metres of tarred oak and old paint, and Lars Eriksen, who was thirty and as talkative as a granite step, called her *her* when she behaved and *it* when she did not. She was held together, as the old men of the Fisketorget liked to say, by habit and the Lord's low opinion of insurance.

The woman with the clipboard was Sigrid Haugen, twenty-nine, marine biologist, who chartered the *Ragnhild* every Tuesday for a cod-tagging study, because her owner would take her to the deep water without asking why. She had not stopped moving since she came aboard. She tapped. She measured. She sighed at the water temperature, at the plankton count, and, with some warmth, at a cormorant.

"The fresh water is coming off the mountain too fast," said Sigrid. "It means the whole top layer is—Lars, are you listening?"

"Mm."

"You say *mm* as though it were a complete sentence."

"It is," said Lars, "in Norwegian."

"It is not a language. It is a *noise.*"

"It carries more than most." He did not look up from the engine hatch, where a spanner and a very small prayer were doing their best. "Sigrid. How long does the sample take?"

"Another forty minutes."

"We do not have forty minutes."

He did not say it loudly. Lars Eriksen did not say anything loudly; he said things the way a fjord says them, by being already full. But she heard the thing under it, and she looked up at last, past the clipboard, and saw what he had been watching for an hour with a stoic's dreadful patience: the western sky going the colour of a bruise, and a line of white, low and quick, coming toward them over the sound.

"Oh," said Sigrid.

"Yes."

"How long?"

"Ten minutes. Perhaps eight."

The first wave struck her quarter like a hand slapping a table. Below the deck came not a crash but a long, wet *sigh,* as of an elderly person sitting down. Lars was in the hold before the spray had settled. He came up the colour of porridge.

"A plank's sprung. By the keel."

"How bad?"

"Bad enough that I am going to teach you to steer."

"I have never steered!"

"Then it will be your first. Both hands, there. Bow to the lighthouse. Do not look at the water; it will only upset you." He pulled the bilge handle, which squealed like a pig at a christening, and when that failed he took up a bucket, because in the end every seaman is a man with a bucket and a great deal of faith. "If the engine dies—"

"What happens if the engine dies?"

“We will have a very interesting conversation,” said Lars, “while I bail.”

✦ ✦ ✦

They did not die. But for forty minutes it was neither comedy nor anything else: cold water, wet wool, the red lamp at Marstein, and a bucket going out and coming in, in the hands of a man who did not once ask for help and a woman who did not once let go of the wheel.

At the end of it, at ten minutes to five, in the black, with the harbour lights of Vågen swimming up out of the rain, the engine coughed, and the old boat limped into the fish market quay and sat down in the water like a horse that has finished its last race.

Lars cut the motor. In the silence the water ran out of the scuppers and clacked against the stones.

“I should not have taken you out,” he said.

“I hired you.”

“You hired a boat. I knew what the boat was.”

“I—” Sigrid let go of the wheel and found that her hands would not at first unclench. “I came out today because I thought that if I counted every plankton in this fjord, I would not have to think about what happens when I have counted them all. And you let me. You said *mm*.”

“It was the right thing to say.”

“It was not *anything*.”

“Sometimes,” said Lars Eriksen, to the harbour, to the rain, to the lamp at Marstein, to the whole unlit shore of everything he could not say, “it is the only thing the boat will carry.”

There was a movement on the quay. It was a woman in a yellow slicker, with a stall of umbrellas lashed in tarpaulin under a lamp, who had been selling them to the ferry queue since morning to, so far, one customer.

“Ha!” said Solveig Dahl, thirty-six, formerly of Ålesund and lately, by her own account, a refugee from a city where it sometimes stopped raining. “You are wet! The sea has done my selling for me. Four hundred kroner.”

“For an umbrella?”

“For the *idea.* One does not buy shelter. One buys the pretence of it.” She regarded Lars, and the bucket, and the boat’s sorry waterline. “The boat will sink next week,” she said, quite kindly, “and you will both pretend not to mind. I do not charge for the truth. Only for the umbrellas.”

Neither of them bought one (Sigrid owned a plum-coloured one already). She walked to the end of the quay and was sick, over the rail, with great discretion; and when she turned back, Lars stood with his bucket, looking at the boat as at a friend who has been faithful a very long time and does not deserve to be put down.

I am afraid, thought Sigrid, *that I will not come back.*

I am afraid, thought Lars, *that I will never ask her to.*

They stood twelve feet apart in the rain, each with a whole unwritten letter in the mouth, and neither of them mended the silence with a single word.

Mark this, reader. A silence is not nothing. It is a boat that has not yet gone under.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

Mirpur, Dhaka. A tea stall at eleven at night. Then a third-floor flat, a laptop, and the first of many nights.

“Bhaiya,” said Bunny, “you are checking your phone.”

“I am not.”

“You are *glaring* at it, which is checking with a bad character.” The boy slid the glass across the counter. He was thirteen, thin as a ruler, and ran the corner stall with an air of having done so since the Mughals. “Who has not answered?”

“It is a client.”

“At eleven at night. On a *Friday*. The client has a first name, Bhaiya, and it has a *flower* in it.” (Bunny saw everything, forgave nothing, and billed for neither.)

Fayaz Rahman, twenty-six, whose company had died in the spring and whose debts had not, put the phone face down on the counter, like a card he did not wish to explain.

“She is a designer,” he said. “From Yogyakarta. We have exchanged, I think, nine messages. Her website does not load properly. I am helping.”

“Nine messages.”

“In five weeks.”

“And how long does she take to answer?”

“Never more than an hour.”

“And you?”

“Four minutes.”

Bunny closed his eyes in physical pain. “Bhaiya. A man who answers in four minutes is a man who is *waiting.* Rule one: you wait four minutes *before* you answer. Not three: that is eager. Not five: that is cruel. Four. It is a medical fact.”

“You have invented that.”

“I have *observed* it.” He wiped the counter with a rag the colour of old weather. “And you have a face like a closed shop. Open it a little. Otherwise she will think there is nobody home.”

Fayaz paid for the tea, and for two biscuits he did not want, and climbed the three flights to the flat, where his mother’s breathing came faintly through the wall, in and out, like a thread drawn over a small rough stone; and where, on the balcony in the dark, his father sat on a plastic chair with a green ledger on his knee and a pencil he did not use.

“Abbu,” said Fayaz softly. “You should sleep.”

“I am counting.”

“It is the same number as yesterday.”

“Yes,” said his father. “I wished to be sure.” Then, after a moment, in a voice so careful that it nearly was not a voice: “Fourteen lakh is not so much. Is it? Other people owe more.”

“It is not so much, Abbu.”

“No.” The pencil moved a little in the old man’s hand, and made no mark. “Go on. You have a client.”

✦ ✦ ✦

At 12:07 by the clock above his desk (the clock was seven minutes slow; he had never fixed it, because to fix it would have meant admitting he was always going to be somewhere between two times) Fayaz opened the chat window.

There was one new line.

Ermis: *Are you awake? Stupid question. I can see the green dot. I am sorry. I am panicking in a very small and well-organised way.*

He waited four minutes. He had never in his life waited four minutes so badly.

Fayaz: *I am awake. What is wrong with the website?*

Ermis: *The portfolio will not upload. It says “file too large.” I have made it smaller three times. I think it is a personal attack.*

Fayaz: *Send me the folder name. Do not tell me what it is for.*

Ermis: *Why not?*

Fayaz: *Because you have not told me, and I would like to deserve being told.*

There was a pause, long enough for a dog to bark twice in the lane and for the power to flicker and, mercifully, hold.

Ermis: *That is the most irritating nice thing anyone has said to me this year.*

Ermis: *It is an application. That is all I can say. It is due at 2 a.m. my time.*

Fayaz: *It is 12:14 a.m. mine. You are an hour ahead of me.*

Ermis: *I know. I have been aware of it for five weeks. I am always ahead of everyone and they always say "slow down."*

Fayaz: *I have never once said "slow down."*

Ermis: *No. You have said "the file is in the wrong format." Which is the same thing, but more helpful.*

It took him eleven minutes. The problem was a single photograph of an indigo vat at dawn, saved as a file the size of a small country, hidden among thirty others like a bear in a sheep-pen. He compressed it, and wrote a four-line script to resize the rest; and through a voice note she had left running by mistake he heard the sounds of a night he could not see: a stove, a tap, a pencil, and a distant, bad-tempered voice shrieking *"TOO LATE!"*

Ermis: *That is Ayu. My grandmother's parrot. She has three sentences and has never used them correctly.*

Fayaz: *She seems well informed.*

Ermis: *She is a lunatic and I love her.*

He looked at that for a little. He did not remark upon it. A man with fourteen lakh taka to find does not remark upon the word *love,* even where it is attached to a parrot.

Ermis: *Uploaded. Oh, it works. It says "received." Fayaz, it says RECEIVED. I feel like I jumped off a very high thing and was told, after, that there was a net.*

Fayaz: *There is always a net. It is simply very far down, with a clock that is seven minutes slow.*

Ermis: *How do you know about the clock? Oh. You told me in your second message. I keep your messages the way other people keep receipts.*

He laughed aloud, alone, in the dark, for the first time that week. Through the wall his mother stirred and settled.

Fayaz: *What time is it there?*

Ermis: *1:23 a.m. I am sitting on the floor of my workshop with my feet in a tray of cold water, because I am a fool. Everything is blue. What time is it there?*

Fayaz: *Sixteen minutes past twelve by my clock, which is seven minutes slow. So really 12:23.*

Ermis: *So you are an hour behind me.*

Fayaz: *I prefer "in your past."*

Ermis: *No. Not the past. The past is finished. You are not finished. You are only a little way down the road.*

Fayaz: *Then what are you?*

There were three dots. They pulsed and sank. They pulsed again. In a workshop that smelled of hot wax, a girl with a pencil in her hair looked at the ceiling beams, at the cold blue water, at a green bird that had gone, for once, to sleep; and then she typed the line she would one day repeat in a different voice, to a screen going dark.

Ermis: *I am in your future.*

Ermis: *Ask me anything about tomorrow. I have seen it. It is only an hour away.*

Fayaz sat quite still.

Fayaz: *Will the electricity come back?*

Ermis: *I can only tell you that in the future, everyone has had dinner.*

Fayaz: *That is not an answer.*

Ermis: *It is the most important answer I know.*

Fayaz: *Will it be a good tomorrow?*

Ermis: *It is only an hour old, Fayaz. I cannot say yet. Ask me again in an hour.*

He did. He asked her an hour later, at 1:16 by his slow clock, which was truly 1:23 and therefore 2:23 in Yogyakarta, while an early rooster, mistaking the hour, went up from some courtyard in the sleeping city.

Fayaz: *It is an hour later. What does tomorrow look like?*

Ermis: *Grey, a little. A very early rooster. A man who is up too late being kind to a stranger with a website.*

Fayaz: *That sounds like a good tomorrow.*

Ermis: *It is a good start. I will tell you if it holds.*

Fayaz: *You will have to. You are the only one who has seen it.*

Ermis: *Yes, she wrote; and then, after a pause so small only the machine measured it: I am quite happy to be, for now.*

Ermis: *Good night. Or good morning. Whichever of us is right.*

She went offline, and the little green dot beside her name went grey. It was past two in the morning in her city and past one in his, and the neighbourhood roosters were beginning to quarrel. Fayaz Rahman closed the laptop, and sat, at the beginning of a day that was already a day old somewhere else, and discovered with some alarm that he was smiling at a wall. On the other side of it, his mother breathed, in and out, steady as a thread.

An hour, he thought. *She is an hour ahead. Then whatever comes, she will see it first.*

It did not occur to him, until he was nearly asleep, that this might be a comfort.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., against Entries 0626, 0443 and 0713 (and, in a smaller hand, 0561):

> *Three clocks, three silences, and one bucket. A man who showed a stranger his own ruin, and a woman who unrolled hers on a table; a man who said mm to the sea; a man asked, in the dark, to name tomorrow. The first two began by the hour. The third began by the minute, and waited four.*
>
> *Nothing in the Register hurries. It is the clocks that do.*

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End of Chapter 14.

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Chapter 15: Fiddle and Fever

“There is a song I cannot finish, and it is about you.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0025

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE I

Galway. A flat above a closed bakery, on a Thursday in December, with the Atlantic doing what it does to windows. A suitcase, open on a bed. A woman who has been packing for nine days and has not yet put in a single thing she means to take.

Aoife Brennan, thirty, veterinary surgeon, was a woman of great directness, and she had never been less direct in her life.

“Socks,” she said to the room. “Two weeks of socks. Why do I own so many socks, when I have only two feet?”

The room, which was small, damp, and loyal, made no reply. On the dresser stood a framed certificate, a jar of coins from the pockets of farmers who paid in kind, and a hoof-pick shaped like a small silver oar. On the bed lay a letter of acceptance from a large-animal practice outside Antigonish, in Nova Scotia, a county that, as she had discovered on the internet at four in the morning,

held a Highland games, kept a great many horses, and was short of a vet who would shout. On the pillow lay a ticket: *Shannon to Toronto. Toronto to Halifax. Sunday, 6:40 a.m.*

She had told no one. Not the clinic, where her resignation lay in her bag, signed and sealed and heavy as a stone. Not her mother, who would say *Canada!* in the voice used for *cancer*. Not Niamh, her oldest friend, who sold fish on the Long Walk and could not say goodbye to a bus.

And not, God help her, the fiddler.

She sat down on the bed, among the socks, and, since there was nobody in the room to be direct to, she was direct to the dark:

> *I have been brave with bulls. I have put my arm Into the throat of weather, to the shoulder, And turned a calf that did not wish to come. I have said "Hold him" to a hundred men Who held, because I said so. I am not A woman who has ever been afraid Of anything with hooves, or fangs, or horns. And yet there is a man on Dominick Street With a bad fiddle and a worse coat, who has Not asked me anything in six years' time Except to stay for the last tune, and I Have never stayed. I leave before the reel. I tell myself it is the early rounds. It is not early rounds. It is that if I stayed To hear the last tune, I would hear its end; And if I heard its end, I would not go.*

She laughed, once, at herself. Then she laid her hands flat on her knees, like a woman who has delivered a verdict, and took out of the suitcase a pair of socks and re-

placed them in the drawer, and took out of the drawer a different pair and put them in the suitcase, which is the sort of thing a person does when she is leaving and wishes not to be.

On the pillow, beside the ticket, lay her phone, and on the phone, where she had left it open for three days, lay a page of the Register of Black Stars.

ENTRY 0025 — Galway, Ireland. "There is a song I cannot finish, and it is about you."

She knew the hand. She did not need the name. Nobody else in the west of Ireland would have written a thing in which the second clause was a promise and the first was a lie.

The doorbell rang like a fire alarm.

"*AOIFE!*" cried a voice from the street. "I have a *hake!*"

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Niamh Quinn, forty-one, fishmonger, stood on the step in a coat the colour of a wet gull with a hake under one arm and a bottle of something under the other. She had the face of a woman who spends her life in the cold being gentle to dead things, and who had never in her whole career managed to hide a feeling.

"It's Thursday," she said. "I know what Thursday is. Thursday is session, and you've a face on you like the last cow at the mart, and I thought: I'll bring her a fish."

"I do not need a fish."

“Nobody needs a fish. That’s the *beauty* of the fish.” She pushed past into the hall with the confidence of the long-acquainted. “I’ll put him in the sink. Don’t look at his eyes, they follow you. What’s that you’re hiding?”

“I’m not hiding anything.”

“You’re standing in front of the bedroom door with your arms out, like an unconvincing Christ.”

“It’s a… it’s a *draught excluder.*”

“Aoife.”

“It’s *laundry,* Niamh.”

And at that moment, with the timing of a thing that has been waiting nine days, the suitcase on the bed, which had been shut with a hasty hand and a prayer, burst its clasps and sent forth upon the carpet a shower of socks, a hoof-pick, a rolled-up map of Nova Scotia, and a small framed photograph of the sea at Blackrock, which Aoife had not known she had packed.

There was a silence in which a hake, in the sink, seemed to take an interest.

Niamh looked at the map. She looked at the socks. She looked at her oldest friend, who stood in the doorway holding the doorframe with both hands as though the building had begun to move.

“Ah, *Aoife,*” said Niamh.

“It’s not what it looks like.”

“It’s a map of *Canada.*”

“It’s a map of Nova Scotia, which is *part* of—” Aoife stopped. She had not cried in front of another person since the funeral of a Labrador in 2009. She did not cry now. She merely sat down rather quickly upon the edge of the bed. “I’ve not told anyone. I was going to tell you. I was going to tell you on Saturday.”

“Saturday?”

“Sunday’s the flight.”

“*Sunday.*” Niamh sat beside her, still holding the bottle. It did not seem to be a bottle in which either of them had any further interest. After a time she said, in the small flat voice of a person who has never learned to say what the next sentence is for: “I’m no good at this.”

“I know.”

“I’ll cry in the airport.”

“You’ll not come to the airport.”

“I’ll cry in the *car park.*” She wiped her face with the sleeve of the wet-gull coat, which smelled of ice and mackerel. “Does he know?”

“Who?”

“Don’t be thick.”

“He doesn’t.”

“He’s going to finish it tonight, you know. The song. He told me on Monday over the haddock. He said, ‘Niamh, I’ve a fever, and I’ve a last verse, and I think God has decided the two should be sung together.’ And I said to him, ‘Liam, that is a *flu.*’”

“It’s a flu?”

“He’s thirty-nine degrees. He took it himself with a thermometer from the chemist, and then he asked the chemist if it was *romantic.*” She turned her wet and honest face on her friend. “Come tonight. You never stay for the last tune. Come, and stay.”

“I’ll come,” said Aoife slowly. “I’ll stay for the last one. And then—”

“And then?”

“And then I’ll see,” said Aoife Brennan, who had never in her life said such a thing, and meant it, as she had meant everything: with her whole hand.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

Mulroy’s of Dominick Street. A long low room, a turf fire, a ceiling of black beams, and a Thursday-night session already three tunes deep. Rain on the windows. Steam on the rain.

Mulroy’s pub held, on a good night, sixty souls; on a Thursday in December, with the Christmas market packed into Eyre Square and half of the west of Ireland looking for a roof, it held eighty-four and a dog.

By the fire, on a stool that had been shaped over decades to the exact curve of his grievance, sat Fergal Walsh, forty-five, who sold roast chestnuts from a cart on Shop Street by day and by night, for the love of God and a free pint, told stories, which he called *the real news*.

He had coveted the Thursday slot for eleven years. He had fourteen stories, each with at least six endings, and a nose that had been broken in one of them.

"Ladies and gentlemen," said Fergal, rising, and the room, which had learned over many winters that it was easier to let him than to argue, turned its eighty-four faces toward the fire. "A story. An old one. I had it from my grandmother, who had it from a man in Inis Meáin, who had it from the sea, which is *notoriously* unreliable."

"Is it the one with the donkey?" someone called.

"It is not the one with the donkey. The donkey is *separate.* This is the story of the two fiddlers."

"Here we go," said a voice.

"In the old time," said Fergal, "there were two fiddlers on the Aran Islands who played a tune between them that had no end. The first would play a phrase and the second would answer, and the first would answer the answer, and on they went, for forty years, through weddings and wakes and one very bad christening. And everyone said: *Isn't it marvellous, the tune that has no end.* And it was. Until the day a stranger came off the boat, a man with a clever face and a leather case, and he said: *That's a grand tune. But where does it finish?*"

He paused, with an expert's cruelty, and sipped his pint.

"And the first fiddler, who was a decent man, said: *It doesn't. That's the point of it.* And the stranger said: *Ah, but the best tunes have a last note, and until you play it, you've never really said anything.* And the second fiddler

—who was a woman, and sharper than the pair of them —looked at the first and said: *He's right.* And the first said: *But if we play the last note, we'll have to stop.* And she said: *Yes.* And do you know what he said?"

"What?" said eighty-four voices.

"He said," said Fergal, "*I'll tell you tomorrow.* And he never did, because the next day she took the boat. And that—" he spread his hands "—is why, to this very hour, there's a tune on Inis Meáin that has no ending, and a boat that never comes back, and a man who has nothing but his own two hands, and that, ladies and gentlemen, is why you should never, *ever,* buy a chestnut from a man who's had a drink."

There was a roar. It is the peculiarity of a fool, reader, that he says the wise thing by accident and the foolish thing on purpose, and so is never forgiven for the first.

But in the corner, near the door, where she had come in out of the rain with her coat on and her hair dripping and a hake's worth of resolve in her chest, Aoife Brennan did not laugh. She had been listening for a long time, and she stood against the wall with the very particular stillness of a woman who has heard a story that was not about her, and found her own name in it.

✦ ✦ ✦

On the low stage, which was a platform of three planks and a tablecloth, a thin man in a worse coat than any she had imagined was tuning a fiddle that he had played since the age of eight and mended, by his own account, with nine different sorts of glue.

Liam O’Connor, thirty-two, pub musician, was ill.

It was visible to anyone with eyes. His face had the high, bright, dreadful colour of a man lit from within by the wrong lamp. He wore two jumpers. His hands, which on a sound day could make a reel sound as though it had been born in a thunderstorm, trembled slightly on the neck of the instrument, and from time to time, between phrases, he coughed into his elbow with a fine sense of drama.

“He’s *dying,*” said a woman at the bar.

“He’s *thirty-nine degrees,*” said Niamh Quinn, from the corner, with the authority of a woman who has taken his temperature through a haddock. “It’s different.”

Beside him sat Maeve Ryan, seventy-two, retired guard on the Galway–Athenry line, with a bodhrán across her knee and a ticket-punch on a string around her neck, which she clicked in time with the reels, because for forty years she had never known a rhythm that was not a timetable. It was Maeve who had taught him his first tunes, in a front room in Spiddal, smacking his knuckles with a ruler for sloppiness. She was a woman of few words and many coughs, and she watched him now with an expression that people took for sternness and that was in fact the face of a person counting something she did not wish to lose.

Next to her, on a low stool, Sinéad Murphy, twenty-four, electrician, who had rewired the pub’s lighting in October and could not be persuaded to stop looking at it, held a tin whistle in one hand and, in the other, a small screwdriver for emergencies.

“Right,” said Liam, into a microphone he did not need. His voice cracked on the *R* and he swallowed. “That’s a set of reels. Thanks, now. Thanks to Maeve, who’s been punching my ticket since I was six. And to Sinéad, who has rewired the room, so if the lights go, that’s *her*.”

“It’ll not be me!” said Sinéad.

“And I’ve one more tonight. A new one. Well, not *new*. It’s been the same one for six years, and I’ve never finished it. I’ll tell you now, folks, I’ve been *saying* it was nearly finished since the Famine.” A little laughter. “But I’ve a fever, and a last verse, and I thought, *God sent me the one, so he should have the other*. So if I fall off the stage, somebody throw a coat on me.”

He took a breath. The fiddle came up under his chin.

He did not look at the door. He had known she was there since the first note of the first reel: a man who has played to a room for ten years knows who has come in, as a sailor knows weather. He played the first notes, and the room, which had been loud, went still.

**The tide goes out at Blackrock Pier, It leaves the weed, it leaves the stone, It leaves me standing, year on year, With a tune I cannot call my own.*

You set the leg of my old collie And told me he was fed too well, And I went home with a sort of folly That no vet’s bill could ever tell.

*You’d stand at the back with your coat still on, And leave before the last reel’s done, And I’d play on till the lamps were gone For the one who never stays for one.**

He was not a great singer. His voice was low and rough and slightly flat on the long notes, and in the third line of the third verse it nearly gave out, so that for half a bar there was only the fiddle, speaking on its own, and in the corner by the door a woman in a wet coat put her hand flat against the wall to steady herself.

He opened his eyes. He looked straight down the long smoky room, over eighty-four heads, over the turf-smoke and the faces and a dog, and found her.

"And this," said Liam O'Connor, very quietly, so that the room had to lean in, "is the last verse. It's the one I've never had. Hold on to your hats."

He bowed the fiddle. He sang:

So here is the end, and I'll sing it plain, For I've the fever and I've the nerve: If you are going, Aoife, go on the morning tide, I'll not be the one to say you've to stay, But before you go, I'll say what I should have said At the back of the bar, on the first wet night, When you took off your gloves to look at my dog: I have loved you since the winter that you

Here the page is torn.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

Lantern House, Cornwall. A little before midnight, in the same hour. A gale. A laptop. A postman's bag, empty at last.

Nadeesha Fernando had answered four thousand, one hundred and twelve messages in fourteen days, and she had come to understand that grief and clerical work have a great deal in common: both are done by lamp, in the dark, until they are done.

"*Is Entry 0388 me?*" said the first. "*I think Entry 0388 is my husband. Is it possible to find him?*" said the second. "*Please remove Entry 0219. It is true, and I would like it not to be.*" The Register, she had learned, could be opened by anyone but could not be closed by her; and she sat at the oak table in the library of Lantern House, in a blanket, with a pot of tea gone cold at her elbow and the wind trying every door in the house in turn, and typed, to each of them, the same four lines that Seraphine had once said she should say: *Thank you for writing. I cannot tell you whose words are whose. I can tell you that they were true. Be kind, and be brave in that order.*

The laptop chimed.

A small square opened. A man, in a white shirt with the sleeves rolled, in a room full of grey dawn and brass fittings and a great wheel of glass, looked out of the screen and smiled at her with the diffident honesty of one who has not yet decided whether he is allowed.

"You are awake," said Anil Perera.

"It is midnight."

"It is five in the morning. The lamp is going off. I have been keeping the Galle light since four, and I thought: I will call. I will not say anything important. I will say good morning, and ask whether the Register is well."

Nadeesha looked at him for a while. She had been looking at strangers' confessions for fourteen days, and she found that the plainest face in the world was rather a rest.

"It is a thing like a tide," she said. "It does not stop. I thought the thousand would be quiet when they were read. They are not. They are *loud.*"

"And you? Have you read your own?"

"I have not written one."

"You did. You wrote, *I opened the Register and now I cannot close it.* It is Entry 0223. I read it before I read mine." He said this all at once, and then looked appalled. "I am sorry. That was private."

"It was *published,*" said Nadeesha, "by me."

"Even so."

The wind knocked once, politely, at the shutter. She laughed, which she had not done in fourteen days, and the sound surprised both of them.

"Tell me about the weather," she said. "At the lamp. I should like to hear someone say a fact."

"Calm," said Anil. "Southerly, five knots. A tanker off the Fort. A woman in the market selling king coconut who has argued with me every dawn for twenty years about a mango, and I have not once conceded." He leaned his chin on one hand, in the pale light, and his eyes, steady and dark as a harbour, held hers across six thousand miles of sleeping water. "I have been reading a Galway entry, Nadeesha. A man who cannot finish a

song. I have been thinking that he will, tonight. It is a thing I know, as I know the tides, without being able to say how."

"You have never been wrong about the weather."

"No."

"And about people?"

He thought about it, honestly, for the whole of a long moment, with the great glass wheel turning behind him, and the first light of a tropical morning gathering on the water.

"I have never been asked," said Anil, "by anyone who wanted to know."

Nadeesha turned the laptop's small lamp down, and the room filled with the sea's dark noise, and a gale, and a thousand voices waiting to be answered; and, in the centre of it, with her tea cold and her blanket slipping, a nurse from Galle sat in the house of a woman she had loved and found that there was, in the middle of the long night, a light that had come on at the far end of the world, and that she had not put it there, and that it did not mind.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., against Entries 0025 and 0956:

A song is a promise made in public. This is why men are afraid of finishing one.

Entry 0956 wrote that she had told no one. By Thursday night she had told a fishmonger, a hake, and a wall.

I do not know the last line. I have never known it. Some tunes are only given the Keeper in pieces.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 15.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 16: Hanbok Hours

“I have measured everyone in this city but you.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0351

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE I

Seoul. The bank of the Han River at one in the morning, minus eleven degrees. A convenience store with a ramyeon machine, two plastic stools, and a man with a spreadsheet.

Daniel Cho, twenty-seven, head coach of the esports team called Hanul, which means *Sky,* believed that every difficulty in life could be reduced to a table, and he had brought his table to the river.

“Column one,” he said, holding up his phone, “is *Reasons to Stay.* The salary. The trophy. The nineteen boys who think I am their father. Column two is *Reasons to Go.*”

“How long is column two?” said Joon-ho.

“It has one entry.”

“What is it?”

“It is in a *foreign* format,” said Daniel, with dignity, and turned the phone face down upon his knee.

Joon-ho Yoon, forty-one, umbrella-maker, sat beside him on the other stool with a paper cup of noodles steaming into his moustache. He kept a repair stall in Euljiro that had survived three landlords, two recessions, and a fashion for folding umbrellas he regarded as a moral failure. He was Daniel's oldest friend, if one can use *oldest* of a man who had only been a friend since Daniel was nineteen and had brought him a broken umbrella and a broken heart in the same week; and he had a vice, which was that he read anything that was lying open. Letters. Menus. Phones.

He had read the resignation before Daniel had finished writing it.

"*Dear Mr. Kang,*" Joon-ho recited, around a mouthful of noodles. "*It is with a heavy heart, and following extensive consideration, that I tender my resignation as Head Coach, effective at the close of the winter split, in order to pursue—*" He paused. "Hyung. Pursue *what?*"

"A quiet life."

"That is not an activity. That is a *sound.*"

"It is a lifestyle choice."

"It is a coward's way of saying you have found a woman." Joon-ho put down his cup with great finality. "I have known you eight years. You do not, as a rule, leave a trophy for a *lifestyle.* You leave a trophy for a *person.* Who is she?"

"I cannot say."

"Cannot, or have not got her name in a *cell*?"

Daniel did not answer. Across the black river, past the ice floes turning slow in the lamplight and the lit bridges stitched across the water like seams, the city went on shining and not looking at him, as cities do. He had spent six years teaching nineteen-year-olds to read a screen in ninety seconds. He had spent the same years failing, by a gap of exactly four steps, to walk into a shop in an alley off Jongno and say a sentence he had drafted one hundred and forty times.

"There is a tailor," he said at last.

"*Ah,*" said Joon-ho.

"She makes hanbok. I take my mother, for the new year. For the autumn festival. For her birthday, for the… I have been in her shop fourteen times in three years."

"You have a mother with fourteen birthdays?"

"My mother is theatrical," said Daniel. "She regards the lunar calendar as a series of *opportunities.*" He rubbed his eyes. "Every time I go, the tailor measures my mother. She measures my mother's shoulders and my mother's wrists and the span from my mother's neck to her heel. She measures the neighbours. She measured a Japanese tourist once, who had come in to buy a hat. I stand at the edge with my hands in my pockets and I think: *I should say something.* And I say: *Is the silk imported?*"

"And is it?"

"It is, apparently, *always imported.*"

Joon-ho, who was not a man of unusual delicacy, said nothing for a long minute. A gust went up the river bank, and the plastic sign above the shop door clapped like a thin applause.

“Hyung,” he said, “you could say a better thing than *quiet life.*”

“Such as?”

“Anything. Something with her in it.” He wiped his moustache and, with a tenderness that astonished them both, laid a hand on the younger man’s shoulder. “I mend umbrellas. Do you know what a broken one has in common with a man? The *frame* is fine. It is only that nobody ever opened it in the rain.”

“That,” said Daniel, “is nearly a good sentence.”

“I know. I read it on a postcard.”

He sent the letter in the morning, at 9:02, a minute after the building opened. He did not use *pursue.* He used six words, and the president of Hanul Esports read them twice, and then, for reasons of his own, closed his office door and did not come out until noon.

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SCENE II

Osaka. The Tenma ward, behind the canal, under the railway arches, at ten minutes before midnight. A ramen shop with eight stools. Steam, trains, a paper lantern that has lost the argument with the weather.

There is a particular kind of Osaka night, in winter, when the trains go over the arches every four minutes and each one shakes a little salt out of the sky, and every shop beneath the tracks keeps its door half open so that you can smell the broth from the next street.

The shop of Hiroshi Tanabe had a curtain, a ticket machine that dispensed a single choice, and a counter with eight stools; and beside the steam pipe, on the stool where the heat rose best, nobody ever sat. In front of it, every night, stood a bowl.

It was a bowl like any other. White glaze, a blue ring at the lip. A clear brown broth fourteen hours in the pot, with a shaving of leek and three slices of pork laid in a fan. He made it at twenty to midnight, after the last customer, and set it before the empty stool, with the chopsticks on their rest and a small blue towel folded in thirds; and then he stood on the other side of the wood with his arms folded and waited, as one waits for a train that is late, but not very late. At midnight he poured it into the sink. He washed the bowl by hand.

“Tonight,” said Rin Hayashi, from the third stool, “has an air of *event.*” He was thirty-three, a retired lifeguard, who had pulled four swimmers from Osaka Bay and had spent six years of nights watching a man pour a bowl down a drain, which he considered the harder rescue.

“You say that every night.”

“I mean it more tonight. Look at the lantern.”

“It is the same lantern.”

“It is *swaying,*” said Rin, “in an expectant manner.”

At the end of the counter, among her pickle-jars, an old woman in a quilted jacket went on shelling cucumbers with the serenity of one who has outlived most omens. At the counter nearest the stove sat Daichi Ito, thirty-four, historian, who had come in from Kobe with a bag of books and had been eating one bowl of noodles for forty minutes in order to be present for the atmosphere. He had written six hundred pages on the history of the noodle in the Kansai region and could not cook water. He read every portent aloud and apologised for none of them, which is the secret of his trade.

"I will say," said Daichi, to nobody, "that in the Heian period it was believed that the last customer of the night was a visitor from a better world."

"It's eleven fifty," said Hiroshi.

"A better world with its own timetable. I merely *note.*"

Hiroshi, thirty-four, perfectionist, said very little and was said to say it in the order of importance. His hands were large, scarred, steady, with a burn along one thumb, and they moved across a clean board with the rhythm of one who has found in repetition the only mercy of the world. Since the spring he had been saying one sentence a day. Last week a retired chef from São Paulo had put his counter on the internet, and the sentence had been *Eat.*

He did not look at the door. He had learned a long time ago that to look at a door is to ask it for something.

The curtain moved.

There are people who come into a room like a stone into a pond, and people who come in like a drop of ink, and people who come in like a held breath. The woman who stepped under the noren, in a grey coat the colour of an old photograph, with her face half-hidden in a scarf and her hand still on the edge of the cloth as though she had not decided whether to let go of it, was the third kind.

She was thirty-three. She had hair cut at the jaw, and tired eyes, and the straight, careful posture of a person who has spent eleven years looking closely at things and has lately been afraid of what she might see. For two years, on the same night every week, she had sat beside the steam pipe and eaten with her eyes closed and said almost nothing. Since the new-moon night she had said nothing at all, because she had not come.

"Welcome," said Hiroshi. It came out of him as a thing is said by a man who has said it fifty thousand times and has never meant it as he meant it now.

"*Irasshai,*" said Rin, instantly, and then, in a stage whisper that could have been heard in Kyoto: "*Look at the lantern.*"

The woman stood in the doorway. She looked at the bowl, the white glaze, the fan of pork, the steam, which went up into the lamplight in a single thin rope and was cut, from time to time, by the roar of a train.

"The photograph," she said. "A friend sent it. A bowl at the end of a counter, in Portuguese. The caption said: *He makes one bowl every night for a woman who stopped coming.*" Her fingers tightened on the noren. "I recognised the glaze."

“Mei-san,” said Hiroshi.

It was the first time he had said her name aloud since the new-moon night. It broke a little in the middle, like a stick of kelp.

“I was not sure you would remember.”

“I know your order. I have known it for six years.” He did not say what else he knew. “Sit. Please. It was made for you.”

“It is *cold,*” said Rin, kindly. “I’ll make a new—”

“It is not cold,” said Hiroshi, without turning. “It is nine minutes old. It was made at eleven-forty. It has been waiting.”

Daichi Ito had stopped chewing. Rin Hayashi had risen halfway off his stool, a lifeguard at the edge of a deep and difficult water. At the end of the counter the old woman, who was Hiroshi’s mother, had put down her cucumber. And above them, at that exact second, the last train of the night went over the arches and shook the whole shop, so that the lantern swung, and the pot lids sang, and the bowl shivered once, and was still.

Mei crossed the room. It was a short floor, four steps, and she took each of them as one crosses ice. She sat. The stool was warm; it had been warmed, she understood, on purpose. Her hands, bare and unsteady, came to the lip of the bowl and rested there, as if she were warming them at a fire. She lifted the spoon. She did not drink.

“Hiroshi-san,” she said. Her voice was very quiet. “Before I eat this, I must tell you the real reason I did not come back. It is not the one you think. It was not shame, and it was not that I—” Her eyes went to the broth, to the clear gold of it, and a thing crossed her face that was not quite shame, and not quite grief, but the look of a woman about to read out a verdict against herself. “It was that one morning in the spring, when I woke, and put a spoonful of miso soup into my mouth, I found that I could no longer—”

Here the page is torn.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

Seoul. An alley off Jongno, between the bindaetteok stall and the stationer’s. The shop of Han Ji-woo, on a Thursday, nearly three weeks before the lunar new year. A bell on the door. A kettle on the ondol. The wild light of a winter afternoon.

The shop was so full of colour that it seemed less a room than an argument that silk had won. Along the walls hung jeogori jackets in jade and ember and plum, their ribbons unknotted like the fringe of some great beast; chima skirts in a hundred pinks; the white collars called *dongjeong* stacked in rows, sharp as new paper. In the back a sewing machine hummed like a bee in a bottle, and in the middle of everything, at a long cutting-table scored by thirty years of chalk, stood Ji-woo.

She was twenty-six. She was small, and exact, and she moved as a good needle moves: neither fast nor slow, but exactly as fast as the thread. Round her neck, for good reason, she wore a yellow tape measure, and she had worn it so long that her friends, when they spoke of her, said *the tape,* as in: *Is the tape in?*

At the counter, in her third-best cardigan, sat a nine-year-old called Tae-yang, who had been left there by an aunt for the afternoon, and was reading a book about volcanoes with the grave air of a magistrate.

"Ji-woo noona," he said, without looking up. "Who measures you?"

"I measure myself."

"No. Who *else.* You said you cannot measure your own back. Nobody can. You said a tailor has the worst-fitting coat in the city."

"It is a proverb."

"It is a *problem,*" said Tae-yang, turning a page. "I read that, in a volcano, the thing at the centre is the one you cannot see."

At the door, the bell gave its small bronze cough.

"*Ji-woo-ya!*" cried a woman of fifty-eight in a gold quilted jacket, entering like weather. This was Yoon Ji-ah, goldsmith, who made the tiny knotted ornaments called *norigae* that hang from the ribbons, and who had never in her life been on time for anything, owing to the fact that she made every promise a little faster than she could keep it. "I have them! I have your *norigae!* I

brought them myself. I said *tomorrow* on Monday and *tomorrow* on Tuesday, and I said *tomorrow* on Wednesday, so it is a statistical triumph that it is only Thursday."

"They were due three days ago."

"They were due *in spirit.*" She dropped a small silk bag on the counter, and out of it spilled a clutch of gold and coral: butterflies, little bottles, a fish with eyes of jade. "And for the *old lady*—for the mother of that nice boy with the face—I have made the peach. The big one. With the tassel. Where is he? Is he coming? He came last Thursday. He asked about the *silk.* I said to my husband, that boy has not once asked about the *silk*—"

"Aunty," said Ji-woo.

"I am only saying. A man who asks about silk four times in three years is not asking about silk."

The bell rang again.

Daniel Cho came in with snow on his shoulders and no coat, having left it, in a state of what he later described to Joon-ho as *procedural collapse,* on the number 6 bus. He had resigned at 9:02 that morning. He had been told, at ten, that the president of Hanul wished to see him. He had been told, at noon, that the president wished him to reconsider. He had been told, at one, in a corridor, by a nineteen-year-old with a stunning mouse-hand and an unexpectedly wet face, *Coach, you can't go.* And he had come here, because it was his mother's turn.

"It's for the new year," said Daniel. "My mother's outfit. She has requested… a *peach.*"

“A jealous peach,” said Ji-ah the goldsmith, “with a tassel.”

“She was quite specific.”

“Of course she was. She is a lady of discernment.” Ji-woo came out from behind the table with the yellow tape hung round her neck, and with an air so composed that only a person who has practised could have achieved it. “Mr. Cho. How is your mother’s height? Last time I had the measurement but I have mislaid the paper.”

It was not true. She had never mislaid a paper in her life. She had the number in her head and in two notebooks and, on a good night, in her sleep.

“I—” said Daniel. “She is— I think she comes to my ear. Here.”

“Here?”

“Or here. Perhaps lower. She wears shoes of an *ambitious* heel.”

“Then,” said Ji-woo, “you had better stand there.”

“Where?”

“There. By the post. I will use you.”

“As a *mannequin*?”

“As a *reference,*” said Ji-woo, who found, to her great surprise, that her own voice had gone a little high at the end, like a thread under strain. “Stand straight. Look at the wall. Do not talk.”

He stood by the post. He looked at the wall, where a calendar hung of a tiger in a hat. He did not talk. This, for him, was a feat of discipline on the level of Olympic

sport, and it was compounded by the fact that somewhere behind him a woman was walking slowly round him, once, and then again, with her head a little on one side, saying nothing, and not touching him at all.

"Shoulder to shoulder," she murmured, to herself. "Neck to heel. The set of the arm." She had her pencil out. "Your mother is smaller. You are… that is the proportion I will take."

"I am taller than my mother."

"Yes."

"Considerably."

"Yes. I will adjust."

"By how much?"

"By a *standard* amount," said Ji-woo, and her pencil moved, not on the large white pad on the counter where her customers' numbers were written, but on the small blue notebook she kept in the pocket of her apron. She had not taken the tape from her neck. She did not need to. She had been measuring this man by eye since the first Thursday, and the tape, which she had worn for twelve years like a stole, hung at her collarbone as unused as a bell with its tongue tied.

"That's not the number for his *mother,*" said Tae-yang, from the counter, without moving his eyes from the volcano.

"Tae-yang."

"It's the one for a man. A *tall* man. You wrote the sleeve in a different pencil." He turned a page. "Also you haven't touched the tape, which you always do, and you

are blushing, and you've dropped it twice."

"I have *not* dropped the—"

The tape was on the floor. It lay in a loose yellow coil at her feet, having given up on discretion.

There was a silence. Ji-ah the goldsmith, who had never in her life let a silence go unfilled, opened her mouth, and then, with a delicacy that surprised everyone, including herself, shut it again and began, with great interest, to reorganise the butterflies.

"Mr. Cho," said Ji-woo at last, in the voice of a person lifting a heavy thing and finding it, to her horror, lighter than she had feared. "How is the team?"

"I have resigned," said Daniel.

"From what?"

"From being a coach. I… would like a quiet life." He turned from the wall, at last, with snow melting in his hair and a face as bare as a field, and looked at her with the whole of his analytical, awkward, honest heart. "I have a table. I mean, I had one. It had a column with one entry. I am here to say that I think I have… that I would like to learn something that is not a game."

"What?"

"I do not know. A button. How to sew on a button."

"That," said Ji-woo Han, slowly, and picked up the tape, and found that her hand did not shake at all, "I can teach you."

"When?"

“The new year is in nineteen days. Come back for the fitting. Your mother’s. And—” She did not say *and what.* “Thursdays are quiet. You may fold silk.”

“For how long?”

“For as long as it takes the silk.”

“That is a great many hours,” said Daniel Cho, who had never in his life said so, and heard it, and found, to his surprise, that he did not mind.

Outside, in the alley, the snow came down in thick, slow flakes over the bindaetteok stall and the stationer and the little brass bell, and Yoon Ji-ah the goldsmith, who had slipped out to give them privacy and had been standing for ten minutes with her ear against the door, said to the street at large, with the most reliable promise she had ever made:

“*Tomorrow,* I will tell the whole of Suwon.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., against Entries 0351 and 0254; and beside Entries 0510 and 0810, a single short line, like a stitch that has been cut:

A tailor who has measured a city and not the man who stands in her doorway. A coach who has made a column and left it blank.

Of the other two, the cook and the critic, I will say only that the bowl was not cold.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 16.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 17: Coffee and the Long Run

“This is my last race. After it my knee is finished.”
— Register of Black Stars, Entry 0243

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE I

Addis Ababa. The slopes of Entoto, a little before six, nearly three thousand metres above the sea. Eucalyptus smoke, cold sunrise, and two runners going up a hill that has no intention of ending.

At that altitude the air is thin as a rumour, and a runner who wishes to breathe must first make friends with it.

“Again,” said Selam Tesfaye.

“I cannot.”

“You can. You are twelve. At twelve one can do anything but one’s homework.” She did not slow. She was thirty-three, hard and narrow as a blade, with a black brace strapped around her right knee that she wore under her tights so that nobody might see, and had worn so long that she no longer remembered running without it. “Again. To the tree with the red cloth.”

“That is *two kilometres.*”

"It is *nineteen hundred metres.* I measured it myself, in 2011, with a rope."

Bethlehem Girma, twelve, schoolchild, who had been running behind Selam's heels every dawn since the previous spring for no reason she would give, said something unrepeatable in Amharic and kept going.

Down the slope past them came the women of Entoto, in a long bent line, each with a bundle of eucalyptus branches on her back that towered above her head like a green and walking house. One of them, an old woman with a face like a folded map, lifted her chin as the runners passed and said, with perfect indifference:

"*Selam. Your leg.*"

"It is fine, Emaye."

"It is *not* fine. It makes a sound."

"It is a *private* sound."

"Then tell it to be quieter," said the old woman, and went on down the hill with the wood.

They ran to the tree with the red cloth. Selam touched it, and turned, and for a moment stood quite still with her hand against the trunk, and the whole bright city lay below her in the haze, with its cranes and its tin roofs and its thousand blue plastic water tanks like a sea of small dull stars. In the spring there was a race, on the roads of Addis itself: twenty-six miles and three hundred and eighty-five yards. It would be the last time she ever ran so far, and she had told no one, because to say it aloud would be to start the counting.

“Selam?” said Bethlehem, who had come up behind her, wheezing. “Why do you only buy your coffee on Saturdays?”

“Because on Saturdays I have earned it.”

“But you go to the same place. The man with the big shoulders who never smiles.”

“He smiles.”

“He does not. I have watched.” The girl bent double, hands on her knees. “He looks at your leg when you are not looking at him. And you look at his hands when he is not looking at you. It is very strange. It is like two people at a bus stop who both pretend the bus has come.”

“Run,” said Selam. “*Down.* And I am not your coach.”

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

Samuel Bekele’s roastery, in a lane off Churchill Avenue. Saturday, midday. A drum, a pan, a brazier. Sacks of green beans, stencilled with the names of the high country: Yirgacheffe, Sidamo, Guji. A smell that could convert an atheist.

Samuel Bekele, thirty-six, steady, proud, and as visibly unsmiling as a very large door, was roasting coffee with the intensity of a man who has a debt.

He had six. That was the part nobody saw.

It had been a good business once. *Bekele & Brother, Green and Roasted, Since 1998:* a name on a board, two trucks, a ledger in Yared’s careless left-handed hand,

and a laugh that came up the lane before its owner. Then, in October, Yared had died on the Awash road, and what he left was the laugh's absence, a warehouse with a mortgage and eleven thousand sacks of green Yirgacheffe, and a list. Samuel had found it in a cigarette tin: *a baker, two cousins, a bank, a priest, a man in Dire Dawa who sold goats.* A brother who owed everyone, and had smiled about it, and had never said.

Samuel, who did not smile, had said: *Then I owe everyone.* Some sentences, once said, do not go away.

At the front of the roastery, on a low stool beside a brazier of coals, sat Selam Tesfaye with her coat open and her bare hands round a clay cup, watching him like a judge watching a defendant who is not quite guilty.

"The pan," she said.

"I have a perfectly good drum."

"I want the pan." She said it without heat, the way one says a plain truth about the weather. "I am a woman of Addis. I will have my coffee made in my grandmother's way, on the coals, in the flat iron, with the beans turned by a man who will not talk to me."

"I have not said a word."

"I know," said Selam. "That is what I am paying for."

He washed the green beans in a bowl, as they had done it in his mother's house, and set them on the pan over the coals, and began to move them with a long iron spoon. There was a sound like rain beginning on a tin roof. Then a smell rose, and it was green first, grassy, bright, and then, as the colour deepened, sweet, and

then, abruptly, nutty and brown, and over the whole room the blue smoke rolled and hung in the sunlight like incense, and Selam bent and fanned it toward her face with her cupped hand, and closed her eyes.

The bean is green, and thinks itself a stone. The fire says: Open. And it will not hear. The fire says: Open. And the hull goes brown. The fire says: Open. And it cracks, and sings, And what it was is lost, and what it is Is all the house can smell for half a mile. Pray, child, that when the heat comes for your hull, You crack, and sing, and do not call it grief.

It was an old song, said by women over pans. Samuel did not know that he had said it aloud until he saw her face.

“Where did you learn that?”

“From my mother,” said Samuel Bekele, and for the first time in four months, did not look away.

The bell on the street door rang.

It was a tall man in a black suit that had once been good, and a short woman in a brown one that had never been, and between them a third, a stout and mournful figure in a woollen hat, carrying under one arm a very large book and under the other a very small umbrella.

“Ato Samuel,” said the tall one. “A moment.”

“It is Saturday,” said Samuel.

“Debts do not observe the Sabbath.”

“This one does. It is Saturday, and I am roasting.”

The short woman in brown, who was Rahel Girma, fifty-five, landlady of the warehouse and scribe of the legal paper for half the lanes of Addis, and who did not so much lack manners as use them as a lawyer uses a cough, set a folder on the sack of Guji beans. “Samuel. There are six. Three are patient. Three are not. The man in Dire Dawa has sent his nephew, who is large.”

“The goat man.”

“The goat man’s nephew. He is outside, and he has brought a goat, as a *warning*.”

At the end of the room, Selam did not move. She sat as still as a runner in the starting-blocks, her cup halfway to her mouth, her face emptied of every expression, as olives are emptied of their stones. She was not looking at the creditors. She was not looking at him. She was looking at the pan.

And Samuel, who could feel her not-looking, felt something in his chest that he had no word for in any of his languages: not shame, nor quite gratitude, but the sweet and awful sensation of being seen and spared.

The man in the woollen hat cleared his throat.

“I am not a creditor,” said Dawit Tadesse, fifty-nine, librarian, of Bahir Dar, with an air of enormous apology. “I wish it understood. I am only a *lender*. Your brother Yared, may he rest in peace, borrowed from me three thousand birr and a book.”

“The book?” said Samuel.

"*Fikir Eske Mekabir.* A first edition, with *annotations.* It is of immense sentimental value, and also one thousand birr." He held up the very large volume under his arm, which was not that book, and then, aghast, put it down. "I do not need the money, Ato Samuel, though I would welcome it. But I have another request, which is a *great* impertinence."

"What?"

"I am fifty-nine years old and I have never seen the sea." He said it with the stricken look of a man confessing to a crime. "I am a librarian. I know the sea in nine languages. I have read about it for forty years. I understand that your trucks go to Djibouti. When the next container goes, I should like—it would settle the whole matter for me—to ride in the lorry. And look."

There was a long pause. The beans cracked on the pan like a small burst of applause.

"A debt," said Dawit Tadesse, in the voice of a man who has said a thing so true that he is unaware of it, "is only a letter that has not yet been answered. I should like to be answered with a view of the water."

Rahel Girma, scribe of debts, who had written ten thousand promissory notes and read in every one the same fear, looked at the old librarian with an expression that, in a less professional person, would have been called *tenderness.*

"Ato Samuel," she said at last. "I will tell the goat man's nephew that you are *in negotiation.* I will give you until the lunar month's end. For the others—" She

picked up her folder. “They will wait. They are more patient than they appear. They have all been to a funeral.”

“Thank you.”

“Do not thank me. I charge for it.” She nodded to the room, and to Selam, with an ironical little bow, and withdrew, followed by the tall man, and the goat man’s nephew, who was audibly arguing with a goat.

Dawit Tadesse lingered at the door.

“I was very sorry about Yared,” he said. “He was the only man in Addis who ever returned a book *late* and still made me glad of it.”

When he had gone, there was only the coffee: the brown beans heaped in the pan, glossy as river stones, shedding their thin smoke into the light.

Selam put down her cup.

“Samuel.”

“Yes.”

“The beans are burning.”

He started, and swept them off the pan with a long scrape of the iron spoon, and stood with his hands on the edge of the table and his back to her. It was a very broad back. It had carried a coffin.

“I did not hear anything,” said Selam Tesfaye. “I want you to know that. I heard the beans, and I heard the street, and I have heard nothing else at all.”

“I know.”

“And you did not see me limp on the stairs, and you did not see the brace, and you did not see me put my hand on the wall.”

“I saw nothing,” said Samuel.

“Good.” She stood. She was shorter than he, by a head, and as upright as a post, and as she rose she did something, a very small thing, with her knee, which clicked, in the quiet, like a latch. Neither of them remarked on it. “Then we are in agreement. I will take two hundred and fifty grams of the Yirgacheffe. And I would like it ground.”

“In the mortar?”

“In the mortar, by you. With the long pestle.”

He ground it, and the room filled with the smell of a crushed morning, dark and floral and bright. When he handed her the little brown bag she held it a moment against her chest before putting it into her pocket.

“There is a race in the spring,” she said abruptly. “Here, on the Gulele Road. It is my last.”

“I did not—”

“I did not say you did. I am *saying.*” Her jaw was set. “So you will understand that I do not want anyone standing at the thirty-fifth kilometre, in the dust, with something hot. I shall not look for you.”

“Coffee,” said Samuel, to the pan.

“*Obviously* not,” said Selam.

She did not say *come.* He did not say *I will.* Between two proud people, reader, nobody has ever said a plainer thing.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

St Petersburg. The fourth-floor studio above the Nevsky Chamber Theatre, at five in the evening, which in January is midnight with the lamps lit. Plaster angels on the ceiling. A barre, a battered piano, an iron stove. A grey sky pressing its face to the windows.

A pianist's love is made, if he is honest, of rests.

This is a secret of the trade, and Dmitri Volkov, forty, accompanist, who had sat at the same instrument for sixteen years and never once been asked what he thought of the ballet, kept it better than most. A note, he knew, is only half the music. The other half is the silence that follows it. It is the held breath, the *fermata,* the pause before the downbeat in which a whole house of eight hundred people forgets to cough; and in a long and orderly life he had learned to love that silence more than any chord, because it was the only thing in the world that was his alone.

At a quarter to five, with the children's class dismissed and the corridor emptied of small shrieking dancers in woollen leg-warmers, he sat at the piano in the half-dark, with the stove ticking and the snow in the window turning blue, and said, to the instrument, to the plaster angels, to nobody:

I wrote it in three-quarter time, because A waltz is three: a step, a step, a breath. The first is for the leaving; and the second, For the return; the third is for the rest In which the dancer, poised above her future, Does not yet know which way her foot will fall. I wrote it for a woman who has taught Two hundred children how to stand on air, And never has been asked to stand on it Herself, since that last night, the knee, the curtain. I have not asked. I have been courteous. I have been courteous for six years: A coward, with good manners. Tonight there is the snow. The room is empty. If I should ask, and she should say it plain— Then let her say it plain.

"You are talking to the angels," said a dry voice from the door, "again."

Dmitri did not leap. He rose, with the grave slow formality that was his only armour, and turned, and there she stood, with her black bag over her shoulder and a cane she denied was a cane. She was thirty-eight. She had a long throat and a proud flat mouth and a way of standing that was less a posture than a ruling, and the left knee, under her trousers, was stiff as a hinge in winter.

Anya Petrova, retired ballerina, who in her day had been called *the Swan of the Fontanka* and, in her present state, had been called by the youngest of her pupils *Madame Hurricane,* looked at him down the length of the rehearsal room as at a man who has been caught with the silver.

"I was warming the instrument," said Dmitri.

“For whom?”

“For the… morning.”

“It is five in the evening.”

“Then for the *next* morning.”

“You are the most courteous liar in the Russian Federation,” said Anya. She came in out of the doorway, and he could hear the knee on each step, the little dry click like a clock being wound, and she dropped her bag on the bench by the barre. “I forgot my glasses. Do not look at me like that. I am thirty-eight. I am entitled.”

“I did not look.”

“You always look. You look and you pretend you did not. You have done so for six years, and since the gala you have done it up four flights of stairs.” She turned, with the glasses in her hand, and did not put them on.

There was a silence. The stove ticked. It was, he noted with the instinct of his trade, an excellent silence: round, full, unhurried.

“Madame,” said Dmitri.

“Do not call me *Madame.*”

“Anya.”

“Better.”

“I have something to ask you.”

“If it is about the piano tuner, he is a thief. If it is about the children’s concert, I will not wear the sequins.”

“It is not about the sequins.”

“Then?”

He crossed the floor. It was twelve paces; he counted them, from habit, in three. At the end of them he stopped, and bowed, with a deep old-fashioned bow, the kind that has not been seen in a Petersburg rehearsal room since the days of Imperial teachers, and came up again with a face as white as a fresh page.

“Anya Petrova,” he said. “I wrote a waltz. You know that. You heard it in the wings, on the night of the gala. I did not know whom it was for until it was written. I have never told you. I have never asked you for anything. I am asking you now.” He drew breath. “Would you do me the honour of one dance?”

There was no sound in the room but the stove.

Anya Petrova stood quite still. A long moment went by in which a great many things happened in her face and none of them stayed: a flush, and a flash of anger, and something so sore and bright and young that it seemed to belong to another person, a girl of seventeen on a stage lit like the inside of a pearl.

“I have a knee,” she said.

“I am aware.”

“It has a longer memory than I have, and a shorter temper. It has not forgiven the third act of *Giselle.*”

“It need not forgive. I do not ask it to *leap.*”

“What do you ask it to do?”

“Walk,” said Dmitri. “In three. A step, a step, a breath. I will play it for you in the head. You need not move your arms. You need not do anything but be in the room while

I am in it."

"That is not dancing."

"That is the *oldest* dancing," said Dmitri Volkov, with the sudden, startling shyness of a man saying the one true thing he has rehearsed for six years, "and I am told I have a gift for the rest."

She looked at him. She looked at the silence, the held breath in the dark, the clock, the angels on the ceiling, who had looked down for a hundred years on every sort of fool.

"No," said Anya.

He did not move. It is a mark of a courtly man that he can be struck in the face and keep it at the same angle.

"Not now," she said. "Not tonight. I will not do it in a room with a stove and a cough. I will not do it badly. If I am to dance with a man for the first time in six years, I intend to do it *well.* Ask me again."

"When?"

"When the Neva thaws."

"That is April."

"It is *usually* April."

"Then I will ask in April."

"You will ask all winter," said Anya. "I know you. You will ask me in your head with every bar. And I will say *no,* and *not yet,* and *you are impossible,* and in April—" She stopped. She took up her bag, and her glasses, and put the glasses at last upon her nose, which gave her the look of an affronted owl. "In April, we will see."

She went to the door. With her hand on it she paused, and did not turn.

“Dmitri Andreyevich.”

“Yes.”

“The seventh bar. The third beat. You are not holding it *long* enough.”

“I know.”

“Play it again. With the rest.”

He sat. He put his hands to the keys. Behind him the door shut with a click, and her uneven footsteps went away down the stairs: step, step, and the dry small click, and the step. And he played the waltz, slowly, the whole of it, in the dark, with the rests as long as they wanted to be, and at the seventh bar, on the third beat, where a great deal of his life was kept, he held the silence so long that the plaster angels leaned from the ceiling to find out what would come next.

In the corridor, among a rack of tutus, with a copy of the *Evening Petersburg* held before his face, Sergei Orlov, costume-master, fifty-seven, devout, who had read half the theatre’s private correspondence by the simple expedient of standing very still, murmured to a feathered skirt:

“*Well, my dear,*” he said. “*She did not say never.*”

Sergei, who read other people’s post and other people’s lives, and was wrong about the one and right about the other, crossed himself and went away to mend a swan.

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Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., against Entries 0233, 0243 and 0234:

A runner and a roaster, who each saw nothing; a pianist and a dancer, who each saw everything and said no. I have been asked by a good many young correspondents what is the difference between a refusal and a delay. In my experience it is the tone of the voice. Mark that she said ask me again.

A debt is a letter that has not been answered. Entry 0233 is learning to write back. I do not know in what currency.

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End of Chapter 17.

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Chapter 18: The Balcony Business

“I write the replies to the letters left on the wall.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0516

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SCENE I

Verona. The courtyard on Via Cappello, at seven on a February morning, before the tourists. Fog the colour of milk. A bronze statue with one shining breast, rubbed bright by a million hopeful hands. A wall papered thick with letters, chewing-gum, and small folded prayers.

The balcony, if one is honest, is not very large.

This is the first thing Giulia Rossi tells the groups, in five languages, at ten o’clock, in the flat voice of a woman who has said it four thousand times. *It is a small stone balcony, added to a medieval house in the nineteen-thirties to improve the story. No lovers ever stood upon it. It is a very good piece of marketing.* She says this in English to the Americans, and in Italian to the Italians, who are offended. Then she lets them take photographs. Then, because she is not a monster, she shows them the wall.

At seven, however, there were no groups. There was only fog, and a coffee, and a basket on the wall beneath the arch, where the night's letters had been left by the faithful, the desperate and the drunk. They came from Tokyo, Lagos, Ohio, Lima, on hotel stationery, on napkins, on the backs of boarding passes, addressed to a girl who had never lived, and every one of them was answered.

"Forty-one," said Giulia, to the coffee. She was thirty-one, a small, sharp woman with ink on the heel of her hand and the expression of someone who has seen the worst of the human heart and filed it alphabetically. "Forty-one overnight. It is the *fog.* Fog makes people honest. By March it will be seventy."

"You say that every year," said a voice from the little office behind the arch.

"It is true every year, Elena."

"Truth is a *habit,* child. It does not make it less so."

Elena Gallo, seventy-four, retired newsagent from Mantua and, for forty years, the senior secretary of the Letters, sat in a cardigan the colour of a tobacco field, with a pair of glasses on a chain and a brass kettle that she did not trust anyone else to fill. She had taught Giulia to read a sentence for the thing beneath it, to answer in a voice that is neither pity nor sermon, and to say *I do not know,* the hardest sentence in any language. She had also, by never minding her own business, introduced eleven couples, of whom three had stayed together, which she considered a creditable average.

"Who is writing in tongues today?" said Elena.

“The cat lady.”

“*Ah.*”

The cat lady was Francesca Costa, fifty, weaver, of Mantua, an anxious woman who drank tea at night and wrote every Tuesday. Her letters ran to seven pages and concerned her husband, her husband’s cat, her husband’s mother’s cat, and the fundamental question of whether a woman could leave a man and keep the cats, or vice versa. She signed herself *Desperate in Mantua,* and had done so for six years, and had never once left.

Dear Desperate, Giulia wrote that morning, with a nib that scratched like a beetle, *You have asked me nine times whether you should leave your husband. You have asked me once whether you should leave his cat. I notice that you only seem alarmed about one of these. Sign the cat over to your sister. Then we shall discuss the husband. In the meantime—drink less tea after nine.*

“That is harsh,” said Elena.

“It is the only medicine she has not tried.”

She opened the next letter. It was on thick cream paper, expensive, and it smelled, faintly and unmistakably, of bay rum and hair pomade. The hand was large, looping, theatrical, a hand that had been taught as a child to sign autographs. It said:

To the Lady of the Balcony,
I am a singer. I am loved by a thousand people on any given night, and I am afraid of every one of them. Each time I stand in the wings, my knees turn to ricotta. I have a great many scarves. I have a reputation. I am very handsome (I do not say this to

boast; it is a medical fact, like a limp). I have sung for nine years in the finest houses in the north of Italy, and I have never once, in all that time, walked onto a stage without wishing to be sick.

I am not what the posters say. How does one go on?

— a Man Who Is Not What the Posters Say

Giulia read it twice. She read everything twice; it was what she was for. Then she did what she had not done in six years of answering the wall: she took off her glasses, held them in her hand, and looked at the fog.

"Elena."

"Mm."

"If a man writes that he is not what the posters say…"

"Then he is probably *exactly* what the posters say," said Elena Gallo, "and is afraid of it. It is the commonest thing in the world. I have a nephew like that. He is a Carabiniere."

"That is not an answer."

"That is a *diagnosis.* The answer is for you to write." She put the kettle on, and a small, grandmotherly, wicked light came into her face. "Write it well. The famous are the ones who most need to be told the truth, and are least likely to get it."

Giulia bent over the paper. She wrote for a long time. When she had finished she read it over, amended one line, and signed it with the only signature the Letters had ever had: *Juliet's Secretary.* Then she did something

else. She added, below, in a smaller hand, four lines of verse, the first she had written since the age of nineteen, and which she would have denied under oath:

Take off your shoes. The floor is cold and real. Find one face in the third row. Sing to her. The thousand are a rumour; she is not. And be afraid. It is how true things feel.

She sealed it and put it in the post-basket. The envelope the letter had come in bore no name, only a printed flap that read *Posta Artisti, Teatro Filarmonico.* She looked at it only once, and then very hard, and then she poured the cold coffee down the drain.

Mark this, reader. She had addressed it to a man she had never met, and told him the truth, and the only person in all of Verona who did not yet know she was falling for him was Giulia.

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SCENE II

The Teatro Filarmonico, Verona. A dressing-room with a mirror ringed in forty bulbs. Eleven scarves. A tin of throat lozenges. A man in a silk dressing-gown, declaiming to a reflection.

Marco Bellini, thirty-four, the first tenor of the north of Italy, did not believe in superstitions, but believed in lucky socks, a lucky lozenge, a lucky mirror, the left-hand dressing-room and the colour yellow, and had once refused a role because it required a green cloak.

"I am *dying,*" he told his reflection.

“You are *shaving,*” said Enzo Marino, twenty-four, his dresser, a cousin from Salerno who had come north for the season with a suitcase, a guitar, and the ambition to be discovered as a baritone. “There is a difference.”

“Not at my level. I am a man on the edge of a precipice with a razor. Look at this face. This is a *national asset.* Tonight it will be seen by eleven hundred people, and one critic, and a *woman in the third row with a hat like a cabbage* who has sat in that seat for thirty seasons and tuts.”

“So don’t look at the third row.”

“I always look at the third row! The first two are for the donors, who smile with their teeth. The third row is where the real ones sit.” He put down the razor. His voice, which a moment before had been a thing of golden bravura, had dropped suddenly to the register of a child. “Enzo.”

“Mm?”

“My knees have gone.”

“They have been gone all week.”

“They have gone to *ricotta.*” He sat down heavily upon a velvet stool. In the mirror, forty bulbs lit a perfect, famous, slightly sweating face. “I wrote to the wall, Enzo. To the *letters.* Like a schoolgirl. I thought, *If anyone in Verona could tell me what to do, it would be a person who spends her life answering the unanswerable.* And I signed it with no name. It has been four days. I am a fool.”

There was a knock at the door. A boy of fourteen in an usher's red jacket held out a small cream envelope with the pride of a messenger from the gods. "From the Via Cappello, Maestro. A courier brought it."

"A *courier*?"

"A woman on a bicycle."

Marco took the envelope. He held it quite still, at arm's length, as one holds a thing that may be alive. Then he tore it open with a thumb that, to his great surprise, was trembling, and read.

Enzo went to the far end of the dressing-room and began, tactfully, to rearrange the scarves.

The note was a page long. It said that fear was not a flaw in a performer but the receipt for having cared; that the thousand were an idea and the one was a person; that the only cure for ricotta in the knees was to take off one's shoes in the wings and stand for thirty seconds on the cold floor, and then to walk on, and find a face, and sing to it. It said that *the vain are only the shy with good lighting.* It said, at the end, in four lines of verse, the thing that made Marco Bellini put the letter down and cover his mouth with his hand.

"Enzo. Who is she? *Juliet's Secretary.* Is she a nun? Is she eighty?" He seized his cousin by both shoulders. "I have never in my life been so *perceived.* I am going to marry this woman. I do not even know whether she has teeth."

"She might be a man."

“She is *not* a man. No man has ever written ‘it is how true things feel.’”

“Forty minutes, Maestro,” said a voice at the door.

He stood. He tied the silk tie. He put on the yellow scarf, and the lucky socks, and a look that transformed him by degrees from a frightened boy into a prince; and at the stage-left curtain, in the dark, in the smell of dust and ropes and old paint, with the orchestra’s tuning-A rising like a drawn breath, he did a thing which had never happened in the history of the Teatro Filarmonico.

He took off his shoes.

The floor is cold. It is a floor. I am A man who stands upon it. Eleven hundred Are out there, and are only a rumour. There is one face. The cabbage. Let it be the cabbage. God keep me from the donors and the knees.

He walked on, in his socks, in the full gold light, and there was a murmur from the house that was the sound of eleven hundred people noticing his feet. And he looked to the third row, and found, under a vast felt hat in the shape and colour of a savoy cabbage, the face of a stout woman in her sixties, who held her programme as one holds a rifle, and who had come, he afterward learned, because her sister’s ticket had gone to waste.

He sang *Che gelida manina* to the cabbage.

It is a famous aria, sung by every tenor in the world and murdered by half. He did not sing it as it was written, for it had never before been sung by a man who had just been told the truth. He sang it quietly, and plainly, with no scarf in the voice, to one astonished woman in a

hat; and on certain nights in an opera house the eleven hundred stop being a crowd and become one person, listening. By the end of the first verse the cabbage was weeping unreservedly into her programme. By the second, so was the whole third row. By the last note, held a beat longer than any tenor has dared since the war, there was not a dry eye from the gallery to the pit, except the critic's, which were never dry, he being a man of principle.

In the interval the usher boy found Marco in the wings, still in his socks, with his hands over his face.

"Maestro. The lady in the cabbage hat says it was not a *performance.* She says, 'He sang as though I were the only one.'"

"She *was,*" said Marco Bellini, and began, quietly and helplessly, to laugh.

That night, at a table in a café in Via Mazzini, with Enzo asleep across three chairs and the street shining with fog, he wrote a letter on a napkin. It said: *I did as you said. I sang to a lady in a cabbage. It was the best night of my life. Who ARE you?*

He sent it to the wall at dawn.

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SCENE III

Mexico City. Colonia Doctores, at midday, in the dry bright cold of a February noon. A trail of blue footprints on the pavement, and three people following it.

The wall on the Calle Zacatecas had opened its eyes in November, and the city had not yet recovered.

She looked out over the Colonia Roma from thirty feet up with her book lowered and her face lifted, and her eyes, brown with a ring of green, were fixed on something just over the rooftops that nobody could see. Offerings had multiplied at her feet: marigolds, pencils, and a hand-lettered card that said *THANK YOU FOR LOOKING UP.* The critics, who had spent two years calling her *La Lectora,* had begun, unsure, to call her *La Que Mira.*

The painter had not been seen since.

"He is *unwell,*" Marisol García had told Camila, on the telephone, in December, and twice in January. "He has an affliction. It is called *Finishing.* It is very common in artists. They do the thing, and the thing is done, and they sit on a bucket."

"Where?" said Camila.

"Mija, I am a woman of honour. I could not possibly say. But if I were a woman of *less* honour, I would observe that he has not washed his boots, and a man who leaves cobalt footprints wishes, in his heart, to be followed."

It was a clue, and Camila knew a clue when one was left on a plate.

"They go this way," said Alejandro Hernández.

He was in civilian clothes, which made him look like a policeman disguised as a larger policeman. He had been suspended since the matter of the jaw, under Article

Forty-One, and spent his leisure saving for a small farm in Oaxaca where he intended to keep goats and be, at last, unarguably in charge of something. Meanwhile he had attached himself to Camila like a retired bloodhound. "A trail of paint is the oldest evidence there is. I have not *tracked* you. I have *accompanied the investigation.*"

"He is a very good tracker," said Lupita Hernández, twenty-five, chef, round-faced and unalarmable, who had come along from Xochimilco with a covered pan of chilaquiles, on the principle that every crisis is improved by a second breakfast. "He walked into three lamp-posts and apologised to none."

"The lamp-posts were in the way," said Alejandro.

The blue footprints went six blocks, faint and then fainter, and ended, as such trails do, at a roller shutter in a back street behind a tyre shop, with a hand-painted sign above it that said *TORTILLAS: SE VENDE,* the last word crossed out, and below it a single marigold the size of a cartwheel, in a hand too enormous to be anyone's but his.

The shutter was half raised. Camila ducked under it.

It was an old tortillería, high and bare, with light falling through clerestory windows onto a floor of buckets and rags, a great copper comal black with ancient masa, and a tortilla press that now held in its iron jaws a bouquet of brushes. And on the walls—

She stopped.

On every wall, on every inch of whitewashed brick from the floor to the rafters, pinned, taped, drawn in charcoal and chalk and ink, hung eyes.

There were hundreds. They were green and grey and black; they were violet, they were amber; there was a pair of deep clear blue with tiny stars in the iris, and a pair like two coins of old gold, and a pair that were frankly alarming. They looked down, up, aslant, sidelong, closed; they looked at nothing and at everything. A little card was pinned beside each, in a quick, impatient hand: *No. No. Too kind. No. A liar's. NO.* There were two hundred and twelve pairs, and not one of them was brown.

On a stool at the long table in the middle of the room, with his back to the door, sat Rafael Ortega, in a shirt he had apparently been wearing for a week, looking at a blank sheet of paper.

"I do not want any tamales, Marisol," he said, without turning round.

"I haven't brought any," said Camila.

He was on his feet before he knew it. The stool went over. He stood with his hands open and a dab of ochre on his chin, and the whole large impulsive weather of him went across his face and found no place to land.

"You *found* it," said Rafael.

"It is not a difficult mystery. You were walking about in cobalt." She came slowly down the aisle between the walls of eyes. She did not look at them. She looked at him. "Marisol says you are afflicted."

“I am not afflicted. I am—” He gestured helplessly at the walls. “You opened your eyes. It was the best morning of my life. And then I came home and there was nothing left to be. For two years I had a thing to do. I got up in the dark for it. I climbed ladders. I was fined by a man in a moustache. And then you went up the scaffold and put in one line of brown, and the whole wall looked at the city, and the city loved her at once, and I thought: *She does not need me. She has her own eyes now.*” He swallowed. “I came here to paint yours properly. Once. For myself. And I have been trying for three months, and look.”

He pointed to the wall. Two hundred and twelve pairs of eyes looked back at both of them.

“I know what colour they are. I know the green ring. I can paint a face thirty feet high from memory. But the moment I paint *these,* they look at the wall, as I always made them look, and they are *wrong.* They never look at *me.* It is the one thing I have never painted.” He laughed, helplessly. “It is a matter of *nerve.*”

There was a long silence in the old factory, in which a pigeon moved on a rafter, and Lupita quietly lifted the lid of the chilaquiles, and Alejandro Hernández took out a large white handkerchief and blew his nose with a sound like a cavalry charge.

“I am here in a private capacity,” said the former Comandante thickly. “As a chaperone.”

Camila took off her coat. She took from her bag the heaviest book she owned, a Constitution in black buckram, and dragged the stool upright with her foot, and

sat on it, in the light of the clerestory, with her hair coming out of its pencil.

“Paint me,” she said.

“Camila—”

“Not a wall. Not thirty feet. *This.*” She opened the book, and bent her head to it, and then lifted her eyes over the top of the page, and looked at him, straight, without any flinching whatever. “I am told I read with the face of a woman who is being robbed. I am going to read Article Six, on the freedom of expression, and you are going to be looked at. For as long as it takes. I am extremely disciplined. I can hold still for hours.”

He did not move. Then he took the blank paper from the table with a hand that shook only a little, found a stick of charcoal, and sat down on an upturned bucket of white, facing her.

“Don’t talk,” said Rafael.

“I will read aloud.”

“Don’t *move.*”

“I am not moving.”

He drew. She read. The charcoal went across the paper with a small dry sound, and the light slid slowly down the wall of two hundred and twelve wrong eyes. And in the doorway, a chef and a suspended policeman, who had been told to leave and had not, held a pan of cold chilaquiles between them like a sacrament, and watched a young man learn how it felt to be looked at, and a young woman, for the first time in her life, to look back.

It took four hours. Alejandro cried twice. At the end Rafael held up the paper, and it was not a mural, and it was not the face on a hundred and three walls. It was small, and quick, and a little crooked: a girl with a book and a raised eyebrow, looking straight out of the page at the person who held the charcoal, with an expression of the most intelligent and suspicious tenderness.

The eyes were brown. They had a ring of green.

They were, he said, in a voice he had not used before, the first he had ever got right.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., against Entries 0516, 0504, 0121 and 0299:

Nine out of ten letters to a wall ask the same question: will she answer?
She did. And in another city a painter, who has looked at one face for two years, is at last looked at.
There is no such thing as an unanswered letter.
There are only the ones still on their way.

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End of Chapter 18.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 19: Press Pass

“The flood took my academy and I smile so the boys will not weep.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0888

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE I

Karachi. The Korangi creek road, ten o’clock on a winter morning, which in that city means a bright, dusty, forgiving twenty-two degrees. A field the colour of dry porridge. A roller sunk to its axle. Eleven boys, one man, and an aunt in sunglasses.

The flood had come in August, and had left in September, and had taken, in the interval, one cricket pitch, two sets of nets, a pavilion made of corrugated iron and optimism, and the entire stock of the Salt Creek Cricket Academy: nineteen bats, forty-one balls, and a trophy for the Under-Fourteen Tape-Ball Cup, won in 2016 and never forgotten.

What it had left was silt. It lay across the ground in a grey crust, cracked like the glaze of an old plate, and out of it, at the far end, there rose, like a mast from a wreck, a single wicket.

“*Six!*” cried Hamza Qureshi.

“It was *not* a six, Coach!” said Waqar Shah, eleven, from the crease, in a cap with FEAR NOBODY sewn across the front. “It went into the mud!”

“It went into the mud *beyond the boundary.* By the Laws of Cricket, as amended by me this morning, that is a six.”

“You amended the Laws?”

“I am an *academy.* We have the authority.”

Hamza was twenty-nine, tall and thin and bronze, with the unbreakable grin of one who had decided in the second week of September to be cheerful, and had been, with the grim ferocity of a soldier holding a bridge, ever since. He wore a cap that had been white, and carried a bat recovered from a drain in one hand and a spade in the other, and moved among the boys like a shepherd among sheep who have not been told that the barn has burned down.

From a folding chair at the edge of the field, under a striped umbrella, in a pair of enormous white sunglasses that she had not removed since 1998, Ayesha Raza, fifty-four, retired schoolteacher, self-appointed scorer and commentator of the academy, lowered a dog-eared exercise book and called, in a voice that carried over three acres:

“*Eleven runs, the Qureshi boy, off four balls! A boundary! An extraordinary stroke!*”

“I did not hit anything,” said Waqar.

“I am recording *potential.*”

She was a woman of undeniable charm who had never in her life spent less than she did not have. She kept the scorebook in a handwriting that no one could read, herself included, for it was an open secret in Korangi that Ayesha Aunty had never learned to read. She had taught for thirty years by memory, reciting every lesson aloud, with the textbook held open before her at an angle of great authority; and nobody had ever had the cruelty to point out that it was upside down.

At the gate, at that moment, a small blue rickshaw stopped, and a young woman got down.

She was twenty-seven, short, quick, in a dusty-green kurta and sneakers that had been white at the start of the week, with a camera bag on one shoulder and, round her neck, a laminated pass that read PRESS. She had the face of a person who has been told *Wait* all her life and has never once done it. She looked at the silt, the roller, the wicket and the man with the spade, and took out a notebook.

"Mr. Hamza Qureshi?"

"That depends," said Hamza, "on who is asking. If it is the creditors, I am my brother."

"Sana Ahmed. *The Sahil Daily.*" She did not smile. She held up the lanyard like a warrant. "I am doing a story on the flood. I'd like twenty minutes."

"The flood is old news."

"The flood," said Sana, "is the only news in this city that has not been told *properly.*"

✦ ✦ ✦

It took her forty minutes. He gave her tea from a flask, and the story the way he gave everything: with a joke, a shrug and a smile. The water had come at four in the morning, when the nullah backed up. The boys had come in the dark and stood at the fence, holding their bats. He had waded in to his chest to save the trophy and had come out holding a plastic chair.

"I saved the *chair,*" he said. "It was a very good chair."

"Mr. Qureshi."

"Hamza. 'Mr. Qureshi' is my father, and he is in Dubai."

"Hamza." She had not written a word. She was standing at the edge of the old drainage channel that ran along the north boundary of the field, looking at a thing that he had walked past a hundred times. "This channel. It used to run to the creek?"

"For fifty years."

"And now?"

"Now it runs to a *signboard.*"

"What signboard?"

"SALT CREEK DREDGING: A GIFT OF THE PROVINCE. They put it up in March. A yellow machine came and sat on the bank for two weeks, and went away. The signboard stayed. I asked the foreman, 'Brother, when does the machine come back?' He said it was a very advanced machine that worked from a distance." Hamza laughed, a short, unbothered laugh. "The water came in August. It had not been told."

Sana Ahmed stood quite still. The wind lifted the corner of her notebook and set it down.

“Who signed for it?”

“A company, with a very long name. A gentleman came to cut a ribbon.” His face had closed, very slightly, like a window against weather. “Miss Ahmed. I do not wish to be in the newspaper. I wish to have a *pitch.* I am not a man who can fight the world. I am a man who can roll a field.”

“Eleven boys,” said Sana, in a voice suddenly less sharp, “will be playing on silt in March, and a signboard will be standing dry.”

“Then I shall teach them to bat in mud.” He lifted the bat to his shoulder with a flourish. “It is practically a *moral education.*”

She did not argue. When it mattered she could look at a man making a joke, and let him; almost nobody knew it of her. She wrote in her notebook, in a fast, forward-slanting hand, *Dredging. Signboard. March. No machine.* She wrote, below it, in smaller letters, *He smiles with his mouth only.* Then she thanked him and walked out through the gate.

Across the road, in the shade of a neem tree, a grey Corolla was parked. It had been parked there the previous day, and the day before. The window was down a hand’s breadth. Behind it, someone was not looking at her very carefully.

She did not look back. She put on her sunglasses, set her shoulders as her mother had taught her, and walked, at the pace of a woman with nothing whatsoever on her

mind, to the end of the road to hail a rickshaw.

It is nothing, said Sana to herself. *The network has been down all week. That is why the phone rings and nobody speaks.*

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By four, the boys had gone. The long light had come across the field the colour of a ripe mango, and in it, on the rim of the old iron roller, with his cap in his hands and his elbows on his knees, sat the coach of the Salt Creek Cricket Academy.

He was not smiling.

He did not know she had come back for her pen. She stood at the gate and saw him for a full minute, in the place where nobody was watching: a man of twenty-nine with his whole face let go, as if he had set down a heavy sack at the end of a long road. His mouth moved, and he said one word, quietly, in Urdu, and it was not a joke.

She walked across the crust of the field, and sat down beside him on the roller, and without a word held out her steel flask, with the tea still hot in it. He took it. He did not ask why she had come back. He drank. For some time they watched the sun go down over the creek.

“You tell it very well,” said Sana, at last.

“What?”

“The cheerfulness.”

“It is not a *performance.*”

“It is a *very good* one.”

He gave a short exhausted laugh and handed back the flask. “If I stop,” said Hamza Qureshi, “they will see. And if they see, they will stop. A boy will play as long as the coach believes in the pitch. It is the only rule I know.” He looked at his hands. “I would be grateful if you did not write that.”

“I do not write what I am not asked to.”

“Then what will you write?”

“The truth,” said Sana. “About the creek.”

“It will be a very dangerous truth.”

“All the good ones are.” She stood, brushing the dust off her kurta. In the long golden light her face was resolute and young, and not afraid, with the unfear of one who has practised it. “Hamza, I will tell you what I tell everyone. I am not afraid of anything. It is a *professional* quality. I have it as other people have a nose.”

“I am sure you have.”

“Good.”

She went. At the gate she paused, and looked once at the car under the neem tree, and then at the man on the roller, and then at the car again. In the dusk, the sky overhead was the dark red of a pomegranate. In the cabin of the Corolla, the little light of a cigarette went out.

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SCENE II

Istanbul. The Üsküdar pier, on the Asian shore, a quarter to eight on a grey December morning, the colour of a pigeon's wing. Gulls. Steam. Two ferries moored nose to tail, each flying its own house flag, and a queue of commuters between them like a river between two armies.

The feud over the Bosphorus lines had run, with intervals for weddings and funerals, for thirty-one years. It concerned a licence, a landing and a promise made by a dead man on a napkin, and it had cost both families, in lawyers and spite, roughly the price of a ferry.

On the left of the quay lay the red boats of the Yılmaz line, on the right the blue boats of the Kaya, and between them, as it had always done, stood a plank-built café with a chimney, a samovar, and a cook.

"*Soup,*" said Sema.

She was a broad, magnificent woman of fifty-one, in an apron the size of a sail, who had served lentil soup to both houses for twenty-eight years on the principle that a man with a full bowl cannot also throw a punch. She stood at the open hatch, ladle raised like a sceptre. "You, Captain's boy, you have not eaten. You, Kaya, you are green. I do not care whose boat you sail. Leave the quarrel on the hook with the coat. *Sit.*"

Ahmed Yılmaz, twenty-eight, the son of the Yılmaz line's old captain, sat. He was a strong, dark, impatient young man in a wool coat and a deckhand's cap, with a split in his knuckle and a stare that kept going, whenever it was not watched, to the small glass-walled ticket office on the right of the quay.

“You are looking at the *wall,*” said Sema.

“I am looking at the timetable.”

“It is a very pretty timetable. It has a girl in it.” “Eat your soup, Ahmed bey. In my experience a man who looks that long at a ticket office is not buying a ticket.”

The first sign of trouble was the rope. Ahmed saw it before he knew he saw it: a pale mooring-line on the Kaya side drawn tight, a flash of blade, and a long slack coil sliding into the black water like a snake. The blue ferry, loosed from her post, swung on the current with her gangway still down, and a Kaya deckhand, halfway along the plank with a crate of oranges, went into the Bosphorus with an enormous, shocked, orange-scattering splash.

“*They have cut us loose!*” a voice roared.

“*They have* rammed *us!*”

It was not true, but in a feud the truth has no vote. Within ten seconds the quay was a tangle of fists and boots, tea-trays flung like discs and a mooring-hook swung at arm’s length; and in the middle of it Ahmed’s cousin Cem Koç, forty, apprentice, who had never been afraid of anything but a debt, drove a shoulder into the nearest chest and was at once knocked flat among the fishing-nets.

Ahmed did not fight. He ran to the edge of the quay. The deckhand was in the water, and the water in December was nine degrees. The man had gone under once, and came up gasping, white as paper, his arms flailing at the oranges. There was no time to remove a

coat. Ahmed Yılmaz, son of the house that had sworn to ruin the Kayas, took off his cap, put it carefully on a bollard, and dived.

He caught the man by the collar and towed him, kicking, to the foot of the iron ladder, and shoved him up it into a forest of hands. As he turned, something struck him on the side of the head from above, a mooring-hook, flung and not aimed, and he went down in the green water with a bright burst of red.

When he came up, hauled by the coat by two men in two colours who had suddenly forgotten which they were, there was blood in his eye, and the quay had gone quite quiet. The brawlers stood as if turned to stone. Not one of the Kaya had said *thank you.* But not one of them had struck again.

From the little glass booth on the right, a figure had come out and stood at the end of the planking. She had a ticket-punch in one hand and no coat. Her hair had come out of its pins. She was twenty-six, quick, dark-browed, slight as a quill, with ink on her fingers that was not from tickets, and she put the back of her free hand to her mouth, and looked at the man in the water, who was looking at her.

There was a great deal in that look, and not all of it was fright.

"*Elif!*" shouted a voice from the Kaya side, her uncle's, harsh and cracked. "*Inside!*"

She went in. But a minute after, as the police boat came round the point with its useless siren and the two families dragged their hurt away in two directions, a boy

of fourteen in a school blazer, a tray of simit hung round his neck, who had stood throughout on a bollard with his mouth wide open, slid down and crossed the quay as if on an errand of no interest to anyone. He pressed into the bleeding hand of Ahmed Yılmaz a ticket for the 8:15 to Karaköy.

"A lady asked me to give you a ticket," said Burak, who read books and feared the telephone and was, therefore, a perfect messenger. "She says the fare is paid."

On the back, in a small, quick, dark hand, was written:

You dived, and did not ask whose son he was, And I, who sell the tickets, know because The boat is blue; the boy is on the red. The fare you paid tonight I'll pay instead. The feud's a rope. Let others cut it through; I'll tie one knot from my side. Tie from you. The boat is blue; the boy is on the red. Come back alive. That is all I have said.

Ahmed read it twice, with the blood running into his collar. Then he folded it and put it inside his coat, against his heart, where a man in his condition keeps the things he means to die with; and, since a constable was shouting about a statement, he had just time to look once more toward the little glass booth, in which the light had gone out.

"Soup," said Sema, in his ear, and a bowl was in his hands, hot as a small sun. "*Eat.* I told you. Leave it on the hook."

I have done what I have done, thought Ahmed. *And now I know what the price will be.*

He was, as the reader may already perceive, right.

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SCENE III

Cairo. The conservation laboratory in the basement of the Museum of Islamic Art, at the hour of the afternoon call. Three muezzins overlapping through the grating, none in agreement. The smell of shellac, acetone and hibiscus tea.

"I will not be told," said Sherif Sabry, "that I have been *deceived.*"

He stood in the middle of the laboratory in a cream suit and a cravat, holding a blue-green vase in both arms like an infant who had misbehaved. He was seventy-two, the greatest novelist in Egypt by his own account, and the author of eleven books that nobody had read, which he held to be the secret of his genius. "I am a student of human nature. I have never been fooled by a man who sells things."

"It is cracked from the lip to the shoulder," said Layla Mansour, taking it from him as one takes a patient from a relative.

"It fell off a shelf."

"It was pushed," said Dina Shaker, fourteen, Official Sweeper and Unofficial Witness, from the corner, without looking up from her broom.

"Dina."

"The *shelf* is saying nothing."

Layla, thirty-two, held the vase under the lamp. She was a woman of exact movements and a dry tongue, who kept her emotions in a locked drawer and could tell the age of a glaze by the sound it made under her fingernail. The vessel was a deep turquoise over fine pale clay, with a band of Kufic round the shoulder and a web of crazing, delicate as frost, over the whole. It was said to be Mamluk. It had been bought, the professor said, the spring before, in the Khan, for his granddaughter's wedding, from an honest man who had never lied to him in his life.

"Which honest man?"

"Haddad and Sons. A charming fellow. He has no sons, but he has *lovely* manners."

The room went quiet. In the three-way quarrel of the minarets, one muezzin paused for breath.

Layla set the vase on the bench, turned off the lamp, and clicked on the ultraviolet. In the blue dark the whole body of the vessel glowed, as a fraud does under an honest light: the crazing was too regular, the Kufic too even, and the glaze, which should have gone dull and chalky with age, shone with the pale violet of something made last year. And in the heart of the glaze, so fine that she would have missed it had she not spent a winter learning a certain man's hand, there was a pinprick of a different green.

It was her mixture. A copper-green she had devised herself on a bad night in a bad winter, and once, at a stall in the Khan, over a glass of mint tea, in a moment of weakness, described.

He was listening, she thought. *Even then.*

She turned the vase over. Under the foot, where a collector never looks, there was nothing. No grain of thuluth, no needle-point of apology. She had held a brass pen-box in this room in November, and under its lid a man had cut, in letters smaller than rice, the whole of his heart. This vase had come from before. It was the last of his forgeries that did not say sorry.

"Professor," said Layla. "It is a very beautiful vase. It is not Mamluk. It is fourteen months old."

There was a pause of great length, in which a novelist who had never been read was read, for the first time, aloud, by an ultraviolet lamp.

"*Impossible,*" said Sherif Sabry.

"It is a first-class copy, by a gifted man. I will mend the crack, and I will not charge you. And I think that you should give it to your granddaughter, and tell her exactly what it is. She will love it better for the honesty."

"And the *man?*" The professor drew himself up. "The rogue! The *scoundrel!* I shall have the law—"

"He will return your money," said Layla, "in person. With an apology. In whatever script you prefer."

"He is a charlatan."

"He is a *retired* charlatan. He has been learning." She took up the little brush and the pot of tinted fill, and began, slowly, to close the long crack, with a hand that did not shake at all. A green line followed the bristles, thin as a hair, as if the glaze had never been broken. "It is a slow subject."

When the professor had gone, trailing indignation and a faint smell of cologne, Dina Shaker leaned on her broom with the hungry patience of a girl who has been told not to listen.

"Is it a love letter?" she said.

Layla had taken a card from the bench, and written on it in her exact upright hand:

Mr. Haddad. A client of yours holds a vase that predates your honesty. It bears no apology. Please supply one, in person, before Thursday, at the Museum, with the receipt. Provenance required. — L.M.

"It is a summons."

"It is a love letter."

"It is a very *formal* one," said Layla Mansour; and her mouth, for the second time in three years, did something that Dina would swear to on the Qur'an, and the Gospels, and the Constitution, and the broom.

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Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., against Entries 0888, 0343, 0211, 0732 and 0666:

A coach who smiles so the boys will not weep; a woman who is not afraid, as other people have a nose; a boy who dives without asking whose son he saves, and a girl who keeps tickets for the sea; a restorer who mends the lie and signs the truth.
Of these, two will be hurt before the winter is over.
I will not say which. The Keeper does not choose;
she merely counts.

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End of Chapter 19.

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Chapter 20: The Border at Dawn

“I once looked away and let a child cross.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0032

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SCENE I

Sofia. The Central Bus Station, ten past five on a December morning. Frost on the tram wires. A kiosk with its light on, like a small lit stage in a very large dark theatre.

At the corner of the Central Bus Station stands a kiosk that opens before the trams do. It belongs to Radka Petrov, forty-nine, who has never sold a newspaper without reading it first, nor a banitsa without informing the buyer what was wrong with his marriage.

“You are not married,” she said to the man at the head of the queue.

“No,” said Nikolai Ivanov.

“A married man buys two pastries and eats one in the street, where his wife cannot see. You have bought one, and you hold it like a document.”

He was thirty-eight, a senior sergeant of the Border Police, long and grey in a greatcoat the colour of wet slate, with the face of someone who had been awake, in one way or another, since a particular night nine years before.

"I have a niece," said Radka. "Stand there and eat. I am doing Sofia."

For a month the whole city had been reading the Register of Black Stars, and Radka had made herself its town crier. Each dawn she propped her phone against the till, put on the reading glasses she wore on a chain like a mayoral decoration, and read to her queue whatever the Register held under *Sofia.* There were nine entries. She had learned them as other women learn hymns.

"Number thirty-two," she announced. "*'I once looked away, and let a child cross.'*"

Nikolai, who had just bitten into the pastry, discovered that he could not swallow it.

"A border guard," said a taxi driver, who had come for cigarettes and stayed for the theology. "Who else lets children cross?"

"A man like that," said Radka, her glasses sliding down her nose, "should be *married.* Nine years he has carried it in his pocket like a stone. That is a conscience. In Bulgaria we have so few that we should keep them in a museum, with a guard." She turned the page. "And this one has a story in it. Number five hundred thirty-four. *'There is a forged passport in my coat for someone I love.'*"

There was a pause, of the kind in which one hears a tram bell three streets away.

“Forged! In *Bulgaria!*”

“What is surprising? Every man in Bulgaria owns two, and one is for show.” The queue laughed; she raised a hand, and it stopped, for she had a sovereign’s ear for a crowd. “But think. A woman, it is a woman, a man would say *wallet,* sits at night with a needle and a magnifying glass, frightened, and does it anyway. That is not a criminal. That is a seamstress with a cause.”

Nikolai set the banitsa down on the lip of the kiosk, carefully, as one sets down something that might be armed. Sixteen years at checkpoints had taught him to look like a wall, and the wall did not move. But in the instant between *forged* and *coat* something went through him, quick as a fish in a dark pond: among the thousands who crossed the western border every week, there might be a woman with a heavy coat folded on her lap.

“You are pale, Sergeant,” said Radka. “It is the pastry. It is meant to be eaten warm, not mourned.” But she was looking at him with a kinder and sharper face. She pushed a second paper bag across the counter, which he had not ordered. “For the checkpoint. Do not eat it. Carry it. A man who carries bread is going to be kind to somebody. It is a rule.”

“I did not know there was such a rule.”

“I have just made it.”

At the door he stopped, and said without turning, so quietly that she might have taken it for a cough: “Entry thirty-two. Did it say anything more?”

“No, Sergeant. Did you want it to?”

“No,” said Nikolai Ivanov. “That was the whole of it.”

And he went off down the frozen platform with a bag of bread against his heart; and Radka, who was no fool, took off her glasses and for the first time in her professional life did not say a word.

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SCENE II

Bergen. An hour behind Sofia, on the same night, some hours before the dawn. Half past eleven. The all-night fish-soup hatch on the harbour front, lit like a small golden ship.

In Bergen the soup is served by a bus driver. Thea Larsen, fifty-one, drove the number twelve by day and ran the fish-soup hatch from ten at night until three, on the principle that both trades consisted of taking wet persons and conveying them somewhere warmer without comment.

“You are going out,” she said to Lars Eriksen, putting a bowl in front of him. “I can tell from the shoulders. A man should not go to sea on an empty stomach and a full opinion.”

Lars ate as if filling a hold. Behind him the rain fell on the harbour in long sideways threads, and the masts swung against the lights of Bryggen like a hundred jostling compass needles. The forecast was a gale at six. The *Ragnhild* lay at her mooring with a new, expensive and inadequate part inside her engine.

“You are not going,” said Marit Strand, arriving in the middle of a sentence, as she always did, in a good coat and a wave of hair that had taken an hour to look careless. She was thirty-eight, a train guard, Kristian’s daughter, and Lars’s friend since the cradle. “—and I said a signal fault is only a man with a lantern who has changed his mind. Lars. You are wearing the Eriksen face, the one where you look carved off the front of a boat.”

“The lines are out. If I lose them, I lose sixty thousand kroner. I owe four hundred and twelve already. I can be there and back in four hours.”

“If nothing happens.”

“Something always happens. It is a question of how much.”

At the end of the zinc, mending a very small and ugly umbrella, sat Solveig Dahl, who sold umbrellas at the Fisketorget by day and kept beneath her bed a tin of savings towards the day she would leave a country with weather in it, and had told no one.

“A storm is not personal,” she observed, to the umbrella. “That is its comfort and its insult.” She held the umbrella up to the lamp. “One goes out to meet the weather with something in one’s hand. It need not *work.* It need only be held.”

“Is that an argument for going,” said Marit, “or against?”

“It is an argument for the umbrella, and I would be obliged if you would buy one.”

The door banged. In came a draught, a puddle, and Sigrid Haugen in her yellow oilskin, with a printout in one hand and, in the other, a borrowed umbrella that the wind had turned inside out. She had run the whole length of Nordnes.

“The front is early,” she said. “Do not say *mm.* I have the buoy at Fedje. Eight metres already, and the wind went northwest an hour ago. It is not six. It is *two.* You will not be there and back in four.”

“I am already dressed.”

“That is not a reason.”

“It is, for me.”

“Cod have no bank, Lars.”

“No,” said Lars Eriksen. “Cod have no *Sigrid.*”

It had not been intended, and nobody could afterward say whom it surprised most. Marit, for once, did not speak. Sigrid’s face went through five stages in a heartbeat and ended a very dark red.

“That is not an argument,” she said. “It is worse than an argument.”

“Yes. I know. I have to go.”

From the dark under the awning came the voice of a waiter, old and dry. “Your table will be kept, young master.”

Kristian Strand stood there, seventy-eight, with a napkin over his left forearm, having come down from his flat because he had heard the wind change, as old waiters can hear a kitchen from three streets off. He had never

in his life said *be careful.* He said, with the severity of one who has laid ten thousand tables and never been thanked for a clean cloth: “The soup will be hot at eight. I shall not hold it past nine.”

“Far—”

“I lied to you once, about where I was the night your mother died. I was at the restaurant, laying a table, because I could not bear the room. It is a poor sort of father who must wait for a gale to say it. *Nine,* young master.”

Lars laid coins on the counter for a soup he had not finished, as a man does when his throat has closed and his hands want work. Then he went out into the rain, and Sigrid watched until the dark had him.

“I shall go to the institute,” she said. “We have a radio.”

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SCENE III

The sea off Hernar. Ten minutes to two in the morning. Nothing is visible but weather.

There are storms that come like an army, with a horn and a drum, and storms that come as a hand laid flat across a table. This was the second kind, and at ten minutes to two it swept the sea clean.

The *Ragnhild* stood on her tail and fell. A grey slope of water with a white beard came out of the dark and went over her like a congregation. Lars was hurled against the bulkhead and hauled himself back by the spokes.

Below, the engine coughed once, and coughed again, and then, with the courtesy of a good servant leaving a ruined house, stopped.

Reader, a man alone in a wheelhouse with a dead engine has the right to say what he likes. He did not shout. He put his forehead against the streaming glass and spoke as a silent man must, if he is to be trusted: slowly, and in measure.

So here we are, old girl, the pair of us, Miles from anything that has a roof. I owe the bank. I owe my father. I Owe every man who ever told me no And was ignored. I thought the sea was cold And large, and I a man too stubborn drowned. I did not think that she would ask me why. Why did I come? To save a string of lines? No. Because a woman said that cod have no Bank, and I could not bear to be looked at By her, not knowing what to answer. There. I'd rather face the sea than say a word. It is a foolish thing, to be a coward In every way but one, and yet it's mine.

A wave took the starboard rail, and the chart lamp went out.

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In a lit room on the Nordnes peninsula, with the rain going across the windows in white ropes, Sigrid Haugen sat before a radio set that was used, as a rule, to ask research vessels about water temperature. She had spent forty minutes learning it, and nine more watching a single blue dot on a screen, the transponder of a fishing

boat that had crawled away from the harbour and now pulsed in one place, in a field of red. On the wall the buoy trace was no longer a line. It was a saw.

"*Ragnhild,* this is the Institute station at Nordnes. Lars. Come in."

Hiss. And then, in the heart of the static, as a hand comes up through water, a voice she would have known on the far side of the world.

"*Mm.*"

She put her fist against her mouth, and took it away.

"Listen. You are four miles northwest of Hernar light. The swell will turn you beam-on in four minutes unless you put out the sea anchor. West of you is a shoal where the water goes from two hundred metres to forty, and the big waves break on it. You must not go west. When the anchor takes you will drift southeast, and in two hours you will come under the lee of Hernar. It is steep and it is not kind. But there is a light. I have my finger on it."

"*The engine is dead.*"

"I know. I can see everything. It is the only advantage of a scientist: I can see all of it, from a very long way off, and it makes me quite useless." Her voice broke, and she let it. "I would like to be out there, Lars. With you, on that stupid boat, with a bucket."

Static, a long bleat of it, like an animal being turned inside out. Then: "*The anchor is out.*"

"Good. Good, good, good. Tell me something stupid."

"*I owe four hundred and twelve thousand.*"

"Another."

"*My father's soup is at eight.*"

She laughed, wet and helpless. "Another."

"*I have your umbrella,*" said the voice from the sea, very faintly. "*You left it on the boat in November. I did not like to return it. Then there was nothing for you to come back for.*"

Out in the dark a wave taller than the wheelhouse had risen over the bow, and was beginning, with the unhurried manner of a great thing that has all the time in the world, to curl.

"Lars. Listen. I have been offered a post at the top of the world, and I have until the fifteenth of January, and I have not answered, because I have been waiting for someone to ask me not to. It is the stupidest reason in the history of science. I am going to say it now, in case there is no later, because I have counted every plankton in this fjord and the only datum I cannot leave out is—"

In the handset there was a roar like the ending of a world.

Then, in the dead air, with nobody to hear it but a blue dot and a rain-streaked window and a set of instruments built to measure the temperature of water, Sigrid said what she had never said in any language to any living creature, and it was

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Here the page is torn.

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SCENE IV

Kalotina. The Serbian border, sixty kilometres west of Sofia. A quarter to seven, in the grey. The checkpoint stands on a plain of frozen mud, with the Balkan range going up behind it like a long blue wall, and a line of lorries stretching back until it vanishes in its own breath.

The guard room at Kalotina has a stove, three desks, a photograph of a mountain, and a kettle that has been boiling since the Berlin Wall fell.

"Sergeant Ivanov," said a young officer named Georgi, putting his head round the door. "They have brought a family off a lorry. Four. The father speaks only Dari and a little Russian. The legal-aid office has sent a translator on the early bus. Georgieva. They say she is *discreet.* I do not know what that means in a translator. It sounds like a fault."

Nikolai got up. In the paper bag at his elbow lay Radka's second banitsa, uneaten, carried sixty kilometres like a charm.

She stood by the radiator with her hands folded, like one who has spent her life in rooms where she alone understood both sides, and had learned never to speak first. Thirty-four. A narrow quiet face, a high forehead, eyes the colour of a pond under ice. Over a dark dress she wore a long coat of heavy grey wool with the collar up. It was too thick for a heated building, and hung on her with the peculiar weight of a coat with something in the hem.

"Elena Georgieva," she said. "Dari, Russian, Turkish, English. I am told there is a child."

“There is a child,” said Nikolai.

The family sat on a bench in the interview room: a father in a jacket too thin for the country, sitting very straight as though the chair might be taken away; a mother with a bundle in a shawl; and between them, with her feet not reaching the floor, a girl of about eight, staring at the stove.

Nikolai had a rule. He had made it nine years before, on a bridge, and he kept it as one keeps a thorn in a shoe: he did not look at children for long. He asked, through the translator, names, dates, route. Elena rendered each question into a language soft as pebbles in a stream, and gave the answers back with a courtesy so exact that it was almost tenderness. She did not soften what was said, and she did not sharpen it. She stood between two walls, and was the door.

At one point the girl slid off the bench, walked across the room, and put into his hand a crayon drawing on the back of a customs form: a lorry, a house, a very large sun, and a small man in green standing before all of them with an arm outstretched like a bridge.

“She says it is you,” said Elena quietly.

“I have never seen her.”

“She says she has drawn the man who will not hurt them. It is what she has decided. I do not think it is a question of evidence. I think it is a child who has done a great deal of travelling and made up her mind.”

Mark this, reader. Nine years before, on a bridge, a child in a red wool hat had put her hand in his, and he had been told to take her to the office. He had looked in-

stead at the river, for one long minute; and when he turned back the road was empty and a pair of small boots was going up a hill into fog. He has never known if she lived. It is the whole reason he is here, at seven in the morning, holding a crayon sun.

By ten the formalities were done. It was not a victory. It was a kind of decency, which in that country and that year was as much as a decent man could manage before lunch.

In the passage, Elena reached for her coat. It hung on a peg by the stove, and Nikolai, who was nearest, took it down and held it open, as a man will in Bulgaria whether or not he is told it is out of fashion.

It was heavier than a coat should be.

He had searched a good many. He knew what a coat should weigh as a butcher knows a chop; and as it lay across his forearms he felt, in the lower hem on the left side, a flat, narrow, stiffened thing, stitched in with small and perfect stitches, with the faint dry crackle of a document folded very small and sewn very tight.

There is a forged passport in my coat for someone I love.

He did not move. In the long grey instant before the next heartbeat he heard Radka’s voice in the frozen air reading a sentence as if it were the price of tomatoes. He saw a woman at a table by lamplight with a magnifying glass and a needle. He saw a pair of boots going up a hill.

He lifted his eyes. They met hers in the cracked mirror above the radiator; and in her face, trained to give away nothing, there was no fear whatever. There was only quiet, exact attention: the look of a person who has weighed a question for a long time, and means to wait for the answer with her hands at her sides.

She knows, thought Nikolai. *She knows that I know.*

It would have taken eleven seconds. A word to Georgi. A hand on a hem. A table, a knife, a report. He had served sixteen years without once being late to his post, and had been commended, in the second of them, for correctness. In the next room the child was singing to herself in a language he did not know.

"It is a heavy coat," said Nikolai Ivanov.

"It is a heavy season," said Elena.

"The road is icy beyond the gate. Mind the step."

"I shall mind it."

He settled the coat on her shoulders with a care that a stranger might have taken for the manners of a handsome sergeant. His hands did not shake. They were the steadiest they had ever been, which is how he knew that something had been decided, somewhere below the level of his speech.

"Thank you, Sergeant."

"It was nothing."

"No," said Elena Georgieva. "It was not." She buttoned the grey coat to the neck and went out across the frozen yard, past the lorries and the barrier and the little

glass booth, towards the bus. At the corner of the car park she climbed the step, and minded it.

Twice, thought Nikolai. *Now it is twice.*

There is a ledger, reader, kept in the margin of every border in the world: not of the people who cross, but of the people who watch them. It does not hurry, and it does not forget, and it has this in common with the stars, that nobody sees it, and that it bends everything near.

In the paper bag on the desk, the banitsa had gone cold. He ate it standing at the window, to the last crumb.

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Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., against Entries 0032, 0443, 0610 and 0534:

I am asked what became of the boat. I do not know. The sea keeps a ledger of its own and has never allowed me to consult it. I will say only that the page was torn neither by me nor by the one who wrote it. It tears at the place where the reader must begin to hope. That is a kind of rule.

As for the man at the border: he looked away from the law and toward the person. It is a sin of the second order, and it is paid for in winter. It will be paid in this one.

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End of Chapter 20.

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Chapter 21: Saxophone Radio

“I dedicate one song each night to a man I have never met.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0749

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SCENE I

Johannesburg. A radio station in Auckland Park, eleven at night, in the second week of December. A highveld thunderstorm has just finished, leaving the streets steaming and the whole city smelling of rain on hot tar.

The name Naledi means *star,* and her mother had chosen it in the hope that it would make her bright. It had made her nervous. Naledi Khumalo, twenty-nine, host of *The Last Dedication* on Goldreef FM, had spent her whole life being introduced as a celestial body, and had accordingly developed the voice of a woman who would very much prefer to be a lamp.

It was a wonderful voice. It was warm, and wry, and low, and it sounded like someone who has just taken off her shoes and wishes you to do the same. From eleven until one, six nights a week, it travelled across the Reef to taxi drivers, night nurses, security guards in their glass booths, bakers beginning their shift in Soweto, and

a great many people who were simply awake and ashamed of it. And every night she was on the air, at a quarter to midnight, it said the same thing.

“This one,” said Naledi into the microphone, “goes out, as it has gone out every night for two winters, to the man behind the door on Kerk Street. I heard you once from the back of a minibus taxi at one in the morning. I did not see your face. I did not get your name. I only know that you were playing a tenor saxophone as if you were trying to talk a person down from a ledge. Wherever you are, this is for you.” She slid the fader. “Nina Simone. Try to sleep.”

“Naledi,” said a voice in her headphones.

“Yes, Thandi.”

“That is the six-hundredth time you have said that.”

“I counted too.”

“It is not a dedication any more. It is a *haunting.*”

This was Thandi Zulu, thirty, of Pretoria, who sold *amagwinya,* the golden fried dough-balls of the Highveld, from a trolley at the station gate until ten each night, and who had by degrees, and without a contract, become the programme’s call screener. Her qualifications were an enormous appetite for gossip and a belief that no problem existed which could not be improved with a fritter. She had been known to refuse a caller “because he has the voice of a man who is lying about his mother.”

“You will say something wise, now,” said Naledi. “You usually do, by accident.”

“I never say anything by accident.” Thandi, in the glass booth, wiped sugar from her fingers. “I say it on purpose and let it look like an accident, so the people will not be cross. Tonight I say: it is not the man who has to be found. It is the *door*.”

“What door?”

“The one in your head,” said Thandi Zulu. “Now read the Register. They have been calling since ten. They want the Johannesburg page.”

This was true. For five weeks the whole country had been reading the thousand letters, and Goldreef had set aside a corner of the show for the confessions that belonged to the Reef. Naledi did not much care for it. She had her own entry in the Register, number seven hundred and forty-nine, and so read other people’s secrets on the air for a living while hers lay in the same ledger, pretending to be someone else’s.

She pulled the laptop toward her.

“Johannesburg,” said Naledi. “Entry four hundred and sixty-six.”

She read it as she read everything, as if it were a letter that had come to her personally.

“‘I play every night for a voice I only know from the radio.’”

Then she stopped.

On the air, a gap opened.

It was an ordinary gap, the length of a breath, and then it was not ordinary. It was two seconds. Then five. In the glass booth, Thandi’s mouth fell open. In the con-

trol room, the engineer, a young man named Siya who had never in his life met *dead air,* turned the colour of old chewing gum and began to make small circular signs with his hand, which in his profession means *for the love of God.*

Reader, there is no horror in broadcasting like silence. A voice on the radio is a rope, and the whole country is holding the other end.

"I am so sorry," said Naledi at last, in a voice that came from a very long way off. "I am told that silence costs money. I am afraid I have just spent some."

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Four kilometres away, in a basement club in Braamfontein called the Blue Rand, a man in a dark waistcoat knelt in the dressing room and picked a reed off the floor.

Thabo Dlamini, thirty-one, tenor saxophonist, had been smooth and unflappable on a stage since the age of six. Offstage he had the manner of a child left in a shop and waiting to be collected. He listened to the radio every night between sets, on a small cracked transistor with a coat hanger for an aerial, the dial fixed on Goldreef. He did not explain to himself why. He told himself it was the news.

The reed had fallen because his hand had opened.

"Tha," said his friend, Jabu Mokoena, twenty-nine, who played the drums, kept a spaza shop in the afternoons, and had been known to confuse the two, selling a customer a snare drum for bread. "You have gone grey."

“She said it.”

“Who said what?”

“On the radio. She read it. *I play every night for a voice I only know from the radio.* That is mine. I wrote it. Two winters ago, in the kitchen, at four in the morning.” He stood up, very slowly. “And she *stopped.*”

“Sho. Johannesburg has four million people.”

“Four million people do not play every night for her.”

“You do not know that it is her.”

“I know the silence,” said Thabo. “It is the silence that comes in a bar when you reach a note you were not sure you would reach.” He picked up the saxophone. It was old and dented, the lacquer worn to the brass where his fingers rested, and it hung from his neck like a very large and very patient animal. “I am going to telephone.”

“The station?”

“I am going to the alley, because I will not be able to say it indoors.”

“Say *what?*”

“I do not know. That is why I am taking the saxophone.”

✦ ✦ ✦

In the alley behind the Blue Rand there was a dustbin, a cat, a lamp, and the smell of the storm still rising off the stones. He leaned against the wall and spoke, because the dark and the horn and the hour were all that

he possessed; and a man who cannot be eloquent in company will often, alone, manage a few lines that do very well:

I have played to a stranger's silence for two years,
And called it practice. Every night I turn The
cracked dial to her voice, and then I blow The thing
I cannot say through twenty inches Of brass, and
hope it finds her through the wall. I never thought
the wall would answer back. And now it has, and I
am shaking like A boy who has been shouting down
a well And hears, at last, a voice that says his name.
What if she hears the man and not the music? The
horn is brave. The man behind it, not. The horn can
climb a ledge and talk one down. The man can
hardly buy a loaf of bread Without rehearsing what
to say to the baker. No matter. Dial. Let it ring. Let
it ring.

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"Goldreef FM," said a cheerful voice. "Thandi speaking. The station is experiencing a *moment.*"

"I would like to speak to Naledi."

"Everybody would. Who is it?"

"I do not wish to say."

"A man with no name." Thandi looked through the glass at the host, who sat quite motionless, hands in her lap, headphones half off. "What do you want to tell her?"

"I do not know. I play the saxophone."

Thandi Zulu was not a sentimental woman. She had sold *amagwinya* through three recessions and a transport strike. But she put one floury hand over the receiver, and she turned, and she said, quite softly, to the engineer: “Siya. Put line three on the air.”

“We do not put callers on without a—”

“Siya,” said Thandi, “I am going to ask you to do a thing you will tell your grandchildren.”

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“Line three,” said Naledi, to the microphone and to nobody. Her voice, which had always carried a smile, had had it knocked out of it. “You are on Goldreef. You are on the air. Do you have a name?”

A pause. Then, over the crackle of an alley and a cat and a distant taxi hooter, a man’s voice, low and a little unsteady, said, “Call me a Johannesburg.”

“A Johannesburg.”

“It is the only name I am sure of.”

“Mr. Johannesburg.” She had to stop; when she resumed, her voice was a good deal smaller. “I read an entry tonight. Number four hundred and sixty-six. I stopped because I thought—I did not know if it—” She gave an unsteady laugh. “I am a professional. I am a woman who has read the weather for eleven years.”

“I know. I have been listening. Every night, between sets. I have a transistor with a coat hanger. It is the only thing I own that I have never had to repair.”

The whole of the Reef, that night, in its taxis and its glass booths and its kitchens, was listening. It was afterward estimated, by people who like to know such things, that four hundred and eleven thousand persons heard the next two minutes, and that four of them were in the same room.

“Where do you play?” said Naledi.

“There is a door on Kerk Street.”

She put her hand over her mouth.

“It is the stage door of the Blue Rand,” said the man. “A green door. It does not close properly. It was blue once. There was a taxi in the road at one in the morning, with its window open, in July, and I was playing a thing called ‘In a Sentimental Mood,’ badly, because it was cold. I did not see who was in it.”

“It was me.”

“I know. I did not know. I have known since tonight.”

“I have been dedicating songs,” said Naledi Khumalo, “to a *door,* for two years.”

“It is a very good door.”

She laughed. It was a lovely laugh, a little wet, the laugh of someone who has carried a heavy parcel and been told, quite unexpectedly, where to set it down. Behind the glass Thandi Zulu was weeping into a sugar-covered handkerchief and making no attempt to hide it.

“Would you play for me?” said Naledi. “I mean now. I do not mean at the club. I mean—you have the saxophone.”

“It is in my hands.”

“Then play.”

There was a long moment. In the dark of the alley, on the far side of a telephone, a man put a mouthpiece to his lips and a phone to the bell of his horn, which is not how it is done, and which has no support in the literature. And then, in the studio of Goldreef FM and in four hundred thousand rooms, there came a sound that is hard to describe to anyone who was not there. It was low, and unhurried, and full of a particular breathless courage. It sounded like a man standing at the edge of something, deciding. It climbed. It was exactly, as she had once said, the sound of someone talking a person down from a ledge; and when it reached its last note, which it held, and held, and then let go in a long soft fall like a hand being opened, nobody in Johannesburg said a word.

The engineer, Siya, discovered that he had stopped making signs.

“Thank you,” said Naledi.

“It is nothing.”

“It is not nothing. It is—” She drew a breath. “May I meet you?”

It was the question. The whole city waited.

“Not yet,” said Thabo.

“Not—”

“I would like to. I want to, more than I have wanted to do any ordinary thing. But I know myself. I am a very good saxophonist and a rather poor man. If you came to

the green door tomorrow you would find somebody who rehearses what he will say to a baker." A breath, with something like a laugh in it. "I have a piece, Naledi. I have been writing it for two winters. It is not finished. I should like to arrive, when I arrive, with something in my hands."

"That is the most foolish thing I have ever heard."

"Yes."

"I will wait for it."

"How long?"

"I am a radio host," said Naledi Khumalo. "I am used to waiting for the top of the hour. Finish your song, Mr. Johannesburg. Until then, same time tomorrow?"

"A quarter to midnight."

"I shall say your name," she said, "when you tell it to me." And on the air she added, to the whole of the Reef, in her old warm lamp of a voice: "Goldreef, that was the first real dedication of the evening. Stay up. Somebody out there is just beginning."

In the booth, Thandi Zulu blew her nose, extravagantly, and said into the talkback, to nobody, with no apparent intention of being heard:

"When a man plays a saxophone to a radio, my sisters, he is not playing to the radio."

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SCENE II

Fort Kochi. The twenty-fourth of December. Dusk. Every house in the old quarter has hung a paper star outside its door, and by evening the lanes are full of small bright constellations, lit from within, turning in the sea wind.

In Kerala at Christmas, the stars come down to the doorways.

They are made of coloured paper over a bamboo frame, five-pointed, with a bulb inside, and every household makes its own. By dusk on the twenty-fourth the whole of Fort Kochi is a sky turned inside out: red stars, green stars, white stars with tails, hung over the old Dutch doorways and the fishermen's huts and the shutter of the chemist, and swinging, a little drunkenly, in the warm breeze off the harbour.

Arjun Nair, up a ladder, was hanging a black one.

"That is not a star," said Lakshmi Panicker, from the doorway of the café next door, where she was holding a tray of banana fritters like a soldier presenting arms. "That is a *bereavement.*"

"It is a star."

"It is *black.*"

"The paper was left over." He tied the cord with care. "I pricked it, Lakshmi. Look. With a pin. When the lamp is lit, you will see the holes."

"What do they say?"

"Nothing. It is only dots."

“A man does not spend four nights with a pin and a lamp,” said Lakshmi, “for *only dots.*” She turned to a customer. “Four nights. I have watched. I do not charge for my observations. Will you take a fritter?”

He did not answer. He came down the ladder, and switched on the bulb, and stood in the lane with his hands at his sides and his mended spectacles gleaming, looking at what he had made.

It was a dark star, and it glowed. Through the black paper, in a thousand pin-holes, the light came out in a scatter of gold, thick in some places and thin in others, like a sky from some other, kinder planet. In the middle of it, in a small bright cluster, you could, if you knew the script, read a line in Malayalam.

Ask me what I wrote.

He had been standing there some minutes, not breathing, when a voice behind him said, in English, in a quite ordinary tone:

“I have a bone to pick with you, Mr. Nair.”

He did not turn round. He could not have.

“Good evening, Meera.”

“It is not a good evening. It is a serious evening. I have been wearing a damp page in my blouse for twenty-three days, and I have come to demand the rest of it.”

She stood in the lane, in the sea-light, in the green sari. She had not, this time, tucked up the hem. She held, in her right hand, a little folded square of paper, gone grey at the creases and soft as cloth.

“I am sorry,” said Arjun. “I—what rest?”

“Do not do the voice of a man who has no idea.” Her chin came up. “On the first of this month a child in my class, whose name I will not tell you, and who has the manner of a very small Russian novelist, took me to the library computer and showed me the Register. She said, *Teacher, the one in Kochi is Mr. Arjun.* I said that I did not follow. She said: *Entry six hundred ninety-nine. Read it.*”

He had gone quite white. She did not seem to notice. She was looking at the black star.

“*I hid a poem in a book I knew you would buy,*” said Meera. “Do you know what I thought? I thought, *he knew I would buy it.* For seven years I believed I was the one who kept finding. I did not know that I was being *expected.* It is a very different thing to be expected. It feels like walking on a floor that someone has been sweeping.”

“I am so sorry. I did not want to—to presume—”

“I wrote one too,” said Meera. “Did you read mine?”

“No.”

“Why not?”

“I was afraid it would say that you did not know.”

“Entry one hundred fifty-three,” said Meera, in the careful voice of a woman reading aloud in a language she does not quite trust. “*I buy that book every year to read the poem again.*” She lowered the paper. “I wrote it three winters ago, in the dark, and sent it to a woman in England whom I will never meet. It was the thing I could

not tell anyone. Not you. Not my father. Not Vishnu Kurup, who thinks the green sari is a legal document. And I said it to a stranger, because a stranger cannot look at you in the lane."

They stood in the star-light. Above them the black star turned a little on its cord, and the gold holes slid across their faces. In the café doorway Lakshmi had stopped breathing, and a fritter fell from her tray, unnoticed, into the road.

"Show me the line," said Meera, "that the rain took."

He could not speak. He held out his hand. She put the grey square of paper into it; and he unfolded it, with fingers that did not obey him, under the light of the star, and there at the end of the third verse was the smudge, a soft cloud of dissolved pencil, where a word had been.

"It was *understand,*" he said, in a voice she could scarcely hear. "It was the last word. I could not rhyme it with anything. I thought—" He swallowed. "I thought, if the rain took it, then I had been spared."

"Do you wish to be spared?"

"No."

"Then say it."

"I cannot. It was in the poem. It was supposed to be—it is a thing one writes. Not says."

"Arjun." She stepped nearer. "In the Malayalam, the poem does not end with *understand.* You translated it for the English edition. I have been to your shelf. I have

read your notes. In the Malayalam, the last word is *manassilaayi.* It is not an imperative. It is a past tense. It is not *understand, please.* It is: *I have understood.*"

"That is—yes."

"So it is not a request," said Meera. "It never was. It is the reader's line. You left it to me. You have been leaving it to me for seven years, and I have been reading right past it, because I thought it was your word."

She took the paper from his hand. She took, from the tuck of her sari, a stub of pencil, and she wrote, with it, on the smudge, in her own quick bright hand, the single word.

മനസ്സിലായി.

"There," she said. "I have understood."

The star turned. Somewhere across the water a ferry sounded its horn, and a hundred paper stars, in a hundred doorways, trembled in the dusk.

"Meera," said Arjun. "May I—will you—"

"You may ask me anything you like," said Meera Menon, "provided you ask it to my face."

"I should like to—to walk you to the end of the lane."

"It is forty paces."

"I should like to do it slowly."

"Then you will have to carry my sandals," said Meera, "because they are in my bag," and she put into his hands, with a perfectly serious face, a pair of green sandals; and he took them as one takes a sacrament; and

they went down the lane in the light of a thousand stars, forty paces, very slowly, not touching, the width of a shelf apart.

On the café doorstep, Lakshmi Panicker set down her tray and addressed the whole lane, in the manner of a judge.

"It took seven years," she said, "and one flood, and a black star. I would like it to be known that I said so."

"You said it every day," said her customer.

"Yes," said Lakshmi Panicker. "I *always* said so."

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., against Entries 0466, 0749, 0699 and 0153:

Four letters, two instruments, a radio and a book. One man who cannot speak will play; one who cannot play will write. A woman reads another's secret aloud and trips on her own.

Observe that one pair has yet to meet. A letter, a sound and a poem are three ways of being near. The fourth is a lane, and forty paces, and a pair of sandals.

The saxophone is unfinished. I have noted that unfinished things, in my experience, are the ones that arrive.

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End of Chapter 21.

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Chapter 22: The Last Tango Lesson

“She was my sister, and you were hers, and I am still jealous.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0027

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SCENE I

Buenos Aires. San Telmo, a Saturday afternoon in January. It is thirty-six degrees. Every shutter in the barrio is closed and every fan is praying. On the first floor of a former printing house, the Academia Cruz.

January in Buenos Aires is summer, and this is the one city in this winter’s book where nobody is cold. The tar softens. San Telmo smells of hot stone, grilled meat and the sweet brown ghost of dulce de leche, and in the Academia Cruz, whose floor is old pine and whose mirrors are older, eleven ceiling fans turned over two persons who were not speaking.

“Again,” said Valentina Cruz.

“I have done it.”

“You have done it *wrongly.* Again.”

Valentina was thirty-three, a tango teacher, small and straight and dark, with a bun pinned so tightly it looked like a decision, and eyes that had watched other

people’s feet for fifteen years and arrived at a low opinion of most of them. She wore black. She had worn it since September two years ago, and told her students that it was practical.

Across the floor stood Mateo Fernández, thirty-five, who had been the best male dancer in the city for a decade, and knew it, and had arranged his entire bearing around the fact, as a cathedral arranges itself around a relic. He was tall, silver at the temples, and graceful in the way of something that has never had to ask. His right arm was raised and curved. His left hand rested on the air at the height of a woman’s shoulder-blade, with the fingers a little spread, holding no one.

For two years he had danced like that, at milongas, at weddings, at the Mundial. He had never been without a partner: she was simply not visible. Patrons moved aside for the empty place. Some of the old ladies, it was said, curtsied to it.

“I cannot do it with anyone else,” said Mateo. “I have told you.”

“You have told me nineteen times. It is a very repetitive grief.”

“You came here,” said Valentina, “to dance with my sister. I am not offering a lesson. I am a landlady.” Her voice, which was perfectly even, did a very small thing at the word. “Marisol would have corrected your left shoulder. It has been a half-beat high since the funeral. A man holds a ghost higher than he held a woman. It is the most common error in grief.”

From the doorway, where he had been sitting for an hour on a plastic chair with a newspaper held at the angle of disapproval, a voice said: “I put twenty pesos on the shoulder.”

This was Ramiro Romero, sixty-seven, a retired choir director, a matchmaker by temperament and a gossip by vocation, who brought to tango the acid ear of one who had spent forty years listening for the flat tenor in the back row.

“On the *shoulder?*” said Agustina Benítez, who had come up the stairs with a thermos and a gourd of mate and handed it round like a priestess. She was fifty-four, a mate seller from Rosario, who sold by the cup to the dancers, the loafers and the heartbroken, who in her professional opinion were the only ones who tipped. “Everyone knows it is the *chest.* A man who has lost a woman keeps the chest closed, like a shop in a bad month. Mateo, sweetheart, open the shop.”

“I do not require a *commentary.*”

“Nobody requires one,” said Agustina placidly. “It is why it is free.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Valentina set down her mate. She crossed the floor in her flat black practice shoes, through the thick shimmering light between the shutters, and stopped in front of him, closer than she had stood since a morning in September in a churchyard.

“Take your hand down,” she said.

“Why?”

“Because it is on the wrong person.”

He did not move. It was, she saw, the first time in two years that anyone had told him, and he stood quite still, his arm held out, as though the air were still warm.

“She used to say,” said Mateo, quietly, “that I led like a man carrying a tray. Everything perfect and nothing spilt. And then, in the last year, she said: *You have started to listen.* I do not know when it was. I would give anything to have asked her what she heard.”

“She heard you, you idiot,” said Valentina Cruz, “*breathing.*” And before she knew that she was going to do it, she lifted her own hand, and laid it flat upon his left arm, and drew it down; and then she stepped into the space where the ghost had stood.

It was only a walk. In tango the first thing, the only thing, is the walk: eight steps, with the weight carried from heel to ball like a secret passed from one hand to another. She did not dance. She stood in the circle of his arm, face turned away, her left hand on his shoulder, which was indeed a half-beat high, and said, not looking at him: “Walk.”

He walked.

She went backward, as a follower goes, with the whole of her attention on the one point of contact on her back. Eight steps. At the fourth he stumbled. At the fifth he was wrong. At the sixth, to his own astonishment, he knew where she was going to be.

“There,” said Valentina. “That is her. That is not her. That is *me,* and I am alive, and I do not hold the way she did. I am heavier. I lean on the left. I would rather die

than be led through a turn.” She stopped. Her voice cracked once, like ice on a pond. “I have hated you for two years, Mateo. She was my sister, and she danced with you, and I taught her. I taught her every step of it. And when she danced with you she never looked at me again.”

The room was very still.

“I did not know that.”

“Nor did I.” She let go. “That is the last lesson of this kind. On Thursday we shall walk. Not dance. *Walk.* Eight steps. Then ten. And if you say *ghost* to me again, I shall put you out of the window.”

“It is the first floor.”

“I shall be generous with the height,” said Valentina.

In the doorway, Ramiro Romero lowered his newspaper by two centimetres, which for him was a standing ovation.

“I withdraw the twenty pesos,” he said. “It was neither.”

Later, when they had gone, and the fans turned over an empty floor, Valentina sat in the light on the edge of the stage, with her shoes in her lap, and said what she had never said to the mirror, or the dancers, or God:

You had the better part of everything, my sister: The stage, the man, the laughter, and the grace. I had the stairs, and thirty years of watching You turn, and turn, and turn away. And now I have the floor you left, and I would give it To hear you laugh at me for being jealous. You laughed at everything.

You would have laughed To see me walk a man across a room Because I could not bear that he should dance With emptiness. You would have said: "Vale, You're hopeless. Take him. He is yours to teach." I will not take him. He was never mine. But I will teach him how to hold a living Woman, so that someone, someday, may.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

Santos, on the coast of São Paulo state. Sunday, the same weekend. A small blue house two streets from the port, where the cranes stand over the roofs like patient herons.

The invitation had come in a handwritten envelope, with a drawing of a bus on it. *Dona Zuleide Teles requests the presence of the Doutora and the Seu Carlos at a lunch in memory of her husband, who would have been fifty-nine.*

It was the first time they had been in the same room since the lift. In the intervening nine weeks Dr. Lima had found it necessary to follow up eleven patients at the Santa Aurora rehabilitation wing, every one of whom, Carlos had observed, was in perfect health. Dona Cida, who was seventy-one and nobody's fool, had said: "That girl has not looked at me once. She is looking at *you.* In my day we called it a follow-up."

Now they sat on a back veranda under a lemon tree, among forty bus drivers in the uniform shirts of the Linha 7, and a widow in black, and a hot Atlantic wind.

Beatriz's father had taken over the kitchen at nine in the morning, in defiance of the entire code of hospitality, and presided over a feijoada of such majesty that a driver of sixty, who had not wept at his friend's funeral, was weeping into a pork rib.

"Senhora," said Pedro Rocha, from the stove, in the voice of a prophet, "a widow has cooked enough."

Dona Zuleide was a small wrinkled woman of sixty-six with a face like a clenched walnut and the eyes of a bird, and she had been watching Carlos since he arrived. She watched him now as he carried the plates to the kitchen and scrubbed his hands at the sink, being a physiotherapist who believed that hands, after food, should be returned to the profession.

He took off the ring.

He did it without thought, and set it on the windowsill beside the soap, where the light fell through the lemon leaves and made it look, for a moment, like a small gold sun.

Then he dried his hands and went out to the veranda, and forgot it.

✦ ✦ ✦

Beatriz found it ten minutes later. She had come in for water.

She did not pick it up. She stood with the glass in her hand and looked at a plain gold band on a windowsill, and at the inside of the band, where a line of tiny letters had caught the sun: *M. & C. — 14.3.* She did not have to

be told what it meant. She was a surgeon. She knew what it was to read an X-ray and see, without being told, the old break that has healed.

“He is a widower, child,” said a voice at her elbow.

Dona Zuleide Teles had come in, as small women do, with no sound at all.

“A married man leaves his ring on,” said the old woman. “A widower takes it off in other people’s kitchens, where nobody will remark.” She took the glass out of Beatriz’s grip and drank from it, with a certain firmness. “I was a wife for forty-one years. I am a widow since the third of November. I have not yet taken mine off. The ring is not a lie, child. It is a *door.* He has been holding it open for her for a very long time. Somebody has to say to him: *You may come through.*”

“Dona Zuleide, I have no right—”

“You have a pulse,” said the widow, tartly. “In my experience it is the only credential. Go and ask him.”

✦ ✦ ✦

He was in the garden by the lemon tree, looking at the cranes.

“Seu Carlos,” said Beatriz. “I have a question, and I am a surgeon, so I am going to ask it in the most efficient manner possible. Are you married?”

He turned. He looked at her for a long time, with his warm crooked face, and she saw, one after the other, six or seven things he might have said, none of which he said.

“I was,” said Carlos Mendes. “Marina died in March, two years ago. It was long. I would sooner not say how long. I have worn the ring because it is easier than a sentence.” He drew breath. “I did not tell you in the lift because the word was heavier than the lift.”

“I know.”

“You *know?*”

“I saw it on the sill. I am sorry. I did not touch it.”

“It is not a thing one needs to protect,” said Carlos gently, and, to her great surprise, smiled. “I left it there on purpose. I did not know I had. I think my hands had decided something before I had.”

They stood together under the lemon tree. Over the roofs the cranes of the port lifted a blue container into the white sky, slowly, with the grave ceremony of the very large.

“I am not asking for anything,” said Beatriz. “I wished to know. It is a matter of accuracy.”

“I will fetch it,” said Carlos. “I would not leave it in a stranger’s kitchen.” He walked into the house, and when he came out the ring was in his hand, and he stood a moment with it, turning it as he had turned it a thousand times against the hem of his coat.

He did not put it on. He slid it, instead, into the breast pocket of his shirt, on the left, over the heart, where it could be felt and was not worn.

“It is not that I am free,” said Carlos. “I do not know what I am. But I should like to find out, in daylight, with no ring on my hand, beside a surgeon who comes to my

ward eleven times in nine weeks to follow up on patients who are not ill."

"It was *nine* times," said Beatriz, scarlet.

"Dona Cida counts eleven."

"Dona Cida," said Beatriz Lima, with great dignity, "is a gossip."

And from the veranda, in a voice of sacred solemnity, her father began, over forty bus drivers and a widow, to sing.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

Yogyakarta. A workshop behind a house in the Prawirotaman quarter. The wet season. The rain comes down on the tiles in a long continuous roar, as if the sky were being poured from a very large jug.

Ermis Larasati opened the email on a Wednesday, at eleven in the morning, with a canting in her right hand.

She had been drawing wax on a cloth: a *kawung,* the old pattern of four ovals, which looks like a field of seeds and is said to be among the oldest designs on Java. The little copper-spouted pen, the *canting,* ran hot wax in a thread as fine as hair. One draws with wax whatever one wishes to protect; the cloth goes into the dye; the dye takes everything unprotected; and when the wax is boiled away what remains, a white line against the indigo, is the thing that was kept.

Her phone gave a soft chime on the table. She read the subject line with the pen still in the air, and a drop of wax fell on the cloth, and made a small spreading golden mistake.

Fellowship Offer — Maashaven Textile Lab, Rotterdam.

Dear Ms. Larasati,

It is with great pleasure that the selection committee offers you a two-year residency, with a studio, a stipend, and full access to the Laboratory's collection of historical dye-works. The programme begins on the twenty-second of May. We would be grateful for your acceptance by the thirty-first of January…

She read it three times. She put down the canting, with great care, in its brass dish, and sat for some time with her hands in her lap in the roar of the rain.

Behind her, on the window-rail, the green parrot opened a yellow eye.

"*TOO LATE,*" said Ayu.

"It is not too late. It is January."

"*BEAUTIFUL.*"

"You do not know what it says."

"*TOO LATE. TOO LATE.*"

"Ayu," said a dry soft voice from the doorway, "go and sit on your perch and let the child think."

It was Eyang Sri, her grandmother, eighty-one, who had made batik for sixty-eight years and had never been in a hurry. She stood in the door in a faded *kebaya* with

a cup of ginger tea, and looked at her granddaughter's face, and then at the wax mistake on the cloth.

"It came," said Eyang. "From the cold place with the water. And you are going to say yes."

"I do not know."

"You know. Your hand has put a mistake on a *kawung* and you have not corrected it. When a girl leaves an error in her best pattern, she is thinking of a very great thing." She sat down on the low stool and turned her granddaughter's hand palm up, as if the matter might be written there. "Is there a boy?"

"*Eyang.*"

"I am not asking whether you are going to marry him. I am asking whether there is a boy."

Ermis looked at the rain.

"There is a person I talk to on Fridays," she said. "In Dhaka. He is an hour behind. He has a father in debt and a mother who is ill, and a sister, and no visa. He is the kindest man I have never met. I do not know what he is to me. I have not said the word, and he has not, and I do not think either of us will, unless somebody is made to." She swallowed. "If I tell him, he will tell me to go. He will say it before I have finished the sentence. He will be generous. He will be right. And then I will go, and it will be done. And if I do not tell him—"

"Then you have bought," said Eyang Sri, "a little more of Friday."

"Yes."

“It is a poor currency, child. It runs out.” But she patted the hand, and she was smiling a little. “Tell the boy.”

“Not yet. Not until I know what I am going to say.”

“When you are a girl of twenty-four,” said her grandmother, rising, “you think the wax is for the part you wish to *keep.* It is also for the part you are afraid to dye.”

She went out. The rain came down.

And Ermis took up the canting again, and stood a long while at her table in the ticking dark of the workshop, and said, not to the parrot, not to the old woman, not even to the wet gold shape of her mistake, but to the whole damp light of January:

An hour is not a long way. It is the time It takes a pot of ginger tea to cool. It is the time it takes a stranger’s name To change into a stranger’s voice. And yet I have it in my hands: two years, a lab, A studio, a river, and a door That opens on the whole wide world of cloth. I have wanted this since I was nine years old. I wanted it the way the earth wants rain. And now it falls, and I am standing here Beneath it, with an umbrella that I made Myself, of wax and promises. Oh, Fayaz, If you were here I would not need to speak. But you are there; and that is what I’ll say. Not yet. Not yet. Not yet. Not yet. Not yet.

✦ ✦ ✦

On Friday, at 22:00 in Dhaka and 23:00 in Yogyakarta, the green dot came on.

“You are *early,*” said Fayaz.

“I am four minutes early,” said Ermis. “It is called being the one who is ahead.”

He had come up from the tea stall, where Bunny had delivered an opinion on his shirt, and sat at the desk with the laptop propped on a stack of textbooks. It was the dry cold of Dhaka’s winter, the season of shawls and date-palm juice and wood-smoke, and the lane outside was misted over. On the corner of the desk, face down beneath a paperweight, lay an envelope with an embassy’s crest, which he had been not opening for nine days.

They talked of Ayu, who had learned a fourth word, which was *invoice;* of a firm in Singapore that had sent him a test project, five nights, with a decision after; of his sister’s physics, which had taken on the aspect of a religious conflict; of whether a *kawung* was better in blue or in brown. They talked for forty minutes, as one talks across a very small table. Twice he made her laugh so hard the pen rattled. Twice she opened her mouth.

“Ermis?” said Fayaz, the second time. “You were going to say something.”

Say it, thought Ermis. *Say: I have been offered two years in a country with water. Say: I am an hour ahead of you and I am about to be five hours behind.*

“I was going to say,” said Ermis, “that you have a very good face for a man who is in debt.”

He considered this.

“It is my only collateral.”

“I know,” said Ermis. “I have been looking at it for three months.” Then, very quickly: “Good night, Fayaz. Tell Bunny the shirt was acceptable.”

“I will tell him. He will be insufferable.”

“He is already. Same time next Friday?”

“I have never missed one.”

“You were four minutes late last month.”

“It was a very slow clock.”

She laughed, and cut the call, and the screen went black, and in the bright small mirror of the dark he saw his own face, and the unopened letter behind it, and did not touch it.

In Yogyakarta, in the rain, with the wax going cold in its dish, Ermis sat for a long while before the glowing rectangle of her second screen. At seven minutes past midnight, by her clock, which was seven past eleven in the lane at Mirpur, where a young man was walking to the corner for a last cup of tea, she put out her hand and pressed *Accept.*

“*TOO LATE,*” said Ayu, from the rail, very softly.

“I know,” said Ermis. “I know.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., against Entries 0027, 0230, 0016, 0818, 0713 and 0714:

Some today have laid down what they should have set down long before; and some have refused to set down what they should. A ring is moved to a pocket.

A hand is lowered from the air. A letter lies face-down beneath a paperweight.

He is an hour behind her. She has pressed the key. It is already tomorrow for the one of them, and tonight, still, for the other. I have told you before: it is not the clocks that part us. It is the thing each of us keeps for the morning.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 22.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 23: Needle and Thread

“I am sewing your wedding dress for another man’s bride.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0730

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SCENE I

Kano, Nigeria. The tailors’ lane behind Kurmi Market, ten in the morning, in the season of the harmattan. The wind has come down from the Sahara with a load of fine red dust, and the sun hangs in the sky like a coin at the bottom of a pond.

In the lane behind Kurmi Market the treadle machines clatter in their hundreds, like a town of nervous sparrows, and on a harmattan morning the dust lies on the cloth, on the counters, on the cats, and on the eyelashes of the goldsmith, who was Bashir Yakubu, fifty, the owner of the loudest laugh in Kano and the shop next door to a tailor.

“*Yusuf!*” he roared, through the wall. “There is a very old woman in your doorway, and she is holding a fan like a sword!”

“I know,” said Yusuf Abdullahi, from the dark of his shop. “I am hiding.”

He was thirty-three, a tailor, devout and modest and the best in the lane, which he would have denied under oath. He was a narrow man with a clean-shaven, serious face and long, exact hands that moved along a seam as if it were a sleeping child. He had a Singer treadle machine older than himself, a tape measure around his neck like a stole, and a prayer-cap that sat very straight. He had never said an unnecessary word, and had accordingly said, in thirty-three years, hardly any at all.

"Malam Yusuf," said Hajiya Zainab Bello, sweeping in. She was sixty-nine, a retired pharmacist and, in the opinion of Kano, the finest matchmaker north of the Niger. She had arranged four hundred and six marriages and been wrong, by her own count, in two. She sat on the stool in the corner and arranged her *zani* about her like a general disposing a flag. "I have come to commission a dress."

"For whom, Hajiya?"

"For a bride."

"I have measured many brides."

"Not this one." She opened her fan with a snap. "Swiss lace. White, but not the hospital white; the milk white. Sleeves to the wrist. A hem that falls as water falls. And embroidery. I have heard that you can do embroidery that cannot be seen except by the light."

"It can be done."

"It is for the wedding of Aminu Danjuma, the baker of Zaria, forty-three years old, a most honourable man, who has never said a kind word aloud but has done a great

many in dough. His bride—" the fan paused "—is the midwife. Hauwa Garba."

There was a very small sound. It was the sound of a tape measure being dropped.

Yusuf Abdullahi did not faint; it was not in his character. He sat down, with great deliberation, on the nearest bolt of cloth, and looked at a small lizard on the opposite wall as if it had said something of the highest importance.

"Hauwa," said Yusuf.

"She is thirty years old. It is not too soon. Her father, Malam Sani, who is a retired boat mender and has had, in a city with no sea, nothing to mend but his opinions, is very much in favour. And the baker is a very solid man. His bread is the best in the north." The old woman fixed him with her hawk's eye. "You do not have an objection, I hope?"

"No, Hajiya."

"Because I have been a matchmaker for forty years, and I have a nose for an objection."

"I have no objection," said Yusuf. He spoke into the lizard. "It is a good match. I will make the dress."

"You will make it as for your own sister?"

"I will make it," said Yusuf Abdullahi, "as it should be made."

"Good. You will not be able to measure her, of course. It is not done. Her mother will bring you a dress of hers to copy." Hajiya Zainab rose, with a rustle. In the doorway she turned, and for a moment the hawk was gone

from her face, and what looked out was only an old woman who had seen a great deal of weather. “Malam,” she said quite gently, “you are a good tailor. I should hate to think I had commissioned the wrong man.”

“You have not,” said Yusuf.

When she had gone, the goldsmith put his head round the wall with a plate of groundnuts and a face of rare tact.

“Yusuf.”

“Do not.”

“I am only going to say—”

“Bashir.”

“—that I have sold gold to four hundred grooms,” said Bashir Yakubu, “and I have never once seen one look as you looked just now. And you are not the groom.” He placed the plate carefully on the counter. “I have a wife. I know nothing. Eat the nuts.”

✦ ✦ ✦

The dress of Hauwa Garba came on Thursday, folded in a clean cloth, in the arms of her mother.

It was a plain green cotton dress, worn at the elbows, with a pocket on one side where a pencil had been carried, and ink on the right cuff, a small blue-black stain. She wrote the register of births. It was the stain of four hundred children’s names. He turned it on the table beneath the lamp, and measured, as he had been told, the shoulder, the sleeve, the fall, and in the measuring he read her, as one reads a page in a language studied for

years: the way she carried her left arm a little crooked, from lifting; the narrowness of the waist, from forgetting to eat; the fold at the elbow where a woman has leaned on a doorframe through a long night, waiting for a head to crown.

He did not say her name. He had a rule.

That night, with the light gone, as it goes every night in Kano (it is the custom in Nigeria to say of electricity that *NEPA has taken the light,* as one speaks of a lodger who has run off), he lit a kerosene lamp, and set out the lace, and cut. It took him four hours. It was the best cutting of his life. When it was done he sat before the pieces, in the gold light, with the wind throwing handfuls of dust against the shutter, and he threaded a needle with black thread, and spoke. He spoke, not to God, who knew it already, but to the cloth:

I measure you by the cuff, and by the elbow, By ink that has forgotten it was ink And is a name. I measure you by the pocket Where you have carried pencils for the births Of other people's children. I have known The width of you for three years and a half, Since you were kind about my mother's cough. I have no right. I own a thread, a lamp, A Singer and a name too poor to put Beside a baker's. Therefore I will make The dress. I'll make it better than a king's, And sew in secret, in the final seam, One star in black. No bride will see it. No Groom turn the hem. It is the one thing I Am keeping. Let it be the dark in the white, The place I hid, that does not need to be seen.

He sewed a single star, five points, in black, in the lowest seam, on the inside, where the lace would fold and nobody look. It was no bigger than his thumbnail. It took eleven minutes. Then he put the dress away under a clean cloth, and put out the lamp, and sat in the dark, with the dust against the shutter and his hands in his lap, until the dawn call came from the mosque at Kofar Mata and the whole city rose up in the grey to pray.

✦ ✦ ✦

At twenty minutes to five that same morning, a woman in a green hijab came down the tailors' lane with a bag in her hand and her feet aching.

Hauwa Garba had been awake since the previous dawn. She had delivered a child in a compound in Fagge at two o'clock, a girl, eight pounds, protesting, and had washed her and wrapped her and put her into her mother's arms, and said as she always said, *Masha Allah, she has a good voice,* and then sat for an hour in the courtyard in the cold, drinking the tea they brought her, because the one thing nobody had taught her about midwifery was what to do with the hands afterward.

She was thirty, tall, quiet, with a long, still face and brown eyes that missed nothing. She had delivered four hundred and twelve children. She had learned to wait. It was a skill, she told the young nurses, and it was not the same as having time.

She was to be married in May. She knew the baker, who was honourable, and silent, and had once walked past her clinic door a hundred times without going in. She knew her father's heart, which was set on it, and

Hajiya Zainab's, which was set on everything. She had said nothing. A woman of thirty in Kano has a great many ways of saying nothing.

In the lane, in the grey, one light was burning. It was a little yellow flame behind a slit in a shutter, in a shop the width of a coffin; and through the slit, because she was a midwife and had learned to see in the dark, she saw a man with his head down, quite still, with a thread in his teeth, and on his table a long cloth the colour of milk.

She did not stop. It would not have been proper. But she slowed, a very little, as one slows beside a sleeping house; and from behind the shutter, in the thin cold of the dawn, there came the last two lines of something spoken aloud, in a low voice, to nobody:

"—the place I hid, that does not need to be seen."

Hauwa Garba stood quite still in the red dust, with her bag in her hand.

She had heard, in the small hours, a great many things said by people who thought themselves unheard. She knew how a person speaks when he has stopped believing in an audience.

She knew whose voice it was. She had known it, in her own way, since a morning three and a half years before, when she had brought a pot of medicine to a tailor's mother and been given, in return, a cup of water in a clean glass by a man who could not meet her eye.

I know whose dress it is, thought Hauwa, *and I am waiting.*

She did not say it aloud. She said, instead, very softly, to the lamp, in the way one blesses a threshold: *Allah ya kiyaye.* May God keep you. And she went on down the lane, under the fading stars, with her aching feet, towards her bed, and the call to prayer rose over the city like a long gold thread being drawn through cloth.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

Lagos. The third floor of Adeniran Court, a Wednesday in January. The harmattan has laid its fine red dust on every windowsill in the city, and on the nine desks of a company that no longer exists.

The company had died on a Thursday and been buried on a Friday, in the form of a letter from a lawyer in Ikoyi; and the nine members of its staff, having read it aloud to one another in the toilet, had agreed to take it as a suggestion.

So they had stayed. Emeka Okafor, twenty-eight, founder of nothing, sat among them with a calculator and the look of one who has been forgiven by a congregation and cannot decide what to do with it. Tobi, twenty-four, had built a spreadsheet of Chidinma Eze's order book so beautiful that it was shown to visitors. Ngozi Afolabi, her oldest friend, a mechanic, had taken the big Juki sewing machine apart on the floor, in her coverall, and was speaking to it quietly, as one talks to a horse before an operation.

“A machine that has been set to one stitch,” said Ngozi, “hates to be asked for another. That is not a fault. That is *character*.”

“Is that a remark about me?” said Chidinma.

“It is about the Juki,” said Ngozi. “But I am glad you took it personally.”

The visitor arrived at eleven. She was Madam Bimpe Adewale, buyer for the Ikeja boutiques, fifty, in a *gele* tied like the prow of a ship, and she walked the length of the room trailing a scent of expensive oranges and looked at the rack of Chidinma’s armoured coats with the expression of one who has been shown the bill.

“Two hundred pieces,” said Madam Bimpe. “I will take them for the Easter season. Fourteen million naira. But *softer,* my dear. Shoulders down. Brighter. A little more *welcome.* And this one—” she touched the indigo jacket, the sharp-shouldered one, the one that had walked down a runway in the dark “—this one is very strong. It is frightening. Women in Lagos do not wish to be armoured. They wish to be *admired.*”

The room went quiet. Nine people who were not employed by anybody stopped typing.

Emeka looked at the calculator. It said fourteen million. It said nine weeks of rent. He had, in the death of a company, learned the single lesson of his life, which was that a practical suggestion is a kindness and an opinion is a weapon; and he said, therefore, nothing whatever, and was a little astonished by how much it cost.

“I will make the soft ones,” said Chidinma. “In the colours. I like them. They are good.”

“Wonderful.”

“Not the jacket.”

“Darling—”

“The jacket is not softer, Madam. It is not for admiring. It is the one thing I have made that does not say *sorry.*” Her hands were trembling; she put them behind her back. “You may have two hundred pieces and I will be glad. I will not sell you a woman who is smaller than she is.”

Madam Bimpe regarded her for some time. Then she laughed, a rich, low, startled laugh, and took out a pen the size of a baton.

“I have been buying clothes for thirty years,” she said, “and no one has ever refused me a jacket. I find that it is making me hungry. Two hundred soft pieces, and the jacket in a window of its own, with a card that says *Not for admiring.* Is that acceptable?”

A cheer went up from the nine desks, which was a little ragged, because Tobi had been holding his breath.

“It is *excellent* arithmetic,” said Emeka, to the calculator, with his ears red. “I have never before disliked a sum so little when it came out in my favour.”

In the stairwell, as the buyer descended in a cloud of orange, a very old woman in a purple wrapper put out a hand like a bird’s and gripped her sleeve. “I saw it in a dream, my daughter,” said Mama Ngozi, who was fifty-nine, and a chapel leader of true faith and no sense of di-

rection. “A woman in this building would be asked to make herself smaller. And she would say *no.* I did not know it was a *Wednesday.*”

“What do you want?” said Madam Bimpe.

“Only to bless you. Also, I do not have bus fare.”

That night, when the nine desks were dark and the dust ticked against the glass, Chidinma went home to a room in Yaba and sat down on the edge of her bed, in front of a trunk. It was a plain wooden trunk, with a brass lock. She had a key to it on a string round her neck. In it, folded in tissue, lay a length of gold *aso-oke,* woven by a cooperative in Iseyin, which she had been cutting and stitching one inch a night since she was nineteen, for a woman of forty who had never in her life apologised to a room. She was twenty-seven. She had told no one. She had not told Emeka, who had carried boxes down three flights in his shirt-sleeves in a month of Saturdays and had not once asked what was in the trunk.

She put her hand on the lid.

“Not yet,” said Chidinma Eze, aloud, to the gold. “I am not that tall yet. But I said *no* to the oranges.” And she laughed, alone, in the dust, for the first time that week, and left the key where it was.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

Karachi. Eleven at night. The newspaper office of the Sahil Daily, on the third floor of an old building in Saddar. Outside the sea wind is rattling a hoarding that says DRAIN YOUR WORRIES: WE FIX NALLAHS.

At eleven at night the *Sahil Daily* smelled of ink, cold tea, and the particular sweat of the truth.

Sana Ahmed, twenty-seven, stood at her desk with her dupatta thrown over her shoulder and a motorcycle helmet in her hand. She was packing her notebooks. There were seventeen, each with a name on the spine, each with the dates and the amounts and the signatures that she had been collecting for four months, all of them concerning a creek, a contract, and a flood. The creek had been dredged, said the ledgers, at a cost of two hundred and ninety million rupees. The creek had not been dredged. This was the whole of her article, and the rest was footnotes.

"You will be careful," said her editor, who was sixty and had the face of a basset hound that has read the Constitution.

"I am always careful."

"You are always *loud.* It is not the same."

"Sir. I am going home."

"Take the main road."

"I take the main road every night."

"Then take it," said the editor, "*faster.*"

She went down the stair, and out into the warm night, which smelled of petrol and the sea. The street was dark and nearly empty; a chai-boy was stacking glasses; the

old hoarding rattled and creaked. Her motorcycle stood where she had left it, under the single lamp, a small red Honda with a cracked mirror.

On the seat was a paper boat.

It was folded neatly, as a child folds one, with a crisp bow and stern. It had been made from a page of notebook paper. She knew the ruling. She knew the faint blue lines. She knew, with a cold, clear, slow dropping of the stomach, the handwriting that ran across the sail, because it was her own.

Name. Contractor. Amount. It was a page from the third notebook, which she kept in the locked drawer of her desk.

On the other side, in a different hand, a hand that had been taught to write by a clerk, a single line:

The creek is dry. Let it stay dry.

Sana Ahmed stood in the lamplight for a long time.

She did not look round. She did not need to. She had interviewed enough frightened men to know exactly how it felt when someone was watching from a car with the lights off, and she would not give him the pleasure. She turned the boat over once in her palm. It weighed about as much as a sentence.

Then she did the bravest thing she knew. She folded it back along its creases, put it into the pocket of her bag, put on her helmet, started the engine, and rode the same way home.

Reader, I will not tell you that she was not afraid. The Keeper has read her letter; it says plainly: "A man has threatened me and I pretend I am not afraid." Pretending is not the absence of fear. It is a form of rowing.

✦ ✦ ✦

At six the next morning, at the gate of the Salt Creek Cricket Academy, a coach in a white shirt too large for him was bowling an imaginary ball at a boy in a cap that said FEAR NOBODY.

"Sana-baji," called the boy, "will you see my wrist?"

"I will see it."

"Hamza-sir says it is better."

"It is much better," said Hamza Qureshi, who was twenty-nine, and had looked at her face for exactly one second, and had stopped smiling by exactly half. He did not ask. He took a cup of tea from the kerosene stove and put it into her hand, and said in a light voice, so that the boys should hear: "Madam Journalist. You are late for the nets."

"I am not in the team."

"Everyone is in the team who is early," said Hamza. "It is a new rule." And then, under the noise, in Urdu, so that only she could hear, with his smile still on for the boys and nothing at all in his eyes: "Show me."

She took out the paper boat. He held it for a long time, in the pale morning, with the sea wind lifting the corner of its sail.

“I will not tell you to stop,” said Hamza. “You would not hear it. I will say only: on this field, you will always have eighteen people with brooms.”

“It is not enough.”

“No,” said Hamza Qureshi, and put the boat, with great gentleness, into his own breast pocket. “But it is a very *large* number of brooms.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., against Entries 0730, 0194, 0051, 0954 and 0343:

A tailor sews a star where no one will look. A midwife hears what is said to the dark. A designer says no to a buyer and keeps a dress in a trunk. A girl is handed a paper boat.

I have observed that the thing a person hides is nearly always in the hem. Nothing is so carefully made as the part that is not for show.

Of the boat I will say only that it is a child’s toy, and a threat, and a letter. In the Register it is the third kind that lasts.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 23.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 24: The Bosphorus Night

“I love a daughter of the house my father swore to ruin.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0211

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SCENE I

Lyon. The Croix-Rousse, the first Sunday of February, half past three in the morning. It is snowing on the hill of the silk-weavers, softly, as though the sky were folding linen.

Pierre Dubois opened the shutter at half past three, and found a woman on his step.

She stood in the snow in a long grey coat, a bunch of violets held out before her like a candle in a procession. Her shoulders were white, and her scarf had acquired a small drift. She had come to leave them and run, as she had run eleven Sundays running; and at the last moment, with her hand already lowered toward the stone, she had found that her feet would not.

“Madame Laurent,” said Pierre.

“Monsieur Dubois.” Margaux Laurent drew a breath, which smoked. “I have been practising what to say for twelve weeks. It was very good. I seem to have mislaid it.”

“You are covered in snow.”

“It is the violets I am worried about.”

“They are *Parma* violets. They are made for snow.” But he had taken them, in his floury hand, and held them as one holds a bird. “Come in. It is a bakery. It is the only thing about me that is warm.”

They sat on two upturned crates beside the oven, in the sweet gold dark, and he put into her hands, without a word, a round dark loaf with walnuts in it, warm from the rack. It was the first he had ever given with his own hand to anyone he could see.

“It is Odile’s,” said Pierre, to the loaf. “My wife’s. She died four years ago in the spring. I have made it every Sunday since. I do not know how to stop.”

“I know,” said Margaux. “I have eaten one of them. It came to my shop in a basket, from a witness.” She turned the bread over. “My husband made violins. Luc. I keep a bow of his in the shop, behind the ribbons. I tell the customers it is for the arrangement.”

“Does anyone believe you?”

“Everyone. It is a *florist’s* shop.” She smiled, which her face had not done in some time. “I wrote it in the Register, you know. *I left the flowers at your door. It was always me.*”

“I read it on Tuesday,” said Pierre. “I was too afraid to come.”

“We are a pair of very large cowards,” said Pierre.

“It is a *skill,*” said Margaux Laurent. “I have been practising for three years.”

They broke the bread. In the steam between them two persons who had made things for the dead found out, with some astonishment, that it is permitted to make them for the living.

At six, a bicycle came up the hill in the dark, and a thin boy in an anorak stopped dead at the door.

“I witness,” said Baptiste Lefèvre, with immense satisfaction. “I will say nothing.”

“You never do,” said Pierre.

“Unless I am not asked.” He looked severely at the two crates and the two faces. “Next Sunday I shall come at *seven.* I think there will be no need for a basket.”

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

Crete. A village in the White Mountains, and a shop behind the harbour at Chania. The olive harvest is over; snow lies on the high peaks, which stand in the east like a row of white pages.

On the same morning, on a mountain road, a taxi came round a bend at the speed of an argument.

“Women,” said Kostas Mavros, forty-four, taxi driver, who kept one eye on the road and the other on his passenger, an arrangement that has made orphans of whole families, “are like the White Mountains. You do not conquer them. You—”

“Everyone has heard it, Kostas,” said the young woman beside him. She was Anastasia Georgiou, twenty-five, a street vendor from Heraklion, with a theatrical

conviction that she was the heroine of any room. She sat very straight with a wooden crate across her knees, tied with kitchen string, like a martyr being driven to the stake. “I do not wish to look at him. I shall look at an olive tree.”

In the crate lay thirty letters.

They had been written, one every spring for thirty years, by a man who grew olives at the end of this road, to a woman in a shop behind the Venetian harbour, and every one had been taken in by that woman and put in a drawer. She had never opened one. Last Tuesday, in the back room of the shop that said *CREDIT IS A SIN,* she had read on her telephone, in the plain white type of the Register, *I have written to you every spring for thirty years,* and had sat a long time with her hand flat on the counter. Then she had fetched the box from the drawer, and tied the string, and sent for her niece.

“What am I to say to him?” Anastasia had demanded.

“Nothing. You are to put it in his hands. You are not to wait for an answer.”

“But Auntie, what does it *mean?*”

“It means,” said Eleni Stavrou, “that I have thirty letters and a very bad character.” And she had gone into the storeroom and shut the door.

George Papadakis was sixty years old, and he was pruning a tree. He stood on a stepladder in the grey light, in the oldest grove on the mountain, among trees that had been in the ground since the Venetians, and

turned his head at the sound of the car with the slowness of one who has been disappointed by a great many vehicles. He climbed down. He took off his cap.

The young woman looked, with theatrical fixity, at the nearest olive. She said “From Chania,” in the voice of one reading a death sentence, put the crate into his arms, and went back to the taxi.

He knew, before he lifted the lid, what it was: the weight of thirty springs. They lay in their order, in their cream envelopes, soft with age, her name on each in his own hand growing older, and on every one the round stamp of a post office that had delivered it to the right door. They had never been opened. There was no note.

“Well,” said Kostas Mavros, leaning from the taxi window. “That is a *no.* I am sorry, my friend. We could have a raki.”

“Thank you,” said George Papadakis. “I will sit a little.”

He sat down on the ground, with his back to the oldest tree and the crate in his lap, and did not untie the string. In the east the white mountains were turning gold along their edges.

“Thirty springs,” said George, to the tree. “A man who writes a letter has a conversation, whether anyone answers. And now they have all come home at once, like sheep.”

He sat until the light was entirely gold. He did not open the box. Kostas, who had crept back with the engine off to sit unseen in the lane, would say afterward

that in all his years of driving he had never seen anything like it: an old man under a tree with a box of letters, perfectly still, in the whole of that bright mountain.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

Kraków. The Main Market Square, Thursday at dusk. Snow lies on the roofs of the Cloth Hall. The horses of the carriages stand in blankets. In the high window of St. Mary's tower a light has come on.

At dusk on Thursday, as always, Zofia Kowalska came to the foot of the tower in a red scarf and opened her violin case on the stones.

She was twenty-three. She had played here every Thursday for three winters, with a saucer for the coins, and the people of Kraków, who are not easily moved, had come to stop for her, without knowing why, for the length of one tune. Across the square, under the arcade of the Cloth Hall, as on every Thursday of the last year, a fair-haired young man with a loupe pushed up into his hair stood with his hands in his pockets, and did not cross.

She tucked the violin under her chin and closed her eyes. She played a *kujawiak,* a slow dance of the plain, and through the first phrase it was as it had been for four months: the thin upper strings fading into mist, the middle notes clear, the low notes warm. She had told nobody. In her left ear there was a sea, and it had been rising since September.

Above her, in the window of the tower, the trumpeter lifted the horn. In seven hundred years the *hejnał* has never been missed, and at the end of it the tune will stop in the middle of a note, in honour of the man who was shot through the throat while sounding the alarm. She had heard it five thousand times. She saw his cheeks fill, and a long white breath go up from the horn into the snow, and she lifted her head to hear.

Reader, here the sound went out.

It did not fade. It went as a lamp goes out, on a single indrawn breath: the mist and the sea and the warm low notes together, and in their place a clean, wide, enormous quiet, as of a world on which a very large white sheet has been laid. She saw the pigeons rise off the Cloth Hall like thrown paper. She felt the string under her fingertip, the little hum of it in the bones of her jaw. And she heard, as the dead may be said to hear the sea, absolutely nothing at all.

She went on playing. The fingers know. For eleven bars she played the dance through the silence, by the weight of the bow, by the place in the body where music had been kept for twenty years, as one walks through one's own dark house; and when she knew, by the slow white clapping of gloves, that she had finished, she opened her eyes.

A fair-haired young man in a worn coat came across the square in a straight line, through the snow and the people. He did not look at her face. He looked at the case, as at a thing he had been meaning to do for a year,

and took from his pocket a single large silver coin, and laid it in the saucer so gently that it made no sound at all.

“Thursday,” said Jakub Nowak.

She did not hear it. She read it, as one reads a word through frosted glass.

“I have a pianino,” he said, slowly, shaping each word, like one who has been careful with words all his life and is trying to be careful with these. “It is out of tune. It always will be. Come and play it with me.”

She nodded, once, and smiled a bright, composed, practised smile. He looked at it for the length of a held breath; and, being a clockmaker, he said no more, for it is the first law of the trade that one does not hurry a promise.

That night she walked through the snow to the Academy and woke her teacher, and told her, in the voice of one reading out a will. She would not tell the boy until March.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE IV

Istanbul. The Üsküdar pier, the same evening. The Council has met that afternoon and decided, in the manner of councils, to decide later.

A wind had come down from the Black Sea at noon. The Turks call it *poyraz,* and it comes without apology and brings the snow in its pocket. By five the Bosphorus had gone the colour of slate and begun to climb the

piers. At six it was announced that all crossings would cease at seven. At ten past six, in the glass room at the end of the Kaya pier, Captain Mehmet Şahin of the *Nilüfer,* a small man with headphones round his neck, heard a voice on his radio say, with terrible calm, that the *Hızır* of the Yılmaz Line would sail at seven-ten, as always.

"They will *not,*" said Mehmet Şahin.

"They are saying the crossing will go to the house that stays on the water," said his mate.

"Then we sail," said Mehmet Şahin; and the whole matter of the night was decided by two old men in two glass rooms, each waiting for the other to be the first to be sensible.

✦ ✦ ✦

At a quarter past six, under the lamp at the end of the pier, in the snow, a boy of fourteen stood with a flat basket between two persons who had never spoken.

"This," said Burak Aydın, "is neutral ground. Nothing may be quarrelled over a sesame basket. I am the Switzerland of the Üsküdar pier. Begin."

She was in her blue cap with snow on the brim, he in his navy jersey with a rope on his shoulder, three feet apart, with the basket held between them like a flag of truce.

"You whistle off the note in the third bar," said Elif Kaya.

"It is how the shepherds whistle."

“Then the shepherds are wrong.”

“There are eleven hundred years of shepherds,” said Ahmed Yılmaz, “and you are one clerk. But I will correct it.” And then, very low, so that the wind took half of it: “I have read your name on the ticket-window for a year. I wished to hear it in a voice.”

“Elif.”

“Ahmed.”

She laughed, a short startled sound, and put a gloved hand over her mouth. Above them the first snow of the night came down between the lamps, very large, very slow, like something sent by a more tender power.

“I have a hundred and seventy-three poems in a biscuit tin,” said Elif, “and I cannot think of one.”

“I have none. I have a whistle.”

“Whistle it right, then. Tomorrow.”

“Tomorrow.” The word did something to his face. “At dawn. The little rowing boat, at the steps, to the Maiden’s Tower. Neither line. A rowing boat belongs to nobody.”

“At six.”

“I will bring the simit,” said Burak, who had gone pink about the ears. “I will be the chaperone and the sesame.”

From the sea came the hoarse voice of the *Hızır,* calling the crossing.

“I must go. My father.”

“I know. Mine is the radio.” She put out her hand in its wet glove, and for the first time, across the width of a sesame basket, they touched; and neither said anything for the whole length of one blast of a ship’s horn, as though the strait had held still to listen.

Mark this, reader. They have said, between them, about a hundred words. Hold on to them.

✦ ✦ ✦

The *Hızır* and the *Nilüfer* left the Üsküdar pier within a minute of one another, in a gale, with six hundred stranded people between them, each captain with his jaw set and his hand on a throttle, and the hearts of both houses already at the bottom of the sea.

Burak had been told not to go. He had gone, as boys of fourteen do, with the last of the simit, on the blue boat. He stood at the rail in the whirling snow, calling the price into the wind, and the red boat rose beside her in the dark, a stone’s throw off, the old rivals running abreast as they had for thirty years; and on her bow a tall man in a navy jersey lifted his hand.

The boy lifted his own.

The sea made no decision about it. A wave came out of the north-east and went under the two boats alike; the blue one heeled; a basket of simit went into the water like a handful of coins, and with it, with a short bright sound of astonishment, a boy.

Ahmed Yılmaz saw it from the bow. He did not stop. Nothing anyone could have said to him, then or afterward, about the cold, or the current the old fishermen

call the Devil's, would have stopped him. He put down the rope. He went over the rail of his father's boat into a black sea a few degrees above ice, and the whole ship cried out.

They said afterward in the cafés of Eminönü that it took less than a minute: that he got an arm round the boy's chest, as one is taught, and kicked toward the blue boat's light; that Captain Mehmet Şahin, who had come down from the wheelhouse of the *Nilüfer* with his headphones still round his neck, threw the life-ring himself, and threw it right. They said that Ahmed Yılmaz put the boy's two hands into it and pushed him toward the ladder with the last of the strength in his arms. And they said that when six men had hauled Burak Aydın, coughing and alive, over the rail, and turned to look for the other, there was nothing in the water but snow.

He had been whistling. The boy said so, later, in the hospital, with his teeth chattering: he had whistled the whole way to the ring, so that there should be something to follow. It was the shepherd's tune. He had got the third bar right.

✦ ✦ ✦

They searched until it was light.

Every boat on the Bosphorus was out, red and blue together, and the lamps went to and fro in the snow like two comets that had found the same sky. On the Üsküdar pier, at the very edge, a young woman in a blue cap stood until dawn with her hands pressed to her mouth, and was not led away, because no one would have dared.

At six in the morning, in the grey, two old men met on the Yılmaz landing.

Captain Süleyman Yılmaz had taken off his cap. His white moustache was full of snow, and for the first time in his life he was smaller than the sea. Mehmet Şahin stood a yard from him, and between them, stooped over a steaming urn, was a woman in an orange headscarf, who had come across the water in the first boat of the morning with a hundred glasses on a tray.

“Tea,” said Sema, quite simply, “has no flag.”

Nobody moved.

“Leave the quarrel on the hook,” said Sema. Her voice broke, and she did not hide it. “There is no one left to fight. Drink.”

It was Süleyman Yılmaz who took the first glass and, with a hand that shook so that the tea slopped in its saucer, held it out across the yard of stone.

“By my mother’s grave,” he said hoarsely, “I swore the Kaya flag would go under. And it was my son.”

Mehmet Şahin looked at the glass for a long time. “It was my niece’s heart,” he said, “on the other pier.” And he took it.

The two old men stood together in the falling snow, drinking tea from the same tray; and at the far end of the Kaya pier a girl in a blue cap lifted her head, for there had come over the water a sound so thin and crooked, one note flat in the third bar, that for a moment nobody could say whether it was the wind. It was Kerem Aydın, seventy-three, retired engineer, who had helped

raise the captain’s son with a spanner in one hand and prayer beads in the other, and who had come down alone to the end of the red pier in his shirt-sleeves, and was whistling the shepherd’s tune badly, because he had never in his life been able to, and because somebody must.

Elif Kaya walked to the edge. She did not weep. She took a crumpled ticket-stub from her pocket and, on the back, in pencil, in a hand that did not shake, wrote what she had not been able to write the night before:

> *The boat is blue; the boy was on the red; Tell him: I hear it. I have always heard. The third bar was the true one. Tell him so. The fathers lay their swords down in the snow. The sea has taken what the strait would give. Tell him, tell him, tell him: I hear. I heard.*

She folded the paper small, as she had a hundred and seventy-three times, made it into a paper boat, and set it on the water of the Bosphorus, which took it at once, as a hand takes a hand.

The sea gave him back three days later, on the stones at Salacak below the Maiden’s Tower, in his navy jersey, and he is buried at Karacaahmet. Burak Aydın lived to be eighty-one, and was a poet, and began every poem with a whistle. And Elif Kaya lived to be ninety, and ran the Kaya Line, and, when the two flags flew from one mast, she was known on the Bosphorus for one eccentricity only: that every morning, at the hour the first ferry came in, she stood at the edge of the pier in a blue

cap and whistled a tune from the Black Sea coast, a little flat in the third bar, so that somebody out on the water should know she was still there.

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Chorus, spoken over the whole of the winter, in the snow.

It snows on Lyon, where two ovens lie; It snows on Crete, where thirty letters stay Unopened by a tree; the Polish sky Is white above a girl who hears no day. It snows on Istanbul. Two flags go down. One boat is blue, and one is red; the sea Is neither. Winter closes on the town, And what is lost is lost; what's kept shall be.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., against Entries 0211, 0732, 0844, 0908, 0208, 0078, 0609 and 0471:

Two fathers swore an oath. It was kept, in the way of oaths: to the letter, and against the heart. I cannot give you back the boy. I can only note that he was whistling, and that a child heard it, and that the sound was true.

The other pages are less cruel. A loaf is broken. A box is not opened. A girl who cannot hear lets a boy put down a coin. Winter asks for payment in many kinds of coin; those pay best who, at the last, put something into the saucer.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 24.

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ACT III — A MIDSUMMER CONFUSION

The Chorus

Now falls the night when all the clocks go wrong, When masks are worn by those who need no mask, And lovers send by wire what once was song, And answer questions no one dared to ask. A boy awake beneath the Bengal moon, A girl one hour ahead of him in time, Shall speak by light of glass, and none too soon, While distant bells of doubt and duty chime. Not all that shines is seen; not all that’s seen Is true; and what is true is hard to hold: The dark is kind, the mask is thin, between The two a heart may choose to grow or fold. So hush; the hour is late, the night is deep, And love hath promised more than sleep can keep.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 25: Masks of Kyoto

“I wear the mask offstage too.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0447

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SCENE I

Kyoto, Japan. A wooden workshop at the end of a lane in the north of the city. The last week of March. The cherries are a day from opening, the cedars are shedding their pollen in clouds of yellow smoke, and half the population of the old capital is wearing a paper mask over nose and mouth, while the other half is pretending not to be.

In spring, in Kyoto, everybody wears a mask, and nobody thinks it strange.

It is the pollen. The cedars on the hills let go in March, and the whole city sneezes in a sort of general agreement, and goes about behind white paper like a congregation of surgeons. A woman may walk from Gion to the Kamo river and not once be recognised. A man may weep on a bus. It is, the Keeper has always thought, the most honest season of the year, since in it a person may hide her face and be thought merely sensible.

In a house the colour of strong tea, at the end of a lane, two hundred faces watched the dust.

They hung on nails and lay in baskets and stood in rows on cypress shelves: the long pale women of the Noh stage, with high painted brows and mouths like closed leaves; old men with beards of horsehair; demons with eyes of beaten gold; and, most of all, the girl called *ko-omote,* the little face, whose expression is neither smile nor weeping, and which has been copied, by carver after carver, for six hundred years. One man had made them, in a corner of the room, with chisels as long as his forearm and the patience of someone waiting for the wood to say what it wishes to be.

“You must not carve today,” said Daichi Kobayashi.

“I am not carving,” said Kenji Watanabe. “I am looking.”

“It is the same. It has the same intention.”

Daichi was twenty-five, and had been a primary-school teacher for exactly one term, from which he had retired on grounds of health, the health being the children’s. He was now the apprentice, in a tea-stained apron, a drinker of too much tea, and a young man of strong superstitions. He had salted the doorstep. He had turned the mask of the old woman toward the wall because she had looked at him in a bad way. He had said, three times, without being asked, that a cypress block with a knot in the left eye would bring misfortune on the house before the cherries fell.

“It has a knot,” said Daichi.

“It has a flaw,” said Kenji. “It is a different thing. A knot is an accident. A flaw is the place where the wood has told the truth.” He turned the block in the light.

He was twenty-seven, tall and narrow, with careful hands and a mouth that closed on its words like a shutter, and he had been quiet since the age of six, when a schoolmaster had told him that his face was *unreadable* and he had taken it for a compliment. At fifteen he had been apprenticed to the great carver of the district. In twelve years he had learned that a Noh mask is a face with its mind removed: it holds a feeling as an empty cup holds the shape of water. He was very good at it. He had never been able to show anyone what he felt. It was possible, as the Register has already told us, that the two facts were related.

The door slid.

✦ ✦ ✦

She came in as she always came into a room: without sound.

She was twenty-six. She wore a plain grey kimono, her hair up in a knot, and carried against her chest, in both hands, a flat box of paulownia wood tied with a purple cord, as though it held something that might wake. Over her nose and mouth she wore a white paper mask, like everyone; and above it, her eyes were large, dark, and extremely controlled. They had a small, fixed, courteous brightness, the shine of a smile that has been held so long that the muscles have been trained to do it alone.

“Excuse me,” said Haruka Mori. “I am sorry to trouble you.”

“You are not troubling anyone,” said Daichi, and turned three masks to the wall at once, out of politeness.

“I am told that the carver Watanabe repairs the old faces.”

“I am the carver Watanabe.”

She looked at him then. He was looking at the box. It was his habit: he looked at the object, and the person arrived in the corner of his eye, as a deer may be seen in a wood by not looking for it.

“It is cracked,” said Haruka. “It cracked on the stage, at the Kanze, the Saturday before last. It was cold in the theatre. It was the line where she says *I have waited a very long time.* I felt it go at the temple, under the lacquer. I finished the scene.” Something that was almost a laugh went across the paper. “I do not know why I am telling you. One does not tell a carver. One merely hands him the damage.”

She untied the cord, and lifted the lid, and in the tray of white silk, as small as a child’s face, lay the *ko-omote.*

It was very old. Kenji knew at once, as a doctor reads an age from a bone. The cypress had gone the colour of tea; the white shell-paint of the face had a skin of fine crackle, like the glaze of a bowl; the mouth had been touched in, a long time ago, with a brush of a single hair. Across the left temple ran a crack no longer than a grain of rice. He did not touch it. He did not breathe. For a little while there was no sound in the workshop but the pollen ticking against the paper window.

“Whose?” he said.

“It was my teacher’s. Before that, her teacher’s. I do not know before.” Her voice had softened. “I am afraid of it. It has played better than I have, for two hundred years.”

“May I?”

She nodded. He lifted it, and tilted it a little upward to the light, and the face seemed to open, to the edge of a smile. He tilted it down, and it closed, to the edge of grief.

“It can be mended,” said Kenji.

“How long?”

“A season. The glue must dry slowly, or it will crack again. The shell-paint must be laid in thin coats, nine, ten, and each must rest.” He set it down. “I do not hurry the old ones.”

“I am to dance *Izutsu* in November.”

“It will be ready in October.”

“Then I will come on Thursdays,” said Haruka, “if I may. To see that she is well.”

It was a perfectly ordinary sentence. Daichi, who was standing behind the pillar with a tea-cloth, felt the room shift slightly on its foundation, as a house does when someone in it has made up his mind.

“Thursdays,” said Kenji, to the mask.

“May I try it?” Her hands were at her face before she had decided. “It is only that I wish to know whether it—whether I can still—”

“It is cracked.”

“I will not wear it. I will hold it.”

She did not hold it. She raised the old face to her own, with the practised grace of one who had done it ten thousand times, and the paper mask vanished behind it, and the little cypress girl, with her faint terrible smile, looked at the carver across the width of the bench.

From behind it a voice said: “It is much easier from here.”

It was not the voice she had come in with. It was lower, and muffled by the wood, and it had in it something that the street voice had not: a sort of weary and entire relief.

“I am sorry,” said the voice. “I know it is rude. I have said *thank you* and *please* and *it was nothing* to everyone in Kyoto since I was nineteen, and I am so tired. I cannot do it behind a face of my own, you see. It will not hold. But if there is a mask in front of it, the mouth can be anything. Do you understand? It can say that it is cold. It can say that it was afraid. Behind this one I could say anything.”

Kenji Watanabe sat quite still. He had made faces for twelve years, and no one had ever told him what they were *for*.

“Say it, then,” he said, to the mask.

“I am afraid,” said Haruka, from behind the cypress, “that I have lost the other face. The one under. I have not seen it for so long that I am not sure it is there.”

Silence. In the lane a bicycle bell rang, and a child laughed, and somewhere a cedar exhaled a long yellow breath.

“It is there,” said Kenji.

“How do you know?”

“Because,” said Kenji, “the wood is always there under the paint.” And he went a dull and complete red, to the roots of his hair, which she could not see, because she was looking at him through a mask, and he was looking at the floor.

She laughed, and it came from behind the face like water out of stone. She lowered the mask, and the paper one was back in its place, and the small, correct, immovable smile above it was a little less so.

“Thursdays,” said Haruka Mori, and bowed, and was gone, without sound, into the yellow light.

When the door had slid shut, Daichi came out from behind the pillar with the tea-cloth held across his chest like a banner.

“Do you know who that was?”

“Mori-san.”

“She wears it in the *street.* She wears that smile in the street and the station and the shop. They say that nobody has seen her without it in six years.” He lowered his voice, as the very young do. “I turned three to the wall. I think it was not enough.”

“It is not a smile,” said Kenji.

“What is it?”

He did not answer for some time.

That night, with the shutters closed, and the faces on their nails turned politely away, he sat alone at the bench with the old mask on its silk, and a single lamp, and he spoke, as a carver does, to the work, in the voice that no living person had heard:

I have made six hundred faces in my life And never one for me. I know the brow Of grief, the cheek of rapture, and the turn Of jaw that says a ghost is in the room. I know them as a mother knows the cries Of children not her own. And yet I stood Today before a woman and could say Three words to her, and one of them was "Thursday." She told a mask her trouble. I said nothing. I held it up and looked, and thought: how strange, That anyone should come across a city To hide behind a face, and be the one Whose face I would have liked to see. Old girl, Old cypress child, I will not hurry you. I think I have a season. It may be All I shall ever need. It may be more.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

Jaipur. A showroom in Johari Bazaar, the jewellers' street, in the week of Gangaur, when the women of the city put on their brightest colours and the lanes look like a spilt box of crayons.

It had been Papa Sharma's decision that the fifty pieces should be shown for three days, in the back of the showroom, behind the curtain with the dead fly in it.

He had given her exactly fifty. He had said *not fifty-one* in front of nine uncles, with dry and entire malice; and on the first morning of the Gangaur week, in the long cool shop where Sharma Textile House had sold its peacocks and its marigolds and its pomegranates to the courts of three maharajas and a Hollywood film, fifty lengths of indigo cloth hung from a wire like the washing of a very serious sky.

They were exceedingly beautiful, and by noon they had sold three.

"Three," said the eldest uncle, with the air of an undertaker complimenting a corpse.

"Three is a start," said Priya Sharma.

"Three is the number of persons who are lost."

She stood at the end of the room in a plain white kurta, with indigo to the wrists, and counted the people who came through the curtain. They came; they looked; they murmured "very modern"; they asked, with a polite tilt of the head, whether it was available with a peacock. A woman from Delhi said it was *brave,* which in the textile trade is the word for a funeral. The window-arches of old Jaipur drifted on their black sea, each with its small open roof, and in the hot noise of the bazaar it seemed that nobody wished to be told that a thing may fall and still be beautiful.

"Priya-ji," said a voice at her elbow. "May I be of professional assistance?"

Vikram Rathore was wearing his saffron safa, his embroidered waistcoat and his moustache, and holding, with the care of a priest, a very large bunch of his

tourists. He had brought eleven that morning, Dutch, damp, and under instructions. He had told them, on the steps of the Hawa Mahal, that there was a collection in Johari Bazaar that would change their view of architecture, and then, in a hushed voice, with his hand on his heart, that it was made by a *young lady with no roof in her soul.*

"They are not here to buy," said Priya.

"They are here to *weep,*" said Vikram. "It is the same thing, one step earlier." He turned to the Dutch, and his voice swelled to the voice that he used for the dead and the maharajas. "Ladies and gentlemen! Observe the window. It is the window of the Chandpole house of my grandmother's grandmother. And here, in the cloth, *where the roof should be,* observe the *nothing.* This is a nothing that has been very carefully made. It is the most expensive nothing in Rajasthan."

There was a pause. A tall damp woman at the back raised a handkerchief to her eyes.

"I will take the one with the broken arch," she said.

"I will take two," said her husband. "They are for the children. We have no roof in Rotterdam either."

Reader, it is a tender thing to see forty thousand rupees pass between persons who understand each other through a weeping Dutchwoman. By the third day the shop had sold eleven.

On the fourth morning, the *Jaipur Mirror* ran a column on the third page, headed **THE NOTHING THAT SELLS**, written by one Pooja Tiwari, twenty-seven, who had been given the society column in the belief that she

would lose it. She wrote of a collection of fifty cloths in which *every roof had been left out, and every window left in,* and went on, in a style she had learned from the odds at a wedding, to say that it was the first time the sky had been seen in a shop in Johari Bazaar *since the sky was invented.* She added, in a postscript, that she was giving twenty rupees to anyone who could say what the guide in the peacock waistcoat was doing there. By noon there was a queue to the end of the street.

It was women. It was hundreds of women, in the week of Gangaur, in orange and green and rose, who had been told by a column that there was a cloth that did not hide the sky, and who had come to find that they had been waiting for it. By Friday evening all fifty pieces had gone. Nine uncles stood in the empty shop under a bare wire, with their hands behind their backs, like a delegation to a funeral that had unexpectedly turned out to be a wedding.

✦ ✦ ✦

At half past nine, with the shutters half down, Mahendra Sharma stood alone at the end of the showroom, and looked at the wire.

He was fifty-eight, in a good grey suit, with a thin black moustache and the face of someone who lost an argument in 1998 and has been preparing his revenge ever since. He heard the curtain move. He did not turn.

“Fifty,” said Priya.

“Not fifty-one.”

“No.”

“They have all gone.” He said it as one reads figures off a gravestone. “I am told the reorder is two hundred. The buyers of three shops in Delhi, who are fools, have telephoned. I have said that I will think.”

“Papa.”

“Two hundred pieces, at wholesale, on the Sharma label. It is simple. You will make them. It is business, beta. You will understand that I do it in a professional capacity.”

“No, Papa,” said Priya.

It was said quite gently. It was the voice of someone who has practised a sentence in the bath for seven years and finds, at the moment of speaking, that it has grown shorter.

“Fifty was the collection. The rest is a different house. I have taken a room.” She drew breath. “It is a corner of the haveli, in Chandpole. The north wing. There is a courtyard, and a neem tree, and no roof. The rent is a thousand rupees a month. I shall block-print there, with twelve women from Bagru, under my own name. You may have your two hundred yards, Papa, if you like. I will sell them to you at a fair price, like any supplier. But I will not be *inherited.*”

For a long time Mahendra Sharma did not move.

Then he put out one hand, and took hold of the last scrap of indigo that had been left on the wire, a rag, a cutting, a nothing, and rubbed it between his finger and thumb, as a mill-owner does, to learn the weave. His

face did not change. But something went through his thumb and into the cloth, a long and unadmitted tenderness.

“It is a very good dye,” said Papa Sharma.

“It is mud-resist and indigo. Eleven dips.”

“Eleven.” He nodded. “Your mother used to say that the sky is only a sort of blue that has not been asked.”

He put the cutting in his breast pocket. He straightened his tie, and walked to the curtain, and stopped in front of it, without turning round.

“A fair price,” he said. “I will want it in writing.”

“I will draw up a contract.”

“See that you do.” And he went out through the dead fly and the dust, a small stiff grey man who had not forgiven anyone, and who walked, for the first time in years, as though looking at something a little above his head.

✦ ✦ ✦

The haveli, that night, had no moon over it, and so the sky was very large.

She found him in the great ground-floor room, under the place where the roof had been, in a column of starlight, with three hundred blocks of seasoned teak stacked around him like the pages of a closed book. He was sitting on the floor in his waistcoat, without the safa, and without the moustache wax, for once looking like what he was, a tired and kind man of thirty on a stone floor.

“I have brought the rent,” said Priya.

“The *rent.*” Vikram stood up, and put his hand to his heart, and spoke in his Thursday voice, which was a little cracked. “Priya-ji, I cannot accept money from a woman who has made fifty skies and sold—”

“Landlord,” said Priya. “Take it.”

She put into his hand an envelope with a thousand rupees in it, in notes of one hundred, and a receipt, which she had drawn up herself, and which said, in a very exact hand, *Received, one month’s rent on the north wing, with sky.*

He read it twice. In the starlight his face did the unpractised thing it had done in her father’s boardroom: for the length of a breath, it did not perform.

“It is the first rent in forty years,” said Vikram. “My grandfather let it go the year the roof went. I thought the house had stopped being a *house.*” He folded the paper, as if it were something that might spill. “I will not spend it. I shall frame it. And then I shall spend it, I think, on the first tile.”

“A tile will not do much.”

“It is not for the tile,” said Vikram Rathore. “It is for the *direction.*”

On the far side of the city, Pooja Tiwari was walking home from a deadline, adding a line to a bet. *Twenty rupees,* it read, *says the roof goes up before Diwali. Fifty says the guide proposes under it.* She read it over, and smiled, and crossed out *fifty.* She wrote *a hundred.*

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., against Entries 0029, 0447, 0626 and 0561:

Spring is the season in which the whole world wears a mask, and I do not wonder that this book has come to it. There are two kinds of persons: those who hide the face and show the work, and those who show the work and hide the face. A carver and an actress are the same woman and the same man, standing on either side of a wall of cypress, saying thank you.

And a girl who will not be inherited has found a haveli with no roof, and a landlord with no sense. Mark this, for the Act is turning: it is in the season of masks that people are most likely to be found.

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End of Chapter 25.

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Chapter 26: The Trapeze Wire

“I read your scans. I know what you hide.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0137

✦ ✦ ✦

Bucharest, a Tuesday in April, 10:40 in the morning.

The Circul Aurora kept its winter quarters in a tin-roofed hangar beside the Dâmbovița, where the river ran the colour of weak tea and the pigeons nested in the trapeze rigging, on the theory that if a man may fly for a living, a bird may do it for free.

The hangar smelled of sawdust, horse, resin, and the hot sugar of the popcorn machine that Mihai Stanciu, the company carpenter, kept running because a circus without the smell of sugar is only a barn with ambitions. High above the ring, nine metres up under the iron rafters, a wire was strung. On the wire, in grey training clothes and bare feet, with a balance pole across his palms like a man carrying a sleeping child, walked Andrei Popescu.

He was thirty-one, and he was the best the company had. Everyone said so, including the posters, which showed him ten years younger. He had walked the wire in Prague and Lyon and Tbilisi, and once across a court-

yard in the rain with a lit candle on his head, without losing a drop of wax. Now he walked it as other men walk to the kitchen, thinking of nothing, humming a tune that was most probably a lullaby.

In the front row of the empty seats, as she had been every morning for three weeks, sat a librarian.

“He is going to fall,” said Roxana Ionescu, fifty-one, devout, and the owner of a handbag large enough to conceal a small choir. She crossed herself. “I can feel it in my knees.”

“You said that on Monday,” said Ionuț Constantin beside her, who in his working life conducted the 783 bus from Piața Unirii to the northern ring road and in his private life conducted everyone else’s affairs. “And on Friday. And, if I am not mistaken, at Christmas.”

Reader, here is the secret of the wire, which no poster tells. A man who walks it does not look at the rope. He looks at the far platform, and the rope looks after itself. But to look at the far platform one must hold the back straight, and the back, that morning, in the thirty-first year of its life and the fourth of its secret, had begun to keep its own counsel.

Andrei reached the middle. He paused, as he always paused, to give the audience time to forgive him for being so graceful. There was no audience; there was only Roxana, and the pigeons, and the sugar smell. He lifted his rear foot to turn, and a hot white thread ran up the left side of his spine and tied itself, very neatly, behind his eyes.

He did not cry out. A man at nine metres does not cry out; he calculates. He calculated that the net was below him, that if he turned a quarter-turn on the way down he would land on the shoulder, and a shoulder is a thing one may spare. He calculated all this in the time it takes to say *no*.

Then the wire let him go.

He turned the quarter-turn. It was beautiful, and nobody has ever said so, because it was also a fall. The net took him, and then the iron ring at the corner, where Mihai had been meaning, since Thursday, to fix a loose bolt, gave a little. There was a sound like a sack of flour set down on a table. Then there was a silence, and in the silence a pigeon, offended, left the rafters.

"*Doamne!*" said Roxana Ionescu, and there was nothing comic in it.

Mihai was already running, apron flapping, hammer still in his fist.

"Andrei! Andrei, do not move! Do not move, I'll call—"

"I am not moving," said the acrobat, from the net, in a voice that was perfectly calm and a very strange colour. "I am having a thought. It is a long one. Give me a moment."

"What thought?"

"That the floor," said Andrei, "has *never* been my friend."

✦ ✦ ✦

The Emergency Department, Floreasca, 1:15 the same night.

(*The waiting room. A vending machine that hummed a single note, flat, forever. Under its fluorescent light the Bucharest night shift went about its holy work, which is mopping. Andrei had refused an ambulance for fourteen hours, on the principle that a man who can still complain can still work; at one in the morning the pain won the argument.*)

The nurse on duty at the triage desk was named Ioana Dumitrescu. She was twenty-eight, and she wore her hair in a plait so tight that patients sometimes thought she must be angry, when she was only thorough. She had a pen in her pocket and another in her hair, and in her bag a small ugly sandwich she meant to eat at four, and would not.

At 1:15 a tall man in grey training clothes was brought in on a trolley by two ambulance men, a carpenter, and a librarian who would not be told to wait outside. He was grey in the face, and he was making jokes.

"My name," said the man, to the ceiling, "is Andrei Popescu, I am thirty-one years old, and I have fallen from a height of nine metres, which in my profession is called *a Tuesday*."

"Date of birth?" said Ioana, without looking up.

Popescu, Andrei.

She had read that name in October, at the private clinic on Calea Dorobanților where she worked three Saturdays a month for the extra money, on a radiograph that had been left in the wrong envelope. It had been the

spine of a young man, a dancer or a soldier by the muscle on the shadows, and in it were two vertebrae, the first and second lumbar, that had been broken once and had healed crooked, like a road mended by a poet. The report beneath had said, in the cold type of such reports: *Unfit for load-bearing athletic activity. Recommend immediate cessation.* The envelope had been collected an hour later by a man in a cap, who had kept his face turned to the wall. She had thought of that spine a good deal since. A nurse is uneasy about a lamp left burning in a stranger's window.

"Ms. Dumitrescu?" said the carpenter. "Is anything wrong?"

"No," said Ioana. She capped the pen. "Take him to Bay Four. Gently. Mind the corner."

It was a long night. They did the scans. The registrar, a grave young man who tapped his teeth with a biro, said that nothing was newly broken, that the left shoulder was badly bruised, and that there was an old injury of the lumbar spine, quite old, curious. He asked the patient whether he had ever hurt his back before. "Never," said Andrei, brightly. "I am a man of the air. Backs are for people who stay on the ground." The registrar looked at Ioana. Ioana looked at the wall chart, on which was a diagram of a heart, with valves, in cheerful red.

When the registrar had gone, and the curtain around Bay Four had been drawn, and the night had settled, she came in with a cup of water he had not asked for and a blanket he had.

"You are not asleep," said Ioana.

“I do not sleep on the ground.”

“Drink this.”

“I read your X-ray,” said Ioana. “In October.”

He did not move. There are two kinds of stillness: the kind that is peace, and the kind that is holding a plate on one’s head in an earthquake. This was the second.

“Which X-ray?”

“The one that was in the wrong envelope. At the clinic on Dorobanților. I did not know it was yours until your name.” She sat on the edge of the stool, with her hands between her knees, very straight. “I did not tell anyone. I am telling no one. I want you to know that before anything else. But I could not let you lie here and say *never*, to a man with a pen, and have it go in a file.”

“You were not supposed to see it.”

“No. Neither were you supposed to leave it.”

“I was not *leaving* it.” He had turned his face to the pillow. When he spoke again his voice was very low. “I was afraid to carry it. It is a ridiculous thing. I will walk nine metres of wire on a bare foot with a hundred faces under me, and I am afraid of a piece of plastic the size of a newspaper. Do you know what it said?”

“Yes.”

“Then you know what I am.”

“I know what you *were told,*” said Ioana. “It is not the same thing.”

“If they know,” said Andrei, “I am finished. The company. The wire. Mihai. The old man who made the net. They will be kind about it, which is worse. They will give me a desk, with a lamp.”

“Is a lamp so terrible?”

“For someone who has lived in the air between two points?” He turned his head and, for the first time, looked at her. His eyes were brown, and wet, and amused at themselves. “Nurse Dumitrescu. I will ask you something unreasonable.”

“I am a nurse. I am used to it.”

“Do not tell me to stop.”

She was silent for a long time. Out in the corridor a trolley rolled by with a small bad wheel.

“I will not tell you to stop,” said Ioana, at last. “I am a nurse. I do not tell people what to do with their bodies. I only tell them what the bodies are saying. But I will say it once, and plainly, and then not again unless you ask.” She drew a breath. “Your spine is a column of very small decisions. Each year it has made a few more of them without you. One day it will decide the whole matter, and it will not consult.”

“And if I ask you to stay while it thinks?”

“Then I would be on the night shift,” said Ioana, “in any case.”

She rose, and drew up the blanket, and left, and did not look back; a nurse never does, at a lit bay.

Alone, in the night, with a vending machine humming flat in the distance and the whole city sleeping on its fault-line of old and new, Andrei Popescu spoke to the ceiling, which was the only audience he had ever fully trusted:

The ground, they say, is where a man belongs. I think the ground is where I'm most afraid: Where every step is flat and nothing sings, Where you may walk a lifetime and not rise. Up there, nine metres, on the thread of steel, I have a face; I have a use; I know Exactly where I am, and what I'm for. Down here, I am a spine and an X-ray And a long list of the things I may not do. And yet, tonight, a stranger touched my shoulder And told me what my body said — and did not Command me — and I find that I am listening. Let the wire wait. Let it hang there in the dark, And let me learn what height there is in staying.

Then, being a professional, he slept.

✦ ✦ ✦

Karachi. A flooded pitch at dawn, the same week.

(*The Salt Creek Cricket Academy, which was a field, a roof, and an idea. The field had been under a metre and a half of the monsoon last August; it was now under a hand's breadth of drying grey silt, cracked like old glaze.*)

At 6:10 in the morning, the hour when Karachi smells most of the sea, Hamza Qureshi stood at the crease of a pitch that was not there and bowled an imaginary ball to a boy who was.

“Again,” he said. “Wrist. *Wrist,* Waqar.”

Waqar Shah, eleven years old, in a shirt three sizes too large and a cap with *Fear Nobody* sewn on it, pushed the bat forward in the grey dust and missed the air by a hand. Hamza, who was twenty-nine and wore his optimism like a good coat, so that no one should see what it covered, clapped.

“Better!”

“I missed it, Coach.”

“You missed it *better*. Last week you missed it badly. A man who misses better each week will, one day, by pure accident, hit it, and then he is a batsman and I am a genius.”

“Coach,” said a voice from the boundary rope. Sana Ahmed stood there in her riding jacket, helmet in one hand, a newspaper in the other. “I said I would bring it myself.”

He took it. It was still warm from the press, the way a loaf is warm. The headline was in the black Urdu of serious news, and beneath it, in smaller type, in English, for the benefit of the ministries: **WHO DRAINED THE CREEK? The Money Behind Karachi’s Flooded Streets, and the Names Behind the Money.**

By Sana Ahmed. A long article, three pages, with photographs: of a dry channel, a locked gate, a signature.

“I did not think they would run it,” said Hamza.

“Neither did I.” Sana’s voice was steady. Her hands, he noticed, were not. “My editor stood in the print room until the plates were made. Then he went home and I

think he has been sick. I have been on the bike for four hours. I did not want to be anywhere that I had been before."

"Sana."

"You will say that I should be careful."

"I was going to say," said Hamza gently, "that you have not eaten."

She stared at him. Then, to her own great surprise, she laughed, a short unwilling laugh, which turned in the middle into something else; and he put the paper down on the bare pitch, under a stone, and put into her hands, instead, a paper cup of chai that had been brewed by the sea wind on a kerosene stove and was, in consequence, the best she had ever tasted.

At the wall, Sana's mother, Mrs. Hira Shah, seventy-five, retired lifeguard of Clifton beach and the only person in Karachi who had pulled eleven strangers and one husband from the Arabian Sea, had come up quietly behind her daughter and set her hand between her shoulder-blades, where one checks a swimmer's breathing.

"Beta," said Hira. "You are home."

"I am only here for the tea, Ammi."

"Yes. And I am only here for the sea." She did not take her hand away.

Then, from the lane, the sound of a car, slow and grey, that did not belong to any neighbour, and which, once it had stopped by the gate, did not at once turn off its engine. A man got out. He was in a clean grey shalwar kameez and good shoes, quite unhurried, and under his

arm, folded small, was the same newspaper. He did not look at Sana. He looked at the boys, one by one, as if counting fruit. Then he walked up to little Waqar Shah, who stood with the bat in both hands and his cap that said *Fear Nobody,* and smiled at him, and bent down, and said, in a voice as mild as milk—

Here the page is torn.

✦ ✦ ✦

Seoul, the same evening. A narrow shop in the lanes behind Gwangjang Market.

(*The shop was the width of a wardrobe and the depth of a sigh. Bolts of silk leaned in the corners like tired dancers. On a mannequin by the window hung something unfinished, charcoal-blue, with its arms not yet attached.*)

Ji-woo Han, twenty-six, hanbok tailor, was pinning a sleeve and not thinking about the man who was late.

She was exact. She had measured the bride from Busan and the grandmother from Daegu and the boy of three who would not stand still for his first-birthday *dol*; she knew the width of every shoulder in the lane, and the tilt of every neck, and which woman in the district had lately lost, in sorrow, an inch round the waist. She had measured the whole district, one citizen at a time, and never once Daniel Cho.

This she regarded as a professional lapse.

“Unlocked again,” said a voice at the door, and in came Ji-ah Yoon, fifty-eight, goldsmith, from the shop next door, wearing a magnifier on her forehead like a

third eye and carrying a plate of rice cakes, which she placed on the cutting table without being asked. “Every night I go home and check, and every morning it is unlocked.”

“I locked it,” said Ji-woo.

“Then anything has been walking in. Two cats and a man selling insurance. And a boy who coaches the computer-game people.”

“He does not walk in.” She bit off a thread. “He stands in the doorway for five minutes every Thursday and looks at the silk. And then he buys a pair of socks.”

“How many pairs has the boy got?”

“Forty-one.”

“*Forty-one!*” The goldsmith removed the magnifier, the better to look reverent. “That is the most romantic thing I have ever heard.”

At that moment the bell over the door gave its small bronze cough, and Daniel Cho, twenty-seven, tall, awkward, with the folded posture of one who has spent years bent over other people’s screens, stood in the doorway, with rain on his shoulders and an umbrella he had plainly been lent against his will.

“I am not late,” said Daniel.

“You are twelve minutes late.”

“I was held up by an umbrella.” He held it out. On its handle was a small brass tag that said, in Hangul, *Yoon Joon-ho & Son, Rain-Goods.* “My friend Joon-ho sold me

this. He said that a man who goes to a tailor should have somewhere to put the rain. It was forty-one thousand won."

Ji-ah Yoon had risen, and was now, with enormous tact, retreating towards the door, taking the rice cakes with her on the principle that they were an accessory to the crime. "I will be next door," she said. "Making a ring for nobody. If anything is needed, the door is unlocked."

"It is *not*—"

But the goldsmith was gone, and the bell had rung, and the rain, that had grown shy, took up its quiet knocking again on the tin awning.

"I made you something," said Ji-woo.

She went to the mannequin. She lifted the sleeves from their basket, one in each hand, as a priest lifts the vessels. And she fixed them, quite quickly, with five pins, to the shoulders of the charcoal-blue shape in the window; and it was suddenly not a shape at all, but a coat.

It was a *durumagi*, the overcoat of the old gentlemen, long and plain and wide in the sleeve, cut from a ramie the colour of the sky just before it has decided to be night. The collar was narrow; the ribbons were of undyed silk, the grey of a dove's back; the seams so fine they might have been drawn in pencil. It was not a coat for a young man. It was a coat for someone who intended to be quiet for the rest of a long life, and wished to be dressed for it.

"I cannot afford it," said Daniel.

"It is not for sale."

“Then what is it?”

“A coat,” said Ji-woo. “Put it on.”

He did. It was an odd, solemn moment, with the bell silent and the rain on the awning and a man in a wet shirt being buttoned into the future. She stood behind him, to tug the shoulders straight. The coat fell from his neck to his shin as water falls from a hillside; it was exactly as wide as his back, exactly the weight of the evening.

“It fits,” said Daniel, in a voice of pure astonishment.

“Of course it fits.”

“But you never measured me.”

“No.”

“You measure everyone. You measured the baby.”

“I measured everyone,” said Ji-woo, “but you.” She said it to the back of his collar, so that he should not see her face. “I did not need to. I have been taking your measure since the first Thursday. The width of the door when you fill it. The height your head reaches against the third bolt of silk. The way your left shoulder drops, from forty hours a week in a chair, and the way it lifts, a little, when you think no one is looking, whenever the bell rings.” She smoothed the sleeve. “I did not want to *measure* you. A measurement is only a number. I wanted to know you before I wrote you down.”

“I have quit the team,” he said. “I have no title. I have a school with eleven children and a flat the size of a drawer.”

“I know.”

“I want a quiet life.”

“I know that too.” She walked round, until she was facing him, and took the cloth tape from about her neck, her oldest instrument and her least decorative, and held it up. “And now, with your permission, because the coat is finished and I should like it to be *correct*: your arms. Out. For the cuffs.”

He held out his arms.

She measured them, wrist to shoulder, with the grave concentration of an astronomer fixing a star; then, because the tape had run out, and because he was not looking at the tape, she let her fingers rest, for one instant longer than the measure required, upon the inside of his wrist, where the pulse was loud as a drum in a small room.

“Sixty-one centimetres,” said Ji-woo, a little unsteadily.

“Is that good?”

“It is *exact*,” she said; and, against all her rules, she smiled.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., against Entries 0697 and 0137 (Bucharest):

A wire, a scan, a sleeve: three kinds of thread, and not one of them knows how much weight it will be asked to bear.

I have kept a great many letters about falling. I have kept very few about the courage of those who stand at the bottom with their arms out. Mark the name Dumitrescu. A catch is a kind of confession, too.

As for Karachi — forgive me. I would give a good deal to turn the page. I cannot. It was torn before it reached me.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 26.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 27: Bridges over the Tigris

“I am building a bridge so you will have somewhere to come back to.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0076

✦ ✦ ✦

Enter the Chorus, between two rivers, one brown and slow, one that exists only in the rains.

Two roads are laid tonight by two proud hands: One crosses water; one outruns the sun. The first is built that someone may return; The second, that a woman may be gone. And both, my friends, are only ways of saying What neither builder dares to say aloud. Now mark: the one who makes the bridge is shy, The one who makes the road has given her knee. Walk softly. Spans are strong, but they have limits, And knees, and hearts, and mornings, have them too.

✦ ✦ ✦

Baghdad, the Karkh bank of the Tigris, five o’clock on a Thursday in spring.

The bridge had no name yet. The city council had held three meetings on the subject, in the course of which a retired electrician named Huda Al-Tamimi, seventy-

three, had proposed that it be called *The Bridge That Was Finished Before the Meetings*, and had been thanked for her contribution and asked to leave.

It was a footbridge, two hundred and forty metres from bank to bank, slung low over the river in a long white curve like the stroke of a calligrapher's pen. On the Rusafa side it came down at the foot of the old street of the booksellers, where on Fridays the pavement vanished beneath a tide of paper. On the Karkh side it came down in a garden of young palms, beside a café where the tea was served in small waisted glasses and the owner had never in his life been in a hurry.

It was nearly done. The deck was laid. The cables sang, very faintly, in the evening wind. At the centre, one segment of the walkway, three metres long, lay on the barge below, wrapped in tarpaulin, to be lifted into place at dawn. Until then there was a gap. Between the two halves of the bridge, over the brown water, nothing at all.

Mustafa Karim stood on the western half and looked at the nothing.

He was thirty-four, a civil engineer, who believed in numbers because numbers, unlike people, could be checked. He had a pencil behind his ear, a hard hat in his hand, and a patient, stubborn face that had spent twelve years trying to look as though it had no feelings and had never once managed it. He had been awake since four. He had a spreadsheet in his head that told him the exact weight, in kilonewtons, that each cable

would carry, and another, which he did not consult, that told him how many days it was until the woman who had drawn the bridge went away.

“You are staring,” said Shaimaa Al-Obaidi.

She was the stonemason, twenty-eight, broad of shoulder and dry of tongue, in a head-scarf grey with dust and a leather apron that had seen the better part of a quarry. She was on her knees at the foot of the western pylon, tapping with a small chisel at the lettering of a stone plaque. She had been given the text by a committee. She had been tapping at it for a week.

“I am inspecting,” said Mustafa.

“You are staring at a hole with your heart showing.”

“Shaimaa.”

“I carve stone, Engineer. I am not obliged to be tactful. The stone cannot hear me and the public does not read the small print.” She blew the dust from a letter. “Do you want to know what the committee wants me to write?”

“I have read the draft.”

“*To the glory of the city and the unity of its people, this bridge was opened in the year such-and-such.* And then fourteen names. Fourteen! Including a deputy assistant of a department that did not, I think, lift a stone.” She sat back. “Your name is ninth. Hers is eleventh. She drew the whole thing, and she is eleventh. I told them it was an affront to the alphabet.”

“The order is by seniority.”

“And the *bridge,* is it by seniority?”

He did not answer. Below them, on the bank, the schoolchildren of the district were already gathering for the evening's tour, in blue pinafores and white shirts, shepherded by two harassed teachers and a sheep that someone had brought and nobody would admit to. A ten-year-old with ink on his chin, named Ahmed, stood apart from the rest, counting the bolts in the abutment aloud.

"Four hundred and twelve," he announced. "Four hundred and thirteen. Engineer! There is one that is a different colour."

"That one," said Mustafa, "was a mistake."

"Does it hold?"

"It holds."

"Then it is not a mistake," said Ahmed, with the severity of the very young. "It is just a different *opinion.*"

Shaimaa laughed out loud. Mustafa, who was trying not to, took a long time to find his pencil.

✦ ✦ ✦

She came at sunset, as she always came. He would never have admitted that he knew the hour.

Noor Hashim was thirty, an architect, and she walked like someone who has been told since the age of six that she is going to be remarkable, and has made the best of it. She wore a long coat the colour of wet sand and carried a roll of drawings under one arm and, in her satchel, where it had lain for eleven days, an envelope with a foreign stamp.

She had drawn the bridge. Not the cables and the weight; that was his. She had drawn the *way* of it: the long curve, the benches in the shade of the pylons, the lamps along the rail, each set in a small pierced shade of brass so that at night the light fell on the deck in the patterns of old Abbasid windows, stars within stars. A hundred and twelve lamps. She had drawn every one of them by hand.

"You are early," said Mustafa.

"You are on the wrong side of the gap," said Noor.

"I am on the side that has the tea."

She had brought, as she always did, two glasses and a flask. She set them on an upturned crate by the pylon and poured; cardamom, sugar, and a thread of steam, the whole of Baghdad in an inch of amber glass. They drank together, on the bridge to nowhere, looking at the place where the bridge was not.

"Tomorrow," said Noor.

"Tomorrow at six. The crane comes at half past five."

"And then it is a bridge."

"And then it is a bridge," Mustafa agreed, "and I am a man who has nothing to do."

"You will have the next one."

"I do not want the next one." He said it to the water. "I want to stand at this end of it, at nine in the morning, on a Friday, and watch a boy with a bad shirt cross to buy a book he cannot afford. I want to watch a girl run across it, late for school. I want to watch an old man stop in the middle, as old men do, and be annoyed that

there is no bench. There *is* a bench." He rubbed his eyes. "Do you see? I am not building a bridge. I am building a place for people to come back to."

He had said more than he had intended. In the tea-glass his reflection trembled.

"For whom?" said Noor.

"For the city."

"And for—"

"For *the city,* Noor."

She turned the glass in her fingers. In her satchel the envelope lay against her hip, like a small stone in a shoe.

"I have a letter," she said.

"I know."

"You *know?*"

"You touch your bag every four minutes," said Mustafa. "It is a professional tell. I once watched a contractor do the same with a counterfeit cheque." He did not look at her. "It is from abroad. It is thick. It is a good letter."

"It is a scholarship," said Noor. "In Copenhagen. Two years, for the study of rivers in cities: how a city should live beside its water. They have chosen me out of four hundred." Her voice had gone very quiet, and very exact. "I have until the seventh to say yes."

"The seventh is Saturday week."

"I can count, Mustafa."

"You should go," he said.

“You say that very fast.”

“I have had eleven days to practise.”

She laughed, not happily, and set down her glass. “You are *impossible.* You will not ask. You will not say stay. You will not even say that you will mind.”

“If I said that I minded,” said Mustafa, “you would stay. Out of kindness. And in a year you would be a woman who had stayed out of kindness, and you would look at this bridge, and you would not see a bridge. You would see a *wall.*” He turned to her at last, and his face, in the going light, was plain and gentle as a brick. “I would rather be a man you left than a man you were *kept* by.”

“And what if I come back?”

“Then I shall be here.”

“At the bridge.”

“It will be here. I will be somewhere near it.” He tried a smile, and nearly managed. “I am an engineer. I only promise things that have been load-tested.”

She stood up. She walked to the very edge of the western span, where the white deck stopped, and stood there in her sand-coloured coat with the wind pulling at the roll of drawings, and looked across the gap to the other side, where the bookshops were putting out their lamps. A single boy was crossing the old stone arch at the end of the street, with a sack on his shoulder, very small at that distance. He looked, she thought, like a comma.

“I will tell you what I will do,” said Noor. “I will not answer tonight. And I will not answer tomorrow. I will answer *after.* After the bridge is opened. After I have walked across it. I want to know what it feels like, to cross a thing I have made, before I decide to cross a thing I have not.”

“That is reasonable.”

“It is the least reasonable thing I have ever said.” She did not turn round. “Will you walk with me?”

“First?”

“At the opening there will be a ribbon, and fourteen names, and a deputy of something. I mean *before.* At dawn. When the crane has gone and the last piece is in, and it is only us and the river.”

“The council will be furious.”

“The council,” said Noor, “can have the sheep.”

He stood beside her on the edge. Neither said anything more; for what is there to say on a bridge that does not yet touch the other bank? Below them, the Tigris went about its ancient business, carrying the sky to the sea. And Mustafa Karim, who did not believe in anything he could not check, took the pencil from behind his ear and, without a word, drew on the white edge of the deck, in a small, firm hand, where no inspector would ever look, a line.

It was a plain line, a hand’s breadth long. Beside it he wrote a single number.

She read it, and did not ask what it meant. It was the span of her stride.

✦ ✦ ✦

Addis Ababa, Meskel Square, 6:10 on a Sunday morning.

(*The altitude, two thousand three hundred and fifty-five metres. The air thin and cold, and bright as a struck bell. The sun not yet over the Entoto hills, but making up its mind.*)

The women's field had been called to the line, and Selam Tesfaye was kneeling on the tarmac with her left leg stretched before her like an unpaid bill.

"Do not look at it," said Abel Haile, the nurse who had been her friend for eleven years and her physiotherapist for the last four, and who was, at that moment, taping her knee with the grim concentration of a bomb-disposal officer. "It is looking at *you*, and it is not impressed."

"It has been looking at me for nine months."

"It has been making a very *clear* case. Have you heard it?"

"I have heard it."

"And?"

"I am not a tribunal, Abel. I do not rule on knees." Selam was thirty-three, lean and brown and fierce, with a long jaw, long thighs and a stillness at the centre of her that unsettled strangers; she had run for her country at three Games, and after today, in all probability, would run only for her own convenience. "Three more hours. Then it may be as unhappy as it likes."

"And the injection?" said Abel, who knew the answer.

“No.”

At the barrier, a small, grey, exquisitely dressed man of sixty-two, with a spray of red roses held against his chest like a rifle, was watching her with an expression of deep suspicion. Yonas Mekonnen had been a florist for forty years and her coach for nineteen, and distrusted anything that could not be pruned.

“Take it,” he said, pushing a rose through the barrier. “A rose in the pocket is a good-luck thing.”

“It will be crushed.”

“So will we all.”

“That is not a comfort, Yonas.”

“I did not say it was a comfort. I said it was a rose.”

Beside him, in a white netela shawl and a grey-brown headscarf, her prayer-cord wound twice round her fingers, stood the oldest and most terrible of her supporters: her mother, Tigist Girma, seventy-six, retired fishmonger, who had never been fooled by a daughter in her life and knew perfectly well that the knee was not the only thing the girl had decided not to mention. Tigist said nothing. She kissed her cross, held it for a moment above her daughter’s head, and put into Selam’s hands a small twist of cloth holding three roasted coffee beans.

“Chew them at the thirty-kilometre mark,” said Tigist. “The beans know you.”

“Yes, Mama.”

“And Selam.”

“Yes?”

“Run like a woman who has *finished,*” said her mother, “not like a woman who is *finishing.* There is a difference. The first has already won.”

“I will try, Mama.”

“Do not try. Trying is for those who are still afraid.”

“No,” said Selam, and there was in it the whole of a long season. “I think that I am not.”

At the very back of the crowd, behind the barrier, stood the man Selam did not look for.

Samuel Bekele was thirty-six, a coffee exporter of Merkato, steady, proud, and very tired. His brother, who had died in October, had left him eleven thousand sacks of green Yirgacheffe, a warehouse with a mortgage, and an unbroken chain of polite and utterly merciless creditors. He had a meeting at ten o’clock with the landlady of the warehouse, a blunt woman of fifty-five named Rahel Girma, who had told him that he might have until noon and not an hour after. He had a buyer in Hamburg who would sign for a price that was a kind of robbery, by the same hour. He had a telephone in his pocket, which had been ringing since five. He had not slept. He was wearing the wrong shoes. He had come to see her run.

✦ ✦ ✦

The Gulele Road, kilometre thirty-eight. Two hours and thirty-one minutes after the start.

(*Dawit Tadesse, fifty-nine, librarian of Bahir Dar and a man who had never been to the sea, was sitting in a café on the corner with a transistor radio. He was a little vain. He had been given leave to narrate.*)

“And now, ladies and gentlemen,” said Dawit, to a room of eleven men with glasses of macchiato and one cat, “I will tell you the manner of this race, for it is a thing of Homer. The leaders are three. They go, as the poet says, like three lions pursuing a fourth, who is an inferior lion and has already gone to lunch. Tesfaye, Selam, of the national club, is in second place. She has the knee of an old oak. She has the heart of a young one. She has, if I may say so, a great deal of timber.”

“*Sit down,*” said the café-owner.

“I will not sit down. I am *speaking.* I speak for the nation. Behold, she approaches the corner of the Gulele Road, with a rose in her pocket—”

“How do you know there’s a rose in her pocket?”

“I have *imagination,*” said Dawit, with dignity. “It is the chief function of the librarian.”

In truth, out on the road, the race was no longer a matter for epic. At thirty-eight kilometres, a runner is not a hero; a runner is a small, hot, rhythmic debt, owing the road everything. Selam ran. Her breath came in two beats and went out in two. The sun was well up now, and the hills had turned the colour of honey; the crowds at the roadside had thinned, and then grown, and then become a single sound. Her left knee was no longer a joint. It was an argument, delivered at intervals, in the voice of a hot nail.

She chewed her three beans.

I have run twenty years to reach this road, And every step was borrowed from the next. I gave my childhood to the hill; my youth To the long dark of

mornings; and today I give the knee. It is a fair exchange. I do not ask what I shall have for it. I ask the road to be a little shorter. The road is not a thing that hears. But look: The hill is gold. The air is thin. I breathe. Somewhere a woman says that I have finished. I'll run as though she were quite right.

At the thirty-ninth kilometre, on the corner by the old petrol station, there was a thermos held up over the barrier.

It was a plain steel thermos with a dent in it. The hand that held it was a man's, not young, tired, and quite steady. It held it out for the length of two strides, and she could have taken it, and did not; for to take it she would have had to look. She looked.

Samuel Bekele was not saying anything. He had no breath to spare. He had abandoned a minibus stuck in the crowds and run along the barrier for the last three kilometres, she saw, in the wrong shoes, in a jacket and a good tie, with a telephone buzzing like a trapped wasp in his pocket. His face was grey. He had never looked less like a coffee merchant, and never more like a man.

"It is *buna,*" he gasped. "Black. No sugar. Mama said the beans know you, but the *coffee* knows me."

She laughed. It cost her a breath, and she paid it.

"You have a meeting," said Selam.

"Yes."

"At ten."

"It is nine thirty-five."

“You will be late.”

“I will be very late,” said Samuel, and kept pace with her along the barrier, three steps, four, five, the thermos held up like a lamp, “and the warehouse will be a day closer to the creditors, and I will, I am afraid, be in a great deal of trouble. But I thought—” He paused to breathe. “I thought it was a more interesting trouble than the other.”

“Samuel.”

“What?”

“*Go.*”

“I am going,” said Samuel. And he kept running.

He ran when the barrier ended and the road narrowed, along the footpath, among the crowds. He ran the last four hundred metres on the pavement, a man in a tie, weeping and laughing and out of breath, while on the road beside him the woman he had not yet said a single word to about love gave her last whole self to the line. A hundred metres out her knee went, as a branch goes in a storm, and she did not stop. She did not stop; she ran on it, the leg dragging like a flag, and the crowd, who knew what it was seeing, rose in one body and made a noise that Dawit, in his café, described as *the sound of Mount Entoto clearing its throat.*

She crossed the line in third place, in two hours and forty-one minutes, and sat down on the road.

Abel reached her first. Then Yonas, with a rose. Then her mother, who did not run, but arrived, with her cross, as a ship arrives in harbour, having never doubted the

harbour. Selam sat with her knee in both her hands, and the sun on her face, and the whole bright, thin, gold-and-blue morning above her, and said, to no one:

"It has finished."

"The race?" said Abel.

"The knee."

"And you?"

She looked up. At the barrier, a little way off, a man in a good tie stood quite still, with a dented thermos in his hand, and the telephone in his pocket ringing, and ringing, and ringing, and not one hand moved to answer it.

"I do not know," said Selam, honestly. "I have not been this far before."

The pigeons rose from the square. Somewhere a church bell was striking the hour. Whether she would run again, the knee did not say; whether the warehouse would stand, the telephone did not say; whether two people who had not said a word of love would say one, the page, with rare restraint, declines to forecast.

But Samuel went through the barrier, at last, and gave her the coffee.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., against Entries 0076, 0165, 0233 and 0243:

A bridge and a road. One is built that a person may return; the other is run that a person may leave. I have noticed that the builders and the runners of

this world are, very often, the same people, at different hours.

I do not know whether Noor will cross. I know only that Mustafa drew a line the length of her stride, and that a man who does that has already said a great deal more than he thinks.

As for Selam: it is possible to finish one race and begin a very different one on the same road. The knee does not take part in that second. Ask the thermos.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 27.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 28: Strings in Vienna

“You are the one flat note in my perfect life.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0665

✦ ✦ ✦

Vienna, the Josefstadt, a lane too narrow for its own good. Monday, 8:02 in the morning.

The shop of Jonas Müller, maker of violins, had a door with a bell on it, and the bell rang a flat A.

Not very flat. A quarter of a tone, perhaps; the sound of a thing that has been left out in the rain and has decided to make the best of it. A man with a perfect ear would hear it and want to lie down. Jonas, who spent his days adjusting violins by a fraction of a hair, had owned the bell for three years, and could have replaced it for four euros.

He had not.

“It is *shameful,*” said Theresa Hofer, pushing open the door, so that the bell said its small sour sentence over her head. “A man who can tune a Guarneri by listening to its mother tongue, and he keeps a doorbell like a sick goat.”

“Good morning, Theresa.”

“I said it was a sick goat. You did not deny it.”

“I am a man of few denials.”

“You are a man of few *everything.*” She hung up her coat. She was forty-nine, a former tax inspector and the oldest apprentice in the history of Viennese lutherie; she had spent twenty years finding out what people owed, and wanted, for a change, to be paid in beauty. She wore a mustard-coloured apron, and on every Monday of the year she greeted her master with the same remark.

“I shall not live to see you married,” said Theresa.

“You are in excellent health.”

“One morning I shall die at the bench, covered in hide glue, and you will stand over me saying, *Oh, Theresa, if only I had asked her.*”

“Asked whom?”

“*Do not,*” said Theresa, with menace, “make me say the name.”

The workshop was long and narrow and smelled of spruce, varnish, hide glue, and the sweetness of old maple, the smell of wood that has been waiting. On the walls hung forty-one violins in various stages of undress, like a row of small, patient saints. At the far end, in the one good light, on a bench scored with thirty years of other men’s knives, lay a violin that was not forty-second in the line and was not for sale.

It was dark-gold, a little small in the body. Its neck was very thin. Inside it, visible through the f-hole to anyone who held it at the right angle to the lamp, a label had been written in pencil:

Für C. W. — die einzige Hand, die es braucht.

For C. W. — the only hand that needs it.

Jonas had been making it for three years. It was finished. He had finished it in November and had not been able to put down the file.

✦ ✦ ✦

The Musikverein, the Brahms Hall. The same morning, 9:30.

(*The orchestra, in its work-clothes, tuning. A hundred and one people, each wishing to be the exception to something.*)

On the podium, with her back to the Vienna Spring Orchestra and her face to the stage door, stood Clara Weber, thirty-two, imperious, in a black polo-neck and flat shoes, with a baton held between two fingers like a cigarette she had given up. She had been, at twenty-two, a violinist of astonishing promise; at twenty-three, a violinist with a tendon in her left hand that had snapped, in the middle of a Bach partita, like a thread in a draught. She had said, aloud, to the dressing-room mirror: *Very well.* Then she had picked up a baton, with the other hand, and made herself the finest conductor in the city.

Her face was as calm as a coin. Behind it, as every morning, was something that was not calm.

For three years, there had been, in her perfect life, one flat note.

It was not in the orchestra. It was in a small lane in the Josefstadt, where she passed on Mondays on her way to the Musikverein, since the bakery there made the only rye bread in Vienna she could stand. It was a door-

bell. It rang a quarter-tone below the A. And she had developed, in three years, a whole system of avoidance: she crossed the lane on the diagonal; she held her breath; she took, on one memorable occasion, a taxi in the other direction.

"Maestra?" said the concertmaster. "We are ready."

"Then so am I," said Clara. She raised the baton.

And at that moment the stage door opened, and in came a man in a conductor's uniform.

✦ ✦ ✦

"He is *the other kind,*" Theresa said afterwards, to anyone who would listen.

It was all, in a manner of speaking, Theresa's doing, though she denied it with the fervour of one caught with a hand in the cash-box. For in Vienna there are two sorts of conductors. There is the sort that stands on a podium and makes a hundred people produce Schubert. And there is the sort that stands on the number 49 tram, with a leather bag and a ticket-punch, and makes four hundred people a day produce a sullen euro-seventy. Lukas Bauer, thirty-seven, of the second sort, had that morning, at Theresa's request, been entrusted with a violin case.

"I am to give this," said Lukas, in the doorway of the Brahms Hall, case held out before him like an offering, "to the other conductor."

"Which other conductor?" said the concertmaster.

“The one with the stick. There was a label. It said *Conductor, Musikverein.* I thought, well, I am a conductor. And it is on my route. And it said *urgent.*” He raised his hands in a gesture of great innocence. “I have been conducting for twelve years and I have never once been urgent.”

“*Put it down,*” said Clara Weber, in a voice that had stopped, in its time, four hundred people mid-chord, “on the *chair.*”

He put it on the chair. He bowed to the orchestra and, to the delighted indignation of a hundred and one professionals, punched the stage-door pass from sheer habit, and left.

For a moment the hall was silent.

Then Clara, who could not help it, came down from the podium. She crossed the stage. She stood over the case. It was old, black, shabby at the corners, and it had on its lid, in a hand she had not seen in three years but which she would have known on the back of a postage stamp, her own initials.

She opened it.

The violin lay on the blue velvet, dark-gold, a little small, quite perfect. It had, she saw at once, a very thin neck. It had a chin-rest set a little lower than the standard. It had a nut cut a hair wider, to give a weak hand space to spread. It had been made, with a patience that was nearly an insult, for a hand that was not quite a violinist’s and was entirely one particular woman’s.

She lifted it. It weighed nothing. It weighed, she thought, about as much as a held breath.

“Maestra?” said the concertmaster.

“A moment.”

She set it under her jaw. She lifted the bow in her right hand, the strong one, and let her left find the neck, and it did; it found it at once, the way a hand finds the light switch in a house it has lived in all its life. She drew a single note. The open A.

It was beautiful. It was warm and dark and clear and unusually full, as though a voice had been waiting in the wood for decades for the permission to speak. And it was, by exactly a quarter of a tone, flat.

Clara stood quite still.

“It is flat,” said Clara Weber.

“Maestra, if I may—”

“It is *flat,* Franz. I know what it is. I have heard it every Monday for three years.” She lowered the violin. Her voice, which was the finest instrument she possessed, was doing something it had never done in public. “It is the exact flat. It is the *bell.*”

She turned. She put the violin carefully back in its case. She closed the lid.

“Rehearsal is cancelled,” said Clara. “Forty minutes. Play something *in tune* while I am gone.”

✦ ✦ ✦

The workshop in the Josefstadt, 11:15.

The bell rang. It was the wrong note. It had always been the wrong note, and today it was the only note in the world.

Jonas, with his back to the door, was engaged in the delicate business of fitting a soul-post, a small spruce dowel, no thicker than a pencil, between the belly and the back of a violin, by means of a hooked steel tool and the breath-held prayer his trade teaches early. He did not turn round. He could not afford to; the post would slip. He said only, to the violin:

"We are closed."

"You are *not.*"

He turned. The soul-post fell over. In the doorway, in a black polo-neck and flat shoes, with a violin case in her hand and a look that had in its time dissolved the nerve of three tenors and a prime minister, stood the finest conductor in Vienna.

"Frau Weber," said Jonas.

"Herr Müller."

"It is… a surprise."

"I should imagine so. It was meant to be a surprise. It was meant to be, I think, a *delicate* one, delivered by a person with a good sense of occasion." She set the case on the bench among the knives. "Instead it was delivered by a tram conductor, who punched the stage door."

"I did not send a tram conductor."

"No. That was your apprentice."

In the corner of the shop, where she had been busy for the last four minutes with a single piece of maple, Theresa Hofer said brightly, to the maple: “I shall be in the back. I have a *great deal* of back to attend to.”

The door to the back room closed. It did not click shut. It closed with the pointed softness of a door that has been told to listen.

“You tuned it wrong,” said Clara.

“I tuned it to the bell.”

“I know. I *heard.*”

“It is the only note,” said Jonas, and the words came out one by one, like coins counted onto a counter, “that I had, the first day you came in. I took your violin. I looked at it. I said something foolish about tendons. And as you left, the bell rang. And you stopped in the street, and you said, to nobody, *Your bell is flat.*” He swallowed. “It was the only thing you ever said to me. I could not mend it. It was yours.”

“I did not mean it as a gift.”

“I know.” He looked at his hands. They were large, and scarred, and very gentle, and at that moment completely unemployed. “I meant it as one.”

“You have kept a flat bell in a shop door,” said Clara slowly, “for three years. Because I said it was flat.”

“Yes.”

“And you made me a violin—*for me*—for three years, with a neck for this hand, and you tuned it to the bell.”

“I did not tune it to the bell. I tuned it to *you.* It happens that the bell is where you are.” He drew a breath. “Frau Weber. You are the most perfect musician I have ever seen. You have not made a mistake in my hearing. And I have thought, for three years, that if there were a single place in the world where a perfect woman might be allowed to be a quarter of a tone below the pitch, without the whole hall turning its head, I should like to have been the man who made it.”

Then she said, in a very odd voice:

“You are the one flat note in my perfect life.”

“I beg your pardon?”

“I wrote it down.” She had put a hand to her throat. “On a card, one night in the third winter, and I sent it to an old woman in England who was said to keep such things. I thought it would be an insult. I thought: I shall say something cruel, and be rid of it. And then I looked at what I had written, and it was not cruel at all. It was the only true sentence I had ever put on paper.”

“Frau Weber—”

“*Clara.* It is absurd. You have been making me a violin.”

“Clara.”

“Say it again.”

“*Clara,*” said Jonas Müller, as though he were testing a string.

She opened the case. She took out the violin, and she did what he had been afraid, for three years, she would do, and what he had never dared to hope. She tucked it

under her jaw, and set her left hand on the thin neck, and drew from it, very slowly, the first four bars of a slow movement of Schubert that he knew she knew, because he had seen the score on her stand. It was not a virtuoso's performance. Her left hand shook; there was a place where the fourth finger would not quite reach, and she took the note up an octave. But the sound was a long gold thread. It went through the dusty light, and the unfinished backs, and the sleeping varnish, until all forty-one violins on the walls seemed to hold their breath.

When she finished, she lowered the bow. She did not say anything.

"It is a good violin," said Jonas, hoarsely.

"It is a very good violin."

"It is tuned flat."

"It is tuned to the bell." She smiled; and it was a smile no podium had ever seen, small and lopsided and a little wet. "You will not mend the bell, Herr Müller."

"Never."

"Good," said Clara. "I have grown accustomed to being corrected by you."

From behind the door of the back room there came, quite audibly, the sound of a sob, a blown nose, and the low, triumphant mutter of a retired tax inspector saying, to nobody: *I will live to see it.*

Let others keep the finest, truest pitch. I'll keep the bell that rang the day you came, A quarter-tone below the measured world, And hang it, flat, above

the door for ever, That every soul who enters may be told: Not all perfection lies in being right; Some lies in being tuned to someone else.

✦ ✦ ✦

Verona, Via Cappello, the courtyard of the House of the Balcony. The same afternoon, 5:40.

(*A narrow court of old brick, ivy, and a green bronze statue whose right breast had been rubbed to a shine by a hundred years of hopeful tourists. Above it, the balcony, which Giulia Rossi had explained, eleven thousand times, was built in 1936 out of a sarcophagus.*)

"And that," said Giulia Rossi, thirty-one, balcony tour guide, cynic, in a green jacket with a laminated badge that said GUIDE and a pencil through her hair, "is the end of the tour. Thank you for your attention. Please do not take a photograph with the statue's hand in the position that I have asked you, three times, *not* to take it."

"But it is *lucky,*" said Francesca Costa, a weaver of fifty from Mantua in the rear of the party, who had been anxious since childhood. "If you touch it, you will find love."

"You will find a hand," said Giulia, "that has been touched by four million other people, and a mild case of something. Next."

It was the last group of the day: twenty schoolchildren from Naples, two harassed teachers, and an unattached weaver. One of them, a girl of ten named Francesca Gallo, severe in a navy cardigan, with her hair in two precisely equal plaits, raised her pencil.

“Signorina. Who writes the answers?”

“What answers?”

“To the letters. In the wall. It says on the sign: *The Secretaries of Juliet answer every letter.* Who are they?”

“A committee,” said Giulia, “of very old women.”

“That is not true.”

“It is *partly* true.”

“Which part?”

“The part about the women.” Giulia looked at the child, and the child looked at her, and for a moment there was something between them as between two very precise people at a very large party. “It is a thing, signorina. People write to Juliet because it is easier than writing to a person. And now and then someone answers.”

“Why?”

“Because they were once,” said Giulia Rossi, who would have been surprised to hear herself say it, “an answer that was never sent.”

There was a pause. In the arch of the entrance, with his collar up and a cap drawn low, a man had stopped. He was tall, and slightly overdressed for the weather, and wore dark glasses on a cloudy afternoon in a way that suggested he thought they made him anonymous and that they made him, by the most elementary principles of optics, extremely conspicuous.

He was Marco Bellini, thirty-four, tenor, and he was terrified.

It was the terror of a person whose whole life is arranged for a single moment, three hours long, in front of eleven thousand people in an arena of stone; a moment in which he had been celebrated, golden-throated, perfect, and in which, since the winter, he had been seized by an unknown hand and shaken like a bell. He forgot words. His knees sang. In a rehearsal in February he had stood on the stage in Parma unable to produce a single note, and the conductor had said, kindly: *Take your time, Maestro;* and he had taken eleven minutes.

In his coat pocket, as he stood in the arch, was a letter he had written and not posted. In his other pocket, folded very small, was the last reply he had received from the wall. It was written in a small, upright, rather severe hand, on cream paper, and it said:

Dear Signor B. — Do not sing to the theatre. Sing to the one person in the third row who has stopped breathing. The rest is architecture. — J.

"*Bellini!*" said Francesca Costa, the weaver, in a stage-whisper that could be heard in the Piazza Erbe. "Is it? *Is it?* From the posters!"

"No," said Marco. "I am a man who looks like him."

"But *you are him.*"

"I am a man who looks like him *a great deal.*"

"Sing!" cried a child.

"Sing!" cried twenty.

"*Sing!*" cried the weaver, wringing her hands, which she did out of pure anxiety about the possibility that he would.

And Marco Bellini, tenor, who could not sing before eleven thousand people, took off his dark glasses, and found himself standing in a brick courtyard in front of twenty small Neapolitans. And there at the front, in her navy cardigan with her notebook open, was a child of ten, with two perfect plaits and an expression of grave expectation, who looked at him as one looks at a bridge to see if it will hold.

She was not the third row. She was the first. But she had, he saw, stopped breathing.

He sang.

He sang the old, slow, simple air from the elixir, the one about the furtive tear, a tune so ordinary that the very pigeons know it. He sang it without accompaniment, in a brick yard under a balcony that was built in 1936 out of an old tomb, with the sun going out of the ivy. His voice shook, once, at the first phrase, and then it did not. It rose, and the whole yard rose with it. The teachers stopped fussing. The weaver stopped wringing. And it was not a performance. It was a man telling a ten-year-old a secret.

At the back of the court, by the wall where the letters are kept, Giulia Rossi had gone quite still, with the badge on her chest and her pencil through her hair.

She knew the handwriting of every letter she had ever answered. She had read a month ago, on cream paper, in a hand like a nervous pianist’s, a confession from a man who could not sing; and she had answered it at midnight, in her own kitchen, with a glass of wine, and signed it with the initial of a girl who had never in her life had a balcony.

That, she thought, *is a very good voice for a coward.*

When he had finished, the silence lasted a very long time. Then Francesca Gallo, who was ten and severe, closed her notebook, and said, with the finality of a magistrate:

"That was acceptable."

The courtyard erupted. Marco bowed, and laughed, and wiped his face, and for the first time since February did not mind being seen to do it. And as the children surged round him, he glanced across the heads, and met the eyes of the guide in the green jacket, who was applauding like a woman putting out a small fire.

"Signorina," he said, over the din. "You know the Secretaries of Juliet."

"I know of them."

"If you see them. Would you tell them thank you?"

"For what?"

"For the third row."

She said nothing for a moment. A pencil slipped from her hair and fell on the brick. She picked it up.

"I will pass it on," said Giulia Rossi. "They are very old women. They do not often get thanked."

"I think they do it for that."

"I think," said Giulia, with a smile that started rather sternly and did not end that way, "that they do it because they cannot stop."

And as the Neapolitan children trooped, singing, out into the Via Cappello, and the tenor stood bewildered in the dusk among them with a ten-year-old holding his sleeve, the Keeper, who is permitted to say these things, will say this: *that was Entry 0504 and Entry 0516, standing eleven feet apart in a courtyard, and neither knew.*

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0450 and Entry 0665. A note held a quarter-tone low is not an error; it is a question. And the one who answers the question is rarely the one who asked.
Verona: do not tell him yet. Let the third row hold its breath a little longer.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 28.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 29: The Vlogger’s Lake

“I fell for the man on the videos.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0826

✦ ✦ ✦

Dunga Beach, Kisumu, on the shore of Lake Victoria. Five-forty in the morning.

(*The lake was the colour of pewter and the size of a small country. Papyrus stood in the shallows like a crowd of green feather dusters. A fish eagle called from a dead tree, a long, laughing, descending cry, as though it had just heard something indecent about the government.*)

“Quiet on the set!” said Juma Njenga, who was a plumber from Nairobi and had been flown to Kisumu, at his own expense, to be a hurricane.

He stood in two feet of water in rolled-up trousers, holding the nozzle of a fire-hose that ran back across the sand to a borrowed pump. Beside him sat an industrial fan the size of a barn door, plugged into a generator, and a boy with a bucket of fish scales waiting to throw them on cue. Forty yards out on the flat water, in a rented boat named in fading blue paint, *MAMA ATIENO,* a man in a yellow oilskin was standing with his legs apart and a fixed expression of heroic defiance.

“*Action!*” cried Juma.

The hose roared. The fan howled. The scales flew. The boat rocked, very slightly, in a manner that could be called a squall if one had never seen one. And the man in the oilskin, in a voice a full octave lower than any that God had given him, shouted into the wind:

"*They said the lake would break me! But I am Captain Otie, the Lake Lion, and the Lake Lion does not break!*"

Otieno Odhiambo, twenty-nine, fisherman of Dunga and star of the most popular channel on the lake, waded ashore with the carriage of a lion and the face of a man caught eating the last biscuit. Under the yellow oilskin he was a slim, laughing, slightly stooping young man in a faded football shirt, with a gap in his front teeth and no idea what to do with his hands when no one was watching.

"And what does the Lion do," said Juma, "when the lion cannot swim?"

There was a pause. The fish eagle laughed again.

It was a secret that half of Dunga knew, and that Otieno kept like a hot coal in a pocket: that he, a son of the lake, who had gone out every night since he was fourteen in a leaky boat to catch omena by lantern-light, had never learned to swim. Many fishermen in that country had not. Water is for working on, not in. But a Lion must wrestle crocodiles, and so he had a plumber, a pump, and, on the wall of his hut, a laminated sign in his own hand that said: **DEPTH: 2 FEET. COURAGE: INFINITE.**

"She will see through it," he said at last.

"Who?"

“The one who writes the comments. The *serious* one. *WanjiruK_tech.* She wrote, last week, *The squall appears to be the same squall at 0:42 and at 1:19.* Then she wrote it in capitals.”

“What of it?”

“What of it?” Otieno took the phone from the tripod and looked at it as at a letter that has come with the wrong stamp. “She is the only one who has ever *looked.* Two million people watch the Lion. She watches the *seams.* And she is not even cross about it. She writes like someone looking for something and sorry to find it.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Nairobi, Westlands. A newsroom on the fourth floor, with a view of a car park and a vigorous acacia. Ten at night.

Wanjiru Kamau had been looking at the same sentence for forty minutes.

She was twenty-seven, a technology reporter with a reputation for being unpleasant to press officers, and she had a degree in computer science, a desk with a very small cactus, and a secret she had not told her editor or her mother or her lawyer, who at that moment was reading her draft in the chair beside her with an expression of gathering gloom.

“*The Lake Lion Does Not Swim,*” read Mwangi Mutua, forty-three, advocate, her oldest friend and the only man in the building who had never been afraid of her. “That is the headline.”

“It is accurate.”

“It is *devastating.* You have the squall, with the time-stamps. You have the borrowed boat, the hired plumber, the dead perch. You have a *fan,* Wanjiru. A fan, in a story about a lake.”

“A fan is a hard fact.”

“It is. I am only noting that it is also very funny.”

“It is not funny.” “He has two million followers. They send him money. Last month a boy in Nyeri swam out into a dam, trying to wrestle a catfish like the Lion, and was taken to hospital. It is not funny. It is a *pattern.* He has built a false man, and people have drunk him.”

“And the real man?”

She said nothing.

On a Tuesday night two winters ago she had started to be a fool. In a video, for one half-second in the middle of a sentence, a man in an oilskin on a boat had worn an expression of such transparent anxiety that she had watched it a hundred times. *That is not the Lion,* she had thought. *That is a man who has just remembered he is on a boat.* She had begun, God forgive her, to wait for the places where he failed to be perfect. And then, with the self-contempt of a woman who has always been right and is now, in one narrow respect, completely wrong, she had written a single sentence on a card and posted it to an old astronomer in England, who was said to keep such things. In November the ledger had opened, and there it was in the open air, number 826, in her own words.

I fell for the man on the videos.

It was not the man. That was the horror of it. It was a man made of tripods. And for nine weeks, with the cold fury of one fooled by her own heart, she had taken him apart, one seam at a time.

“Wanjiru,” said Mwangi, gently.

“Run the story,” she said. “I have a duty to the boy in Nyeri. I will run it.”

“I did not say not to.”

“You were about to.”

Waiting by the door with a plastic bag of tea and mandazi was Njeri Wafula, twenty-five, who kept a stall by the matatu stage that sold airtime, phone covers, sunglasses and, in the back, social-media followers at two hundred shillings the thousand. She was loyal to a fault, a chatterbox, and a total innocent about ethics.

“Madam,” said Njeri, in a whisper of audible dimensions. “I did not sell him the followers. But when I saw your story on the screen I said, aha, Njeri, you must go and tell her the thing about the song.”

“What song?”

“The one he hums. Captain Otie. When he thinks the camera is off. At the end of the one with the crocodile, in the minute after he says *cut.* He goes, *mm, mm-mm, mm-mm-mm*—” and Njeri, in the middle of the fourth floor, hummed, quite beautifully, eleven notes of a lullaby, “and I said to myself: *that is my grandmother’s song.* It is the song she sang when we were going to sleep. It is not a Lion’s song. It is a song for a child with a cold.”

There was a very long pause.

“Thank you, Njeri,” said Wanjiru, in a voice that did not sound like hers.

Njeri looked at her. And then, with the swift merciless perception of the very simple, she said, picking up her bag: “Aaah. Madam. *You* like him.”

“I like,” said Wanjiru, “*accuracy.*”

“That is what I said,” said Njeri, kindly.

✦ ✦ ✦

The Kalotina checkpoint, the Bulgarian–Serbian border. Midday on a Thursday in May.

(*The mud had dried to dust. The Balkan range stood up behind the barrier in a blue spring haze. A line of lorries stretched along the road with their cabs open, and drivers sitting on the steps in the sun, eating sunflower seeds and spitting the husks into the gutter with the contempt of men who have been on a border since breakfast.*)

Senior Sergeant Nikolai Ivanov had for four months been seeking duty at Kalotina in all the hours for which it was possible to sign. He gave reasons for this to his captain, who had not asked. He did not say that every time a bus drew in from Sofia his eyes went through its windows like a hand through a pocket, and that he had stopped being surprised to be disappointed.

The bus that arrived at a quarter to twelve was the local one from Dragoman, full of the old and the thrifty, who crossed into Serbia on Thursdays to buy cheaper

sugar. It was a loud bus, with a woman carrying a hen in a basket and a man carrying a ladder.

And it had, at the very back, in the second to last row, an old woman in black.

She was bent over a stick. She wore a black headscarf, pulled low, and thick spectacles, and a man's grey cardigan with the sleeves rolled, and she carried a string bag of onions. She leaned on the arm of a girl of seventeen or so, in a school anorak and a red wool hat, who walked beside her with the careful, patient face of a granddaughter on a long errand.

They came to the booth in their turn. The old woman held out two passports in a shaking hand, and said, in a cracked, quavering Bulgarian, the Bulgarian of a small village in the north-west: "Good day, son. We are going to see my sister in Pirot, and we are coming back before dark. She has a bad leg. It is a long way for an old woman."

Nikolai Ivanov looked at the passports.

He did not look at the old woman's face. It was a rule. The face is the one thing a person can arrange; the hands are not so easily lent. And the hands that held the documents, thin, brown, extraordinarily steady beneath their affected tremor, with a small callus on the first finger of the right, such as years of holding a pen will make, were the hands of a woman who had stood at his elbow in December, translating a child's crayon drawing of a sun.

The first passport was the old woman's, and it was in order. The second, the girl's, was a very beautiful piece of work. It was made of the correct paper and the correct thread, and it gave a name and a place of birth and a father, and was not, in any particular that a machine could discern, false. He laid it on the glass, under the lamp. The machine gave a small green glow.

He felt, then, a particular weight on the back of his neck. He looked up, very slowly, through the window of the booth, and saw, in the guardroom opposite, the figure of the young officer Georgi, with a mug of tea in his hand, standing quite still at the glass.

Georgi was looking at him. Georgi, who was young and kind and not at all stupid, wrote nothing.

A man who does not write, thought Nikolai, *is a man who is remembering.*

He looked at the girl.

She was looking at the barrier. She had a long brown face and grave dark eyes, the eyes of someone who has done a great deal of travelling and finds it difficult to be surprised, and under the red wool hat her hair was cut short like a boy's. She stood with her hands in her anorak pockets, as one stands who has been told that if she is quite still and quite ordinary, no one will see her at all.

And the red wool hat was a little too small for her, and had been mended at one ear.

He did not know why that struck him. He would turn it over for months, and never find out.

He stamped the passports.

“It is a heavy season, Grandmother,” said Nikolai, in a voice that sounded like someone else’s.

There was a short pause. A hen in a basket, in the next lane, said something coarse.

“It is a lighter one, son,” said the old woman, in the cracked and trembling voice; and under it, for the quarter of a second, there was a different voice, low and exact, with every edge squared, and in it a thing that was not quite a smile. “I thank you.”

“Mind the step.”

“I shall.”

She went through the barrier on the girl’s arm, bent over her stick. At the far side, a woman in a grey car with Serbian plates, a woman in a blue headscarf who had been standing beside it for two hours and was now crying openly, ran forward with her arms out; and the girl in the red hat, who had not cried for any border in her life, put down her bag in the road, and ran to meet her.

(Mark this, reader. A girl had once gone up a hill in the fog, nine winters before, in a red hat, from a crossing by a river, and a guard had turned his head away. She had walked until dark, and been found at the edge of a village by a translator from Sofia with a flask of tea, who spoke her mother’s language and said: “You are not to be afraid. I have a spare room.” That was the child. That was the one for whom a coat was sewn. And the man in the glass booth, who had carried her for nine

years like a stone in his pocket, had just let her cross a third time, with his own hand and no knowledge at all; and would never, if the page is honest, be told.)

✦ ✦ ✦

She came back by herself at dusk, on the last Dragoman bus. She got off at the lay-by a hundred metres short of the barrier, where the road widens beside a dry fountain and a bench, and sat down on it with her stick across her knees. She had taken off the headscarf and the thick spectacles. Her hair had come down in strands. She looked very tired. She looked thirty-four years old.

At the other end of the bench, at a respectful distance, which was exactly the length of a crossed arm and a policeman's cap, sat a man in uniform with a paper bag on his knee.

"I am off duty," said Nikolai.

"I did not ask."

"I thought you might wonder."

"I did not wonder." She looked at the road. "I have been wondering for five months, Sergeant. It is different from wondering for a moment."

He held out the bag.

"A rule," said Nikolai. "I am told that a man who carries bread is a man who intends to be kind to somebody."

"Who told you?"

"A woman at a kiosk."

She laughed, a short laugh, startled out of her. And then, in the dusk, with the spring swallows going over, Elena Georgieva put her face in her hands and wept, quietly, for ten whole minutes, while the man at the other end of the bench looked straight ahead and held out, the whole time, a paper bag of banitsa, not moving it nearer or farther, like a lamp set at a window.

At last she took it.

“You do not ask,” said Elena.

“I am a border guard,” said Nikolai. “I have a trained inability to understand things that are not on the form.” He cleared his throat. “I will say only this. I saw a very fine piece of paper this morning. I did not see anything else. And if there should ever be a question, of any kind, it is a question that I will answer by myself. Do you understand? *By myself.*”

“Nikolai.”

It was the first time she had used his name. He turned his head, and she was looking at him with her narrow ice-water eyes, steady and bright and wet, and he saw for the first time how afraid she had been.

“It was a child,” she said. “That is all I will tell you. It was a child that no paper had wanted. Everything else, someday, I will say; but not tonight. Tonight I am only so tired.”

“Then eat,” said Nikolai, and looked away again; and that was, perhaps, the whole of his gift.

They sat until the lamps came on along the road, side by side, with a yard of dusty wood between them, and neither of them moved it. Behind them, in the guard-room, a young officer with a mug of cold tea watched them through the glass, and for a long time did not write a single word.

✦ ✦ ✦

Dunga Beach. The following Monday, at dawn.

The story had run on Friday. By Saturday it had been shared four hundred thousand times. By Sunday there were thirty-one television producers in Kisumu, a man selling T-shirts that said **THE LION DOES NOT SWIM,** and a letter from the sponsor of the channel that said, with great regret and a very small lawyer, that it would not be renewing.

Otieno sat on the sand at the end of the pier with his knees drawn up and his phone in his hand, and read, for the sixth time, the last paragraph.

It was the one that Mwangi had said he could not change.

I have spent nine weeks, writes Wanjiru Kamau in the closing lines of the piece, watching a man who does not exist. I am a journalist. I am trained to distrust him. I have done my job, and the facts are on the page, and they are true. But I will add one fact, that is not a fact, and is therefore against all my training: in the second before every cut, there is a man on that boat who is afraid, and does not hide it well, and hums to himself the

song of someone's grandmother. I do not know him. I would not presume to say which of the two is real. I leave that to the lake.

"She is a very cruel woman," said Kiprono Wafula, eighty-one, retired boat-mender, who had been sitting at the end of the pier since before the generator and would, if no one stopped him, be sitting there when it was over. "She has written four thousand words, and the best of them is the last. That is how you know a person is cruel. They do it with *style.*"

"Mzee, she is not cruel."

"No?"

"She is *right.*"

"Ah," said the old man, with great satisfaction. "Then it is worse."

The sun had come up. The lake, which had been pewter, was brass. On the far side, a line of fishing boats came in from the night, their lanterns going pale. Kisumu was waking, as it had woken every morning for a thousand years, unconcerned with the opinions of the internet.

He did not jump. He was not a fool. But he put his feet in the lake to the ankle, and spoke aloud, not to the phone, nor to the old man, but to the water; for we all, in the end, have one listener we can trust:

I told you that I'd wrestle you, old lake. I never did.
I stood in you two feet And swore that I was drowning. You said nothing. You let me hang a lion on
your back, You let me roar upon your shallow edge,

And when a woman, far away, wrote down That I was not the thing I claimed to be, You did not laugh. And so I'll say it plain: I cannot swim. I'm frightened of your depths. I love you as the very small love storms. If that is not a lion, then it is The truest thing I have, and I will show it.

He took up the phone.

He did not set up the tripod. He did not put on the oilskin or lower his voice. He held the phone at arm's length, in the dawn, with the lake behind him going gold, and his own face in the lens, shabby, tired, laughing at itself, with the gap in his teeth.

"*Oyawore,*" said Otieno. "Good morning. My name is Otieno. I am a fisherman. I do not wrestle crocodiles. I have never wrestled anything bigger than a bad net. I cannot swim." He swallowed. "The fish, though. The fish are real. Let me show you the fish."

He turned the phone, and filmed, for two minutes and nineteen seconds, with no edit and no music, the boats coming in; and the omena silvering in the baskets, and an old woman in a green kitenge laughing at something on the sand; and, at the very end, because he could not help it, he hummed a few bars of his grandmother's song.

He posted it before he could think. He put the phone face-down on the planks.

In a newsroom in Nairobi, on the fourth floor, at nine minutes past seven, a woman with a small cactus and a bad night behind her opened her laptop to find that her notifications had stopped being a list and become a wa-

terfall. She did not at first understand. Then she saw the thumbnail: a man's face in dawn light, looking not at the camera but past it, as one looks at a thing one is ashamed to need.

"Erokamano," the title said. *Thank you.*

She did not press play for a long time.

Then she did.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., against Entries 0483, 0826, 0032 and 0534:

Of all the unmaskings, the kindest are those done by a person who is sorry to do them. I have kept a great many letters from people who feared they were someone else. I have received very few from people who were relieved to find they were not. Elena: a coat can be heavy and light for the same reason. Nikolai: you are writing a bill in a hand that does not know its own sum. I would pay it for you if I could. It is not permitted.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 29.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 30: Between Two Seas

“I am an hour ahead of you, and I keep looking back.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0714

✦ ✦ ✦

Enter the Chorus, alone, in the dark between two cities.

Between two seas a single night is strung, One hour long, as thin as spider’s thread, On which two hearts, both silent, and both young, Hang out their lamps and fear to be misread. Behold: not here the clash of rival lines, Nor poisoned cup, nor ferry set aflame; But two lit screens, a parrot, and the signs Of two shy souls too proud to speak a name. Be gentle, then. For this is how it goes When ambition and duty keep their hours: No sword is drawn; the only thing that glows Is one small glass, a candle, and some flowers. Sit close. We tell the night they almost said it. The Keeper noted it. The ledger read it.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE I

Mirpur, Dhaka. A tea stall at the corner of a lane. Friday, 9:20 p.m. Rain, then no rain, then rain again, as though the sky were undecided.

Bunny, who was thirteen, owned a kettle, a bench, and an opinion on every subject, and had never once been asked for any of them. His uncle owned the stall; Bunny owned the customers.

"Bhaiya," he said, as he poured the tea (two spoons of sugar, one of condensed milk, as prescribed), "you are wearing your *good* shirt."

"It's the same shirt."

"It is the same shirt," Bunny agreed, "but today it has been *ironed*. A shirt that is ironed on a Friday night is a shirt with a plan."

Fayaz Rahman, twenty-six, freelance developer, founder of a company that no longer existed, and sole proprietor of a worry that did, took the glass. "I have a call at ten."

"With the Java girl."

"She is from Yogyakarta."

"That is where Java is."

"*Yogyakarta is in Java*," said Fayaz, "but Java is not in Yogyakarta."

Bunny considered this with the gravity of a judge. "That is very clever," he said, "and I am not sure it is true." He leaned on the counter. "Bhaiya. Let me tell you a thing about this girl."

"I have not asked."

“No. But I have been pouring your tea for four months, and in four months a man has told me three things. One: she laughs like a tin roof in rain. Two: she is always awake before you. Three—” he held up three tea-stained fingers “—she is *an hour ahead*.” He shook his head. “A girl who is an hour ahead, and a man who runs an hour behind? Bhaiya. That is not a love story. That is a *timetable*.”

Fayaz opened his mouth to say that nobody had said the word *love*, which was not a thing a sensible man said to a boy with a kettle.

Then the light bulb above the stall went out. The whole lane went out. The humming refrigerator at the pharmacy next door sighed and died, like a very large beast surrendering to sleep.

“Load-shedding,” said Bunny serenely. “Twenty minutes. Maybe an hour.”

“An *hour*?”

“You see,” said Bunny. “Everything in your life is an hour.” He took the candle stub from under the counter, the last of the Eid supply, and set it in Fayaz’s hand as a priest sets a blessing. “Go. Tell the timetable I said it will be on time.”

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

The same night. Fayaz’s flat, third floor. A candle. A phone. One laptop, at eleven percent.

At 9:58 by his clock, which meant 10:58 by hers, Fayaz propped the laptop on two textbooks and a copy of *Thinking in Systems*, lit a candle, and pressed the green button.

For a moment there was nothing but a spinning ring.

Then the room across the sea came into being.

It was a workshop: low beams, hanging cloths in rust and indigo, a copper-tipped pen in a brass dish, a small stove where wax lay melted to gold. In the foreground sat a young woman with her hair pinned up with a pencil, a smudge of blue on her cheekbone, and the particular quiet that belongs to people who are about to say something difficult and have spent the afternoon rehearsing something else.

"You are in the dark," said Ermis.

"The power is out."

"You look like a man in a play."

"I am a man in a *flat*," said Fayaz. "But I accept the compliment."

"I did not say it was a compliment." Her mouth moved. "It was an observation. I make observations. It is a professional habit." She leaned closer to the screen. "Is that a candle?"

"It was cheaper than a generator."

"You *do* have a generator! You said so in March."

"I said it was *on the wrong circuit.*"

She laughed, and he heard the tin roof, the rain, the particular music that had been the best part of every Friday for four months. Then something small and sharp in the room behind her said, quite clearly:

"*TOO LATE! TOO LATE! BEAUTIFUL!*"

"That is Ayu," said Ermis, without turning. "My grandmother's parrot. She is not allowed in the workshop, but she is not allowed anywhere, and she has taken the principle personally."

"She sounds wise."

"She is *vile.* Ayu! *Diam!* She is Eyang's parrot, not mine. My grandmother is eighty-one and has never lost an argument, and she has taught the bird to do it for her."

"*BEAUTIFUL!*"

"*BEAUTIFUL!*"

"She says that to everyone," said Ermis, a little too quickly.

"I am sure she does," said Fayaz, a little too gravely.

There was a silence. It was a comfortable silence, as the best ones are, with two separate rains in it.

"Fayaz," said Ermis.

"Yes."

"I have to tell you something, and I would like you to not say anything until I have finished."

"I can do that. I am the most patient man in Mirpur. It is my only qualification."

She took a breath, carefully, like someone who has learned in her profession how long wax takes to cool.

“I have been offered a fellowship,” she said. “In Rotterdam. At the Maashaven Textile Lab, which works with *tulis* masters from four continents. Two years. They pay for everything. I will have my own studio. I will learn what I cannot learn here. I will…” She stopped. She looked down at her hands. “I have known since January.”

“Since *January*?”

“You said not to speak.”

“I withdraw the question.”

“I said yes in January,” said Ermis. “At seven minutes past midnight, an hour after we had said goodnight. I sat with my finger on the button, and then I pressed it, and then I sat there until my tea went cold. That is the part I am ashamed of. Not that I accepted. That I did it after you had said goodnight, so that I would not have to see your face. And I did not tell you, because I did not want you to look at me the way you are looking at me now.”

“How am I looking at you?”

“Like a man who is happy for me and wishes he were not.”

Fayaz said nothing. In his flat, the candle burned very straight, there being no wind to trouble it.

“I leave on the twenty-second,” said Ermis.

“Of this month?”

“Of this *month.*”

“That is three weeks.”

“I can count, Fayaz.” Her voice cracked on his name, once, like a thread taking a strain. “That is why I am telling you tonight. I wanted to tell you in January. And then in February. And then in March. And every week I thought: next Friday. And every Friday you made a joke about a generator and I thought: how can I say that to a man who makes jokes like that?”

“That is what jokes are *for*.”

“I know.” She wiped her cheekbone with the back of her wrist; the smudge of indigo went with it, leaving a long blue comet. “I know exactly what they are for.”

And then, because he was kind, and because he was twenty-six, and because the whole dark city seemed to forbid anyone to be selfish for very long, Fayaz Rahman did the thing that cost him the most.

He smiled. A real smile, not a courtesy.

“Ermis,” he said. “Go.”

“That is not what I asked you.”

“You did not ask me anything. You said not to speak. I have been speaking out of turn for two minutes now, and so I will finish with this. *Go.* Go to Rotterdam. Go and learn everything those four continents know and then come home and teach it to the world.” He drew a breath. “I will not be the thing that makes you stay.”

“I did not say you would be.”

“No. You were too kind to say it. That is why I am saying it.”

For a long moment she looked at him, and he could not read her face, which was a thing he had never before had to say. The wax on her stove had started to smoke a little; she reached out without looking and turned the flame down.

“You are a very stubborn man,” said Ermis.

“It is the only thing I have inherited that I could not sell.”

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

The call continues. The power does not return. The battery, at six percent, begins to fail.

“Now you,” said Ermis. “Your turn.”

“My turn for what?”

“For telling me the thing you are not telling me.” She said it lightly, the way one walks across ice. “I said you could not speak until I finished. I have finished. So: speak. What is it this week? The company? Your father? Tithi’s exams? Do not say ‘nothing’. You say ‘nothing’ like a man sitting on the lid of a pot that is boiling over.”

Fayaz laughed once, ruefully, and rubbed the back of his neck.

“It is all of them,” he said. “On the same day, in a good week.”

“Tell me.”

He told her. It took longer than he intended, and shorter than it felt. He told her of the debt that had come, like a stray dog, with the death of the company; of a supplier his father had trusted who had not been trustworthy; of fourteen lakh taka, which was not a great sum in the great arithmetic of the world, and was a mountain in a flat in Mirpur. He told her of his mother's breathing, and how at night he could hear it through the wall like a clock that has been wound too tight. He told her of Tithi, who was seventeen and sharp as a nail and would be the first in the family to go to university if the fees were paid. He told her of two embassy letters, each beginning *We regret,* and of a third he had not opened because he knew what it would say.

"I have a contract with a firm in Singapore," he said. "Night work. It pays in a currency that is kind to me. In eleven months it will clear the debt. In twenty it will clear my mother's treatment. In thirty it will let me think about something else." He gave a half-laugh. "I have a very good schedule. It is only that I am somewhere in the middle of it, and the middle is a long place."

"You never said."

"I never *say*," said Fayaz. "It is a practice. I am very well-mannered about my own misfortune."

"That is not manners. That is a wall."

"Then it is a wall with *excellent* manners."

"Eyang says a wall is only a door that has been told to wait," said Ermis.

"Your grandmother says a great many things."

“She is eighty-one. She has earned the rest.” She did not laugh. She leaned her chin on her hand, and her eyes, which were large and dark and the color of strong tea, moved slowly over his face, as though reading a pattern she had known for months and was only now seeing in full.

“You wrote,” she said, “*I would tell you everything, if I were free to.*”

“I did.”

“Two winters ago.”

“I was twenty-four. I had a company. I was a very confident man.”

“And now? Are you free to?”

He considered it. The candle shivered; the battery icon blinked an amber warning.

“No,” said Fayaz, slowly, honestly. “Not yet. But I am more free than I was. And I am telling you *this.* Which, if you knew me, is a great deal.”

“I know you,” said Ermis. “That is why I know it is.”

✦ ✦ ✦

The battery, at two percent, begins to blink.

“I will lose you in a moment,” said Fayaz. “Let me say something before the machine decides for me.”

“Say it.”

He did not say what he had intended. That was the trouble with having been honest for twenty minutes: it had worn the cover off the thing.

“I am not going to ask you to wait,” he said. “That would be a cruelty. You will go to Rotterdam. You will be wonderful. You will meet people who are not tired and not in debt. And I would think no less of you, at the end, for anything.”

“Fayaz—”

“But if I may ask one thing.”

“Yes.”

“Every Friday. This hour. *Ten, mine; eleven, yours.* If you can. If you are willing. For as long as we are able.” He swallowed. “I am not asking for a promise. I am only asking for an appointment.”

There was a long silence. In it, he heard a copper pen touching a brass dish, once. In it, the parrot said, softly, as though even she had been moved: “*Beautiful.*”

Ermis took a very deep breath.

“I will tell you,” she said, “what it is to be an hour ahead.”

“I would like to hear it.”

“When I wrote that line—two winters ago, at the end of my last year, at a table with no light—I meant a friend. A boy who went home. I kept looking back at a window that had gone dark.” She looked at the screen. “I did not know it was a prophecy.”

“It was a line of poetry.”

“It was a *forecast.*” Her mouth trembled and then, with great resolution, did not. “It means this. I am an hour in your future, Fayaz Rahman. I have already seen

it. And I want you to know that you were kind. All of it. The debt, and the dark, and the long middle. You were kind."

His throat closed. He did not trust himself to speak. Outside, the rain began again, as if to give him cover.

"So that is my appointment," said Ermis. "Fridays. Ten, yours; eleven, mine. And I will tell you what I will do, between Fridays. I will draw a pattern, on indigo, with no name. It will be a field of dots—*bintang,* stars—and every dot will be black. And when it is finished I will call it *Bintang Hitam,* because someone must, and because that is what it is. Black star. A thing that cannot be seen and that bends everything near it." She breathed out. "And I will send it to you when it is done."

"A field of black stars," said Fayaz, "and nobody to see them."

"You will see them." She said it so simply that it did not sound like a promise. It sounded like weather.

"I have no way to repay a thing like that."

"Do not repay. Be on time."

"I have never been late in my life."

"That," said Ermis, "is not true. Last Friday you were four minutes late, and you pretended the clock was wrong."

"It *was* wrong."

"By four minutes."

"By *four* minutes," said Fayaz, with great dignity. "A very small error, very consistently made."

She laughed. She laughed until the pen rattled in the dish and the wax on the stove shivered and, in the room behind her, a large green bird screamed "*TOO LATE! TOO LATE!*" with every appearance of joy.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE IV

The laptop shuts down. Fayaz is in the dark, with a candle. He picks up his phone.

The screen died on a half-laugh, which is, of all the ways to die, perhaps the kindest.

For a time Fayaz sat quite still in his flat, with a candle for a sun and the rain going on and off like a clock wound by a clumsy hand. Below in the lane a boy was whistling. Through the wall, his mother coughed twice and was quiet. In the next room Tithi was asleep with a physics textbook on her face.

He picked up his phone, which still had nine percent, and opened the chat window, which had a little pale dot of green beside her name.

He typed:

Fayaz: *Same time Friday?*

He looked at it. He deleted *Friday* and typed *next Friday* and deleted that and typed *every.* He deleted *every.* He put back *Friday.* He had written three thousand lines of code a day for years and had never, once, been so slow.

He sent it.

The little word *delivered* appeared beneath it.

Then a moment. Then a lighter, nervous moment, in which the whole world seemed to wait for the weather.

Ermis is typing…

He watched the three small dots pulse, and sink, and pulse again, like a heart pretending to be calm.

Ermis is typing…

They stopped.

They began.

They stopped.

What she was writing, in her lit workshop an hour ahead of him in time, with indigo on her cheek and a stove at her elbow and a parrot at the window, the page does not say. It is not for want of curiosity. It is that some sentences are not given to the reader. They are given only to the one for whom they were written, and then, if the stars are kind, to a ledger, in due time.

Ermis is typing…

The dots pulsed once more.

Outside, the rain stopped. Somewhere, a generator coughed and started. A lamp in the lane came on, and then another, and then the whole street, like a thousand small decisions made at once.

From the lane below, a thirteen-year-old voice shouted, "*Bhaiya! The light has come! Is the girl still there?*" and was answered by nobody.

And in a third-floor flat in Mirpur, a young man in an ironed shirt, with no fortune to speak of, looked at the little green dot on a screen, and thought, for the first time in two years, with a surprise that he would have been embarrassed to admit:

It is possible that I am happy.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., found in the weeks after her death between the pages of Entries 0713 and 0714, where she had slipped it years before either of them had met:

Entry 0713 and Entry 0714. They will meet. Not this year, and not by plan. Not before the debts are paid, nor before the work is done. But I have read the margins of a thousand lives, and I know the handwriting of a fate when I see it.
She is an hour ahead. He is, I think, on his way.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 30.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 31: The Pizzaiolo’s Duel

“I wrote that recipe for you to find.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0486

✦ ✦ ✦

Reader, you want the dots.

You are not alone. The Keeper, who has the whole ledger open on her knees and the lamp turned low, has looked at the little grey ellipsis under the name of Ermis Larasati a good many times, and has never once been permitted to turn it into a sentence. What she can report is only this: that on the Saturday morning after that Friday, at a tea-stall in Mirpur, a boy of thirteen poured two spoons of sugar and one of condensed milk for a customer who had not, in six whole minutes, said a word, and who was whistling.

“Bhaiya,” said Bunny, with the air of a physician arriving at a diagnosis, “that is not a Friday tune. That is a tune from the *future.*”

And now the spring moves on, with its hands full of other people’s business. Let us go where it is warmest, and loudest.

✦ ✦ ✦

Bucharest. A Thursday night in late April, 8:15.

The number 783 bus had been rerouted. This was announced by its conductor, Ionuț Constantin, in a voice of such profound sorrow that eleven passengers got off out of sympathy. “A burst main on the Calea Victoriei,” he said. “We must go by way of Lipscani, where the only stops are a hospital, a church, and a restaurant. I would advise the restaurant.”

When the bus was empty save for one acrobat in a good shirt and one nurse in a green coat, Andrei Popescu leaned across the aisle and said, in a low voice, “Is there a burst main?”

“No,” said Ioana Dumitrescu. “It is Roxana Ionescu, the librarian. She rang my father, who is a tailor and cannot keep a secret in his pockets. My father rang the circus, the circus rang Mihai, Mihai rang Mr. Constantin. It has taken them eleven days to arrange a dinner for two people who have been walking the same corridor for six weeks.” She folded her hands on her handbag. “It is *Romania.* We arrange everything except the roads.”

The restaurant was a *crama*, a cellar in the old merchants’ quarter, down eleven worn steps from the cobbled lane: all vaults and whitewash and strings of dried peppers, with candles in wine bottles and an old man in the corner with an accordion. On the table: *zacuscă* with black bread, a carafe of plum brandy that Andrei was forbidden to touch and touched, a bowl of tripe soup sharp with garlic, and, to come, stuffed cabbage rolls the size of a baby’s fist.

Neither had been taught how to have a dinner. She had spent six years of night shifts learning to eat standing; he had spent twelve on bananas and fear.

“I should say,” said Andrei, “that I have been discharged with orders. No wire for six weeks. A physiotherapist named Mrs. Radu says that my core is a *rumour.*”

“It is rare for her to be wrong.” Ioana tore a piece of bread. “What do you see, from up there? I stand at the bottom of ladders at work and look up at the lamp. I have never been the one on the ladder.”

“The tops of people’s heads,” said Andrei. “You would be astonished what a head says when it does not know it is watched. A man who has had bad news bows his neck, just so. A woman in love tilts. A child looks straight up, with its mouth open, as if it were being offered something. And the wire is the only place in the world where I am not *explaining* myself. On the ground I am always saying, *I am fine, I can lift that.* On the wire there is no room for the sentence.” He turned the glass in his fingers. “I do not think I am afraid to die, Nurse Dumitrescu. I think I am afraid of the *ground.* It is such a small place to be put.”

“I am afraid of the opposite,” said Ioana. “That I will be so reliable at the ground, so useful and thorough, that I will not notice until I am sixty that I have never once gone up.”

“Up where?”

“Anywhere that was not a ward.”

“You are in a cellar,” said Andrei gravely. “It is eleven steps *down,* but one must begin somewhere.”

She laughed at last; the plait came undone a little; the old man struck up a waltz. They said nothing of importance, which is the most important thing two people can do at a first dinner. At the end of it she took his wrist across the table, with the casual authority of long practice, and held two fingers on the pulse.

"Well?" said Andrei.

"It is arguing. It cannot decide whether to be frightened or glad. A strong argument. I would not worry."

"On the fourteenth of June there is a gala at the Aurora. Mihai has made me a *low* wire: six feet from the ground, a sixteen-foot span, with a net, and a man called Gigi to stand underneath with his arms out for no reason except the principle. A very small, very polite wire. I would like to walk it once. I would like you to be there."

She looked at him for a long time.

"I will bring my bag," said Ioana.

✦ ✦ ✦

Johannesburg. A weeknight in Braamfontein, eleven minutes past one in the morning.

(*A city of gold and glass, in the pitch dark. Load-shedding, Stage Six. A thousand windows out, and above them a great many stars, a little embarrassed by the attention.*)

On the ninth floor of an old tailoring factory turned radio station, with a wind-up lamp on the desk and a battery pack in the mixing-board, Naledi Khumalo, twenty-nine, host of *Late Light* on Nightjar FM, did the thing no host is trained to do. She put down her script.

“Good morning, Johannesburg,” she said. “I cannot play you any music tonight, because the building has no power but the radio has a very brave little battery. So I will tell you something. *Naledi* means *star.* And I have never in all my years been permitted to see one over this city. Tonight I can. I am looking at the Southern Cross over the roof of the Standard Bank. It is quite small. It is quite nice.

“For fourteen months I have dedicated one song every night to a man I have never met.”

In a flat above a dry-cleaner’s on the other side of town, in the dark, sitting on the edge of his bed with a saxophone across his knees, Thabo Dlamini, thirty-one, went entirely still.

“I do not know what he looks like,” the voice went on, from a transistor radio on the sill. “I know how he breathes. Each night at ten minutes to two he plays me something down a telephone line, for four minutes, and I put it on the air. I know the sound of a man who stops, just before the last note, to be afraid of it. Tonight the line is down. So I am telling you what it is to be given a song every night by a stranger who asks for nothing. That is the show.”

Thabo stood up. There was no logic in it. He was a very good saxophonist whose life had been arranged to avoid being looked at; he played from the back of the stage with his eyes closed, so that he need not meet anyone’s. He had not, in fourteen months, taken a taxi to the building in Braamfontein, on a principle which he believed to be *respect.*

"*Hawu,*" said Jabu Mokoena, twenty-nine, absent-minded shopkeeper and his oldest friend, in the stairwell, in a pyjama top, with his keys in his hand. "I will drive. I have been waiting fourteen months for you to do something stupid, and I do not intend to miss it."

They crossed the dark city in a rattling white bakkie, through junctions where no light worked and the minibus taxis moved by pure telepathy. At the door of the factory, with a paraffin lamp and a sizzling pan, a woman in a blue doek was frying vetkoek.

"A man with a saxophone at one in the morning," said Thandi Zulu, thirty, street vendor. "Either you are a musician or it is a very elaborate robbery, and the banks are all *closed.*" She tilted her head, and her whole broad face changed. "Wait. Two winters ago. A Tuesday. I was selling in Eloff Street and I had sold nothing and had no bread at home, and a man with that very *case* bought a vetkoek, and gave me a hundred, and said *keep the change,* and I said *it is only eight rand,* and he said *then keep the bread.* And I did not thank him. I have been looking for you ever since."

"I do not remember."

"*Of course not.* That is the thing about you people who give. It is nothing. I will remember it until I die." She pressed a hot parcel into his hands. "Ngiyabonga. There is polony in it. Go up and be a hero."

It was nine floors, in the dark, by the light of a phone, with the case knocking at his hip and Jabu panting behind him, saying, "Eish, I am a *shopkeeper.* My heart is for sitting." On the eighth he stopped with his hand against the wall, and heard it: her voice, not through a

telephone, but through a door, in the actual air, speaking low, to nobody, in the way people speak when they have forgotten they are on the radio.

He went in.

It was a small glass room with a wind-up lamp and a high window full of southern stars. A woman in a grey jersey sat at the microphone with her chin on her hand. She was small, and brown, with a large mouth, quick eyes, and a scar through one eyebrow that no voice could have told him. She looked up, and said nothing at all. Behind the glass, Mama Palesa Zulu, forty-four, goldsmith, who had made her fortune in gold and her station in love of noise, put a hand over her mouth.

He did not say a word. He opened the case, fitted the reed, and put the strap round his neck. The engineer, a young man of great presence of mind, put a live microphone in front of the bell. Naledi, with her hand on the fader, nodded.

He played.

It was an old slow tune from the township, a tune his mother had hummed when she washed the floor. He played it with his eyes closed, as he always did, and the sound went out of the ninth floor into the transmitter and from the transmitter over the dark roofs: into the cab of a taxi stuck at a dead traffic light, where the driver stopped the engine; into a night nurse’s kitchen in Hillbrow, where she turned off the stove; into a shebeen in Soweto, where a hundred people stopped in the middle of an argument. And when he came to the last note, the place where he always stopped, and was afraid, and went on, he opened his eyes.

She was standing quite close, crying openly, with no regard for the microphone.

At that moment the city's power returned. The lights of the factory, the lights of the street, the windows of ten thousand rooms, the robots flickering green from the Brixton tower to the Carlton Centre; and a great sound rising off the roofs, from people at their windows and in their cars, who had heard the last note in the dark and had, with the lights, begun to clap.

"You are taller than the radio," said Naledi.

"You are louder than the telephone," said Thabo.

"That is *exactly* what you should have said," said Naledi, wiping her face with her sleeve. "That is why it was the best song."

On the top step Jabu Mokoena sat down with a hand on his chest, and said, in a voice of pure content, to a vetkoek: "I have waited fourteen months. It was worth it. I might die. Let me die."

✦ ✦ ✦

Naples. A Sunday in the Piazza Bellini, three in the afternoon.

(*The smell of woodsmoke, hot oil, orange blossom, and a thousand years of argument. Laundry hung across the lane like bunting. Above the rooftops, the lilac shoulder of Vesuvius, asleep, or pretending.*)

The feud between the pizzeria of Alessandro Greco and the pasticceria of Chiara Esposito was in its fourth year, and had by now a constitution.

They stood at either end of a narrow lane off the Via dei Tribunali, in two shops facing each other like two old actresses on opposite sides of a stage. On the left, with a red-brick wood-oven and a hand-painted sign that said **DA SASÀ — PIZZA DAL 1961,** was Alessandro: thirty-three, broad, handsome, a man who shouted everything, including *good morning,* and who made the best margherita in the quarter by common consent and by his own. On the right, with a window full of golden sfogliatelle and a pink neon sign in the form of a spoon, was Chiara: thirty-one, small, quick, a pastry chef with a mouth like a drawn knife, who sold her babà in little boxes marked, in capitals, **NO REFUNDS.**

The cause was famous. Four Easters ago, at the Festival of the Quarters, Alessandro had won the Golden Peel with a creation called *Pizza Immacolata:* a pizza whose crust, to the astonishment of the judges, was crisp as a biscuit and scented with orange-flower and a trace of Sorrento lemon. It was, as every old woman in the lane would tell you, *Chiara Esposito's grandmother's pastiera dough,* which had never been written down, and which he had somehow obtained from a card in a bag of flour. He had never said so. She had never said so. They had stopped speaking on the Monday.

"*Pasta frolla,*" bellowed Alessandro, rolling out a dough, "*is for people who do not believe in fire!*"

"*Fire,*" replied Chiara, not looking up from a tray of sfogliatelle, "*is for people who cannot be patient!*"

"I am patient!"

"You were patient *once.* You waited three weeks to steal a recipe."

A gasp went through the lane. A man selling cornetto charms stopped selling. An old woman leaned from a balcony with a bowl of peas; and a thin, gossipy man named Paolo Ricci, thirty, choir director and self-appointed town crier of the quarter, stepped into the cobbles with an accordion at his hip and raised both hands.

“Citizens! It is Easter week, and in this lane there are two persons who have been shouting about a recipe for four years. I say: let it be *settled.* A duel! Pizza against pastry! Each shall make a single dish, in the piazza, today, and it shall be judged, not by foreigners with clipboards, but by *the people.*”

“Done!” said Alessandro, who shouted it.

“Done,” said Chiara, very quietly, and went, for no reason that anyone could see, quite white.

✦ ✦ ✦

By three o’clock the Piazza Bellini was a theatre. There were two long tables, two portable ovens, and a referee: Matteo Conti, fifty-three, police officer, gossipy, holding a pizza cutter as a sceptre and a whistle as a threat. The judges were nine persons drawn from a hat, among them Anna Bruno, seventy-eight, retired rickshaw-puller; Lucia Bruno, nine, schoolchild, severe; and Paola Fontana, twenty-five, a lifeguard. “We live by the sea,” she said, with dignity.

Alessandro worked like a thunderstorm. Dough flew. Flames roared. He slapped, stretched, spun, cried out to the crowd, and slid a margherita into the oven with a cry

like a man launching a ship. Matteo Ricci, twenty-six, a welder and a cousin of the pastry chef, stood by with a wrench, to see that the oven door did not fall off.

Chiara worked in silence. She made, to the bafflement of the crowd, not a babà, not a pastiera, but a flat white disc of dough, and put it into the oven, and took it out, and covered it with something, and covered that with something else, and finally, with trembling fingers, laid across the top a circle of Sorrento lemon peel, thin as a thread. She carried it across the cobbles herself.

"It is a pizza," said Chiara Esposito. "I made it with your dough."

It was flat, round, golden-brown, with a faintly blistered rim, smelling of orange-flower and wood-smoke and the particular char that comes only from an oven at four hundred and eighty-five degrees; and on it, in place of tomato, a thin layer of sweet ricotta, candied orange, and lemon peel. It was a margherita in a dream.

"It is *my* dough," said Alessandro. "How did you know my—"

"I have been buying it from you under another name for three years. The boy who comes to the back door on Thursdays is my cousin. I have studied your crust like a scripture." She lifted her chin. "I cannot stand you, Sasà. You are the loudest man in Naples. But you are the only person in the city who knows how much to *leave out.*"

He took a bite. For a moment he forgot to shout. It was the first time in thirty-three years.

Then he put down the pizza and took off his big white apron, with the name of his grandfather's pizzeria stitched on the bib, and folded it with great care and laid it on the table, as one lays down a sword.

"I will not make a dish," said Alessandro Greco, and, to the stupefaction of the whole square, he said it softly. "I will lose the duel. I stole a recipe from you four Easters ago. It came in a bag of flour, with a card, in a hand that I knew, and I read it, and I thought: *this is the best thing I have ever seen.* And I did not send it back. I won a prize with it. I have been ashamed, every day since, to the bottom of my boots. I stole your recipe, and I am sorry."

There was an enormous silence. Even the pigeons stopped.

"You did not steal it," said Chiara. "It was in the flour because I put it there."

"By *mistake*—"

"On *purpose.* It was a long card, and a very good recipe. Did you read it to the end?"

His face went slowly crimson. "I read the *dough.* I did not read the end."

"Of course you did not. Nobody ever does." She took from her pocket a small, soft, flour-dusted card, creased with four years of carrying, and handed it to him. "Read it now."

His lips moved; they always did when he read. At the bottom, below the quantities, below the oven temperature, below *knead for eleven minutes until the dough re-*

members you, in small, neat, rather angry pastry-chef's handwriting, was a final line.

Serve to the one who finds this, and tell him the lemon should be from Sorrento. And tell him I have been waiting for him to ask.

The whole piazza was quiet enough to hear a spoon fall.

"I wrote that recipe for you to find," said Chiara. "I did not know how else to say it. You do not listen when I *talk.* You only shout."

"I have been shouting for four years in the wrong direction," said Alessandro, in a very small voice.

"It was a little further to the left."

He laughed, a great helpless broken laugh that came out of him like water out of a cracked pipe, and the whole square roared with it, and Paolo Ricci began to play, with a tear running down his nose, something sentimental and sixty years out of date. In the third row, Anna Bruno, seventy-eight, keeper of every secret in the quarter, who had seen the card go into the flour and had waited four years for the pot to boil, nodded once, and said to the child beside her: "That is the first honest dough I have eaten since the war."

"Which war?" said Lucia Bruno, nine, severe.

"Any of them," said her great-aunt.

The vote was declared a draw. The referee blew his whistle and wept into his cap; and Matteo the welder handed the oven door to his cousin's rival with the grav-

ity of a man giving away a bride. “It is a very good door,” he said. “Do not break it.”

“I have never broken anything of hers,” said Alessandro. “I did not steal it. It was a gift.”

“At last,” said Chiara, “he has read to the end.”

O love, you came to me in flour and fire, Disguised as theft, so I might dare to take you. I read you wrong for four whole years, and burned A thousand loaves of pride to learn your name. Now let the lane say what it likes; I’ll shout it: There is no crust so sweet as what is given, No oven hot enough to match the warmth Of being, at long last, and wholly, forgiven.

(This verse was recited in the Piazza Bellini by Paolo Ricci, with accordion, without permission, eleven times, and he had to be removed from the stage by the police.)

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., against Entries 0486, 0466, 0137:

Three dinners; three tables. A cellar in Bucharest, a black night in Johannesburg, a square in Naples. At one the words were few and the pulse was loud. At another a man played what he could not say. At the third a woman wrote a thing in flour, and waited four years for it to be baked.

I have often thought that the only difference between a love-letter and a recipe is the quantity of salt. Either must be read to the end.

Bucharest: the wire is six feet from the ground. It is a very small wire. Do not trust small wires. They are the ones that remember how to be tall.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 31.

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Chapter 32: Pearls and Ledgers

“I test every pearl and I have never tested you.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0949

✦ ✦ ✦

Dubai. The thirty-first floor of a glass tower above the Creek. Eight in the morning.

(*Below the window the old Creek went about its business as it had for a thousand years: abras crossing with their cargo of clerks, wooden dhows riding low with refrigerators and cooking oil for the far shores of the Gulf, a single heron, indifferent to the dirham.*)

Tariq Al-Rashid wore the best suit in Dubai, and it was, in the strictest sense, a lie.

It was charcoal, cut in Milan, with a lining of dove-grey silk. He was thirty-seven, a shipping broker of the old Creek school, polished, courteous, quick with figures, with a smile that opened doors in four languages and shut, very quietly, in a fifth. He had never been late for a vessel. And for fourteen months, in a locked drawer of a desk of Italian walnut, he had kept a stack of papers, each of which began with the same word: *Notice.*

It was a matter of a guarantee. An old schoolmate had chartered a ship and a cargo and lost both to a storm and a bad insurer; and Tariq, who had signed the guar-

antee in a moment of friendship and a restaurant, had been left to pay. Four million, two hundred and nine thousand, four hundred dirhams. It was not the end of the world. It was only the end of every plan he had made for ten years. He had spoken of it to nobody, and the silence had acquired a shape, and a weight, and a smell, rather like the drawer.

"Sir," said a voice from the washroom, in Arabic with a Sharjah accent. "I am afraid I have found something."

Saeed Al-Balushi, fifty-eight, plumber, an anxious man with a face like a worried walnut, emerged holding a soggy bundle of papers the size of a small loaf. "It was behind the tank. It is the reason for the leak. I did not read it, sir. In forty years I have never read anything I found in a pipe. But *Ya Allah,* the letters at the top! It says *FINAL NOTICE.* In red. Eleven times." He lowered his voice. "I loved your mother, you know. Before you were born. I mean that I once mended her sink in 1987, and she gave me tea, and I thought: *there is a woman with the correct opinion of water.* I would not say a word to anyone, sir. I am a vault. I am a *grave.*"

He went down in the lift, and across the Creek by abra, to a kiosk in Deira, where a man named Rashid Al-Harthy sold cold drinks, prepaid SIM cards, and, to the discerning, the whole inner life of the quarter.

By eleven it was known to the old women of Al Rigga. By noon it had reached the mother of the man in question: Mariam Al-Harthy, seventy-three, retired schoolteacher, who had kept her own family name as the women of her generation did, and gossip of the first magnitude, who could keep a secret for exactly as long

as it took to find a second person who would be moved by it. At twenty to two a call reached the thirty-first floor from Latifa Al-Habsi, forty-two, a journalist in Sharjah and the oldest friend he had.

“Tariq. There is a piece going out tomorrow in the *Gulf Maritime Review.* It has your name, the guarantee, the figure. I stopped it for two days. I cannot stop it for three.”

“Thank you, Latifa. I have been surprised for fourteen months. I am tired of it.”

“What will you do?”

He looked out of the window. Far below, an abra was crossing, with a clerk in a white kandura sitting very upright and a small girl beside him trailing a hand in the water.

“I will go to Muscat,” said Tariq.

✦ ✦ ✦

Muscat. The souq of Mutrah, in the late afternoon.

(*The labyrinth of Mutrah: carved lintels, frankincense smoke, lanterns of pierced brass, a thousand narrow lanes that smelled of silver and rosewater and the dust of the sea. The call to prayer rose from three mosques at once, a rope plaited from three strands.*)

The shop of Al-Sayed Pearls had no sign. It had a heavy teak door, a brass knocker in the shape of a hand, and a single window in which, on black velvet, lay one pearl: not large, not perfect, the colour of a very old tooth, faintly pink, faintly gold, with a small flaw at the

crown. It had been brought to the shop forty years before by a diver's widow, in a twist of cotton, in exchange for six months' rent. It had lain in the window ever since.

Maryam Al-Sayed, thirty-three, sat behind a long counter of carved walnut with a jeweller's loupe in one eye. She wore a long dress of dark green and a loose black scarf, and she had a face composed from the forehead down: straight brows, steady eyes, a mouth that did not waste itself. She was shrewd, formal, courteous to the point of hostility, and could tell a Gulf natural pearl from a cultured one in the time it took to boil a kettle. She had tested nine thousand, one hundred and twelve pearls in the nine years since her grandfather's death, and had been wrong, she often said, never. She took a pearl from the tray and, in the unembarrassed manner of her trade, laid it against her front teeth and drew it across. A genuine pearl is gritty, like the finest sand. A false one slides as glass slides.

"This is real," she said.

"I have been saying that they are not," said Khalid Al-Mazrouei, sixty-five, dreamy, who ran the flower stall at the end of the lane. "I am here, you understand, because there is a man coming. I saw him in the lane. He has a suit, and the shape of his shoulders suggests a letter. I found a letter once on your doorstep, last summer. Sealed, in a man's hand, very upright. I did not open it. I put it through your door."

"I did not receive a letter."

"Ah," said Khalid, serenely. "Then he sent another."

From a shadowed corner at the back came a slow dry *tick, tick, tick,* and a soft cough. This was her uncle, Majid Al-Hinai, fifty-six, clockmender, who had raised her after her parents' death and sat at a bench with forty clocks in various stages of death around him. He was her chaperone for propriety and her counsellor for life, and performed both offices by being present, unobtrusive, and extremely amused.

"The broker from Dubai," he said, to the clock. "The one who has called nine times about the shipment, each time with a different excuse for calling. I have sat in this corner for three weeks, and I have watched you take the loupe out of your eye every time he enters the lane. I know the sound of a mainspring that has been wound too tight."

"I am not a mainspring."

"No," said Majid mildly. "You are a pearl. Which is worse. A pearl cannot be unwound."

The teak door opened. The bell above it rang a short bright note. And in the light of the lane, with the shoulders of a man who has been carrying something heavy for a very long way and is trying to look as though it were a briefcase, stood Tariq Al-Rashid.

✦ ✦ ✦

It was a long afternoon, and a courteous one. This is the Gulf, and nobody in it has ever said a hard thing before the coffee.

She received him in the majlis at the back: a low room of carpets and cushions, with brass lamps and a window on a courtyard where a lemon tree stood in a pot. Her uncle sat in the corner with his clocks. An elderly man in a white dishdasha and a small embroidered cap sat cross-legged on a cushion with an expression of immense contentment: Salim Al-Balushi, eighty-three, retired imam of a small mosque by the Creek, a man of theatrical piety and quiet mischief, who had come up from Dubai the day before. He had come, he said, to see the pearls. He had come, in fact, because he was eighty-three and wanted to see how a story ended.

The coffee was brought in a brass pot, thin and bitter and scented with cardamom, and poured into tiny handleless cups with the right hand. Dates were passed. Greetings were exchanged for six whole minutes. Then there was a pause, and the sea, somewhere, breathed.

"First," said Maryam, "I should like Sheikh Salim to tell us about the pearl in the window."

The old man's face lit like a lamp. "My father dived for it! On a dhow out of Dubai, in the days before oil, when a man went down on a rope with a stone at his feet and a clip of turtle-shell on his nose, for as long as he could hold his breath. Ninety times a day. And the *nahham,* the singer, stood on the deck and sang to him, from dawn to dusk, so that he would know where the surface was."

> *Down on the rope, down through the green, Where the light grows old and the stones are keen, Hold your breath, my brother, hold your breath: There is a pearl in the house of death. Up on the rope, up*

through the gold, Where the sun is warm and the air is cold, Come up singing, my brother, come: The pearl is a wound that has not been dumb.

"A grain of sand gets into the oyster, and hurts it, and the oyster does not cast it out. It covers it, layer upon layer, patiently, for twenty years, in the dark. And the thing it makes out of its pain is the most beautiful thing in the world. My father said: *A pearl is a wound that has been patient.* That is the whole of my wisdom. I have said it."

In the corner, the clock ticked on.

"Mr. Al-Rashid," said Maryam. "You came to say something."

He set down his cup and put both hands flat on his knees, as a man does who is about to be weighed.

"I came to Muscat today to ask your uncle for the honour of your hand."

The clock stopped. It had not run down; it had been stopped by a clockmender's thumb on the pendulum. From the lane a boy's voice cried *jasmine, jasmine, five baisa a string.*

"I had a speech. I had a ring, which is in my pocket, and which is, I am bound to tell you, *on credit.* I had a very good suit. And I have just heard that a journal in Dubai will publish, tomorrow morning, a number I have not told you. So I will tell it myself, before the newspaper does, that you may have it from the one person who would have preferred, with all his heart, to be the last." He drew a breath. "Four million, two hundred and nine thousand, four hundred dirhams. It is a guarantee. I

signed it for a friend over a plate of grilled fish, on a Tuesday. He lost the ship. I have lost the money. I have been paying the interest out of my salary for fourteen months, and I have not told my mother, or my banker, or you. I wanted to ask for your hand as a man with *nothing to hide.* And the truth is that I have been nothing *but* a thing to hide, for a year, in a very good suit."

Nobody spoke. Salim Al-Balushi had closed his eyes, and his lips were moving in the beginning of a prayer.

Maryam laid her loupe on the carpet. She rose, as slowly as if climbing from a well, and from a small inlaid cabinet took a tray of black velvet. On it lay nine pearls in a row, each the size of a pea. She set it between them.

"I test every pearl," said Maryam. "I have tested nine thousand, one hundred and twelve. I have never once been wrong. I have tested old women's pearls and young men's, the pearls of a prince and of a thief. I have never," and her voice wavered, like a lamp in a draught, "tested you."

"You are under no obligation."

"I am under every obligation." She sat on the carpet across the tray. "There are nine pearls here. One is false. I should like you to pick it out."

"I have no knowledge of pearls."

"I know. That is why I ask. You are a man who knows the tonnage of every ship on the Creek and the price of fuel at Fujairah. In eight months you have never said to me a thing you did not know the answer to. I do not know whether you are honest. I know that you are *careful.* The two are not the same."

He looked at the nine small pearls on the black velvet, dull gold, pink, white, cream, looking to his eye exactly alike.

"I cannot tell," said Tariq. "I will not guess. I would rather tell you that I do not know than be right by luck and have you think it was skill. It is the first time in fourteen months that I have said that sentence aloud. I feel as if I had put down a great stone, and found that I am still standing."

There was a long silence.

Maryam took up the fourth pearl from the left with the silver tweezers, held it against the lamp, and laid it against her teeth. She frowned. She took the second. She took the seventh. Then she put them all down in a row, and looked at the man across the tray with her steady dark eyes, and said:

"Mr. Al-Rashid. There is a thing that a true pearl does that no false one can do. It is the reason that I test them. It is not the grit, and it is not the weight, and it is not the lustre, though I use all of those. It is that a true pearl, when you hold it to the light, shows you, not the surface, but—"

Here the page is torn.

✦ ✦ ✦

Buenos Aires. San Telmo, a Saturday night, a milonga in a basement behind the Plaza Dorrego. Eleven forty.

(*The bandoneón sighed in the corner like a very large animal at the end of a very long walk. Under a low ceiling of pressed tin, a hundred couples moved in the dark in a slow clockwise river, their feet making a sound like rain on a roof. The air smelled of cologne, leather, floor-polish, and mate.*)

They called it *El Cielo de los Zapatos,* the Heaven of Shoes, and in the fourteen months since the night that Luciana Cruz died, Mateo Fernández had not set foot in it.

He came in at a quarter to midnight, in a black suit with a white scarf, with the shoulders of the finest dancer in the barrio, who has forgotten how to be seen. He was thirty-five, handsome in a hard, vain, wounded way. He stood at the top of the stairs, under the single red lamp, while the room, as it does in Buenos Aires, went on dancing and *noticed.*

"*Che,*" said the woman at the foot of the stairs.

Agustina Benítez, fifty-four, sold mate and hot water from a stool with a great steel thermos, and had acquired, over thirty years, the right to say what she liked to anyone who had to pass her. She was also, in a way no one had established, a fortune-teller, though she charged only for the hot water.

"Fourteen months," said Agustina, and poured a cup. "It is a long time for a foot. Nobody comes to a milonga to *dance,* Mateo. They come to look, and find themselves dancing, as a man who goes to the sea to look finds he is wet."

"I have not come to dance."

“No. You have come because she is here.”

At the long table of the teachers, with her back to the wall and a glass of mineral water before her, sat Valentina Cruz, thirty-three: Luciana’s elder sister, and the finest teacher of tango in the city. She wore black. She sat upright and a little apart, proud and guarded, and had not said Mateo’s name aloud since the funeral without something in her face closing, like a shop at five.

“She will not dance with you,” said Ramiro Romero, appearing at Mateo’s elbow like a bad conscience. Ramiro, sixty-seven, a retired choir director and the oldest matchmaker in San Telmo, was as blunt as a stone. “You are like a choir, Mateo, with no basses. All treble, no ground. I would have you *cross the room.*”

“The code—”

“The code was written by people who had never lost anybody. You need only a pair of legs and no sense.”

A tanda of vals began, slow and dark, the bandoneón climbing a note at a time. Mateo crossed the dance floor through the slow river of couples, who parted for him like water. He did not stop in front of Valentina. He stopped before the chair beside hers, which had been empty for fourteen months, for it had been Luciana’s, and nobody in San Telmo would sit in it.

He bowed to the empty chair.

It was the old gesture, the courtesy before the dance, the nod that asks and is not spoken. He held it a long time. In the whole low warm cellar, not one foot moved.

“She is not there,” said Valentina, so quietly that only he and the chair could hear.

“I know. I want to learn how to stand in a room with her in it and not be ashamed that I am the one who is breathing. I cannot do it alone. I am sorry. I am asking.”

She looked up at him. Her face in the red light was a thing carved, and he thought she would rise and walk out, and he would have understood. But she had been a dancer all her life, and a dancer knows that silence is a part of the music.

“She was my sister,” said Valentina. “And you were hers. And I am still jealous.”

“I know.”

“Of *both* of you.”

“I know that too.”

“Good,” said Valentina Cruz. “Then at least we are not lying.”

She stood, and laid her hand, very lightly, in his.

✦ ✦ ✦

They danced the first song at the width of a hand.

The old teachers say that the tango embrace is not two bodies but a third thing between them, made of breath and weight, which has to be fed. Mateo opened his arms, as he had done ten thousand times, and Valentina stepped into them; and there was between her chest and his a space as wide as a palm, in which something invisible was being held. Neither closed it. He led a slow walk, a pause, a turn, a long held trembling si-

lence on the downbeat; and she followed with her eyes shut and her cheek turned away. A hundred people stood at the edges of the room and watched two people dance with a whole grief held open between them like a door.

It was the width of a sister.

On the second song a little of the space closed. His hand moved on her back a half-inch. She breathed out. In the corner a big old tender man in a white shirt, Gonzalo Benítez, sixty-two, Valentina's godfather, sang with his eyes shut and his hand on his heart, in a voice that cracked in the middle and went on, a tango about a lamp in a window.

On the third song, with the bandoneón crying out its last long chord, Mateo stopped. He did not drop her. He simply stopped, in the middle of the floor, with his arm at her waist and the space between them.

"I cannot close it."

"I know," said Valentina, without opening her eyes. "It is all right. It is the first time in fourteen months that you have danced. It means the floor still has you. We will close it when we can. Not tonight."

"And if I never can?"

"Then we will dance at the width of a hand for forty years," said Valentina Cruz, "and people will say, *look at those two, they are so formal,* and we will know better."

At the foot of the stairs Agustina Benítez, who had not poured a cup of mate since the music began, blew her nose. "The basses have come in," said Ramiro Romero, in a voice of grudging triumph.

“They are *very* quiet,” said Agustina.

“The best basses,” said Ramiro, “are.”

And on a shelf above the bandoneón, where it had been put fourteen months earlier by a person who could not bear to take it down, a small framed photograph of a laughing young woman in a red dress seemed, for one moment, in the red light of the lamp, to look down with an expression of the profoundest satisfaction.

(Mark this, reader: the dead are not jealous. They are only punctual. They wait in the place where you left them, extremely patient; and when you finally come, they say nothing, and make room.)

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., against Entries 0949, 0919, 0230 and 0027:

I have been asked whether a person can be both ashamed and honest in one breath. The answer is a pearl. It is a wound, covered patiently, until it is the loveliest thing a person owns. But it must first be admitted to the oyster.

I do not know what the pearl dealer held up to the light. The page was torn at the point where the answer would have been, and it is, in my experience, always so; for the answers are never what a story is for.

Buenos Aires: a hand’s width is not nothing. It is the exact width of a promise.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 32.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 33: The Jeepney Night

“I fear every typhoon that finds you at your night shift.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0874

✦ ✦ ✦

Enter the Chorus, in a raincoat.

In old Manila every road’s a rosary: Each bead a bus, a saint, a horn, a prayer. Mark one bead, painted red, with chrome for crown, That bears upon its rear a scroll of words, Four words, which, like all four-word prophecies, Mean one thing in the morning, one at night.

✦ ✦ ✦

Manila, 9:40 p.m.

There are two congregations in the Philippines: the one that meets on Sundays under a roof, and the one that meets every day on four wheels. The second is the larger, the louder, and the more devout, since it prays at every red light.

The chapel in question was a jeepney called *Hiraya*, which is to say *May Your Wish Come True*, and it was running the Santa Mesa–Guadalupe line with nine passengers, one Santo Niño in red velvet glued to the dash-

board, a garland of sampaguita swinging from the mirror, and a driver of twenty-eight who was singing a ballad off-key to the traffic, which did not mind.

His name was Gabriel Santos. He was cheerful as a lamp is cheerful: not by effort, but because that was what he was for. He gave free rides to nuns and to schoolchildren who had spent their fare on fishballs. He was generous with everything in the world but one thing, and that thing was sitting in the front seat beside him, as she had done every night for seven months, with her lanyard tucked into her blouse and her eyes shut, resting them before the long work.

Her name was Maricel Dela Cruz. She was twenty-six. She was a call-centre agent on the night shift for a company that sold the internet to Americans, and on the telephone she was a woman named *Marcy*, who was from Ohio, in a manner of speaking. *Marcy* was brisk, friendly, and entirely without a past. Maricel had a past: a mother's grave, a sister who wrote poems, and a laugh that made the whole jeepney lean slightly to the left.

"Bayad po," said a voice from the back.

The fare began its journey. In a jeepney the money travels hand to hand down the long benches until it arrives at the driver, who does not look, because he knows from the weight of the coins who has given what. It is the most honest postal service in the Republic.

Maricel's coin arrived, as it did nightly, warm from her palm. Gabriel took it and, as he did nightly, did not give it back.

“Kuya,” said Maricel, without opening her eyes, “sukli po.”

“Walang sukli, Ma’am. Libre ngayon.”

“It is not free *today*. It was not free *yesterday*. Give me my change.”

“Ma’am, the machine is broken.”

“It is a *jeepney*. There is no machine.”

“Then it is *very* broken,” said Gabriel, with perfect gravity, and dropped the coin into a biscuit tin that lived under the dashboard, where it joined, had she known, one hundred and ninety-six of its brothers, none of which had ever been spent.

“The shortest library in Manila,” said Joy Aquino, from the bench behind. She was fifty-six, a librarian from the Sampaloc branch, and a woman who trusted everybody, which in a librarian is a courtesy, and in a Manila librarian is a hobby. “Borrow, return, never overdue. I would give you a card, Gabriel, but I lent forty books last week to a nice young man from the Department of Education, and I have only his handshake.”

“Hay naku, Ma’am Joy.”

“I know. I have a heart like an open window and the whole of Quezon City flies in.”

“There is nothing to watch,” said Maricel.

“Of course not, hija. That is what I have been watching.”

From the far end of the bench came Ramon Garcia, thirty-nine, a weaver and the self-appointed matchmaker of the Santa Mesa line. “I will have this solved by Holy Week,” he announced. “I promise on my mother’s loom.”

“Your mother’s loom has been promised to eleven people,” said Gabriel.

At the back, in the corner, an old man named Rey Bautista, seventy-seven, who had taught philosophy for forty years and rode this line every night to the cemetery gate for reasons he gave to nobody, turned a page of his book and said, without looking up, “In my experience, a man who rides the same bus every night for seven months does not own a bus. He owns a reason.”

There was a long silence, in which Santo Niño rocked on his dashboard and a truck passed with a pig in it.

“Para po!” cried an eleven-year-old, Grace Ocampo, who rode the jeepney home from school and was the fiercest critic of the romance. She had been sitting very upright for twenty minutes with her arms folded. “Kuya Gabriel, *you* are very stupid. And *Ate* Maricel is very stupid. And if I have to watch another month of this I will tell everyone on the line myself!”

“Grace,” said Maricel, eyes still shut, “what would you tell them?”

“That you want to *marry* him!”

The jeepney, which had been at a red light, did not move when the light changed to green. Behind it, forty horns began a sort of prayer.

“Ay,” said Gabriel, and put the machine in gear, and drove very straight, and very red in the ears, to the end of the line.

On the rear panel, in the careful hand of a father long dead, the scroll told all who followed what was written on the heart of the vehicle: **SAKAY NA, MAY ORAS PA.** *Get on. There is still time.*

Mark it, reader. We will not mention it again until we must.

✦ ✦ ✦

Kano, Nigeria. Eleven in the morning, under a sun that did not negotiate.

In another week, on another continent, in the tailors’ lane behind Kurmi Market, where the treadle machines clatter like nervous sparrows and the heat stands in the doorway like a customer who will not leave, a man of thirty-three stood in a shop the width of a coffin, with a bridal gown hidden under a white sheet.

Yusuf Abdullahi was devout, modest, and the best tailor in the lane, which he would have denied under oath. For forty nights, after the dawn prayer, he had sat before this one gown: Swiss lace the colour of milk from a clean bowl, sleeves to the wrist, a hem that fell as water falls, and down the placket an embroidery in white upon white, so close that the pattern lived only in the changing of the light.

It was for a bride who was to be married in a fortnight, in Zaria, to a good man, a baker, Aminu Danjuma, forty-three, superstitious, honourable, and not known to

have said one kind word aloud in his life, though he had done a great many in dough. It was for the bride that the tailor was, at this moment, trying not to look.

"Malam Yusuf," said Hajiya Zainab Bello, sixty-nine, retired pharmacist, matchmaker of Kano, and chaperone for the occasion, who had arranged the match herself. She sat on a stool in the corner with a fan, pretending to doze, as a hawk pretends. "Is it ready or is it not ready? A woman does not get married by being kept waiting."

"It is ready, Hajiya."

"Then why is it under a sheet?"

"I am… arranging the light."

"It is the sun. It arranges itself."

"*Assalamu alaikum*," said a voice at the door, and in came, with an enormous box in his arms, the other Aminu: Aminu Yakubu, fifty, goldsmith, who had the next shop along and the loudest laugh in the lane. "I have the bridal gold, Hajiya, wallahi! Where is Aminu?"

"*Which* Aminu?" said Yusuf.

"Aminu the *groom*."

"You are not the groom," said Hajiya Zainab.

"Thank God," said Aminu the goldsmith. "I have a wife." And he sat down beside her and began to eat her groundnuts, and she hit his hand with the fan, and it was all very much as it should be.

It was at this moment that the door-curtain moved again, and a woman came in out of the glare. She was thirty, slim, in a plain green hijab, and she had the still-

ness that belongs to those who have held human beings in the first minute of their lives. Hauwa Garba, midwife, had delivered four hundred and twelve babies in Kano, and not one of them had been in a hurry. She had learned from this that waiting is a skill, and that it is not the same as having time.

"Sannu, Malam Yusuf," she said.

"Hauwa." He had not meant to say her name. It was a little thing, like a thread pulling, but the whole lane heard it, and the goldsmith stopped chewing.

"I have come for the dress," said Hauwa.

"Of course."

"I am told you have made it very well."

"I have tried to make it as it should be made."

"And it is under a sheet."

"It is under a sheet because it is for *another man's bride*," said Yusuf, and then, as he heard it, went the colour of ash. He had said it to the wall, as he said everything.

She did not smile. She did not look away. She crossed the little shop, laid her hand on the corner of the sheet, and drew it off.

It stood on its form in the wavering light, so quiet and so entirely made that nobody spoke. The embroidery rose in the light and fell in the shade, and the pattern was a sky.

Then she did what a midwife does with everything: she used her hands. She turned back the hem of the skirt, gently, and examined the inside seam, and there, in the shadow of the lining where no bride would see and no groom would think to look, among ten thousand white stitches, she found a single small star, worked in black thread, five points, no larger than her thumbnail.

“Malam Yusuf,” she said, very softly.

“Yes.”

“I have been told whose dress this is. I have been told by the Hajiya, and my father, and the market.” She let the hem fall. “I know whose dress it is.”

“It is yours,” said Yusuf, with his eyes on his hands. “It is yours for the day, and then it is Aminu Danjuma’s wife’s, and I have prayed for her. I have prayed for you both, wallahi, that Allah make it easy.”

“You have prayed for me to be happy with another man.”

“I have prayed for you to be happy.”

“That is not what I said.”

“No.” The tailor looked up, and his face, in the sun, was very young. “It is what I *could* say.”

Hajiya Zainab had stopped pretending to sleep. Aminu the goldsmith had put down the groundnuts. Even the treadle machines in the next three shops had found a reason to pause.

“Hajiya,” said Hauwa, without turning. “Please tell my father that I will not marry Aminu Danjuma.”

The fan fell out of the old woman's hand.

"Please tell him also that I will tell Aminu myself, to his face, tomorrow, with my father beside me, as is right. He is a good man. He will not hear it from a goldsmith."

"I have not *said* anything," said the goldsmith, hurt.

"You will," said Hauwa, "by the evening prayer." And at that, even Yusuf, who had never been known to laugh before noon, made a noise that was mostly breath.

She turned at last to him. "I have delivered four hundred and twelve children," she said, "and learned one thing about time from them. Nobody is promised the hour. I have heard a woman begin a sentence at three in the morning, *I will tell my husband tomorrow*, and I have not heard her finish it. I will not wait to be sure of a thing I already know."

"Hauwa—"

"The dress is not for sale," she said. "It is not for another man's bride. Hang it where it is. If you wish to ask me, Malam, you will ask me as it is done, with your mother, and with the Hajiya, who has been doing this longer than you have been alive and will be insufferable about it." She looked at the little black star again, and her voice cracked very slightly. "You sewed it where I would find it."

"I sewed it where *no one* would find it."

"I am not no one," said Hauwa Garba. "Barka da rana."

She went out into the white heat, with the slow step of one who has chosen. The curtain swung shut. In the shop, Yusuf Abdullahi sat down on the nearest stool as though his legs had been cut, and Hajiya Zainab, who had never in forty years been speechless at a match, said to the ceiling:

"I arranged the *wrong* wedding."

"You did," said Aminu the goldsmith. "But you arranged it *very well.*"

✦ ✦ ✦

Manila, the second week of May. A glass tower, and a storm.

The weather bureau had begun to speak in the tones people use at hospital doors. A storm had formed in the Pacific, weeks before its season; the old people said the sea had misread the calendar. It had been given a name, Isidra, and a signal number, three.

The company had not closed. Companies like that do not close. The Americans, in their daylight, needed their internet; the agents, a bulletin stated, with the courtesy that is also a locked door, would *shelter in place on the floor, as the shuttle service has been suspended, in the interest of client continuity.*

So Maricel did not take the 9:40 that night. At 8:15 the first wall of rain came off the bay, and she was at her desk, in her headset, with eight hundred other people in a glass tower, when the lights flickered once, and the generators answered.

“Thank you for calling Northwind Broadband, this is Marcy, how can I make your day brighter?”

“Well, hello there, Marcy,” said a voice like an old gate, from a great distance. “My name’s Walt. I think I’ve broken the internet.”

He was eighty-one. He lived in Duluth, Minnesota, where it was ten in the morning and a great lake sat outside his window like a grey animal. His router had a red light, and a daughter in Phoenix had told him to call this number.

“Mr. Halvorsen, let’s see what we can do. Can you tell me what colour the light is?”

“Well, it’s red.”

“All right. And is the cord plugged into the wall?”

A pause. A very long pause. Then, in a tone of great and honourable surprise: “Marcy, it is *not*.”

She laughed, and the whole row of agents looked up, because it was not Marcy’s laugh but Maricel’s, the one that made rooms lean.

That call took forty-one minutes in a company where the target was nine, and it was fixed in the first two. For the rest, Walt did not want to hang up. He had a kitchen in which a dead woman’s cup still hung on its hook. He told Maricel about the lake, and she told him, in a voice she had never used for clients, about the rain on the glass, and the jeepney she was not in.

“A jeepney,” said Walt. “That’s a bus?”

“It is a chapel,” said Maricel. “With a driver.”

On her desk the phone had buzzed three times, face-down, like an insect that wants to be freed.

The rain struck the tower like thrown gravel. She rose, left her headset on the chair, and went to the pantry window with her phone in her hand. Thirty-one floors down, Manila was a black bowl with a few lights swimming in it. She spoke then, as the lonely do, to the glass, and in verse, because there are hours when prose will not hold the weight:

Six hours a night I speak to strangers' ears. I know their routers, daughters, dead wives' cups; I say, "I understand," and understand. I have a name for every hour of work, And for the hour I live, a different name, Which no one hears, because I will not say it. There is a man who drives a painted bus; He will not give me back my coins. I will not keep My silence much longer. This I swear tonight: Tomorrow, on the first ride after dawn, I'll pay my fare and ask him for my change, And when he says the machine is broken, I Shall say: "Then keep it, Gabriel. Keep it all. And keep the one who gave it." Let him laugh. Let him laugh once, and take me home.

She read the message screen. There were three.

Gabriel: *Lubog na ang Pandacan. Wala nang makabalik na sasakyan. (Pandacan is under water. Nothing is getting back through.)*
Gabriel: *May mga pamilya sa bubong. Mataas ang Hiraya. Magtatrip ako. (There are families on the roofs. Hiraya sits high. I'm going to make some trips.)*

Gabriel: *Hintay ka lang diyan. Papunta na ako. (Just wait there. I'm on my way.)*

"Gabriel," said Maricel, aloud, to the phone. Her thumbs went white. "Don't be *stupid*."

But it was already an hour old.

She went back to her desk. Walt, who had waited on the line through four minutes of silence, said gently, "You went away, honey."

"I'm sorry, Mr. Halvorsen."

"Don't be sorry. Is it the driver?"

"I do not know what you mean."

"Marcy, I was married fifty-four years. I know what a girl sounds like when she is listening to a different phone. Tell him tonight."

"Tomorrow," said Maricel. "I will tell him in the morning."

"Honey," said Walt, "I have found that *tomorrow* is a long way to go on a road you've never driven."

She said nothing.

✦ ✦ ✦

Manila, 4:10 a.m.

At 4:10 the screen lit again.

Gabriel: *Isang trip pa, tapos diyan na ako. May sasabihin ako. (One more trip, and then I'll be there. I have something to tell you.)*

She sat very still. Something went through her that was not hope, since hope is a lamp, and this was the moment before a lamp, when the wire is warm. *He has something to say.* The man who had not once in seven months spoken a word to her that could not be said before a nun had, in that rain, on that road, made an oath.

She began to type.

Sabihin mo na ngayon. (Say it now.)

She deleted it. It was not enough. She wrote: *Please. Don't be—* and stopped.

Under the little word *delivered*, a pale line of three dots began to pulse, as if some unseen hand were typing back.

It was her own, reflected in the dark glass.

The rain slackened, and slackened, and then, a little before six, lifted off the city like a hand from a table.

At 6:20 she took the stairs, since the lifts had failed, thirty-one floors. The lobby was a pond. A little behind the security desk, in a grey blanket from the school gym, with her wet hair stuck to her forehead, sat Joy Aquino, the librarian, with the biscuit tin from the dashboard held in her lap like a baby. She had waded a quarter-mile from the gym through water to the knee, because he had told her to bring it.

Maricel stopped on the last step.

"Hija," said Joy. "He has not come back to the gym." And that was all, for a while. There are silences that a librarian knows better than a priest, having stood in them every day beside the shelves.

It was Joy who told it, afterward, and she told it exactly the same each time, because she had resolved that it should be told exactly. He had come to the roofs by Pandacan at one in the morning, with the water at the footboards and the wind trying to lift the roof off his chapel. He had taken thirteen people on the first trip, eleven on the second. On the fifth he took Joy herself, and the old, and the children, to the school gym on the high ground by Guadalupe, and put them down in the dry, and then turned the jeepney round for the one family whose roof was left.

"He had to go through the underpass," said Joy, with her face wet. "There was no other road. He said, *Ma'am Joy, hold the tin, I will be one more minute.* He said, *Tell the girl in the front seat…*"

"What?" said Maricel.

"*Tell her she left her change.*"

She did not understand, then. She understood afterward that he had meant the coins: *sukli*, in the language of the street; what is left over; what is given back. The rest of the sentence belonged to the road.

They found *Hiraya* at nine, when the water went down, at the foot of the underpass, with the Santo Niño still on the dashboard, unspoiled, face to the glass. The family of the last roof was safe. He had lifted them, one by one, onto the dry ramp, the child with the cat last, and then the water had taken the chapel. That, reader, is the part of the story to hold: that seven people stood on the dry ramp that morning who would not have stood anywhere at all.

And on the rear panel, above the brown water, as bright as the day his father painted it, were the four words, which in the morning meant one thing, and now meant another, and never once ceased to mean both.

SAKAY NA, MAY ORAS PA.

She stood on the last step in her lanyard and her wet shoes, with a phone in her hand, and on the phone a word she had written and not sent, and she said nothing to anyone for the whole of the first hour.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0874. Gabriel Santos, 28. Entry 0045. Maricel Dela Cruz, 26. I have written before that the unsaid bends the lives it touches. Let me add a harder line: it bends them, and sometimes it breaks them, and I cannot promise the Register will always arrive in time.

But hold this. He was carrying other people when he was taken. In the whole of that night he never once stopped to say what he was afraid of. He only did what he was afraid for.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 33.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 34: Puppets Without Strings

“My puppets are braver than I am.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0418

✦ ✦ ✦

Prague. Seven o’clock on a spring evening, in the lane behind the Church of Our Lady beneath the Chain.

The cloakroom of the Theatre of the Golden Hare had been guarded for eleven years by a woman who had been, before that, a lifeguard at the Podolí swimming pool, and who regarded the two professions as one with less water in it.

“People come in wet with the world,” said Markéta Veselý, forty-five, taking a coat from a trembling pensioner, “and I hold it for them. No tickets lost, no one drowned, and nobody dares say the water was my fault.” She hung the coat. She was a vain woman, and her hair was the colour of a good copper kettle. “Two hundred crowns, madam, for the privilege of being looked after.”

“It is *twenty*,” said the pensioner.

“Twenty for the coat,” said Markéta. “Two hundred for the dignity.”

The Golden Hare held sixty-three seats, a stage the size of a generous kitchen, and a puppeteer. He was a man of forty named Petr Novák, who had made, in eighteen years, three hundred and twelve puppets and spoken in his own voice, on a stage, in the presence of a living audience, precisely never.

For Petr was a person to whom words came easily, as long as there was something wooden between them and the world. Give him a Kašpárek, the little red-capped fool of every Czech childhood, and he would be funny, wise, cruel, tender, and shrewd for two hours, in a dozen voices. Take the puppet away, and he would say, *Yes. Thank you. That is correct,* and go and stand in the corner like an umbrella.

His brother Vojtěch, a cobbler, who had the wit that comes of spending a life at other people's feet, put it best. "Most human trouble," he liked to say, "is a matter of soles. The rest is a matter of souls. And people confuse the two at their peril. You cannot mend a heart with leather, Petr. But you can sometimes get it to walk."

He had come that evening with a dozen pairs of tiny shoes, to be glued to tiny feet, and was now seated cross-legged in the wings with a pot of glue, wearing the absent-minded air of a man who has forgotten whether he has his own.

"Strawberry-coloured heels for the Queen," said Vojtěch. "Are you sure?"

"I am not sure," said Petr, behind a curtain.

"Good. Certainty is for cobblers who have never met a foot."

Beside him, a girl of fifteen with a stage-hand's black T-shirt and a pencil through her bun was threading a silk line through the head of a dragon. This was Jana, Petr's niece, and she was watching him as the young watch the old when they have decided to make a project of them.

"Uncle," said Jana.

"Yes."

"The seat is taken."

He went still. A glove puppet, the Kašpárek, was on his left hand, and for a moment the hand and the man seemed to share one pulse.

"Which seat?"

"You *know* which seat. F7. Second row from the back, on the aisle. It has been empty for fourteen months. Every night I have put a program on it and every night nobody sat in it. I thought you did it so you could look at a hole in the room." She swallowed. "Tonight there is a woman. A scarf up to here. A hat like a bowl. She gave Markéta two hundred crowns for the coat."

"For the *coat*," said Markéta, from the door, with immense dignity, "two hundred. For the dignity. I told her so." She lowered her voice. "She asked me not to tell you who she is. I said, madam, I have been guarding the wet for eleven years and I have never named a drowner."

"She is not a drowner," said Petr, quietly.

"She is a *critic*," said Markéta. "It is the same thing, but with ink."

There was a pause, in which Vojtěch, with great care, set down his glue.

“Ah,” he said.

✦ ✦ ✦

She had been a critic for fourteen years. Her name was Lucie Horáková; she was thirty-six, and she wrote for a Prague daily in sentences that were beautiful and exact and had the odd property of making the people they described feel they had been measured for a coffin. Once, fourteen months before, in a sentence she could not now bear to reread, she had written of a small theatre in a lane behind a church:

A man who speaks only through wood has, for all his eloquence, nothing to say. The puppets are very well made. Their maker is not in the room.

Within a month the Golden Hare’s subscribers had halved. Within two, the landlord, a gentle old trader named Kučera who drank too much tea at night, had given notice. It had survived. It survived, as small things do, by the stubbornness of three people and a girl with a pencil through her hair. But it had been a near thing, and Lucie knew it, in the secret place in which a critic keeps what she has done.

And then, in the November of the Register, in the first week of the opening, she had sat at her kitchen table with a glass of Moravian wine and the screen of a laptop, and had typed *Prague* into a search bar, as she had typed it, in her time, into the press releases of the damned. And there it was, the third entry of the page: **ENTRY 0418. “My puppets are braver than I am.”**

She had known the hand at once. A critic knows a hand. She had put her own beside it, at midnight, for no reason she could name, and sent it into the dark: **ENTRY 0227. "I wrote the review that nearly closed your theatre and I regret it."**

She had not thought it would be read. One does not expect an answer from the dark. She had only wished to be, for one night, a woman who had said something true.

She sat now in F7, in her hat like a bowl, and held her program as one holds a hot plate. The house lights went down. A single lamp came up on the little stage, and on it, with nobody visible, a small red cap rose over the edge of the curtain, followed by a very large nose.

"*Good evening,*" said the Kašpárek.

The audience, twenty children and thirty parents and a few who had come in out of the rain, laughed with the joy of those who have just been recognized.

"*Is there a person from the newspapers in the house?*" said the Kašpárek, leaning out, with his hand to his brow. "*No? I thought not. Newspapers do not come to small theatres. They send a man with a very large opinion and a very small umbrella. Therefore, I shall sit at the front and tell the truth.*"

He sat. He told it. The evening was called *Bez nitě*: *Without Strings*. It was a one-man piece, and it was about a puppet-maker whose puppets, one by one, rebelled. A king refused to be crowned. A dragon declined to breathe fire on a cabbage. A Queen in strawberry-coloured heels announced, to a scandalised court, that she would no longer speak the lines in which she was

loved; she preferred to speak the lines in which she was *known*. The children howled. The parents wept, when they thought nobody saw. And somewhere in the second half, as the Kašpárek strolled to the edge of the stage with a lantern in his tiny wooden fist and let the light fall across the rows, he stopped, as though he had seen a thing in the dark.

"*Ah,*" he said.

The room was still.

"*There is a person in F7,*" said the Kašpárek, gravely. "*The seat has been empty for fourteen months. It has become a kind of monument. I thought it should be left to the pigeons. And tonight, look: a hat. A hat like a bowl. Madam, forgive me. I have been warned to say nothing. But your seat is warm.*"

Sixty heads went round in the dark, like a field of sunflowers. In F7, Lucie Horáková did not move. A critic, in such an hour, has only one resource, which is to appear to be taking notes.

"*I have decided,*" said the Kašpárek, "*to forgive the newspaper, though not the headline. But I will say this, to the hat.*" And he took off his own little red cap, and held it over his heart, and the voice that came from the stage was, for the first time in the history of the Golden Hare, a voice she knew was not the puppet's. It was lower, and a little rough, and it cracked a little, like wood in the first warm day of spring:

> *I am not braver than the wood I carve. I put a word inside it and it lives. And you, who read me through, and called me hollow, Were right, for I was hiding in*

the hollow. I am come out. It is not much to see. A man; two hands; a nose that is his own. If you should wish to write of it again, Write that he came out slowly. That he came.

And from behind the curtain, in a spill of lamplight, with the puppet dangling forgotten at his side and nothing between himself and sixty strangers but his own forty years, stepped a tall, thin, shy man in a black jumper, who said, to the room, in a voice which shook like a ladder:

"*Děkuji, že jste přišli.*" Thank you for coming.

It was four words in Czech, and the first speech of his life. A woman in the third row began to clap, and then a child, and then, like rain on a roof, the whole house.

In F7, a critic put her pencil on her knee and did not write one word.

She was gone before the second curtain-call, hat and scarf and all. Markéta returned the coat at the cloakroom as one returns a rescued infant. There was an envelope on the counter, with a coin in it that was far too large.

"For the dignity," said Markéta.

The note was folded in four. It had been written in the sort of handwriting that has spent years correcting other people's. It said, in Czech, in a hand that shook:

I was wrong. Not about the wood. About the man. — L.H.

Petr read it in the wings, with Jana looking over one elbow and his brother over the other. He read it twice. Then, because he was a man who found it easier to say a thing through a hand, he put the Kašpárek back on his fist, and the Kašpárek read it aloud, in the voice of an immensely solemn judge.

"*It is the first time,*" said the Kašpárek, "*in the history of Czech criticism.*"

Jana began to laugh, and could not stop, and had to sit on the dragon.

"*Also,*" said the Kašpárek, who had a good deal to say for a bit of wood, "*it is a very short note. The lady is economical. I like this in a woman.*"

"Petr," said Vojtěch, very gently.

"Yes."

"The hand is yours. The voice is yours. Do not leave it on the puppet." He tapped, with a cobbler's thick finger, the little wooden chest. "A sole will last you a year. A soul, I am told, takes a little longer to wear in."

✦ ✦ ✦

Crete. The same week, in the hills above Chania, before the sun was well awake.

Kostas Mavros, forty-four, taxi driver, had one eye on the road and the other on his passenger, an arrangement that has made orphans of whole families on Cretan mountain roads, and which he practised with serene indifference.

“Women,” said Kostas, as the old Mercedes took a bend at the speed of an argument, “are like the White Mountains. You do not conquer them. You wait for the snow to melt.”

“I am sixty,” said George Papadakis, who was holding the door handle.

“The snow has been *melting* for thirty years!”

“Mind the goat.”

“What goat?”

There was a goat. There had been a goat for some time, and it was now a little behind them, in the mirror, wearing the look of a creature that has just seen the hereafter.

George had been made by sun and olives into one piece, with a face like a good boot and a heavy hand taught to be gentle by thirty years of branches. He sat very straight in his one good suit, with a wooden crate across his knees. In the crate were two things. The first was a tin of oil from the first pressing of the year, the green, peppery *agiourelaio* that has been known to make grown men cough and ask for their mothers. The second, tied with kitchen string, was a bundle of thirty letters, which had come back to him, one winter morning, in the hands of a niece who would not meet his eyes: every one that he had written to Eleni Stavrou, in the thirty springs since she left, returned unopened.

He had not reread them. He had not needed to. He knew them as he knew his own terraces.

“You will go in,” said Kostas, “and you will say, *Eleni, I am here.* And she will say, *George, what is this, a tragedy?* And you will say, *No, a delivery.* Ha! Because you have the oil! You see? I have the whole thing arranged. All you have to do is open your mouth.”

“Kostas.”

“Yes.”

“Stop the car at the corner, please. I will walk.”

They stopped. Kostas put his hand over his heart, a thing he did to prove that, in his case, one existed. “My friend,” he said, with unwonted quiet. “Thirty years is a long time to be right and not be asked.”

“I have not come to be right,” said George, getting out slowly, like a man in a tall boat. “I have come to be seen. It is a smaller thing, and it is quite enough.”

✦ ✦ ✦

The shop was in a lane behind the Venetian harbour, where the walls are the colour of apricots and the cats have the manners of landlords. Over the door was painted *STAVROU — HERBS, HONEY, & EVERYTHING ELSE*, and the *everything else* was true: it held diktamo from the gorge and thyme honey from the mountain and nine kinds of olives, a poster of the Virgin, and one hand-lettered sign that said *CREDIT IS A SIN*, and beneath it, in a smaller hand, *ASK ELENI.*

On a stool in the doorway, with her arms folded and the expression of a magistrate, sat a girl of twelve in a school uniform, Katerina Nikolaidis, who was minding

the till for the afternoon and had decided that this was the afternoon.

"Are you the olive man?" said Katerina.

"I am an olive man."

"Mrs. Eleni cries in the storeroom every April, when the almond flowers. I have heard it. She says it is the dust." The girl surveyed him, from boots to hat, with merciless attention. "Is it true you wrote thirty letters?"

"It is true."

"*Thirty?*"

"One a spring."

"What did you say in them?"

"I do not know," said George, with perfect truth. "I never opened them again."

"Katerina," said a voice from within. It was a dry voice, stern, a voice that ran a shop and a family and a good deal of the street. "Go and see if the Kalogeropoulos woman has paid for her beans."

"But Mrs. Eleni, there is a—"

"*Go.*"

Katerina went, looking back over her shoulder like a comet.

Eleni Stavrou stood in the doorway of her own storeroom, fifty-eight, in a black cardigan, a widow of six years, with a carved wooden spoon in one hand like a sceptre. Her hair had gone silver before she had permitted it, and she was not a handsome woman, but a *fin-*

ished one, as a good wall is finished, and the two of them stood and looked at each other across a floor of cold stone and thirty springs.

"You have got fat," said Eleni.

"I have got *old*."

"It is the same thing at our age." She did not smile. The wooden spoon moved, once, like a metronome. "What is in the box?"

"Oil," said George. "And what is yours."

He put it on her counter, the crate and the tin and the string, and stepped back, as one steps back from an altar.

"I am not asking you to open them," he said. "I am not asking you for anything. I am only bringing you what is yours. They were never mine, after I had posted them. A letter belongs to the person it is for. I should have understood that thirty years ago."

For a long moment she did not move. Then she said, in a voice whose steadiness cost her a good deal, "You will sit. I will make coffee."

She made it. It was a long, strict, ceremonial business, a copper *briki* on a low gas, a spoon of sugar, the froth watched like a child. She did not look at him once. When it was done she set before him a small cup, a glass of water, and a saucer on which sat a single spoon of quince sweetness, and she sat down across from him, and for twenty minutes they spoke, with every appear-

ance of calm, of the weather, and the olive fly, and the price of fuel, and the mule he had once owned that was a most excellent judge of character.

Not a word of the letters. Not a word of the thirty years.

At the end of it, when the cup was empty and the light on the harbour had turned from white to gold, George rose and put on his hat. And then, because he was a Cretan, and because in that island the heart has always had a form, he said, in the old, easy, singing way that the old men use in the *kafeneio*:

Thirty springs I sent my blossoms down the road to you; The post said "not at this address," but still the blossom grew.

It was a *mantinada*, one of those rhyming couplets the Cretans fling at one another across a table like olives: a verse that asks no question, only leaves a space where an answer might sit.

Eleni did not look up. The wooden spoon lay on the table. A long breath came out of her, and then, quite quietly, in a dry, half-broken voice which belonged entirely to the girl of twenty-eight who had left, she gave the answer. It was the old rule of the form, that you must not leave a couplet standing alone:

The tree that learns to bear must learn to let its fruit fall down. Go home, old fool. I'll send for you. Don't bring me any crown.

George stood quite still. His hat was in his hand. Something went across his face that was too large for it, and was gone.

"*Efharisto,*" he said.

"Go *home,*" said Eleni Stavrou.

He went. Katerina, coming back from the Kalogeropoulos house with an air of devastating success, found him in the lane, looking at nothing with great attention, and watched him walk away down toward the harbour with his hat in his hand, like a man leaving church.

✦ ✦ ✦

She did not open it that afternoon. She did not open it that night. She served eleven customers, scolded a fishmonger, and told Katerina at six that she might go home. At eight, with the shutters down and one lamp burning above the till, she sat on a sack of flour and took the bundle of letters out of the crate and held it in both hands, as a woman holds a creature that might bite.

She said, aloud, to the Virgin on the poster, in the plain tones of one who has been on speaking terms with her for fifty years:

You know that I am not a coward. I buried A husband and I did not flinch. I've sold Dried herbs to princes and refused their credit. I'll tell you what I feared. Not blame: I know That tune. Not hate. A hate may be outlived. I feared a letter that said nothing cruel, And nothing that required of me an

answer, And only said: I’m here. I’m here. The door
Is on its hinges. That is what I feared. That he
would be, for thirty springs, quite kind.

She cut the string with her kitchen scissors. The first envelope was soft with age. It was dated the April of the year she left, in a hand she had known as well as her own, and when she unfolded it there was only a half page, written, one could see, with great care and no hope:

Eleni. The almond is in flower. It is not the same without you to say it is too early. I have nothing to ask. The house is warm. Come, or do not come. The door is on its hinges, either way. — George.

She read it. She read it again. She laid her head down on the flour sack, among the herbs and the honey, and there, in the one lamp’s light, in a shop that said *CREDIT IS A SIN*, the sternest woman in Chania began, at last, to laugh, and the laughing turned, and turned back, and she let it.

It was kind. It was exactly as kind as she had feared.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0418, Petr Novák, 40. Entry 0227, Lucie Horáková, 36. Entry 0208, George Papadakis, 60. Entry 0078, Eleni Stavrou, 58.
Observe how long it takes the old to say what the young say in one night. Observe, too, that it is no slower to be kind than cruel. It only requires, of a person, the willingness to be seen doing it.

A voice is not a puppet, reader. It must be put down in the light, with the hand empty, to be heard.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 34.

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Chapter 35: The Lighthouse Keeper’s Son

“I keep the lamp lit for ships and for you.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0630

✦ ✦ ✦

Galle, Sri Lanka. Late April, in the weeks between the monsoons, when the afternoons are thunder and the evenings are forgiveness.

At the south-western tip of the old Dutch fort, where the ramparts run out of wall and into the sea, there stands a white tower that has been telling ships where the land is since long before anyone needed telling anything else.

On the morning that concerns us, it was failing.

“It is the bearing,” said Anil Perera, thirty-two, lighthouse keeper’s son, lying on his back beneath the great lens with a torch in his teeth, so that what he said came out in the shape of a hum. “The last monsoon got into the housing in February. It has been grinding for two months. Last night it stopped.”

“What does that mean?” said the young woman who was holding the other torch.

“It means,” said Anil, removing the first torch, “that for the first time in living memory, if you leave the lamp on, it will not turn, and if it does not turn, it is not a lighthouse. It is a very tall lamp.”

“That is an unfair distinction.”

“It is the only one the ships care for.”

Nadeesha Fernando, twenty-nine, nurse and executor, had come home to Galle three weeks before with two suitcases, a death certificate, and a feeling, which she had not told anyone, that she had been left on the shore by a tide. The Register had been open for five months. She had read, by her own count, four thousand letters of thanks and eleven hundred of rage. She had a mother in Kandy who loved her and could not apologise for it, a brother who sold tea on the ramparts, and an aunt in a churchyard in Cornwall who had left her a house and a cabinet and a world.

What she had not got was a place to put down the torch. And so, when the tall quiet man who ran the Galle Light, whom she had known since she was nine, had said on the telephone, *The bearing has gone, the lamp is dark, and my father cannot see to help me,* she had said: *I shall come at six.* She had carried up one hundred and thirty-six steps a king coconut, a spanner, and a sense of mission.

“Hand me the sixteen,” said Anil.

“The sixteen *what*?”

“The sixteen. The spanner.”

“There are five spanners.”

“The one that says sixteen.”

“Anil, they *all* say sixteen. Someone has been buying the same spanner for fifty years.”

“My father,” said Anil, with a flicker that was the closest he came to a smile, “does not forget what he likes.”

At which moment there was a great clanking on the stair, and a voice that came before its owner like a crier before a king: “*Aney, aney,* the god-blessed Perera boy and the nurse madam! I have brought *offerings!*”

Chaminda Abeywardena, forty-seven, proprietor of the newsagent’s by the clock tower, was devout in the way a sponge is wet. He carried in his arms, with the care of a procession, six king coconuts, a flask of tea, a bundle of white thread, and the front page of a newspaper dated the fourth of February 1989. “I have kept every paper since the day I started,” he declared, “and today I thought: what is a lighthouse but a very old newspaper? It tells the news and warns of danger. It is the same trade.”

“Chaminda,” said Anil, from the floor, “why have you brought the *paper*?”

“For the pirith! I will bless the lamp. I have brought the sacred thread. And for the *luck* I have brought the paper of the day the lamp was last repaired.” He unfolded it. “This,” he said, with great tenderness, “is the Independence Day parade.”

“Chaminda, the lamp was last repaired in 1994.”

“Then I have brought the *wrong* parade,” said the newsagent, calmly, and sat down on the floor and began, in a noble baritone, to chant.

It was in the eleventh minute of this blessing, with Anil swearing quietly in two languages at a seized housing, and the sea behind the great curved glass the colour of a very old coin, that Nadeesha, who had been lying on her stomach holding a torch into the cavity behind the lens pedestal, said, in an entirely different voice:

“Anil. There is a tin.”

✦ ✦ ✦

It was an old biscuit tin, with a faded painting of a coach and four on its lid, and it had been placed in the hollow behind the brickwork so long ago that the rust had bonded it to the wall. They had to cut it out. Anil did it with a chisel, as gently as a man delivers a calf, and when it came free he carried it to the window like a sleeping child.

Inside lay the letters.

There were seventy-one. They were thin and blue and weightless, the old airmail kind that folds into its own envelope, bundled in the faded string of an age that tied bundles. The earliest were addressed in a girl’s looping hand to *Mr. D. Perera, Keeper, Galle Light, CEYLON.* The later ones said *SRI LANKA.* On the back, in the corner, each carried the same return: *Miss S. Wyndham-Rao, Mrs. Alder’s rooms, Kentish Town, London.*

Nadeesha did not touch them. She sat on the bottom step of the gallery stair, with her hands pressed between her knees, and a sound came out of her that was not a word.

"My grandfather," said Anil, very quietly, "was the keeper in those years. He never told us. I thought he had *no* letters." He turned the first envelope over, with a care that cost him. "It is your aunt's hand."

"I know it is," said Nadeesha. "She wrote *every list in her life* in that hand. She wrote my birthday card in it. She wrote *Wash your hands* on the kitchen door."

It was she who opened the first. It had been written in the summer of 1964, by a girl of eighteen about to go to London to study the stars:

Dear Mr. Perera. Thank you for letting me stand in your lamp-room when I was twelve, and again last August, and for not laughing when I asked what the light was for. You said, "for the ships." I have been thinking since. I think it is for the ones who do not know they need it. I am going to London. I shall write to you. You need not answer. A keeper is not expected to. A light does not reply, it only goes on being there. — Seraphine W.-R.

She read it aloud. Chaminda had stopped chanting, which, in an age of miracles, was perhaps the whole miracle. When she had finished she held it against her chest.

"There is one more," said Anil. "At the bottom. It is the last. It is dated 1979."

✦ ✦ ✦

The afternoon went. The bearing went in, a new bronze one that had come up from Colombo on a bus, on the knee of Nadeesha's brother Sampath, who had sold tea to the driver all the way. Anil set it with a tenderness that was almost indecent. The housing was oiled; the lens, the size of a small room, was released.

At half past six, with the dusk coming down like a cloth on a table, a girl of fifteen with a basket of jasmine appeared at the foot of the stair and shrieked something up the well of the tower. This was Kumari Senanayake, who had been telling the whole of the Fort for a month that the lighthouse keeper looked at the sea when the nurse was not there, and at the nurse when she was not looking.

"What did she say?" said Nadeesha.

"I did not hear it," said Anil, who had. He went to the switch. His father, who had kept the Galle Light for thirty-eight years and whose eyes were now two milk-white moons, stood in the doorway of the lamp-room in his old white jacket, with one hand on the rail and his head tilted, listening. Nobody had asked him to come up the stairs. Nobody had been able to stop him.

"Throw it, putha," said Mr. Perera.

Anil threw it.

For a moment there was nothing but the light, white and round and enormous in the glass. Then, with a faint sigh, the lens began to turn. The beam swung out across the sea, a hard bright road laid down on the water, and went round, and found the horizon, and went on. Far be-

low, on the ramparts and the beach and the fort road, people looked up, as a congregation looks up when the bell is finally rung.

“Twelve seconds,” said Mr. Perera, listening. He had counted it by ear. “Twelve. Same as always.” His blind face turned, with great accuracy, toward the nurse. “Madam. Your aunt used to stand at the rail where you are standing. She was twelve, I think. My father allowed it. She never once said thank you. She only looked.”

“Mr. Perera,” said Nadeesha, “I am going to cry.”

“Do it on the rampart, madam,” said the old man gently. “The glass is expensive.”

✦ ✦ ✦

She went down. It seemed the only thing to do. She went out through the old iron door at the tower’s foot and along the rampart to the place the fort-people call Flag Rock, where the stone drops sheer to the surf, and there, with the wet wind blowing the first of the cool evening against her face, she stood and let herself weep for the first time since a night in November.

Behind her, high up, the beam went round.

It found her, as it passed. It left her. It came back. Twelve seconds, a circle of light, a long turn of dark, and again the light on her wet face, a pulse like a slow heart. She could not have said why this should comfort her. Perhaps because something in the world had been turned, at last, in the right direction and would go on being turned whether or not she could stand it.

Above her, in the gallery, with a spanner still hanging forgotten from his belt and his father humming softly beside him, Anil stood at the rail and watched the small figure on the rock. Each time the light passed over her, he saw her face for the length of a breath. Then the dark. Then, twelve seconds on, the face. He found he had begun to count. It was the longest he had ever waited for anything, and the shortest.

He spoke then, quietly, as men do who have kept silent for a very long time and find that the night is not listening, and are mistaken:

> *The lamp goes round. I never see the ship. I send the light to find a thing it cannot see, And trust it will be found. This is my trade. For ships, I keep the lamp. For her, I keep… I have no word. The beam goes round again, And finds her face, and leaves it, and returns. There is no kindness like a thing that turns And passes you in the dark, and comes again. I'll turn like this, if she will let me. Slow. For twelve long seconds, and for as many years As there are stairs. I'll come round. I'll come round.*

"It is for the ships," said Anil, to nobody, to the glass.

"*Putha*," said his father, who had very good ears, "it is for the ships *and* for the stairs."

✦ ✦ ✦

She came up when it was dark. It was a hundred and thirty-six steps, and she took them one at a time, with the last letter in her fist. She stood in the doorway of the lamp-room with her face still wet, and the beam went over her like a hand.

“I found the one from 1979,” said Nadeesha. “I read it on the way up.”

“What does it say?”

“I’ll read it.”

She read it in the doorway of the lamp-room, by the light that went round:

Dear Mr. Perera. A man wrote to me from a ship in the autumn of ’77, and I have kept his letter, and I find that I want to keep others. I have placed a notice in three foreign papers: if there is a thing you cannot say, write it to me. I will keep it. I will number it. I will say nothing. I do not know why I tell you, except that you taught me what it is to keep a light for someone who may never come to harbour.

P.S. If any of my blood should come to your door one day, needing to see further than she can, let her up the stairs. — S.

She folded it.

“You let me up,” said Nadeesha.

“Of course,” said Anil.

“She asked you to.”

“She asked my grandfather.”

“You were not *asked*,” said Nadeesha. “You came with a spanner and a torch and a king coconut.” And then, because there are limits to what a person can carry in one evening, she laughed, and wiped her face with the heel of her hand, and walked across the room and put her hand on the brass rail of the lens beside his own.

They did not speak. The great glass turned above them, and every twelve seconds the room flashed white and dark and white again, and in each flash the two of them were standing a little closer, until at the last their hands lay together on the rail, which was warm from the lamp, and neither one said anything at all.

In the corner, Chaminda Abeywardena, who had been present throughout and had been entirely forgotten, took out the front page of the fourth of February 1989 and, with the greatest delicacy, laid it over his face.

✦ ✦ ✦

Kyoto. The same evening, by a different light.

The workshop of Kenji Watanabe smelled of cypress and glue and the old sweet dust of shell. It stood at the end of a lane in the north of the city, in a wooden house the colour of strong tea, and it contained, on shelves, in baskets, hanging from nails, some two hundred faces.

They were all of one family: the long pale women of the Noh stage, with brows high-painted and mouths like closed leaves; the old men with beards of horsehair; the demons with gold eyes; the girl called *ko-omote*, whose face is neither smiling nor weeping and has been copied, by carver after carver, for six hundred years. They watched the room with the patience of the dead.

“You may not touch the chisel today,” said Daichi Kobayashi, twenty-five, apprentice, tea-drinker, and a young man of strong superstitions, to a figure bent over a workbench in the corner. “It is *Butsumetsu*. It is a day of ill omen. A man who carves on Butsumetsu will make a face that will not look at him.”

“I am not carving,” said Kenji. “I am finishing.”

“It is a different *kind* of bad luck.”

Kenji Watanabe was twenty-seven, quiet to the point of furniture, a man whose hands were far more fluent than his tongue. He had been apprenticed at fifteen, and had learned in twelve years that a mask is a face with its mind removed: it holds a feeling as an empty cup holds the shape of water. He was very good at it. It was perhaps because he could not show his own.

On the bench before him, wrapped in a square of purple silk, lay the thing that had taken him four months.

“Master,” said a voice at the door, “the wood you ordered has come.”

It was Yuto Shimizu, the river-boatman from Arashiyama, a hot-tempered man of twenty-nine who believed whatever he was told by anyone who looked sure of themselves, and who had brought on a handcart an enormous slab of timber, presenting it like a firstborn. “Genuine three-hundred-year-old cypress. From a temple that burned down. My cousin’s friend got it. Look at the *grain.*”

Kenji looked at the grain. He tapped the slab. He bent and smelled it.

“Yuto-san,” he said, with great gentleness. “This is the top of a chopping board from a sushi shop in Osaka.”

“No!”

“There is a small fish-scale in the corner.”

“It is a mark of *age!*” said Yuto, and sat down on the handcart, abruptly, betrayed by a cousin and a cousin’s friend. “I paid four hundred thousand yen.”

“You were robbed,” said Daichi, with delight.

“I was *educated*,” said Yuto, with dignity.

The door slid, and there was a hush, because there is always a hush when a certain kind of person comes into a room. She came in as she always came, without sound. She was twenty-six. She wore a plain grey kimono and her hair up, and there was a small, correct, immovable smile on her face that she wore through the streets, and the station, and her mother’s table, and the green-room of every theatre in the city.

Haruka Mori was a Noh actress, and a very fine one, in a tradition that had not been built for her. On the stage she could, in the turn of a head, be a ghost of a thousand years. Off it she was a woman with a polished smile, who said *Yes, of course,* and *It was nothing,* and *Please don’t trouble,* and who had told no one in six years what it cost.

“Watanabe-san,” she said. “Your boy said you wished to see me.”

“Mori-san,” said Kenji.

He said nothing for some time. It is a method of speech, in certain trades. Daichi, with an almost audible click of the brain, took Yuto by the elbow and removed him, protesting, along with his chopping board, to the lane.

When they were alone, Kenji took up the silk bundle and placed it, with both hands, on the bench between them.

“It is not for the stage,” he said. “I did not make it for the stage. It will not be good on the stage. It is for you.”

She unwrapped it.

It lay in the purple silk, a young woman’s face of pale cypress, finished with a thin pearl of shell-powder; and it was *wrong*. It was perfectly formed, and entirely correct in every curve, and it was wrong in that it had no expression whatever. The brow did not lift. The mouth did not close. There was no sorrow in it and no joy. It looked, in its blank, restful, patient beauty, like a face before it has been told what to be.

“It has no face,” said Haruka.

“It has *all* of them,” said Kenji. He took it, and tilted it a little upward, so that the lamp fell across the brow, and the face seemed to lighten, as if on the edge of a laugh. He turned it down, and the shadow ran into the eye-sockets, and the same face, without a mark altered, held a grief as quiet as a pond. “It is called *terasu* and *kumorasu*: to brighten and to cloud. All the masks do it. But this one has no mind of its own to get in the way.” He set it down. His fingers were not quite steady. “I make faces because I cannot show my own. You wear one because you will not set yours down. I thought: if you had a face that was permitted to be nothing, you could rest. You could put it on in the evening, in the dark, and not have to choose.”

The workshop was very quiet. The two hundred faces on the walls seemed, with great delicacy, to look elsewhere.

Haruka lifted the mask. She held it before her own face, not yet touching, and for a moment he saw the little perfect smile she wore, and the blank cypress one, side by side, and he understood, as a carver does, which was the hollow.

She put it on.

She did not tilt it up. She did not tilt it down. She stood, with a young woman's blank face over her own, in the lamplit shop of a quiet man, and said nothing at all; and from behind the wood a very small sound came, such as a person makes who has been holding her breath for six years and has been given leave to let it go.

When she took it off, there was no smile on her face. There was only a wet, tired, entirely honest face, which was, he thought, the most beautiful thing that he had ever carved or ever would.

"It is the first one," said Haruka Mori, "that lets me stop."

On the inside of the silk, in a hand so small that it might have been a worm's, Kenji had written, in the old five-line form of the court:

Carved from one block, a face that has no country.
Tilt it to the lamp: spring. Tilt it from the lamp: rain.
Whichever you are, be it.

She read it. She folded the silk. She said, in a voice quite without the smile, “Watanabe-san. You will have to teach me to be *sorry* in front of people.”

“I do not know how,” said Kenji. “I have never done it.”

“Then we will be bad at it together,” said Haruka. And at that, in the lamplight of a Kyoto evening, with a blank mask between them and two hundred painted faces turned politely to the wall, the carver and the actress did, for the first time in either of their lives, the same thing at once: they laughed.

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Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0630, Anil Perera. Entry 0223, Nadeesha Fernando. Entry 0029, Kenji Watanabe. Entry 0447, Haruka Mori.
I am told I should be embarrassed that my girlhood was found in a biscuit tin. I am not. A lighthouse does not choose the ship it saves. A face does not choose the weather it must wear. But both, if they are wise, will agree to be turned toward the light that is coming.
I wrote to a keeper once, and he did not answer, and it was the kindest thing that anyone has done for me.

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End of Chapter 35.

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Chapter 36: Cycling Through Cloud

“I crashed because I was thinking of you.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0586

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Antioquia, Colombia. Stage Six of the Vuelta. A quarter to eight in the morning, on the climb of Las Palmas, inside a cloud.

In the Colombian Andes the cloud does not drift; it sits down on the mountain like a hen on an egg, and stays until it has been sufficiently admired.

On this particular morning it had been sitting for six hours, and the road up from Medellín, which climbs a thousand metres in eleven kilometres by way of hairpins and prayer, had been swallowed to the knee. Along its edges the people of the mountain stood in their ponchos with transistor radios held to their ears. They sold empanadas and sweet *aguapanela* from steaming pots. They shouted the names of men they could not see. And over every radio, from a motorbike somewhere in the white, boomed the voice of the most beloved commentator in the south-west of the Republic, a gentle, nervous, cardiganed man from Cali named Esteban Ortiz, who became, the moment a microphone came near, a thunderstorm.

“Amigos del ciclismo, GOOD MORNING! Nobody can see anything, which is the finest thing that can happen to a radio man! I am inside a cloud, I am inside a legend! Here come the leaders, I think. I hear them. It sounds like a swarm of very expensive bees! And behind them, forty seconds behind, comes the story of the day, ladies and gentlemen: Sebastián Torres of Bogotá! Eleven months ago, a crash on the descent at Letras. A collarbone, a hip, ten months of hospital and rehabilitation. And today, the comeback! I have lost a bet on this man four times, and I would lose it again for the pleasure!”

The man in question was at that moment climbing at the speed of a determined snail, in a group of six, with the white wall closing before his front wheel and his own breath loud in his ears. Sebastián Torres, twenty-nine, professional cyclist, stubborn by trade and humorous by reflex, could not see his handlebar. He could see a foot of grey tarmac, and a rival’s rear tyre, and now and then a yellow leg like a drowned man’s.

It is a strange thing, he thought, *to ride for a year toward a day, and have it arrive in a cloud.*

He knew the road. He had ridden it a hundred times in training. And he knew what lay a kilometre ahead, behind a green gate on the left, where a hillside of glass had been hung out of the cloud like washing.

A year before, he had punctured at that gate, on a Tuesday, cursing in two registers; and a young woman in rubber boots had come out of a greenhouse with a roll of tape, a spoon, and a face like an indignant sunrise. *You climb,* she had said, kneeling to his wheel, *like a man running away from something. I climb,* he had said, *like*

a man who is late. She had mended it with a teaspoon and a temper. She had given him a rose for his mother. It was a Tuesday, and nothing had occurred.

Two weeks later, descending a mountain in the Tour of the Andes at eighty kilometres an hour, he had seen, at the corner of his eye, a flower stall, a bucket of red roses, and thought of a teaspoon; and the road had turned, and he had not.

He thought it now, in the white, in the only prose the lungs allow at that gradient, which is verse:

> *White, and a white beyond the white, and breath. I cannot see the road. I know the road. The legs are maps that need no light to read, And I have ridden blind since one small spoon Mended one wheel. So let me climb in cloud And trust the grade, as some men trust in prayer Who never saw the One they pray to. Let There be, somewhere on the left, a gate. A boot.*

The cloud thinned.

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The same morning, at a green gate on the left.

The farm was called La Nube: The Cloud. That season it had been living up to its name.

Daniela Ruiz, twenty-eight, flower farmer, bright and proud and out of money, had stood in her greenhouses before dawn, among forty thousand roses that nobody would now buy. A Miami buyer had cancelled by e-mail on Thursday, with a pleasant apology, and the apology had arrived at the precise moment that the letter from

the bank had arrived with an unpleasant one. A rose, once cut, keeps for nine days. These had been cut on Wednesday. By Friday they would be a very expensive compost.

"I could *give* them away," she had said at four in the morning, to her foreman, to the radio, to the stripped benches. "Or I could put them on the road."

It was not a plan. A plan has a bottom line. It was the thing that proud people do when they cannot afford to be seen losing, which is to lose magnificently.

Now, with sixty of her workers and every cousin in the *vereda* and a ten-year-old named Paola Ramírez who was supervising with a hand-lettered sign, she laid them out, stem to stem, in a long red ribbon along the grass on the left verge of the road, for eight hundred metres, from her gate to the top of the rise. Forty thousand roses. They lay in the white like a thread of blood on a bandage, and nobody who came up that road, if he looked to his left, could fail to follow it.

She did not know if he would see it. She did not know if he was even riding. She had read **ENTRY 0586** in a cloud of her own, in November, in her kitchen, at three in the morning, and had said nothing to anyone, and had put the phone in the flour jar.

"I can hear them!" howled the radio, in the hands of eleven people. *"Here they come! A blur of colour! A tremble in the air! And—wait. Wait. Friends of Colombia, I do not believe it. There is a road of roses on the left. Forty thousand red roses, the whole verge, a carpet! The leaders are riding on the right of the road, they are going past in a kind of astonishment—"*

On the right of the road the leaders went by like a gust. They did not look to the left. Cyclists do not. They are busy, and in pain. Then the second group, and the third.

And then, out of the white, with his head down and his jersey the grey of old ash, came a single rider on the left-hand edge of the tarmac, so close to the verge that his tyres hissed in the petals.

"It is Torres!" cried Esteban Ortiz, and his voice cracked in half. *"He has seen it! He is riding the roses! He is following them as a blind man follows a rail! Señoras y señores, a man who crashed because of a flower is climbing through a cloud on a red road. I am a professional. I am not supposed to cry. I am crying."*

She saw him pass. It was a second, no more. His face was streaked and grey and grimly absurd. His eyes went sideways, once, to a girl in rubber boots standing at a gate with her hands clasped under her chin, and held there, as you hold a hot plate you have no intention of putting down. And then he was gone into the white, and the sound of his freewheel faded up the hill.

He did not win. It should be said at once, since the reader is an honest person and will want to know. He came over the summit in eleventh, with a time that Esteban Ortiz described to the Republic, in a voice quite gone, as *the best eleventh place in the entire history of cycling, and I have the figures.*

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Kraków, Poland. The old hall of the Collegium Maius. The same week, as the evening bells began.

There is a hall in Kraków, up a stair where Copernicus is said to have set his boot, and in it, on this night, three hundred people held their breath for a girl who could not hear them.

Zofia Kowalska, twenty-three, violinist, stood alone in a pool of light, in a blue dress, with her instrument under her chin. She had not heard a note for nine weeks. She had not told her teacher until the day the sound went; she had not told her mother until the day after; and she had told only one other person the whole of it, in a stairwell, in March, in the voice of one reading a will. There was a name for what lay on her nerves, a Latin name, which Jakub Nowak, clockmaker's apprentice, had written on his palm that day in biro and spent three weeks learning to pronounce.

She was to play the great *Chaconne*, the long dark mountain at the end of Bach's second partita, fourteen minutes without a note of accompaniment. Nobody could play it without hearing it. This was a well-known fact. It was why the hall was full.

She lifted the bow.

Nobody saw that the floor of the stage had a trapdoor. Nobody knew that beneath it, on his back among old cables and the dust of two centuries, in his one black suit, lay a thin young man with a clockmaker's mallet in his right hand, tapping, on a seasoned oak beam, with the precision of the finest escapement in Poland, the pulse of the *Chaconne*.

It was a thing he had worked out over six weeks, with a stopwatch, a stethoscope borrowed from a cousin, and a length of rubber hose. The boards of the stage were

old and resonant. A tap on the beam went up through the joists, through the planks, through the soles of a violinist's shoes, and into her bones; and she, who had stood and played with her whole body since she was five, could take the pulse of the music in her feet.

She began. And the thing she could not hear came out of her instrument, and out of her, and went into three hundred listeners as a river goes into a sea.

He could not see her. He could only hear it, from below, through the planks, as the people in a cellar hear the church above them: the great chords like beams falling, the long ascents, the slow descent into the minor, the dark opened and opened again. He tapped. His arm went numb, and he went on. Somewhere in the ninth minute he found that he was weeping, flat on his back in the dust, quite soundlessly, and that he had not missed a beat.

At the end she stood in the silence with the bow lifted, as the old players do, to hold the last chord in the air. She did not know whether it had ended. She felt, through the soles of her shoes, three taps, soft, final, like a clock saying *there*. And so she lowered the bow.

The hall rose. She felt it as one feels a ship's deck begin to move: three hundred pairs of feet, a shudder in the boards, a roar in the floor, a gladness that she could not hear and did not need to.

Afterwards, in the arcaded courtyard, in the half-dark, with the old clock above them preparing to strike, Jakub came out with dust in his hair, and she saw it, and began to laugh.

“You have been under the stage.”

“Fourteen minutes. I was very comfortable.”

“Liar.” She put out her hand and brushed the grey from his fringe with great tenderness. She read his lips by the lantern. “Jakub. I have to tell you the date.”

“I know the date.”

“It is on the ninth. They say that if all is well, I may hear again, a little. They say that if all is not well—” She did not finish. The Latin name lay between them like a coin. She took from her bag a small silver pocket watch with a faded engraving on its case: *Z.K.*, her grandfather’s, which had stopped three summers ago, and which had, in January, been left on her doorstep, going. She had never asked who had mended it. “Keep it wound,” said Zofia, “will you? At nine every night. Do not let it stop.”

“I will.”

“I want to ask you one thing. The last bar.” Her eyes did not leave his lips. “Did I get the last bar?”

“Every note,” said Jakub.

“Liar,” said Zofia, tenderly.

“Yes,” said Jakub.

And she smiled, and put her forehead against his shoulder, and they stood in the arcade of the oldest university in Poland while above them the little mechanical figures of the great clock began to turn, and the hour was struck, and she did not hear it, and he did, and neither of them said so. It was the kindest transaction in Kraków that night.

Reader, you were told this was a tragedy, and it is. The Keeper's pencil is not a cruel one, and so here is the fact, plainly: the operation was on the ninth of June. She did not wake. The surgeon wrote that it was quiet. And Jakub Nowak wound the silver watch at nine every night for the rest of his life.

✦ ✦ ✦

Bucharest, Romania. The Circul Aurora, on the night of the new programme.

Elena Stanciu, seventy-seven, retired hotelier, had sat in the third row of every circus performance in Bucharest since 1962, and was therefore in a position to inform the young woman beside her that nothing, in the entire history of the circus, had ever been as dangerous as it looked, or as safe.

"My husband was a trapeze man," said old Elena, sucking a lemon sweet, "and he fell eleven times, and he was never so hurt as when he did not fall."

"That is not comforting, doamnă," said Ioana Dumitrescu.

She was twenty-eight, a nurse, and she was sitting bolt upright, with her hands knotted in her lap and her coat still on. She had read the scans. She could have drawn the crooked seam between the first and second lumbar vertebrae of Andrei Popescu with her eyes shut, and had told him that she would not tell him to stop, and would not pretend to like it. She had brought her bag, and it sat on her knees like a small black dog. Here she was, eyes open, as the lights died on the ring and the owner of the circus, Ionuț Radu, forty-three, a dentist

who had inherited the big top and pulled teeth on Mondays, made his announcement in the voice of a man who has bitten on something and decided to enjoy it.

"Ladies and gentlemen! Without nets, without harness, without insurance, and with my *deepest regrets*—the man who has walked the wire for eleven years! *Andrei Popescu!*"

The drums began.

There had been a low wire, six feet from the ground, with a net beneath it, built for him by Mihai for the gala. Andrei had walked it twice in rehearsal, thanked the owner with great courtesy, and asked for the high one.

He came out in white. He was thirty-one, lean, quiet-faced, fearless in the air and timid on the ground, a man who in the ordinary world had needed a conspiracy of six people to ask a woman to dinner, and who now climbed a rope ladder as though it were a staircase in his own house. At the top he stood on the little platform, twelve metres above the sawdust. He lifted his pole. He looked down, once, over the rows, until he found the third seat in the third row, and a woman with her hands in her lap.

He smiled. And he set his foot on the wire.

It was nothing. It was eighteen metres of steel cable, thin as a pencil, and he walked it as a man walks a pavement, with the pole sinking and rising, sinking and rising, like the bar of a scale. The drums hushed. The trumpets held a single sustained note. In the third row Ioana counted his steps, as she counted a pulse, one, two, three, four, and found that her own had slowed to match.

Halfway across, the wire sang a note she had never heard it sing. It was high, and short, like a kettle just before the lid. And she saw his left foot come down a little to the side of where it should have, and in the same moment saw him smile, which was not what he did when a step was good, it was what he did when

Here the page is torn.

✦ ✦ ✦

Antioquia. Six in the evening.

At six, in the first clear light of the day, when the cloud had gone up the mountain like a congregation going home, a figure on a racing bicycle came down the Las Palmas road without his team, without his jersey zipped, and with a lamp clipped crooked to his handlebar.

The roses were still there. The road had been opened, the vehicles had passed, the whole circus of the Vuelta had flowed on to Rionegro in a river of horns. But on the left verge, in the dusk, a long red ribbon still lay along the grass, half trampled, half untouched, an eight-hundred-metre testimony.

Daniela was at her gate, in her boots, with the end of a broom. She had sent her workers home. She had told Paola to go and tell her mother. She stood alone at the entrance of a farm, with a letter from a bank folded in her back pocket, and watched a man ride toward her through a field of her own pride.

“You are supposed to be in a hotel with a physiotherapist,” said Daniela.

“I am supposed to be where I crashed.”

“You did not crash *here.*”

“I did, a little,” said Sebastián, and put his foot down.

He was shaking. It was not the effort. He leaned the bicycle against her gate, with the care that he gave nothing else in the world, and he stood with his helmet in his hand and his hair plastered and his knees going, a man of twenty-nine who could not remember the first line of what he had rehearsed up a mountain.

“I came eleventh,” he said.

“I know. I heard. It was on every radio in the valley. They are going to name a *sandwich*.”

“I crashed because I was thinking of you.”

“I know. It is on the Register.” She did not smile. She held the broom as a bishop holds a crook. “Sebastián. They were going to rot. It was not a gesture. It was a Tuesday decision. I could not sell them. I have a bank that wants ninety million pesos by the end of the harvest, or it will take the farm, and I will not stand in my own greenhouse and tell a man who has just climbed a mountain on a carpet of my roses that I need to be rescued. I am *not* a rose in a bucket.”

“I did not say that you were.”

“No. You were too kind.”

“I have a prize of four hundred thousand pesos,” said Sebastián, “for the eleventh place.”

She laughed. It was a startled, offended laugh, the laugh of a person who has been caught in the middle of being proud, and it went on a good deal longer than she meant, and left her eyes bright and wet. He, who had made a career of timing, did not say a word.

"If I asked you now," he said, after a while.

"Then I would say, *not now.*" She looked at him, straight and clear and tired. "It is not the same as *no.* I have found that the two are very different animals. One of them is a door shut. The other is a door that wants to be a better door."

"How long does it take to build a better door?"

"I think," said Daniela, "until the end of the harvest."

He nodded, slowly, in a ragged dusk, like a man who has been told the length of a mountain and will take the hairpins as they come. From the edge of the verge she took, out of a bucket, one single rose, the last one, stem and thorns and all, and held it out to him, across the gate.

"For your mother," said Daniela Ruiz.

"She will be insufferable," said Sebastián.

"I am counting on it."

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0586, Sebastián Torres. Entry 0360, Daniela Ruiz. Entry 0609, Zofia Kowalska. Entry 0471, Jakub Nowak. Entry 0697, Andrei Popescu. Entry 0137, Ioana Dumitrescu.

Three stories, and the weather in each of them was the same: not knowing. A cloud, a silence, a wire in the lights. I have noticed that we ask of the unknown the one thing it cannot give, which is its name; and that the brave among us go on, regardless, in the white.

Of the page that stops in the middle of a sentence, reader, I will say nothing. Some silences are the author's and some are the paper's. I have never been certain which of them is the more merciful.

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End of Chapter 36.

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ACT IV — WHAT TIME TAKES

The Chorus

Time, that devours the child and feeds the old, Walks softly through the summer’s heavy hours; He steals the voice, the hearing, and the gold, And leaves instead a handful of dry flowers. Yet mark how time restores what time hath torn, Not in the shape it left, but changed and grown; The seed laid down in winter greets the morn, The wandering heart returns to claim its own. But some shall wait, and wait, and not be paid; And some shall sing their last in empty halls; For summer’s wage is kind, but long delayed, And every light at last to dark must fall. So bear with Time: he steals, but he is just; And what he spares was meant to outlast dust.

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Chapter 37: Exile Poems

“I am writing your story before you have lived it.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0198

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Enter the Chorus, in the heat of noon, carrying a fan.

The summer comes. It does not ask permission. It sits upon the roofs of Cairo, Baghdad, And presses, like a palm, on every forehead: “Remember what you left. Consider what you carry.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Giza, Cairo. A clinic on the second floor above a pharmacy, in the street where the Sudanese had opened, in nine months, three restaurants, two tailors, and this.

It was forty-one degrees at ten in the morning, and the ceiling fan of the waiting room had been turning for eleven years in the belief that it was doing something.

Dr. Hassan Idris, thirty-five, courteous to the point of illness, bent over the chest of a four-year-old girl with a stethoscope, and said to it, under his breath, as he said to everything, “Please.” He said it to the child, to the instrument, to the door, and once, on a bad night, to a generator. He had been a surgeon’s registrar in Khartoum.

He was now a doctor of no licence in a city of twenty million, practising under the signature of a kind Egyptian colleague and the discretion of a landlord, and he had learned, in nine months, that the first medicine for a man who has lost everything is to be called *doctor* by somebody.

“Breathe in, habibti,” he said.

“It is hot,” said the child.

“Yes. It is very hot. That is why you are coughing. It is also why I am asking you to breathe in.”

On his phone, which lay on the desk face-up, a voice note had come in from Omdurman. It had been arriving in pieces since seven, in a staccato of dropped syllables. *Hassan… Mama… the fever… the pharmacy is… no, the road to… Hassan, I cannot… do you hear…* His brother Osman, who made umbrellas and was therefore, in that country, a prophet. He had said it nine times, this morning, in nine different broken ways, and it came to the same thing: *Mother is not well. Come. Or do not come, and send the money, and say nothing.*

He had not said anything. He had gone on listening to the child’s chest, which was clear.

“Doctor,” said a voice from the doorway, “your feet.”

It belonged to Old Zuhura, who had been the cleaner of this building since it was a dentist’s, and who would, in the opinion of everybody, be mopping its corridors when it was a mosque, a bank, and a ruin. She was seventy, from Aswan, as dark as a good coffee and as wide as a doorway, and she could not read a letter of any al-

phabet; but she had learned the whole building by heart, as a blind man learns a house, and she did not trust any person who was not standing on a dry floor.

"I am not wet," said Hassan.

"You are *always* wet, ya doctor. It is something in the walk." She took a few swipes at the tiles round his shoes, and straightened, one hand on her back. "I have been watching you since January. You walk like a man carrying two sacks of flour, one in each hand. One is the clinic. The other is Omdurman." She nodded to herself. "A man cannot carry two sacks and open a door."

"Zuhura—"

"It is not wisdom," said Zuhura. "It is flour. We had a delivery on Monday and the boy dropped it." And she moved off down the corridor, trailing wet, singing something in Nubian that sounded like a very long apology to a very large river.

It was her idea, too, that the walls of the waiting room should wear poems.

She had had it in January, when a young Egyptian woman named Amal Yusuf had come, with an enormous bag and a face like a lit match, to ask whether the clinic would allow her to read verse to the patients on Thursday afternoons, *as waiting rooms are the only churches without sermons.* Hatim Babiker, the manager, a nurse of sixty-two from Omdurman who was superstitious and could not keep time, and who arrived every day at noon with a fresh omen to account for it, consulted a cat, and said yes.

Since then the poems had begun, like moss, to appear. They were taped to the wall beside *WASH YOUR HANDS*; they were stuck up with plasters; and Zuhura, who could not read them, had decided, with great confidence, that they were *the prescriptions of the clinic's second doctor, the better one,* and had begun to dispense them by instinct.

"Take this," she would say, peeling one from the wall and pressing it into the hands of a man with a bad back. "Three times a day. With bread."

"It is a poem about the sea," said the man.

"It is *medicine*," said Zuhura.

It must be recorded that the man's back got better.

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Baghdad. The Dijla, which the foreigners call the Tigris, at the east end of a bridge that did not yet reach the west.

On the other side of a desert, at a quarter to twelve, in a heat of forty-six degrees, the most obstinate stonemason in the Republic of Iraq was refusing to answer her telephone.

"It is the butcher," said Shaimaa Al-Obaidi, twenty-eight, wiping her chisel on her thigh, with the voice of a woman who knows what she is looking at. "He has rung eleven times."

"Then answer it," said the engineer.

"Never. A telephone is a leash. A man at the other end of it wants something."

The bridge was a footbridge, six hundred metres of steel and pale stone, from the old book-market at the bottom of Mutanabbi Street across the brown water to the Karkh shore, and it was due to open in the autumn, and was, at the moment, exactly two metres of air short of the far bank. A gap, like the gap in a child's smile. The two halves stood in the river, each reaching, and between them the Dijla went through, slow as a thought.

"*Habibti!*" came a roar from the quay, and up the steps, with a steaming foil parcel the size of a baby, came a short wide man in a stained apron, perspiring with indignity. This was Zaid Jabbar, thirty-five, a butcher of Basra, who had driven eight hours with the lunch, and who made promises faster than he could keep them, a habit that had made him, at once, the best matchmaker in the south and its most unpopular. "I promised the kebabs by noon!"

"It is three minutes past," said Shaimaa.

"Then I am a liar and a butcher."

"It is the same thing, but the second one is on a skewer."

"Mustafa, my friend, *tell her!* I have not slept! I have been driving since the *dawn* prayer, and I have good news, I have news of the woman—"

"Zaid," said Mustafa Karim, civil engineer, thirty-four, hopeful, practical, with a safety helmet on the back of his head like a halo that had slipped, "not here."

"But the Basra gossip is *excellent*. Her father is coming on the bus!"

The engineer put down his drawings.

“Her father,” he repeated.

“On the five o’clock! He will not telephone, because he fears the telephone, he is seventy-eight, he was a lifeguard on the Shatt al-Arab for forty years and he has never in his life been willing to say a thing to a machine that he could say to a face! I have it from the cousin of the baker’s wife. He is coming up to Baghdad, to see his daughter, for the *answer*.” The butcher put down the kebabs. His voice dropped by an octave, which for him was a collapse. “She has until tomorrow midnight. The Danes, I am told, are impatient.”

Nobody spoke. Down on the water a boy in a very small boat passed under the gap, singing to himself, and a pair of pigeons crossed the open air above the Dijla in a short, scornful line, unimpeded by engineering.

For the past five months, Mustafa Karim had built a bridge. He had stood in the river at dawn with a surveyor’s staff. He had drawn the piers and checked the tolerances and argued with a committee of sixteen. And on every one of those mornings, he had been joined, at six, with two glasses of sweet black tea, by the architect who had designed the lamps, the railings, and the little pavilion at the Rusafa end, in which a man could sit and read; Noor Hashim, thirty, ambitious, eloquent, with a pencil in her hair and a way of looking at a half-finished span as though it owed her an explanation.

He had built the whole of it so that she should have somewhere to come back to. It was a sentence he had written to a stranger in a ledger, and had never once said aloud.

“Eat the kebab,” said Shaimaa Al-Obaidi, unexpectedly, in the voice of a woman who, for all her war against the telephone, was a good deal kinder than she let on. “It will get cold. The rest is the river’s business.”

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Giza, Cairo. Thursday afternoon.

At three, by the clock above the pharmacy, nineteen people sat in the waiting room in the heat, with their bad backs and their children’s coughs and their ration of silence, and a young woman stood at the front in a long grey dress, with a notebook open in one hand like a hymn-book, and began to read.

Amal Yusuf was thirty-one. She was fierce and lyrical, and wrote, as she lived, at the edge of a thing; and her father, a retired railway guard of sixty-nine who believed in timetables and had never forgiven poetry for being late, said that she would starve for it, as other men’s daughters did for love. She had a great deal of black hair and an inability to be dull. She read in a plain, hard, steady voice, with no performance in it, as one reads a ration card, and in the third row, with a tin of salt crackers on her lap, sat a girl of fifteen named Nahid Osman, who had come from Khartoum with her aunt and a battered book of Arabic grammar, and who drank in every poem as other girls drink fizzy orange.

He will not go home this year. The roads Have learned a new geography of fear. He will stand at a window in a borrowed city And carry, in two hands, a river and a house. He will heal the stranger’s fever, and forget To eat; he will say “please” to the

stethoscope; His mother's number will be busy, busy, busy, And then one morning, like a bird, it rings. He will not say what he has left behind. That is the whole of it. The leaving. And the doctor Who leaves to save, and lives in what he saves, And does not know that he is already home.

A silence settled over the waiting room, the kind that comes after a thing has touched the right bone. Somebody blew her nose.

At the back, against the wall, with a clipboard he was not reading and a stethoscope he had forgotten to take off, a man had gone entirely still.

"Is it about someone real?" said Nahid, from the third row, who had no talent for tact. "The doctor?"

"It is about a man I have not met yet," said Amal, which was true; and then, because she was honest, "or whom I met in January, and have been writing for five months, in the future tense, to see if he would arrive."

A ripple went through the room. Old Zuhura, who had been mopping a corner in an attitude of the deepest disinterest for the past twenty minutes, stopped, and put her mop upright against the wall.

"I wrote it," said Amal, "in November. In the dark. On the night the Register opened. I read a sentence there from a doctor in Cairo, whom I did not know. It said: *I left my family behind to save strangers.* And I thought: *somebody should write that man a country to walk into.*" She closed the notebook. "I wrote him a country. It is a poem. It is a rather bad one. It is only a poem. Thank you for coming."

She went out. She went out quickly, with the big bag and the lit-match face, down the stair into the white glare of the street.

Hassan Idris did not move. His stethoscope hung from his neck like a rope.

“Doctor,” said Zuhura, at his elbow.

“I am not… I did not…” He took off the stethoscope with unaccustomed violence. “It is a coincidence.”

“It is an *accident*,” said Zuhura, with the stern gentleness of the old for the foolish, “and an accident is only a coincidence in a hurry.” She reached into the bandage cupboard, which no one but herself ever opened, and took out an enormous brown envelope, softened with handling. “She leaves them here. Every Thursday. All of them. Not for the wall: for you. She did not know I knew. *I* did not know I knew, until the second month, when the knees told me.” She put it in his hands. “Read it tonight. I will lock the door.”

“Zuhura, I cannot read the private—”

“*Ya doctor,*” said Zuhura. “In forty years I have mopped every secret in this building. They are all very small. You will be quite all right.”

✦ ✦ ✦

The clinic, ten at night.

It was the hour at which the building ceased to be a clinic and became a place of old tiles and good silence. The fan had stopped turning. The street below was a long yellow sleep of lamps. In the empty waiting room,

in the chair by the window where the mothers sat, with a single bulb on, Dr. Hassan Idris sat with a brown envelope open on his knee, and read.

There were thirty-one poems. They were written in a quick, black, impatient hand, as of one who writes at a kitchen table with a cigarette she is trying to give up. They told, in the future tense, the whole of a man's life, and he knew, from the first, that it was his. The long flight; the stairs; the room above the pharmacy. The sack in each hand. Osman's breaking voice in the notes; the way he could not bear his mother's name said in a certain tone. His mother's door. In the nineteenth poem, he found the bread; in the twenty-second, the wall; and in the twenty-seventh, with a clean stab of shock, a line about a boy of nine on a bad road, whom Hassan had never mentioned to a living soul.

She could not have known.

She wrote it, said another part of him, with weary logic, *before I lived it.*

He turned the thirty-first page. It was the last, and the shortest. It was not in the future tense. It was untitled, and the hand had changed, was smaller and less sure, as of a woman who had written it on her knee in a doorway:

> *I wrote you in the future tense because The present was too small to hold the thing. But here's one line that cannot wait: it's now. The door is open. I am standing here.*

He read it. He read it twice. He was a man who had spent a lifetime reading the faces of those in pain, and he read, without being able to say how, that the person

who had written this had put down the pen at that moment and was, at this moment, in the building.

There was a sound behind him: a small, deliberate, human sound, the sound of a breath being taken by someone who has decided on a course.

Beneath the last line, in a hand grown so small that he had to tilt the page to the lamp, there was one more sentence, written, evidently, an instant before the poet had walked in from the stair. It was the only line in the whole of the cycle that had no verse in it, and the only one that spoke of the very moment in which it was being read, and it said that she was standing in the doorway behind him now, that she had been for some time, and that when he turned round she would

Here the page is torn.

✦ ✦ ✦

Baghdad. Five in the morning, on the bridge.

The call to prayer came up out of the old city in a long, rising thread, and was answered by another, and another, until the whole of the Dijla seemed hung with sound. The sky over the Karkh shore was the grey of a pigeon’s back. On the unfinished bridge, a girl with a pencil in her hair stood on the stone of the east half, with her toes at the edge of two metres of air, holding a telephone, and, on the opposite lip of steel, with his helmet in his hand, a man stood and looked at her across the gap.

Her father had come on the five o'clock bus. He had not telephoned. He had sat for an hour in Noor Hashim's kitchen with a glass of tea in his old gnarled lifeguard's hands, and had said, at the end of it, in the voice of one who has said all the prayers he knows and has only the plain ones left: *In forty years on the Shatt I pulled nine people out of the water. And I will tell you the one thing I know. You cannot save anyone by standing beside them. At some moment you have to go in.* And then, since he was a man who feared the telephone and the sea in about equal measure, and had conquered only one, he had gone to bed.

"I have written it," said Noor. "I am going to press the button."

"I know," said Mustafa.

"You do not know what I have written."

"I know what it *says.* I have known since the winter. I have never been able to say what I would have said, and so I built six hundred metres of it." His voice was quite steady. It cost him a great deal. "It will be a good bridge, Noor. It will be the best thing I ever do. I will not ask you to stay for it."

"You have not *asked* me anything," said Noor. "You never have. It is the most infuriating quality in a man."

"It is the only one I inherited."

She laughed, in the dawn, on the lip of the stone. And then the laugh went, and she said, very low, across the gap: "I am going, Mustafa. In September. Copenhagen. Two years. They want me to learn how a city should live beside its water. And I want to. I want it so badly that it

frightens me. And I want *this*," and she lifted her hand, with a small, hopeless gesture, toward the bridge, the river, the shore, the man, "and I have never in my life wanted two things that were the same size."

"That is why one builds a bridge," said Mustafa. "Two shores. One road."

"Do not be an engineer at me. Not now."

"I am not being an engineer. I am being a man who will leave one bolt out."

She looked at him.

"The last one," said Mustafa. "In the centre of the last span. The bridge will be finished, and sound, and safe, and open, and in the very middle there will be one bolt that I do not tighten. For you. And I will not tighten it until you come and stand on it, and say it may be done."

"That is *unsafe*."

"It is a very small bolt."

"Mustafa Karim," said Noor Hashim, with her eyes quite bright and her voice shaking at the seams, "you are a terrible engineer."

"I am an excellent one," said Mustafa. "I know exactly how much a bridge can bear."

Behind her, over the old city, the sun came up over the minarets, a clean white coin. She raised the phone. She pressed the button: a small sound; a tiny whoosh; *sent*. Then she did a thing she had never done in her life. She took the pencil out of her hair and threw it, underarm, across two metres of air, and he caught it, in both hands, like a man catching a bird.

“Keep it,” said Noor. “For the drawings.”

They stood, the two of them, one on each lip of the unfinished span, with the Dijla going by below, and neither crossed, since it was not yet a bridge, and both knew it; and the pigeons passed over, and did not care.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0181, Hassan Idris. Entry 0198, Amal Yusuf. Entry 0076, Mustafa Karim. Entry 0165, Noor Hashim.

Summer, they say, is the season of fruit. I find that it is the season of distances. A river between two halves of a bridge. A thousand miles of dust between a son and a mother’s door. A whole life in the future tense.

I am old enough to know that a gap is not an absence. It is a place where something is being decided.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 37.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 38: The 5:40 to Lucknow

“I drive past your platform twice a day and never stop.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0363

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Delhi. Seventeen-fifty-eight, by the clock on platform six of Shanti Nagar Junction, where the great expresses do not stop.

There are stations at which trains arrive, and stations at which trains are merely seen to pass, and the second sort are the more romantic, since a thing that does not stop must be, by definition, on its way to something.

Shanti Nagar was the second sort. It sat on the eastern edge of the city, in a haze of brick-dust and marigold, with six platforms, a footbridge, a signal cabin the colour of a tired mango, and a tea-stall; and the Lucknow express went through it every evening at 5:58 at a speed that made the pigeons rise in a single grey sheet. It had never slowed. For eleven years it had gone through Shanti Nagar the way a very important person goes through a room of people he does not mean to speak to.

On the sixth platform, at the very end, under the one working lamp, a woman had been standing every evening at half past five for four years.

Her name was Sunita Verma. She was thirty-nine, a teacher of Hindi to the eighth class at a government school two stops down, a woman wry and resolute, in cotton saris the colour of old tea, with a leather satchel of exercise books and a steel flask. She stood at the same spot. She stood with her left hand on the strap of her satchel and her right hand free. And at 5:58, when the great blue engine came round the curve with its headlamp burning like a decision, she raised that hand, with a yellow handkerchief in it.

And the horn spoke: two short, one long.

That was all. It had been all for four years. But the biscuit-seller had a view.

"You are a very *odd* woman, Madam," said Pooja Singh, thirty-four, baker by origin, platform vendor by misfortune, who hid behind her jokes as other people hide behind newspapers. "For four years I have sold you a biscuit every evening, and you have not eaten one. A platform is not a temple. A train is not a god. It does not hear you."

"It is a *horn*," said Sunita. "It speaks."

"A horn says what the driver tells it."

"Then he is a man of very few words."

"*Hai Ram*," said the vendor. "She admits it. That it is a *he*."

Sunita Verma, who had faced forty children a day for sixteen years without once blushing, adjusted her satchel strap and said with the greatest composure, "It is a figure of speech."

“So is love,” said Pooja.

On the footbridge’s lowest step, with a stopwatch and the pinched, concentrated face of a sixteen-year-old with a theory, sat Shweta Bansal, the eighth class’s sharpest pupil and its worst for minding other people’s business. She was Madam Sunita’s student. She was, by a coincidence she had not arranged, the niece of an assistant loco pilot of Northern Railways. And she had spent the past month, in her free time, at the signal cabin’s small shrine to Hanuman, in a state of the most devoted prayer.

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The cab of the 5:40 to Lucknow, doing eighty-five kilometres an hour.

“Ravi sahab,” said Rohit Bansal, forty-three, assistant loco pilot, bookish, an Agra man who read other people’s mail whenever he could, and who was at the moment reading a magazine of Urdu poetry propped on the control desk, “the signal at Shanti Nagar was green at 5:54.”

“It is always green at 5:54.”

“I am only saying it is a *good* green.”

The driver did not reply. Ravi Chaudhary, forty-one, loco pilot, punctual, patient, had a long, grave, handsome face, a moustache of unvarying length, and a hand on the regulator that had never, in nineteen years, been known to shake. He drove the 5:40 out of New Delhi to Lucknow six days a week and had never been late except

for fog, floods, and, on one occasion, a cow of such obstinate holiness that the Divisional Manager had written a letter to a temple.

In the long dark between stations, with village lamps swimming past the window, he had a habit his assistant had learned to tolerate, which he indulged without knowing, as another man hums. He recited the stations. It was not poetry. It was a list. But a list, said often enough, in the right voice, can carry a man across the night:

Ghaziabad. Khurja. Aligarh. Tundla. Etawah.
Kanpur. Unnao. Lucknow. A rosary of stations; every
bead A halt where I am wanted, and I halt. But one,
the first, the small one, which is hers, I pass at
eighty with my hand upon the horn, And what I say
to her is two short, one long: The only sentence that
I know by heart.

"You did not say Shanti Nagar," said Rohit, not looking up from the page.

"I said *hers*."

"Hers has a name. It is Shanti Nagar. It means *the town of peace*."

"I have never been able to afford it."

The curve was coming up. Beyond it, the lamp.

"It is only that I do not know why she is there," said Ravi, to the windscreen, in the smallest voice the cab had heard from him in eleven years. "A woman does not stand on a platform in the heat for four years to wave at

a driver. She is waiting for a train that stops. There is some man, Rohit, for whom the evening halts at six, and she is polite enough to wave to the one that doesn't."

"It is also possible," said Rohit Bansal, turning a page, "that you are an idiot."

Ahead of them, with a clean, bright, mathematical suddenness, the colour on the signal over the curve changed from green to red.

"That," said Ravi, "is not right. It has never been red."

"It is a *very* red red," said the assistant, with reverence, and closed the poetry.

✦ ✦ ✦

Vienna, Austria. A bus on the Ring, on an afternoon of the same week.

It was the last bus in Vienna with a conductor, a fact which the municipality had overlooked, as it overlooks the odd great tree, and which a man named Lukas Bauer, thirty-seven, took as a personal charge.

"*Frau Maestra*," said Lukas, taking her coin with a clip of his punch, "you are late."

"I know that I am late," said Clara Weber. She was thirty-two, a conductor at the Musikverein, five feet five of Prussian-blue coat and absolutely nothing out of place, holding a score like an infant that has begun to scream. "I am *conducting* in an hour."

"So am I," said Lukas.

"You are not conducting. You sell tickets."

“I conduct people from one place to another, with a clip and a bell. You do it with a stick and sixty violinists. We are colleagues.” He leaned on the pole. He was blunt, could not apologise, and had in nine years acquired the biography of every regular on the line. “And you are on my bus at a quarter to five on a Thursday, going the wrong way. The Musikverein is *behind* you. Where is it that you are *really* going?”

“That is none of your—”

“A violin maker.”

The bus rocked round the Opera, and the conductress, a woman who could silence the second violins with one eyebrow, visibly considered murdering a man in public service.

“Since February,” said Lukas. “You get on very tense. You get off at the Albertina very *less* tense. Frau Weber, I am a simple man, and I know that there are only two things which make a person walk that fast to a door. One is a debt. And the other…”

“If you say it, I will have you removed from the municipal register.”

“The other,” said Lukas Bauer, with immense tenderness, ringing the bell for the Albertina, “is a *flat note.*”

She got off. The door hissed. She stood on the pavement by the Albertina in the late sun, knowing that a bus conductor had just played her better than the second violins ever had.

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It was a small shop in a narrow street, with a bell over the door and one window lined with the pale amber bodies of unfinished violins. It smelled of spruce and maple and varnish and hide glue. At a bench at the back, with a magnifying lens in one eye, a man of thirty-six was bending over a scroll, and an apprentice of forty-nine named Theresa Hofer, wry and unstoppable, who talked over everyone, including herself, was telling the entire shop about her cousin's wedding.

"—and the *cake*, Herr Müller, three tiers and a *gondola*, I told her, Gretl, it is Salzburg, not Venice, and she said, *It is a symbol*, and I said—*oh*."

Her voice died. Clara Weber had stood in the doorway for some time, with her score in her arms and her face composed, and Jonas Müller, who had not looked up, had known it, as a man knows that the weather has changed.

"Frau Weber," he said.

"Herr Müller."

"The violin is on the wall."

It was. It hung alone, in a case of glass at the back, made over the winter from a piece of maple he had been keeping for ten years, with a dark red-gold varnish and a faint wavering flame in the grain of the back. He had made it so carefully that it was perfect; and he had made it, secretly, with a flaw. For every violin has, at some place on its fingerboard, a note that growls: a wolf, the old makers call it. Every maker spends his life driving the wolf out. Jonas had built his in. He had tuned it, to

the last hair, so that the wolf lived on one note only, the flat one, the one that sounded, in a house of pure tone, like a human being.

“I have not touched one since I was twelve,” said Clara. “I conduct. One must stop one’s hands from doing anything, and let sixty people do it instead.”

“I know,” said Jonas.

She set down the score. She took the violin from its case, with fingers that had forgotten, and that remembered, and that were not entirely able to be steady. She lifted it to her chin as to a face. She drew the bow, once, along the lowest string, and it spoke, rich and round and deep, and then she found the place where her hand knew to go, and put down a finger, and drew.

It was flat.

It was not the flatness of error. It was flat as a voice is flat when someone has stopped pretending. It filled the little shop and rang in the glass cases of the unfinished violins, and it went on, a single note, a little off the world, and she let it ring until it died.

“That is me,” said Clara.

“That is you,” said Jonas.

“No.” She lowered the bow. Her eyes, which were grey and very exact, were wet, and she did not trouble to hide it. “That is *you*. I have conducted four hundred concerts and never had one flat note. And you came into my life on a Tuesday, with a screwdriver, and everything has been very slightly off ever since, in the most beautiful way.”

“I can fix it,” said Jonas, in a terrified voice. “If you do not like it—”

“Herr Müller.”

“Yes.”

“If you ever fix it,” said Clara Weber, “I will never forgive you. I have enough perfect violins.”

At the bench, Theresa Hofer, for the first time in her entire life, had nothing to say, and said it very loudly.

✦ ✦ ✦

Sofia, Bulgaria. The Palace of Justice, between two stone lions, at nine in the morning.

The judge was a tired woman of sixty in a black gown, with the look of one who has read a great many sentences and written every one of them in her sleep, and she asked the question in Bulgarian, gently, because she had read the file and was not a cruel woman.

“Nikolai Ivanov. Do you admit that on the night of the fourteenth of November, nine years ago, at the post on the mountain road, while on duty as an officer of the Border Police, you did see a child of about six years old cross the line, and did not stop her?”

Nikolai, thirty-eight, in the grey suit of a man who has not been in a suit since a funeral, shook his head from side to side.

In Bulgaria this means *yes*. It is one of the glories of the nation that its people nod for no and shake for yes, and the foreign newspaperman at the back of the court,

who had been told this twice and forgotten it twice, wrote on his pad, with great decision, *DENIES.*

"Yes," said Nikolai, aloud, to avoid all doubt. "I admit it."

It was the Register that had done it. The Keeper's ledger, which had opened a thousand doors, had opened one more than anyone intended. *I once looked away and let a child cross.* Entry 0032, written in the dark, to be rid of it. A colleague had read it in a canteen on his phone. There are no secrets in a canteen. By Christmas there had been an inquiry; by March, a charge. And on the third of June, in a courtroom that smelled of floor-wax and old coats, the dutiful, haunted, honest man stood up and said that it was true.

"The court has heard a witness," said the judge.

The witness was fifteen, small and straight, in her school blouse. She had come from Plovdiv by the early train with a foster mother and a notebook, and in the box she did not look at the judge. She looked at Nikolai.

"My name is Tsvetana Dimitrov," she said. "It was not always. I do not remember the first name. I remember the night. It was very cold, and the man in the booth looked at his boots. He had very clean boots. I thought, as a child will: *that is a man who polishes the things he is afraid of.* And then he looked at the other side of the road. And I went across." She swallowed. "I do not think it is right to send him to prison for looking at his boots. But I understand that the law is not an ear. It is a ruler."

The courtroom was very still.

The sentence, when it came, was two years. The judge said it with her eyes on the file, in the voice in which grief is read from a card. And then, because she was human, she added something that was not in the law, and was not recorded: “Mr. Ivanov. For what it is worth to you. Thank you.”

On the steps, between the stone lions, with a policeman standing at a decent distance and looking at the sky, a woman in a long coat was waiting. It was a very warm day for a coat. In its lining she had carried for six months a document with the photograph of a man she loved and a name that was not his; she had been to a border and back with it, and had not used it, which was luck, and had not been able to burn it, which was love.

Elena Georgieva was thirty-four, a translator in four languages, discreet, precise, and entirely out of words.

“The train for Thessaloniki is at ten,” she said, in a flat, quick, unnatural voice. “I have the tickets. I have the passport. They have not looked at the coat. Nikolai, they have not put the cuffs on. You can be on the platform in nineteen minutes.”

“Elena,” said Nikolai, very gently, and took her two hands, coat-cuffs and all, in his. “I looked away once. It was the only wrong thing I ever did, and I have not been able to put it down in nine years. I cannot do it a second time. I will not look away from my own account.” He smiled; it was a terrible, tender smile. “It is only two years. I shall learn to read the old poets. You will write to me in four languages.”

“I will not be able to *bear* it.”

“You will do it very well. You do everything very well. It is the most infuriating thing about you.”

She was crying now, quite openly, in a way that made the policeman study a pigeon. He did not let go of her hands. He spoke, then, in the plainer language of two people standing in sunlight:

A border is a line drawn by a man Who never had to walk it with a child. I crossed it once by looking at the ground. I’ll cross it back by looking at your face. Keep the false passport. Put it in the fire The day I’m out, and make me a new one: A true one. We shall take a train at noon To any country where the guards are kind.

She laughed, through everything, a wet cracked laugh, and kissed him once, on the forehead, as one signs a document of which one is proud. The policeman, with the delicacy of a man who has seen a great many partings and has never got used to one, stepped forward, and said that it was time.

✦ ✦ ✦

Delhi. Seventeen-fifty-eight, and four minutes, at platform six.

The blue engine of the 5:40 to Lucknow came to a stop at Shanti Nagar Junction at 5:58 and eleven seconds, with a long, enormous, trembling sigh of brakes, directly opposite a woman with a yellow handkerchief, in a silence so total that the pigeons did not know what to do with their wings.

Nobody on the platform spoke. The biscuit-seller had dropped a tray. On the footbridge, Shweta, who had asked of a mango-coloured shrine only that *the signal be red for a very short time, not enough to hurt anyone,* put her hand over her mouth and sat down suddenly on the step.

Sunita Verma did not move.

The cab door above her opened. A man leaned out of it, a tall man in a blue cotton uniform with a smear of engine-grease on the sleeve, holding the rail as though it were the rail of a ship. For four years he had looked at her from eighty kilometres an hour. He had never before seen the colour of her eyes. They were dark brown, and she was regarding him with perfect and ferocious composure, which was, he recognised with sudden horror, the face of a woman working very hard at not crying.

"The signal," said Ravi Chaudhary. "It is red."

"I see that," said Sunita.

"It will change in a minute. Perhaps four."

"Then you will drink tea."

She had a steel flask in her satchel, carried every evening for four years and never once opened. She unscrewed it and poured into its steel cup, with hands that were very steady and a face that was not. The tea was cold. It had been made at seven that morning. She held it up to the open door, to the cab, to the man.

He leaned down. He took it. His fingers touched hers for one second, and in that second, on the sixth platform of Shanti Nagar, among the shoes and the pigeons and

the stunned vendors, a great many people discovered that they had been holding their breath.

He drank. It was dreadful. It was the best tea he had ever had.

“Madam,” said Ravi. “I have always wished to stop.”

“Then,” said Sunita, “you should have stopped.”

“I did not know,” he said, in a voice quite unlike a driver’s, “whom you were waiting for.”

She looked at him. Something went across her face that was not a smile, but was the shadow of one, travelling a long way. “Mr. Chaudhary,” she said, “I teach the eighth class. I have forty pupils. Not one of them is as slow as you.”

Above the cab, with a click that sounded to everyone present like the closing of a book, the signal turned green.

He gave her back the cup. He did not say anything else; he did not know what it would have been. He drew in the door and took the regulator in his hand, and the great engine began to move; and at the end of the platform a woman with a yellow handkerchief did not wave it, but pressed it to her mouth, and stood.

And then, as the train drew out into the evening, for the first time in eleven years, the horn did not say *two short, one long.* It said something else: a new sentence, entirely unrehearsed, a long, rising, trembling blast that went on far longer than regulations allow, and was

heard, it is reported, at the signal cabin, at the school, and in a kitchen two streets away, where an old woman put down a ladle.

Mark this, reader. It was not in the code.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0363, Ravi Chaudhary. Entry 0292, Sunita Verma. Entry 0665, Clara Weber. Entry 0450, Jonas Müller.

Entry 0032, Nikolai Ivanov, of Sofia, thirty-eight. I will set this down plainly, for I have promised the Register an honest keeper. He served nine weeks. In the ninth, in the infirmary of the prison, the heart he had never told anyone about, because a guard may not be ill, stopped on a Tuesday afternoon, while he was reading a letter aloud to a man in the next bed who had never been taught to read. It was a letter from Entry 0534, in her fourth language. The man in the next bed said afterwards that it was the first letter anyone had ever read to him, and that he had understood every word, though it was in French.

I did not foresee that the truth could cost a man his post. I foresaw only that it might cost him his sleep. I have been wrong in forty-five years about a number of things, and I would like it understood that I know the number.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 38.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 39: Brass and Mud

“The band is folding and you are the only thing I would keep.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0542

✦ ✦ ✦

Enter the Chorus, in a raincoat, which in Manchester is the only costume that never goes out of fashion.

Two things this city lost and could not mend: A ground whose grass has run its final mile, A band whose brass must lay its music down. Yet one small note, held faithful to the end, May outlast stand and bandroom, turf and town.

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SCENE I

Marsden Road Ground, Manchester. Dawn, one week before the last match. Drizzle, as ordered.

There are two kinds of grass in Manchester: the kind that is grown, and the kind that is *kept*. The first needs only rain, of which the city has a surplus. The second needs a man.

William Hartley was that man. He was thirty, he had been at Marsden Road since the age of sixteen, when he had been handed a roller as big as a bus and told to

make the world flat, and he knew every blade of the pitch the way a shepherd knows a flock: by temperament. The left wing sulked in October. The penalty spot drank water like a Methodist at a wedding. The centre circle, which he had painted ten thousand times with a chalk-wheel and a steady hand, had a slight tilt to the east, as though even the middle of things were leaning toward something else.

This morning he mowed it for the second-to-last time, which is a sadness of its own.

He did it slowly, as one eats the last of anything. Up the length of the pitch, a stripe dark where the grass bent away; back again, a stripe pale where it bent toward him. Behind him the stands rose, grey and empty and a little rusted, like the ribs of a patient animal told it was to be put down, and resolved to be dignified. On the east gate a banner, already tired, said: **MARSDEN GARDENS: 214 LUXURY APARTMENTS. COMING SOON.**

“Coming soon,” William told the roller. “They always say *soon*. Nobody says *sorry*.”

“I say it!” cried a voice from the tunnel. “Sorry! Sorry! Terribly sorry! I have been trying to say it for a week and it keeps coming out as a whistle.”

It was true. It generally did.

Out of the tunnel, with a bunch of keys the size of a small bagpipe and a flat cap that had seen four decades of Saturdays, came Mr. George Lowe, sixty-eight, caretaker of the Marsden Town Silver Band’s rehearsal room beneath the east stand, known to every living soul in the

district as **Mr. Pennywhistle**, because he could not walk, think, grieve or be afraid without whistling, and because no one had ever heard him whistle a recognisable tune. He had been writing the Great Salford Novel for nineteen years. It was, by his own account, "nearly there"; its first chapter had been nearly there since 2006.

"Pennywhistle."

"Will! A word. Two words. Three, if you will pay for them." He leaned on the rail, panting, all anxious elbows. "I have news. Poppy Ashworth has been seen in the bandroom at six in the morning, *alone*, playing the one piece she says she will never play in public. A woman who plays by herself at dawn, William, is a woman with a thing on her mind."

"She practises."

"She practises *you*."

"Pennywhistle."

"A groundsman and a cornetist," said Mr. Pennywhistle, with the air of a man unveiling a statue. "One keeps the pitch; the other hits it. If that is not Providence, I do not know what is, and I have read the Bible twice and a great deal of the Yellow Pages."

"It is not Providence. It is a pun."

"Providence *is* a pun, William. It is the pun God makes when He is too tired to explain." He wagged a finger. "You have been mowing round that centre circle as though you were afraid of it. Mind me. If a man will not look at his own middle, he will not look at anything."

William did look at it. The circle sat in the green, pale and perfect, a whole round O, and for a moment he thought that it looked like nothing so much as a note.

He put the thought away. A groundsman does not entertain thoughts that cannot be rolled.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

The same night. The pitch, empty. A single floodlight, the last still working, throws his shadow a hundred yards.

He had told no one about the letters.

There were two. The first, from the club, offered him a place at the *new* ground, four miles east and shining like a new tooth, where the grass was plastic, and the man who looked after it was called a *surface technician*, and the work consisted of sweeping rubber crumbs from one end of a carpet to the other. The second came from an academy in Southampton, three hundred miles away, where they grew real turf under real sky and wanted a head groundsman who knew the difference.

He had folded both in his breast pocket. He had carried them to the pitch. And now, in the one remaining light, with the rain thinned to a mist and the stands dark as a sleeping choir, William Hartley did what the lonely do when they are certain that nobody is listening: he spoke it out.

Good ground, old ground, that held me up so long, I never learned to stand on anything else, Forgive the man who leaves you to the diggers. I fed you, and you fed me back in silence: Each autumn's mud, each summer's patient green, The hush before the whistle when ten thousand Held in a single breath. I knew you, ground. I knew you by your moods, and by your drains. And yet it is not you I cannot leave. It is a girl who plays a cornet badly At six a.m., on purpose, so I'll hear. She thinks I do not know. I know. I know. And she is going, too — to Leeds, they say; A school, a salary, an end to brass. So both of us are leaving, and the grass Will keep the foot-prints longer than the feet.

He stopped. The floodlight buzzed. Somewhere beyond the wall a late bus coughed up Marsden Road and went on without anyone.

"That was very good," said a small voice.

William nearly left his own skin on the turf.

At the touchline stood a girl of thirteen in a school coat three sizes too wide, holding a torch like a sword. It was Hannah Hughes, the neighbour's daughter, who had climbed the back fence nightly for two years to count the foxes and who had never once, to anyone's knowledge, been where she was supposed to be.

"How long have you been there?"

"Since *good ground, old ground.*" She considered. "It doesn't rhyme."

"It is not meant to rhyme."

“Then it’s a speech. You should say it to her. Poppy. Not to the grass. The grass can’t say anything back.”

“Hannah, go home.”

“I am *going*.” She turned. Then she said, with the withering patience of the very young, “Grown-ups always say things to the wrong thing. My nan says things to the cat.” And she was over the fence and gone, and William was left alone with the floodlight and the unpleasant sensation of having been correctly judged by somebody who still had a primary-school timetable.

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SCENE III

Kisumu, on Lake Victoria. The same week. The beach at Dunga, before sunrise. The lake the colour of weak tea; the sky preparing something larger.

Mark this, reader, for we must cross a continent between two paragraphs. Pack lightly.

A woman in a green anorak stood among the moored boats, with a notebook she had decided not to open.

Her name was Wanjiru Kamau. She was twenty-seven, she was a technology journalist of the exact and unflattering kind, and four months ago she had written an article that had begun, *The man who calls himself Captain Kali has never caught a Nile perch heavier than his own ego.* It had been true in every particular. It had also cost a fisherman from Kisumu four hundred thousand followers and, as far as she could judge, a good deal of sleep.

It had cost her the same sleep, on the other side of the ledger, and she had not yet worked out the exchange rate.

She had taken the first flight from Nairobi. She had not told him. She had come to correct the record, which is what she told herself, and which was what the notebook was for.

"You are standing in my light," said a voice from a boat.

Otieno Odhiambo, twenty-nine, was sitting in the stern of a wooden boat called *Mama Akinyi* (after his grandmother, who had fished this gulf for sixty years and had never once worn a cape). He was untangling a net. He did not wear the cape either. He wore a torn grey sweater and the look of someone who had been very loud for a long time and had lately discovered how pleasant quiet is.

"Wanjiru."

"Otieno."

"You came to fact-check my net?"

"I came," said Wanjiru, "to say that I wrote a true thing and I am not sorry I wrote it, and that I have been sorry every day since. Both are the case. I could not find an article that fits both. So I came to say it aloud."

He looked at her for a long moment, and the sun, which had been waiting politely behind Kit Mikayi, put one pink finger on the lake.

"Get in," said Otieno. "The omena do not run for apologies."

They went out. He rowed first, then ran the little motor, and the gulf opened round them, papyrus along the margin and water hyacinth drifting in green islands, with egrets standing on them like waiters who had not been told the party was over. He told her he had posted nothing in four months. He told her the truth about the persona, which was that Captain Kali had begun as a joke to sell dried fish, and then the joke had begun to sell *him*, and then there was a day he could not find where the Captain stopped and he began.

"The hippo story?" said Wanjiru.

"Never met a hippo. They frighten me."

"And the sixty-kilo perch?"

"I bought it from Mama Njeri in the market. She gave me a discount on the *story.*"

"Otieno."

"I know."

"Why?"

"Because a fisherman who catches tilapia is a fisherman," he said, "and a fisherman who wrestles a perch is *content*, and nobody would pay for the truth, which is that I am good at a quiet job and was afraid of that." He cut the engine. The silence that came was enormous and full of water. "You wrote it was a lie. It was. But you also wrote, in the last paragraph, *the man has real talent, and I would rather watch him use it honestly.* I have read that line four hundred times. I am not sure you meant to put it in."

Wanjiru, who had never in her career been caught by her own sentences, looked at the water.

“I did not mean to,” she said. “It was the only true thing I could not edit out.”

Then, thirty yards off the starboard bow, the lake bulged. A grey back the size of a wardrobe rose, blew a plume of spray into the dawn, and opened a mouth that could have comfortably accommodated a family saloon.

Otieno screamed.

It was not the scream of Captain Kali. It was a long, high, honest scream, the scream of a boy, and it went on until he ran out of lungs, whereupon he clapped both hands over his mouth, and Wanjiru, who had begun to laugh somewhere around the second second, was laughing so hard that the boat rocked.

“Never met a hippo,” she wheezed.

“I *have* now!”

“You are not filming it.”

“I forgot the camera!” said Otieno, wide-eyed. “I forgot to *perform!* Did you see? I was only frightened!”

“I saw.” She wiped her eyes. “That. That man. He was very good.”

“He has fewer followers.”

Wanjiru Kamau looked at him in the first true light, a fisherman in a torn sweater, afraid of hippos, with the whole bright lake around him like a verdict.

“He has one,” she said.

The hippo sank. The omena ran. Neither of them noticed.

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SCENE IV

Marsden Road. The following Saturday. Last match, last whistle, last light. The ground full for the first time in a decade, and every seat damp.

They lost two–one in the ninety-third minute, which the crowd agreed was the only fitting way to end, as the club had never in its history been on time for anything.

Then, as the referee's whistle died, the old tunnel doors swung open and out marched the Marsden Town Silver Band, twenty-six strong, in their maroon jackets gone to the colour of old wine, with Poppy Ashworth at the front.

She was twenty-nine, she was loud in every sense a woman can be, and her cornet was dented from a fall off a coach in 2019 and played all the better for it. She marched with her chin up and her eyes straight ahead, which is how one marches when afraid to look at the thing one most wants to see.

Behind her came Callum Brown, the euphonium, forty and shy as a clam, who was William's best friend and who had once spent an entire wedding trying to ask a bridesmaid to dance and had asked the cake instead. Behind him came the basses, the trombones, the old man on the bass drum who had played at the Cup final in a blizzard and had never let anyone forget it.

They marched into the middle of the mud.

For it was mud now, a century of drainage in the rain, black and sticking, up to the ankle, and the bandsmen's polished shoes went into it with a noise like a sigh. They did not stop. Brass bands, as Mr. Pennywhistle would tell you, do not stop for weather; they stop for *death*, and then only after the last verse.

"Have you looked at the pitch, Poppy?" hissed Callum.

"I am not looking at the pitch."

"You should look at the pitch."

"*I am not looking at the pitch, Callum.*"

But in the press box, high on the roof of the west stand, Mr. Pennywhistle, who had climbed up there with a thermos and a notebook and had been writing nothing at all for forty minutes, had seen it. He was the only man in the ground who could. And when he realised what it was he stood up so fast that the thermos went over the edge, bounced three times, and landed in the executive car park to a sound that has been described in the literature as *a terrible gong*.

"Look!" he shrieked, to no one. "*Look at the grass!*"

For this is what William Hartley had done on the last morning of his craft. He had not mown it in stripes. He had mown it in *lines*: five long bands, straight as rails, down the whole length of the ground, dark and pale and dark and pale and dark, until, seen from above, the pitch was a great musical stave laid across the earth. And in

the very middle of it, on the third line, where the centre circle sat in its tilt toward the east, there was a single round, hollow, perfect mark.

A whole note. A semibreve. The longest thing in music, the one you hold until the conductor lets you go. And on a stave in the treble clef, the third line is **B**.

It was the note Poppy had been practising, alone, at six every morning since Easter. It was the note that began the piece the band had never played in public because she said it was too private. And only one man in the whole of Manchester knew that she played it, because only one man had been standing outside the bandroom window at dawn every day for seven weeks pretending to check the drains.

The band reached the centre. They turned. Callum lifted his baton, because the conductor had gone home with a cold, and nodded to Poppy.

She stood in the mud with her cornet at her lip, and for the first time in her life did not know whether she could breathe. She looked up. Not at the stands. At the grass. Across the field, stripe after stripe, she followed it, and found at the end of it all the one round O at her feet, and, standing in the technical area with his cap in his hand, soaked to the skin, the man who had made it.

William did not wave. He did not smile. He only nodded, very slightly, the way you nod to someone across a railway platform when you have decided not to be a coward.

She played.

If you have never heard a cornet in the rain: it is not a sweet sound. It is a *bright* one, a bright hard thread pulled through the wet air, and it climbed out of the old ground in one long note that held and held and would not let go, past the rusted stands, past the banner, past the cranes already waiting beyond the wall; and when she ran out of breath and had to lift her lip, the whole band took it up beneath her, twenty-six brass voices in the mud, and the crowd who had come to bury a football ground found that it had been given instead a hymn.

Nobody left. Ten thousand people stood in the rain and sang a tune they had known all their lives, and the groundsman stood at the edge of the grass he had made and wept, very quietly, into his cap.

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SCENE V

After. The tunnel. A bucket of water, a towel, a cornet case with the lid open, and two people who had both been very brave and are now very tired.

“You mowed a stave,” said Poppy.

“I mowed a stave.”

“On purpose.”

“A groundsman does nothing by accident. We do not have the budget.”

“William.” She turned the cornet in her hands. “I’m going to Leeds. There is a school. They offered me the music department. The band is folding, and I thought—”

she laughed, one short crack—"I thought, well, if I cannot keep the band I may as well keep the *pay.* I wrote to say yes. I have not posted it."

"I am going to Southampton," said William. "There's an academy. They want a head groundsman. I wrote to say yes. I have not posted it."

They looked at each other.

"We have *both* got letters in our pockets," said Poppy.

"That is the most Manchester thing I have ever heard."

"You were going to leave me at the same time I was going to leave you, and neither of us said."

"I said it to the grass."

"I heard," said Poppy. "Hannah Hughes told me. She told me in the chip shop. She said you said it wrong."

"Hannah Hughes has no respect for privacy."

"She's *thirteen*, William. She is the only honest person on Marsden Road."

He laughed, and it came out of him like a held breath. Then, because it was the sort of evening on which everyone had said too much, he said a little more.

"I'm not going to Southampton," said William. "I tore it in two on the way down the tunnel. There's a vacancy with the city parks. Seven playing fields and a bowling green. It's not Wembley. It's got a lot of mud. I'd be good at it."

“I’m not going to Leeds,” said Poppy. “I wrote to the school across the road from the park. They’ve an empty music room. They have, I’m told, *nine* unplayed cornets in a cupboard, and nobody to tell the children which end to blow.”

“The band’s still folding.”

“The band’s folded,” said Poppy. “It’s what we do. We fold, and then we’re a very good *shape*.” She put the cornet in its case and snapped it shut. “Mr. Pennywhistle says the room under the east stand is mine till the diggers come. After that, I’m told, we may rehearse in his flat. He has promised us biscuits. Which means we shall have none.”

“Poppy.”

“Yes?”

“The band is folding, and—” He faltered. A man may mow a stave in perfect straight lines and still be unable to finish a sentence. “And I would keep *you*. If that is a thing a person can say. In a tunnel. Wet.”

She did not say *love.* She was Mancunian; she had her pride. She said, “I know. You mowed it in B.”

And then, in the cold smell of the tunnel, among the buckets and the wet boots and the last of the Marsden brass, Poppy Ashworth kissed him once on the cheek, as one stamps a letter, and walked out into the floodlit rain with her dented cornet and her head very high. William stood quite still, with his cap in his hand, and the whole ground hummed.

From the shadows came a small, sniffling, delighted whistle, tuneless as ever.

“Pennywhistle,” said William, without turning.

“I was not here.”

“You have been here all night.”

“I am the *caretaker*,” said Mr. Pennywhistle, with immense dignity, wiping his nose on the Great Salford Novel. “It is my duty to take care. And I’ll have you know that I left that door unlocked on purpose.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0542 and Entry 0639. A ground is a promise made to the earth that it will be kept. A band is a promise made to the air that it will be heard. Both are broken, in time. But a note, once held by two people at the same moment, is not broken; it merely passes into the walls.

Entry 0483 and Entry 0826. The lake forgave him before the woman did. She, however, was not slow.

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End of Chapter 39.

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Chapter 40: The Calligrapher’s Ink

“I would teach you every letter, if you asked.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0502

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE I

Marrakech. The spice souk, near the old square of the apothecaries. Noon, and a heat with opinions.

A man who cannot read must be a very good liar, a very good listener, or a very good nose. Youssef Benali was all three, and handsome besides, which helps.

He was thirty, and he sold spices from a stall the width of a wardrobe, in a lane so crowded with cones of saffron-gold and cumin-brown and paprika-red that the sun came down into it already tinted. He could tell ras el hanout from its imitators with his eyes shut. He knew forty prices by heart and eleven languages of haggling. He had a voice like warm honey poured slowly over a very hot spoon, and tourists from Lyon to Lagos would stand and listen to him describe a pinch of turmeric as though he were reading them a love poem.

He was not reading. He had never read anything in his life. He had, since the age of ten, *remembered* it.

His jars carried no labels. They carried small, careful drawings: a crocus for saffron, a seed with a tail for cumin, a flame for chilli. The tourists thought this was charming branding. His customers thought it was eccentric. His accountant, a bookish clockmender named Mehdi Bennani from the next stall, who had once told him that he had "the most *visual* ledger in Morocco," thought it was a sign of genius, and was quite sincere.

"I have found," said Mehdi that noon, appearing between the saffron and the sumac with a ledger under his arm, "an error in your invoice from Fez."

"I do not see an error."

"You will, when I read it out." Mehdi, who trusted everyone and was wrong about most of them, adored reading aloud, and did so in three voices: a gruff merchant, a prim clerk, and a tragic widow. "*'Seventy kilos of cumin, at forty dirhams—'*"

"I have left my glasses at home."

"You do not wear glasses."

"Then I have left my *eyes* at home," said Youssef smoothly. "It is a hot day. Read on."

Mehdi read on. The lie passed over them as it had passed over every day for twenty years, like a small, tame cloud. It was a good lie. It had a beautiful voice. It had never once been found out, and Youssef loved it and hated it, as one hates an old coat that has come to fit the exact shape of one's shame.

"Do you know what the trouble with you is?" said Mehdi, closing the ledger.

“I am sure you will tell me.”

“You are *too* clever. A man like you could do anything, if he would only sit down and learn something.”

Youssef smiled at him, and it was a very good smile, and behind it a door in his chest shut as softly as a drawer.

“A fool speaks wisdom by accident,” he said, “so they say. You are the proof.”

“I take that as a compliment.”

“Naturally,” said Youssef Benali. “You are an optimist.”

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

An atelier in a lane behind the old madrasa. A window on a courtyard with a lemon tree. A long table, a row of reed pens, a smell of soot, honey and gum arabic.

His shop sign had been commissioned in May. He had to collect it in June. That was the whole misfortune, and he had known for a month that it would end in this lane.

The woman at the table did not look up when he came in. She was finishing a stroke, and one does not interrupt a stroke any more than one interrupts a prayer. She was twenty-eight, with her hair wrapped in a plain indigo scarf, ink on the second finger of her right hand, and a way of holding her breath while the reed was on the paper that made the whole room seem to hold it with her.

Salma Idrissi lifted the pen. She let out the breath.

“You are the spice man.”

“I am the spice man.”

“Youssef Benali, *Épices*, two lines, one in the Maghrebi hand, one in French for the tourists. It is nearly done.” She turned the board toward him. “Tell me if the proportions please you.”

He looked at the board.

On it, in black ink as deep as the pupil of an eye, ran a line of Arabic so graceful that it seemed less written than *grown*, curling across a ground of faded saffron paper, the letters leaning against one another like a family on a sofa. He looked at it for a long time. He did it well; he had had twenty years of practice at looking at pages.

“It is beautiful,” said Youssef.

“Thank you. And the words?”

“The words are what I asked for.”

“Which is the second word?”

It was said so quietly, and so gently, that for a moment he did not understand it was a question. Then he understood, and the room tilted a little, as a boat tilts when the weight of the cargo is suddenly found.

“I would prefer,” said Youssef, honey-voiced, hand steady, “to hear you read it. It is rude to read your own sign aloud. A man should hear his name in a woman’s mouth.”

“That is a very handsome evasion.”

“I have had practice.”

“I know,” said Salma. “I know exactly how much.”

She did not say it unkindly. She laid down the reed and wiped her finger on a cloth, and she looked at him full on, as one looks at a letter one has been trying to place for months.

“Forgive me, Monsieur Benali. I have a bad habit. I read the Register of Black Stars at night when I cannot sleep. There was an entry from Casablanca.” She said it as if she were handing him something very fragile. “Number four hundred and thirty-nine. It said that a man could not read well, and had hidden it for twenty years. I do not know who wrote it. I never will, unless he tells me. But when you walked in, and looked at my work as a man looks at a closed door in a house he knows very well—”

“I do not know what you mean.”

“No,” said Salma. “Of course you don’t.”

Silence. Outside, in the courtyard, a lemon dropped from the tree and rolled across the stone, in no hurry, like a small yellow thought.

“I wrote one, too,” said Salma. “It is the five hundred and second. I will not tell you what it says. It is not a thing to be *read* to someone. It is a thing to be *asked* for.”

Youssef looked at his hands, which had never shaken, even in a bargain with a rival or a scorpion.

They were shaking.

“I do not ask for things,” he said.

“I know. It is the same with me.”

“I have lived twenty years behind this smile.”

“It is a good smile.”

“It is a *wall* with a good smile on it.”

“Then,” said Salma, with the very slightest tilt of the mouth, “we have the same architect.”

He sat. It was the first time he had sat in somebody else’s shop without a bargain in his head.

“I did not learn,” said Youssef Benali. “The letters moved. The teacher said I was lazy. The teacher hit me, and then said I was stupid. After that I did not need a teacher to say it. I said it to myself so well.” He breathed out. “The *ba* looks like the *ta* and the *ta* looks like the *nun*, and when I stare they dance. So I learned the rest. I learned the world with my nose and my tongue and my memory, and I became very, very rich in everything but the one thing every child is born into.”

“Do you want to learn?”

“Yes,” said Youssef.

It was the word he had not said in twenty years, and it came out of him smaller than he expected and a great deal heavier, like a stone from a well.

“Say it again,” said Salma, “and mean the whole sentence.”

“I am asking you,” said Youssef, “if you would teach me every letter.”

“I would.”

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

The atelier. Many afternoons. The reeds, the ink, the lemon tree changing its mind about being green.

She began not with letters but with ink.

“You will make your own,” said Salma, “so you will know what you are asking it to carry.” There was soot, scraped from a lamp; there was gum arabic, in amber tears; there was water in which a pinch of saffron had steeped, which was the only part he could have done blind. She stirred it for an hour. “Honey,” she said, “to keep it from cracking. Everything that endures needs a little sweetness.”

“You have been waiting to say that.”

“I say it every time. It is a very good sentence.” She put a reed in his hand. It had been cut on a slant, with a split at the nib, and it sat in his fingers as awkwardly as a stranger’s child. “Now. The *nuqta*. The dot. Press the pen flat and make one.”

He made one. A rhombus, small and clean and black.

“That,” said Salma, “is your ruler. Every letter in this alphabet is measured by the dot of your own pen. The *alif* is five of them, stacked, one on the other.” She drew it: a single upright stroke, plain and tall. “The circle that holds all the other letters has the *alif* for a diameter. Nothing is by eye. Nothing is *guessed.* Do you understand? This is not a thing the clever are born knowing. It is a thing you may *measure.*”

He stared at the line. He did not say anything. He had been measured all his life, and found short, by people with rulers who had never given him a reed.

She taught him by his own trade, because a teacher who ignores the pupil's gifts is a fool, and she was exacting but never foolish. The *ba*, she said, was a small boat, and in its hold a single seed. "A seed *beneath.* You know the cumin seed. Put it in the boat." The *ta* was the same boat with two gulls above. "Two gulls." The *tha*: three cloves, set above like a crown. The *nun* was not a boat at all but a bowl, deep, with one fly floating on the top.

"Ba, a seed in the hold," said Youssef slowly, and made the stroke. The reed squeaked. The line wobbled and sat on the page like a drunk on a pavement. "Ta, two gulls. Tha—three cloves. Nun, a bowl, with one fly."

"The fly is above."

"The fly is *above*," said Youssef, "and may he drown."

She laughed. It was the first time he had heard it, and it was not the tin roof or the bell or the cascade of other people's laughter. It was a short, surprised sound, as of a bird that had not meant to sing. He wrote it down in his head with the other things he was keeping, alongside the smell of the ink and the lemon tree's light on the table, and he thought: *whatever else happens, I have this.*

They had many afternoons. He cried over the second week, not noisily; he wiped his eyes with the heel of his hand, and she looked at the window until he was done, and no one mentioned it. In the third week he confused

the *dal* and the *ra*, and she did not correct him; she drew a very small camel and a very small tree, and he fixed it himself.

On the fortieth day he read a word.

It was a short one. He did not read it with his eyes, as other children do. He read it with his hand: he felt the stroke before he saw it, the boat, the seed, the little gulls. It rose up out of the page as the first star rises out of the dark, a thing that had been there all along waiting for the lamps to go out.

"*Salma,*" read Youssef Benali.

"That is my name."

"It is on your door. I have walked past it for six weeks, and I did not know that it was *you.*"

"You have never read my door."

"I have read it now," said Youssef. "Now it is the only thing in Marrakech I can read."

She turned her face aside. The scarf had slipped, a little. She put it right.

"Come," said Salma. "You've earned a walk. The square is waking up."

They walked, in the long copper evening, through Jemaa el-Fna, where the snake-charmers were packing and the storytellers were beginning, each in his circle of listeners like a pebble in still water. A storyteller with a voice like an old drum was telling the story of a merchant who lost his ship and found his wife, and Youssef stood at the edge of the ring, as he had stood a thousand evenings, and listened with his whole body.

“You see?” said Salma softly. “There is more than one way to hold a story. The ears are very old. The eyes are only a *recent* arrival. My grandfather, who copied the Book in this hand sixty years, used to say that a letter well made is a courtesy to God and to the reader, but that the courtesy was first learned by those who *listened.* You are not behind, Youssef. You are *early.*”

He did not answer. He did not trust the honey in his voice. He had spent twenty years making it sweet and now it only wanted to be true.

At the end of the story the storyteller held out his cap, and Youssef dropped in a hundred-dirham note, and the old man looked at him, and said, “God make your page the colour of your heart.”

“Which colour is that?” asked Youssef.

“Ask your teacher,” said the old man, and winked.

That night, when the lane had gone to sleep and the jars stood in their rows like a congregation of small saints, Youssef sat alone at his stall under one bare bulb, with a reed, a pot of ink, and a sheet of cheap paper, and did what he had never done: he spoke to himself without a smile.

Twenty years I wore my silence as a coat And called it style. I sold the world its saffron And bought myself one thing: the fear of paper. It is a small thing, on a table, white, Which cannot hurt me. Yet I would have crossed The desert twice to dodge it. Here it lies. I have a seed, a boat, a bowl, a fly. I have a woman who will wait while I Make crooked

letters, and who does not laugh Except in the right places. Is that love? I will not say so. I will say: the ink Is warm. The line is wrong. I'll draw it twice.

He drew it twice. Then, because the *ba* has a seed beneath it, he drew the seed, and put the date under it, and the first line in his own hand that he had ever shown to nobody: a name, four letters long, with the dot where the dot belongs.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE IV

Mexico City. Coyoacán. A Saturday, eleven in the morning, and a church bell with no sense of time.

Half a world away, in a city where it was still the morning, a man in a black wedding suit was standing on a ladder with a brush.

This was not, strictly, how the programme had been planned.

"Rafael!" shouted Camila Reyes, from the foot of the ladder, in a white dress and fury. "You are *married!* You have been married for forty-five minutes! There is a *mariachi!*"

"I know," said Rafael Ortega, twenty-six, painter, romantic, who had once painted the same woman's face on a hundred and three walls without knowing her name. "I will be a minute."

"You said that at the altar."

"I *was* a minute at the altar."

“You were eleven. Father Anselmo timed you.”

For they had been wed at the church of San Juan Bautista at ten o’clock, in the old Coyoacán way: the *lazo*, a great looped rosary of white flowers laid round the shoulders of both in a figure eight, binding them to one another; the thirteen gold *arras* coins poured from his hands into hers, a promise to keep a house, which she received with a look that said she would be checking the accounts. Her mother, Paloma, a hairdresser who had been happy once and not noticed, had wept through the entire Mass and ruined four handkerchiefs and an uncle’s tie. Rafael’s father, Ignacio, retired vendor of anything, had wept into a tamale.

And now the whole party had spilled out into the lane behind the house, where an old wall of lime plaster, prepared that week by the stonemason Ximena Salazar, a woman of sixty-three with forearms like cables and the severity of an Inca queen, stood white and waiting.

“It is the hundred-and-fourth,” said Rafael, not coming down. “I could not marry you and leave you on a hundred and three walls like a lost umbrella. There has to be one that is *finished.*”

“You have painted me a hundred times!”

“I painted a *face.* An idea. The girl in the pictures is a stranger. She is kind and tall and she has never once lost her temper in court.”

“I lose my temper in court every day.”

“I know,” said Rafael. “I am going to paint *that.*”

He turned back to the wall. And the street, which had been squabbling and eating and tuning guitars, went quiet in the way crowds go quiet for a thing they have not been told to watch.

It was not the Camila of the hundred walls. It was the one who stood at the foot of the ladder in a white dress with her hair coming down: sharp-jawed, a little cross, one eyebrow raised in indictment, and in the crook of her arm a thick law book with a broken spine. She was laughing at somebody off the edge of the picture. Behind her he painted marigold petals in orange flame, the *cempasúchil* of the dead and of the living; and the thirteen coins like small suns; and, in the lower corner, very small, a street full of people who had come to a wedding and stayed to be remembered.

"Is that me?" said Officer Alejandro Hernández, forty-five, of the Coyoacán police, who had come to direct the traffic and had been standing at the edge of the mural for twenty minutes stroking his moustache.

"It is a policeman," said Rafael. "Anyone's."

"It has my moustache."

"All policemen have your moustache, Alejandro."

"I do not think that is *true,*" said Officer Hernández, deeply wounded, and went to look at his own reflection in the patrol car, saving money, as he often said, to disappear, and meanwhile appearing at every public occasion in the district.

Camila said nothing for a long time.

Then, in her wedding dress, in front of the whole of Coyoacán, she took the ladder in both hands and began to climb.

"What are you doing?" said Rafael.

"I walked to every wall," said Camila. "A hundred and three walls, in four years, in the heat, in my good shoes, to find the hand that painted me. I found him. And I have never once held the brush." She reached the top, took it from his fingers, and dipped it in black. "Move."

"What are you going to paint?"

"Your hand," she said.

And there, at the edge of the plaster, beside her painted self, a little crooked and a little too thick, with a lawyer's confidence and no training whatsoever, Camila Reyes painted the five long fingers of the man who had painted her: the left hand, the hand that held the brush, reaching up out of the corner of the wall as though to lift her down.

The mariachi, who had been waiting since the end of the Mass, took it as a cue.

"*¡Que vivan los novios!*" cried Ignacio Ortega, with tears running into his moustache.

"*¡Que vivan!*" shouted forty neighbours; and a nine-year-old flower girl named Renata Vargas, who had been told to scatter petals and had thrown them all at the policeman, threw the basket as well.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0439 and Entry 0502. Learning to read at thirty is not a defeat. It is a second birth, with the added advantage that one can already speak.

Entry 0299 and Entry 0121. Observe that a hundred walls could not do for them what one hour did: the day the painted woman climbed the ladder and took the brush.

Observe also: the heart is a very poor reader and a very good calligrapher. It spells nothing correctly, and yet is always understood.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 40.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 41: The Ship’s Log

“My captain wants me; so does the sea. You are third.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0991

✦ ✦ ✦

Enter the Chorus, in an oilskin, with a lantern, a compass and a very small violin.

A ship has but two mistresses: the shore She leaves, the sea she goes to. Let it be That one small heart, which neither’s, wants her more Than either, and is told to wait. For she Is owned by tides; he, by a harbour wall; And log-books keep what lovers cannot say. Here is the log. We read it, one and all, And mark the hour where each one lost the way.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE I

Split, Croatia. The Riva, the long stone promenade under the walls of Diocletian’s palace. The last evening of the month. A hot, heavy wind from the south, the jugo*, which makes the dogs bite and the philosophers weep.*

LOG OF THE M/V MARJAN, bulk carrier, Split. Entry in the hand of Ivan Horvat, deck rating.
1900. All stores aboard. Crew complete but for the

cook, who is late and is, he says, "not late, merely anticipated." Wind S, force 4, jugo. Barometer falling. Spirits: high. Heart: not recorded; the form has no column.

The Dalmatians have a word, *fjaka*, for the blessed state in which a man, on a warm afternoon, is neither working nor resting nor thinking, but simply *being,* as an olive is being on a branch. The jugo brings it. It lay over the Riva like a damp blanket, the palm trees stood in it motionless, and the old men on the benches argued about football, as men do who have been wrong together for sixty years.

Through it, at a rapid, determined pace, strode Marija Kovač, thirty, second officer of the *Sveti Duje*, in her blue shore-uniform and a face from which no emotion was permitted to escape without a pass.

"You are late," said Ivan Horvat.

"I am nine minutes early."

"For the *sea,*" said Ivan. "For me, a woman who is nine minutes early is nine minutes *late* in a better coat."

He was thirty-three, brown as a walnut, with a smile rubbed smooth by weather like a stone at the foot of a quay. He sat on the sea wall with his legs swinging, an enormous canvas bag at his feet, and a paper bag of fritule in his lap, and he held it out to her, and she took one, because refusing him anything was a thing she had never learned to do properly.

"Six months," said Ivan.

"One hundred and eighty-two days."

“I have counted too. I make it one hundred and eighty-*three*, with the leap of my heart.”

“You are not a mathematician.”

“I am a *deck rating,*” said Ivan, “which is the same thing with less pay.” He licked sugar off his thumb. “Marija. You said you had something to tell me. You said it four times this week. Each time you said it, you said it was nothing. A thing that is *nothing* does not need to be said four times.”

She looked out at the water. Beyond the harbour, low and violet in the haze, lay the island of Brač, steady as a lie.

“Captain Šimić,” she said, “has offered me a post.”

“The Captain wants you.”

“As chief officer. On the *Sveti Duje.* Twenty-four months. Rijeka, Suez, Busan, Shanghai, and back. There is no shore leave for the first year. The pay is—” she named it, and Ivan whistled. “I have until eight o’clock tomorrow morning to answer him.”

“Well,” said Ivan, “that is wonderful.”

“Yes.”

“That is *magnificent.* You will be the youngest chief officer in the Adriatic fleet.”

“I know.”

“Then why,” said Ivan, and he did not stop smiling, because he smiled as a ship keeps its lights on in a gale, “why are you looking at me like a woman reading out a sentence?”

“Because,” said Marija, “I wrote to an astronomer in England, three winters ago, and it was the only honest sentence I have ever written. It is in the Register. I will not tell you which number.”

“You do not have to.”

“I know. I am going to tell you, anyway, what it says.” She took a breath, as one takes a bearing. “*My captain wants me; so does the sea. You are third.*”

There was a very long silence. “Third,” said Ivan Horvat.

“I am sorry.”

“Third.” He turned the word over like a coin. “Do you know, Marija, that on a ship the third mate is the officer who stands the watch from midnight until four? When the Captain is in his bunk, and the chief is in his, and the sea is at her blackest and every other soul aboard has gone to sleep. It is the *third* who is awake. Who holds the ship. Who sees the dawn before any of them.” He grinned, wide, with an effort that cost him something. “I have always thought it the most honourable post afloat. I would be glad of it.”

“Ivan, that is not—”

“I will take the dog watch, then. Gladly. Somebody should be up.”

“I did not want you to be *glad.*”

“What did you want?”

She said, very low, “I wanted you to be angry. I wanted you to *ask me to stay.*”

“Ah,” said Ivan, and for once he did not smile. “That is the difficulty. If I ask you to stay, you will; and if you stay, you will be a woman who stayed. I knew a girl at school who never forgave a man for a thing he did not ask. I would rather be third than be the reason.”

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

The same night. A quay, a hundred paces down the harbour. A tall gangway, a large man, and a very large supper.

2130. Cook arrived. Reports he was “detained by destiny.” Destiny, on inquiry, turned out to be a barmaid in Kaštela. Wind backing SW, force 5. Visibility moderate. Cook says it is the first time in five years he has been seasick before sailing.**

The ship’s cook of the *Marjan* was a man called Luka Matić, fifty-five, from Zagreb, who had never in his life been outdone in vanity by anyone but his own moustache. He was a chef of great and terrible talent, once dismissed, he claimed, from a presidential luncheon for “being too delicious,” and had taken to the sea at fifty because “a man who will not be a legend on land must be one at sea, where no one can check.”

He stood now at the foot of the gangway with a stockpot in his arms, regarding the deck rating with a shrewd, meddling eye.

“You have *told* her.”

“I have said nothing, Luka.”

“You have said *nothing,* in the loud way. Nothing, with the shoulders.” He put down the pot. “There is a technique. You do not say ‘I love you.’ That is for the amateurs. You say, ‘I have made you a stew.’ You see? It means the same, and nobody can sue.”

“Luka. She has been offered the sea.”

“The sea!” Luka threw up his hands. “The sea is a *brute.* It will not remember her birthday. It has never once thanked me for a meal.” He lowered his voice; his hand, Ivan noticed, went briefly to his side, below the ribs, and came away again, in the quick way of a man brushing off a crumb. “The truth is, boy, that most people spend their whole lives choosing between two things they love, and the thing they *lose* is whichever they were too busy to hold. Do not stand there like a bollard. Go and *do* something.”

“What?”

“Something stupid!” said Luka. “That is the only kind of thing that has ever worked!”

He picked up the pot and went up the gangway, humming, a little unsteadily.

Ivan stood alone on the dark quay. Above him the *Marjan* creaked at her lines. Along the Riva, a klapa of six old men in white shirts had begun to sing in the close harmony of that coast, about a girl who waited by the sea. He listened. Then he walked to the waterfront bar, borrowed a pen, and did a stupid thing.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

Dawn. The Sveti Duje*, at her berth. A steel ship, a steel sky, and a steel-grey woman at the head of the gangway, with a piece of paper in each hand.*

> ***LOG OF THE M/V SVETI DUJE. Entry in the hand of M. Kovač, Second Officer.*** *0540. Wind NE, force 3, the bura arriving, cold and clean. The jugo has gone. Decision outstanding. 0610. Received, delivered by hand by a deckhand of another vessel, a small package, no name. Contents: a paper bag of fritule, now cold; and on the back of the paper bag, in pencil, a note.*

She had read it eleven times.

It said: *I did not ask you to stay. I am asking you, instead, to come back. It is the only question I know how to ask of a person who is going away. — I.*

And under it, smaller: *P.S. The third mate takes the watch you cannot. I will be awake.*

Marija did not weep; it was against regulations. But her chin did something it had never done on duty: it *trembled,* once, like the needle of an instrument finding north.

At 0745, Captain Vlaho Šimić came down the gangway, sixty-one, a large grey walrus of a man in a cap that had survived four ships and two marriages.

"Well, Kovač?" he said gruffly. "I will have your answer."

She looked at him. She looked at the sea beyond him, wide and cold and bright, and at the harbour mouth where, even now, a bulk carrier with a white funnel was

easing out under the shadow of Marjan hill, with a small figure at the stern, a long way off, who was too far to be seen and who she knew, without any evidence whatever, was waving.

“I will take the post, Captain.”

“Ha!” said the Captain, and clapped her on the shoulder so hard that she very nearly went into the harbour.

“For six months.”

“For *six* months?”

“For one rotation. At the end of it I will tell you if I stay.”

The Captain’s eyebrows climbed his forehead like two caterpillars discovering a leaf.

“Is it a man?”

“It is a rotation,” said Marija Kovač, with the flat, unarguable calm of an officer at the end of an argument. “That is the whole of the answer. And I will take the watch from midnight until four, whoever is on the roster.”

“That is the *third* mate’s watch.”

“Yes,” said Marija. “I know.”

He looked at her for a long time, and then, having been in love twice and wrong only once, he grunted and went up the gangway.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE IV

Cairo. A Thursday evening, under a sky the colour of a ripe apricot. The Khan el-Khalili, drums, lanterns, and a family trying to get through a door at once.

Elsewhere, where the Nile slides under the old bridges like a slow brown thought, a wedding was beginning.

I must be brief, reader, for it was a very long wedding. The *zaffa* began at six: drums, tambourines, a reed pipe that could weep and make you dance in the same bar, forty cousins with candles; and in front of them, in a cream-coloured jacket cut by a tailor who had not been paid and was only attending to see he would be, walked **Omar Haddad,** thirty-five, antiques dealer, and the finest liar in the whole of Egypt, looking like one who had, for the first time in his life, nothing to sell.

The *katb el-kitab,* the signing of the contract, was done in the courtyard of the bride's family house, beneath a trellis hung with jasmine. The officiant was a venerable sheikh with a beard like a cloud. The witnesses were Karim, a potter, built like a wardrobe and weeping like a fountain, and Tarek Hassan, a librarian of forty-one, who drank tea at every hour and had read too many contracts to trust any of them.

"Read the conditions," said the sheikh kindly.

Tarek unrolled the paper. Layla Mansour, thirty-two, the bride, in a gown of ivory silk, sat beneath her veil with a back as straight as an argument. For she was a restorer of antiquities, and an Egyptian bride may add her own conditions to the contract; this one had done it with the exactness of one cataloguing a tomb.

"*'The first,'*" read Tarek, with a quiver, "*'that the husband shall never sell the wife anything without a receipt.'*"

"*'The second: that if the husband should at any time describe an object as "genuine," he shall provide a certificate; and if there is none, he shall provide a confession.'*"

"Third," read Tarek, who had begun to enjoy himself and so had begun to sweat. "*'That the husband shall come home on time on Fridays; and that, should he be late, he shall say plainly that the clock was wrong, and not that he was detained by an Italian count.'*"

"That," said Omar, "was *one time.*"

"*'Fourth: that the bride was not deceived.'*" Tarek read slowly, and the courtyard fell still. "*'She knew it was false. She kept it because it was his.'*" He cleared his throat. His eyes had gone suddenly very bright. "I do not think," he said, "that I have read a contract before in which the *clauses* made me want to cry."

They proceeded. The bride said yes. The bridegroom said yes, a little louder than needed, as a man says yes who has had much practice saying no to himself. And the women in the courtyard let loose the *zaghareet,* that long, high, trembling trill of joy that goes up from the throat of Egypt like a flock of white birds, and for one long minute the whole of Cairo seemed to be ululating.

There were gifts. Omar's was a small clay lamp from the Fayoum, plain, chipped, entirely genuine, with a certificate of provenance signed by three experts and a customs officer.

“It is *real,*” said Omar. “I swear it on every receipt I ever lost.”

“I believe you,” said Layla.

“Truly?”

“I have tested it.” She smiled, behind the veil, for the first time. “Now. Mine.”

She gave him a flat package wrapped in a newspaper. He opened it. Inside, in a frame of plain wood, restored with infinite care to its own original imperfection, was the forgery, the little false scarab he had sold her six years ago and never confessed to, with a typed card beneath: **GENUINE FAKE. Circa six years ago. Provenance: the heart.**

Omar Haddad, who had once sold a pyramid to a Dutchman, stood for a long time with his mouth open, and said nothing at all.

At the back of the courtyard, among the aunts, a fourteen-year-old girl named Dina Shaker went very pink and very still. For she had told no one that it was she, one wet afternoon last year, who had posted a certain small, anonymous note through a certain shop door, and the thing had grown and grown, as these things will, until here it was, in jasmine, with drums.

“Why are you smiling like a cat in a dairy?” asked her aunt.

“It is the blush of the wicked,” said Tarek, passing with fresh tea. “A child who has done good in secret. I am a librarian. I know where the bodies are shelved.”

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE V

Naples. The Via dei Tribunali. A pizzeria older than the street's last three governments. A Saturday night, queue to the door, and a baker in a state.

A third wedding, you will say. It is not a wedding. It is the thing before: the question.

> ***Alessandro Greco*** *was thirty-three and had spent six years in a war with a pastry chef. It had involved a stolen recipe, a rigged contest, and one very memorable incident with a hundred kilos of flour and a Vespa.*

Now he stood in his own pizzeria, with a clean white apron, a hand that was not quite steady, and a calzone.

"A calzone," said Paolo Ricci, thirty, choir director, his oldest friend and his worst gossip, from the end of the counter. "You are going to propose with a *folded pizza.*"

"It is a *symbol.*"

"Of what?"

"A pizza," said Alessandro, "is open. A pizza is a thing that shows you everything. A *calzone* is a pizza that has closed its heart and is only waiting for the right person to cut it."

Paolo wiped an eye. "It is almost *sacred.* Shall I sing? I have composed an aria."

"Paolo, if you sing, I will bake you."

The door chimed. In came Chiara Esposito, thirty-one, pastry chef, with flour in her hair and a smile on her face that was not entirely trustworthy, because she had been told by seven separate people that she was needed urgently at the pizzeria and had worked out why by the fourth.

"You have summoned me," she said, "in front of everyone."

"I have not summoned you."

"Matteo Ricci told me there was a fire."

"He is a welder, he sees fire everywhere."

"Alessandro." She came up to the counter and looked at what lay on it: a golden half-moon, crimped at the edge, sleek with oil. "What is this?"

"I stole your recipe," said Alessandro, in a tremendous rush. "Six years ago. The one for the dough. I told myself it was *competition*. It was not competition. It was that it was the most beautiful thing I had ever read, in the most beautiful handwriting, and it said at the bottom, *for whoever finds this,* and I thought, *that is me,* and then I was too proud to say so. I made it every day. I have never once said sorry, and I am sorry. This is made from it. Cut it."

"Cut what?"

"The *calzone.*"

Chiara looked at him, and at the whole queue, which had stopped breathing.

"I wrote that recipe," she said slowly, "for you to find."

"I *know,*" said Alessandro. "I worked it out in the fourth year. I am slow. I am a pizzaiolo. We are a patient people."

"You are an *idiot.*"

"I am a *closed calzone,*" said Alessandro. "Cut me."

She took the knife. She cut it, and the steam rose, and out of the ricotta and the ham and the heat tumbled a small gold ring, which rolled across the marble and came to rest against her wrist, and stopped.

"Your dough," said Chiara, picking up the ring and wiping it on her apron, "is too thick."

"That is *not an answer.*"

"It is the beginning of one," said Chiara Esposito, and put the ring on her finger, and the whole of the Via dei Tribunali, which had heard nothing in the last four minutes but its own heart, burst into noise. Paolo Ricci began his aria, which was dreadful. Nobody stopped him. Alessandro, at last, was crying into a bowl of flour, and being kissed, once, on the forehead, by a woman who smelled of cinnamon and fury.

"*Ué, guagliò,*" breathed the lottery man, wiping his eyes. "Now *that* is a Saturday."

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE VI

Night, nine days on. The open Adriatic, far from any lit shore. Two ships, a mile apart, on opposite courses. The VHF radio on the bridge of the Sveti Duje*, in the dark.*

0140. Wind NW, force 4. Sea slight. The Marjan has just been raised on the radar, bearing 232, range 1.4 miles, steering a reciprocal course. 0141. I have not slept since Wednesday. 0142. Hailed her on Channel 16. For operational purposes only.

"*Marjan, Marjan, Marjan.* This is *Sveti Duje. Sveti Duje.* Over."

There was a crackle. The sea hissed along the hull. A long, very long, ten seconds went by, in which the whole Adriatic seemed to lean in.

"*Sveti Duje, Sveti Duje.* This is *Marjan.* Receiving you, strength five. Over." A pause. "Is that the *chief officer?*"

"It is the officer of the watch. Over."

"The *third* watch?"

"The third watch," said Marija, and her voice shook very slightly, and she cursed it. "Over."

"I am on watch also. Over."

"Understood. Over."

"It is a fine night. Over."

"Affirmative. Over."

Another long, hissing silence. On the *Marjan,* miles from anywhere, a deck rating who ought to have been asleep stood on the wing of a dark bridge with a radio in his hand and a cook breathing down his neck. "*Say it!*" whispered Luka, from the shadow of the funnel. "*Say anything stupid!*"

"*Sveti Duje.*" Ivan's voice was careful as a plank-walker's. "I have a message. Did you receive my paper bag? Over."

"Received. Over."

"Did you eat the fritule? Over."

"Negative. Over."

"Did you read the message? Over."

"Affirmative. Over."

"And?"

"Say again, *Marjan.* You did not say 'over.'"

"*And—over.*"

There was a very long silence. Marija Kovač stood alone in the glow of the radar, with the stars uncountable above her and a boy in a canvas coat a mile away across the dark. She lifted the handset.

"*Marjan,*" she said. "I have revised the order of priority."

"Say again?" said Ivan, hoarsely.

"Negative," said Marija. "I will say it in port. Over."

"Which port?"

"The first one," said Marija, "that either of us arrives at. Out."

The radio clicked. The two ships slid past one another in the dark, a mile apart, their running lights red and green like two small questions, and went each their way.

On the *Marjan,* a deck rating sat down very suddenly on a coil of rope.

On the *Sveti Duje,* a second officer wrote in her log, in her small, level hand, the one entry that for twelve years she had never made. It was a single line. It was not a position. It was not a bearing. It said:

0151. Course steady. Heart: recorded.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0603 and Entry 0991. A sea captain once told me that the best navigators are not those who know where they are going but those who know, to the minute, where they have been. Mark the hour. It will be asked for.
Entry 0353 and Entry 0486. A closed calzone is, in my experience, a very sound proposal. Open ones tend to cool.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 41.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 42: The Throat-Singer’s Winter

“I leave for Europe in spring. I have not told the horses.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0551

✦ ✦ ✦

Enter the Chorus, in a fur hat, breathing smoke.

Beneath the Sky that has no roof but Blue, Where winter shuts the grass beneath its glass, A man must choose what horse to save; and who Must choose between the hoofbeat and the pass. Draw close the felt. Put on the stove its dung. The tea is salt. The night is forty cold. And here a woman, with two notes, one tongue, Prepares to sing a story yet untold.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE I

Ulaanbaatar. A concert hall behind the Square, in the last week of the Month of the Tiger, or the Rabbit, or whichever animal the weather had decided to be. A rehearsal. The radiators are working, which is a miracle, and the miracle is being resented.

In a land where a person may live a lifetime without seeing a ferry, it is a matter of some wonder to find a woman who works as a ferry hand.

Munkhzul Bold, twenty-five, of Erdenet, was exactly this. In the summers she worked the little white boat that crossed Lake Khövsgöl with tourists in life jackets. In the winters the lake froze to a depth of four feet, the boat was put up on blocks like an old bull, and Munkhzul, having nothing to ferry, found herself ferrying everything else: instruments, rumours, other people's lunch, the long grievances of the Eternal Blue Sky Ensemble, whose assistant, driver, porter, tea-maker and general bearer of burdens she had become by a process nobody could reconstruct.

She had wanted to be a singer. She could sing exactly one note. It was an A, it could strip paint, and she held it every morning in the shower to the despair of the building.

"Oyun-*egch,*" she said now, lugging a horsehead fiddle in its felt case across the stage, "the Europe men have phoned. Again. They want the shoe sizes."

"Shoe sizes?"

"For the *costumes.* For the *photographs.* They say it is a *concept.*" She dumped the case on a chair. "Do you know what a concept is? It is when a European wants to see your feet before he hears your voice."

"Munkhzul."

"I am merely observing." She sniffed. "Twelve cities. Utrecht, Lyon, Ljubljana. I looked them up. They have fountains. A person can stand and *watch* water run for

no reason. It is called ‘cultural heritage.’ Here we call it a leak.”

At the centre of the stage a young woman sat with her eyes closed.

Oyun Dorj was twenty-seven, and she looked like her own instrument: long, dark, a little weathered, with a deep stillness in the neck. She was the finest *khöömei* singer of her generation. She could do what the old herders call the *impossible* and the physicists call the *harmonic*: sing two notes at once, one drone from the floor of the belly, low as a quarry blasted in the next valley, and over it, impossibly, a high clear whistle, thin as a spider’s thread, which the old people say is the voice of the wind itself, borrowed for the occasion.

She opened her eyes.

“Munkhzul. How many days till the plane?”

“Seventy-one.”

“And how far is it to the Munkh camp, in Töv?”

“One day, in a jeep, in this weather. Two if Batmunkh drives.” Munkhzul narrowed her eyes. “Why? Oh. *Oh.* You have not told him.”

“I have not told the horses.”

“Oyun, horses do not *read* the Register.”

“No.” Oyun’s voice was very level. “They read the throat. If I go to them with Europe in my chest, they will hear it before I have drawn breath. They hear all of it. A horse is a very honest critic.”

“Then sing something else.”

"You cannot sing *something else* to an animal that can hear you thinking."

Munkhzul considered this, a rare gravity settling on her round face, and then said what is said by every fool of every age at the one moment when it is least expected:

"A horse does not need to be told that a person is leaving. It only needs to be told that the person is *coming back.* The first it can work out. The second it cannot. So tell it that, and be sure it is true."

She picked up the fiddle again and carried it away, humming her A.

Oyun sat quite still for a long time, and then she took out her phone and ordered a seat on the morning jeep.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

Töv province. A white valley. Forty below by the thermometer on the jeep, which had been broken since November and gave this figure only to be polite.

The winter had begun, as these winters do, with a lie.

It was a mild October. It was a mild November. In the first weeks of December the herders of the steppe began to say, *It will be a good year,* and by the end of that month the snow had come, and thawed a little, and frozen again, in a crust as thick and hard as iron, so that the grass lay under it like a drowned thing under a lake. The horses, who can paw through snow but not through

ice, stood in the white field and starved, with the whole green summer buried one hand's breadth beneath their hooves.

They call it *dzud.* It is the old word for the winter that kills. It had taken from the Munkh family alone two hundred and seventy horses of three hundred and forty.

Oyun saw the first carcass from the road. It lay in the snow twenty paces off, a bay mare, quite whole, frozen into the posture of a gallop, with her neck outstretched and her legs flung wide. It looked as though she had been running toward something so hard that the cold had decided to let her keep it.

"Do not look," said the driver, Batmunkh.

"I will look," said Oyun. "Someone must."

There were fourteen more before the ger.

Baatar Munkh was standing in the yard, in a heavy *deel* of faded blue, with his hands behind him and a face like a closed door in a good house. He was twenty-nine. He was a horse trainer, as his father and grandfather had been, with the best racing colts in the province, and a patient manner with animals and a very impatient one, so far, with himself. He saw the jeep and did not move. He did not run toward what he had trained himself, for three winters, not to need.

"Oyun," he said.

"Baatar."

"You have come a long way."

"It is a short way," she said, "when one knows where it ends."

He blushed. She saw it, even in that light, even under the beaten bronze of his cheeks, and she thought, with that clear mystical directness which had made her at once famous and unmarried: *There it is. The thing the horses will hear.*

“Come in,” said Baatar. “Mother is boiling milk. Father is praying. It is the same thing, in this house, in a winter like this.”

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

The ger. Felt walls, a painted ring of roof-poles, the stove glowing with the dried-dung fire that makes the whole of Mongolia smell, to a native, like home. In the north, the family altar: a photograph of a lama, a small brass lamp, a dried white cheese on a dish. The old man by the door, turning a prayer wheel with fierce, steady devotion.

They gave her tea, salted and milky, in a bowl so large she held it with two hands, and dried curds hard as bone, and a bowl of mutton broth that tasted of smoke and thyme and the far side of the world. Old Erdene Munkh blessed her in the old way, with a small, solemn bow, and, being seventy-three and the sort of man who has stopped being shy because it saves time, said, “You have come to take my son’s heart to Europe.”

“Father,” said Baatar.

“I merely observe. She is a singer. A singer takes the heart and gives back the music. I have heard the music. It is a fair exchange.”

“Father.”

“I will go and feed the sheep,” said Erdene, with great dignity, and did, though the sheep had been fed an hour ago and were eating in the manner of beasts who had learned the habits of the very poor.

They sat alone in the warm. The wind sang through the roof-ring on one long ghostly note, a perfect fifth, and Oyun, who could not help hearing it, listened to it for a while.

“Seventy horses left,” said Baatar quietly. “Perhaps sixty by the thaw. I had a colt who would have won at Naadam this summer. A dark bay. I called him Night. He died last week, in my arms. I took him into this ger and kept him by the stove, and he lay down on the felt, and —” He stopped. “It does not matter.”

“It matters.”

“I am a horse trainer with no horses.” His mouth did a small, bitter, ruined thing. “A poor man. Poorer by spring. I have a ger, a name, and a rope. That is what I have. And you have Utrecht.”

“I have a *plane.*”

“It is the same thing.”

“Baatar—”

“I have read your letter in the Register,” said Baatar, to the stove. “I did not mean to. A friend sent it. *I leave for Europe in spring. I have not told the horses.*” He lifted his head. “I wrote one too. Do you know what it said?”

“I know,” said Oyun.

“You read it.”

“I read it the night they published. Number one hundred and thirty-nine. *Our herd is dying; I cannot ask you to stay.*” She set down the bowl. “That is a very stupid sentence, Baatar.”

“I thought it a very honourable one.”

“It is the same thing,” said Oyun Dorj, “and I would rather you were stupid at me than honourable at a distance.”

For the first time that night, he laughed: a short startled sound, the sound of a man to whom it had not occurred that the weather might change inside the house.

“Sing for me,” he said. “Before the horses. Before the winter takes any more. I would like to hear it in this room, where it is warm, and where—” he glanced at the altar—“where there is someone to hear it who has been listening a long time.”

So she sang.

She sang low first, the drone, that great dark shaping thing from the floor of the body, the sound of a mountain breathing. And out of it, as a star comes out of the black, rose the second voice, a thin bright whistle, unbelievably pure, which wandered high and came down and rose again, like a bird making up its mind about the sky. The old man at the door stopped turning his prayer wheel. The stove ticked. In the roof-ring the wind, which had been playing a fifth all night, was quite suddenly *silent,* as one stops talking when a better speaker comes in.

Then she sang words, in the old tongue, and I give them here as best the language can be given, which is badly:

Over the world is the Blue that has no end, And over the Blue, a golden peg is driven, And to the peg the whole bright sky is tied, The seven elders, and the herds of stars, Wheeling for ever round their one fixed post, As colts around the post their master set. And I am but a colt upon that line, And what I wander from I wander toward. The rope is long. It is not made to break. It only means: go far, and come to the post.

When she stopped, nobody spoke. It was Erdene who broke it, from the doorway, in a thick voice.

“The Golden Peg,” he said. “The North Star. Every child in this country knows it. All the stars go round it, and it does not move.” He wiped his eyes with his sleeve. “A man could do worse, my son, than to be a peg.”

“I am a peg,” said Baatar hoarsely. “I am the one that cannot go.”

“No,” said Oyun. “You are the one to whom it is *tied.*”

The two of them looked at one another across the stove. A log fell. Somewhere in the dark yard a horse coughed, and another answered.

“Come,” said Baatar, rising. “Come and meet the herd, before the night closes. They should know your voice. It will be, in their ears, the most beautiful thing of the winter.”

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE IV

The horse line. Midnight, or near it. No moon: a new moon, the dark of it, which is the time of the year when the sky shows what is truly there. The stars, enormous, close, colder than a blade. Snow squeaks under the boot like a mouse.

Mark this, reader: breathe gently. We are going quietly.

They stood at the long rope where the weakest of the animals were tethered close to the ger: thirty horses, in the starlight, shaggy and gaunt, their breath rising in plumes that hung in the cold like questions nobody has dared to answer. At the end of the line, loose, because he would not stay tied, stood the herd's old stallion, a grey with a white blaze and eyes like polished obsidian, whom Baatar had trained himself and who had never in nine years allowed any other human to touch him.

"That is Altai," said Baatar. "He leads them. If he is quiet, they are quiet."

Oyun walked up to him in the snow, unhurried. She did not hold out a hand. She stood a pace off, and breathed with him, long and slow, until their breath was one cloud.

Then she began to sing.

It was not a song for a concert hall. It was the oldest kind, the kind a woman sings to a mare who will not take her foal: low, nearly without words, a long, warm, patient drone with a very thin thread of whistle above it.

The horses lifted their heads. One by one, along the whole line, thirty great dark shapes grew still and attentive, like a congregation recognising the hymn.

She sang to them of the pasture under the ice. She sang of the thaw. She sang that the grass was only sleeping and that there were roads under the snow, and that a person might go away and come back, as the stars go round the peg, and that nobody here was being abandoned.

Altai stepped forward and laid his great head against her shoulder.

Baatar stood in the snow with his hat in his hands. He had stopped feeling the cold. It may have been the only time in his life, he thought, that he had seen a thing and been entirely unafraid of it.

"Oyun," he said, when the song ended, and she turned. "Listen. Whatever the horses do. Whatever comes. I did not ask you to stay, because I am a poor man with a dying herd and nothing to offer you but a rope and a name; and because the sky is wide and you are a voice that belongs to all of it, and I would not shut it in a ger. But I want you to know, before the spring, before the plane, before any of it, that if you asked me whether I would follow you down every one of those twelve cities, to every fountain and every concert hall and every cold hotel room in Europe, I would—"

Behind them, up on the ridge, something moved.

It was not the wind. The wind had gone still hours ago. It was a long low dark shape against the stars, and then another, and then a sound came down the valley

that every herder knows in his bones before his ears have named it: a high, thin, trembling note, like the whistle of her own voice turned inside out.

The old grey stallion lifted his head from her shoulder. His ears went flat.

“Wolves,” said Baatar, very softly. “The iron winter brings them down.”

The grey mare at the head of the line screamed.

It was a sound he had heard only twice in his life, and both times he had afterwards wished he were deaf. The thirty on the rope threw up their heads together and, like one animal with thirty throats, hauled back against the line; and the line, old and frozen and strained by a winter’s tugging, snapped with a crack like a plucked string; and from the dark below the ridge the whole great herd, the sixty, the seventy, the last of the Munkh horses that had stood in the snow of the open valley all winter, came sweeping down toward them out of the night in a long dark river of hooves and steam and flying manes, and behind the ger the door burst open and the lamplight fell out across the snow in a yellow tongue, and in it the horses poured past, so close that Oyun could feel the heat of them on her face; and Altai gathered under her hand like a wave drawing back before it breaks; and Baatar caught her wrist and shouted her name, and she turned, and he said, in a voice that she could barely hear over the thunder of the herd:

“Oyun, I have been trying to say it since the autumn, and if the horses go, and if I never see them again, and if you go, and if—I would sell the last of them, and the ger,

and the saddle off my own back, and my father's lamp, and I would walk behind you to Utrecht on my own two feet, if you would only let me tell you that I—"

Here the page is torn.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE V

Ulaanbaatar. The concert hall behind the Square. Six days later. The radiators working, the miracle unresented, for there was nobody to resent it.

I will not tell you what became of them. I do not know. Do not look at me so, reader. I have turned over every page I own.

I can tell you only what the hall looked like on the Thursday after.

The rehearsal room was empty. Twelve folding chairs stood in a ring round the stage, and a horsehead fiddle lay in its felt case where somebody had set it down, and on the central chair sat Munkhzul Bold, in her padded coat, with a thermos of tea gone cold at her feet and her telephone in both hands. It had not rung for six days. She looked at it as one looks at a sleeping animal that one has been told not to wake.

The ensemble's manager came in, grey with worry, and said what he had said every morning since Friday.

"Anything?"

"No."

“The radio says there were wolves in Töv. A great stampede. Three herds lost.”

“I know.”

“The jeep has not been heard from.”

“I *know,* Mr. Ganbold.”

“What shall we tell the Europeans?”

Munkhzul looked up from the telephone. She looked at the chairs. She looked at the fiddle. She was twenty-five, she could sing one note, she was a ferry hand in a country with no sea, and her round face, in that moment, had the terrible untroubled clarity of the simple.

“Tell them,” she said, “the horses know the way home. It is only people who need roads.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the only one in this building.” She stood up, and put the telephone in her pocket, and picked up the fiddle, and held it, for a moment, against her chest, like a child. “I will go to Töv in the morning. I am used to carrying things. Somebody should carry *this.*”

She went to the window. Outside the Square lay white and still under a sky the colour of old iron, and in the north, hidden by day but never absent, the Golden Peg held the whole turning sky on its long rope, as it had for ten thousand winters, and did not tell.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0139 and Entry 0551. They wrote to me on the same night, in the same winter, neither knowing the other had written. I answered neither. I do not know how it ended. I have not asked. I have found, in my years of keeping, that there are pages one is not meant to read to the end; one is meant to carry them.

Be gentle with the ones that break. They are not the ones that failed. They are the ones that were told the truth at the very moment the world began to move.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 42.

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Chapter 43: The Widow’s Classroom

“I sell maize and I sell nothing of what I feel.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0662

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SCENE I

Lusaka, Zambia. Soweto Market, seven in the morning, in the cold dry season, when the city wears a blanket of woodsmoke and the sun comes up the colour of a ripe mango.

Enter the Chorus, in a chitenge wrap, with a basket on its head.

Two cities in this chapter: one that drowns, One that is dry and dusty and awake. In one a woman sells her golden grain; In one a girl is told to stop, and stops. We shall not tell you which was kinder. Both Were hard, and both were holy. Both are ours.

The cold season in Lusaka has a sharpness at dawn that sends the whole market to the charcoal braziers, and at seven in the morning the great Soweto Market, bigger than some towns and a good deal louder, was a smoking maze of tarpaulin, tomatoes, secondhand shoes and shouting.

Grace Banda's stall stood in the third row from the east gate, between a man who sold blankets and a woman who sold buns.

It was a good stall. It had a painted sign, in blue letters going a little pale: **BANDA & WIFE — MAIZE, GROUNDNUTS, KAPENTA.** Three years ago the *Banda* had died, of a short sickness and a long hospital, and the *Wife* had kept the sign exactly as it was, for the reason that nobody could have said what else to put. She was thirty-five. She had a laugh like a drawer of coins being gently shut, a daughter named Chilufya, aged eight, who did her homework on a crate under the table, and a way of weighing out white maize in a battered tin cup so exactly that the whole row said she could weigh a man's soul in it.

She could sell anything to anyone. What she could not do was add.

That is, she could add to ten. She could count a tin of maize, and a coin, and a coin back. But the *books*, the figures of what came in and went out, who owed and who had paid, which her husband had kept in a green school exercise book, had gone into a drawer on the day of the funeral and never been opened. The stall had run three years on memory and goodwill, which are fine currencies until somebody asks for a receipt.

"*Muli bwanji, Mama Chilufya?*" said a man's voice.

"*Ndili bwino. Kaya inu, Ba Teacher?*"

"*Bwino, zikomo.*"

He came every Saturday. He was tall and narrow, in a pressed white shirt and a grey cardigan with a darned elbow, and he held the hand of a girl of ten and the hand of a boy of seven, one in each of his, as a man holds a pair of kites. This was Joseph Tembo, thirty-eight, schoolmaster of the Chilenje Community School, widower these four years. He was solemn, kind and courteous, and his pupils said he could silence a classroom by lifting an eyebrow and then make every child feel it had been their own idea.

“Three cobs, Mama,” he said, in the Nyanja of the capital, which is the Nyanja of people who mean to be polite to everyone. “Roasted. And one for yourself.”

“I do not need one for myself.”

“It is the custom of the stall. The vendor must eat.”

“That is not the custom of any stall, Ba Teacher.”

“It is the custom,” said Joseph gravely, “of *this one,* on Saturdays, by my own regulation.”

She roasted the cobs on the brazier, turning them with long tongs, until the kernels split and blistered brown and the whole row smelled of summer. She gave him the sweetest, chosen by her own thumb, and charged him the right price; and he paid, as he always did, with a note that was a little too large, and she gave him his change, as she always did, which was exactly right. And they both stood a moment with the small silent trouble of two honest people who have each spent a year being scrupulous for the other’s benefit.

“Mutale,” said Grace to the girl, “you are tall.”

“I am ten, Mama Chilufya.”

“It is a very good age for being tall.”

“Kondwani lost a tooth.”

“He lost it *on purpose,*” said the boy, very grandly, and opened his mouth to show a gap like a small dark doorway.

Grace laughed, and Joseph looked at the cob in his hand as though it were a very difficult piece of arithmetic.

“Oh, ho, ho!” came a voice from the next stall, enormous, rich, and well-upholstered. “Look at the pair of them! A schoolmaster and a maize-seller. It is a very *Biblical* match. Man of letters and woman of the field. I have said it from the first.”

“Loveness,” said Grace.

“I am *merely* observing.”

Loveness Zulu, thirty-eight, baker and proprietor of *Loveness’s Heavenly Buns,* had such dazzling vanity and such tremendous warmth that the market had ceased to tell them apart. Her wig that week was a startling auburn; the week before it had been platinum, and the week before that a short severe black bob, “in mourning for my last hairdresser.” She could not say goodbye, which was the market’s chief entertainment. A conversation with Loveness began at seven and might be concluded, by the grace of God and the intervention of customers, at nine.

“I must go,” she told Joseph now, and did not go. “Ba Teacher, a word from a woman who has seen more weddings than the Bishop. A man who buys three cobs and says he is buying them for his children is buying *four.* I know the sums. Goodbye. I am going. Mama Chilufya, he is a good man, I have *checked. Goodbye*—”

“Loveness,” said Grace.

“I am gone.”

“You are *still* here.”

“That,” said Loveness, with immense pride, “is because I have a very big heart, and it does not fit through the door.” She swept off, in a wave of perfume and flour and auburn nylon, bellowing farewells at the next three stalls.

Joseph Tembo looked at the cob again. He did not say what he had meant to say. He had said nothing for a whole year, with the same grave good manners, and the list of things unsaid had grown very long.

“Mama Chilufya,” he said at last.

“Yes, Ba Teacher.”

“I teach a class, on Tuesday evenings. For adults. Reading, writing, and—” He paused. “Bookkeeping. The simple kind. For market people. There is no charge.”

She looked at him. Grace wondered, for a moment, whether she was being offered a kindness or a pity. She decided, because he had said it as a *fact* and not a *favour,* that it was a fact.

“Who told you,” said Grace, slowly, “that I could not add?”

“No one,” said Joseph. “I saw your sign. It says *Banda and Wife.* It does not say *and Ledger.*”

“That,” said Grace Banda, after a moment, “is the cruellest sentence I have ever heard, and it is also correct.”

“Tuesday,” said Joseph. “Six o’clock. Bring a pencil.”

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

Manila. A narrow lane in Tondo, five nights after a typhoon. The water has gone down, but it has left a brown line on every wall at the height of a child’s chin. A wake.

Now across the world, to a house where nobody was speaking of arithmetic.

In the Philippines a death is not an event but a *season.* The body is not taken quickly. It is kept at home, in a white coffin with a glass lid, for five nights, seven, nine, while neighbours and cousins and strangers come and sit, and drink coffee out of paper cups, and play cards at folding tables in the lane all night, loudly, so that the family will not be alone with the silence. It is called the *lamay.*

The house was in a lane too narrow for a car. And yet there stood, in the lane, in the dark, with its lights off and a white sheet drawn over its nose, a jeepney.

Gabriel Santos had bought it at twenty-two, with a bank loan and his mother’s earrings, and painted it from bumper to bumper in the colours of a carnival: red, yellow, a green parrot on the hood, a silver horse on each fender, a hundred small mirrors, and, in a sacred row

above the windscreen, a number of pious slogans, as is the custom. *GOD IS GOOD. BLESS THIS RIDE. SAFE TRAVELS.*

Gabriel had been the cheerfullest driver in Tondo, and had never been seen without a hat, a joke, and a coin of change for the child who had lost hers. In the night of the typhoon, when the water came up the lanes like a brown tide and the whole neighbourhood stood on its roofs, he had driven his jeepney into the flood and made seven trips: forty-one neighbours, two goats, an old woman and her sewing machine. On the eighth, at the bridge, the current had taken the jeepney by the nose and turned it, gently, like a hand turning a page.

They had found the jeepney on the second day, in the creek. They had found Gabriel on the third.

Nakikiramay po, the neighbours said at the door, one after another, the old phrase: *We share your grief.* They said it to his mother, a small, silent woman with a white scarf; to his father, who sat in a corner with his hat in his lap; to his cousins, his friends, a hundred drivers who had come in white shirts, with their jeepneys, from every route in the city.

And they said it, softly, to a girl of twenty-six at the back of the room, who had not cried, who had come in the night straight from work with her headset still hanging around her neck, who stood with her back against the wall as though it were the only thing holding up the roof.

Maricel Dela Cruz was a call-centre agent. She spoke for six hours a night, in a bright clear American-adjacent voice, to strangers in Ohio and Perth and Leeds, about

their phones and their insurance and their lost parcels. For those six hours she was **Maggie,** a name the company gave her, and she was never tired or afraid or sad. Every night at four in the morning she took off her headset and went home in a jeepney, and the jeepney was always *his.*

He had never charged her. She had never said that she knew.

"You must eat something," said a voice.

It was Joy Aquino, fifty-six, retired librarian, who had run the Tondo branch of the public library for thirty years and had taken on, for the duration of the wake, the management of all the grief in the lane. She had a clipboard and a rota, and a list of those to be told firmly to stop singing "My Way."

"I am not hungry, Ma'am."

"Of course you aren't. Eat anyway." She put a cup of coffee in Maricel's hands and a *pandesal* in her pocket. "I have a rule at the library, child. In a library you are quiet, because people are reading, and their reading is sacred. But in a *wake* you are not quiet. The dead like noise. They have the rest of time for silence."

"I do not know what to say, Ma'am."

"Then say nothing, and say it where people can see you. That is all a wake is." And she swept off toward the card table, where a very old woman was cheating at *tong-its* with an honesty so complete that nobody had the heart to stop her.

At midnight, Gabriel's best friend, a big shambling farmer from Cebu named Ariel Reyes, who had come up on the morning boat in his only suit, stood in the doorway and cleared his throat.

"Maricel," he said. "There is a thing."

"What thing?"

"He did not want you to see it until it was finished." Ariel's voice cracked. "He painted it last month. He said it was the best thing he had ever done. He said he would show you in the spring. He kept it under the sheet."

They went out into the lane. The whole wake came with them, a slow silent crowd, until the little street was full from wall to wall. Ariel took hold of the white sheet over the jeepney's nose, and pulled.

Above the windscreen of the jeepney, in a row of small gold letters, in a hand that was clearly Gabriel's, not a professional painter's, a little crooked and a little too large, were the words:

PARA KAY MARICEL.

In Tagalog, *para* has two meanings. It means *for*. And it means *stop.* A jeepney driver hears it a thousand times a day, when some passenger raps on the roof with a coin and cries *Para po!*, "Stop, please," and the driver brakes and lets the stranger down at the corner of her life.

For Maricel. Stop, Maricel.

Nobody said a word.

Then Maricel, who had not cried in five days, put her hand over her mouth, and made a sound that was not any sound she had ever used in her six hours of calls,

and went down on her knees in the wet lane; and a hundred drivers in white shirts, who knew exactly what that word meant, took off their caps.

They buried him on the ninth day, in the afternoon, under an enormous grey sky. The hearse went first. Behind it, in a line a mile long, honking one long note, forty jeepneys followed in their carnival colours. And in the front seat of the last, with a farmer from Cebu at the wheel, a girl in a white blouse sat with her hands in her lap, in the seat that had been kept.

At the cemetery they passed the flower down the line, hand to hand to hand, a white chrysanthemum, in the old jeepney fashion: *Pakiabot po,* each one said to the next. *Kindly pass this forward.* It went from the farthest to the nearest, from stranger to stranger to friend, until it reached the coffin, and Maricel laid it there.

"*Pakiabot po,*" she said, to nobody. Her voice broke on the second word. "Kindly—pass it—"

"It has been passed," said Joy Aquino, softly, behind her. "It has reached him, child. That is the whole of the law."

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

Lusaka. The Chilenje Community School. A Tuesday evening, six o'clock, the sky already dark. Load-shedding: the power gone, the lake behind Kariba Dam being low. A paraffin lamp, six candles, a blackboard glimmering with chalk.

There were nine pupils in the Tuesday class: a bus conductor, two market women, a retired railway clerk who wished to write his memoirs, a youth who wished to sell phones, and **Grace Banda,** at the back, in a school desk made for a child of twelve, with her knees nearly to her chin and a stub of pencil gripped like a trowel.

"Debit," said Joseph Tembo, in the candle's glow, "is what comes in. Credit is what goes out. Or the other way round. It does not matter, so long as you are *consistent.* At the bottom of the page is a line, and under the line a number, and the two columns must *agree.*"

"And if they do not?" said the bus conductor.

"Then somebody has been telling a lie," said Joseph. "Usually the person holding the pencil."

Grace did not laugh. She was looking at the chalked columns with terrible concentration. She had been afraid of this thing for three years, and tonight she had decided that it was only a *shape.*

"They must always agree?" she said.

"In bookkeeping, yes."

"In my life," said Grace Banda, "they have never once agreed."

Half the class thought it a joke. Joseph did not. He stood a moment with the chalk, and then said, very gently, "That is why we draw the line at the bottom, Mama Chilufya. Not to *make* them agree. To show how much they differ. So that you may see exactly what is owed, and by whom, and what is left."

“And what is left,” said the old railway clerk, “is called the *balance.*”

“No,” said Joseph. “It is called the *remainder*. The balance is only a word we use when we are being polite.”

It was an hour before they finished. At the door, in the dark, among the departing chitenge and torches, he put a small exercise book into her hands.

“What is this, Ba Teacher?”

“Your ledger,” said Joseph. “It is blank. I have ruled the columns. Those are things a stranger might do.” He looked at his own shoes. “The first line is for you.”

She opened it. In the glow of a borrowed torch, on the first line, in his small clear schoolmaster’s hand, he had written one word: *Grace.* And beside it, in the debit column, nothing. And in the credit column, nothing.

“Both columns are empty,” said Grace.

“They are *yours,*” said Joseph. “You will fill them. I did not like to presume what is owed.”

She did not answer. She held the ledger against her chest, as one holds a thing that might otherwise blow away, and went home through the dark, past the shuttered shops and the glowing braziers, saying to herself, quite silently, all the way: *Debit. Credit. Balance. Remainder.*

And at a kitchen table four streets away, by one stub of a candle and the great noise of the Lusaka night, a widowed schoolmaster marked forty exercise books and, without noticing, began to think in verse.

I marked a hundred pages, and my hand Went stubborn at the margin of the ninety-first. A woman wrote, in letters like a child's, The sum of two plus two, and made it five, And I could not correct it. Let it stand. Four years I've kept a house of silences, A tidy house, with two small kites to fly. I thought the ledger of my heart was closed: That what was owed had long ago been paid. But here a woman, awkward at a desk, Has opened me by adding up a column. I do not know what I would say to her. I know that in the morning I shall go And buy three cobs, and not know what to do With my own hands, which hold three cobs, and four.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE IV

A night, a week later. An office in Manila where six hundred headsets glow in rows. Four in the morning, local time. A girl at a desk, on her break, with a cold coffee and a phone.

It was Joy Aquino who had told her. "There is an answer," she had said, on the telephone, in her library voice. "Someone has replied to your Register letter, child. They have posted it publicly. I thought you ought to see it, and not alone."

So Maricel sat, in a break room that smelled of microwave noodles and carpet cleaner, in the small hour of the morning in which she had always been strangest, and read.

To Entry 0045 — from Lusaka, Zambia.

Dear Maricel,

I do not know you. I am a woman who sells maize in a market. I have read what you wrote, that you speak six hours a night to strangers and never to the one you wished to. I do not know how it ended. A friend told me it ended with water.

I am a widow. Three years now. I sell maize, and I sell nothing of what I feel, and I cannot tell you that it gets better, because I do not know that this is true. What I can tell you is what I have learned this month, from a man who teaches me to add. It is that there is a line at the bottom of every page, and under it, a number, which is called the remainder.

You are the remainder, Maricel. That is not a small thing. It is the only thing the page is for.

Your six hours are not wasted. Every stranger who rang you was held, for those few minutes, by somebody kind.

Say what you cannot say. Say it to the page. Say it to the water.

— Grace Banda, Soweto Market, third row from the east gate.

She read it twice. She did not cry; she had cried herself dry at the cemetery. She sat for a long while, with her coffee going colder in her hand, and then the little light on her desk, which meant a call, began to blink.

She put on her headset. She drew a breath, and found her bright, clear, practised voice, the voice of a woman called Maggie, and then, somewhat to her own surprise, set it down, as one sets down a heavy bag in a hallway, and spoke instead in her own.

“Thank you for calling,” said Maricel Dela Cruz. “My name is Maricel. I am sorry. I am a little—I have had a hard month. How may I help you?”

There was a silence on the line, from the other side of the world: a man in a kitchen in Ohio, where it was a quiet afternoon, with a broken phone and a bad week. Then the man, gently and a little uncertainly, said:

“Take your time, miss. I’ve got all afternoon.”

Para, thought Maricel, with her whole body, and for the first time in a week it was a word that meant *rest.*

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0133 and Entry 0662. A column of figures that will not balance is not a failure of mathematics. It is merely a heart, in ruled lines.
Entry 0874 and Entry 0045. The dead are carried by the living in a long, slow, forward-passing of small white flowers. The first is not the one who carries it furthest. The last is. Honour the last.
Be quiet when the quiet are reading. Be loud when the loud have nowhere left to go.

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End of Chapter 43.

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Chapter 44: Lanterns of Hoi An

“I am ill and I do not want to be pitied.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0469

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SCENE I

Hoi An, Vietnam. The Old Town on the night of the full moon, when the electric lights are switched off by custom and the whole town is lit by candles in paper and silk. A river the colour of dark tea.

Enter the Chorus, carrying a lantern a little away from its body, as one holds a very small sun.

Two nights the story keeps: one lit, one dark. Be tender with the first. It will not last.

In Hoi An, on the fourteenth night of the moon, the town forgets that it has electricity.

The yellow walls turn amber. The old merchants’ houses, which have leaned over that river four hundred years, lean their carved shutters toward the water as if to hear. Lanterns hang by hundreds over the lanes, red and gold and jade, silk stretched on bamboo; and on the Thu Bon, little paper boats go drifting by the thousand, each with a candle and a wish, so that the whole black stream seems to carry a second sky downhill to the sea.

In a workshop on a side lane, behind a turquoise door, a young woman sat cross-legged on a mat, stitching.

Hà Trần was twenty-seven, from Huế, the old imperial city, where girls are taught to speak softly and make things that last. She made lanterns. She had a rare, nearly religious gift for taking something frail and giving it a skeleton of bamboo, a skin of silk and a heart of fire. Her lanterns looked as though the light inside them had been *asked,* and had agreed.

She was very pale tonight, under the red glow, with a silk scarf wound round her head. She had been tired for eleven months, in the way sleep does not mend.

"*Chị Hà,*" said a voice at the door, with a blast on a tin whistle. "The *Seven-Fifteen* has *arrived.*"

"Thảo," said Hà, "you are not on the railway any more."

"The railway is in my blood!" cried Thảo Đặng, twenty-four, formerly a guard on the Reunification Express and now the shop's errand-girl and professional noise. She blew one whistle to open the shop each morning, a second to close it, and a third to announce that a crisis had begun. "A customer is *on the platform.* He has a camera. He says he has been photographing you for nine months."

"He has been *what?*"

A young man stood in the door, tall and rumpled, in a linen shirt the colour of old tea, from Hanoi, with a face a little too thin and a little too bright. He had the side-

long, hungry look of someone who has spent his life watching other people's happiness through a small window. Round his neck hung a battered black camera.

"Hà," said Quân Nguyễn.

"You are the photographer from the magazine. You said it was for an article on *lanterns.*"

"It was. It is." He swallowed. "I have taken one hundred and forty-two photographs of you. I have never shown you one."

Hà laid down her needle. "Why?"

"Because you are in every one of them," said Quân, "and I did not know how to say that to someone who was only looking at the lantern."

Down the lane the street-singer Mai Bùi, fifty-five, who had brokered more marriages there than anyone cared to count, stopped in the middle of a song about a river and listened to a silence she had been waiting six months to hear.

Hà stood too fast, and the room tilted; and the next thing she knew was the bamboo floor, cool against her cheek, a whistle blasting the *crisis* signal over and over, a pair of shaking hands turning her over, and a voice that was not at all the voice of a magazine photographer saying her name.

"Don't," said Hà. "I am only tired."

"You are not *only* tired."

She looked up at him. She had meant to hold the lie a little longer. She had folded it small, for eleven months, and kept it in her sleeve. But a lie weighs too much in

the arms of someone who has said your name like that.

"It is in the blood," she said. "They found it in the spring. There is a hospital in Đà Nẵng. There are medicines, and they do some good, for a time." She smiled, a little crookedly. "I am not telling you so that you will look at me the way you are looking at me now."

"How am I looking at you?"

"As if I were already a picture."

✦ ✦ ✦

Later. The river. A bench. Two small paper boats, each with a candle, not yet launched.

"You may ask me for anything," said Quân. "A doctor, a cart to Đà Nẵng. I will carry you in my arms."

"No."

"Hà—"

"*No.*" It came out hard, and then softer. "I know you. You will become a man with a task, and I will become the task. You will bring soup, and cry when I am not looking, and speak in the voice they use for children and the dead. I make lanterns. For as long as I can, I would like to go on being only that."

"I do not pity you."

"Everyone says that."

"I have watched you for nine months," said Quân, low and fierce. "I have seen you take a plain frame and a yard of silk and make a thing that looks as if the light

had *thought* of it. I do not pity a woman who can do that. I envy the people who will stand under it."

She looked at him for a long time. "Show me. The hundred and forty-two."

He turned the little screen toward her, and they sat shoulder to shoulder while the pictures slid by. Hà at the bench, her hands in the glow. Hà laughing at Thảo's whistle, the scarf coming loose. Hà asleep over a frame in the noon heat, a half-finished lantern against her cheek. Hà looking at a finished lantern with a look he had not known a face could hold: as though she had made a sun and were not yet sure it was hers.

A tear ran down her face, and she let it fall.

"Is that me?"

"It is the light," said Quân. "You are what it shines through."

She laughed, shakily, and laid her head on his shoulder, and said, as if reciting a lesson she had known since childhood and only now understood, the old song of her city, in the six-and-eight measure of Huế:

Thin silk, a frame of cane, And in the midst, one little flame. It does not ask the night For pity, only to be held, And carried through the lanes at dusk, A while, before it goes. Hold me, then, as you hold the light: Not to keep, but to be near.

"Stay," said Hà. "Not as a nurse. As a photographer. When it is time, I would like someone to have a picture of the woman who made the lanterns, and not of the woman who was ill."

“I will stay.”

“I will make one lantern each month, for as long as I can. The last one,” she said, so quietly he scarcely heard, “you will carry.”

Quân could not speak. He lit the two candles, and together they set the little boats on the river. For a time the flames kept close, side by side in the black current; and then the water took them gently round the bend.

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SCENE II

Prague. A hospice on a hill in Žižkov. A long bright room, the beds wheeled to face a small stage of two screens and a table. A Wednesday afternoon.

In a city of a hundred spires, a man was preparing to perform for the most honest audience in the world.

They were seventeen, in beds and chairs, under blankets from home, with oxygen tubes and, in one case, a very large hat. They had been told it was “a puppet show,” and were unimpressed. But a hospice is hard on pride, and so they had come.

Behind the screens, in the dark, with his strings between his fingers, stood Petr Novák, forty, the shyest puppeteer in Prague. He had never spoken a sentence of his own to a room of strangers. Now he lifted a three-foot wooden figure in a red cap, to speak through the mouth of someone braver.

"*Dobrý den!*" cried **Kašpárek,** the clown, bobbing and bowing, in a cracked comical voice. "Ladies and gentlemen! Some of you may have heard that I am a *fool.* This is true. I have been a fool since the year 1700, and I am *very good at it.*"

The seventeen began, grudgingly, to smile.

At the back, in a plain grey coat, with the notebook she had left in the car, sat Lucie Horáková, thirty-six, theatre critic, whose pen had been until last year the sharpest in the Czech lands. Beside her, under a plaid rug, lay her father, Martin Horák, seventy-four, retired tour guide, who had a few weeks left.

"It is very good," whispered Martin, before it had begun, and settled himself.

It was an old story: a clown loses his hat and looks for it all over the city, finding in each place a thing he had not been seeking. A candle. A stone. A child. At the end he sat down with nothing in his hands.

"I have found everything but the hat," he said, in his shaking, merry voice. "Perhaps that is the way it goes. One loses one thing and discovers one is wearing the rest."

Then the little figure turned to the back of the room.

"And now," said Kašpárek, "a word for the lady in the grey coat."

Lucie sat very still.

"The clown has read a certain review. It said three things that were true and two that were cruel. He has been grateful for the three. He does not remember the

two.”

“The clown is very bad at speaking for himself, and so he has always used a hat. But there is a gentleman behind the screen who would like to say one thing without the help of any wood.”

The strings went slack. And from behind the screens, small and hoarse, came the unmistakable voice of a very shy man with nothing in his hands:

“Thank you for coming.”

That was the whole of it. He did not wait for an answer.

In the back of the room a critic put her hands over her face. And her father, who did not know it was a first, cried clearly and cheerfully to the whole ward, “*Bravo!*” and was echoed at once by sixteen people who had very little time left in which to be generous.

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SCENE III

Dhaka. The rooftop of a house in Mirpur. A Wednesday evening in the middle of the rains. A sky going green at the edges; tomatoes in kerosene tins; a line of washing; a tin jug; an old man, watering.

Abbu had never told anyone how much the roof meant to him.

It was the only part of the house the debt had not touched. He kept tomatoes up there, and chillies, and a struggling jasmine in a bucket, and every evening, at the hour when the crows go home, he climbed the last flight

with a tin jug, in the blue shirt he had worn to the office for twenty years, before a supplier he trusted had left him with no office to go to.

One floor below, Fayaz was writing code for a firm in Singapore, in the first bluish ache of the night shift, when he heard the jug fall.

It is a small sound, a tin jug on concrete. It is the sound of something that was being carried and is not any longer.

He took the stairs three at a time. He found his father on his side among the pots, the water running in a dark tongue across the roof, eyes open, mouth moving, unable to say. Fayaz, who had carried only code, lifted a man who weighed as little as a rolled mat and carried him down the stairs, shouting for Tithi, for the whole sleeping lane.

It was Bunny who found the three-wheeler. Bunny, thirteen, who had been shutting the tea stall, took one look, dropped everything, and ran into the main road waving both arms at a green CNG auto as though he could stop a cyclone with his hands.

"The heart hospital!" he screamed. "*Bhaiya's father!* Drive, Uncle, I will pay you in tea for a year!"

The driver would not take a taka.

At the National Institute of Cardiovascular Diseases they said he was lucky in the hour; that there was a blockage, a stent, a procedure; they said it with the weary gentleness of doctors who say it forty times a day. Two lakh to begin. Three more after.

The debt, which had been fourteen lakh, became nineteen.

Fayaz did not weep. He sat in the corridor among the families asleep on newspapers and did the sums. His mother came in the afternoons with a tiffin, her breathing a little worse each time, and sat beside him, and did not ask. Tithi did her physics on her knee.

He did not look at his phone.

He had switched it off the first night. He told himself it was the battery. In truth every buzz had become an invoice, and somewhere in that glowing rectangle was a name he could not bear to see.

I will not be the thing that makes you stay. He had said it himself. It had been his best sentence. Now he could only watch, in great calm horror, as he proved it true. She was in Rotterdam, with a studio and four continents of masters and a long bright road, and there is no sentence in any language that begins, *My father has had a heart attack and I owe nineteen lakh,* and ends in anything but *and so I must ask you for something.*

It was a wall with excellent manners, and it had fallen on the one person he would have let in.

On the second Friday, at ten in the evening, he stood and looked at the clock over the nurses' station for a very long time. Four hours back along the longitude, in a city of canals, a woman would be sitting down at a table.

"Bhaiya," said a hoarse voice at his elbow.

Bunny, in a school shirt gone grey, with a flask of tea and unaccustomed gravity, sat down beside him.

“That clock is wrong by fifteen minutes. I have checked.” He poured. “Bhaiya, I am only the boy at the stall. But a man who misses two trains in a row has not lost the *train.* He has lost his *nerve.* Send her a dot. One dot. It costs nothing.”

Fayaz put his hand on the dead phone in his pocket. He did not take it out.

“I cannot tell her what the middle looks like.”

“Then tell her it is a middle,” said Bunny. “People have been known to survive them.”

At ten past, the clock ticked forward in its fifteen minutes’ error. Through the ICU door the monitor beat, small and green and faithful. And Fayaz sat down, and put his head in his hands.

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SCENE IV

Rotterdam. A room above a bakery in Delfshaven; a lab in a former tea warehouse on the Maashaven; a grey sky that will not darken in June. The same Friday, six in the evening.

In Yogyakarta the sun sets at six, like a clerk. In Rotterdam in June it stays out until ten and then goes off in a sulk.

Ermis Larasati had done the arithmetic on her first night, at the window of her new room. She was no longer an hour in his future. She was four hours in his

past. When it was ten at night in Mirpur it was six in the evening in Delfshaven, and she did not know what to do with a fact like that, except to look at it.

She had been in Rotterdam nine weeks. She had learned to ride a bicycle in the rain, that *gezellig* means anything pleasant that has candles, and that her landlady, Mevrouw Visser, who ran the bakery below, believed all sorrow a matter of *stroopwafel.* And she had learned the lab: fifteen masters of wax from four continents, and a wall of clocks, one for each master's city. On her second day she had very shyly asked the director to add one.

"Dhaka?" the director had said. "Do you have a master in Dhaka?"

"No," said Ermis. "A client."

It hung now between Lagos and Kyoto, four hours ahead of her own, and she looked at it a great deal.

For nine Fridays he had come. At six her time, ten his, with an indigo cloth on a frame at her elbow, a hundred dots to every Friday, and *he* on the screen: ironed shirt, a joke, a sum, a tea-boy's verdict, a four-minute error blamed on the clock. On the last of them he had said, with a strange stiffness, that he would be busy next week. And she had said, *Of course.*

And then nothing.

The first Friday she sat at six. At ten past: *delivered.* At half past: *delivered.* She told herself that Dhaka had a great many power cuts.

The second Friday she told herself nothing. She wrote a message eleven times and deleted it eleven times: *Are you well? Is it your mother? Did I say too little?* In her own window the three small dots rose and fell, *Ermis is typing…,* a cowardly heart unable to decide on a sentence.

Her grandmother rang on the video, with the parrot on her shoulder.

"*TOO LATE!*" screamed Ayu, in delight. "*TOO LATE! BEAUTIFUL!*"

"Ayu," said Ermis wearily. "Not yet."

The parrot, to everyone's astonishment, fell silent.

"Then do what we did," said Eyang, who had been born in a time of letters and never fooled by a screen. "Write it on paper, child. A telephone is a door that opens only from the inside. Paper can be pushed under."

So she did. She sat at the table with a sheet of the lab's hand-made paper, thick and cream, and the fountain pen her father had given her at eighteen. It took six sheets, and the first five were spoiled by sentences that said too much. The last said, in her small upright hand:

Rotterdam, Friday night.

Fayaz,

You will say it is old-fashioned to write on paper. It is. I do it because I have used up three phones' worth of patience on a little word that does not change, and paper does not blink.

I am well. It rains sideways, like something personal. The lab is wonderful; it is full of people who know everything about wax and nothing about how to boil rice.

I have a problem in arithmetic. In Yogyakarta I was one hour ahead of you, and I told you from an hour ahead that you were kind. Here I am four hours behind. It is six for me when it is ten in Mirpur. So now you are four hours in my future. I did not plan it. It means, if I am logical, that you know what happens. I would be very grateful if you would tell me.

I do not know why you are silent. I have decided not to guess. If it is your father, I am sorry; if your mother, the same; if the debt, the same. If it is that you think you must not be a weather in my window, I shall tell you, since you will not ask: you are not weather. Weather passes. You are the window.

I have begun the cloth. A hundred dots each Friday. Nine hundred so far. It needs a thousand, and then it has its name. I will not make the last hundred until I hear from you.

I shall be at the table on Fridays at six. If you can only manage one letter, send a dot.

Be on time. If you are late, I will say the clock was wrong.

— E.

P.S. Ayu said "too late." I told her, "Not yet." She has been unusually quiet since.

She did not write that word. She had always privately thought it a note of large denomination: easy to spend and impossible to take back.

On the Saturday morning she went out in the sideways rain, in the wrong raincoat, past the bakery and the chained bicycles, to the red postbox at the end of her street. It had two slots: *Rotterdam,* and *overige landen.* Other countries. She stood before it a long time with the envelope in her hand.

On the front she had written, in her neatest capitals, kept for strangers and clients, the address she had been given on the last Friday before she flew, by a man who had said, *A postman will need a map and a priest:* a third-floor flat in a lane in Mirpur, five thousand miles to the east.

A letter, she thought, is the opposite of the dots. One cannot take it back, and one cannot watch for it. One can only let go, and go home.

She put it through the slot. She heard it drop, a small flat sound.

"Not yet," said Ermis, to the postbox. And then, to the grey Dutch sky, which for once, for no reason at all, had begun to lighten: "Is it, though?"

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0713 and Entry 0714. A letter from Rotterdam to Mirpur takes eleven to nineteen days. A set of three dots takes no time at all. Observe which of them the heart can bear to wait for.
Entry 0474 and Entry 0469. She asked that nothing be written of pity. I have kept to it. I have written only of light.

Entry 0418 and Entry 0227. A clown in a red cap learned this week that one may say a thing without wood. It is a smaller miracle than fire, and a good deal rarer.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 44.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 45: Glass and Gothenburg

“I dressed your burn and I have not forgotten your pulse.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0457

✦ ✦ ✦

Enter the Chorus, with a paper fan in one hand and a thermometer in the other, for it is the first week of July in two countries and neither of them is behaving.

In Kyoto the cicadas cry the hour; In Gothenburg the sun forgets to set. One bride wears wood to hide her face; one nurse Wears blunt remarks to hide a softer thing. A man who carves, a man who blows his breath In molten sand: they hold in either hand The same unlikely trade, to make a thing That’s fragile, and to hand it over whole.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE I

Kyoto. A workshop above a lacquer-seller’s shop in a lane east of the river. The morning of a wedding. The cicadas have begun their daily argument with the sun, and the sun, as usual, is winning.

Kenji Watanabe, twenty-seven, mask-maker, had been awake since three o'clock, which he considered a reasonable hour for a man to start being married.

He stood in the middle of the room in a black formal kimono with his family crest white upon the sleeves, and he could not tie his own sash. He had carved old women, young women, demons and gods, a fox that wept and a boy who laughed in his sleep. But the knot at his own waist had defeated him three times, and the fourth attempt was going the way of the other three.

"Stop that," said a voice from the door. "You are strangling yourself."

"I am *dressing* myself."

"It is the same motion, with a different intention."

This was Daichi Kobayashi, twenty-five, retired teacher. He had taught one class of nine-year-olds for one term, had resigned in protest at a lesson plan, and had never accepted another title. He was the best man. He was also superstitious to the point of ornament: about his person hung seventeen lucky charms, a pouch of salt, and a small brass bell that rang whenever he turned his head. He had been drinking tea since midnight, in the belief that it was a sort of armour.

"I have checked the calendar," said Daichi, advancing on the sash. "It is a *taian* day. The luckiest of the six. Nothing begun today can fail."

"That is a relief."

“I also checked the aunts. The aunt at Fushimi says a crow looked at her sideways. Do you know what that means, Kenji?”

“That the crow was looking at the aunt.”

“It means a *test.*” The sash went round, and round again, and was tied with a snap. “There. You are a married man in all but fact. Stand like a married man.”

“How does a married man stand?”

Daichi thought, and the little bell rang. “As though someone else were holding the other end of the rope.”

Kenji laughed, and some of the white went out of his face.

“Sleep deprivation has made me a philosopher,” said Daichi gloomily. He paused at the door. “Ferry-hand Yuto has the rings. A stranger on the train told him he looked trustworthy, and Yuto trusts anyone who says so. He is hot-tempered, Kenji, but *in good faith.*”

“The rings are not going to be lost.”

“Which,” said Daichi, “is exactly what everyone says on the morning that they are.” And he went away down the stairs, ringing.

Left alone, Kenji went to the bench by the window. There lay a small unfinished mask in pale wood, a young woman’s face, with the eyes not yet cut and the mouth a single quiet line. He had begun it the night he first heard her speak a line on a stage, and had never finished it, because every time he came near the eyes he found himself afraid of what they would see. He took a

curl of cypress shaving between his fingers, and it smelled of rain and temples, and he spoke to the faceless wood as the lonely do, gently, and in measure.

I carve the faces other people wear. I give the grieving widow her wet cheek; I give the demon horns; I give the god His smile, which is the hardest thing to cut, For gods must smile and never seem to try. And every face I give away is lent, And every face goes back into its box, And I have kept no face to call my own. She wears the mask when no one asks her to. I hid behind the knife. She, behind wood. Two cowards, then, who found each other out, And did not run. Now, with her sleeve in mine, I learn that being seen is not a death. It is a window in a house that was a wall.

The cicadas shrieked. Kenji put the unfinished mask carefully in its silk and turned it face-down, as one does for a sleeper.

"Later," he said to it. "After. When there is someone to look back."

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

Gothenburg, on the other side of the world, many hours later by the clocks. The emergency wing of the hospital on the hill. A corridor, a window full of impossible light, and a cart.

It was seven in the evening, and the sun hung over the harbour like a guest who has been asked to leave and has taken it for a compliment. In Gothenburg in the first

week of July the night is a rumour: a peach sky at ten, a rose at midnight, and at one o’clock a sort of apologetic blue. The Keeper, who loved the dark between the stars, would have found it distressing; and yet it was in all that terrible light that Astrid Lindqvist had spent eight months learning how much truth she had been hiding.

She was thirty-two, a nurse, and she stood in the corridor of the emergency department with a clipboard held against her chest like a shield, being addressed by a tea cart.

“You are doing it again,” said Sofia Holm.

“I’m not doing anything.”

“You are looking at the door with your whole body. I have seen better composure in a dog with a ball.”

Sofia Holm was twenty-eight, a tea seller, and a romantic of the most dangerous kind, the kind who has read a great many books and believes them. She had pushed her cart in these corridors for seven years on the principle that the sick and the frightened should not be made to choose between hope and a hot drink. She also kept a notebook, and in the notebook the name of every person who had ever insulted her tea. The list was a hundred and twelve names long. The first, from 2019, was a registrar who had called her best blend *warm water with ambitions*; he had since gone to work in Malmö, where she hoped he was lonely.

“Take a tea,” said Sofia. “It is chamomile. It is for nerves.”

“I don’t have nerves.”

“It is also for people who say they do not have nerves.” She poured. “He is coming today, is he not? The glassblower.”

“He is not *my* glassblower. He is a former patient.”

“Former patients send a card. They do not send a *lifeguard.*” Sofia lowered her voice to report a naval engagement. “Your sister rang the kiosk. Two men at the main entrance. One carries a box as though it were a baby; the other steers him by the elbow. They asked her the way to the emergency department, and when she said, *Are you ill?* the one with the box said, *In a way. It is an emergency.*” She drew herself up, gentle and quite grave. “Astrid. I have sold tea in this corridor seven years. A man who burns his hand twice to see a woman is not a man who has a pain. He is a man who has an *intention*.”

“He burned it once.”

“The second one was a *lentil*,” said Sofia, “and you know it.”

Astrid opened her mouth. She closed it. Down the long hall, past the wheelchairs and the plastic tree that had been sad since the previous Christmas, the automatic doors slid open with a sigh. Two figures entered the brightness together. The first was a tall, fair man of thirty, with the shoulders of someone who had spent a decade saving strangers from water, and the look of one who had been told, on the train, to *stop talking about drowning*. The second was Erik Johansson.

He was thirty-four, in a clean white shirt with the left sleeve buttoned a little too tightly at the wrist, and in his arms, wrapped in two blankets and a Stockholm newspaper, he carried a box. He saw her at once.

“Sister Lindqvist,” said Erik.

“This is the emergency department.”

“I am aware.”

“You are not bleeding.”

“I am aware of that also.”

“Then you cannot be here. It is a rule. It is a stupid rule, and I don’t make it, but I enforce it, and I am extremely good at it.”

“Is it a medical emergency,” said Erik, “if a man has come three hundred miles by train with a bowl?”

Fredrik Andersson, lifeguard and best friend, said gently, “Erik. You were supposed to say, *I’d like to see the sister about a follow-up.*”

“I said I would, and then I saw her, and I said the bowl.”

Sofia Holm, at her cart, wept very softly into a teaspoon. Astrid looked at the box, and at the buttoned cuff, and at the face above them, and then, with the brisk air of a woman who had spent ten years handing out bad news and did not know how to take good news off a tray, she looked at her watch.

“My shift ends at eight,” she said. “There is a roof. It is not allowed. Go up the stairs by the laundry. Don’t drop that.”

“I will not drop it.”

“You are a glassblower. I have *seen* your hands.”

“Then you know,” said Erik, “that I am careful with what I cannot afford to break.”

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

Kyoto. A shrine on the green slope of the eastern hills, in the heat of noon. Cypress, gravel, white paper streamers, and the sound of a drum like a slow heart.

They came up the stone steps in procession, under a great red parasol: the priest first, then the shrine maidens, then the bride and groom, and behind them the families, sweating beautifully.

Haruka Mori was twenty-six, a Noh actress of the Kyoto school, and she wore the white robe of a bride from throat to hem. On her head sat the white hood called the *tsunokakushi*, which, as every Japanese grandmother will explain, is meant to hide the horns of jealousy. It is a pretty custom, and a gently comic one for a woman who had played the Demon of Jealousy a dozen times in horns of gilded wood, and offstage had worn a mask everywhere else. She had worn one to the market. She had worn one to her mother’s funeral. She wore one now, beneath the white silk: the small pale face Kenji Watanabe had carved for her in the spring, which fitted her cheekbones as nothing in the repertory ever had, and made her look exactly like herself, only calmer.

No one remarked on it. A bride, after all, is permitted a veil.

At the front of the crowd stood Shun Ito, sixty-one, a retired airline pilot from Osaka who had introduced the couple in a tea-shop in March for a fee of nothing, and had been quietly collecting on it ever since. He gambled when he was afraid, and he had been so afraid that morning that he had lost four thousand yen to a pigeon. Beside him his sister Aoi, a newsagent and notorious meddler, whispered to the bride's cousins that she had *always known.* And in the third row Daichi Kobayashi sat, eyes closed, bell ringing, lips moving in a prayer against the aunts' crows.

Behind him, in ill-fitting black, stood a ferry-hand from Kobe named Yuto Shimizu, twenty-nine, with a little silk bag clutched in his fist and the wild look of a man who suspects every passer-by of being a thief.

The priest chanted. The drum went on. A cicada, immune to ritual, began to scream in the camphor tree, and was joined by a hundred more, until the whole hillside shouted its praise. Kenji sat on the left, very straight. Haruka sat on the right, veiled twice over. Neither looked at the other.

Then came the three cups.

This is the oldest part of the Shinto wedding, the *sansankudo:* three small red cups of sake, passed between groom and bride, three sips from each. It is not meant to be pretty. It is meant to be shared. Kenji drank from the first cup. Then a shrine maiden lifted the second in both hands and held it out to Haruka.

And Haruka, who had not shown her bare face in a public place since she was nineteen, raised her hand to the small pale mask beneath the hood, and took it off.

There was no gasp; everyone was too well brought up. But the drum dropped half a beat, and the cicadas, for one astonishing second, ceased, as though they too had been told to look. Haruka's face was bare to the noon: long-eyed, serious, with a small scar on the left cheekbone where a stage lamp had once fallen, and a mouth that was already, against all her training, beginning to tremble. She drank her first sip with her whole face open to the hill.

Kenji did not look at the cup. He looked at her. A man who had spent his life hiding behind the knife found that he could not hide behind anything now, not the crest on his sleeve, nor the priest's white shoulder. His eyes filled. He let them fill. Then they said their vows, which are short, and which they had written themselves, and spoke them in couplets because neither had anything left that would go into prose:

HE: *I carved a thousand faces, none my own; I'd rather wear yours, if you'd let me, known.*
SHE: *I wore the mask so none might read me through; I lay it down for one who sees it's true.*

It was then that Yuto Shimizu stepped forward with the little silk bag and, with enormous ceremony, tipped its contents into his palm.

They were empty.

He stared. He turned the bag inside out. He looked at the priest, the bride, the bridegroom, the camphor tree. “The *stranger,*” he said, in a ringing stage whisper that reached the farthest aunt. “The stranger on the train. I *knew* it. He had a nice voice, and I *knew* it. Wait there. Nobody move. I will find him. I will go to Osaka.”

“Yuto,” said Daichi, from the third row, in the tone of a man who has seen his horoscope come true and takes no joy in it. “Look in the other pocket.”

Yuto looked in the other pocket. The rings were there, two plain bands of gold made in a week by Nanami Ito the goldsmith. There was a pause, in which the entire shrine breathed out. Somebody laughed. Then everybody laughed: the priest, the aunts, the pilot, the families, and the bride with her bare face, who laughed out loud, head back, for the first time in her life in front of strangers.

Mark this, reader. A laugh is the one mask that cannot be worn. It comes through the wood.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE IV

Gothenburg. The roof of the hospital. Eight o’clock, and as bright as three. A bench, two chairs, a tarred floor, a view of cranes and church spires and the grey-gold curve of the Göta älv, and a box.

She sat with her arms folded, which is the posture in which a Swedish nurse prepares to be moved.

Erik had put the box on the bench and was unwrapping it with great care. From beneath the last of the blankets he lifted, in both hands, a bowl.

It was not a perfect bowl. It was a little taller on one side than the other, thick at the base and thin at the lip, and the green of it was the green of the sea off Marstrand in March, darkening toward the bottom; and in the thick glass at its heart a single bubble of air hung suspended, small and round, no bigger than a lentil.

"I blew it on Tuesday," said Erik. "It is the first thing I have blown since the burn. For a year and a half I have held the pipe like a stranger's hand. You said the nerves might come back. They have, a little. It means I make everything lopsided." He swallowed. "I thought you would prefer it lopsided. Everything in this building is level."

Astrid took the bowl from him. She turned it in the light, and the green went gold, and the bubble swam. For a long time she said nothing; and then, in a voice sanded rough, she said, "That's a pulse."

"It's a lentil."

"A lentil is a pulse. It's a legume, you fool. Do you know that you have blown the most accurate piece of glass in Sweden?" She had begun to shake with a laughter she did not trust. "I do not know what to do with a man who can say it in a *bowl.*"

"I am sorry about the lentil," said Erik. "The one I put on my hand. That winter." He took a very deep breath. "I want it entered into the record. The first burn was an accident. Hot glass never lies about what it is. But the second, the little one, the one I came back with—"

"I know."

"—I did it on purpose."

"I *know*, Erik."

"—wait." He stopped. "You *know?*"

"I have been a nurse for ten years." She was looking at the bowl, not at him, and the words came out of her flat and rapid, like water from a tap that has been shut too long. "Yours was a perfect circle with a clean edge, the size of a lentil. It had not been *touched* by anything. It had been *placed.* I could have written that on the chart." She put the bowl down on the bench. Her hands, he saw, were not steady. "I wrote *accidental.* It was the only untrue word that I have ever entered on a form. I put it in black ink. I pressed so hard that it came through to the next page."

"Why?"

"Because I did not want you to stop coming."

He did not move.

"There," said Astrid Lindqvist, furiously, to the cranes. "That is the confession. I dressed your hand the first time, and I took your pulse. A hundred and eighteen. And I thought, it is the pain. And then you came back and it was a hundred and four and there was no pain at all, and I thought, *oh.* And I have not forgotten it. I wrote that down, once, to an old woman in Cornwall, and it was published, with a number, for the entire world to read. Do you know how mortifying that is, for a woman who never says a thing she cannot chart?"

“I read it,” said Erik quietly. “In November. I searched *Gothenburg.* I found a woman who said she had not forgotten a pulse.” He turned his left hand over, and she saw the pale shining scar on the heel of the palm, like a little map of an island. “I knew whose it was at once. Nobody else would have bothered to mention the *pulse.*”

“It’s a perfectly clinical detail.”

“It’s the most romantic sentence I’ve ever read.”

“It is *clinical*.”

“Astrid. I would like to ask you something. It is not an emergency. I would like that on the record also.”

She looked at him then, in the light that would not fail, without a clipboard, without a mask, without the blunt remark that was her version of both, and found, to her great alarm, that she could not hold it for more than two seconds together.

“Not now,” she said.

His face fell, and she felt it like a missed step on a stair.

“Not *now,*” said Astrid, with a rush, taking his burned hand in both of hers and turning it palm upward as she had done once in a cubicle under a white lamp, “because it is light, you fool. It is a quarter past eight and as bright as a dentist’s waiting room. I do not trust anything this light tells me. A thing like that should be asked in the dark.” She took her fingers to his wrist, and he felt them find the place and settle there. “In August. At the first crayfish party, when the dark comes back and

somebody finally lights the paper lanterns. When the first star comes out, over the roof. Ask me then, and I shall tell you what I think of it, in the right light."

"And in the meantime?"

"In the meantime," said the nurse, counting silently, "a hundred and four. You are improving."

Below them, in the harbour, a ferry sounded its horn, long and low. Far down in the corridors, a woman with a tea cart opened her notebook, crossed out the first name on the list, and wrote beside it, in a small, impatient, tender hand: *Forgiven. Chamomile works.*

And on the roof of the hospital on the hill, a bowl the colour of the sea stood on a bench in the long light, with a lentil of held breath at its heart, and nobody saw it begin, very faintly, to glow.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0457 and Entry 0911. A burn is the body's way of saying a thing in the only language that cannot be argued with. Entry 0029 and Entry 0447: a mask, the mind's way of saying the same. Both were taken off in summer, in front of witnesses, and neither lover died of it. Mark that.
The autumn will ask what the summer promised. I have a feeling it will be paid in full.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 45.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 46: The Weaver’s Promise

“I promised to wait and I am weaving the promise.”
— Register of Black Stars, Entry 0281

✦ ✦ ✦

Enter the Chorus, trailing a loose thread, a loose wire, and a loose bicycle chain.

Three promises, each made of different stuff: One
thread, one wave, one wheel. The thread is slow,
The wave is quick, the wheel goes round and round;
And none may say which one will hold the longest.
But mark: the thread is longer than it looks.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE I

Bonwire, outside Kumasi, in the hills of Asante. A weaving shed with a tin roof, four looms, and a smell of cotton, dust and groundnut soup. August; an afternoon shower drumming overhead like a hundred small fists.

The loom said *clack*, and then it said *clack* again.

It is a narrow thing, the kente loom, and an ancient one: a frame of wood, a weight of stone, two pedals worked by the feet, and a warp of thread stretched away into the dark of the shed like a road that had decided to

be a rumour. The weaver sits at the near end and throws the shuttle through the shed with his right hand and beats the weft with his left, and his feet, meanwhile, go up and down as if pedalling steadily toward a place he has not told anyone about. What comes out is not cloth. It is a *strip*, four fingers wide, no more; and a hundred strips sewn edge to edge make the cloth that kings are buried in, and the cloth a girl wears to be named, and the cloth that a young man, in his thirtieth year, is weaving now, with a promise in it.

Kofi Boateng sat at the loom. He had sat there since four o'clock. He was thirty and patient, which in Asante is an old and honoured combination, and proud, which in Asante is a young man's one acknowledged vice. Beside him, on a stool, with her handbag on her knee and her glasses at the end of her nose, sat his mother, Akosua Asante, sixty-one, a lawyer. She was reading a contract. It was his.

"Paragraph three," said Akosua.

"There is no paragraph three. I did not write a contract."

"I have written one for you. Paragraph three says, *The party of the first part, being a weaver, undertakes to wait.* It does not say how long." She looked at him over the glasses. "A promise with no term, Kofi, is not a promise. It is a rumour with a heartbeat."

"It is not a contract. It is a cloth."

"It is a *warp*," said his mother, with the air of one who has cross-examined a hundred thieves and found her son the most elusive. "I counted it. Do not think I did not.

One hundred and forty yards. You wound that warp on Monday. A man does not wind a warp of one hundred and forty yards for a market stall; he winds it for a *term*. Twenty-four months. That is how long her scholarship runs."

Kofi's hands did not stop. *Clack.* "You have been in my shed."

"I stay where the evidence is."

"I have not asked her to wait for me."

"You have not asked her to *go*, either." Akosua folded the paper. "I stayed in this town thirty-six years when I should have gone to Accra and been a judge. Nobody asked me to stay. Nobody asked me to go. I have had a very long time to consider the difference." She stood. "Weave the cloth. But tell the girl, or the cloth will tell her, and cloth has a poor sense of timing."

Overhead, a ladder creaked. Kwabena Quaye, fifty, electrician, who had been summoned from Tema to fix the shed's single wire and had been fixing it since breakfast, put his head down through the rafters. He was a punctual man, and a bitter one, and he had never forgotten that, twenty-six years ago, a weaver had told him his shirt did not match his trousers.

"The light is ready," said Kwabena. "I want it noted that I could have done it in an hour if I had not been *judged.*"

"Nobody judged you."

"Your uncle looked at my sleeve."

"Kwabena. It is *twenty-six years.*"

“I have a good memory,” said Kwabena darkly, and threw the switch. A single bulb came on above the loom and showed, in the strip that lay unrolling from the cloth-beam, a pattern of gold and green and black: broad blocks and narrow, in the order the old weavers call *Emaa Da*, which means, *it has never happened before.*

“There,” said Kwabena, relenting, because the light was beautiful. “Now it has.”

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

A classroom in Kumasi, after the last bell. A blackboard, thirty small chairs, a letter on a teacher’s desk, and a window through which a tea-seller is shouting up the price of sugar.

Esi Appiah, twenty-nine, schoolteacher, held a letter in both hands and had not read it for the third time that afternoon.

She did not need to. It said what it had said on Monday: that she, Esi Appiah of Kumasi, had been awarded a two-year scholarship to study education at a university in Scotland, where it rained, she had been told, as it rained here, but colder, and with opinions. It said she must reply by the end of the month. It said *Congratulations.* It was the first word on the page, and she had spent four days looking at the other ones.

“You have not said yes,” said a voice from the window.

Below, with a thermos on his hip and a tray of sugar bread on his head, stood Kojo Asante, thirty-three, tea-seller, her oldest friend, and a deeply devout man with a habit of spending money that was not his on things that were holy. That week he was a hundred cedis into the church building fund on borrowed sugar. He had asked God for a ruling on the matter, and God, so far, had been silent.

“I have not said anything,” said Esi.

“Not even to Kofi?”

“*Especially* not to Kofi.”

““Then you are *both* very quiet.” Kojo clasped his hands. “Madam. I will tell you what my grandmother told me, and then I will sell you a tea. She said, there are two things you cannot do to a person: you cannot ask them to stay, and you cannot tell them to go. You can only stand in the door and hold it open for whichever way they walk.”

“That is very profound.”

“It is also why she lost three husbands,” said Kojo. “Tea?”

She laughed in spite of herself. And then, when the laugh was done, she turned to the empty blackboard, and spoke, as people speak who are alone with the thirty small chairs of a school:

I have been brave in every way but this. I crossed the river when the bridge was down; I taught a hundred children how to read, And stood before a minister and said That girls should have the books. I

have not feared. And now, a letter, and a name, and a door, And on the other side of it a man Who has not asked, who will not ask, who sits At his slow loom and weaves while I decide. If I go, I shall not know what he weaves. If I stay, I shall not know what I have been. O Time, who carries one of us away, How shall I say a yes I cannot spell?

She did not hear the shed door open, nor the footsteps on the damp laterite. She only looked up, when the poem was done, and found Kofi Boateng standing at the classroom door in his weaving clothes, with a thing wrapped in brown paper under his arm, and a tea-seller behind him pretending to count loaves.

“I came about the warp,” said Kofi.

“The warp.”

“It is a hundred and forty yards. It is wound for twenty-four months. I did not mean you to know until the cloth was finished.” He put the parcel on her desk. His hands, which had never trembled at a loom in his life, trembled at the string. “It is a strip. It is the first. It is the width of one month. I thought, if you go, I would weave one every month you are away, and send you a hand’s breadth, and at the end of two years, there is a cloth. And if you stay—” His voice caught on the word. “If you stay, I will cut the warp and burn it, and you will never need to know.”

She opened the paper. The strip lay in her hands, four fingers wide, gold and green and black. In the weave, very small, there was a pattern she had not seen before,

and he named it, as weavers do, in the old way, with a proverb.

"It is called *Emaa Da*," said Kofi.

"*It has never happened before.*"

"It has been done before. A weaver cannot make a thing that is new." He smiled, a little ruefully. "But I think it has never been done for this."

"Kofi," said Esi.

"Do not say it. Do not say yes or no, not to me. I do not ask you for a promise. I am only telling you that the thread is long. It is longer than it looks."

She stood very still with the strip lying across her palms. She had never in her life failed to answer a direct question, and she found now that she had no answer except to put one hand, lightly, over his, where it lay on the desk.

"I will write to Scotland on Friday," said Esi.

"And?"

"And I will tell you on Friday," said Esi Appiah, "which letter I wrote."

Down at the window the tea-seller dropped the entire tray of sugar bread, and said *Amen.*

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

Soweto, Johannesburg. A Sunday afternoon in the church hall of a street whose name every schoolchild knows. The roof is corrugated; the floor is polished like a wish; and on a trestle table by the door sits a radio microphone wrapped in a ribbon.

It is a fact, known to every taxi driver in the province of Gauteng, that there was no wedding in the history of Johannesburg that the whole city heard at once.

There was one now. The radio station, whose night show had begun as a joke between a woman and a microphone and grown into the bedtime ritual of eight hundred thousand people, had parked an outside-broadcast van beside the church hall, and run a cable under the door, and informed the city that at four o'clock, on the frequency that had carried a woman's voice into the dark for four years, the woman would be married, live, to the man who had played saxophone to her through that same dark and not once been seen.

"I am not nervous," said Jabu Mokoena, twenty-nine, shopkeeper, best man, and master of ceremonies by popular misunderstanding.

"You have put the ring in your shoe," said a voice at his elbow.

"That is *tradition.*"

"It is *pain,* Jabu." This was Thandi Zulu, thirty, who sold fat-cakes from a barrow in Pretoria and had come to the wedding with forty dozen, in the belief that a hall full of the hopeful is also, by the laws of arithmetic, a hall full of the hungry. She was gleaming with oil and good intentions. She had never in her life met a stranger. "I

will tell you what it is. It is that you hide behind jokes. I do too. I am a fat-cake woman; nobody asks a fat-cake woman if she is afraid. They say, *Madam, a dozen.* And I say, *Right away, sir,* and I think, *I never thanked the woman who first sold me bread.*"

"Who was she?"

"I don't know!" wailed Thandi. "That is the *problem.*"

At the front of the hall, in a dress of deep-blue shweshwe, with a gold necklace from her landlady Palesa Zulu round her throat, Naledi Khumalo stood in the hush of two hundred guests and one microphone. She was twenty-nine. She was warm, and wry, and a radio host, and she had never in her life been at a loss for a word.

Beside her stood Thabo Dlamini, thirty-one, saxophonist, shy offstage as a deer, in a black suit with a thin gold tie and a saxophone slung at his hip.

Neither of them had a speech. That was the arrangement. In the pause before the priest began, an old man in the second row, very thin, in a grey coat too heavy for the warm hall, rose up unbidden and said, in a quavering voice, "Excuse me. Before it starts. I wish to say that I have listened every night. I cannot read. Never learned. The radio was my newspaper and my church and my friend. I wish to thank the lady." He sat down. Tshepo Radebe, sixty-six, retired newsagent, had been listening for four years, and had come to the front on the arm of a taxi-driver, and it was observed that the bride wept before the ceremony began.

It was a short ceremony and a loud one, as Soweto weddings are: with the ululation going up from the aunts at the vows, and a choir in the corner singing in three languages at once. The vows were not long. Naledi went first, because she was the voice, and said them to the microphone and the man and the city, in the plain measure that the heart finds when it has been practising for years:

For four years I have sent a song into the dark And never known the one who heard it best. I called you stranger. Now I call you mine, Not as a thing possessed, but as a hand Is held: because it fits, and will not tire. I am a voice. You are the sound I wished for. Be with me when the radio goes quiet.

Then Thabo, who had no voice for it, lifted the saxophone to his mouth.

He did not speak. He played. It was a slow, warm, impossible tune, the one that had come down the wires to her on a hundred nights, and it went up through the corrugated roof and through the open door and down the length of the street, where people had stopped; and down the length of the city, where cars had pulled over, and minibus-taxis had turned off their engines in the middle of the road with the driver’s hand still on the wheel, and a hundred thousand people were listening to a man propose, in the one language that has no accent, to a woman he had never failed to know.

When the last note went out, the hall was entirely silent.

Then Jabu Mokoena took out the ring from his shoe, with an expression of great suffering, and a cheer rose that could be heard in Pretoria. They say that at a taxi rank on Bree Street the whole thing was played from a single car radio, and a hundred people stood with their heads bare in the sun, and no one, afterwards, could remember who had taken up the collection, or for what.

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SCENE IV

Medellín, Colombia. The Feria de las Flores, the Sunday of the great parade. A mountain road at dawn above the city; a cyclist, a farm, and a wheelbarrow.

Meanwhile, on another continent, a man was riding downhill with forty buckets of carnations strapped to a racing bicycle.

It was the most expensive delivery van in Antioquia. Sebastián Torres, twenty-nine, professional cyclist, lately of a crash and a long plaster, stood on the pedals as the road dropped away beneath him in a series of hairpins that gave onto cloud. He had not yet been told by any doctor that this was permitted. He had been told it by Daniela Ruiz, which was a good deal more binding.

"You are carrying the Pinzón order," she had said, at dawn, on the porch of the farm that was dying. "Forty buckets. Carnations and a few spray roses for the florist. If they arrive wilted I am finished."

"They will not wilt."

"They will *wilt*, because you will ride like a lunatic."

“I will ride like a man who has been told to ride *carefully* by a woman who is afraid,” said Sebastián, “which is the most dangerous kind of careful there is.”

Daniela Ruiz was twenty-eight and a flower farmer, and she was bright, and proud, and in debt. In the greenhouse behind the house the roses had a blight, and in a notary’s office in town a man named Julián Gómez, fifty-one, a scribe, loyal to the point of agony and quite unable to deliver bad news, held a paper from a buyer that would take the whole farm, house and ground and mountain, for a sum that was both fair and a catastrophe. He had brought it up the hill on Thursday. He had stood on the porch for an hour holding it, and gone down again without handing it over, and returned on Friday, and done the same.

“It is a very *hard* paper to deliver,” Julián had explained, nearly weeping.

“Give it to me.”

“I cannot. It is *heavy.*”

“It is two pages.”

“It is the weight of the thing it *says,*” said Julián, “and I have been a scribe for thirty years, and nothing else has ever weighed anything.”

Now, on the Sunday of the parade, the farm’s last silleta, a great wooden chair of flowers strapped upon the back of a bearer, stood on the porch waiting. It had been made by Daniela’s grandmother, and her grandmother’s mother, and by every woman of the line for ninety years: seventy kilos of orchids, and lilies, and carnations, bound in the shape of the mountain itself, and carried

down into the city once a year on a human back, in the old way, in front of five hundred thousand people. Her sister, Mariana Rojas, forty-four, a butcher, who had a cleaver for every occasion and a joke for every cleaver, had inspected it that morning with great suspicion.

"It is very heavy," said Mariana. "I will say this for it. It will never be accused of being *silly.*"

"Silleta."

"That is what I said. Silly."

"Mariana."

"I am a butcher. I carry the whole side of a cow and nobody gives me flowers." She sniffed. "Who is going to carry it? Not you; you have a bad knee. Not *him*; he has a plaster still on his *wrist.*"

"I will," said Daniela.

"You will *die.*"

"Then I will die with an orchid." She put her hand on the carved arm of the chair. It was the kind of line that could be said in a house that is about to be sold. "Sebastián will ride behind me down the mountain, and every kilometre I will think: *I have not lost it yet.*"

He did, in the end. All the way down, past the roadside shrines and the vultures and the little tin kiosks selling *arepas*, behind a woman with a seventy-kilo mountain on her back, he rode at walking pace, a racing bicycle at the speed of a funeral; and she never once stopped, nor spoke, nor looked back, and the sun came up over the whole green valley and caught the petals, so that she seemed to walk into the city carried by a small

blazing garden. Somewhere at the bottom of the hill a team manager from Spain stood waiting with a contract that would send Sebastián across an ocean for four years, and somewhere on the same hill a notary's scribe sat on a rock with his two pages, weeping at last, because he had finally decided to deliver them.

"Don't read it yet," said Daniela, over her shoulder, not knowing which paper she meant, and not turning. "Ride with me to the end of the parade. Whatever they say, we will decide it at the bottom."

"Together?"

"At the same time," said Daniela. "I'm not proud enough to say *together.*"

It was, said the Keeper later, a very good answer.

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Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0281 and Entry 0532. A weaver measures a promise in yards. A radio host measures it in frequencies. A cyclist measures it in kilometres, and a farmer in the weight of a flower on her back. They are all the same unit. It is called: how far are you willing to go with your hand still open?
Entry 0466 and Entry 0749. A saxophone has no words, which is why it was believed.
Entry 0586 and Entry 0360. The wheel is still turning. I will not say which way.

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End of Chapter 46.

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Chapter 47: Tiles of Isfahan

“A pattern that never repeats is the closest thing to you.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0228

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SCENE I

Isfahan, Iran. A ruined madrasa behind the great square, in the last gold hour of an August day. Scaffolding, a bucket of lime, a dome the colour of a turquoise someone has dropped into the sky, and a wall that is missing one corner of its own face.

There is a legend in Isfahan, told by every tea-seller to every tourist, that the old masters made one mistake on purpose in every panel they ever laid. *Only God is perfect,* they said, and set one tile crooked, so as not to be presumptuous.

Ali Rezaei, thirty-six, tile master, did not believe the legend. He believed in measurement. But he had been kneeling since noon in front of a panel five centuries too old for its own good, with a bucket of lime at one elbow and a stub of pencil behind one ear, and he was beginning to suspect that God had taken the legend personally.

“It is not a repeat,” said a voice behind him.

“I know it is not a repeat.”

“I mean that I have checked every unit in the field. It *looks* like a repeat. It looks like the five-fold stars that the masters used everywhere. But you set one star beside the next and the next one is turned a hair, and the one after, a hair more. The whole panel is made of a rule that does not close.” Parisa Karimi, thirty-one, architect and restorer, had come up the scaffold with a clipboard held as carefully as a baby and the expression of someone who has found, in a ruin, a handwriting she cannot copy. “I do not know how to restore a thing that has no template. Every other panel I have mended, I took one tile, I made forty.”

“Then do not make forty.”

“What do you mean?”

“I mean,” said Ali, sitting back on his heels, “that you make *one.* And then you look at it, and you listen, and you make the next.”

Parisa lowered the clipboard. “That is the worst building method I have ever heard.”

“It is the only method that is true to the panel.”

“It is *slow.*”

“It is the only speed I have.” He took a glass of tea from the ledge beside him, because she had brought it, and had not said so, and he had not said thank you, which in their long habit of exactness was a form of understanding. He bit the sugar-cube between his front teeth and drank through it, the old way, and for a while the two of them looked at the wall.

“A man from Shiraz is selling a carpet in the lane,” said Ali, “to a woman who does not want it. I can hear him from here.”

“He has been selling it since morning.”

“He will go on until she buys it, or one of them dies.”

This was Reza Jafari, fifty-seven, trader, so profoundly stubborn that he had once sold a Shirazi rug to the husband of a woman who had come in to return the same rug. He had been conducting his business in the lane below the madrasa for three days, and had acquired an audience of tourists, pigeons, and two municipal inspectors. Now he stood at the foot of the scaffold, shouting up with great politeness.

“Master Ali! Madam Architect! I have heard everything!”

“You have heard *nothing,* Reza,” said Parisa.

“I have heard that the pattern does not repeat, and the man must listen to each tile before he lays the next. I am a trader. Do you know what that is called in trade? It is called a *relationship.* And may I recommend, for the sake of your own *lives*—”

“Reza,” said Parisa, going the colour of a pomegranate.

“—that a pattern which never repeats is the best a man can sit down to, because it is never boring, and never finished, and nobody can say you have done it *wrong.*” Reza bowed deeply, tripped over the carpet, and sat down in the lime.

Ali did not laugh. He turned very slowly towards her. He had not planned it; he had planned, for eight months, to say it on some day in the autumn, with proper notice and a proper bunch of flowers. But the light was going gold, and the dome behind her was the colour of something that does not last, and a man may be forgiven the one sentence he has never been able to carve.

I have laid the same star ten thousand times, And every star was perfect, and was dead. The masters knew: one crooked tile, no more, Lets in the breath of someone who is living. You are the tile that will not lie like others. You turn a hair. You turn again. You fail To close the pattern. And I find, to my Considerable alarm, I would not have it Closed. I would rather listen all my life.

Parisa Karimi, who restored ruins because she did not know how to restore herself, said nothing for so long that the muezzin, in some tower beyond the square, began the evening prayer. Then she took off her work glove.

“My mother is in Shiraz,” she said. “She prefers that a man’s uncle call. With flowers. And sweets. It is a very old, very silly custom.”

“I have an uncle.”

“The tailor?”

“The tailor. He has been waiting for the call since I was nineteen. He has kept a suit.”

“Tell him Friday,” said Parisa. “Tell him to bring the *gaz.* Not the sugar one. The one with the pistachios.”

“I will tell him.”

“And Ali.”

“Yes?”

“Do not make forty.”

Below them, in the lime, Reza Jafari wept softly, and said it was the dust.

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SCENE II

Baghdad. The new footbridge over the Tigris. Evening of the same week. A flock of pigeons, a ribbon, and a plaque.

The new bridge was a thing of steel and glass and cable, and people had been walking on it since noon, to be sure it would hold.

It had been built in two halves, from either bank, as the best bridges are, so that it should meet in the middle, in the middle of the river, in the middle of the sky. The engineers had reckoned a tolerance of fifteen millimetres. When the two halves came together on the thirty-first of May, they had met with a gap of three.

“Three millimetres,” said Mustafa Karim, thirty-four, civil engineer, to a crowd of two hundred and a television camera. “In a river three hundred metres across. I would like it noted that nobody has ever done better, and that I am not at all pleased.”

There was applause. In the third row, a young woman in a long grey coat and a green scarf did not applaud. Noor Hashim, thirty, architect, ambitious, eloquent, stood with her arms folded and her eyes on the cables. She had not said a word to him in three weeks. She had also not left his side at any public function, and the two phenomena were beginning to confuse the neighbours.

The ribbon was cut. A poet named Huda Al-Saadi, twenty-five, devout and best friend of the engineer, climbed the little podium and began an ode of two hundred and eleven lines, each ending in the same rhyme, which was *Tigris.* The crowd, which had its principles and its supper, began to drift down the ramps. On the parapet a young stonemason named Shaimaa Al-Obaidi, twenty-eight, who had spent a month carving the plaque in the dry heat and was the wryest woman in Baghdad, stood with her chisel in her belt and her face turned carefully to the river.

"Shaimaa," said Mustafa. "The plaque says *Mustafa Kareem.* My name is spelled *Karim.*"

"I know how your name is spelled." Shaimaa did not turn. "I carved it correctly. Then a flake of limestone came off the *i,* and in fixing it I made it, in every sense but spelling, a *better* name. You may be wrong in the particular, Mustafa, but you are right in spirit."

"Nobody who builds a bridge," she added, as he opened his mouth, "is *entirely* himself."

By the time the ode had reached its hundred-and-fortieth line, the footbridge was nearly empty. The lights came on along the cables, white and blue, and on the water below the long, slow lanterns of the fish-grillers

began to glow along the bank, with the smell of *masgouf* and woodsmoke rising up to the rail. The heat that had stood on the city since June had finally drawn a little back; a hot wind from the desert went down the river.

In the middle of the bridge, where the two halves had met, a seam of three millimetres ran across the walkway, small and polished as a scar. Noor was standing on it.

"You are standing on my error," said Mustafa, coming up.

"I wanted to see it."

"It is not a big error."

"It is the only thing on the whole bridge that is *honest.*" She looked at him, and then at the river. "Mustafa. I answered the university."

"I know."

"You know?"

"Huda told me. She was giddy on her own ode." He had put his hands behind his back, which is a thing an engineer does when he does not trust them. "You go in three weeks. Two years. Copenhagen. A studio on a canal. They want you to design a thing that has not been built."

"Yes."

"I am glad."

"You are not," said Noor, "glad."

"I am extremely glad, and also not glad, and I would like the two to stand on the bridge together without a fight." He drew a breath. "Noor, I wrote once that I was

building this for you to come back to. I wrote it in the dark, and I should like to correct it. A bridge you can only *come back* over is not a bridge. It is a leash. I built it to go both ways. That is the engineering of it. A bridge lets you go, and lets you come, and does not mind which."

She was silent a long time. The call to prayer from a nearby mosque drew itself out over the water, and from the Rusafa bank a late firework spilled a thin red thread across the dark.

"I do not know if I will come back," said Noor, "to the city. Or to *you.* I want to be honest."

"I know that also."

"And you are not going to ask me to say."

"I am going to ask you," said Mustafa Karim, slowly, "to walk with me to the east end of the bridge, and back to the west, and then, if there is time before your tea gets cold, to the east again. And we will see how far that is. And I will not say another word about it."

Noor took her hands out of her coat pockets. She looked down at the seam. Then, carefully, she stepped across it, off the error, into the sky on the other side; and he stepped across beside her, a respectful two feet away; and they walked, without touching, the length of a bridge that did not need to be anyone's leash, and she did not say *yes,* and he did not say *wait.* It was the open sort of ending, and the Keeper, who disliked a closed door, let it be.

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SCENE III

Mirpur, Dhaka. A Friday in the high monsoon. The lane under water to the ankle; the sky the colour of wet slate. A third-floor flat, a tea stall, and a parcel in brown paper tied with a string that has been to Rotterdam.

It had arrived on a Thursday in the arms of a courier who stood at the foot of the stairs in the rain and refused to go up.

“One thousand eight hundred taka,” said the courier. “Customs. For *cloth.*”

“It is a gift,” said Fayaz.

“Gifts are taxed at the rate of generosity.”

“That is not a rate.”

“It is in the *regulations,*” said the courier, who had never read them. Fayaz Rahman, twenty-six, had in his pocket two hundred taka, and in his head the grey arithmetic of nine lakh still owing to a man his father had trusted, now that the last of the village land had gone to pay the rest. The Singapore contract worked him from midnight until eight, and was kind, but not that kind.

“Bhaiya,” said a voice from the doorway of the tea stall, “I will lend it.”

Bunny had come across the flooded lane with his trousers rolled to the knee and a tin in his hand. In the tin was the stall’s takings of three days. He put it into the courier’s hand without being asked. “It is a *loan,*” said Bunny, with the gravity of a banker. “At two spoons of sugar, one of condensed milk, repayable at tea.”

“I cannot take your money.”

“It is not *my* money. It is the *stall’s* money. I am only its guardian.” He looked at the parcel, and at the brown paper, and at the Dutch stamp, and at the neat handwriting, and made a judgement on it that would have done credit to a high court. “A parcel that comes from so far *behind* you, Bhaiya, should be paid for in advance.”

Upstairs, in the third-floor flat, they opened it at the table. Tithi cut the string. Their mother sat with her hands in her lap, breathing carefully, on a cushion that Tithi had put there, and their father, home since June from the hospital, thinner, slower, and unusually quiet, sat in his chair by the window with a stick across his knees and watched without saying a word. On the table under the lamp lay a letter in a Dutch envelope, which Fayaz kept inside *Thinking in Systems,* and had read eleven times, and had never shown anyone.

The paper came away. Inside was a smell: wax, and woodsmoke, and indigo. Folded in the middle lay a note that said, in careful Latin letters, *Do not iron. — E.* And on the corner of the wrapping, chewed, was a single green feather.

“She says,” said Tithi, looking at the note, “that you must *not iron* it.”

“A cloth that cannot be ironed,” said Bunny from the door, dripping, “is a cloth with a plan.”

Fayaz unfolded it.

It was a great length of indigo, as deep as the river at midnight, and across the whole of it, in rows, were dots. They were black. They were so black that at first the eye

took them for nothing, a shadow on the weave, a stain of some darker blue. Only when he turned the cloth to the lamp, and the light came across it at a slant, did they rise up out of the dye, one by one by one, each with five small points, each a star, each bright with the dull gloss of wax-resisted ink. They were *bintang.* They were black. They went on to the end of the cloth.

"It is *beautiful,*" breathed Tithi.

"It is a *star-field,*" said their mother.

Their father got up. It took him a long time. He crossed the room with his stick and put out one hand and touched the cloth, as a man touches a thing he has no business touching, and held it to the window, and looked at the weave against the grey light.

"The dye is true," he said. "It does not run." And then, after a pause, to no one: "Tell her thank you."

Fayaz could not speak. Their mother, who had coughed twice and recovered, looked at him with eyes bright from the effort of looking, and asked, in the voice of a woman who has been waiting a year to ask: "This girl. The Java one. Is she kind?"

"She is," said Fayaz, "extremely punctual."

His mother laughed. It cost her a minute's breath. It was worth it.

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At ten that night, which in Rotterdam was six, he propped the laptop on two textbooks, lit a candle in case, and pressed the green button. Behind the screen the room came into being: a long bare studio with steel

windows, a harbour under cloud, a tall drying-rack hung with a dozen unfinished cloths, and a young woman with her hair pinned up by a pencil.

“You are four hours *behind* me,” said Fayaz.

“I know. It is a demotion.” Ermis Larasati put her chin on her fist. Her face was thinner, a little, in the Dutch light, and the tin roof of her laugh was exactly the same. “I have been looking at the clock since April. I have been awake in your yesterday for four months. It is *very* strange, Fayaz. I used to know what would happen to you. Now I must wait.”

“You were never in my future. You were only an hour early.”

“It is the same thing.”

“It is not.” He lifted a corner of the cloth to the camera. In the dark, the black stars did not show. He tilted it. They rose, one by one. “I have counted them.”

“Of course you have.”

“There are nine hundred and ninety-nine.”

She did not answer. In the studio behind her a kettle, which was a Dutch one, began to whistle, and went on whistling, and she did not get up.

“The last is bare,” said Fayaz. “In the corner. A star the shape of the others, but not dyed. Just the cloth. It is the only one you can see without the light.”

“Yes.”

“Is it a mistake?”

“I do not make mistakes in wax,” said Ermis. “I make decisions.”

“What is it for?”

“It is for when the sky is clear,” she said. “I do not know what for. I only know that it is for *then.*”

For some time neither of them spoke. Over Mirpur the monsoon beat out the long drum of the rain on a thousand tin roofs. In Rotterdam the kettle shrieked and, at last, was turned off, because nobody else would.

“Fayaz,” said Ermis.

“Yes.”

“Do not say it.”

“I was not going to.”

“You were going to say that you would tell me everything, if you were free to.”

“I was going to say,” said Fayaz, “that you were kind.”

It was not what she had expected. He saw it in her face. She had been braced, as people are, for the thing that has no name. And what he had given her was the other thing: the sentence she had once handed to him on the other end of a candle, and which he had been carrying since, folded very small, inside a book.

“I have seen it,” he said. “I am four hours ahead of you tonight, and in that time I have already lived this Friday, and I can report that it was *very* good, and that you were kind in it. The studio, the harbour, the kettle.

You were kind.” He stopped, because his voice had done the thing it did when she laughed, only the other way. “I thought you ought to hear it from the future.”

Ermis said nothing at all. She put her hand over her mouth. On the screen, the pencil in her hair slid, and her hair came down, and behind her, in the grey Dutch window, a gull went by. At last she took her hand away and said, in a small and entirely ordinary voice: “It is the first thing anyone has told me from the future that I wanted to hear.”

“Then I will tell you more next week.”

“Fridays.”

“Fridays,” said Fayaz. “Ten, mine. Six, yours.”

“I am *not* going to say *eleven,*” said Ermis, and wept, and was laughing in the same breath, so that the whole feeble connection shook.

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When she had gone he did not sleep. The power failed at midnight, and he lit the candle, and laid the cloth across his knees; and being a man who could not leave a question alone, he began, with a pencil and the back of an old bill from the electricity board, to measure it.

It took him till two. The stars were in rows; he had known that. But the rows were not level. Each lay, by the smallest degree, at a different angle from the row above, so that the whole cloth, from first row to last, was twisted by one steady turn. He drew it, and drew it again, and worked out the angle. It came to fifteen degrees, to the width of a thread.

He sat very still with the pencil in his hand.

Fifteen degrees. It is what the sky turns, in one hour.

Outside, the rain was slackening. Somewhere in the lane a boy was singing a song from a film, with the wrong words. The candle burned straight. And in a rented flat on the third floor, a man with an ironed shirt and nine lakh of debt held a cloth made of nine hundred and ninety-nine black stars and one clear space, and thought, as a man does who has been given a very long sentence in a very small hand, that it would take him a lifetime to finish reading it, and that he had, he found, no objection at all.

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Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0228 and Entry 0595. The old masters set one tile crooked. They were not careless; they were polite. Only a fool lays a perfect floor in the house of God.

Entry 0076 and Entry 0165. A bridge goes both ways. That is the only reason it was built.

Entry 0713 and Entry 0714. Nine hundred and ninety-nine. The thousandth is a place kept. I know something about those. I have kept one myself.

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End of Chapter 47.

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Chapter 48: The Fish Market Fire

“I may have started the fire with one cigarette.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0316

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SCENE I

Marseille. The quay of the Old Port at six in the morning, the day after the worst night in the history of the fish market. Smoke, steam, and ten thousand gulls, all of whom feel personally addressed.

There is nothing so ridiculous, or so sad, as a fire in a fish market.

It is a place built entirely of ice and water. Every stall has its tank, every table its drain, every crate its little coffin of crushed cold. And yet, at ten to four in the morning, with the mistral blowing down the quay like a drunk with a grudge, the polystyrene boxes at the north wall had caught, and the whole thing had gone up in nine minutes, and the fire brigade, arriving to find the blaze put out chiefly by its own stock, had been obliged to stand in a lake of sea bass with their hoses idle.

Nobody was hurt. That was the miracle, and nobody in Marseille had time to mention it, being too busy telling everybody else what had caused the fire.

“Electrical,” announced Mathieu Vidal, fifty-eight, librarian, who classified scandal as he classified books, by subject, author, and date, and who had been at the barrier since half past four with a notebook. “A short in the compressor of the number six freezer. I had it from the *fireman’s cousin.*”

“It was the mistral,” said a fishwife.

“It was the *Spanish*,” said another. “Who were in bed. Which is exactly what they *wanted* us to think.”

In the middle of the blackened aisle, in what had been, till midnight, the stall called *La Daurade Joyeuse,* stood Hugo Martin. He was thirty-five, built like a door, and he was laughing. He had been laughing since five o’clock. The stall was a skeleton of tin; the awning was a blackened sail; the family scales, three generations old, had melted into a small bronze puddle on the slab. And Hugo Martin, fish seller, loud enough to be heard from the Panier to the Prado, stood in the wet ash in rubber boots with his arms spread wide and announced, to a quay of staring people, that the first round of pastis was on the house.

“At six in the morning?” said a policeman.

“A fire is a *festival,* monsieur! Nobody died! The fish went out *gloriously!*”

There is a kind of laughter that is a shout, and a kind that is a shield. Only the second cannot be turned off. At the barrier at the end of the aisle, in the navy jersey and cap of the Old Port ferry, a woman stood very still with her hands in her pockets and did not laugh at all.

Camille Bernard was thirty-three, a ferry pilot, calm and dry as a biscuit. She had piloted the little boat that crosses the harbour from the Town Hall quay to the Place aux Huiles every day for nine years without once being rattled by weather, or tourists, or the Marseillais. She was not rattled now. She was stone. At ten to four that morning she had been standing at the north wall of the market, in the dark, waiting for the five o'clock crossing, with a cigarette between her fingers that she had told every person she knew, in March, she would never touch again.

She had not seen where it fell.

"Madame Bernard," said a young inspector, taking off his cap. "I understand you were on the quay."

"I am always on the quay. I drive a ferry."

"Did you see anything? Smell smoke?"

She thought of the red dot, small as a seed, going out over the dark water on the edge of the wind. She thought, *I looked. I looked at the water.*

"I don't recall," said Camille Bernard.

Behind her, with a hose coiled round one shoulder and a wrench in each pocket, came Colette Lefèvre, thirty-one, plumber, so patient that fishermen came to her to be taught to wait. She had been called in at dawn to inspect the water-mains and had spent the morning defending them from accusation.

"It was not the pipes," said Colette to the inspector, with immense gentleness. "A fire is only a pipe whose water has gone the wrong way. It wants to be some-

where. Tell me where it wanted to be, and I will tell you why it left." She turned, and her eyes, which were kind and slow, rested a moment on Camille's pale face, and she added, to nobody, in the voice of one remarking on the weather: "Funny how often it is a small thing. A washer. A spark. A bit of cold. A little cigarette."

Camille went the colour of the ash.

"What did you say?" said the inspector.

"Nothing," said Colette placidly. "I said it is going to rain."

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SCENE II

The following night. The burnt market, under a clean sharp moon and a ribbon of police tape. The wind has dropped. The smell is smoke, salt and wet char. A single stall light, run off a car battery, shows a broad man sitting on an upturned crate.

He had sent them all home. That was the mark of Hugo: at midnight he had given every fish-wife a hug and every fireman a bass, and told the crowd to go to bed, and then he had sat down alone in the ruin and stopped smiling.

He spoke to the dark, as the cheerful do, when nobody is in a position to be cheered:

They said I laughed. I did. The way you laugh When someone's handed you a thing too large To hold in just one pair of hands, so you Hold up the other side with joking. Father, This was your stall, and his, and

his before. I took it with the scales; I took the name.
I never learned to lose a thing. I learned To make
the losing sound like a good story, And put the story
on the slab, and sell it. Tonight I have no story. I
have ash. If someone came now, quiet, with no joke,
And sat beside me while the ash went cold, I think
I'd tell them how it really was: I smiled so none
should see me not know how.

"I have brought coffee," said a voice at the tape.

He did not jump. He knew the voice; he had known it for nine years, across a stretch of green water, in every weather. She ducked under the ribbon and came across the wet floor with two paper cups, and put one into his hand, and sat down beside him on a second crate, not close, not far, as a ferry lies against a quay.

"It is terrible coffee," said Camille.

"It is the best I have had all day."

"That is not the praise you think."

He laughed, and it was a real laugh this time, small and cracked, and neither of them said anything for a while. A gull walked the length of the ruined slab and inspected the ash for unreasonable hopes. Across the black water the lights of Notre-Dame de la Garde burned on her hill, small and gold.

"You didn't laugh this morning," said Hugo.

"No."

"Everybody else did. They think I'm mad. I let them. It is easier."

“I know.” She turned the cup in her hands. “That’s why I came. I have been sitting in my kitchen since noon trying to think of a way to say it that was better than the way I’m going to say it, and there is none, so I will say it the poor way. Hugo, there is something I must tell you. About the night of the fire.”

He went very still.

“I told you in March that I had stopped smoking,” said Camille. “I said it on the quay. You were selling oysters. You said, *Good, a woman who can stop a thing can stop a boat,* and I was—I was so pleased, Hugo, I have never been so pleased by a thing a man said to me about boats.” She breathed in. “I hadn’t stopped. I had told everyone I had, because I wanted it to be true, and it is very easy to tell people things you want. On Tuesday night I was on the quay at ten to four. By your north wall. I was waiting for the first crossing. And I had one. It was the last one in the packet. I stood there in the wind, with my back to your stall, and I smoked it, and when the wind came round I

Here the page is torn.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

Buenos Aires. La Boca, in the damp middle of July, which here is the middle of winter. A social club of corrugated tin painted the colours of a parrot’s wing; a wooden floor worn pale by sixty years of shoes; and a hall full of people who have all agreed not to look at the dance floor.

It was the night of the anniversary, and no one was dancing.

In Buenos Aires a milonga has laws more binding than any parliament's. The men sit on one side of the hall, the women on the other. A man who wishes to dance does not cross the floor. He looks. He catches the eye of the woman he wants, and nods, once, the smallest of nods, and if she nods back, he comes; and if she looks at her shoes, he has been refused, and nobody in the hall has seen a thing. It is called the *cabeceo.* It is the most merciful form of rejection ever devised by the human race.

Mateo Fernández, thirty-five, tango dancer, arrogant and graceful, had sat on the men's side since nine o'clock. For a year he had danced with nobody. He had danced alone in the dark of his flat with a chair, and at the corner of a rehearsal studio with a mirror, and once, in a moment he did not care to remember, with a coat-stand. But on the floor of a milonga, among the living, he had not taken a woman in his arms since the night his partner died.

"You are staring at the ceiling," said Ramiro Romero, sixty-seven, retired choir director, blunt as a brick and the evening's DJ, from the tiny booth behind the bar.

"I'm resting."

"You are resting with your whole *face.* She is over there. She has been looking at you since the second tanda." He put on the next record. "I choose the music for this room, Mateo, and I will tell you what I have chosen: three tangos and a waltz and a cortina. After the cortina, it is the last tanda. I have put in the one you used to dance to. And I have put it *last.*"

“You are cruel.”

“I am a choirmaster. We believe in resolution.”

On the opposite wall, in a black dress with a plain neckline and her hair drawn tight back, sat Valentina Cruz, thirty-three, tango teacher, proud and guarded, with her hands folded in her lap. She had taught him for a year. She had taught him to lead, in a studio where the sunlight came in at an angle, and she had hated every minute of it, and she had not missed a lesson. She did not look at him. She looked, instead, with great care, at an old woman in the corner who had begun, quite without hurry, to pour mate from a thermos into a gourd.

This was Agustina Benítez, fifty-four, a tea-seller from Rosario who had come three hours by bus because someone ought to. She was gentle, rather deaf, and believed the temperature of water to be the foundation of civilisation.

“It is too hot,” said Agustina, to nobody, tasting. “Water at the boil is a *scream.* A person is not scalded into a conversation. A person is *coaxed.*” She held out the gourd to Valentina, without looking at her. “Take it.”

“I don’t want any, Señora.”

“It is not for wanting. It is for holding. A woman who is holding something is a woman who does not have to hold *herself.*”

And then, from the bench beside Valentina, came a dry old voice. Julieta Romero, eighty, retired ferry hand, who had worked the river-boats of the Riachuelo for forty years and was said to have known every secret that ever crossed it, put a small brown hand over Valentina’s.

“I took them across,” said Julieta. “Your sister and him. Twice a week, when they were poor. They danced on the deck. Nobody asked them to; they did it as other people breathe.” Her eyes, pale with age, did not leave the floor. “She told me on that boat, the last summer. She said, *Julieta, if I go first, make him dance.*”

Valentina did not move.

“I have not told you,” said Julieta, “because I thought you hated him. And then I thought: she is jealous, and that is not hate; it is only love that has been left in the rain.” She patted the hand. “I took the blame once for a thing you did. A broken window. You were seven. It is the only lie I have told in my life. I should like to tell a second, to say that I did not hear her say it. But I did, child. I did.”

In the corner a girl of fourteen, small and suspicious, in school shoes, who had come in from the street to watch the dancers and had not been told to leave, said, quite clearly, in the hush: “Why doesn’t one of them just *nod?*”

It was Lucrecia Medina, from the next block. Nobody answered her.

The cortina came on, a thin sweet curtain of music between one set and the next, and the floor, which had been empty, emptied still further.

Mateo stood. He did not walk. He lifted his eyes across thirty feet of polished wood, in front of the whole hall, and the DJ, and the old women, and the girl in school shoes, and a dead woman’s ghost who had come, perhaps, in the mate-steam, and he nodded.

Valentina looked at her shoes.

For one long second the hall stopped breathing. Then Valentina Cruz, who had been taught from the age of six that a woman refused loses nothing, and a woman who accepts has surrendered something she can never get back, set down the mate-gourd, and raised her head, and nodded.

They met in the middle of the floor. They did not smile. He lifted his arm and she settled into it, the way a thing slips into the place it was always cut for, and the old record began, the one he used to dance to, a slow tango, with a bandoneon that breathed in and out; and they walked.

Mark this, reader: they did not dance *well.* That is the thing the Keeper would have you know. He was stiff. She was angry. Every step was a negotiation. For the first minute there were two of them and a ghost, and for the second the ghost was only a shape of warmth at the edge of the lamp; and by the third there was only a man and a woman crossing a floor, with the dead sister's name unspoken between them like a hand resting lightly on each of their backs. *Go,* it said. *Go on.*

The last tango ended. The cortina began. The floor, by every law of the milonga, cleared. The couples drifted away to their sides, and the men sat down and the women sat down, and Ramiro in his booth, with tears running down into his collar, put on the next tanda and did not need to.

Valentina and Mateo stood alone in the centre of the floor, in the cortina, which is the law of leaving, and did not leave. A man and a woman who stay on the floor af-

ter the curtain have declared a thing before the whole room. They stood there with her hand in his, and the music went on, thin and sweet and unfinished, and neither of them moved toward either wall.

“The girl is right,” said Valentina, very quietly. “I should have nodded first.”

“You are not supposed to nod first.”

“I am a teacher. I have been breaking the rules for years.” She looked up at him. “Mateo. Is this a thing that you can do?”

“I do not know,” said Mateo. “Ask me after the next song.”

“And the one after that?”

“And the one after that.”

On the side wall, a girl of fourteen sniffed and said, with unconcealed superiority, “*Finally.*”

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SCENE IV

New Delhi Railway Station. Platform Six. The tail of the monsoon, at twenty to six in the evening. Every train on the northern line has been halted by the flooding of the Yamuna, and the platform is crowded with the stranded, the sleeping, the praying, and a very great number of sweets.

In nineteen years of driving trains, Ravi Chaudhary had never been late.

It was his only vanity. He was forty-one, a train driver, punctual and patient, able to tell a delay by the hum of the rails; and tonight, for the first time in all those years, he had nowhere to be. The Lucknow line was shut. The river had risen over the tracks at the bridge, and the 5:40 stood on Platform Six with its engine ticking as it cooled, and its driver, in his cap and his blue jacket, had stepped down from the cab and begun, for the first time in his life, to walk the whole length of the train.

At the far end of the platform, on the bench under the pillar, as she had been every evening for eleven years, sat Sunita Verma.

She was thirty-nine, a teacher, wry, resolute, with a cloth bag of exercise books on her knee and a tiffin carrier at her feet, and she did not look up as he came. She had learned, in eleven years, never to look up. It was a kind of discipline. The 5:40 left Platform Six every evening, and each time, as it passed her bench, the driver sounded his horn twice. It was not necessary. It was not in the regulations. It was a sentence in a language that had two words and no grammar.

“You have stopped,” said Sunita.

“The signal is red.”

“It was green for eleven years.”

“It was,” said Ravi gravely, “a very reliable signal.”

On the next bench an old woman, eighty-eight, in a faded cardigan, with a camera round her neck older than most of the trains, lifted her head from her chin. This was Neha Mehra, retired photographer, who had

been taking one photograph a day of Platform Six for sixty years, and who now, with the air of a connoisseur, raised the camera to her eye.

“Don’t mind me,” said Neha. “I am furniture.”

Beside her, wedged between a family of nine and a man asleep on his luggage, sat a plump young woman from Jaipur surrounded by forty tin trays. Pooja Singh, thirty-four, a baker, generous, had been on her way to a wedding in Lucknow with three hundred jalebis, and had now, in the course of a six-hour wait, given away two hundred and ninety, including a number to a policeman, who had accepted them under protest.

“Take one!” said Pooja Singh, thrusting a tray at the driver. “The syrup is melting. A jalebi that is not eaten is a tragedy, and I have been very sad all day.”

“I cannot. I am on duty.”

“You are on a platform in a flood, sir. The only duty you have is to be *sweet.*”

He took one, a small gold spiral, dripping. Sunita took one too, because it would have been ridiculous not to, and the two of them stood and ate in silence, before a camera and a baker and an audience of nine.

“I have a question,” said Sunita, at last, licking her thumb. “I have had it for eleven years.”

“Ask it.”

“Why twice?”

“Twice?”

“The horn. Two blasts. Why not one? Why not three?”

Ravi Chaudhary, driver of the 5:40 to Lucknow, took off his cap. He turned it round, once, in his hands.

"One is a warning," he said. "Three is an emergency. Two is—" He looked for the word and found only the true one. "Two is *hello.* It is what a man says when he cannot stop the train."

"And now that you have?"

"Now it is the wrong number," said Ravi. "I will have to think of another."

Sunita, who had spent eleven years teaching children that there is no such thing as an impossible sum, set down her bag. "Sit," she said. "The bench is long."

"I am in uniform."

"The bench," said Sunita Verma, "does not care."

He sat. A respectful two feet of wood lay between them, and a third of a jalebi, and eleven years of platform. On the far bench, Neha Mehra took her photograph, and was heard to say softly, "*That's* the one." The rain, which had never entirely stopped since July, began again, drumming upon the great arched roof of the station; and in a signal-box a mile away a man who had worked the points for forty years looked at a red light and, for reasons he could not have explained, decided to leave it red for a little longer.

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Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0316 and Entry 0585. A cigarette is a very small fire. So is a word.

Entry 0230 and Entry 0027: they did not leave the floor. Entry 0363 and Entry 0292: the signal stayed red a long while. And look: the calendar has turned. The storm has used up its thunder. What comes next is a clearing.

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End of Chapter 48.

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ACT V — THE TEMPEST CLEARS

The Chorus

The storm is spent; the sea lies glass and grey, And one by one the ships come home to shore; What burned is ash, what drowned is borne away, And what was owed is paid, and owed no more. Now open every letter ever kept, Now speak the word that waited, locked and still, For here are those who laughed, and those who wept, And those who learned at last to bend their will. Look up: the dark is full of unseen light; Each hidden star hath held its steadfast place; And one, the thousandth, burning out of sight, Was lit for you, and keeps you in its grace. So close the book, but leave the window wide: The dark is not a wall; it is a guide.

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Chapter 49: Snow Sculptor

“Everything I make will melt, and I have kept you anyway.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0296

✦ ✦ ✦

Enter the Chorus, in an overcoat, shaking off the last of a very long storm.

The thunder’s done. The sea lies down like glass.
Now come the rings, the vows, the hands in hands;
Now every unsaid word is let to pass Across a threshold, over frozen lands, Past tin-roofed chapels, past a trampled green, And finds its owner.
Reader, it is time. Be glad awhile. Be glad that you have seen How far a sentence goes, and how it climbs.

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SCENE I

Sapporo, Hokkaido. A shop on a side street behind Odori Park, in the last week of October. The sky is the colour of a pewter spoon. The air smells of milk, caramel, and a snow that has not yet decided to come.

There is a particular kind of lunacy peculiar to Hokkaido, which is that in the coldest city in Japan, in the coldest week of the year, the people line up for ice cream.

They line up at the shop of the Nakamura family, a narrow shop with a red awning and a painted cow, where the soft-serve is made of milk from a single farm, with a burnt-caramel swirl that nobody has ever been able to copy. The queue went out of the door and past the bicycle rack. It was held together by schoolchildren, elderly gentlemen with their hats pulled down, and a retired nurse of seventy-six named Haruto Shimizu, who had come every afternoon for four years and ordered one small cone, and who sat on the bench outside in his good coat, licking it in perfect silence.

Behind the counter, in a white cap and an apron stained with five seasons of caramel, was Yuki Nakamura.

She was thirty-five, cheerful and stubborn, and she had run the shop since her father's last winter. She had inherited the recipe, the cow, and a lease that ran out in March. It was not a catastrophe. It was only a number, and a man at a bank, and a long winter in which, as she had cheerfully explained to the cow, she would sell ice cream to people who ought to be at home. Her father's shop was all she had. She had said so in a letter once, to an old woman in Cornwall, and had been horrified to see it in print.

"You have a visitor," said Nanami Hayashi, from the doorway.

Nanami was forty-six, a chef, and the owner of the *iza-kaya* next door, a small fierce woman with arms like a stevedore's and a laugh like a pan dropped on a stone floor. She had once walked into bear country to retrieve a mushroom and, as she told it, the bear had apologised. She also blamed herself for everything, and would not share the credit.

"I do not have time for visitors."

"It is your sculptor."

"He is not *my* sculptor."

"He is standing at the back door with the face of a man who has swallowed a snowball. He will not come in unless you ask him. Ask him in, Yuki, before I put him in the soup."

He stood in the yard at the back, a lean man of thirty-seven with a long face and hands too large for his sleeves, in a heavy coat dusted with a fine grey powder that was not snow. Takumi Ishikawa had been a snow sculptor for fifteen years. Every February, at the great festival in the park, he built a crane, a castle, a tall Buddha with a patient face, from packed snow as high as a house; and every March it went back to water and ran down the drains of the city. He had made two hundred and eleven things, and had not one of them left.

"I have come to say," said Takumi, "that this is my last season. I told the festival committee on Monday." He looked at his large hands, as if they had been guilty of something. "Every thing I have made for fifteen years has gone to a drain. I am thirty-seven. I think I should

like to make a thing that stays." He paused. "I came to ask whether I might take the last of my things out of your freezer."

There was a silence in the yard. A pigeon landed on the drainpipe, and thought better of it.

"*My* freezer," said Yuki.

"The walk-in. At the back. Behind the milk." He did not meet her eye. "You said, years ago, I could have a shelf. For *practice.*"

"I thought you meant some *practice* ice."

"It is a bit more than practice."

Yuki Nakamura put down the scoop. She walked through the kitchen, past a tub of cream and a colander of roasted chestnuts, to the heavy steel door of the walk-in freezer, which she had not opened for anything but milk in six months. She pulled the handle. A breath of white poured out round her ankles like a ghost that had been waiting in a corridor.

On the back shelf, behind a crate of cream, in a nest of folded cloth, stood a small figure of ice.

It was the size of a pear. It was perfectly clear. It was a woman's head and shoulders, turned a little to the side, with her mouth open and her eyes screwed shut and her nose wrinkled up, and it was laughing. It was the laugh of someone helpless with it, a laugh that comes up from the stomach and takes the whole face in its fist.

It was, quite unmistakably, Yuki.

“I made it in February,” said Takumi, behind her. “Five years ago. At the festival. You gave me a cone because I was blue with cold, and I said something, I cannot remember what, and you laughed. I thought: *that will not be there tomorrow.* And so I made it before it could go. And then I did not want it to go. So I came to your shop with a story about a *shelf.*” His voice, which had never once failed him before a hundred thousand people, was thin. “Everything I make will melt. I have always known that. I did not want this one to.”

“You have been coming in here every month. For *five years.* You said you were checking the temperature.”

“I was. Of it.”

Behind them a throat was cleared with gentleness and a faint tinge of triumph. Nanami Hayashi stood in the door of the kitchen, arms folded.

“I found it in April,” said Nanami. “I borrowed a corner of the shelf for a tray of scallops and it *looked* at me. Who else laughs with her whole nose? I have stood on that information for six months. I am not made for silence. When I know something, I *boil* it.”

“You *knew?*” said Yuki.

“I blame myself entirely.”

“You are not *to blame,* Nanami.”

“That,” said Nanami, “is what I always say, and nobody ever agrees.”

Yuki Nakamura turned back to the shelf. She laughed at everything, which is a trade like any other. She did not laugh now. She put out one finger and touched the

cold cheek of the ice, and it was so cold that it burned, and left on the surface of the figure the smallest, clearest print.

"It will melt," said Yuki, "if you take it out."

"Yes."

"And if I leave it in, it stays."

"Yes. In a freezer. Behind the milk."

"Behind the *milk,*" said Yuki. "For *five years.*" She breathed in, and the air was so cold it hurt, and she smiled, quite helplessly, with her whole face, and the ice, in the light, seemed for one second to laugh back. "That is a stupid place to keep a woman."

"I know."

"Take it outside."

"It will melt."

"It's *October.*" She said it fiercely. She picked up the figure, in both hands, with the cloth, and carried it through the kitchen, through the back door, into the grey yard and the smell of coming weather, with Takumi hurrying after her, arms half out, as if after an escaped bird.

She set it on the doorstep.

It was twenty to five. The sky, which had been holding its breath since morning, let it go. A flake came down, as large as a coin, and settled on the shoulder of the small ice woman. Another followed; then a dozen; then the air was full of it, white and soundless and thick, the first

snow of the winter, falling on the shop and the cow and the head of a retired nurse on a bench, who looked up with great satisfaction and said, to nobody, “There.”

“In Sapporo,” said Yuki, watching, “whatever you give to the first snow is kept till April.”

“I know.”

“Then it will be here in April.”

“Yes.”

“And in April it will melt.”

“Yes.”

“Then in April,” said Yuki Nakamura, turning to him, with snow in her hair and her whole bright stubborn face alight, “you will have to come and stand beside it. And we shall see what we think.”

He could not answer. He took the cone she put in his hand, burnt-caramel, and stood in the falling white and ate it, a grown man in the snow, weeping gently; and the retired nurse on the bench, who had said nothing in four years but *a small one, please,* said, with deep contentment: “I envy him.”

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SCENE II

Manchester. The bowling green of a public park, on a damp Saturday in the third week of October. A marquee, an urn, a trestle of sandwiches and thirty folding chairs

in a quivering row. And, on the green, a ring of grass cut with a straight edge, a little darker than the grass around it, like a note.

The bride was eleven minutes late, which in a woman who had once marched across a football pitch without missing a beat was considered a sign of the times.

"She is never *late,*" said Callum Brown, forty, euphonium, shy as a clam and best man, tugging at his collar. He had lost his speech in the car and been left with only the opening: *Friends.*

"A bride," said Mr. George Lowe, sixty-eight, better known to the district as Pennywhistle, "is not late. She is *delayed by her own beauty.* I have written it into the poem." He patted his bulging breast pocket. He had come in a charity-shop tail-coat of which the left tail was an inch longer than the right, whistling a tune that was not a tune. "Nineteen stanzas. It does not rhyme *and* it does not scan, and it is the best thing I have ever written."

"You will not disappoint us, Pennywhistle."

"I have never been anything else," said Pennywhistle.

William Hartley stood on the green in a suit that his mother had pressed so thoroughly it had developed a personality. He was thirty, a groundsman for the city parks, and the ground he stood on was not, strictly, this ground at all.

He had lifted it in the dark, with a spade. On the night before the diggers came to Marsden Road, he had cut the centre circle into four hundred squares of turf and carried them to a van borrowed from a fishmonger

named Harvey Clarke, which had smelled of haddock for a month. He had laid them that same week on the park's green, in a perfect circle, and told nobody. They had taken. The old black earth of a hundred years of Saturdays had put out roots in a new place and held. This was where he had chosen to be married.

"Is that *it?*" said a small voice at his elbow.

Hannah Hughes, fourteen now, in a blazer with the cuffs let down twice, regarded the circle of dark turf with the eye of a lifelong inspector. "It's smaller."

"Everything is smaller when you move it."

"That's not true," said Hannah. "Poppy says the *note* is bigger." She considered. "She's here."

She was. She came through the gap in the hedge on her mother's arm, and the thirty folding chairs rose with a sound like a flock lifting off a lake. Poppy Ashworth was twenty-nine, a school music teacher, loud in every way a woman can be; she wore a cream dress and Doc Martens, and carried, instead of flowers, a cornet dented from a fall off a coach, its bell wrapped in ivy and a yellow ribbon. Her mother, Lucy Wilson, fifty-nine, an airline captain in full uniform, treated every plan as a flight plan and had been heard to tell the vicar, "We are cleared for landing, Reverend, in three minutes. Please confirm the runway."

"The *grass,*" said Poppy under her breath, at the edge of the circle. Her face crumpled, and uncrumpled. "William. You've brought the *pitch.*"

"Only the middle."

"You moved the *middle.*"

"It's where you stood."

She put the cornet to her lip. She did not play. She looked at the dark circle at her feet with a face that said what a hundred speeches could not, and then she stepped over the edge of the turf onto the very place where she had, in the rain, in front of ten thousand people, held a note until the world forgot to breathe.

They were married by the vicar, who was Methodist and brief. They were married in front of Grace Taylor, seventy-nine, retired pharmacist, whom Poppy had noticed at the back of the church hall every Wednesday for two years and never once seen speak to anyone, and who sat in the front row with her handbag on her knees, stiff as a duchess, and cried the whole way through without a sound. They were married with Hannah Hughes as official witness, who signed the register in green felt-tip with the tip of her tongue out, and with the florist, Mrs. Brown, whispering to the neighbours that it was the *prettiest* bouquet she had ever done, though the bride had not carried it.

Then Pennywhistle read his poem.

It was, as promised, nineteen stanzas. It did not rhyme and did not scan. He had arrived at the final one by the road of exhaustion and wept, loudly, as he began, so that the opening couplet was inaudible; and the rest ran, as nearly as anyone could make out:

A groundsman and a cornet! Mark the pun! (I have
been up all night.) The thing is done. They stood,
and one was grass and one was brass, And neither

could say, "Love," but both said "Pass." Now they are wed. The tunnel's left behind. And may all days be level. And be kind.

There was a silence, and then a roar, and then, from the back of the marquee, from a row of old men in maroon jackets gone the colour of wine, came a long, slow note on a trombone. And another. And the whole band, which had folded, and was a very good shape, stood up between the sandwiches and played the tune that Poppy had always said was too private; and she raised her cornet to join.

William Hartley did not wave. He stood with his cap in his hand. He nodded, very slightly, across the grass.

"You are not going to say it," said Poppy, between breaths.

"I've mown it. It's in B."

"I know," said Poppy. "It's the best thing you've ever said."

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

Kano, northern Nigeria. The compound of the Garba family, in the old city, on the eve of a wedding. Henna night. A courtyard of red earth under a dusk the colour of tea; the smell of woodsmoke, suya, and sweet crushed leaves; women's laughter going up from the roof like birds.

The bride was late for her own henna night, because a baby had arrived early.

“A midwife,” Zainab Bello was explaining to the circle of aunts, “is the only bride who may be late because *someone else* came sooner.” Zainab was sixty-nine, a retired headmistress and the greatest gossip in Kano; she held every marriage, scandal and recipe of four generations in her memory, and held court on a mat with a glass of sweet *kunun* in one hand and an entire wedding in the other.

“She delivered a boy at dusk,” said Aisha Danjuma, twenty-eight, a bus conductor, who hid her fears, as conductors do, in a joke. “The father wept. He named the baby *Yusuf.*”

“After the *groom?*”

“After the *tailor.*”

“That will be *confusing,* in the register,” said Zainab, with deep relish.

In the doorway, with her sleeves still rolled and a smell of antiseptic about her, stood Hauwa Garba. She was thirty, resolute and tender, and her hands, which had caught four hundred and thirty-one babies, were shaking a little now, as the hands of the brave do when the work is over. She had walked home in the dusk past the dye-pits, where the great clay vats of indigo steamed in the last light, and she had not stopped to change.

At the other end of the courtyard, on a stool, in a white *babban riga,* sat the old man who would give her away. Bashir Garba was eighty-six, a retired kiosk-keeper, her grandfather, and absent-minded to the point

of poetry. As she came into the light he looked up, and his face cleared, as a window clears when the cloth is drawn across.

“Hauwa,” said Bashir. “I wanted to be a singer.”

“I know, Baba.”

“I never told anyone. For sixty years I sold sweets and sang to the kiosk, and the kiosk never said a word. I should like to sing at the tying of the marriage. Is that permitted?”

“I will ask the Malam.”

“Do,” said Bashir. “It has only one verse.”

It was permitted. The next morning, in the great mosque, after prayer, before two hundred men in white, with Malam Sani Lawal, forty-four and patient as the earth, seated with the book open on his knee, it was Bashir Garba who gave his granddaughter to the tailor who had spent a year of nights sewing her a dress. He gave her in the proper words, with the dower named and the groom’s consent heard three times. And then, because the Malam bowed his head, and nobody wished to be the man to forbid it, the grandfather stood, lifted his chin, and in a thin and cracked and perfectly pitched old voice, to the arches of a mosque that had heard centuries of prayer, sang his one verse:

I sold the sweets of other men’s delights Through sixty years of days and sixty nights. Now one sweet thing is mine, and I have none To give her but a song. Let that be done.

When the last note went out, the Malam was seen to put one hand across his eyes. Yusuf Abdullahi, thirty-three, tailor, devout and modest, who had not looked up from the ground the whole of the ceremony, looked up. He had sat at a treadle machine for fifteen years sewing other people's happiness, and had never made a thing for himself. His lip shook, and he said *Alhamdulillah,* very low, like a man setting down a long burden, and two hundred men said it after him, and it went up like a wave.

✦ ✦ ✦

They gave her to him at dusk, in the old way, with ululation and a procession of girls bearing basins of rice and yards of Dutch wax cloth on their heads.

The dress was blue and gold. It had been cut, a year before, for a wedding that never took place, and sewn with seams so fine you could not find them with a fingernail. She put it on in the room at the back of the Garba compound, with her mother and her aunts and nine-year-old Musa Danjuma, the neighbour's small son, who had been told to stay out and was peeping through the door like a cat. She had insisted on the dress. They had told her it was unlucky.

"It was meant for another man's bride," Zainab Bello had said. "People will remember."

"It was cut for me," said Hauwa. "I knew whose dress it was, and I waited. It was the only thing in the whole business that was never a mistake."

When she came out into the courtyard, hennaed hands held before her, the singing went up. The tailor stood in the lamplight with the ring-maker at his shoulder: Aminu Yakubu, fifty, goldsmith, comic, a comic, who had been arguing for a week that the bride's finger was the wrong size and could not, on principle, apologise.

"I have made it *exactly* to the measure," said Aminu, handing the gold band to the groom.

"It is too small," said Yusuf, trying.

"It is the *finger* that is wrong."

He took the ring back. He looked at it. He looked at the bride's hand, lifted, patient, amused. A great stillness fell upon the courtyard. And Aminu Yakubu, who had not said *I am sorry* in fifty years, was heard to say, in a small hoarse voice, "*I measured the wrong hand.*"

The whole compound laughed until the old man on the stool had to be fanned, and Hauwa Garba, who had not wept at the birth of four hundred and thirty-one children, nor at her grandfather's song, wept now at last, and laughed, and held out her left hand, which was the correct one.

Mark this, reader, says the Keeper. *The only mistake in the whole affair was a goldsmith's. A thing may be sewn for a year in the dark and fit the day it is put on.*

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0296 and Entry 0556. In Sapporo, what is given to the first snow is kept until April. I did not know this. I am pleased to have learned it at the

end.

Entry 0639 and Entry 0542. Four hundred squares of turf. A man who will not say “love” will carry a pitch across a city on his back.

Entry 0730 and Entry 0194. The dress was cut for her. It was always cut for her. What a tailor makes in silence is a vow, and the cloth keeps it.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 49.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 50: Cigars and Letters

“I roll one note into every box for you.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0207

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE I

Havana, Cuba. A cigar factory in the old city, ten o’clock in the morning. A long hall of high windows and tall green shutters; two hundred wooden tables; the smell of cured leaf, which is the smell of a very old library that has been set gently on fire.

At the head of the hall, on a little raised platform with a lamp and a glass of water, the factory’s reader was reading the newspaper aloud to the rollers. On Fridays the reader was the director, who would let nobody else.

It is an old Havana custom, and the hall was proud of it. For a hundred and fifty years a reader has sat above the tables and read to the workers while they work: the papers first, then a novel, a chapter a day, so that a man might spend thirty years rolling cigars and come out having heard all of Dumas twice. The director, Yoel Cabrera, fifty-five, had been a newsagent in Trinidad before the factory made him its master; he was bookish, hopeless with time, and read the headlines with such relish that the rollers depended on him as on weather.

At the fourth table from the window, under the great fan, a man of forty-four rolled a cigar.

Héctor Álvarez did it as he had done it for twenty-six years, with the round blade in his right hand and the leaf on the board beneath his left: the filler gathered, the wrapper laid on at a slant, the cigar turned and smoothed under the heel of the palm, the head capped with a dab of gum. He was romantic and wry. He was known in the factory for the speed of his hands and for a habit that nobody mentioned. In every box of twenty-five he filled, before the lid went down, he laid one folded slip of paper beneath the cedar.

He had done it for six years. He had sent out, by his own count, four thousand and twelve.

“You have the face of a man composing,” said Armando Delgado from the next table, thirty-three, a journalist, loyal, restless, and shameless. “You are rolling a *sonnet.* I have a column in the paper. *The Cigar Roller Who Writes to Strangers.* Four hundred words and a photograph.”

“Armando.”

“I am not apologising for the idea.”

“Nobody has asked you to,” said Héctor, and bent to his leaf.

On the platform, Yoel Cabrera, who had reached the sporting results with unstoppable joy, said without looking up: “Is that a visitor at the door?”

It was a woman. She was forty-one, in a plain blue dress, with a canvas bag on her shoulder and a battered letter in her hand, and she stood in the doorway with her back very straight, like someone who has rehearsed a speech on a bus and forgotten it at the door. Her name was Rosa Hernández. She taught nine-year-olds at a school on the Malecón, and read aloud to them every Sunday evening on the sea-wall from a green book with a broken spine, because her classroom had no roof worth the name and the sea was free.

"Excuse me," said Rosa. "I am looking for the man who writes the notes."

Two hundred rolling hands stopped.

"There is no such man," said Armando Delgado quickly.

"There is a letter," said Rosa, and held it up. "It came from Madrid. It took four months, which I am told is fast. My sister bought a box of your cigars for her husband's birthday in a shop near the Plaza Mayor, and under the lid she found this." She unfolded the slip. Her hand shook very slightly, and her voice, which could hold thirty nine-year-olds in silence in a gale, did not. "It says, *To the teacher who reads to the children on the Malecón on Sunday evenings, from a green book. I do not know your name or street.* And my sister wrote, in her own hand, across the top: *Rosa, isn't this you?*"

Nobody breathed.

And then, in the fourth row, a man put down a blade.

"It is," said Héctor Álvarez, "a very bad poem."

"It is not a poem. It is a *letter.*"

"It rhymes."

"Only a little. It is the only thing about it I am proud of." He stood up, wiping his hands on his apron, a lean man with a grey streak in his hair and a face that had, to his own astonishment, turned the colour of the leaf. "I saw you once. Six years ago. I was walking along the wall with a box under my arm, and a woman was reading to a ring of children, and they were so quiet that a wave came over the wall and nobody *moved.* I thought, *somebody should say to that woman that she has been seen.* And I had a pen. And I had, in the box under my arm, a place to put it."

"Six years," said Rosa.

"It is not a fast method."

"You wrote to me every day for six years and did not *know my name?*"

"I know it *now,*" said Héctor. "I am very pleased with it."

There was a roar from the hall, the roar of two hundred cigar-rollers who have kept a secret for six years and would have died rather than tell. Armando Delgado, scarlet, leapt up on his stool and shouted, "I *knew* about it," and Yoel Cabrera, from the platform, said, with the air of a man handed a headline, "Madam, would you care to *read* it? Aloud. It is the custom. I am a newsagent. I recognise a headline."

"But it is *his,*" said Rosa.

“A note that has crossed the Atlantic twice,” said Yoel, “has the right to be heard.”

She did not know afterwards how she got up the three steps. She stood above two hundred tables and the great fan turning, and found that the habit of reading aloud was a handrail. She read it, as she read everything, steadily, to the back of the room. And the thing she read was this:

I do not know your name or street, Nor if your coffee’s sour or sweet; But I have seen the green book’s spine, The children hushed, the sea in line. I roll this note inside the leaf And send it out past port and reef, To say what I have never said: That someone sees you, and has read.

When she had finished, nobody spoke for a time. The fan turned. In the fourth row, Héctor’s old master, Raúl Delgado, seventy-five, who dreamed through most of the day and woke only at crises, lifted his head and murmured, quite distinctly: “At last.”

“I have to tell you,” said Rosa Hernández, from the platform, to the whole hall and to one man in an apron, “that I am not an easy woman. My sister left. She is in Madrid. I am still deciding if I may follow. I do not know if the answer is *here.*”

“I did not ask for an answer,” said Héctor.

“I know. That is why I am saying it.”

“Then say it again, on Sunday. On the wall. To the children.” He swallowed. “I will come. I will stand a long way back. I will not say anything. A wave may come over the wall. I should like to see what you do.”

“I shall go on reading,” said Rosa.

“That,” said Héctor Álvarez, “was exactly what I had hoped.”

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

Hoi An, Vietnam. The river, on the night of the full moon of the eighth month. Ten thousand paper lanterns, a hundred small boats, and a young woman at the waterside with a star.

The star was red.

It was a five-pointed lantern of bamboo and paper, the kind that children carry at the Mid-Autumn Festival, with a candle in the middle and a thin red glow that makes the skin of whoever holds it look briefly well. Hà Trần had made ten thousand lanterns in her life, in a workshop in Huế that smelled of paste and cut bamboo, by a method her grandmother taught her. She was twenty-seven, gentle, luminous, and dying; and she had wished, as one makes the last wish on a long list, to make one more.

“I did not want to be pitied,” said Hà.

“I know,” said Quân.

“I want you to remember I said it. I do not want people to look at me as though I were something to be sorry for.”

“I am not looking at you that way.”

“How are you looking at me?”

“Like a man,” said Quân Nguyễn, twenty-eight, street photographer, entirely out of excuses, “who has four hundred and twelve pictures of you in a box in Hanoi, and has never shown you one.”

She stood still. Beside her on the quay, Hương Bùi, thirty-six, a carpenter and her best friend, who had built the little wooden boat with her own hands and cried quietly over every plank, stepped back a pace into the shadows.

“I took them every day,” said Quân. “Since the first morning. You were folding paper at the window and you did not see me. I told myself it was work. But you were *never* on the street, Hà. You were in the window. I was only looking in.” His voice cracked. “I never showed you because I thought you would know. And then you would be sorry for *me,* and I could not bear it.”

“Show me.”

“I have not got them here.”

“Yes, you have.” She smiled at him, and for a moment, under the red of the star, the illness was not in her face at all. “You have been carrying that bag since Hanoi. Show me, Quân.”

It was a flat box, in an oilcloth bag. He opened it on the stone beside the river, and the first print was of a young woman at a window in the thin gold light of early morning, with a strip of bamboo between her teeth and a paste-brush in one hand, completely intent; and the second, of the same woman, laughing at something out of the frame; and the third, her hands alone, the light

moving through the thin paper; and the hundredth. She looked at every one. It took a long time. Behind them the festival went on, with drums and dragon-dancers.

“I look,” said Hà, at last, very slowly, “like someone who is not afraid.”

“You are not.”

“No.” She put the last print down, carefully, with the others. “No, I do not think I am. Isn’t that odd? I thought I should be, and I did not know where it had gone. It is *here.* In these. I did not know a person could be looked at like that and be well.”

She knelt, then, with a care that cost her, and lit the candle in the middle of the star. The red light came up and lit her face. Then Hương, without a word, slid the little boat into the water; and Hà set the lantern in it; and the river took it, as rivers do.

It was not the best lantern she had ever made. It was a little crooked at the third point, where her hand had trembled. But it floated out into the black water beside ten thousand others, a small red star among stars, and caught the light of the full moon, so that for a moment it seemed to be two.

“Do not photograph this one,” said Hà.

“I will not.”

“Look at it instead.”

Quân Nguyễn, who had not been without a camera in eleven years, took the strap off his neck, and put the camera down on the stones, and stood beside her, and looked.

She died four nights later in Huế, in her aunt's house, in her own bed, with the window open, without pain. The lantern in the river, as far as anyone could tell, burned till morning. In the workshop, on the long strings where the paper lanterns hang to dry, Hương Bùi found, the following week, four hundred and twelve photographs pinned in rows, a pale and shining river of a woman looking up from her work; and underneath the last, in careful pencil, in Hà's crooked hand: *Do not take these down.*

They are there still.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

Marrakech, Morocco. A spice stall on the edge of the great square, at the hour when the sun goes to bronze. Cones of saffron, cumin, ground orange peel; a smell like a hundred kitchens opening at once. Behind the counter, a man with a honeyed voice and a piece of paper.

For twenty years Youssef Benali had sold spices by memory.

It was a remarkable accomplishment, and he had hidden it with great skill. He knew a hundred and forty spices by smell and colour and the weight of a handful, and the exact blend of the *ras el hanout* his father had sold, which had twenty-seven ingredients and was said to turn bad news to good. What he did not know, because no one had ever been patient enough to teach him and he had been too proud to ask, was how to read the words on the sacks.

Today, he was going to read a letter.

“Do not look at me,” said Youssef.

“I am not looking at you,” said Salma Idrissi, twenty-eight, calligrapher, exacting and kind, who stood at the counter with her hands behind her back and her whole attention on him, in the way a clock is not looking at a pendulum. “I’d like a quarter-kilo of patience.”

“We have run out.”

“Then read.”

He held the paper at arm’s length, in both hands, as if it might go off. It was a half-sheet of thick cream, and on it, in black ink, in a hand that began rather bravely and grew less sure toward the foot, were forty-one words in Arabic. They had been written in ten days, with a reed pen she had given him, every stroke traced seventeen times in a notebook, in the back room of his shop, at night, under a single bulb.

On a pile of cumin sacks sat Mehdi Bennani, thirty-six, clockmender and self-appointed examiner, the only man in the Medina who could be trusted to be unkind to the truth. Beside him sat Madame Khadija Tazi, sixty-nine, retired judge, who had spent thirty years deciding whether men were telling the truth, and who listened with her hands folded and grave courtesy.

“I shall read it now,” said Youssef.

“Do,” said Madame Tazi gently.

He read it slowly, one word at a time, with his finger moving under each line, in the honeyed voice that for twenty years had persuaded Frenchwomen to buy saf-

fron they did not want. He stumbled at the seventh word, and went back. He stumbled at the nineteenth, and went back again; and the Keeper tells you only that when he reached the end his voice was no longer the honeyed one but a plain, shaken, boyish one that belonged to nobody but himself:

I could not read until I met you. I could not write. I hid it well. Today I wrote your name. I knew you. And you, who knew, said nothing. Tell Me how to learn the rest. I'm slow. I have the time. I'd like to know.

"Thirty-one," said Mehdi Bennani.

"What?"

"Thirty-one of the forty-one words are *correctly spelled.* The rest are *artistic.*" He sniffed. "I am not impressed."

"It is a *start,*" said Salma. Her eyes were shining, and her voice, usually so exact, was not exact at all. "It is *more* than I wrote in my first year." She took the paper from him and held it against her chest. "Youssef. I would teach you every letter, if you asked."

"I am asking."

"Then tomorrow. Dawn. The back room. Bring the pen."

"I have never been so frightened in my life," said Youssef Benali, "and I would like to do it every morning."

Madame Tazi, who had heard ten thousand confessions and was a woman of few words, rose, shook out her robe, and said to the entire shop, to the saffron and

the cumin, in the dry, kind voice of the Bench: “The court finds that the accused is *not guilty,* and that the prosecution is in love.”

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SCENE IV

Accra, Ghana. A house in Osu with a green gate and a great many chairs, on a Saturday in November. A knocking ceremony. Gold cloth, brown envelopes, six cases of drinks, and, standing in a straight yellow row along the wall like a choir who have lost their music, eleven taxi-drivers.

They had come to witness, and they did it as they did everything: in unison.

“Mr. Mensah is *late,*” said the driver at the head of the row.

“*LATE,*” said the other ten.

The first was Quaye, a man of sixty with a face like a boiled sweet, who had driven for Kwame Mensah for nine years and spoke, when he spoke, for the whole fleet; and the fleet repeated the last word of every sentence, a Greek chorus schooled in minibuses. They were known throughout Accra as the Taxi-Chorus.

“He is not late,” said a voice from the gate. “He is *taking the long way.*”

“*WAY,*” said the Chorus.

Kwame Mensah, thirty-one, taxi-fleet owner, generous with strangers and stingy with feeling, stood in the gateway in a kente cloth of gold and black, his uncles at his

back and a bottle of schnapps in his hands, looking as if he were being driven to his own execution at sixty kilometres an hour.

A knocking ceremony is how a Ghanaian marriage begins. The groom's family comes to the bride's door and *knocks.* They are let in. The bride's spokesman, an *okyeame* with a gold-topped staff, asks their business; the drinks are brought; the list is read. There is a great deal of laughter. But there is also a moment of silence at the heart of it, when the father of the bride is asked whether he consents.

Abena Owusu's father stood up.

He was sixty-two, Kojo Darko, a lawyer, and suspicious by trade. He had not spoken to Kwame Mensah in six years, since a debt of the family's was found to have been paid by a person who would not be named, and the family was told the creditor had forgiven it. In Accra everybody knows who pays what. And nobody says.

He walked to the middle of the room, through the chairs and the drinks and the eleven yellow shirts, with a brown envelope in his hand, and held it out to the groom.

"It is the sum," said Kojo Darko.

"I do not know what you mean."

"Mr. Mensah." The old lawyer's voice shook, as an old tree shakes in no wind. "Six years ago, a man whose name was on no paper paid a debt of mine to a bank. He let me believe it had been forgiven. I knew within a week who had done it. A lawyer *knows.* I said nothing, because I was ashamed, and because I could not pay. I

have paid it back now. Every cedi. I should like you to *count* it, because I was proud of you every day of those six years, and I told you it was nothing, and it was *not* nothing. And I cannot give you a daughter until I have given you back your money."

In the silence, Abena stood up. She was twenty-eight, a pharmacist, sharp-tongued and scrupulous, in gold and green, and she had her chin lifted in the way of a woman who has long ago decided how a thing will be done and has been waiting for the others to arrive. She crossed the room. She stopped in front of Kwame.

"I know who paid it," said Abena. "I always knew. I have been waiting for you to say."

And Kwame Mensah, who had never in his life been out of arguments, opened his mouth, and the thing that came out of it, after six years of silence, was the only true sentence he had.

"I paid your father's debt," said Kwame, "and let you think it was forgiven."

"You did."

"I was afraid that if I said it, you would marry me for the money."

"I am a *pharmacist,*" said Abena. "I would have marched in here with a *ledger.*"

The room broke into laughter and weeping and the great boom of the *okyeame's* voice, shouting that it was *settled.* Kwame took the envelope. He counted it, in the middle of the room, in front of everybody, note by note,

with the face of a man doing the hardest sum of his life; and when he had finished, he said, in a voice quite steady:

"It is correct."

"*CORRECT,*" said the Taxi-Chorus.

He handed it to his bride. "For the refrigerator," said Kwame. "For the pharmacy. The one that keeps breaking. I have been meaning to buy it for years, and I could not find a reason."

"Is that a gift?"

"It is a *fare,*" said Kwame, "which is only a gift that has been agreed to."

And at the wall, eleven men in yellow shirts broke formation for the first and last time in their history, ran forward, and carried him bodily around the room, with Quaye at their head, weeping, shouting, in a voice that went out over the whole of Osu:

"*A BRIDE SHOULD BE DRIVEN, NOT DRAGGED!*"

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0207 and Entry 0364. A note put under a lid goes round the world and comes home. Entry 0439 and Entry 0502: he reads the words he could not. Entry 0625 and Entry 0941: a debt paid in silence is a letter written in another currency.
Entry 0469. I have read your four hundred and twelve photographs, little lantern-maker. You were never once pitied. You were looked at, which is

rarer, and which is better. The light on the river was yours. Let it burn.

Now the tide is coming in. Mark it, Keeper. The tide takes a long time to turn, and then it turns all at once.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 50.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 51: Tea and Tide

“A man died on my watch and I have not forgiven myself.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0618

✦ ✦ ✦

Enter the Chorus.

Two waters meet in every Bengal day: The tide that comes to leave, and tea that stays. The one will drag a ship’s long bones away; The other steep a sorrow into praise. Now autumn lays her white flags on the grass, And storms, grown tired, fold up their thunder-cloth; The sword-grass bows to let the quiet pass, And hearts that held their breath may now be loth To hold it longer. Hear, then, how it goes When one who cannot pardon meets one who Has patched a thousand wounds, and yet still owes Her own the thing she gave to others, too. Ships break at Chittagong; at Sylhet, tea: And both, in time, are made to set men free.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE I

The ship-breaking yards at Sitakunda, north of Chittagong. Dawn. The tide is out, and the shore is a mile of mud, iron and gulls.

A ship, when it is old and no longer wanted, comes to Chittagong to die, and it dies in the manner of kings: slowly, in public, and to the great profit of the heirs.

She comes in at the top of the spring tide with her engines running, and her captain, who has sailed her thirty years, throws her at the beach at full speed. Then the sea goes out and leaves her: a cliff of rust on mud, her name still painted on her bow, and four hundred men walking up the shore towards her with torches on their shoulders.

Rahim Chowdhury, foreman, thirty-three, stood at the foot of the cliff with a gas meter in his hand and watched them come.

"Helmets," he said.

"Rahim bhai—"

"Helmets, Babul. Boots. Gloves. Not slippers. *Boots.* The sea has been kind to you twenty-two years and does not need more evidence of your faith."

"The helmet is hot."

"The helmet is hot," Rahim agreed, "and the alternative is a hot head with a cold floor beneath it. Put it on."

The men laughed, because it is the privilege of the poor to laugh at the rules that keep them alive. But they put the helmets on. They called it *Rahim bhai's school*, and in the evening they sometimes called it other things, but they came.

For there had been a morning, eleven months before, when he had not been so strict. A plate of hull steel, long as a bus and thick as a door, had been cut free by a man

who had been told the compartment behind it was cleared. It was not cleared. A pocket of gas, a spark. And a young cutter from the north named Jamal Uddin, twenty-two, six weeks on the yard, was standing where the plate came down.

Rahim had signed the permit. That is the whole of the story, and it takes three words to say and eleven months to carry. *I signed it.*

"Tea, bhai?"

It was Nayeem, who kept the canteen under the tarpaulin, a thin, anxious, kindly man from Dhaka who had once been a waiter in a hotel with chandeliers and now served biscuits to men in sandals made of tyres. He was fifty-two and absent-minded, and he held out a glass, steaming.

"Not now."

"It is the good tea. From Sylhet. My cousin sends it."

"Not now, Nayeem."

"You do not sleep, and you do not drink tea," said Nayeem. "Bhai, how do you live?"

"Out of spite."

"Ah. It sustains. But it does not warm the hands." He pushed the glass into Rahim's hand, since a thing refused is only a thing postponed, and added, quite casually, as he turned away: "You say *not now* like a man putting a lid on a pot. Nobody carries a thing like that, bhai, unless he is waiting for somebody to take it off him. I have noticed this, being a man who carries trays."

Rahim looked at the tea. Then at the vast red ship. Then at the sea, which had gone very far out and looked like something that had given up all argument.

He drank the tea. It was, God forgive him, very good.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

Sreemangal, in the tea country of Sylhet. A garden dispensary, a tin roof, and rain.

Mark this, reader: rain on a tea garden is not a sound but a conversation, ten thousand leaves each answering in a different voice.

Under the tin roof of the garden dispensary, Dr. Nusrat Jahan, twenty-nine, was setting the broken wrist of a child while the child's mother told her, with great firmness, that it was not broken, and the child's grandmother told her, with greater firmness, that it was.

"Both of you are right," said Nusrat, who had learned in four years that this was a medical opinion and a diplomatic one. "It is broken *and* it will mend. Hold her hand. Now, little one, look at the clock. Tell me what the hands are doing."

"Walking."

"Walking where?"

"To lunch."

"Excellent."

She was the only doctor for three thousand pluckers and their children, in a garden that ran along the green hills like a stitched cloth, and she had come to it at twenty-five with a stethoscope and a conviction that she would stay two years. That was four years ago. She had lanced, stitched, vaccinated, scolded, and been given in thanks three hundred and eleven pineapples.

She healed everyone. It was her profession, and also, as she sometimes admitted in the small hours when the rain was loud, her hiding-place.

When the wrist was set and the family gone, she washed her hands and found a woman waiting in the doorway: a plucker in a faded blue sari, with a basket strap still across her forehead, and a flat tin box held to her chest like a lamb.

“Rokeya apa,” said Nusrat. “Is it Mitu again? Is the fever back?”

“No, doctor-apa. It is the other thing.” The woman, who was perhaps thirty and looked forty, held out the tin. “Will you read them? You read well. I cannot. I have asked the boy in the post office, but he reads aloud, and the whole market—”

The tin held eleven small slips of paper, each rubbed at the folds: money-order receipts. The money had come every month for eleven months, three thousand taka, precisely, on the ninth. It had begun, said Rokeya, after her husband went to the yards in Chittagong to earn for the children, and died there, on a day with no warning.

“I thought it was from the owner,” said Rokeya. “But the owner sent the first money, with a letter that said *regret.* This one says nothing. I do not like a thing that gives and says nothing, doctor. It is like a man who stands at your gate at night and does not knock.”

Nusrat turned the slips over. On every one the sender’s block, in the same flat, careful, upright hand: *R. Chowdhury, Fauzdarhat, Chittagong.*

She said nothing for a time. The rain went on.

That night, when the lamp was low and the wards asleep, she opened the laptop the district council had given her for vaccination forms and, being a doctor, who must know the cause before the cure, typed into the search bar of the Register of Black Stars the single word *Chittagong.*

Nineteen entries.

The fourteenth said:

ENTRY 0618 — Chittagong, Bangladesh. *“A man died on my watch and I have not forgiven myself.”*

She read it, and sat quite still, and her heart, which was a professional heart and generally kept regular hours, went off the rails.

She wrote, which she should not have done, because a doctor should not meddle in what she cannot cure:

To the writer of Entry 0618, from the writer of Entry 0083. A woman in Sreemangal has a tin box with eleven receipts and a question. She does not

want money. She wants to know who it is that stands at her gate and does not knock. I think, perhaps, you could knock. — N.J.

She sent it. Above her a gecko hung motionless in the lamplight with the air of a witness.

"Do not say a word," said Nusrat. The gecko, to its credit, did not.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

Naples. A pizzeria on a street so narrow that the washing on one side may be borrowed from the other. A table, six chairs, a menu, a war.

Meanwhile, at the other end of the world, a different feud was being settled by a different tribunal: the planning of a wedding.

"The pizza," said Alessandro Greco, thirty-three, pizzaiolo, "is the *first* course. It has been the first course since Naples was Naples."

"The pastry is the *last* course," said Chiara Esposito, thirty-one, pastry chef, "and a last course is what they *remember*. They will tell their grandchildren about the sfogliatella."

"They will tell their grandchildren about my *margherita*, made with *your* recipe—"

"Which you stole."

"Which I *borrowed*, with sorrow."

"With *sorrow*," said Chiara, "and *flour*."

At the head of the table sat Paolo Ricci, thirty, choir director and cousin to both families by one of those Neapolitan marriages whose branches have not been traced since the Bourbons, writing it all down on a napkin. He believed that a thing written became true, as governments do.

"A *concordat,*" said Paolo. "Pizza first, pastry last, and in the middle the pasta, over which no one has any feelings."

"My mother," said Alessandro, "has feelings about the pasta."

"My mother," said Chiara, "has feelings about *your mother's* feelings about the pasta."

"Then," said Paolo, who had a gift for peace, "pizza at the beginning, pastry at the end, and the middle left open, like a door, so that the guests may wander in."

The two cooks looked at each other as they had a year before, when she had come in with a rolling pin and he had come out with a peel and every man in the street had gone indoors.

"A door," said Alessandro slowly.

"That is," said Chiara, "not *entirely* stupid."

"I said it was *musical,*" said Paolo, wounded.

Behind the bar, an old woman who had been polishing one glass for eleven minutes remarked that in her day the mothers settled a wedding in one afternoon. Nobody heard her. The old are the prophets of Naples, and are listened to only at funerals.

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SCENE IV

Verona. The courtyard of a small house with a very large, very famous, very tired balcony on its far side. A wedding, three hours before the bride.

Marco Bellini, tenor, thirty-four, could fill the Arena with one sustained note, and had that morning been sick into a flowerpot.

"It is the *speech,*" he said. "I can sing for ten thousand. But I cannot say, in my own voice, to forty people, *I take this woman.* It is the difference between a mask and a face."

"You are wearing a very nice waistcoat," said Enzo Conti, fifty-two, the scribe who sat each day beside the wall of letters copying out tourists' sorrows in a handsome script. "Breathe."

"I *am* breathing."

"You are breathing like an aria. Breathe like a man."

Francesca Costa, fifty, a weaver from Mantua with a talent for catastrophe, hurried through the courtyard announcing that she had lost the *only* pin, and that the pin was *symbolic.* Elena Gallo, seventy-four, who had known the bride's mother, said, "Francesca, you are holding it in your teeth."

"I am *consulting* it," said Francesca, and left, with the pin.

Meanwhile, three streets away, in a room above a bakery, Giulia Rossi, thirty-one, balcony guide, was sitting in her wedding dress with her shoes off, answering a letter.

For years she had answered them, the letters left by pilgrims on the wall, the tear-stained, the misspelled, the hopeful, small paper boats launched at a balcony by people who believed that stone has ears. She had answered them under a hundred invented names, with the cynicism of a woman who knows the post. One of the last had been written by a tenor.

She wrote now, on the back of a wedding-order card:

Dear Marco: You are going to be sick in a flowerpot. Do it, and then come and stand in the square. I will be the one in white, and if you cannot say the words, sing them. I will know what they mean. They are, after all, the same words as in the letters, and I have been reading those for eight years. — G.

She sent it by the baker’s boy.

At noon, in the courtyard, with forty people and a priest and a reluctant sun, the tenor of Verona stood before the bride and opened his mouth and found that he had nothing at all. His face went white. His hands went cold. Elena Gallo, in the third row, quite audibly said “Oh, *dio.*”

Then Giulia, who had walked up the aisle in a plain white dress with a pencil in her hair, took the card out of her sleeve and held it up, and he read it, and he laughed, and the laugh broke the lock.

He sang. Not an aria. A thing of his own, with no accompaniment, half-spoken, in the plain Veronese of his mother:

I had a voice for ten thousand, And none for the one who stood by the wall; I had a name that was cheered by a city, And none that I dared to call. But you took a pen and you gave me the words, You answered the thing I could not say; So I stand here, bare, at a stone-built door, And I take you. And I stay.

The priest, who had seen four hundred weddings, was seen to remove his spectacles.

"That," said Enzo Conti softly, writing it on his cuff, "is going on the wall."

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SCENE V

The bridge of a container ship in the Adriatic. Night. A radio. A decision.

Marija Kovač, thirty, second officer, stood watch on the bridge of the *Zagora* in the small hours, with a cold coffee at her elbow and the black Adriatic spread before her like an unbalanced ledger.

"Officer Kovač," said the captain, behind her. He was sixty, white-bearded, lean as a mast, and had been trying to keep her four years. "The company's offer. The Rotterdam–Singapore line. A chief officer's berth. Four months out, five weeks home. I wanted you for it before I wanted anyone."

"Thank you, Captain."

“You do not need to thank me. You need to decide. I am told there is a sailor, on another ship.” He looked at her, not unkindly. “The sea is faithful and cannot be wounded. A person is neither. Choose with that in mind, and you will not choose wrong.” He went out, and closed the door softly.

She stood a long while at the glass. In the dark ahead a pinprick of light grew, and passed, and fell astern: some other ship, some other watch, some other officer with a cold coffee and a question. She picked up the radio.

“Ship at position forty-three, fifteen north,” she said. “This is *Zagora.* Do you read?”

A crackle. Then, a long way off, in a voice she would have known through the roar of a typhoon: “*Zagora,* this is the *Vela.* I read you. Is that the second officer?”

“It is.”

“What is the weather, Marija Kovač?”

“Clear. The captain has offered me the world.”

“And what will you say?”

She looked at the black water. She had made herself a rule at twenty, that a woman who waits at a rail to be asked is only a figurehead; her one discovery since was that she liked being asked.

“I will say yes to the world,” said Marija. “And I will tell the world that on the ninth of March, for four days, between Rotterdam and Singapore and a certain ship called the *Vela,* there is a gap in the schedules, and in

that gap there is a church in Split. And I will tell the world that it may take what it likes of me, but that for those four days it may not have me.”

The radio hissed. “I have no idea,” said Ivan, “what you just said.”

“Then I will say it again in March,” said Marija.

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SCENE VI

Sreemangal. The tea garden at the end of the afternoon. The kash-grass in flower, white as a surrender. A man walks up the hill alone.

He came on the night train, with a small bag and a smaller hope, and walked up from the station in the wrong shoes through three miles of tea.

He had not written back. He had read her message four times, and stood on the sand facing the sea for the length of a tide. Then, on the fifth day, without telling anybody, not even Nayeem, who knew everything, he had taken a day’s leave, the first in eleven months.

Nusrat was on the dispensary steps. She had seen him coming from the end of the lane, a man in a good shirt and bad shoes, walking like one who has carried a plate of steel for eleven months and is not sure what to do with his arms.

“Dr. Jahan?”

“Mr. Chowdhury.”

“I have come to knock.”

“Yes,” said Nusrat gravely. “I see that. Please come in out of the rain. You are going to catch your death, and I am the only doctor for three thousand, and I would be embarrassed.”

She gave him the seven-layer tea they make in that country, bands of red and amber and cream and green, each lying on the last as though poured by a patient God. He held it a long time without drinking.

“Rokeya is in the next room,” she said. “She knows. She said she would hear it from your mouth or not at all.”

“I am afraid of it,” said Rahim, “more than the ship.”

“There are two kinds of fear,” said Nusrat. “The kind that stops you moving, and the kind that tells you it is the right direction.” She stood. “Come.”

In the next room, on the bench beneath a picture of a mosque and a calendar of a cricketer, sat the widow in the blue sari, with the tin box in her lap. She looked at him. He was taller than she had imagined, and thinner, and he stood in the doorway as though the doorway might fall.

He told her. He did not dress it. He told her about the permit, and the plate, and the three words he had carried since, and that the money was the only way he knew to say a thing he had no right to say. He did not ask to be forgiven. He had come, he said, because a man who stands at a gate for eleven months should at least have the courage to be seen by the woman inside.

When he had finished, there was no sound but rain.

“It was a bad day,” said Rokeya at last. “And you signed the paper. And you are the one standing here, and the owner is not. That is not nothing.” She looked at the tin in her lap. “Every month on the ninth the child asks, *Is it the ninth?* and I say, *Yes,* and she says, *Then we eat fish.* You have fed my daughter fish for eleven months, foreman. I do not know how a woman is meant to hate a man for that.” She stood up, and touched his sleeve, once. “I forgive you. I did it last month, in the dark, and did not say. Now I have said it. And now *you* will do the harder thing.”

“What is that?”

“You will forgive yourself, and you will eat a proper dinner.”

Rahim Chowdhury, who had faced tides and torches and a ton of falling iron, sat down on the bench, put his face in his hands, and wept as a child weeps, with complete relief. Rokeya patted his shoulder as one pats a goat that has finally stopped butting a gate. Nusrat, in the doorway, with a glass of tea in each hand, did not move.

Later, by the garden’s edge, where the tea bushes ran down to the white kash like waves going over a ridge, they walked together a little way, not touching.

“You have a bad cough,” he said.

“It is nothing.”

“You say *nothing* like a man putting a lid on a pot.”

She stopped. “That is a very exact sentence.”

“I took it from a friend,” said Rahim gravely. “A canteen man. I am told I am a quick study.” He looked at her. “Dr. Jahan. Your Entry says you heal everyone else and have never been healed.”

“I wrote that years ago.”

“Is it still true?”

She considered it, in the long light, with the wet leaves shining all about her.

“I do not know. I have been very busy. It is difficult to find out whether a thing is true when one has been so careful never to be quiet enough to hear it.” She turned her head. “Mr. Chowdhury, my autoclave has been broken since June. The district office says *soon.* Is there anything a foreman who has opened ships can do with a steel box?”

“I can,” said Rahim, “look at it.”

“Then look at it,” said Nusrat. “And afterwards, if you are willing, you might stay for dinner. It will be rice and dal and a little fish. I am told that on the ninth of the month, in this valley, it is traditional.”

He laughed. It was a rusty sound, hardly used, like a hinge in a house long shut. It was the first laugh since the morning of the plate, and the tea bushes, who are old and do not gossip, bent a little in the wind to let it pass.

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Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., beside Entries 0618 and 0083:

Tide takes the ship; the hill keeps the leaf. Between them stands a person whose whole work is to be kind to the dying and the living both, and who must be told, at last, by somebody else, that she is permitted to rest.

He will mend her machine. She will mend nothing, and be mended. Note the order of it, reader: it is usually that way round.

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End of Chapter 51.

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Chapter 52: Dancer of Ubud

“I dance for the gods and I think of you.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0445

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SCENE I

Ubud, Bali. The hour before dawn, on the last day of a long engagement. A temple courtyard, a split gate, a smell of frangipani and wet stone.

There is a kind of dancer who dances for the audience, and a kind who dances for the gods, and it is the great secret of the island of Bali that the second kind is the more exacting critic and is never once impressed.

Putu Wirawan, twenty-eight, had been dancing for the second kind since he was six. At that hour, with the stars still out and the roosters beginning their wars across the rice terraces, he stood alone in the courtyard of the family temple in his practice sarong and a plain white headcloth, and he danced the warrior’s dance, the *baris,* to no music at all but the dripping of the eaves.

It is hard dancing, reader. The knees are bent and the back is straight, the fingers quiver like a leaf in a draught, and the eyes, which you would think were for seeing, are thrown wide, flashing, with a ferocity that

must be put on and taken off like a coat. He had practised it every dawn for twenty-two years. He had never yet been satisfied.

“You are late for the gods,” said a voice behind him.

“The gods,” said Putu, without moving his feet, “have been told I would be late. I sent a banten.”

“They do not take bribes of rice.”

“They have taken worse.”

Dewi Anggraini, twenty-six, weaver, stood in the gate with a tray of morning offerings: little palm-leaf boats of flower, rice and incense, each no larger than a hand, laid with the habit of a lifetime. She had been awake since three. Her fingers were stained at the tips with the red-brown of the *mengkudu* root, and she had a loose thread of cotton in her hair that she had not noticed.

“Tomorrow,” said Putu, “there will be three hundred people watching us be married.”

“Today there are three. You, me, and that gecko.”

“I am not afraid of the gecko.”

“No,” said Dewi, laying a small boat of flowers upon the temple step, “you are afraid of the three hundred. You, who dance in front of the god of the mountain and the god of the sea and every tourist from Düsseldorf. Putu.” She straightened, and her calm face, which was famous in the village for being impossible to ruffle, went a little soft at the edges. “Do you remember what I wrote?”

“*My cousin has taught me patience; I am still learning.*”

“And what did you write?”

“I wrote that I danced for the gods and thought of you.” He lowered his arms. “I should have written *only* of you. The gods had their turn.”

“They are very patient.”

“They have had to be,” said Putu. “I took four years to ask.”

Behind them, in the dark of the lane, something shuffled, and sneezed, and said in a loud, grave, wholly foreign voice, in the Javanese of Yogyakarta: “*Is this the temple? I was told the temple would have a sign.*”

“That,” said Dewi, closing her eyes, “will be the delegation from my mother’s side.”

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It was. It consisted of Bayu Saputra, fifty-three, a scribe of Yogyakarta, who wrote letters for those who could not, and who had been drafted by Dewi’s grandmother as an escort on the grounds that he owned a good umbrella; of Dewi’s grandmother herself, Eyang, eighty, upright as a lamp-post and about as likely to be moved; and of a large cage covered in a batik sarong, from which came, at intervals, a muffled sound of grievance.

“We took the night bus,” said Bayu. “Then the ferry. Then another bus. Then a driver who said he knew the way, which is the most dangerous sentence in any language. Eyang has not slept. Neither has the bird.”

“*TOO LATE!*” said the sarong.

“She is nervous,” said Eyang.

“She is *always* nervous.”

“She has a right. It is her first Hindu wedding.” Eyang took Dewi’s face in two dry hands and looked at it for a long time, as one looks at a finished cloth. “You are thin. You have been weaving all night.”

“Eyang, I have to finish the wedding cloth.”

“Then finish it.” The old woman let go. “And Ermis lands this morning. She comes from the airport at noon, in a taxi, with a suitcase of Dutch cheese. She does not know what a wedding costs. She has been in the cold.”

“*BEAUTIFUL!*” said Ayu, from the dark.

“She says it to everyone,” said Bayu Saputra, “but a little more *firmly* at weddings. It is a thing I have observed. A wedding, I find, is only a long tea with a great many chairs.”

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Ermis Larasati, twenty-four, designer, resident for six months of the city of Rotterdam, came out of the arrivals hall at Ngurah Rai in a coat that was far too heavy, and was struck at once by the island: the wet flowered air, the smoke of incense, the sky the colour of a pearl, and the roar of ten thousand motorbikes.

She stood a moment with her suitcase and her heart. She had not expected it to feel so much like putting down a stone.

In Rotterdam, she thought, *I am four hours behind him. I have eaten my dinner at the hour of his tea, and called at the hour when my mind is only starting to work, and have never once complained, because there is no one in Rotterdam to hear.*

And here, thought Ermis, *I am two hours ahead.*

It was a very small thing. She smiled at it, standing in the exhaust, and was unreasonably happy for the length of a minute.

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SCENE II

The same night. The family compound, a veranda, a screen, and a very long distance. Friday. Midnight, Bali; ten o'clock, Dhaka.

The compound was at rest, as much as a Balinese compound before a wedding is ever at rest. Bamboo *penjor,* tall and bent like fishing rods against the stars, leaned over the lane; the offerings stood in rows on the wall; and from the pavilion at the back the muffled noise of a gamelan orchestra rehearsing its one piece, again, again, again, with the patience of the dead.

On the veranda, beneath a lamp haunted by moths, Ermis opened the laptop.

The window blinked. A flat in Mirpur came into being. There was a candle in it, as there so often was, though this time it was a mere ornament, for the electric light was on; there was a wall behind him with a cloth hung on it, indigo, patterned with a field of black dots.

“You are early,” said Fayaz. “By nine seconds.”

“I am *not* early. I am *ahead.*” She pulled the lamp nearer. “I am two hours ahead of you tonight. Do you see how I have grown?”

“You are two hours *taller*, at least. Where are you?”

“Bali. At my cousin’s. There is a wedding. Do you hear that noise? That is a gong being hit in a pattern. It has been hit in the pattern since seven. I think it is going to be hit in the pattern at my funeral.”

“It sounds beautiful.”

“It is *very* beautiful,” said Ermis, “at three in the afternoon, from a distance of one mile.”

He laughed. There was a sound, behind him, of a cough through a wall, and a lighter sound of a girl asking in Bengali whether she might *please* have the room for physics, and he turned his head and said something short and kind and returned.

“Tithi?” said Ermis.

“Tithi. She has an exam on the fourth. She is going to come first in the district, and it will be unbearable.”

“And your mother?”

“The new inhaler is better.” He said it lightly; he had said it lightly for a long time; but there was a place behind his voice where, for the first time, it did not feel like a lid. “She walked to the end of the lane on Tuesday. She stopped four times. She told the neighbours it was to inspect the drains.”

“And the other thing?”

“The other thing is a number.” He looked away, at the wall. “It is a smaller number than it was. Not by a great deal. But it has begun, how shall I say, to *consider* going down.”

Ermis looked at him through the small glass, from the middle of an island, from a great black distance, and was silent a moment.

“Your cloth,” she said. “You hung it.”

“It is the only thing on the wall that is not a certificate.” He glanced behind him. “It has been there since the day it came. People ask what it is. Bunny says it is a map of all the houses in Bangladesh that have no electricity.”

“Is that what you say?”

“I say it is a field of stars that cannot be seen,” said Fayaz, “and that someone I know made it, and that I am being very careful about the nail.”

There was a little pause. The gamelan in the back began its piece again, from the beginning.

“Fayaz.”

“Yes.”

“In Rotterdam,” said Ermis, “I am four hours behind you. I did not tell you. I did not like it at all. It is as though I have been left a long way back in the corridor of the day, and you are at the other end of it, waving.”

“I know. I have been doing the sums.”

“And now I am ahead. And I wished to say it while I was.” She turned her head, a little, so the lamp took her cheek. “It is a very small thing. But for tonight, I have a view of your tomorrow again. I have a view of it. It looks all right.”

“Does it?”

“It looks like a Saturday,” said Ermis. “With tea.”

He did not speak for a moment. Then he said, very gravely, “I will see that it does.”

At that instant a sound, great and sudden and not to be borne, issued from the other end of the veranda, as a tall, sleepless Javanese parrot, who had in all her days been permitted a view of no cloth but the one that covered her, tore a corner of her sarong aside and shouted, directly into the lens, from a distance of eighteen inches:

“***TOO LATE! BEAUTIFUL! TOO LATE!***”

“Ayu,” said Fayaz, with deep respect, “good evening.”

“She is *delighted,*” said Ermis. “She never talks to men. I have not heard her address a man since my uncle.”

“What did your uncle do?”

“He lost an argument,” said Ermis. “She learned it from him. All three sentences. It is the whole of her education.”

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SCENE III

Saturday. Four weddings, on the same day, in four countries. Watch the clocks: that is the whole of the joke.

Kochi, 9:00 a.m.

Meera Menon, twenty-six, schoolteacher, stood in a cream-and-gold *kasavu* sari at the door of a small temple beside the backwaters, holding in her left hand a book, which she had been told, by three aunts and a priest, she was not to bring to her own wedding.

It was a small, brown, sea-stained volume of poems. It was the book she had bought every year for six years, and in which she had found, every year, on the same page, in the same careful hand, a poem that was for her.

And beside her, in a white *mundu* with a gold border, a bookseller of twenty-seven who had not stopped trembling since Tuesday, stood Arjun Nair, with the look of a man who has seen the hour.

"You brought the book," said Arjun.

"I did."

"They said not to."

"I am a schoolteacher. When a person says *not to*, I put it on the board for the whole class." She held it out. "Read it. The one you hid. Now. In front of everybody."

"Meera—"

"*Now,* Arjun."

So the shy bookseller of Kochi, in the presence of two hundred relatives, a brass lamp, a drummer, a nadaswaram player and his own father (who was sev-

enty-six and had not been told), opened the book and read the poem aloud, in a voice that began as a whisper and rose, line by line, like water in a lock, till it reached the beams. Vishnu Pillai, her father, a retired train guard of theatrical disposition, had begun to weep before the second verse and had borrowed the handkerchief of a waiter, Lakshmi Panicker, who stood at his elbow with a stack of banana-leaf plates, trying to look like furniture.

"I did not want her to win," whispered Rajesh Kurup, the temple singer, a rival of other years, to the person next to him. "I thought it was a trick of the book. I was wrong. I will sing the *vazhi* myself."

And he did.

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Lusaka, 10:00 a.m.

In the yard behind a house in the Kabwata quarter of Lusaka, beneath a mango tree, a schoolmaster of thirty-eight in his one good suit and a maize-seller of thirty-five in a blue *chitenge* of such magnificence that three women had to be seated to look at it were being introduced to each other, for the fifth time, by their families.

It is the Zambian custom, which is wise: the families must meet before the people do, as the river must meet the sea before the fish. It is called the *lobola,* and in its way it is a duel of courtesy. Joseph Tembo's uncles sat in a row on one side, with a basket of gifts, speaking with great solemnity. Grace Banda's aunts sat in a row on the other, with arms crossed, listening with a gravity so profound it was clearly enjoyment.

“The groom,” said the senior aunt, “is a good man. He is a teacher. He has two children. He is a widower. We have enquired. His late wife’s mother has said that he was kind to her. This is rare in a man, and rarer in a son-in-law.”

“The bride,” said Joseph’s uncle, “is a woman of sense. She sells maize. She has a daughter. She is a widow. We have enquired. Her late husband’s friends say that she gave him a good funeral. We have never heard so much said about so much grief, so quietly.”

“We have a fair price in mind,” said the aunt.

“We have a fair price in mind,” said the uncle.

“It is *very* fair,” said Loveness Zulu, thirty-eight, baker, who had brought the cake and could not be silenced, “so we should *all* eat.”

Joseph, at the end of the row, sat very straight, with his hands on his knees and the two children, Chisomo and Mapalo, on either side, scrubbed and furious with importance. Across the yard sat Grace, beside her friend Thandiwe Mumba, fifty-one, a railway ticket-inspector and a woman of no sentiment whatever, who had once told Grace that romance was a thing invented by people who sold greetings cards.

“I am still not sure I believe in it,” murmured Thandiwe now, into Grace’s ear.

“I know.”

“But I believe in *him.*” She nodded across the yard, to where the schoolmaster, with immense solemnity, had begun to straighten a child’s collar. “I have watched him

with that boy for two years. He is the kind of man who would apologise to a door. Marry him, you fool, before somebody sensible does.”

Grace smiled. The aunts, at that moment, announced that the price had been agreed, and nobody present could say afterward, with any exactness, what it had been, except that it included maize.

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Naples, 12:00 noon.

It cannot be told in the time. There were three hundred guests, eleven priests, a pizza oven carried on a cart into the cathedral square by the groom’s cousins, and a tower of *sfogliatelle* so tall that the bride’s cousins had to hold the corners.

It was an hour of pure Neapolitan insanity. The groom wept. The bride, who is the sort that does not, wept, to her enormous annoyance, into the first pizza of the wedding, which she bit into in the doorway of the church, in her veil, to find that it was her own recipe, to the grain, with a tiny cross of basil in the middle.

“You stole it,” said Chiara.

“I *borrowed* it,” said Alessandro, and the entire square, which knew the story, said it in chorus.

His sister, Anna Gallo, translator, who had married into Mantua and come down in a hat of tragic proportions, stood up at the long table to make a toast, and confessed to the assembled company that eleven months earlier, in the dead of night, she had found a letter on the shelf above the oven, an unsigned confession in her

brother's hand, which he had meant to burn. "I did not let the fire have it," said Anna. "I put it in an envelope, and I posted it to an old woman in Cornwall who kept the secrets of strangers. I have been *waiting* to confess that. Alessandro, you owe me a finder's fee, in pizza."

"I *knew* it!" cried Chiara, to nobody.

✦ ✦ ✦

Ubud, 5:00 p.m.

And at five o'clock, on an island at the far end of the clocks, the gamelan struck, and three hundred people fell silent, and the wedding began.

Mark this, reader: a Balinese wedding is not a ceremony but a landscape; one walks through it. The bridal pair were led out beneath a shade of gold, he in a dark *saput* and crown of frangipani, she in a gold-threaded *songket* that she had woven herself, with a pattern on the hem in black and white squares: the *poleng,* the cloth of the balance, which tells the god and the stranger that all things in the world come in two halves, and that neither is the enemy of the other.

Ermis stood at the back with her grandmother and a caged parrot and was weeping in a manner she had arranged to look like hay fever.

They went round the fire. They touched the coconuts. The priest, a very old man with a voice like a drum, sprinkled holy water and chanted in an ancient tongue that not one in ten present could construe, and everyone present knew perfectly what it meant. And then, when the blessings were done, and the ritual had ended, and

the guests had risen to eat, the bridegroom, who had never in his life been persuaded to dance for himself, stepped to the centre of the courtyard in his gold and his white and stood before his wife, and spoke, in the plain Balinese of the kitchen, the only vow he had written:

Four years I carried you in my two hands, As men carry water, not daring to spill. The gods have had my mornings. They have had My knees, my breath, my best and truest fear. Tonight I give the gods a holiday. The dancing now is yours, and so am I.

And then, with no music, he began to dance.

It was not the warrior's dance. It was another, one that he had not shown to anyone, a slow circling with the hands, in which the fingers open like petals and the eyes, which in the *baris* are weapons, are for once simply lowered.

It was a dance for a woman, and he danced it to the gods, and the gods, for the first time in twenty-two years, were pleased.

Dewi stood quite still. She was watching his hands.

"That," said Eyang, in a whisper that could be heard in the next village, "is the first thing I have seen in Bali I understand."

"*BEAUTIFUL!*" said Ayu, with a clarity that cut through the gamelan like a blade through silk. "*TOO LATE!*"

"It is not too late," said Ermis, wiping her face with the back of her hand. "It is exactly on time."

She did not say what she meant. She was looking at her own phone, which lay dark in her palm, and at a field of black stars on a wall, in a flat, in a distant city, two hours behind her, in a Saturday with tea.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Four weddings on one Saturday. A coincidence of dates is only the calendar's way of saying: the world has patience, but it also has deadlines.
Entry 0445 and Entry 0141: a dancer, a weaver, and a cloth whose pattern says that two halves are not enemies.
Say this to the girl with the indigo on her thumbs: it is not the hour that matters. It is that, somewhere, a window has been left lit.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 52.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 53: Engine Eleven

“I carried a stranger out of a fire and thought of you.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0548

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE I

Boston. Dorchester Avenue. Firehouse of Engine Company Eleven, a brick building older than the fire code and wiser than the fire department. An October evening, the annual Chili Night, which raises money for children’s coats and every year for an argument.

There are two kinds of men who join a fire company: those who wish to be brave, and those who wish to be useful. The first kind generally leave. The second stay for thirty years, and are buried with a bell.

Patrick Murphy, forty, lieutenant, was the second kind, and had been since he was twenty-six. He was a broad, quiet man with a face like a good doorstep, scuffed but unbothered, and he stood now at the back bay of Engine Eleven, beside the great red truck with its brass bell polished to a shine that could have started a small religion, being told by a college professor that the chili was wrong.

“It is not wrong,” said Mike Flynn, thirty-nine, historian, bespectacled, owner of nine hundred books and no boat. “It is *anachronistic.* There are beans in it.”

“Mike, you teach medieval shipping.”

“And am therefore *qualified* in the comparative method.” He sipped. He grimaced. He sipped again. “It is the best chili I have ever eaten,” he said bitterly. “I will not be speaking of it.”

Across the bay, on a folding chair, sat Laura Hayes, forty, a community pastor from Somerville with a gift for blessing machinery and a greater one for knowing the business of the entire Commonwealth. She had come to bless the new hose reel. She had stayed because the chili was free. And between the two she had learned, in twenty minutes, that the lieutenant of Engine Eleven had written an anonymous letter to England, that the nurse who did not come to Chili Night had a brother who had died in a fire, and that these two facts were, in her judgment, about to meet.

“Patrick,” she said, in the bright, carrying voice of one who intends to whisper. “A word.”

“Reverend Laura.”

“The Lord does not mind what a man writes to the Register. But He minds, a little, what a man does *not* say to a woman who works nights at the hospital where he delivers half his casualties.” She smiled with perfect innocence. “I have blessed the hose. I am free to bless a conversation.”

“I do not know what you mean.”

“Of course you do not,” said Laura Hayes. “That is the *joke.*”

Mike Flynn set down his cup, like a man who has just discovered the sea. “Patrick. Is there a woman?”

“There is a *nurse,*” said Laura.

“Mike,” said Patrick Murphy, “put down the chili.”

✦ ✦ ✦

For there was, as it happens, a woman; and what bound her to the lieutenant was one night.

It had been a Tuesday in February, a three-alarm fire in a triple-decker on Ashmont Street, a night so cold that the water froze on the hose in the instant it was thrown. On the third floor a woman had refused to leave without her child, and the child had gone back for the cat, and the stairs, that had been wood at six o’clock, were by half past seven a rumour. Patrick had gone up. He had come down with a boy of nine in his arms, unconscious, black to the eyelashes, and he had run with him across the ice to the ambulance, and put him down, and a woman in blue scrubs and a grey coat had taken the child’s wrist with one hand and held his sleeve with the other.

Stay, she said. It was not an order. It was the voice of a person who has said the word to a great many people, to very little effect.

He had stayed for four minutes, until the boy coughed, and breathed, and cried. In the cold of the ambulance bay, in the red wash of the lights, he had looked at her

face, white and fine and fixed, with eyes the colour of a wet slate roof, and she had looked at his, and neither had said a word.

Her name-tag said WALSH.

He had carried a stranger out of a fire that night. Ever since, one thought had repeated itself in his head like a prayer: *a woman in a grey coat took the child's wrist, and I should like to have been standing where she could take mine.*

It is a ridiculous thing to think about a stranger. He had written it to another stranger, in England. He had not meant to be answered.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

Lagos. A warehouse in Yaba, once a server farm, now a fashion house. Heat, generators, a hundred chairs, a smell of starch and ambition.

In another quarter of the world, in a city that never ceases to explain itself loudly, a former founder of a financial technology company was setting out a hundred plastic chairs, and a designer of dresses was standing at the end of a runway deciding whether to be sick.

The chairs, said Emeka Okafor, twenty-eight, had been borrowed from a wedding. The runway had been a loading ramp. The lights had come from a man in Ikeja who promised Thursday and arrived the following Tuesday with the face of a saint. The building had once held sixty servers and nine employees, whose salaries he had paid

for eleven months out of his own savings after the company was already dead, as one goes on feeding a horse after the cart has gone over the cliff.

The servers were gone. The nine were here. Kemi, once his lead engineer and now, by some alchemy of the heart, sewing-room manager, reported that the back generator had been turned off because the noise upset the models.

"The models are upset by *everything.*"

"It is the whole of their skill, Oga."

He laughed. Then he looked at the end of the ramp, where a young woman of twenty-seven was standing in the half-dark, with pins in her mouth and a dress on a stand before her, and the laugh dropped out of him.

Chidinma Eze had cut gowns for brides and carnivals, bright and extravagant, and sold them under a name nobody remembered; and every night for eight years she had gone home and turned off the light on a dress she had never shown to anybody. It hung on a stand at the end of the runway: a long column of gold *aso-oke,* woven by a cooperative in Iseyin, split from the shoulder to the floor to show a lining of indigo as deep as the evening sea. It was a dress for a woman of forty who has never apologised to a room.

"It is not finished," said Chidinma, through the pins.

"It is the best thing I have ever seen."

"It is *not finished.* It has no model. The woman I made it for does not exist."

“Then,” said Emeka, who had learned in the death of a company that the surest cure for fear was a practical suggestion, “she must be invented. Ngozi, are you there?”

“I am here,” said a large and magnificent voice from the third row, and a woman rose in a purple *iro* and *buba* and a head-tie like a cathedral. She was fifty-nine, a pastor from Enugu who had come to Lagos by bus to bless the evening, and who would by its end have blessed the chairs, the ramp, and the caterer. “Daughter. The Lord, who made the woman you are afraid to become, has seen her. He says: She is *very* tall. She is wearing gold. She is a little bit rude. Go and meet her. She has been waiting.”

Chidinma took the pins out of her mouth. She looked at the dress. She looked at the man who had once paid nine salaries out of a dead company’s grave and was now arranging chairs for hers. She looked, last, at the end of the ramp, where a hundred people, borrowed from a hundred weddings, were beginning to sit down and fan themselves with the programme.

“Help me with the zip,” she said.

And at eight o’clock in the evening, in a converted server farm in Yaba, in a dress that did not exist, a woman of twenty-seven walked out into the light as a woman of forty who has never apologised, and the room, which had been rattling like a tin of nails, went silent as the inside of a bell.

When she reached the end of the ramp she did not turn, as models do. She stopped. She looked down at a man in the front row, in a black shirt, with eyes like a

window that has just been opened.

“Emeka Okafor,” said Chidinma, in front of the whole city, “my company is open and your company is dead. I do not want your money. I want your arithmetic, and your dinner on Sundays, and you at the end of every ramp I walk. Will you?”

There was a roar like a pot boiling over. Somewhere at the back the Reverend Ngozi was heard to say, “*I said it in the car,*” and a man accused all his life of calculating every outcome found himself on a plastic chair with no calculation at all.

“I will,” said Emeka.

“Say it properly.”

“I will,” he said, “and I will bring my father, and a goat, and a very long list.”

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

Boston. Boston Medical Center, the emergency department. Four in the morning, which is the hour at which nurses stop lying.

Ellen Walsh, thirty-eight, charge nurse, sat on an upturned crate in the loading bay behind the hospital with a paper cup of coffee in both hands, and watched the steam climb towards the single sodium lamp, and thought, as she always did at four, about her brother.

She had not said it in fourteen years: not to her father, nor the priest, nor the counsellor in the nice room with the box of tissues. She said *the night.* She said *what hap-*

pened. She said *the thing on Dudley Street.* She had taken the word out of her mouth as one removes a nail from a wall, and left the hole.

"You have the face on," said Beth Murray, who had flown the medevac helicopter for eleven years and who flew, in conversation, at the same low altitude with a great deal of noise. She sat on the next crate. "The *Tuesday-in-February* face. You know the one. Where you look at the trucks."

"I do not look at the trucks."

"Ellen, you can tell the make of a fire engine by the *sound.*"

"It is professional."

"It is *Eleven.*" Beth took the coffee and drank half of it. "He sent you a card at Christmas, and you put it in a drawer and then in a different drawer. Why don't you say it?"

"Say what?"

"Whatever it is. Say it to *someone.* A person who can't say the word has the word in charge of them."

Ellen looked at her coffee. There was a long silence in the bay. A truck went by on the avenue; its lights crossed the wall, and passed.

She said, to the lamp, in a voice that sounded as though it were someone else's:

I have not said it, and it has been fourteen years. I say "the night," I say "what happened," say "The thing on Dudley Street." My tongue goes round The word as water goes around a stone. My brother

Danny, twenty-four, a roofer, Who sang in the shower and was frightened of the dentist, Went up a stair to get a neighbour's dog. That is the whole of it. It is so small. It is so small a word, and I have made it A building I cannot go into, a room Whose door I keep with both my hands. I want To say it, and I do not know how. I want To be a person who can say it, and To still be here at the end of the sentence.

"Okay," said Beth gently. "Good. That is the start. You can't say it to me. Say it to the one it's for."

"He's dead, Beth."

"No." Beth shook her head. "It's for the one who's *alive.* There is a man in Dorchester who carries people out of it for a living, and who, I am reliably informed by a Reverend Hayes, has been writing letters to an old lady in Cornwall about a woman in a grey coat."

Ellen stared at her. "Who *told* you?"

"Everybody, honey. It is Boston."

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE IV

Lake Victoria, off Kisumu. A Saturday morning. A fishing boat dressed in ribbons and palm leaves, a hundred guests in smaller boats, and a camera.

Mark this, reader: there is a wedding on the lake, and it is being broadcast, and the groom is not performing.

He had once made a living by it. Otieno Odhiambo, twenty-nine, fisherman, had made a hundred videos in which a loud, invincible man who did not exist caught enormous fish and told his followers in a voice of thunder to *live their best lives, my friends, in the name of the lake.* The man in the videos had never been seasick. The man who made them frequently was.

This morning, a handsome boat named *Mama Atieno* rode at anchor in the warm brown water off the Dunga shore, with palm fronds along her gunwale and a cloth of orange over the bow, and her skipper stood at the wheel in a plain white shirt with his real face, holding a phone out at arm's length, and said to the camera, in his own small voice:

"Hello. My name is Otieno. I am a fisherman. I have been telling you a lie for three years, and today I am going to tell you something true: this is my wedding. It is a bit wobbly. I am a bit frightened. If you wish to unfollow, I will understand."

Eleven thousand viewers did not. Many more joined.

"You said *a bit wobbly,*" said Wanjiru Kamau, thirty minutes later, in white, in the stern, with the wind in her veil. She was twenty-seven, a technology journalist, a woman of exact opinions, and she had already counted the guests, the fish on the table, and the misspelled words on the banner. "Technically it is *seventeen degrees* of wobble."

"You measured it?"

"With the phone. I have an app."

“Of course you have an app,” said Otieno, in tender despair.

“I would like it noted,” said Wanjiru, “for the record, that I fell in love with a man who did not exist. And that it is a *great* relief to find that the one who does is a better liar *and* a better cook.” She took his hands. “*Erokamano,* Otieno. For telling me the truth, even badly.”

“Say the bit about the fish!” called a trader named Akinyi, twenty-five, from the next boat, who had been told to keep silent and had not.

“There was no bit about the fish.”

“There is *always* a bit about the fish!”

The whole lake, to the last canoe, began to laugh; and the bride, who did not as a rule, laughed with it; and the groom stood up in the stern, in the sun, and was for the first time in three years exactly as large as himself.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE V

Boston. The firehouse. Chili Night, an hour before midnight. The tables are cleared; the children gone; the red truck stands in the bay with her doors open, as a tired animal stands.

She came at ten to eleven, in the grey coat, alone, on her night off, with her hands in her pockets, and she stood in the great door of the bay with the cold behind her and the whole company turned to look.

Mike Flynn, who had been explaining Hanseatic League shipping to a probationary firefighter, stopped in the middle of a sentence. Laura Hayes, who had been about to leave, sat down again with the air of a woman who has bought a ticket. The old captain of the company, a man named O'Hara, seventy-four, retired nine years and still in possession of a key, laid down his coffee.

"I am looking for Lieutenant Murphy," said Ellen.

"Here," said Patrick, from the back of the bay.

He had been cleaning a hose coupling. He put it down very carefully, as one puts down a glass, and wiped his hands on a rag, and came across the concrete, and the whole bay was suddenly so quiet that one could hear the clock on the wall.

"I'm Ellen Walsh," said Ellen, "I am a nurse. You carried a boy to me in February."

"I remember."

"He is fine. He is nine and he is in a choir. He asked me to say thank you. I said I would. It has taken me eight months." She took a breath. "I was afraid of your truck."

"It is a large truck."

"It is not the size." Her eyes went past him, to the wall above the coat-hooks, where, in a row of framed photographs, a number of young men in old helmets looked out over the years with the grave goodwill of the dead. "Is that a log?"

He turned. On a shelf under the photographs stood a row of old green ledgers, each with a year in white paint on the spine. He had not meant her to see. He had been eight months finding the right way to say it, and now saw that there is no right way, only the hour.

“It’s the run book,” said Captain O’Hara quietly. “Every call, since nineteen-sixty. Would you like to see one?”

“Which year?”

“Yours,” said the old man. “Fourteen years back. The twenty-third of January. Box two-four-four. Dudley Street.”

For a moment nothing moved.

Then she crossed the bay, and took the green book down, and opened it on the engine’s fender, under the work-lamp. The entry was in a clerk’s hand, short, grey with age. *2314 hrs. Box 244. Dudley St. Working fire, 3-story frame. Two persons removed from 2nd floor stair. One deceased at scene. D. Walsh, 24, roofer. Removed by Eng. 11 crew. Captain O’Hara commanding.*

She read it twice. Her hand lay on the page.

“We carried him down,” said Captain O’Hara. “I carried his feet. We were careful. I have never told it to a living soul in fourteen years, and I told it to Murphy, last February, because he asked me what the run book was for. He wanted to know if he could find a name. I think he was looking for yours.”

“I did not know the name until the night I saw it on your coat,” said Patrick, very low. “I swear it. I did not. And then I thought: if I tell her now, she will think I carried the boy out to be forgiven. And I did not. I carried him out because he was a boy.”

“I know,” said Ellen.

“I should have told you. I am sorry.”

“No.” She looked up. And her face, which for fourteen years had been the face of a nurse at four in the morning, did a thing that faces do very rarely: it simply gave. “I came to say it. I have not said it since it happened. May I say it to you? You are the only one in the world who has been inside it.”

“Say whatever you want.”

She put her hand flat on the page. Beneath it, the clerk’s grey ink, and all the winter of her life.

“My brother,” said Ellen Walsh, in a voice that shook and then did not, “died in a *fire.*”

The word went out into the bay. It struck the red flank of the engine and the brass bell and the old photographs, and came back to her as an echo, and nothing at all fell down.

“A fire,” she said again. “Danny died in a fire. He was twenty-four. He was carried down the stairs by a man named O’Hara, who was kind to his feet. And I have been frightened of that word for fourteen years, and it is —” She laughed, astonished, wet-eyed. “It’s only a word. It is only four letters. It is the smallest thing I’ve ever been afraid of.”

Captain O'Hara had put on his glasses to hide his eyes, which does not work. Mike Flynn was blowing his nose in a napkin. Laura Hayes bowed her head with real piety, which she did seldom, and in a voice that did not carry at all, said, "Amen."

Patrick Murphy did not speak. He took off the rough glove he was wearing and held out his bare hand.

She took it.

Above them, in the dark roof of the firehouse, the bell began to ring: the long double stroke, a box alarm, a call.

"That's us," said Patrick. He did not let go. "I have to go. It's a good company. It will not wait."

"I know."

"Will you be here when we come back?"

She looked at the red truck, which the crew was already boarding in a thunder of boots, and at the great bay door rolling up into the night, and at the man whose hand she held.

"I work nights," said Ellen. "I will be where the trucks come." She let go. "Go and carry somebody."

He went. The engine went out into the dark with her bell and her lamps and her thunder, and Ellen Walsh stood in the doorway of Engine Eleven and watched it down the whole length of the cold street, till the light of it was gone; and for the first time in fourteen years, in the place where the word had been, there was something quiet and clean.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

The word you cannot say is a house you live outside of. The saying does not tear it down. It only opens a window.

Entry 0548 and Entry 0082. He wrote of a stranger; she of a brother. It was the same fire. They had only to find the same hour.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 53.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 54: The Tallinn Choir

“My voice failed and I do not know who I am without it.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0090

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SCENE I

Jaipur. The old city. A sandstone haveli in a lane that smells of marigolds, hot oil and old arguments. Morning, and for the first time in forty years, a roof.

For four decades the Rathore haveli had been the proudest ruin in Rajasthan.

It had everything a great house requires except a ceiling: a gateway like a sunrise, carved lattices through which a thousand wives had watched a thousand processions, a courtyard painted in rose and peacock-blue, and above all of it, the sky, a very fine one, which entered by day and left by night without once being asked to wipe its feet.

Vikram Rathore, thirty, heritage guide, heir, ham, and the loudest man in the Pink City, stood in the middle of the courtyard in a turban of saffron silk and watched the last tile go down, and wept openly.

“It is a *roof,*” he told the assembled workmen, whom he had hired and who had worked for him for a year at a price that no accountant should be told. “It is not merely a roof. It is the end of a lament. It is the first stanza of a glorious—”

“Hukum,” said the foreman, “the paint is wet.”

“*—glorious—*”

“Do not lean on it.”

“I would not dream of it,” said Vikram, leaning on it.

Behind him, in a plain white *kurta* with her sleeves pushed to the elbow and indigo to the wrist, stood Priya Sharma, twenty-seven, heiress and apostate, who had refused to inherit the family’s mills and had instead begun, in a rented corner of the haveli, a small house of her own, in which a dozen women, trained in the old block-printing of Bagru, made cloth with a design that was not their grandmothers’. Her collection was to be shown here tonight, under the new roof, to four hundred people, among them her father, who had not yet forgiven her and who had said he would attend “in a professional capacity.”

“You have not slept,” said Priya.

“I have slept in *spirit.*”

“The spirit has a bag under its eye.”

“A heritage bag,” said Vikram, wiping his eye with his sleeve. “Priya. Thank you for the cloth. For the awning. For the whole—” He waved at the courtyard. “I have never been so afraid of a party. Everyone I know is com-

ing. Four hundred people. The man who wrote the guidebook. My mother's cousins, who believe I have sold the house to the Americans."

"You have sold it to nobody."

"I have sold it to *you*," he said, "in spirit."

"I own a spirit and a lease," said Priya, "and I will thank you to stop exaggerating." But her mouth moved.

At the gate, a young woman with a notebook and the manner of a ferret, Pooja Tiwari, twenty-seven, writer, who had been sent to cover the party for a magazine and had been there since six, whispered to an old chef from Agra named Pankaj Singh, seventy-three, who had come to cook the dal for four hundred and was stirring a pot the size of a boat.

"He is going to propose tonight," said Pooja. "I can feel it. I have a nose."

"You have a notebook."

"I have both." She looked at the chef. "Do you think she'll say yes?"

"Madam," said Pankaj Singh, with the gravity of one who has made a million lentils, "I have only ever known one thing about a proposal. The cook is the last to be told and the first to know."

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

Tallinn, Estonia. A late October afternoon, with frost already in the shadows. A wooden house in Kalamaja, grey, tall and old, in a street where all the houses lean together like men at a funeral.

If you wish to know what silence is, reader, do not go to the mountains. Go into a house where there was always someone, and where now there is no one, at four o'clock on a winter afternoon in the north.

Mikhail Sokolov, forty-two, engineer, stood in the kitchen of the house in which he had been born and listened to the refrigerator.

It was a small noise, a dutiful hum, and the only sound in the building. His mother had died three winters ago, quietly, in the room above; his father had gone before her; the stairs, which had once creaked all day under three pairs of feet, had since become, under one, eloquent in their silence. He owned no radio and no television. He had at first thought it was grief. Then he had realised it was *fear*: of the particular pitch a quiet house has when it is waiting for you to speak.

A letter lay on the table. It had arrived that morning, with a Pärnu stamp, and was addressed in his sister's round, no-nonsense hand. It was the forty-first of its kind. She wrote every month. She did not ask him anything. She answered.

Dear Mikhail. You will want to know whether to sell the house. No. You will want to know whether to learn the piano. Yes, it is not too late, and you may begin with the one in the church. You will want to know whether

anybody could ever bear to live with a man who says "perhaps" nineteen times in a conversation. Yes, Misha. Someone could. Go out. Helena.

He folded the letter and put it in the drawer with the other forty. Then, for lack of any other plan, he put on his coat and went to work.

The house has learned my footsteps and gives back
No other sound. I wind the clock; it ticks As though
in apology. I run the tap To hear the water.
Engineer, they call me: One who can make a hundred thousand voices Heard on a field, and cannot make a single Voice in his own kitchen. I know the physics. A silence is a room with nothing in it And all the room's resonances intact. I do not fear the quiet. I fear it asks A question, and I fear I know the answer.

✦ ✦ ✦

The work was the Song Festival Grounds.

They stand on a green slope above the Gulf, at the edge of the city: a great grassy bowl for a hundred thousand listeners, and above it the arch of the stage, a huge white shell of concrete, curved like the inside of a sea-creature. Once in five years the whole nation fills it, thirty thousand singers from all the choirs of Estonia, and that is as nearly as a country can be said to pray. For twenty years Mikhail Sokolov had been the man who kept it standing. He knew every bolt of the shell, every drain, every cable. He loved it as one loves the only thing that has never asked a question.

That afternoon, as he checked the lamps on the stage, he heard behind him a sound that was entirely out of place. A cornet. A brass cornet, playing, with enormous joy and moderate accuracy, a Lancashire hymn tune.

He turned. At the lip of the stage, in a bright anorak, a young woman with a face like a scone and the shoulders of a bell-ringer was sending her note out across the empty bowl; and the shell, which had been built for the voice, had taken it, and thrown it, and was giving it back, clear as a coin on a plate, from the farthest rim of the grass.

"Nine seconds!" cried a man, running down the slope, a tall, burnt-faced, sentimental sort of man in a wet jacket, carrying a stopwatch. "Nine and a *half,* Poppy! The note hangs for nine and a half seconds! I have timed it!"

"William," said the woman, lowering the cornet, "you are on our honeymoon."

"I am timing a *wall.*"

"You are timing a wall on our honeymoon."

"It is," said William Hartley, with deep reverence, looking up at the arch, "the finest wall in Europe."

"Excuse me," said Mikhail Sokolov, in the precise Estonian of a man who has spoken it carefully all his life and never quite believed he was allowed. "You are not permitted on the stage."

The woman looked at him. The man looked at him. In perfect unison, they said, in the accent of the English north: "*Oh, sorry.*"

It was the beginning of the most unlikely friendship of the Baltic autumn. Within a quarter of an hour Mikhail had shown the groundsman the drainage system under the field, which William fell in love with on sight; and the cornetist had been permitted, as a very great favour, to play one hymn from the centre of the stage while Mikhail stood on the grass at the far rim, a hundred metres away, listening. The note arrived at his ear perfectly, small as a lit match, with no loss at all.

He had known it, of course. He had always known the shell's secret: that at the focal point of the arch, where the curve gathers, a voice no louder than a whisper can be heard from the back of a field. It had never mattered. No choir had needed it. They sang loud.

But he stood a long moment at the rim, with the cold wind in his coat, and a thought began to form in his head, like frost on a window, slowly and with great beauty.

"You have a choir here?" said Poppy Ashworth, coming down the grass with her cornet under her arm. "Mr. Sokolov? We heard singing through the wall, in the rehearsal hall behind the stage, when we came in. It was *lovely*. But there was a woman at the end of the soprano row, with a lot of scarves, who turned the pages and mouthed every word with them. Every word. And she never made a sound."

"That is Madam Mägi's women's choir," said Mikhail. "They rehearse on Thursdays." He frowned. "I do not know the woman."

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SCENE III

The rehearsal hall behind the stage. A long room of pine floor and tall windows. Forty women of Tallinn, in cardigans, at the end of a Thursday. The light going.

Katrin Tamm, thirty-nine, had been a soprano for twenty-six years, a good one, and for the last two a woman who held the music for other people.

It was the throat. A small thing: a surgery on the thyroid, two winters ago, and a nerve, in the doing of it, that had been touched and had since declined to explain itself. She could speak, if she spoke softly. She could laugh, in a manner of speaking. She could not sing. Specialists in three cities had said *possibly* and *give it time* and *the nerve is a stubborn creature,* and she had gone on turning the pages at the end of the row with her scarves around her neck and her lips moving, a soprano without a sound, like a bell with the clapper removed.

"From the *top,* ladies," said Liis Mägi, fifty-two, conductor, who farmed rye in the south and drove up on Thursdays in a lorry. "And Toomas, I don't need you to lead the sopranos from the bass line, you are a *tenor*."

"I was moved," said Toomas Rebane, thirty-five, weaver, the only man in the women's choir by virtue of an administrative accident in nineteen ninety-nine, and a romantic by profession. "The Mozart. It *moved* me. I felt that the line wished to be—"

"Toomas."

"—*carried,* Liis."

"Go and be a tenor."

The women began. The sound went up in the long room like smoke up a chimney, and at the end of the sopranos' row, a woman with a long fair plait and a grey scarf mouthed every syllable of it and pressed the page flat with her thumb.

"You should say something to him," said a voice at her shoulder.

Katrin turned. It was her mother, Triin Saar, fifty-eight, dockworker at Muuga, a square, weather-cured woman who had come straight from her shift in her boots, who did not hold with singing as a rule and had come only because it was the one place her daughter went. "The engineer. He has been standing in the door for twenty minutes. He is a Russian. He looks as though he is going to be sick."

"He is a *Sokolov,*" whispered Katrin. "He keeps the Grounds. He does not speak to people."

"Then that is two of you." Triin nodded to the door. "He is looking at you as I looked at your father, at the dockyard dance. I did not speak either. He came across the floor."

In the doorway, a tall man in an engineer's coat stood with a roll of drawings under his arm and the pale, courteous, hunted face of a person who has just walked into a room with a question in it.

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"Miss Tamm," said Mikhail Sokolov, ten minutes later, in the corridor, in his careful Estonian. "I apologise. I have no right. I heard that you are not singing."

“I have a nerve.” She said it in the thread of voice that was all she had left; it was a soft, husky, unsteady sound, like a cello played in another room. “It is not important. I turn the pages.”

“I am an engineer,” said Mikhail. “I do not understand voices. I understand rooms.” He unrolled the drawing. It was a section of the great stage-shell, with a curve drawn across it, and at the curve’s heart a small neat star in pencil. “Here. This is the focal point. A sound made here, however quiet, is given back to the field by the whole arch. I measured it this afternoon. A whisper at the star can be heard at the farthest rim. It does not need a voice. It needs only—” he searched for the word, in a language that had never given him words easily, “—*breath.* The shell does the rest.”

She looked at the drawing for a long time.

“You are saying,” said Katrin slowly, “that I could—”

“I am saying nothing.” His courtesy, which was a wall, wobbled. “I am saying a physical fact about concrete. It is a fact that has no feelings. But I have thought all afternoon, since an English girl played a hymn, that this building was made for people who have a great deal to say and very little air in which to say it. It is a very Estonian building. It has been waiting a long time for somebody to try.”

“Now?” said Katrin. “In the dark?”

“There is a light on the stage. And the field is empty.” He swallowed. “I will stand at the rim. If it does not carry, I shall say *it was the wind,* and you need never speak of it. I am an excellent liar about the weather.”

A silence. In the hall behind them the women's choir broke upon a chord, and held it, and let it go.

At the end of the corridor, twenty women of Tallinn, who had apparently been standing against the wall for some time pretending to examine a noticeboard, scattered like sparrows.

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The sun had gone, and the great bowl of the Grounds lay black and silver under a rising moon, frost on every blade. Far out at the rim of the field, a hundred metres off, a man in an engineer's coat stood with his back against a lamp-post and his heart in his teeth. On the stage, under a single work-lamp, at the small pencilled star on the boards, a woman in a grey scarf stood with her hands at her sides.

From the dark behind the wings the whole choir, and her mother in her dockworker's boots, and a groundsman with a stopwatch and his bride with a brass cornet, had crept out as softly as they knew how, and were watching from the shadows, hardly breathing.

Katrin Tamm closed her eyes. She thought: *I do not know who I am without it.* She thought: *Then let us find out.* She drew a breath, the first real breath she had drawn for two years, from the very bottom of her, and the whole white arch above her seemed to lean a little closer, as an old house leans to hear its youngest child, and she opened her mouth, and from the far rim of the field Mikhail Sokolov, with his hand on the cold iron of

the rail, heard the first note come across the dark grass towards him, small as a lit match, and understood at last that the

Here the page is torn.

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SCENE IV

Jaipur. The courtyard of the Rathore haveli. Night, under the new roof. Four hundred guests, a thousand lamps, and a very long hush.

The collection had been shown. It had been applauded. A man in a good grey suit, in the third row, who had said he would attend in a professional capacity, had been observed taking off his spectacles, and then, with great dignity, wiping them on a handkerchief that was not wholly dry.

And now the lamps had been lowered, and the tablas had stilled, and across the courtyard, in the saffron turban of an ancestor and a sword that had never been drawn, a tall, vain, magnificent man was walking towards a woman in plain white, with indigo to the wrist.

“Priya Sharma,” said Vikram Rathore, in the voice that he used for kings and coaches, “I have been a guide for twelve years. I have shown the Palace of Winds to eleven thousand people. I have told them, every one, that a house is a story told in stone, and that its greatest romance is not its walls but the person who comes to live in it.” He sank onto one knee, with a clatter. “I was

the heir of a haveli with no roof. You gave it a roof. And I have no more to give you than a ruin that now leaks less. Will you—”

“I will answer,” said Priya, “after I have read the contract.”

There was a gasp. Somewhere near the chef’s pot, Pooja Tiwari dropped her notebook.

“There is a contract?” said Vikram.

“There is always a contract. I will have the north wing for a studio, the courtyard on Thursdays, final say on all colour, and a name on the door.” She folded her arms. Her eyes, which were the dark and steady eyes of a woman who has shown her father a whole room of her own, were quite wet. “Is that agreed?”

“Agreed,” said Vikram, in a smaller voice. “Agreed, agreed, agreed. All of it. Every word. I will sign in blood.”

“Ink will do.” And then Priya Sharma, heiress, apostate, designer, put out both hands, and drew him up off his knee, and kissed him on the forehead, once, in front of four hundred people and a fine Rajasthani moon.

“Yes,” she said. “Obviously. I was only waiting for you to finish the *speech.*”

The roar went up under the new roof and lasted until the dal was cold.

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SCENE V

Manchester. The band room. A Tuesday evening, with rain.

The band room smelled, as it had for ninety years, of valve oil and damp wool, and Mr. Pennywhistle, caretaker, sixty-eight, who had held the key to it for forty-one of them, was reading a postcard to an empty room.

It was an old habit. He read aloud all post, to the chairs, and the chairs, who had heard every confession of the brass section since nineteen-eighty, had never yet corrected him.

Dear Mr. P. We are on the ferry to Helsinki. The honeymoon has been a triumph. Tell the lads there is a stage here, in Tallinn, shaped like the inside of a shell, and a hymn played on it hangs in the air for nine and a half seconds. Poppy says she is going to make the band come out and play it. I have measured the lawn. It is excellent.

I will not tell you what happened on the last night, Mr. P. We were standing in the dark at the side of the stage with some new friends, and the whole place went so quiet, and it was not ours to post. I will tell you in person, or I will not. Poppy says some things you keep. But I wanted you to know there is a place in the world where a person tried a very hard thing, in front of the people who love her, and we were there.

The cornet is fine. Love, W. and P.

Mr. Pennywhistle put the card on the music-stand. He looked out of the rain-streaked window at the car park, where a single streetlamp was holding up the whole dark like a mast.

“He does not say,” said Mr. Pennywhistle, to the chairs. “A postcard, I have always held, is a thing that stops where it can.” He sighed. “It is the one form of writing that is entitled to leave the best part out.”

The chairs, who had heard everything, said nothing at all.

“And I never do find out how anything ends,” said Mr. Pennywhistle, “my own novel included,” and went to put on the kettle.

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Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

Entry 0606. Entry 0090. A man who feared his own quiet; a woman who had mislaid her sound. I will say only what I have learned in a great many rooms: that a silence is not a wall. It is a very large room, tuned, with a door at the far end, and the door is not locked.

Keep the door in mind, reader. Do not ask me which way it opened.

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End of Chapter 54.

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Chapter 55: Cassava and Code

“I breed seeds and I cannot grow a way to say your name.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0385

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SCENE I

Ibadan, Nigeria. A research station on a red-earth hill above the city, where the rooftops below lie like a sea of rust. Seven in the morning, and the harmattan not yet come.

Victor Adeyemi, thirty-two, agricultural scientist, had been trying to breed a perfect cassava for eleven years, and in all that time had never once been late for a plant.

He was late now. He stood in the long green field of Plot Fourteen with a clipboard against his chest and let the sun come over the hill, and looked at the stems, which were taller than he had expected, and the leaves, which were whole where the mosaic disease should have curled them, and the roots, which he had dug up at dawn with his own bare hands and weighed on a kitchen scale, because the lab scale was being repaired and science, like the gods, is not proud.

Eleven kilograms a plant. Disease-free. It had never been done.

“Professor Afolabi,” he said into his phone, as though announcing a birth, “it is ready.”

“Is it a miracle?” said the voice at the other end, which belonged to Segun Afolabi, sixty, the director of the station, a dry, rumpled, comical figure in a tie that had been a wedding present to somebody else.

“It is a *line.*”

“I asked if it was a miracle.”

“It is a line with a high yield and a tolerance to mosaic and a low cyanide content.”

“That is the Nigerian definition of a miracle,” said Segun. “Come and register it. I have the form. The only thing missing is the name.”

Victor looked at the clipboard. On the line marked *Variety Name* a small neat blank awaited him, a little white doorway.

He had named a hundred lines, in his time, by codes: *TMS-14-A, IBA-9-11, ABD-02.* Machines had no feelings. But the registry of the Federal Ministry required, for any variety to be released to a farmer, a *name*: a word that a woman in a village could say across a market without being thought a clerk. He had had the form for a month. He had written on it, and crossed out, forty names. They were the names of mountains, of old kings, of his grandmother.

He had not written the one he wanted. He did not know how.

I breed the seed, and cannot grow the word. I know the genome of a thousand roots; I know which gene will carry which resistance; I can make drought and blight lie down like sheep. But I have sat these eleven months beside A woman at a loan desk, and I could Not tell her that her laugh was my best crop. A name is such a little thing to put On a form. And yet the blank has stood there since The month she came to the institute with chickens To ask me, shyly, if the peel could feed them.

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SCENE II

The same morning, on the other side of the hill. A poultry farm, forty thousand birds, and a loan.

Funmi Balogun, thirty, poultry entrepreneur, had been smiling at people for two years in the hope that they would not ask her for money.

She was good at it. She smiled at the bank manager, the feed merchant, the man from the electricity company, and the pastor of the church, who had also lent her something. She smiled in the voice of a woman who owes six million naira to four institutions and a cousin; she smiled in the rhythm of a woman who has learned to say *next week* with a face like a sunrise. She was sharp and funny and exhausted, and she kept her books in a green exercise book with a cartoon hen on the cover, which was the only honest ledger in the building.

"Aunty Funmi," said a boy in the doorway of the office, "the man from the bank is at the gate."

“Tell him I am in the shed.”

“He says you said that last time.”

“Then tell him,” said Funmi, “that I am in a *different* shed.”

“He says there is only one shed.”

“Tell him it has been renovated.”

On the wall behind her hung a calendar from the feed merchant, with a photograph of a very contented hen, and, tucked in its frame, a card from the research station on the hill, with a diagram. On it, in a careful engineering hand, a man had drawn how cassava peel, properly dried and ground, could replace forty per cent of her maize in the feed. Beneath it ran a few lines of code for a spreadsheet, which he had written himself one night, to work out her ration to the kilo. He had sent it six months ago. He had never sent anything else.

The man from the bank came in. He was a patient man named Mr. Tunde Obi, fifty, bank manager and in a former life a dentist, who had learned that extracting a debt and a tooth required identical bedside manners.

“Mrs. Balogun.”

“Miss.”

“Miss Balogun, I have to inform you that on the thirtieth the board will call the loan unless there is a payment.”

“The thirtieth is a Friday.”

“It is.”

“I will have it on the Thursday.”

“You said that in July.”

“And God was a witness,” said Funmi, “and He has not corrected me.”

“He is a very patient creditor,” said Mr. Obi. “The board is not.”

Mr. Obi looked at her, a long, kind, professional look, over the top of a face that had watched eleven hundred tragedies arrive as missed repayments. “Madam,” he said, “I will tell you a thing that I should not. There is a rumour that the research station on the hill has a new cassava. A great one. It will cut the cost of feed by a third. The word is that the man who bred it has been asking where to find a poultry farmer who has the nerve to try it first.”

“Which man?” said Funmi.

“The one who sent you the card,” said Mr. Obi. “It is a small town, madam, and I was once a dentist. I am still told everything through the mouth.”

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SCENE III

Lisbon. A small white church in Alfama, on a street so steep that the groom had arrived on all fours. Saturday.

Meanwhile, in a city where all roads lead down to the river and none of them are straight, a tram mechanic and a postwoman were being married by a priest who had known them both since the day the mechanic’s tram broke down in front of the church and he had said a prayer to it.

“You are shaking,” said Nuno Pereira, twenty-seven, best man, in the vestry, with an expression of deep concern.

“I am not shaking. I am vibrating at the *frequency of joy*.”

“You are talking to the cufflinks.”

“They are very good cufflinks,” said Tomás Villaverde, twenty-nine, who spoke to engines when he was frightened and had been reduced, in the absence of an engine, to a pair of silver ovals. “I am saying that I *appreciate* them.”

The winter had asked its payment. It had asked it of the pair of them in full, and they had paid, as people do, with what they had; and in the paying they had learned the one thing the Keeper’s note had not told them, which is that a debt well paid makes a marriage out of a courtship. It was enough to say that they had come through. It was enough that they were standing in a church in Alfama on a Saturday in October, in the autumn light, with a scent of grilled sardines coming in at the door.

The bride came up the aisle on the arm of the lampseller.

It was a great honour, and it was entirely against his wishes. Pereira, sixty, a dealer in lamps who had sold perhaps four in his life and had told her, daily, for nine years, that business was bad, had said that he would walk her up the aisle only if she promised not to tell anybody he had cried. He was crying now, noisily, into the sleeve of a suit that had been in a trunk since nineteen-

ninety, and all the way up the nave he was audibly telling her that it was a *good* sort of aisle, a *straight* aisle, a very *reasonable* aisle, as though he had built it himself.

“Pereira,” whispered Inês Carvalho, twenty-seven, postwoman, in a white dress and a pair of her mother’s pearls, “you are leaning on me.”

“I am *guiding* you.”

“You are leaning like a lamp-post.”

“A lamp,” said Pereira, with great dignity, “is a thing that shows the way. You have never once thanked me for it.”

“Thank you, Pereira.”

“Business,” said Pereira, blowing his nose, “has never been worse.”

At the altar, Tomás saw her, and his face went completely, helplessly open, like a tram door.

Inês took a folded paper from her sleeve. Eighteen months it had lain in the pocket of her postwoman’s jacket; she had read it in the bath, and on the tram, and once on the roof of the sorting office in the rain. It was addressed to a street that did not exist, and it had found her anyway.

“I have a thing to read,” she said to the priest.

“It is not in the liturgy.”

“It is in the post,” said Inês.

And she read the second line aloud. We shall not repeat it. Those who wish to know it must go back to the beginning, and stand in a doorway in Alfama, and ask the tiles; they are old, and they hold their tongues until they are asked in the proper voice. It is enough to say that it was short. It is enough to say that Tomás Villaverde, who had written it in the dark to a woman whose face he had never seen, had been begged by his own blushes to forget it, and could not; and that it was a perfectly good second line, and the best thing she had ever delivered.

"I do," said Inês, when the priest had finished weeping.

"I do," said Tomás, to the cufflinks, and then, hastily, to her.

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SCENE IV

Vienna. The Brahms Hall of the Musikverein. A Sunday matinée, a full orchestra, and a bride.

Clara Weber, thirty-two, conductor, had a perfect ear and an imperfect patience, and had never in her life permitted a note to go flat.

She stood now on the podium, in a white concert dress, baton in hand, at her own wedding, and the orchestra, who had been sworn to silence, were looking up at her with the pale terror of men who have never seen her smile.

In the front row, with a violin in his lap, sat a meticulous, shy, sandy-haired man of thirty-six, a violin-maker, who had built an instrument that only one woman in the world could play, and who had come, as he always came, in a clean shirt, an hour early, to be sure of finding his seat.

"Ladies and gentlemen," said Clara, in the voice she used for the brass. "The A, please."

The oboe sounded the A. The orchestra, as one, tuned.

All of them, to a man, to a woman, to the last second violin, tuned a quarter-tone flat.

It was the most appalling sound in the history of Vienna. The ushers winced. The old professor in the third row put his fingers in his ears. And Clara, with her baton raised, stood quite still in the middle of it, with tears running down her imperious face, and spoke the only verse she had ever written, in four plain lines to a man in the front row:

I have kept the pitch for thirty years, and I am tired of it. One note in all my perfect life rang false, and it was you: The wrong, the dear, the unforeseen, the flat and human one. I tune the world to you today. Come up and play it through.

Jonas Müller, who had never in his life been the subject of a verse, stood, and picked up the violin, and walked down the aisle between the weeping horns, and with a perfectly steady hand played, in front of six hundred of the best-trained ears in Europe, the one note that was wrong.

It was the most beautiful sound in Vienna.

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SCENE V

Gothenburg, on the sea. The southern archipelago, a ferry, a rock, a glassblower's two hands.

Erik Johansson, thirty-four, glassblower, had burned his hand to see a woman again, and had been frankly insulted by how well it had worked.

It had been a second burn, a small one, a few seconds against the pipe, deliberately mistimed on a Tuesday, in the sure and shameful hope that a certain nurse at a certain clinic would be on duty. She had been. She had dressed it, with a firm, blunt, tender competence, and looked at him over her glasses and said: *You did that on purpose, Mr. Johansson. The edges are too clean.*

"I did," he had said.

"I will not tell the clinic." She had taken his pulse, for no clinical reason. She had held it a second too long. "It is a very good pulse."

Now, on a rock in the southern archipelago, with the sea going out in long grey silk to the edge of the world, thirty guests in woollen jackets stood in a ring around a table on which stood two tall glasses, blown that week, a pale green like the inside of a wave. They were the best thing he had ever made. The hand that made them was healed, a little shiny, a little tight, a faint pink scar across the palm.

"Hold them up," said Astrid Lindqvist, thirty-two, nurse, with the sea wind blowing her hair across her face, "and I will tell you whether you have done them

right.”

He held them up. She examined them as she would a wound, with her head on one side.

“There is a bubble,” she said.

“It is a flaw.”

“It is a *pulse,*” said Astrid. “You told me so yourself, in the summer, over a lopsided bowl. I asked for one in mine, in the stem. It is a heart, Erik. The hand that burned remembers.” She looked at him with those brown, steady, impertinent eyes. “I said I had not forgotten your pulse. This is it. This is the sound of it, in glass.”

Behind them, Sofia Holm, twenty-eight, a tea-seller from the island and a woman of ferocious romance, was heard to sniff, and to murmur to nobody that she had never been so happy at a funeral, and when corrected, that it was perfectly the same.

They drank from the glasses. The sea went out and came back. And on the rock, among the thirty guests, there was a hush as of something very large and very tender being passed from one pair of hands to another.

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SCENE VI

Ibadan. A Thursday, at the end of a long red afternoon. The field day. Four hundred farmers on benches under a tin shade, a microphone with an opinion, and a hen.

At the end of the field day, in front of four hundred farmers, thirty women's co-operatives, a delegation from the Ministry and a young man from the radio, the director of the research station stood up, in a tie that did not fit, to announce the release of the new cassava.

"It is high-yielding," said Professor Segun Afolabi, to the benches. "It is resistant to disease. It cuts the cost of feeding the poultry of this country by one third. It has been bred by a man of exceptional patience, who has been up since four. It has a code. It has a number. It has had, until this morning, no name."

A murmur ran along the benches.

"I have here," said the Professor, holding up a form, "the registration. The name has been entered in a hand I recognise, at nine minutes past nine this morning, by a very frightened young man, who then ran away and has been hiding behind the tractor. I am going to read it to you."

He cleared his throat. At the back of the tent, behind the last row, a thin, anxious, extremely unhappy man in a lab coat put his face in his hands.

"The name," said the Professor, like a judge reading the verdict of a very friendly court, "is *Funmi.*"

In the third row, between a farmer from Ogbomoso and a woman selling roasted corn, a young woman in a yellow head-tie had stopped smiling.

Funmi. A common word. A name. In Yoruba, the old tongue of that country, it means, in plain English, *give me*, and in the longer form, *give me joy.* She had been

told it as a child; she had been laughed at for it; she had grown up with a name that was a request.

"It is a very good variety," said Professor Afolabi, to the benches, "and I have a rule that a name should be a thing you can call across a field. I have tried. It carries."

And across the field, from behind the tractor, in an unsteady voice, like a man calling a bird that has flown over a wall, Victor Adeyemi said it again, not to the Professor, not to the benches, but to a woman in the third row in a yellow head-tie, with her hands over her mouth and the loan of six million naira falling from her shoulders like a winter coat:

"*Funmi.*"

She stood up. She walked, with great composure, down the length of the tent, past four hundred farmers who had forgotten to breathe. She stopped in front of the tractor.

"You named a *root vegetable,*" said Funmi Balogun, "after me."

"I named a *line.*"

"It is going to be in every farm in Nigeria. People will say my name in markets. They will say, *Is there any Funmi? Is it the good Funmi? Funmi is yielding.*" She was crying and laughing, in the helpless way of the very proud, and her yellow head-tie had come undone. "You cannot grow a way to say my name, you wrote."

"I could not."

“You *did.*” She took his clipboard out of his hands, quite gently, and held it against her heart, a plain wooden board with a form on it and eleven months of fear. “Come to my farm tomorrow. Bring the stems. I will feed them to the hens. And when the bank man comes on Friday, we will show him a *harvest.*”

“And on Saturday?”

“On Saturday,” said Funmi, “you can call me whatever you like.”

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Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R.:

A seed is a promise made to the dark and kept in the light. A name is the same, said aloud.

Entry 0385. Entry 0038. He could not grow the word; he grew the root, and the word came up beside it, as weeds and sweet things do. Mark: a Saturday of weddings, and a Thursday of one name. The Thursday was the braver.

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End of Chapter 55.

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Chapter 56: The Archive of Lights

“I have kept your log for twenty-five years.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0668

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Enter the Chorus, with a lamp.

A light is not the thing that lights the way; It is the promise that a shore is there. The keeper trims the wick and does not pray To see the ship. He prays she’s seen the flare. So in this archive, shelved by year and name, Are logs of men who lit, and men who sailed, And one who wrote a girl’s name down in flame And closed the book, as brave men do, and failed To open it again. Mark how it goes: The keeper is a woman, and she knows.

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SCENE I

Oslo. The Archive of Lights, a long, low, wooden-floored building on the harbour at Bygdøy, where the logs of every lighthouse and many ships in Norway are kept in steel cabinets, dry, cool and catalogued. Early November. The first dark of the year at four in the afternoon.

A light has a character, said the manual, and Ingrid Solberg, forty-seven, archivist, had read it so often that she could have recited the sentence in her sleep. *Every light is identified by its character: the pattern of its flashing, the colour, the period. By its character a mariner shall know it from every other light on the coast, and know where he is.*

She had always thought it the most consoling sentence in the language.

She sat at her high desk under a green-shaded lamp, in a grey wool cardigan, a pencil behind her ear, a precise, patient, slightly forbidding woman with eyes the colour of cold water over stones, and entered into the catalogue the last of a box of lightkeepers' journals from Lofoten. *Light: Skrova. Character: Fl W 10s. Keeper's remarks: wind SW, force 7, seen a whale.* She had catalogued four thousand lights. She knew every one of them by its flash.

"Fru Solberg!"

It was a large, cheerful, weather-beaten voice, and it came through the door ahead of its owner, followed by four people in orange life-vests, which was alarming in a building so far from water.

"Captain Dag," said Ingrid, closing the box.

"We were passing *deliberately,*" said Dag Ellingsen, sixty, captain of the sightseeing boat *Fjordfrue,* whose crew had been asked by travellers from sixty-one countries the same question, which was *where is your par-*

rot? “May I present the crew? Astri Dahl, my deckhand. Ragnhild Dahl, her aunt, my engineer. We are all of us *parrotless.*”

“A man from Iowa asked me yesterday whether he might pat it,” said Astri Dahl, thirty-nine, with great bitterness.

“What did you say?”

“I said it had flown to Denmark.”

“That is the correct answer. Now.” He took off his cap, which with Dag was equivalent to a stage direction. “I am here for an old shipmate. He has something he wishes to give the Archive, and he is a coward, and I have undertaken to carry it in the door.”

“Who is the shipmate?”

“A man,” said Dag Ellingsen, with all the delicacy of an anchor on a church floor, “named Nilsen.”

Ingrid’s pencil, which had been in her hand, was suddenly on the floor.

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He was in the car park. He had been there forty minutes, in an old blue seaman’s coat, with a parcel under his arm wrapped in oilcloth and tied with tarred string, and a face that looked as if it had been issued with the coat.

Anders Nilsen, fifty, retired captain: gruff, long-boned, white at the temples, hands like a pair of oars. He had retired two summers ago, with a bad back and a good pension, after thirty years at sea, and had since discov-

ered that anyone who has been bound for somewhere all his life is a poor tenant of the shore. He had a small flat in Grünerløkka and a cat that disapproved of him. And he had under his arm the last of his ship's logs, which the Archive of Lights would, a clerk had said with a sniff, be *happy to receive.*

He had read the name on the staff board three times. *I. Solberg, Archivist.* It is a common name, he had told the cat. The cat had declined to agree.

The door of the Archive opened. A woman stood in it, in a grey cardigan, with a pencil mark on her cheek.

"Captain Nilsen," said Ingrid.

"Fru Solberg."

"You have brought a log."

"I have brought it for the shelf. I do not need a receipt. I would—" He stopped. He looked at her, and the wind, which was coming up the fjord with a smell of snow, took the end of his sentence and carried it out to sea. "I have been told you are the keeper of these."

"I am."

"Then you will have the older ones. The ones from the early years. The *Havørn,* and the *Kristiansund,* and—" He cleared his throat. "Nineteen ninety-eight."

"The *Havørn,*" said Ingrid, "ninety-eight. Yes."

"You have it."

"I have had it," said Ingrid Solberg, "for twenty-five years."

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She took him, without a word, down the long room between the cabinets to a small steel drawer at the end, and opened it with a key from her belt. From it she lifted a log-book, black with age, stamped with an anchor, and laid it on the reading table under the lamp. It fell open, without searching, to a page that had been opened so often it would do so on its own.

Bergen. 14 June. Alongside Bryggen 1800. Fair. Wind light N. Shore leave to 2200.

And below, in a young hand, in a smaller, quicker ink, set a little apart from the rest as one sets a thing in a locked drawer:

2140. Quay. A girl in a blue coat asked me the time. I did not give it. I wrote her name in the log, as she had given it me, to keep it. I. Solberg.

"I was twenty-two," said Anders, to the page. "I was a third mate on a ship that was sailing at midnight, and you were nineteen, and the time was a quarter to ten, and I said nothing, I said *I do not know,* and you laughed, and said *the clock is behind you,* and it was. It was a clock on a post. And I turned back and you had gone. And I stood there with the name in my head, and I could think of nothing to do with it but write it in the one book I owned that nobody would ever read."

"I read it," said Ingrid. "In two thousand and one. A box came from the shipping company, with fifty years of logs. I was a junior, cataloguing the rubbish. I opened the *Havørn* at random." She laid her hand on the page. "And there was my name, in a stranger's hand, and a quay I had stood on, and a boy who had said *I do not know,* whom I had thought for three years a very rude

sailor.” She smiled, or something very close to it. “I put it in this drawer. It was a theft, and I have committed it every day since, and the Archive has never missed it.”

“Twenty-five years,” said Anders.

“A little more. And I have a thing to say to you, Captain Nilsen, which I have not said to a living person, which is that you were a very bad liar. *I did not give the time.* You wrote it down. You gave it. You gave it to the log.”

> *I might have been a lamp that no one trimmed, A shelf, a drawer, a cardigan, a card. I kept your log. I had no right to keep it. I read it in the spring, each year, in April, When the first light comes early to the harbour. I never wrote to you. I did not know If you were living, or had married, or Had forgotten the whole of it by Lisbon. I only knew that you had written me down. It is a thing, to be written down. It is Perhaps the only thing that I had wanted.*

For a long time neither of them said anything. Outside, the wind blew a long note through the rigging of the harbour, and the lights of the city came on, one by one, in good order.

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SCENE II

St Petersburg. An old theatre on a canal, after midnight. The stage dark but for one lamp. First snow beginning on the glass.

In another city, in another dark, a man who had been a pianist in the same theatre for twenty years was sitting at its great black Bechstein, with a woman standing at the edge of the light, holding a stick.

Dmitri Volkov, forty, courtly, rigid, had written a waltz for her and never asked her to dance; and Anya Petrova, thirty-eight, retired ballerina, proud, with a bad knee and a worse temper, had heard it from the wings of a gala and known at once that it was hers.

They had danced once since, at the edge of a crowded floor, as people dance who are making a point. Her knee had not forgotten it.

“You do not have to,” said Dmitri.

“I know that.”

“It is a cold night. I merely wished—”

“Dmitri Volkov.” She tapped the stick on the floor. “Sit. Play the first sixteen bars. And then stop. I shall tell you when.”

He played. The waltz came out of the Bechstein as it had come out of him in the spring, a little formal, a little startled, an evening suit that has wandered onto a beach. It went up, and turned, and came gently down. And on the sixteenth bar Anya Petrova laid her stick on the lid of the piano, like a duellist ending the quarrel.

“Stop,” she said.

He stopped.

“Stand up.”

“I cannot play and—”

“I will hum.” She held out her hand. “You have played it nine hundred times to an empty room. I have known it by heart since the gala. I have hummed it in my kitchen. It is mine. I shall supply the rest.”

She hummed. It was not a trained sound; it was low, wry, a trifle flat; it was the sound a woman makes when she is opening a door in a house she has never entered and has always known the way to. Dmitri Volkov rose from the stool, in the single yellow lamp, and put his right hand on the small of her back, and they began, in the empty theatre, with the first snow tapping at the fly-tower, to waltz.

She did it badly. The knee failed her once, at the turn, and he held her, and she swore, richly, in a language the stage had known for three hundred years. Then she laughed, an astonished laugh, and they went on, round and round the bare boards where a hundred thousand people had once watched her; and neither of them, afterwards, could say who had been leading.

“It is not a good dance,” said Anya, out of breath, with her forehead on his shoulder.

“It is the best I have ever been in.”

“You have never been in one.”

“That,” said Dmitri gravely, “is what makes it a record.”

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SCENE III

Addis Ababa. A flat on the slopes of Entoto. A coffee ceremony, at dusk. Frankincense on the charcoal and a clay pot with a long neck.

In the hills above Addis, a woman sat on a low stool beside a small brazier, roasting green beans in a pan, while a man who did not know how to be silent in her presence sat opposite her, silent.

Selam Tesfaye, thirty-three, who had run her last race on a bad ankle and had not yet decided what to do with the rest of her legs, shook the pan, and the beans, which were from his own warehouse, spat and smoked and gave off the dark, sweet smell that is Ethiopia's single greatest argument. Samuel Bekele, thirty-six, coffee exporter, watched her with a respect that bordered on the religious.

"The debts," said Selam.

"Are what they are."

"That is not an answer."

"It is a *summary.* My brother owed forty-one people. I have paid eleven. The bank has given me until June. I have no right to ask a woman anything until I can say *none.*" He looked at his hands. "I am a man who is behind. You are a woman who has finished. I do not think those two things can be put in one house."

Selam poured the coffee. It came out of the *jebena* in a long black thread into the tiny cup, and she handed it to him with both hands, as is the custom, and her mother, Tigist, seventy-six, who had been shelling beans in the corner with an expression of total inattention, spoke without looking up.

“A woman who has finished,” said Tigist, “is a woman who has begun something else, and has not been told.”

“Mama.”

“I am only shelling beans.”

Selam did not look at Samuel. She looked at the smoke. “There is a girls’ running club on Entoto,” she said. “Thirty children. They have no coach. I start on Monday. The track is at five in the morning. It is very cold, and very high, and it is a long way up.”

“I do not run.”

“No,” said Selam. “But you could walk behind.”

He considered it a long time.

“At what distance?” said Samuel.

“That is the question,” said Selam Tesfaye, and drank her coffee, “that I do not yet know the answer to.”

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SCENE IV

The Red Sea, southbound. Ship’s radio. Night. Two hulls, one mile apart, passing at a combined speed of forty knots.

“*Vela, Vela, this is Zagora. Do you read?*”

“I read you, Marija Kovač. You are on the wrong side of the world.”

“You are on the wrong side of the *channel.* Mind your lights.”

It was the only eleven minutes they would have that month: a ship northward for Rotterdam, a ship southward for Singapore, passing in the dark off the Gulf of Suez, with their radios in range for the length of time it takes two moving things to be in the same place.

“What is your position?” said Ivan Horvat.

“Dead ahead of you, a mile to port, and getting further.”

“I can see your lights. Very bright. That is the deck, and that is the bridge, and I think that is *you.*”

“It is the second officer’s cabin. He has left the lamp on again.”

“It is a good lamp,” said Ivan. “Eleven minutes. What shall we do with them?”

“The ninth of March.”

“The ninth of March,” said Ivan, as if repeating a creed. “A church. A priest. A gap in the schedules, which I have been told by three captains and one agent does not exist.”

“It exists. I have the tables.”

“And if the schedules slip?”

A long pause on the channel. Out on the black water, the light of the *Vela* slid slowly aft. Marija Kovač, chief officer, stood on the wing of the bridge with the radio in her fist and the night wind in her face, and thought of the sea, who was faithful and could not be wounded, and of the man, who was neither.

“Then it will be the ninth of April,” she said. “Or the ninth of May. I have decided to be a woman who is expected somewhere. It is not the same as being a woman who has arrived. But it is a start.”

“I do not know,” said Ivan, hoarsely, “whether that is a promise.”

“It is a position,” said Marija. “Plot it.”

The signal began to thin. The *Vela’s* lamps shrank to a spark, then a rumour, then a point in the huge dark behind. Static rose like surf. On the bridge of the *Zagora* the radio hissed and the watch went on, and the ships sailed apart, each toward the end of its charted day, with a church in Split, a long way off, unmoving in the mind.

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SCENE V

Bonwire, near Kumasi. A weaving shed under a tin roof. A loom, a lamp, a long morning.

A cloth of kente is not woven in one piece. It is woven in strips, narrow as a man’s hand, and sewn together edge to edge, so that a wedding cloth may be sixty strips, and every strip a month’s patience.

Kofi Boateng, thirty, weaver, sat at his loom in the shade with a shuttle in either hand and the thread of green and gold running through his fingers like water, and did not look up when a woman’s shadow fell across the cloth.

“I have said yes,” said Esi Appiah.

The shuttle stopped. “To the scholarship.”

“To the scholarship. For two years. I fly on Tuesday.” She was twenty-nine, a schoolteacher, with a bright, brave, difficult face, and she stood at the edge of the shed with a suitcase in one hand and a packet of boiled groundnuts in the other. “I did not know how to say it. I wrote *I do not know how to say yes.* And then I said it to my mother, and she said, *Esi, a thing you cannot say to the one it is for, you say first to someone else.* So I said it to the cat.”

“What did the cat say?”

“It said,” said Esi, “*Go.*”

He laughed, softly, a little hoarse.

“I promised to wait,” said Kofi, “and I am weaving it. See.” He held up the strip beneath his hands, a hand-breadth of green and gold, with a small black figure, a bird, looking back over its shoulder, woven into the edge: *sankofa,* the sign that says *go back and fetch it.* “A strip for every month you are gone. When you come home, I sew them together. It will be the size of your absence, Esi. Twenty-four strips. A cloth you can wrap yourself in.”

“And if I do not come home?”

“Then it will be a very large and very well-made cloth,” said Kofi, “and I will give it to the museum.”

She set down the suitcase, and went to the loom, and laid her hand on the edge of the strip, on the small black bird.

“Do not finish it too quickly,” she said.

“I will not.”

“I do not promise either.”

“I did not ask you to.”

On the tin roof the rain began. At the loom the weaver took up his shuttles again, and the thread ran through his fingers as it had for centuries, and the strip grew, a very little, on its frame.

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SCENE VI

Oslo. The deck of the Fjordfrue, *before dawn. A thin mist on the fjord. A flask, a cat’s-eye of light on the water, and a very large silence.*

He had asked her to come at six.

She came in a long blue coat, which she had last worn at nineteen in Bergen, and which still, by one of those small miracles of Norwegian wool, fitted; and she stood on the quay with her hand shading her eyes against a sun that had not yet risen.

“The captain has been persuaded to lend the boat,” said Anders Nilsen, from the gangway, in a clean shirt. “For an hour. He asks only that no one mention the parrot.”

“We are *parrotless,*” said Astri Dahl, from the stern, with dignity, “as a matter of principle.”

They went out through the mist, slowly, down the long grey water towards the islands, the lights of the harbour going out one by one behind them. Neither spoke for a long time. It is the privilege of two people who have

known each other, on and off, for twenty-eight years and a handful of days that they may be silent without saying so.

At the rail, Anders took from his coat the old black logbook. He had brought it out of the Archive that morning, on her own signature, which she had made with her pencil without once reading the form.

“I should have written something else,” he said. “That night. I should have written: *she asked me the time. I did not give it. I will go back.*”

“You did go back.”

“It took me twenty-eight years and a bad back.”

“The back,” said Ingrid Solberg, “was the quickest part.”

He opened the book to the last clean page. He took a pencil from his pocket, the stub of one, and held it out.

“You are the keeper,” he said. “Enter it.”

She took the pencil. For a long moment she stood at the rail with the book against her arm and the wind in her hair and the light, at the end of the fjord, beginning to come, and then she wrote, in the small upright hand in which she had catalogued four thousand lights:

Oslofjord. 6 November. Fair, wind light N. Dawn 0735. Aboard the Fjordfrue. *A man who did not give the time has given it. Position known. Character: steady. —I. S.*

She closed the book.

“You wrote ‘steady,’” said Anders.

“It is the technical term,” said Ingrid, “for a light that does not go out.”

The sun came up over the fjord. It lit the water gold, and the mist, and the faces of five people on a small white boat: a captain wiping his eye on his sleeve, and the parrotless crew, who had said nothing at all for six full minutes, which was a record.

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Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., beside Entries 0073 and 0668:

A light has a character, which is the pattern in which it tells the truth. Some flash. Some turn. Some, like these two, stand steady in a drawer for twenty-five years and are not diminished.

Mark, reader, how many of the stories in this book are lights seen from ships that did not stop. I have kept a thousand. Not one of them, I think, was truly lost. They were only waiting to be entered.

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End of Chapter 56.

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Chapter 57: Telescopes Over Lima

“I am chasing a dark star because I am afraid to look at you.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0567

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Enter the Chorus, with a lantern, which is of no use to the story but looks well.

Lima lies under cloud nine months in twelve, A rain so fine it wets no sleeve, yet blinds; Who hunts the stars must leave the wettest shelves Of sea-level and climb, and leave behind The warm, the fed, the footsore, and the near. We climb with one who flees a man with lunch, And with that man, who follows, pale with fear That love, like fish, is ruined by a hunch.

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SCENE I

Surquillo, Lima. A cebichería called La Marea, eleven-forty in the morning. The garúa lies on the rooftops like a lid.

Sergio Castillo, thirty, cook, believed three things: that fish must be bought before the sun, that a lime must be squeezed by hand and never twice, and that cebiche,

like love and unlike taxes, must be finished before four in the afternoon, after which it is not food but evidence.

He stood at the long steel table over a bowl of sea bass and watched the lime do its work. That is the secret nobody believes: there is no fire, only acid and time, and the fish goes from glass to silk in the length of a short hymn. Leave it three minutes and it is raw; five and it is rubber. The whole art is knowing when to stop waiting, and Sergio had practised it on fish for twelve years and on one woman for nine months, and the fish had been the more cooperative.

"Causa," said his younger brother Renzo, shaking out a black umbrella in the doorway, with great care, as a man does who has never needed to. "I sold one."

"An umbrella? In Lima?"

"To an Englishman. He said he wanted to feel at home." Renzo, twenty-five, umbrella-maker, owner of the least necessary trade in the southern hemisphere, set it on a stool. "I told him garúa is not rain. It is the sky *thinking* about rain. He bought two."

"That is not a sale. That is a sermon with a receipt."

Renzo sat down to the best cebiche in the district, coughing a small, quiet cough that he had been promising to take to the doctor, every spring, for three years.

At the next table sat Rosa Chávez, forty-two, community spiritual leader of three streets and a stairwell, whom nothing had ever frightened except a decaffeinated morning. She had a thermos of tea and a saucer on which she was reading, with great concentration, the dregs of the last customer's lime.

“The leaves say,” announced Rosa, “that the star-woman is leaving the dome.”

“Those are not leaves,” said Sergio. “That is a lime wedge.”

“Everything is a leaf, hijo, if you respect it.” She lowered her voice to a whisper audible across the street. “Nine months you have watched that little black circle on your phone. I charge for less.”

He had. It was the public feed of the all-sky camera at the university’s mountain station above Ticlio: a fisheye turned up to the night, the Milky Way across it like a spill of salt, and in one corner the edge of a dome with a small yellow window. That window was lit when Lucía Paredes was working. He knew its hours as other men know the prices of stocks. It was the only telescope he owned, and he had found, as lovers do, that *nothing* can be enormously detailed.

“There was snow on the camera for three nights,” he said. “And the window has been dark since Tuesday.”

Rosa tipped the saucer. “A dark window means a dead lamp. A dead lamp means a dead battery. A dead battery means *nobody has gone up with a new one.*” She looked at him with the gentleness of the truly fearless. “A star that is dark, hijo, is only a star waiting for somebody to bring it a lunch.”

Sergio, who had been given many oracles and never one so near to useful, put down the lime.

“Renzo. Mind the shop.”

“I am an *umbrella-maker*.”

“Then mind it with an umbrella.”

He filled a thermos with leche de tigre, the pale sharp milk of the marinade, which in Lima is drunk against hangovers, heartbreak and the general weight of existence; and at the door Milagros Ramos, the tea-seller who kept her cart at the university gate, caught his sleeve.

“She sends the bowls back,” said Milagros softly. “You know that? Washed. With a number in pencil on the rim.”

“I thought it was a code.”

“It is,” said Milagros. “A telephone number, Sergio. Only it is a *star's.*” She smiled, a little jealous of the young, and generous for once. “Go and ask her which one.”

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SCENE II

Above Ticlio, nearly 5,000 metres. Night. The dome is lit again, by a camp lantern. Inside, a woman alone.

Lucía Paredes had not slept for thirty hours, nor eaten properly for four days, and had written the same coordinates nineteen times in her notebook, and was, in her own estimation, perfectly well.

She had come up on Monday with the technician, who had gone down on Tuesday for a new generator battery, leaving her a lantern, a tin of biscuits and a promise to return on Friday, which had been, in the manner of Andean promises, an observation about the weather.

She was twenty-nine, small and quick, in four jumpers, one of them her father's, and she was, for reasons she would not have defended aloud, speaking to the telescope.

The dark is not an absence. It's a hand That pulls. I have been watching one red star Lean left, and lean again, eleven days And back, as someone leans who hears a name Called from a room behind. There's nothing there. That is the thing I'm hunting: nothing, weighted. My father taught me, when I was a child In Cusco, how to read the llama drawn Not by the stars but by the dark between them, Black in the river of the Milky Way, With two bright eyes, and walking, always walking. He said, "The bright is loud. The dark is true." And so I built a life on what I cannot See, and measured it by how the lit things lean. It's easier, you understand, than looking At what is plain and warm and very near: A man who sends a bowl of something clear Each Thursday, and who never asks for thanks; Whose bowls I wash, and write a number on, Because it is the only way I know To say the thing—

She stopped. The word was in her mouth, and she put it back like a coin of the wrong denomination.

"*Yana quyllur,*" she said instead. Black star. It was what her father called it when she was seven and had asked why the sky had holes in it.

She was reaching for the lantern when somebody knocked on the door of the dome.

Nobody knocks on a mountain. It does not have visitors; it has weather. The knock came again: three small taps, the knock of a man accustomed to asking whether the kitchen is open.

She slid back the bolt. On the step, leaning on the frame as though the frame were the only thing holding up the night, stood a young man with a thermos and lips the colour of a bruised plum.

"Buenas noches," said Sergio Castillo, in a voice as thin as the air. "I have brought lunch."

"It is past three in the morning."

"It is the lunch I owe you from Thursday. It has had a long journey."

"You are *blue.*"

"It is the cold."

"It is the altitude," said Lucía. "You have soroche. Come in. Sit. Put your head between your knees."

He sat. She made mate de coca on a camp stove, bitter and green and warm, the old tea of the mountains that her grandmother had given to every guest and every child and, on one occasion, a goat; and she watched him drink it, and found that her own hand was shaking, which she blamed on the stove.

"The night bus," said Sergio, between sips. "The conductor made bets on whether I would be sick before Ticlio. I was sick after. I was loyal to the wager." His colour came back by degrees, like dawn in a poorly run sky. "I saw on the camera that the light was out."

"You *watch* the camera?"

He did not lie. Raw fish and raw truth were the only two things he had never learned to cook.

“Every night,” he said. “It is the only telescope I have.”

Lucía put down the stove. She said nothing for one minute and fourteen seconds, which the dome, having heard a great many silences in sixty years, would have called a good one.

“The bowls,” she said at last. “You noticed the numbers.”

“Milagros said they were a telephone number.”

“They are *coordinates.*” Her voice cracked slightly on the word. “Right ascension and declination. Of the star I am hunting. I could not think of any other way to tell you where I was.”

“You were telling me where you were?”

“I was telling you where I *would be.*” She pushed the hair from her face with a mitten. “It is a very bad code.”

“I did not reply,” said Sergio, “because I thought it was a telephone number, and I was afraid to ring it.”

They looked at one another, two people who had been standing in the same dark with the same lunch.

“Wait,” said Lucía. She turned to the screen, where a graph lay stretched like a sleeping animal. “It is four-oh-two. In ten minutes my star should lean. I have waited eleven days for this. If the cloud holds off—”

She went to the slit. And the cloud, which had lain on the ridge all evening like a grey cat, rose, stretched, and with the contempt of its kind strolled away.

The sky opened: the whole ceiling of the world, thick with fire, and through it the river of the Milky Way, and in the river, black as ink on a bright cloth, the dark llama walking, her two bright eyes, Alpha and Beta Centauri, only now clearing the eastern ridge.

“The llama,” said Sergio, from the floor. “You drew her on a napkin at my table, the first day. I had it framed.”

She laughed, a short astonished sound, like a latch giving way. Then she crossed to the old telescope, with the brass eyepiece she kept for visitors, though nobody had ever visited, and turned its tube a quarter of a degree, and stood back.

“Come here. You are a cook. You know how to look at one thing for a long time.”

He rose, unsteady, and put his eye to the glass.

“What do you see?”

“Stars,” said Sergio. “A great many. And—” He paused. “A gap.”

“Yes.”

“Between them. A little round gap, like a place at a table laid for someone who has not come.” His voice dropped. “And all the lights around it are leaning toward the empty chair.”

Lucía Paredes, who had spent nine years studying the unseen and never heard it so well described, put her hand over her mouth.

“You cannot see it,” she whispered. “That is what a dark star *is.* You cannot see it. You can only see what moves because of it.”

“Then I see it,” said Sergio.

“It is *unconfirmed.* It may be a faulty sensor. It may be a flaw in the glass. To be sure I must see the lean twice: tonight, and again in eleven days. I will not believe it myself from one night.”

“Is it a long way, eleven days?”

“It is,” said Lucía carefully, “about a very good marinade.”

He turned from the eyepiece. He did not say *love,* a word he had never managed to say sober, nor, at that altitude, upright. He said, his lips the colour of a plum going slowly to rose:

“In cebiche, the lime does the cooking. You only have to know when to stop waiting.” He swallowed. “I have been waiting nine months. I do not know if that is four minutes too many or four too few. I only know that I came up a mountain to ask you.”

“And if it is too many?”

“Then the fish is rubber,” said Sergio, “and I will eat it anyway.”

The camera chimed on the desk. The exposure was finished. On the screen, in a cold grey square, a single faint red star was drawing itself, pixel by pixel, a little to the left of where it ought to be.

It might be the lean. It might be the sensor. It might be a hand, in the dark, pulling.

For the first time in nine months, Lucía Paredes did not look at the screen. She looked at him.

What she said, the page does not record, and the mountain keeps its counsel. But at sunrise the technician, who had returned a day early with a new battery and a bad conscience, found the two of them asleep in the old chairs with a thermos between them, and a notebook open to a page on which someone had written eleven days *and underlined it twice.*

Whether it was a star, we shall learn in eleven days. Whether it was a man with a thermos, you may already know.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

The Chorus turns the telescope. A lens, it is said, finds not what is far but what is dear.

Swing the glass eastward, over cloud and sea: The same dark sky is lifting over three Or four more beds of lovers, none yet crowned Nor lost, but tangled, or just homeward bound. Look. São Paulo. Dawn. A park. A hill. And someone with a ring he's wearing still.

São Paulo, Ibirapuera Park, 6:10 a.m.

Dr. Beatriz Lima had not slept since Tuesday, and it was Saturday, and she sat on a bench in her scrubs, grey as a hospital sheet, watching the joggers as though they were an interesting but irrelevant tribe.

"Doutora," said a voice. "You are asleep."

“I am resting my eyes. They are contemplating.”

Carlos Mendes, thirty-three, sports physiotherapist, sat beside her with two cups of coffee and a paper bag of pão de queijo. His left hand had a narrow pale band of skin where a ring had been for seven years, and it was beginning, this spring, to tan.

“You took it off,” said Beatriz.

“In the tango school. Very dramatically.” He gave her the coffee. “Beatriz. I have something to ask you.”

“Is it medical? I am off until, I believe, my retirement.”

“It is not medical.”

“Then ask me on a Saturday on which I have slept.”

He looked at her with the patient eyes of a man who has taught strangers’ legs to walk again, one centimetre at a time, and knows the difference between *no* and *not yet.*

“That is a date,” said Carlos.

“Is it?”

“I am afraid so. It is in my diary.”

From the kerb a taxi sounded its horn: Seu Gustavo, sixty-four, who had driven Carlos for twenty years and advised him, mostly, about football.

“Doutor!” he shouted. “When a woman says *ask me later,* she has already answered the first half of the question!”

“Which half?” said Beatriz, with her eyes shut.

“The *asking,* doutora!” said Seu Gustavo, radiant, like a man who has never in his life been wrong on purpose.

In São Paulo the story stands open, like a door on a warm morning.

Now north, to Prague, where marionettes are hung
Like words that hesitate upon the tongue.

Prague, a small theatre in Malá Strana, 9:45 p.m.

The lights went down on the last puppet, an old marionette in a green coat named Vendelín, who bowed; and the audience, nineteen people and a dog, clapped, and the dog barked, which in Prague is a rave.

In the third row sat Lucie Horáková, thirty-six, theatre critic, with her notebook shut. She had written nothing for ten months, not since she had understood that a review is a very small door through which, if one is careless, one may drive a whole theatre.

The curtain stirred. And for the first time in the history of that theatre, the puppeteer Petr Novák, forty, came out from behind the cloth with no puppet on his hand.

“Pan Novák!” hissed Markéta, who sold the tickets. “Where is Vendelín? You have forgotten your *hand!*”

“I have not forgotten it,” said Petr. “I am using it.”

He walked down three steps to the third row. His voice, which had hidden behind eleven wooden voices for twenty years, was small and rusty and wholly his.

“Paní Horáková,” he said. “I have not a very big sentence. I have only a short one. I would like to be reviewed by you, for the rest of my life.”

Lucie opened her notebook and held her pen a moment above the page.

“I did not hear the middle,” she said.

“There was no middle.”

“Then say it again.”

He said it again. She wrote it down in her harsh square hand, underlined it, and for the first time in a long career gave a man four stars.

And west again, to the green sierras: dawn, And a man with a flower on a mountain lawn.

Medellín, the climb above Santa Elena, midmorning.

“*Torres has attacked!*” cried Esteban Ortiz, soft-spoken commentator of the Cali radio, who had the distinction of being wrong on every broadcast and loved for it. “*He is away from the peloton! No, he has stopped! He is — he is picking up a flower!*”

Sebastián Torres, twenty-nine, professional cyclist, had indeed stopped forty metres from the finish for a single white carnation held out from the crowd by a woman with soil under her nails.

He finished eleventh. The prize for eleventh is a handshake and a bottle of water.

“You lost the stage,” said Daniela Ruiz, twenty-eight, flower farmer, whose farm was a field of petals and a bank letter lying face-down in a kitchen drawer.

“I was *distracted* from winning it. It is very different.”

“The bank has given me until Monday. They will not give me more.”

“I know.” He held up the carnation, grown from a cutting of her grandmother’s, a small stubborn flower that did badly in the markets and well in the hands of anyone who loved it. “I have eleventh-place money. And a sponsor who is thinking about me, which is not the same as paying.”

“It is not enough.”

“No. But it is a *start,* and I am very good at a start. I am bad at a middle and poor at a finish, but I have never had a bad start.”

Behind them the commentator told his listeners, “*I do not understand what is happening, but it seems beautiful.*”

“It is Monday I am worried about,” said Daniela.

“Then let us have Sunday first,” said Sebastián.

Monday, we are told, is another country; and whether they reached it, the Keeper does not say.

And last, to Persia, where the tilers keep A pattern which will never end, nor sleep.

Isfahan, a courtyard beside the river, evening.

There is a custom in the marriages of Iran that the bride, asked whether she consents, shall not answer at once, for she has gone to pick flowers. Twice the officiant asks, and twice the aunts call that she is not at home, and the third time she says *baleh,* yes, and the whole room breathes out as though it had been under water.

Parisa Karimi, thirty-one, architect-restorer, sat on a cushion before the sofreh, the spread of mirror and candles and honey and sugar loaves, and let the officiant ask her once, and twice, and let the aunts say, with great enjoyment, that she had gone to pick violets.

Across from her sat Ali Rezaei, thirty-six, tile master, hands scarred and steady, who had spent four years laying a blue pattern on the courtyard wall in which no figure repeated, tile by tile, like the thought of someone one loves.

"How do you know," Parisa had asked him, in the spring, "where each one goes?"

"I do not," Ali had said. "I only know where it fits."

That afternoon he had set the last tile and stood back; the pattern had not ended, but could now be left, like a sentence that has reached its breath.

"Third time," said Reza Jafari, the trader from Shiraz, fifty-seven, related to neither of them, who had come on the principle that a free dinner is a relative. "She will answer now."

"She may not," said Azadeh Ahmadi, eighty-seven, who had sold melons on this street for seventy years and was permitted every opinion. "She is a clever girl. She

may be waiting for the tile to be well and truly set."

"It is *set,*" said Reza.

"Then she will say yes," said the old woman, "which is what I told him when he was seven and could not put the blue one in the right place."

Parisa lifted her head. A woman who has spent her life putting broken things back, and a man who has spent his finding where the next thing goes, regarded one another with great seriousness.

"*Baleh,*" said Parisa.

And the courtyard, which had been waiting for a thousand years, laughed and wept and applauded all at once, as though a lamp had been lit.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., beside Entries 0567 and 0958:

"Candidate. Unconfirmed. Observed once. Do not announce a discovery until it has been seen twice." This is excellent advice for stars and nearly useless for people, who must announce the thing first and watch for the second sighting afterward. She will be back at the mountain in eleven days. So, I think, will he. I have marked both dates in the ledger and not what happens, for it is a great vulgarity to peek. Entries 0016 and 0818: a door left open. 0418 and 0227: a review, rewritten. 0586 and 0360: Sunday. 0228 and 0595: yes.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 57.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 58: Ten Thousand Miles of Wifi

“My family is still there. I cannot settle until they are here.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0680

✦ ✦ ✦

Enter the Chorus, with a cable over one shoulder, like a man about to hang a picture of the sea.

Ten thousand miles of cable in the deep Now carry, at the speed of light, a word; Yet who was ever fed, or helped to sleep, By something only sent, and only heard? Tonight we ride the wire from shore to shore To hear a dozen lovers say, “I’m here,” And two who say it slant, and wish for more, And do not say it yet. Lean closer, dear.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE I

Toronto. Pearson Airport, arrivals hall, 6:40 in the morning. A great many balloons.

Idris Hakimi, twenty-seven, engineer, had once built a bridge over a river in a country he could not name without his throat doing something complicated, and he had never in his life been so afraid of a set of sliding doors.

“They are late,” he said.

“They are on the ground,” said Fatima Noori, twenty-five, nursing student, who had checked the board eleven times. “Customs takes an hour. It is the law of customs.”

“It has been three years.”

“Then an hour,” said Fatima, “is a rounding error.”

It had been three years, nine offices, two sponsors, a lawyer who had cried once at a hearing and apologised for it, and a file that had at one stage been mislaid on a Tuesday. His mother and his sister were in that building somewhere, in a line, holding two bags and a bundle of bread wrapped in cloth, and he had not slept since the call from Frankfurt.

Behind them, a voice rose, unsteady with joy and helium.

“*Idris-jan! The balloons!*”

Najib Sultani, twenty-five, writer, devout, and the most generous man in Scarborough with other people’s money, came through the crowd with a sign in one hand and fourteen balloons in the other. The sign read WELCOME TO CANADA, HAKEEMY FAMILY. The balloons read, in curly silver, CONGRATULATIONS ON YOUR NEW BABY.

“Najib.”

“They had a sale.”

“Najib, we do not have a new baby.”

"*They* do not know that," said Najib, with great logic. "And also they were from the baby shower, and the baby shower was in the next hall, and the supermarket was closed, and it is clearly the will of God that these balloons find a home. I used your card. I will repay you in the next book."

"You have never repaid me in the last book."

"It is a long book."

Fatima, who was shaking, laughed, and put her hand over her mouth; and the doors slid back, and out of them, pushing a trolley with a bundle in a cloth, walked a small woman in a grey headscarf and a long coat, and beside her a girl of fifteen with enormous eyes, who looked at the balloons, and the sign, and the ceiling, and the enormous gleaming country behind the glass, and said, in Dari, "Madar-jan, it is very *clean.*"

Idris did not run. He was an engineer; he walked the whole distance, at a steady load-bearing pace, and when he reached his mother he said, as he had rehearsed on the plane, "*Salaam, Madar-jan,*" and then said nothing else, for there was nothing in the engineering of language that would hold.

She put both hands on his face. She looked at it as one looks at a bridge one has been told has been rebuilt, and has not quite believed.

Then Fatima stepped forward.

She had rehearsed it for two years, on the bus, in the bath, once in a hospital cafeteria at four in the morning with a patient's grandfather correcting her vowels. Her

parents had come from Herat, but they had raised her in kitchen Dari, a Dari for salt and bread and *wash your hands,* and she had needed more: a Dari for this.

"*Madar-jan,*" said Fatima, slowly, setting each word down like a cup on a tray. "*Khosh āmadid.*"

Welcome. Then, in the same careful hand, a second sentence, longer, in a language that had taken her two winters to learn, and which the page, for once, will not translate, except to say that it was about how a person does not have to be carried alone any more. Idris stood very still beside her; for the first time in his life he did not translate; he could not have.

The old woman said nothing. She took Fatima's face in both hands, as she had taken her son's, and kissed her once on the forehead, and began, without the least attempt at composure, to weep. Beside her, the girl said, in English, "Is that a *baby* balloon?"

"It is a mistake," said Najib, "that has become a blessing."

Mark this, reader. A man may be ten thousand miles from his mother and three years from his promise, and then a pair of doors will open, and the arithmetic will be, for once, kind.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE II

Lyon. A bakery and a florist's, side by side, with a new door cut through the wall between them. Sunday, five in the morning.

Pierre Dubois, forty-five, baker, gruff, stooped, and a widower of eight years' standing, stood at the oven in a floury apron and lifted out two loaves.

The first was his wife's: round, dark, dusted, scored with a cross. He had baked it every Sunday for eight years, and it was the best bread in the arrondissement, and he had never once sold it.

The second was new. It was scored not with a cross but with a spray of small curved cuts, like a handful of violets thrown at a wall.

"It is crooked," said Mathieu Lefèvre, the clock-mender, fifty-nine, from the doorway. He had come to oil the shop clock and had stayed, as he always stayed, for the free bread and the pleasure of being slightly wrong. "A baker's loaf should not look like a *mistake.*"

"It looks like violets."

"Which is a mistake in a loaf." Mathieu consulted his watch. "It is ten past five. No. Twenty to six. No— I believe the clock above your door is correct and my watch is a liar. Pierre. Why have you cut a door in your wall?"

"For the draught."

"You have cut a door in a wall for a draught."

"It is a *very* specific draught," said Pierre, and went through the door.

On the other side, in the dark among the buckets, stood Margaux Laurent, forty-two, florist, widow, with her sleeves rolled and a bunch of violets in her hand. She had been leaving flowers at his door for three years. Nobody was supposed to know. All of Lyon knew.

He set the loaf on her counter. He did not say anything. His hands, which were large and white with flour, were shaking, and she looked at them with the gentlest irony in France.

“It was always me,” said Pierre at last, hoarsely. “The bread. On your step. Every week, when you thought it was the neighbour’s boy. I could not put a note in it. A note is a thing that can be read.”

“I know.”

“You *know*?”

“The neighbour’s boy cannot bake,” said Margaux. “He has been to my kitchen. He has burned a salad.”

He laughed, a sound like a heavy door on a good hinge. She put the violets in his hand, and took the loaf in hers, and they stood in the dark and held each other’s offerings like two people exchanging coats on a cold platform.

Behind them, in the bakery, Mathieu’s clock struck, thirteen times, and was never repaired.

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE III

Mirpur, Dhaka. The tea stall at the corner of the lane, a Friday, nine-fifteen at night. It does not rain. The lane has electricity. Everyone is slightly alarmed.

“Bhaiya,” said Bunny, who was fourteen now, and had been promoted from the kettle to the cash drawer, and from opinion to policy, “you have been looking at your phone for six minutes without drinking your tea.”

“It is a thread. From the Register.” Fayaz Rahman, twenty-seven, looked up. He had on the good shirt, ironed, and the look of a man who has for twelve months been rather more afraid of good news than of bad. “Nadeesha started it. *One year. Say where you are.* There are four hundred replies.”

“Read me one.”

“*Youssef, Casablanca,*” read Fayaz. “*I read this whole page myself. It took eleven minutes. Salma timed me. She says the next one may take ten.*”

“Good. Another.”

“*Dr. Nusrat, Sylhet. The new autoclave is a marvel. Rahim bhai says that is because it has never met the district.*”

“I like him. He is from Chittagong?”

“He is a foreman.”

“Same thing. Another.”

“*Dewi, Ubud,*” read Fayaz. “*For my cousin in Rotterdam: your grandmother says Ayu has learned a new word and will not tell me which. I have my suspicions. Putu says I am not to say. I am not saying.*”

Bunny wiped the counter, which did not need it. “Bhaiya. Rotterdam is five hours behind us now.”

“You have looked it up.”

“The Dutch put their clocks back in October,” said Bunny, “and took another hour off her. In the summer it was four. Everything in your life is an hour, Bhaiya; I said so in the spring.”

“I look up everything. Last year she was one hour in front of you. Now she is five behind. At this rate, by next year she will be in yesterday and you will be in Tuesday and the only place you can meet is in the middle of the sea.”

Fayaz opened his mouth, and shut it.

“That,” he said, “is not very far from geographically accurate.”

“I know,” said Bunny, solemn as a customs officer. “I read the map.”

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE IV

The flat, third floor. A desk, a lamp, an Instant Power Supply the size of a small coffin, humming. On the wall above the desk, hung with four pins and tremendous care, a long cloth of dark indigo covered in black stars.

At 9:58 by his clock, which was now correct to the second, since a man with a contract keeps the time he is paid by, Fayaz sat down and pressed the green button.

He had a contract. He wished, he found, to say it often, as one says the name of a new town. Not the night-work for the agency in Singapore, which had been a rope thrown across a river; but a contract in his own name, with a logistics firm, for the building of a system that would track containers across half the world, and a day-time salary in a currency that was, in the language of his old arrangements, *kind.* On the balcony, his father sat with the green ledger on his knee, as he had every

night since the spring, and with a steel ruler and a pencil, and on the first of each month he drew a neat line through a number. There were four numbers left. They were large. They were visible, which was a different thing from large.

The Wi-Fi was called BINTANG_HITAM. Tithi had named it, and refused to rename it, on the ground that it was the only thing in the house that never dropped.

The screen woke.

It was a studio. Tall windows, the dark coming down on a wet grey city at five o'clock in the afternoon, a long table, a steaming iron, a copper canting in a brass dish, pinned cloths in rust and indigo and a white so pale it seemed to be thinking. On the wall, over the table, hung a clock whose hands said eleven.

"It is five o'clock in Rotterdam," said Fayaz.

"On Fridays," said Ermis Larasati, twenty-five now, indigo on both cheekbones and a pencil in her hair, "Rotterdam is a province of Java. I have told them the clock is broken. They find me charming and a little ill."

"You have kept it for six months."

"I have kept it for every Friday. You said *ten, yours; eleven, mine.* You did not say whose clock." She smiled. "You have a generator!"

"I have an IPS."

"It is a *generator*."

"It is, on the right circuit," said Fayaz, "and I would like it recorded that no one was more surprised than me."

They looked at each other. A year of Fridays, he thought, is not a year of looking: it is a year of looking *at.*

"Show me," said Ermis.

He turned the laptop. She leaned toward it, the way one leans toward a small window in a very large wall, and took in the long cloth on the wall of the Dhaka flat: *Bintang Hitam,* a field of black dots on indigo, the pattern she had drawn for him in the spring.

"Tithi counted the dots," said Fayaz, "and gave up at four hundred and some. She says a pattern that wants to be counted is flirting."

"Tithi is a very dangerous girl."

"She has just been admitted to the university."

"I *know.* She told me. She told me *first.*" Ermis laughed, and her eyes were bright. "Fayaz. It is finished. Mine. The big one. It goes on the wall tomorrow."

She turned a second camera, and the screen showed a cloth three metres long, hung from the beams, in two halves. The left half was night: deep indigo, a single white star, small as a pin. The right half was dawn: the palest blue, and in the middle of it, one black star.

"*Selisih,*" said Ermis. "It means the difference. As in, *the difference between two clocks.* The director asked me what it meant and I said *an hour.* She said it was a very expensive hour. I said that is how they come."

"It is beautiful."

"I am going to cut it in half."

"You are *what?*"

"It is made to be two," said Ermis. "I have always known. I have not decided which half will be whose." She looked into the camera. "I will decide when I can see."

Something small rang in the room behind her: a phone, propped against a jar, playing a message. A voice that had been compressed through three networks and a grandmother's thumb shrieked into the studio:

"*TOO LATE! TOO LATE! FAYYAAS! BEAUTIFUL!*"

There was a very long silence.

"She learned my *name*?" said Fayaz.

"She learned it," said Ermis, in a voice of ruined dignity, "from my grandmother. Who learned it from me. Who said it, very *occasionally,* in the kitchen, to a *saucepan.*"

"She has put it in the right order."

"She says it to *everyone.*"

"She said it to me *first.*"

"Fayaz—"

"I have no complaints," said Fayaz, gravely, and laughing. "I wish only to record it."

She put her face in both hands. When she took them away her cheeks had a third stripe of blue, and her mouth was trembling, not from sorrow.

"All right," said Ermis. "Now. Serious. The thing we have not said in a year. I want us to say it."

“Which thing?”

“*When.*”

He had known it was coming. He had known it for a year, as one knows the date of one’s own exam; and he had come to the screen with a plan, three contingencies and a spreadsheet, and found them all, in the face of that small lit window, perfectly useless.

“I cannot say a date,” said Fayaz, slowly. “My debt is four lakh from clear, and four lakh is very near, and very far. My mother’s treatment has its second phase. My father is better, and I do not wish to leave while he is learning to be.” He took a breath. “You have the lab until March. And a second year, if you take it. And after that the world has asked for you.”

“I know.”

“I would not hold a date over your head like a wet cloth.”

“Nor I over yours.” She picked up the canting, put it down. “So no date. I do not want a date. A date is a promise with a lid on it. I want something *looser.*”

“When both our skies are clear,” said Fayaz.

The pencil in her hair slid and fell. She did not move.

“Say that again.”

“When both our skies are clear. Not before. Not by plan. The way a tide comes.” He smiled, a little crookedly. “I think it was something I took from my Keeper.”

“Where?” said Ermis.

"*Where* is the question." He pulled up a map on the second screen, because he was, after all, a man who built systems. "My Dhaka to your Java, by line, is nearly four thousand kilometres. You cannot come here, with Rotterdam, and I cannot go there, with the embassies as they are, so we need a place *between our homes.* Halfway. I have measured. It is a little nearer to me, which I shall not apologise for. I will carry the bags." He turned the screen. "Bunny says we shall meet in the middle of the sea. I have looked for the least wet place."

The map showed the long green leg of the Malay peninsula, and, hanging off it into the blue like a pendant on a thread, an island.

"*Phuket,*" said Ermis.

"It is in the Andaman Sea."

"It is in *Thailand,* Fayaz. Thailand has a flag."

"The beach does not."

"Beaches do not have *visas.*"

"Exactly," said Fayaz. "It is halfway. It is where no flag stands. I will bring a passport that has been renewed, which in Dhaka is a pilgrimage in itself. And I will not be sick on the ferry."

"It is on my time," said Ermis, who had begun to laugh and cry in the same breath, which in a designer is called *registration.* "Phuket is on the Java hour. You will have to put your watch forward."

"I know."

"You will be in *my hour.*"

“For once,” said Fayaz, “neither of us will be ahead.”

She stopped laughing. In the window, her face had gone very still, and very soft, and she looked just then like the girl in the workshop in a pale first morning, with her sentence on a page, and no one to say it to.

“Then I will tell you what I will do,” said Ermis. “In the spring I said that I was an hour ahead of you. Now I am five hours behind you, and it is the first time in my life that I have been behind anyone and not minded.” She leaned on one hand. “From where I sit, you are in my future. Tell me what you see.”

“Ermis—”

“Tell me. I saw yours, once. It is only fair.”

Fayaz looked at the cloth on his wall, and at his father on the balcony, drawing a line through a number with a steel ruler, and at the lit window with the pencil-haired woman in it, five hours back in the day and a year forward in everything else.

“I see a beach,” he said slowly. “I see two people who are very bad at beginning a sentence. And one of them says, *I would tell you everything.*” He breathed. “And the other waits for the *if* — and there is no *if.*”

There was a very long quiet. Rain on the Rotterdam windows. A kettle on the Dhaka stove. A parrot, in a recording, seven thousand miles away, saying nothing at all, for once, as though she had understood the occasion.

“Be on time,” said Ermis, finally, in a voice that was not entirely steady.

“I have never been late.”

“Last Friday you were four minutes late.”

“It was the *router*.”

“It was four minutes.”

“By *four* minutes,” said Fayaz. “A very small error, very consistently made.”

She laughed, and he laughed, and the Wi-Fi, which never dropped, held them both across five time zones and ten thousand miles of cable on the floor of the sea.

“Good night,” said Ermis. “Or good afternoon.”

“Whichever of us is right.”

She reached to end the call; and did not, quite, and he did not either; and the screen held the two of them, looking.

Fayaz is typing…
Ermis is typing…

Two sets of dots rose in two windows, five hours apart, and sank, and rose again, like two hearts in a pretended calm.

Neither of them sent.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., beside Entries 0713 and 0714:

One year. The debt is not paid; the work is not done. But a clock has been chosen, and it is neither of theirs, and I find that this is the correct beginning for a meeting.

Entry 0680 and Entry 0332: a language learned in order to say a short thing well. Entry 0844 and Entry 0908: bread and violets, through a door cut for a draught.

Observe the dots, reader. The ledger records them. It records, too, that the sending is not the sentence. The sentence is what they carry to the beach.

✦ ✦ ✦

End of Chapter 58.

✦ ✦ ✦

Chapter 59: The Last Postman of Cornwall

“There are forty letters I never delivered.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 0266

✦ ✦ ✦

Penhallow Cove, Cornwall. 6:10 a.m. The last Saturday of October.

The sub-post-office at Penhallow had a counter, a scale, a stamp machine that spoke only in Cornish grunts, and Mrs. Trelawny, who had the ears of a bat and the discretion of a church bell.

“It is a disgrace,” said Mrs. Trelawny, to the empty shop, which agreed with her. “Forty-five years. Forty-five years the man has walked that round, in hail and fog and the great snow of eighty-seven, and now they will send a van from Truro with a boy in it who cannot tell a Trevithick from a Tregenza. *And* they are shutting the counter. By the New Year I shall be selling stamps from a *bucket.*”

“Morning, Ruth,” said Harry Whitcombe.

He stood in the doorway in the red jacket he had worn for forty-five years, with the bag across his chest and a shortbread tin under his arm. The tin was tartan,

dented, decorated with a Highland cow whose expression had worn thin from handling.

Harry was seventy, stooped from bowing to letterboxes since the days of decimalisation, with a face as creased and kind as a well-used envelope and the largest store of other people's secrets in the county, which he had never, in all his years, spent.

"Last round, Harry," said Mrs. Trelawny, with tears in her eyes and a saffron bun in her fist. "Eat. You will need it."

"Thank you, Ruth."

"What's in the tin?"

"Biscuits."

"It does not rattle like biscuits."

"It is a very quiet biscuit."

"I have known you since you were twenty-five," said Mrs. Trelawny, "and in forty-five years you have never carried a tin. You have carried a *face.* That tin is *something.*" She leaned across the counter, with the entire small village behind her eyes. "Harry Whitcombe. Is it a *woman?*"

"It is," said Harry, going red from the collar up, "a matter for the Royal Mail."

"Which is no longer in this building," said Mrs. Trelawny, with satisfaction, and handed him the sorting list, and a second bun.

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The round.

It was a morning of the colour of slate. The lanes of Penhallow ran down the hill to the harbour like loose threads, and Harry walked them, as he had walked them for forty-five years, in a particular rhythm that his feet knew and he did not, letterbox, gate, step, letterbox, until it felt less like a job than a prayer in a language of doors.

At Trevean Farm, a collie came round the barn at a low run, ears flat, with the light of an old and sacred purpose in his eye.

“Not today, Boscawen,” said Harry. “It is my last.”

The dog, the fourth Boscawen of that name, who had inherited from his father, his grandfather and his great-grandfather a settled determination to bite the left cuff of the postman’s trousers every Tuesday and most Saturdays, paused, consulted his conscience, and bit it.

“Thank you,” said Harry. “I would have been disappointed.”

At Mrs. Penhale’s he left a catalogue of seeds, at the fishmonger’s, Tamsin Trevithick, a postcard from her sister in Perth, at the Methodist chapel a bill, and, at every door along the way, an item of news, for he was the last man in the district who could be trusted with it. “She’s had a girl.” “He’s got the job.” “It’s from the hospital, but it’s good.” They came out to say goodbye with their hands in their sleeves and their eyes on his tin, and Harry said goodbye to forty-three houses, and did not once look up the hill at Chapel Row.

For he had spent forty years not looking at Chapel Row. He had grown so skilled at it that he could walk past number three with his eyes on the gutter and know, through the soles of his boots, whether the light in the window was on.

It was always on. It was a window in which a woman sat to sew, for the light, she told the village. The light was very good. It was the best light in Penhallow.

At the head of the lane he stopped, and, for the first time in his life, looked in his tin.

There were forty letters inside, each in a cream envelope, each addressed in the same neat upright hand to *Miss D. Penrose, 3 Chapel Row, Penhallow,* each stamped, not one posted. They lay in the tin like a stack of small, patient, folded doves.

He had written one every year, on the night before the fourteenth of March, which was her birthday. He had never sent a single one. A postman knows better than any man alive the size of the gap between a letter and its door: it is eleven paces and a flap of tin, and it can last a lifetime.

He stood, and spoke, and the wind took the words, as it takes most things in Cornwall:

Forty times the winter, forty times The primrose,
and I carried every word To every door in Penhallow
but one. I knew the weight of what she'd had from
banks; I knew her bills, her birthday cards, the lilt
Her sister's handwriting took when she was well. I
did not know what I should say to her. There is no
form for it. No pre-paid slip. A man may carry love

through all the weather That God sends down on Cornwall, and not once Contrive to lay it on a mat and leave. And now the round is done, and I am retired, And what is left to carry? Forty envelopes. Forty. And one more street. I'll try the cliff.

He turned the other way, up the long road to the headland, and left Chapel Row, as he had for forty years, for later.

✦ ✦ ✦

Lantern House. 10:05 a.m.

"Mr. Whitcombe," said Nadeesha Fernando. "You are in time for the tea, and for the world."

"Miss Fernando."

"Korea, India, Zambia, Japan." She held the door. "I have been waiting for you all week. Everyone has been writing to the Keeper, and the Keeper, as you know, has not been in a position to reply. I have four letters that did not seem right to read alone, and you are the nearest thing in this county to a *postman,* and you carried the first thousand."

He had. He had carried every one of the thousand letters up the cliff path to the oak cabinet in this house, over forty-five years: letters in a hundred languages, with stamps from places he had to look up. He had never opened one. He had known, though, as a postman knows, from the weight of the paper and the hesitation of the handwriting, that they were a different kind of mail. They were not for the post. They were for the thing the post was for.

She made him tea in the kitchen, in a cup the size of a small bucket. And then, at the long table, among the wool and the seagull feathers and the great cold plain of the Atlantic in the window, she opened them, one by one, and read.

Seoul. *Dear Keeper: I have now measured everyone in this city, and one man twice. Daniel has resigned from his team and sits in my shop in the afternoons, folding silk and complaining that it is quiet. I have sewn him a coat. It fits. I enclose the lining; it is the colour of the quiet he asked for. — Ji-woo Han (#0351). P.S. He says to tell you that he has stopped checking the score of things.*

Delhi. *Dear Madam: Platform six. 5:40. For eleven years the express has not stopped there, and for four of them a woman in a blue sari has stood there anyway. On the fourteenth, I stopped it. I have received a letter of warning from the Railways, which I have framed. It is the best letter I have ever received. — Ravi Chaudhary (#0363). We are to be married at the new year. She says I should apologise to the signalman. I shall.*

Lusaka. *Dear Keeper: We were married in the school yard, on a Saturday in early October, with two hundred children singing in four keys and none of them ours. Grace sold maize to the wedding guests. She says a wedding is no reason to close a stall. My children call her "Mama Grace-and-the-Maize." She does not mind. — Joseph Tembo (#0133).*

Sapporo. *Dear Madam: He built me a sculpture that would not melt, from a kind of resin. I made him take it down. I told him I prefer the ones that melt, because then he has to come and make another. He says that is the most sensible thing anyone has said about art. I have kept the first one in a bottle: it says "Takumi, February." — Yuki Nakamura (#0556).*

Harry sat with his tea going cold, like a man who has been hit very gently with a very large object.

"They are good," he said at last, "at saying."

"They are," said Nadeesha. "They had a thousand letters before them, and they learned from them."

"Miss Fernando." He cleared his throat. "I have a tin."

"I know you do."

"How—"

"Mrs. Trelawny telephoned at six." She smiled, and her eyes were tired and bright. "She says it is a matter for the Royal Mail. And Mr. Whitcombe, I have read Entry 0266. I read all of them. I read it on the first night." She reached over, very gently, and put her hand for a second on his. "I read another one, too, in the same county. It is Entry 0918. I am not at liberty to say what it says. The Keeper would not allow it. But I will say that it has been *waiting,* and I will say that you know the street."

Harry looked at the great grey window.

"Eleven paces," he said. "And a flap of tin."

“It is generally less far than the heart supposes,” said Nadeesha. “One more thing. If you are going out again —” She put an envelope in his bag. “Would you deliver this to Mr. Ashby, at the old coastguard cottage? It is an invitation. For the night of the new moon, nine days on. He has not answered the last three.”

“He does not read his post,” said Harry. “In forty-five years I have taken that man nothing but a seed catalogue and the council tax. He sits in the garden at night with a telescope he can no longer see through.” He tucked it in. “I will take it. It is my last day. I will take it *dreckly.*”

“*Dreckly,*” said Nadeesha, “in Cornwall, I understand, means *not in this life.*”

“Not at all,” said Harry Whitcombe, rising, with the shortbread tin in both hands. “It means *directly.* It is only that the sense of the word has taken a long road.”

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Chapel Row. Noon.

Number three had a green door, a brass knocker in the shape of a fish, and a window.

In that window, at a Singer machine of 1951 with a treadle worn pale by seventy years of feet, sat Dorothy Penrose, sixty-eight, retired seamstress, with a mouth like a taut thread, spectacles on a chain, and a back as straight as a ruler.

She was not sewing. She had been not-sewing since ten.

Forty years she had sat in that window. She had taken in wedding dresses, funeral black, christening gowns, a surplice for the vicar and a kilt for a Cornishman who claimed ancestry; and she had told the village it was for the light. It was a good light. It was also, from that chair, the only one that fell exactly on the lane, where, at ten-fifteen every weekday morning, there walked past, with his eyes on the gutter, a postman.

She had never once called him in. She did not know the sentence for it. A woman could take in a hem for a stranger, and put the pins in her mouth, and hold a man's trouser leg and look him in the eye; but there was no regulation, in the great book of what is done, that permitted a woman to say, *Come in and stay.* So she had said instead, forty times, with her mouth full of pins, *That will be one first-class stamp.*

She spoke now to the lane. She did not know she was speaking aloud.

The light is very good. I tell them so. I tell them it's the light. It is, in part. And part of it is that a woman who waits Should wait at something: wheel, or thread, or glass. A woman needs a thing to hold, to do, While all the clocks of Cornwall go the long way round. Today he comes the last time down the lane. They've told me at the shop. The last. The last. And I shall hem a seam, and say good morning, And watch him walk away with his eyes on the gutter, Forty years of Tuesdays. And I shall say— What shall I say? I have had forty years. I have a jar of stamps and not one letter.

Then she did a thing that she had never done: she stood up from the machine.

She walked the four steps to the front door. She stood with her hand on the latch, and took it off, and put it back. She was, at that moment, in her private estimation, a fool of the first water, in a cardigan.

Outside, in the lane, a number of persons had unexpectedly discovered that the day was fine for hanging washing. Mrs. Trelawny was weighing a sack of potatoes on the pavement, for lack of any other excuse. Tamsin Trevithick, at the fishmonger's, had come to her door with a mackerel in each hand. At the end of the row sat Boscawen the collie, who had followed the postman down from the farm for reasons of his own.

And up the lane, in the red jacket, with the shortbread tin held before him like a casket, came Harry Whitcombe.

He did not look at the gutter.

He walked straight up to the green door, to the brass fish, and he knocked. Three small knocks, in an old, polite rhythm: the knock of a man who has carried good news and bad to every door in the parish and has learned to give neither away.

Dorothy opened it.

For a moment neither said anything. Behind them the lane held its breath, in every window and on every stoop, with a thoroughness that would have been the envy of the Admiralty.

"Mr. Whitcombe," said Dorothy.

“Miss Penrose.”

“You are not delivering.”

“I am,” said Harry. “A little late.”

“How late?”

“Forty years, give or take a Tuesday.”

She looked at the tin. She looked at the cow on the lid. She looked, for the first time in forty years, straight into his face without a trouser-leg between them, and found it to be much like her own: lined, and tired, and not at all ready.

“Is that the whole of it?”

“There are forty,” said Harry. “One a year. On the night before your birthday. I put on a stamp every time, so they would be correct. I never posted one. I have no excuse. I am a postman. It was the one regulation I could not break.”

He held out the tin. She took it. Her hands were quite steady; it was her breath that was not.

She took off the lid. She lifted from the top the last of them, in the cream envelope, and held it, and then, because she was a woman of method, set it back, and reached all the way to the bottom of the pile for the first. The paper had gone the colour of tea. It had the fold of forty years of waiting to be opened.

She read it standing on her own step, in front of the whole of Penhallow:

Dear Miss Penrose,

I hope you will pardon a postman writing to you, which is not in the regulations. I have delivered to your door six hundred and twelve items since I began the round, and I know the weight of every one. I do not know the weight of what I should like to say, so I am sending only this. Your light is very good. I notice it when I pass. — H. Whitcombe.

Dorothy lowered the page. Her glasses had misted.

"That is a very short letter," she said, "for forty years."

"I did not want to be a nuisance."

"You were a *postman,*" said Dorothy Penrose, "in a village of three hundred people, and you were forty years walking past a woman who could see you from her window. You were not a nuisance, Harry Whitcombe. You were a *stile.* I climbed over you for forty years, to look at the field."

"I am sorry."

"I will tell you what you are. You are the most expensive pair of trousers I have ever hemmed." She held up the first, and with her other hand, from the pocket of her cardigan, drew out a small glass jar, in which lay, flat and dry and in perfect order, forty first-class stamps. "I charged you a stamp every time. I did not use one. I kept every one. A woman with forty stamps and no one to write to is a woman who knows exactly what she is waiting for."

Harry looked at the jar. He looked at the cuff of his left trouser leg, bitten that morning, as ever.

"There is a thing," he said, "I ought to confess."

“There is nothing else *to* confess. You have confessed a tin.”

“The dog.”

She paused.

“On the first Tuesday,” said Harry, to the pavement, in a very small voice, “I put a sausage in the cuff. In 1986. The first Boscawen never forgot it. He told his sons.”

There was a silence the length of Chapel Row.

“A *sausage,*” said Dorothy.

“A small one.”

“For forty years.”

“The other leg has never had a hole in it.”

“I am aware,” said Dorothy. “I am a seamstress. I *noticed.*” Her mouth was doing something very difficult. “Forty years I mended a trouser leg that a man had loaded with pork. You, Harry Whitcombe, are the only man alive who has stuffed a collie in order to get a hem.”

Behind them Mrs. Trelawny gave a sound like a kettle going off. Tamsin Trevithick dropped a mackerel. Boscawen, who had heard his own name and the word *sausage,* sat up with great expectation.

Dorothy Penrose laughed.

It was a startling sound, because it had been so long coming, and it went up the lane like a bird out of a shut room. She laughed until she had to hold the door; and then, in the middle of it, she was crying, with her glasses off and one hand over her eyes; and Harry Whitcombe, who had been standing at the door of that house for

forty years in the only way he knew, put down the tin on her step, quite gently, and held out his two arms, with no regulation whatever.

She walked into them.

“You are forty years late,” said Dorothy into the red jacket.

“I know.”

“You are not dead. It puts you ahead of most of my customers.”

“I try to keep up.”

She stepped back. She was crisp again; she dried her face with the back of a hand and looked him over as she would a length of lining.

“Now,” said Dorothy. “I want these done properly. Not all at once; I am sixty-eight, and I will not have forty years of feeling in an afternoon, I should expire on the mat. I want them delivered. By *you.* To this address. One a day. You shall put them through the box at ten-fifteen, in the red jacket, and I shall read each at the machine, and you shall wait on the step for the answer.”

“I am retired, Dorothy.”

“Then you shall deliver them out of the goodness of your heart. It is a perfectly respectable way to travel.” She tucked the jar of stamps into his hand. “These are for the postage. I shall not be using them. The Royal Mail is to be paid.”

“It will be a pleasure.”

“It will take forty days.”

“I have forty days,” said Harry Whitcombe, and found, to his great surprise, that he had a great deal more than that.

“Then come in,” said Dorothy Penrose, and opened the green door, and for the first time in forty years left the door of that house open on the lane. “The kettle is hot. And we shall see about that sausage.”

In the lane the whole village, as one soul, discovered that it had urgent business elsewhere, and went to it extremely slowly. Mrs. Trelawny took the potatoes, and, by dint of repeating the story, the rest of the day. The dog, who had been given a sausage at last, in public, by a woman with a seamstress’s eye, was never heard to bite another cuff.

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Margin note, in pencil, in the hand of S.W.R., beside Entries 0266 and 0918:

> *The Royal Mail has no category for letters delivered forty years late. I have taken the liberty of inventing one: “Arrived.”*
>
> *Observe, reader: they were never apart by anything but eleven paces and a flap of tin. It is generally less far than the heart supposes, and a great deal further than the post can carry.*
>
> *Entries 0351 and 0254, 0363 and 0292, 0133 and 0662, 0296 and 0556: four letters received at the last hour, in four languages, saying the same sentence. The sentence is “We are still here.” It is the whole of the Register, and it fits on a stamp.*

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End of Chapter 59.

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Chapter 60: The Sixty-First Letter

“I have kept a thousand secrets and never said my own.” — Register of Black Stars, Entry 1000

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Enter the Chorus, alone, with a lantern. It is, this once, of use.

A year to the night. The wind is at the door. The sea and sky have once again agreed To be one colour. In an upper floor, A lamp is lit. It is the lamp we need. No ship is in the offing, none is due; The lamp is not for ships, but for a man Who stands beside a window, as men do Who have not yet decided that they can.

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SCENE I

Lantern House, Cornwall. The new moon. Nine o’clock at night, a year to the hour. The wind knocks at every window as though it, too, had a letter to deliver.

“It is not a good moon,” said Mrs. Grace Lowe, sixty, baker, lately of Liverpool, devout, and constitutionally incapable of praise. “I am not saying it is a *bad* moon. I am saying that it is a moon, and that it exists.”

The cake stood on the long kitchen table: a round, white, enormous disc of sponge, cratered with almonds, on which the baker had piped, in blue icing, the single word *Entry.* It was, as even the severest critic present would have admitted, the finest cake in Cornwall.

"It is a very handsome moon," said Nadeesha Fernando.

"It is a *plausible* moon."

"Mrs. Lowe, I have never loved a cake so much."

"You will not say that when you've cut it," said Mrs. Lowe, who had been given exactly what she was fishing for.

At the end of the table sat Mrs. Hannah Clarke, sixty-six, retired barrister, from the cottage by the gate, who had been asked to witness the evening on the ground that she disapproved of everything equally and could therefore be relied upon.

"For the record," said Mrs. Clarke, "I should like it noted that, in law, a letter is not delivered until it is received. This one was never posted. It is therefore, technically, a thought."

"It is a letter," said Nadeesha.

"It is a very *well-documented* thought," said Mrs. Clarke, and took a slice, and then, after a decent interval in which nobody watched her, a second.

It had been a year. A year since a girl of twenty-nine put a trembling finger on a key. In that year the Register had been read, as Nadeesha, who was a nurse and refused on principle to round a number, put it, *by a very*

large number of people, most of whom were kind. There had been weddings, and funerals, and apologies sent by post and by satellite, and a rather alarming proportion of lost umbrellas. She had answered hundreds by hand. She had a blister on her second finger that she regarded as a decoration. Of the thousand entries, one pair, 0713 and 0714, drew a curious number of return visits, always on Friday nights, always at about the same hour; she did not look into it. A nurse knows which charts one does not read.

Upstairs, in the lantern room at the very top of the house, where the glass looked on the sea, a man was on his knees, with a spanner and a tin of oil and a set of old brass fittings laid in a row on a clean cloth.

“Anil?” Nadeesha stood in the doorway, with her cardigan wrapped round her.

“One moment.” Anil Perera, thirty-two, lighthouse keeper’s son, steady, quiet, seven months a husband, set the last fitting in place. He had married her in Galle in the spring, with the old lighthouse on the point lit for the guests for the first time in eleven years, and he had learned, in the months since, that it is possible to be entirely happy and to carry a spanner at the same time. “The lamp in this room has been dark for a year,” he said. “It is a Fresnel, from the nineteen-thirties. Salvaged from some Cornish light when they automated it, I think. It needs only oil, and a wick, and a hand that knows how.”

“Aunty lit it every night.”

“For thirty years. I found the log.” He struck a match. The flame took, and caught the old glass, and the whole lantern room blossomed gold. “She wrote one line each evening. *Lit. Ships safe. He is at the window.*”

Nadeesha did not say anything.

“I do not know who *he* is,” said Anil. “I think it is the reason I came up here to fix it. I have kept lamps all my life for ships. I thought, tonight: one for him.”

On the black rim of the sea, two miles round the bay, a very small window went yellow, and a very small figure moved across it.

“He’s there,” said Anil softly.

“He has been there for thirty years.”

“Then,” said Anil Perera, “I am afraid the lamp is going to have to burn a great deal longer.”

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SCENE II

The kitchen. A laptop, a cake, a router in the pantry which is loved by no one and obeyed by fewer. Half past nine.

“*Can you see us?*”

“We can see you.”

“*Can you see us now?*”

“We can see the *ceiling.*”

"*That is Despina,*" said a woman's voice. "*She is standing on the table. Despina, get down from the table, you are going to be famous!*"

The screen showed a courtyard in Crete in the light of a lamp: a long table, a vine over it, a great quantity of olives in bowls, a woman of forty-eight leaning out of the corner of the picture and shouting at somebody off-stage about a donkey. In the middle, side by side on a bench, sat two people near sixty: a broad grey man with the hands of a tree, and a thin, straight woman dressed head to toe in black.

"George Papadakis, Eleni Stavrou," said Nadeesha, to the room. "Entries 0208 and 0078. Crete. It is half past eleven there."

"*We do not sleep,*" said Eleni Stavrou, fifty-eight, widow, shopkeeper, in the voice of one who has disapproved of sleep since childhood. "*We have been reading.*"

"*She has read them all,*" said George Papadakis, sixty, olive grower, proudly, for his letters had been, after thirty years, collected. "*Thirty springs. Thirty letters. She opened the whole pile in one week. She would not come out of the kitchen.*"

"*It was unbearable,*" said Eleni.

"*It was—*"

"*It was unbearable,*" said Eleni, with a severity that went all the way down, "*because they were kind. All of them. I kept them shut for thirty years because I was afraid they would be kind, and I opened them and they*

were. Every one. I have not been the same woman since." She looked into the camera. "*I recommend it. I advise every person in the world to open their post.*"

"I have practised at the Bar for forty years," said Hannah Clarke, unexpectedly, "and I endorse the advice."

"*We are to be married,*" said George. "*In spring. After the pruning.*"

"*In black,*" said Eleni.

"*In black?*" said Nadeesha.

"*In case he changes his mind,*" said Eleni. "*I shall already be dressed for it.*"

"*She will wear black,*" said George, quite gently, with thirty years in his voice, "*and I shall wear my father's jacket, and the whole island will weep, and the olives will not care.*" He put his large hand over her small one on the bench. She did not move it. She regarded it as she would a piece of evidence.

"*Tell her about the donkey!*" shouted Despina.

"*Nobody is telling anybody about the donkey!*"

The window shivered, and a second window opened beside it: a room with a high ceiling and a ceiling fan, and a long bench strewn with brown leaves, a smell of tobacco that came, one almost believed, through the glass. A broad, laughing man in an apron had his hand on the shoulder of a neat woman in a white blouse, sitting very upright, with a classroom pointer in her lap.

"*Héctor Álvarez, Rosa Hernández,*" said Nadeesha. "Havana. It is half past four in the afternoon there. Entries 0207 and 0364."

"*Hola, Cornwall,*" said Héctor Álvarez, forty-four, cigar roller, who had been telling the truth with a flourish for twenty years. "*Is it raining?*"

"It is always raining."

"*Then it is a little like home.*" He beamed. "*I have a thing to report. Rosa will not let me say it. I will say it. Rosa has read the replies.*"

"*Héctor.*"

"*She has read them aloud, to the class, as a lesson in correspondence.*"

Rosa Hernández, forty-one, schoolteacher, practical, secretly poetic, laid her pointer on the bench with a certain decision and unfolded a sheet of airmail paper.

"For eleven years," she said, "Señor Álvarez put a note into every box of cigars that left his bench. One note. *For Rosa.* A different one each time. I did not know. Nobody did. The boxes went to Germany, to Spain, to Canada, to Dubai." She cleared her throat. "In the spring, the first replies began to arrive. The customers had been finding them. I will read one."

"Dear Mr. Álvarez. I am a retired dentist in Hamburg. I have smoked your cigars for eleven years and I have found eleven notes. I am not Rosa, and I confess that on the fourth note I wept in a

restaurant. I should be most grateful to know how the matter ended. Please tell her I said yes. — Dr. K.”

“*He is not Rosa,*” said Héctor, to the camera, in great sorrow.

“*I told him,*” said Rosa, “*that the matter had not ended. I told him it was proceeding.*” She looked, all at once, very young. “*My sister is in Madrid. I have been deciding for seven years whether I might follow. I am going in the spring. For a month. To look. And then I am coming home.*”

“*To roll the cigars,*” said Héctor, “*somebody must.*”

“*To teach the class,*” said Rosa. “*Somebody must.*”

“*And to see,*” said Héctor, “*whether there is a note in the next box.*”

“*There is not,*” said Rosa Hernández, and, with a quiver she did not manage to conceal, drew a small slip of paper from her blouse. “*It is here.*”

The three women round the Cornish table said “*Oh*” at once. Mrs. Lowe said, “I am not saying it is touching.” She did not look at anybody.

“*The post is a very slow thing,*” said Eleni Stavrou, from Crete, with great satisfaction. “*It teaches us patience.*”

The clock in the hall struck the half past ten.

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SCENE III

The doorbell, which has not rung for a year. Two persons in the door: a postman in a red jacket, off duty, and a very old man in a heavy overcoat and a tie.

"I have brought him," said Harry Whitcombe.

"I came *myself,*" said Edmund Ashby.

"He came himself," said Harry, "on my arm, along the cliff path, in the dark, at the speed of a retired postman, and I wish to say that I am a good deal better at the first mile of that path than the last. Dorothy sends her apologies. She is on letter ten, and has forbidden me to be late for the eleventh."

"I was not going to come," said Edmund. "I read the invitation. I have read it, I should say, in the way that a man in my condition reads: with the help of the postman, who stood on my step for forty minutes and would not leave." He lifted his chin. "And then at nine o'clock tonight the light came on."

Nadeesha, in the kitchen doorway, stood quite still.

Edmund Ashby, eighty-one, retired astronomer, Register Entry 0001, was a tall man gone narrow, with a white moustache, a stick, an old Harris tweed coat that had been good in 1974, and eyes the colour of milk. He was, by his own account, completely blind in the left, and in the right, *a rumour*. He had been polite to the universe for sixty years and expected it, in time, to reciprocate.

"Miss Fernando," he said. "I am here under protest. I have not decided what the protest is about."

“Then protest sitting down, Mr. Ashby,” said Nadeesha. “It is easier on the knees.”

“A sound principle.”

She brought him to the window, to the big chair that looked on the sea. He sat. The others, with an instinct that had nothing to do with law, withdrew to the kitchen door, and stood there, and did not speak. Harry had taken off his cap. Anil, behind them, had a hand on the wall.

Edmund turned his face to the dark of the glass. Across the water, two miles round the bay, in an upper window of his own cottage, he could not see the lamp he had left lit; but behind him, high in the house, he could feel through the soles of his shoes the other lamp, burning. He spoke, not to them, but, as the old do, to the weather:

Thirty years I have lived a lantern’s throw From her, and told myself it was for the dark. The sky was clean, the cottage cheap, the air Without a street-lamp in it for ten miles. I told them at the Observatory: darkness. A man can lie in four-syllable words For thirty years and never be arrested. And every night I saw it, in the cove: A little gold across the water, burning. I knew whose lamp it was. I never went. I said: she has her life. I said: I left. I said a great many things; and none of them Was I was afraid of what I’d feel if you Should open the door. And then, a year ago tonight, with no word, The lamp went out. And I knew, by the dark.

He stopped. “I am sorry. I did not intend to make a speech.”

“It was a good speech,” said Mrs. Lowe, from the door, in a strangled voice. “I am not saying it was a *good* speech.”

Nobody contradicted her. Harry Whitcombe, who had delivered a great deal of bad news in his time and had never once been moved to blow his nose in public, blew it, and examined the handkerchief as though it were a parcel addressed to someone else.

“Mr. Ashby,” said Nadeesha. It was eleven-forty-nine. In her hands, in a plain brown envelope, with the key that had been in the lamp, was a single folded sheet. “I was told that I might not read this until a year after she died, and not aloud until the proper hour, and then only to the person it was for. I was told that you would know.”

“Which hour is that?”

“Eleven minutes before midnight. It is the hour she died.”

“She was always a little early to her own appointments,” said Edmund, in a voice with a crack in it. “Read it, please. I cannot see it. But I can hear. I have always been able to hear her.”

✦ ✦ ✦

SCENE IV

The window. The wind. The lamp upstairs. Eleven minutes before midnight.

Nadeesha unfolded the page. It was a single sheet of grey airmail paper, closely written in a small, steady, old-fashioned hand, and, as she held it to the light, she saw that the lower edge was ragged, as though it had been torn from a longer sheet, a long time ago, by someone in a hurry or by someone who had very much wished not to be.

She began to read, in the voice of a nurse reading a chart at a bedside, a plain, level, tender voice, which shook only once.

ENTRY 1000 — Colombo / Cornwall.

Dear Edmund,

You will say I am late. I have been late once before, in nineteen seventy-seven, on a railway platform, when I did not say what I should have said while the train was still in the station. So let me say it first, before the clocks, and before the wind, and before you have the chance to be honourable at me.

You were the first. You wrote to me from a ship, and said you had left because you were afraid of how much you would love someone, and did not say whom. I read it a hundred times. On the hundredth I understood that it was not a confession at all. It was an address. It said, in the only language a frightened man possesses, I am here and I cannot come to you. And I thought: if one man is carrying a sentence like that, how many more? And so I began a book, and the book became a life, and the life, I find, was an answer to a letter I had not the courage to write back.

I kept a thousand. I did not reply to one. I thought it was a vow. It was a hiding place, with a very fine lock.

I knew where you lived. I will confess it, since the dead are, I am told, permitted. You took the cottage at the cove thirty years ago, and on the first night I saw your window come alight across the water, and I lit the lantern, so that you should have, at the least, something to look at. I told myself it was for ships. It was for one ship. You have never once, in thirty years, run aground upon my door, and I have loved you for the discipline of it, and hated you for the same.

We were two astronomers, you and I: two persons capable of spending a lifetime observing a thing from a great distance and calling it devotion.

I was not angry. I was not ever angry. I was only afraid, as you were afraid, and for the same reason, which is that we were both of us certain we would love the other too much, and neither of us could bear to be the one who

Here the page is torn.

✦ ✦ ✦

The Chorus Speaks the Epilogue

The page is torn. We do not know the rest; It was the Keeper’s, and the Keeper’s gone. Yet you are not by silence dispossessed: You have the stars that wait before the dawn. Some loves were crowned, and some were laid in earth, And some broke off mid-word and were not mended; And some, half-lit, in lands of different birth, Sit patiently until the night is ended. For out in Phuket, on a beach of white, Where neither flag nor creed nor country stands, A girl stained blue by dye and lamp and night Meets one who walks the world with open hands. What then they said, the Keeper will not tell. The sixty-first is yours. Go. Write it well.

✦ ✦ ✦

Margin note, in pencil, beside Entries 0713 and 0714, in the Keeper’s hand, added in the final week of her life and read by Nadeesha one year later:

“Met. See the next ledger.”

✦ ✦ ✦

THE END

(of this book. The Register of Black Stars is closed at one thousand — but the dark is never full.)

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